A Daily Companion

a reading for each of the 364 days — one KoT Book for one week, each day

WEEK I

Chesed of Chesed

Days 1–7

Day 1 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Raise our Heads, Choose a Master, and Recognize G-d's Oneness

Week one is the week of Rosh Hashanah, and the year's counting begins on the same weekday the Counting of the Omer begins — the second day of Passover. It takes in the days of selichot leading up to the holiday, when we rise early to ask forgiveness and start the year with a clean slate.

The first creature in Perek Shirah is the rooster, who says: "When the Holy One, blessed be He, comes to the righteous in the Garden of Eden, all the trees in the Garden of Eden scatter their spices, and they rejoice and praise, and then He, too, is aroused and praises." (Zohar, Vayakhel 195b) Then come seven calls, one to each day of the week. The first is "Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O everlasting doors! And the King of glory shall come in! Who is this King of glory? G-d strong and mighty, G-d mighty in battle!" (Psalms 24:7-8) The second says it again, and answers differently: "G-d of hosts, He is the King of glory, Selah!" (Psalms 24:9-10) The fifth and sixth ask, "How long will you sleep, O sluggard? When will you arise from your sleep?" (Proverbs 6:9) and "Do not love sleep, lest you come to poverty." (Proverbs 20:13) The shofar is blown a hundred times and the rooster's verses contain a hundred words.

Pirkei Avot opens the same way: an introduction, then seven pairs of rabbis, and the lesson repeated through them is to acquire a master. On Rosh Hashanah we acquire the ultimate Master.

The pairing is Chesed shebeChesed, kindness within kindness. It was on Rosh Hashanah that Sarah, old and barren, was told she would bear Isaac, and that Chanah was told of Samuel. The month is Tishrei, whose tribe is Ephraim, who

studied under his grandfather Jacob.

The rooster's own lesson is the plainest one: stop sleeping, get up, move forward. We thank G-d each morning for giving the rooster the understanding to tell day from night.

Week 1, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 2 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Rosh Hashanah - Creation and the Grave, Avraham & Sarah and Acquiring the Torah, Shechem and Acquiring a Head

Haazinu's first verse opens the week: "Listen, O heavens, and I will speak! And let the earth hear the words of my mouth!" (Deuteronomy 32:1) Heavens and earth — which is how the Torah itself begins, and the week of Rosh Hashanah is the week of the world's creation.

The haftorah opens David's song and gives its reason: "on the day that the Lord delivered him from the hand of all his enemies, and from the hand of Saul." (II Samuel 22:1) Saul — *Shaul* — is spelled exactly as *She'ol*, the pit, the grave. On Rosh Hashanah we too mark having lived to see another year, and hope to be inscribed in the Book of Life.

The first of the forty-eight ways of acquiring Torah is not in the list but in its introduction: "Torah is greater than priesthood and kingship, for kingship is acquired with 30 qualities, priesthood with 24, whereas the Torah is acquired with 48 ways." It points at Proverbs — the beginning of wisdom is to acquire wisdom. Rashi reads it as two steps: first learn from others and take the tradition from the mouth of a teacher, then with everything you have acquire understanding, working it out for yourself. That is Book 1's lesson again, from the other side.

The prophets are Avraham and Sarah, the first to go looking for knowledge of G-d. Sarah's birthday and her yahrzeit both fall on Rosh Hashanah, and so does the Akeidah.

The Levitical city is Shechem, also a city of refuge. *Shechem* means shoulder — the part the head sits on, and Rosh Hashanah is the head of the year. It is the first place Avraham, Yaakov and Yehoshua each came to on entering the Land: its gateway, as this week is the year's.

What the week asks for is *ratzon*, desire. Nothing stands in the way of desire, and Rebbe Nachman teaches that the wanting matters more than the outcome.

Week 1, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 3 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Moshe and Deborah, Judgement and Adam, Ramses and Being G-d's Firstborn

Book 3 opens where the Song of the Sea opens: "Then Moses and the children of Israel sang this song to the Lord, and they spoke, saying, I will sing to the Lord, for very exalted is He." The haftorah answers it: "Now Deborah and Barak the son of Abinoam sang on that day." Both verses are leaders of the people singing in unison, and Rosh Hashanah is about connecting to the head of the people.

The week's portion of Sotah is the passage the whole tractate rests on — the woman who is judged by water. If she was defiled the curse-bearing waters become bitter in her; if she was not, "she shall be exempted and bear seed." It is a judgment, which is what this week is.

The generation is Adam, the first man, who is the spiritual and physical source of all mankind. Rosh Hashanah is the day Adam was created, and it holds the same whole-of-humanity scope that he does.

The journey is the first one: "They journeyed from Rameses in the first month, on the fifteenth day of the first month; on the day following the Passover sacrifice, the children of Israel left triumphantly before the eyes of all the Egyptians. And the Egyptians were busy burying" — burying their firstborn, and occupied with their mourning. *Ramses* means the sun-god made him. The work of these days is to take in that we are Hashem's firstborn and that Hashem is the Creator; to leave Egypt, and to leave the idea that there could be any other god.

Adam's lesson for prayer is scale. Pray not only for yourself but for all mankind, and first for whoever needs it most. It is not by accident that every prayer we say is in the plural. We are more connected than we think.

Week 1, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 4 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Elkanah and Rabbi Meir, Acquiring Wisdom and the Yenuka

The story of Chanah begins with her husband's lineage: "Now there was a certain man of Ramathaim-zophim, of the hill-country of Ephraim, and his name was Elkanah, the son of Jeroham, the son of Elihu, the son of Tohu, the son of Zuph, an Ephraimite." Tishrei's tribe is Ephraim, and Elkanah was the leader of his generation and a prophet in his own right. The verse opens with *Ish Echad*, one man — and this week everything is on the one. Ramathaim-Zophim means the heights that look into the future, which is what Rosh Hashanah does.

The sixth chapter of Pirkei Avot opens with the name of Rabbi Meir and with the subject the rest of the year will keep returning to: "Whoever studies Torah for Torah's sake alone, merits many things." Torah lishmah, learning for its own sake. Like Elkanah, Rabbi Meir stood head and shoulders above his generation. "Merits many things" reads as almost superfluous beside the spiritual gifts listed after it; some commentaries take it for the physical blessings. That is Rosh Hashanah exactly — a spiritual day on which this world's portions are settled.

Proverbs opens with the same subject in its own words: "To know wisdom and discipline, to comprehend words of understanding… The fear of the Lord is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and discipline."

The yahrzeit is 2 Tishrei, Rabbi Yisrael of Stolin, the Yenuka, who became rebbe at five years old — a rebbe higher than intellect, loved and feared by his chassidim. Like Samuel and Solomon, who also came to prominence as children, he lived to fifty-two. He is known as the Frankforter, because that is where he passed away; he asked to be buried in the place of his passing, and so lies near Rabbi Amnon of Mainz, who died on the first of Tishrei. Rabbi Amnon was maimed limb by limb for refusing to convert, asked to be carried to the Ark on Rosh Hashanah, and died as he finished saying *uNetaneh Tokef*.

Week 1, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 5 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Song of Songs and Reuven, Oaths and Jeremiah

"The Song of Songs, which is Solomon's. Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth, for your love is better than wine. Because of the fragrance of your goodly oils, your name is 'oil poured forth.' Therefore, the maidens loved you."

Song of Songs means the song that excels all songs, and perhaps the song that contains them all. Rosh Hashanah is the day that excels all days and contains them all. Every *Shlomoh* in Shir HaShirim is read as a reference to G-d: Solomon is the king, and this is the day we make Hashem King. Solomon's name also means peace is his, and on this day peace too is in Hashem's hands.

The second verse speaks of nearness, which is what the days of awe are. The third, the oils poured forth, is how Hashem's dealings with Israel give off a scent the whole world can smell — which is why the maidens, the nations, love Him as well. On Rosh Hashanah all mankind is judged, and the nations feel something of it. Wine and oil are the physical blessings of the day, and both are also figures for knowledge.

Of the seventy souls who went down to Egypt the first named is Reuven, the firstborn, whom Jacob calls "my first-born, my strength and the first of my vigor." Firstborn, from *rosh*, a head.

Shevuot is built from verses scattered through the Torah rather than one passage, and an oath, like this day and like this song, is an all-encompassing thing. Jeremiah's first chapter is all-encompassing too: it states the whole book's theme, the destruction coming to Israel and Jerusalem, and it holds the idea of a thing settled from the start — Jeremiah is told he was chosen while still in his mother's womb.

Week 1, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 6 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing Week of Rosh Hashanah - Psalms 1-3, 16:1-4, 89:1-2

Book 6 is the week read in psalms, and for the week of Rosh Hashanah they are the first three, with the opening of the Tikkun HaKlali and the opening of Psalm 89.

Psalm 1 sets two ways against each other. "Fortunate is the man that has not walked in the counsel of the wicked, nor stood in the path of sinners, nor sat in the

company of scoffers. Rather, his desire is in the Torah of the Lord, and in His Torah he meditates day and night. He shall be like a tree planted by streams of water, that yields its fruit in its season, and whose leaf does not wither." The wicked are chaff the wind drives away, and "the wicked will not endure in judgement."

Psalm 2 is the nations gathering and conspiring against the Lord and His anointed, and the answer from above: "He Who sits in heaven laughs." Then, plainly, "It is I Who have anointed My king, upon Zion, My holy mountain." It ends by telling the kings of the earth to serve with awe and rejoice with trembling.

Psalm 3 is David's, from when he fled from Absalom his son. Many rise against him and many say there is no salvation for him, and he answers: "But You, Lord, are a shield for me, my glory, the One Who raises my head." Then, "I lie down and sleep; I awake, for the Lord sustains me."

The Tikkun HaKlali's first psalm begins "Watch over me, O God, for I have put my trust in You," and Psalm 89 begins "I will sing of the Lord's kindness forever; to all generations I will make known Your faithfulness with my mouth."

Three psalms about judgment, kingship and being held up, in the week of the head of the year.

Week 1, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 7 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Rooster is saying,

Book 7 gathers the week. Every verse the six books sang this week is laid into one song, line alternating with line, and the week's gathering is called after the first of them: the rooster is saying.

So the rooster's calls run through it with everything else threaded between them. "When the Holy One, blessed be He, comes to the righteous" meets "Listen, O heavens, and I will speak!" — "in the Garden of Eden, all the trees in the Garden of Eden" meets "And let the earth hear the words of my mouth!" Psalm 89's "To all generations I will make known Your faithfulness with my mouth" and "I will sing of the Lord's kindness forever" fall in beside the trees scattering their spices.

Then the gates. "Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O everlasting doors!" takes in David's song — "And David spoke to the Lord the words of this

song" — and the opening of Song of Songs, and the Song of the Sea, "Then Moses and the children of Israel sang this song to the Lord." Twice the question comes: "Who is this King of glory?" and twice the answer, G-d strong and mighty, G-d of hosts.

The rooster's remaining calls carry Elkanah's lineage and the Tikkun HaKlali with them. "Stand, O righteous ones, and busy yourselves with Torah" sits beside "of the hill-country of Ephraim, and his name was Elkanah"; "How long will you sleep, O sluggard?" beside "Those who hasten after other gods, their sorrows shall increase"; and the last call, "It is time to act for G-d; for they have made void Your Torah," beside "the son of Zuph, an Ephraimite."

Six readings, one voice. It closes on the Song of the Sea: "I will sing to the Lord, for very exalted is He."

Week 1, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK II

Gevurah of Chesed

Days 8–14

Day 8 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Relate Well to Others and to Our Own Body

Week two is the week of Yom Kippur, and the creature is the hen: "He gives bread to all flesh, for His kindness endures forever." (Psalms 136:25) She sings of G-d feeding every living thing, in the days when it is settled how much each will receive — and who will live and who will not.

Two customs of this week run through the hen. Eating well on the eve of Yom Kippur is held to be as meritorious as the fast itself. And it is in this week that Kapparot is done, the ancient custom of atoning through a hen, which is then slaughtered and given to families in need; many now use charity money instead.

Pirkei Avot gives Shimon, the son of Rabban Gamliel: "All my life I have been raised among the wise, and I have found nothing better for the body than silence. The essential thing is not study, but deed. And one who speaks excessively brings on sin." To take in what another says you first have to be quiet. And the silencing of the body is this day plainly — the fast, no leather shoes, no anointing, no relations. For one day we stand apart from the physical, like angels.

Week one was about acquiring one teacher. This week it is the wise in the plural. One is unity and two is multiplicity, and they do not contradict: a person can have one master and still learn from everyone.

The pairing is Gevurah shebeChesed, discipline inside kindness — which is the fast itself, self-control exercised while begging for mercy from a G-d we know to be just and kind.

The day also insists that deeds are what count. Its high point is the reading of Jonah, which turns on "And G-d saw their actions."

After the rooster got us out of bed, the hen's lesson is the next step: eat properly, take care of the body you were given.

Week 2, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 9 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Yom Kippur - Rain and Rescue, Isaac and Study, Gezer and Annulling Evil Decrees

Haazinu turns to water: "My lesson will drip like rain; my word will flow like dew; like storm winds on vegetation and like raindrops on grass." (Deuteronomy 32:2) Rain and dew — the beginning of time again, and the Flood. Water is purity and it is life, which are not two things. Dew in particular belongs to resurrection: it was with dew that G-d revived the Jewish people at the giving of the Torah, and the Torah itself is called dew.

The haftorah answers with shelter: "The Lord is my rock and my fortress, and a rescuer to me." (II Samuel 22:2) On Yom Kippur we are the ones delivered.

The week's quality is constant study. Last week was desire; this week is discipline, because Torah is not acquired without it. The prophet is Isaac, who is discipline — *gevurah* — and whose dedication is read off the Akeidah. One opinion in the Talmud puts the Akeidah on Yom Kippur. Like Jews on this day, Isaac lived a heavenly life while still on earth; the Zohar says he spent three years in the Garden of Eden afterwards. He is called a pure offering, and he never once left the Land of Israel.

The Levitical city is Gezer, a place so strategic that it is among the most excavated sites in Israel, and a wedding gift from Pharaoh when his daughter married Solomon. *Gezer* shares its root with *gzerah*, a decree — and the business of this day is annulling evil decrees through prayer, repentance and charity.

What constant study asks for in practice is a fixed time. It is one of the questions put to a person in the World to Come: did you set times for Torah? The Alter Rebbe adds that the times must be fixed not only in the day but in the soul.

Week 2, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 10 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Casting our Ego into Water, Seth and Soulmates, connecting to our Father and preparing for Sukkot.

The Song of the Sea reaches the drowning: "a horse and its rider He cast into the sea. The Eternal's strength and His vengeance were my salvation." That is Yom Kippur — we throw ourselves into the water and come out clean. Rabbi Akiva says it outright: Hashem Himself is our mikvah. He is our strength and our song and our salvation, and it is on this day that we actually know it.

The haftorah speaks of "when breaches are made in Israel, when the people offer themselves willingly, bless the Lord." Breaches, *phra'ot*, has the same root as Pharaoh — who stands for the oversized ego and for stubbornness. Seeing what the ego costs, and giving ourselves over willingly, is how the blessing gets said.

The tractate opens here. Daf Beit, the first daf of Sotah, is about how couples are matched and brought together — souls paired before they come down. Two is the number of a mate.

The generation is Seth, who was given to Adam and Eve as consolation for Abel. That belongs to this week too, which is spent undoing what was done, or better, turning it into merit. *Shet* means foundation and source — like the Even Shetiah, the Foundation Stone the world was made from, which sat in the Holy of Holies, the room entered once a year, on this day.

The journey is the second: "The children of Israel journeyed from Rameses and camped in Succoth." Last week was taking in that Hashem is Father and Creator; this week it is Hashem as protector — and in the calendar, after Yom Kippur, we go straight out to build the sukkah.

Seth's lesson for prayer is direction. He is the source, and prayer runs the other way: bringing blessing down, the spiritual into the material.

Week 2, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 11 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Chen, Merit, Life and Death Choices, and the Magen Avraham

"And he had two wives; the name of the one was Hannah and the name of the second was Peninnah; and Peninnah had children, but Hannah had no children." Two wives — two, and marriage, and relationship, which is this week. Peninah means pearl, the beauty that is inside. Channah comes from *chen*, grace and also mercy; Rebbe Nachman makes chen essential to prayer, and the Talmud learns how to pray from Channah herself. All of it is this day: through prayer and fasting the inner beauty is uncovered, grace is found, the past is washed.

Pirkei Avot says of the one who studies Torah for its own sake that "not only that, but the creation of the entire world is worthwhile for him alone." Set that beside the verse: Peninah had children and Channah had none, and yet Peninah and all her children were worth creating because of Channah. The Talmud says the same of Rabbi Chanina — whose name is also from chen — "The whole world is nourished because of Chanina, and for Chanina, one amount of carob is enough from Sabbath eve to the next." (Brachot 17b)

Proverbs' second chapter lays out the two roads: "for her house sinks to death, and her paths lead to the dead… in order that you go in the way of the good, and you keep the ways of the righteous. For the upright shall dwell in the land."

Two yahrzeits. On the eighth of Tishrei, Rabbi Noach of Lechovitch, a link in the chain to Slonim, Kobrin, Koidenov and Karlin, who taught that a Jew who begins to doubt his faith should have faith that he has faith — that it is there, only hidden. On the ninth, the Magen Avraham, among the greatest authorities in Jewish law, sickly as a child, who wrote that when someone wrongs you, do not hold the grudge in silence: say "Why did you do this to me?" — in private, calmly, with soft language.

Week 2, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 12 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Yom Kippur - Entering the Inner Chamber, Enoch, Remembering the Love of Our Youth

"Draw me, we will run after you; the king brought me to his chambers." Having been given a glimpse of being drawn near, we run. And on this one day of the year the Kohen Gadol goes into the inner chamber, the Holy of Holies.

The Talmud calls Yom Kippur, with Tu B'Av, the happiest day of the year — which is a startling thing to say of a day with no feasting and no wine. Rashi reads the wine of this verse as standing for every physical festivity.

Then the song turns to what we are: "I am black but comely, O daughters of Jerusalem! Like the tents of Kedar, like the curtains of Solomon." We have sinned and we are beautiful underneath it, and teshuvah is still open. Rashi: black as the tents of Kedar, blackened by rain because they stand out in the desert — and as easily cleaned, to be like the curtains of Solomon. The next verse is the admission: "they made me a keeper of the vineyards; my own vineyard I did not keep." We were to be a light to the nations and could not keep our own.

Of the seventy souls the second is Enoch, Reuven's firstborn — who carries the name of that earlier Enoch, so righteous that Hashem took him alive and he became an angel. Which is what this day asks of us.

Shevuot opens with laws that "are two that are really four," the doubling of a second week, and its first daf gives most of itself to the Yom Kippur offerings.

Jeremiah's second chapter is the verse Rashi was quoting: "I remember to you the lovingkindness of your youth, the love of your nuptials, your following Me in the desert, in a land not sown." Shavuot was the wedding. This day is the second one, when the second tablets were given.

Week 2, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 13 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Review of the Week of Yom Kippur - Psalms 4-6, 16:5-7, 89:3

The week of Yom Kippur in psalms is the fourth, fifth and sixth, with three verses of the Tikkun HaKlali and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 4 is a man asking to be heard and telling others to stop: “Answer me when I call, O God Who knows my righteousness. You have relieved me in my distress.” Then, “Tremble and do not sin; reflect in your hearts upon your beds, and be silent forever.” Against those who ask who will show us good, he answers that the joy put in his heart is greater than theirs when grain and wine abound, and ends, “In peace and harmony I will lie down and sleep, for You, Lord, will make me dwell alone, in security.”

Psalm 5 is prayer at first light. “Lord, hear my voice in the morning; in the morning I set my prayers before you and hope.” It is blunt about what cannot stand before G-d — the boastful, the speakers of falsehood, whose throat is an open grave though their tongue flatters — and it closes on shelter: “You will envelop him with favor as with a shield.”

Psalm 6 is the one said from the floor. “Lord, do not punish me in Your anger… heal me, O Lord, for my bones tremble in fear. My soul is panic-stricken; and You, O Lord, how long?” Then the line that gives the reason: “For there is no remembrance of You in death; who will praise You in the grave?” And: “I am weary from sighing; each night I drench my bed, I melt my couch with my tears.” It turns at the end — “The Lord has heard my supplication; the Lord accepts my prayer.”

The Tikkun HaKlali’s verses are contentment with what was given: “The Lord is my allotted portion and my cup; You guide my destiny. Portions have fallen to me in pleasant places.” Psalm 89 holds the week’s foundation: “Forever will it be built with kindness.”

Week 2, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 14 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Hen is Saying

The hen opens the gathering, and the week’s six readings come in behind her, a line at a time.

“He gives bread to all flesh, for His kindness endures forever” meets the haftorah’s shelter — “The Lord is my rock and my fortress, and a rescuer to me” — and then the running: “Draw me, we will run after you.” The willing offering follows, “when the people offer themselves willingly, bless the Lord.”

Haazinu's water is broken in two and set on either side of the rejoicing. "My lesson will drip like rain" / "We will rejoice and be glad in you" / "My word will flow like dew" / "They have loved you sincerely" — and then Psalm 89's building, "as the heavens, with which You will establish Your faithfulness."

The sea comes next, "a horse and its rider He cast into the sea," answered by the tents of Kedar and the curtains of Solomon, and by "You guide my destiny." Then the king's chambers, and immediately the two wives: "And he had two wives; the name of the one was Hannah."

From there the song braids the vineyard with the barrenness. "They made me a keeper of the vineyards" / "even the inheritance pleases me" / "my own vineyard I did not keep" / "and the name of the second was Peninnah; and Peninnah had children, but Hannah had no children." The mother's sons who were incensed sit beside the breaches made in Israel, and "I am black but comely" beside "portions have fallen to me in pleasant places."

It ends where a day like this one would want to end: "Even at night my conscience instructs me. I will bless the Lord, Who counseled me."

Week 2, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK III

Tiferet of Chesed

Days 15–21

Day 15 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Be Happy, Balanced, and Secure in G-d

Week three is Sukkot, and the dove sings: "Like a swift or crane, so do I chatter; I moan like a dove, my eyes fail with looking upward; O G-d, I am oppressed, be my security." (Isaiah 38:14) She says one thing more, before the Holy One: "Master of the World! May my sustenance be as bitter as an olive in Your hands, rather than it being sweet as honey through flesh and blood." (Talmud, Eruvin 18b)

That is the whole week in a sentence. We dip the challah in honey and we eat under branches. The word the dove uses for security, *arveni*, means be my guarantor — and can also be read be sweet to me. It is the word behind *Kol Israel Arevim Zeh LaZeh*, that every Jew is responsible for, and mixed up with, and sweet to every other, which is what Sukkot is about.

The sukkah is a flimsy thing, open to the weather. We do our part and we know the rest is not ours. The dove is loyalty: the Torah likens Israel to a dove and tefillin to its wings, and the wings guard the dove as the mitzvot guard us. She is also the bearer of good news — it was the dove Noah sent, who came back with an olive branch.

Three runs through everything here. Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Shimon the son of Gamliel: "By three things is the world sustained: law, truth and peace." (Zachariah 8:16) Those are the three holidays we have now passed: Rosh Hashanah is the Day of Din, judgment; on Yom Kippur we are sealed, and G-d's seal is truth; and Sukkot is peace, the One who spreads a sukkah of peace over us. The world stands on three pillars — Torah, Divine service, acts of kindness — and so on the three fathers, with Jacob third, who is *tiferet*, the balance between Abraham's kindness and Isaac's

strength. After parting from Esau, Jacob went to a place called Sukkot.

The pairing is Tiferet shebeChesed. This week the yahrzeit of the Rebbe Maharash falls, who was born on the seventeenth day of the Omer — tiferet within tiferet — and whose father sometimes called him by it.

And this week we are commanded to be happy. The dove's lesson is not to be anxious, but also to make a vessel: to be grateful, and to keep the place you live in as ordered and pleasant as a sukkah.

Week 3, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 16 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Calling out to G-d and Being Sheltered by Him, Listening and Jacob, Kibzaim and the Holiday of Ingathering

"When I call out the name of the Lord, ascribe greatness to our G-d." (Deuteronomy 32:3) The day after Yom Kippur is called G-d's name, and the four days between Yom Kippur and Sukkot answer to the four letters of it. Then comes the ascribing of greatness, which on Sukkot is done with the hands: a good sukkah, a beautiful etrog, a beautiful lulav. That is what the sages read in "This is my G-d and I will glorify Him." (Exodus 15:2; Shabbat 133b)

The haftorah piles up the shelter: "G-d is my rock, under whom I take cover; My shield, and the horn of my salvation, my support, and my refuge; He is my savior Who saves me from violence." (II Samuel 22:3) Last week's protection was large and far off. This one is close enough to sit under, which is the sukkah.

The quality is attentive listening — *shmi'at haOzen*, the listening of the ear. The ear is where the body keeps its balance, and it is the organ of this holiday. Listening is also what it is to be a vessel: you cannot receive a teaching while talking. On Sukkot we are all vessels, and the blessing comes down through the roof.

The prophet is Jacob, who is this holiday twice over — he travelled to a place called Sukkot, and his yahrzeit falls in it. He is listening itself: a plain man who dwelt in tents, and the Shema opens "Listen, O Israel," where the Midrash reads Israel as Jacob himself.

The Levitical city is Kibzaim, which means two gatherings. Sukkot is Chag Ha'Asif, the festival of the ingathering, when the harvest comes in — and its offerings come in two kinds, those we bring for ourselves and those we bring for the

other nations.

What constant study taught last week, listening tempers this week: be realistic. Enthusiasm sets a schedule nobody can keep. Add a little at a time, as a lifter adds weight. *Tafastah merubah, lo tafastah* — grab too much and you have grabbed nothing.

Week 3, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 17 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Making a Habitation for G-d and Beautifying Him, "Giving Ear" and Receiving the Divine Spirit, Enosh and Sukkoth

"This is my G-d, and I will make Him a habitation, the G-d of my father, and I will ascribe to Him exaltation." A house built to honour Him — which is the sukkah, and which is also *Zeh Keili v'Anvehu*, the beautiful etrog and the beautiful lulav.

The haftorah is all ears: "Hear, O kings, give ear, O princes; I, to the Lord I shall sing." *Anochi* comes twice over, and Rashi reads it as the great revelation that happens under the sukkah — like receiving the Torah over again. Our sins have been let go, and we are happy enough to sing.

Sotah's third daf is about how a Divine spirit enters a person, and Sukkot was the season when people received Ruach HaKodesh.

The generation is Enosh, whose name also means mankind as a whole, and on Sukkot we pray on behalf of the whole world.

The journey is out of the shelter: "They journeyed from Succoth and camped in Etham, at the edge of the desert." Etham can mean a fortress — not unlike a sukkah — and in ancient Egyptian, a seashore. The work of this week is the edge: to take in everything the shelter is giving while you are still in it, so that you can do something with it when you walk out into the world. A small child is entirely inside the fortress. Then comes the shoreline, where you go a little further out and run back for approval, not yet in the desert but at its edge, meeting a world that is not interested in you.

Enosh's lesson is about knowing where you are weak. The Hayom Yom gives four words for a person: *Adam* is mind, *Ish* is heart, *Enosh* is weakness in one or the other or both, and *Gever* is the one who gets past it — Gever works on Enosh to raise him to Ish or Adam. Which means Enosh already has what they have, or it could not be

raised. As Rebbe Nachman said: if you believe you can break, believe you can fix.

Week 3, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 18 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Pilgrimage and Friendship, Happiness and the Maggid of Kozhnitz

"And this man went up out of his city from year to year to worship and to sacrifice unto the Lord of hosts in Shiloh. And the two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, were there priests unto the Lord." Three priests in one verse, and Elkanah going up year after year — Sukkot being one of the three festivals you go up for.

Rashi notices the tense: he *would* go up, season after season. And the Midrash adds the detail that makes him a tzadik rather than merely observant — the road he took one year he did not take the next, so that different people would see him going, and come too. He went up, and the number of pilgrims went up with him.

Pirkei Avot this week says of the one who learns Torah for its own sake that he is called a friend. Elkanah is what that looks like. And this is the week of walking into each other's sukkot.

Proverbs' third chapter is the same subject in instructions: "Do not withhold good from the one who needs it when you have power in your hand to do it. Do not say to your fellow, 'Go and return, and tomorrow I will give,' though you have it with you. Devise no harm against your fellow, when he dwells securely with you. Do not quarrel with anyone without cause, if he did you no harm."

On the fourteenth of Tishrei is the yahrzeit of Rabbi Yisrael Hopstein, the Maggid of Kozhnitz, whom his chassidim called the second Baal Shem Tov. He was born to elderly parents after a blessing from the Baal Shem Tov — and the blessing was earned by their joy, by his father the bookbinder breaking into a dance at the Shabbat table. The Baal Shem Tov smiled that Friday night because he could see the heavenly court dancing along.

He was sickly as a child and a prodigy. As a young man he studied Magen Avraham with a friend before dawn, and came away so alight that he went to ask Rabbi Shmelke of Nickelsburg where the light had come from. Before he could ask, Rabbi Shmelke said: Israel, I can see on your face that you studied Magen Avraham. That book generates a great light in the heart of the wise.

The next day, the first day of Sukkot, is the yahrzeit of Rabbi Mordechai of Lechovitch, whose teaching turns on happiness.

Week 3, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 19 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Shepherds' Dwellings

"Tell me, you whom my soul loves, where do you feed, where do you rest the flocks at noon, for why should I be like one who veils herself beside the flocks of your companions?"

Rashi makes the question harder and better: where do You feed Your flock among these wolves they are standing in the middle of, and where do You rest them at noon — in this exile, which is as hard on them as noon is on a flock. In the sukkah we are out in the weather and we feel the noon sun. The companions are the other nations, and on Sukkot we bring offerings for them too.

Then G-d answers, and because we have been judged and have turned back, He calls us the fairest of women: "go your way in the footsteps of the flocks and pasture your kids beside the shepherds' dwellings." The shepherds' dwellings may be the seven shepherds who come into the sukkah.

The third verse goes back further — Pharaoh's chariots and their horses, silenced. All that was asked of us then was to keep still and trust, which is what the sukkah asks now, remembering forty years of being kept.

Of the seventy souls the third is Pallu, whose name is close to *peleh*, a wonder: the clouds of glory, the manna, the forty years of them.

Shevuot's third daf takes up oaths about eating, and the law of carrying in and out of a home — which is eating in the sukkah, and making the sukkah a home. It also treats lashes for things not done, and the sukkah is the mitzvah you keep by sitting still inside it.

Jeremiah's third chapter answers the Song: "Return, backsliding children, says the Lord, for I possessed you… And I will give you shepherds according to My heart, and they will feed you with knowledge and understanding." And later, on where to put us: "How shall I place you among the sons? But I will give you a desirable land… Call Me 'my Father,' and do not turn away from following Me." All the nations are called

sons there, and we bring for all of them.

Week 3, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 20 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of (the first part) of Sukkot - Psalms 7-9; 16:8-10; 89:4

The first part of Sukkot in psalms is the seventh, eighth and ninth, with three verses of the Tikkun HaKlali and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 7 is a man under pursuit who submits himself to examination. "I put my trust in You, Lord, my G-d; deliver me from all my pursuers and save me. Lest he tear my soul like a lion, crushing me with none to rescue." Then the oath: if I have done this, if there is wrongdoing in my hands, if I have rewarded my friends with evil — then let the enemy overtake me. It settles on the judge: "G-d is the righteous judge," the "Searcher of hearts and minds." And it watches the trap work backwards: "He digs a pit, digs it deep, only to fall into the trap he laid. His mischief will return upon his own head."

Psalm 8 steps outside and looks up. "Lord, our Master, how mighty is Your Name throughout the earth, You Who has set Your majesty upon the heavens! Out of the mouths of babes and sucklings You have established might." Then the question the night sky puts: "When I behold Your heavens, the work of Your fingers, the moon and the stars which You have set in place — what is man that You should remember him?" And the answer, which does not shrink him: "Yet, You have made him but a little less than the angels, and crowned him with honor and glory."

Psalm 9 is thanks and the throne. "I will thank the Lord with all my heart; I will recount all Your wonders… You sat on the throne, O righteous Judge." Its mercy is specific: "The Lord will be a stronghold for the oppressed, a stronghold in times of trouble… He does not forget the cry of the downtrodden."

The Tikkun HaKlali's verses are steadiness: "I have set the Lord before me at all times; because He is at my right hand, I shall not falter. Therefore my heart rejoices and my soul exults; my flesh, too, rests secure." And Psalm 89 swears: "I have made a covenant with My chosen one; I have sworn to David, My servant."

Week 3, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 21 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Dove is Saying

The dove opens, and this week the gathering is full of listening and sheltering.

"Like a swift or crane, so do I chatter" is answered by "Hear, O kings, give ear, O princes," and then Haazinu — "When I call out the name of the Lord" / "Ascribe greatness to our G-d" — and the Song of the Sea's own ascribing: "the G-d of my father, and I will ascribe to Him exaltation."

Then the dove speaks before the Holy One, and the haftorah's rescue falls in beside her, with Elkanah going up: "He is my savior Who saves me from violence" / "to worship and to sacrifice unto Hashem of hosts in Shiloh."

The moaning and the cover come together. "I moan like a dove, my eyes fail with looking upward" / "G-d is my rock, under whom I take cover" / "This is my G-d, and I will make Him a habitation" / "I have set the Lord before me at all times" / "O G-d, I am oppressed, be my security."

The olive and the honey sit at the centre — "May my sustenance be as bitter as an olive in Your hands, rather than it being sweet as honey through flesh and blood" — with "My support, and my refuge" and "Because He is at my right hand, I shall not falter" on either side of "Master of the World!"

Toward the end the covenant and the flocks braid together: "I have made a covenant with My chosen one" / "if you do not know, O fairest of women" / "go your way in the footsteps of the flocks" / "my flesh, too, rests secure" / "I have sworn to David, My servant." Hophni and Phinehas come in at Shiloh, and the song ends where the shepherds are: "where do you feed, where do you rest the flocks at noon" — "and pasture your kids beside the shepherds' dwellings."

Week 3, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK IV

Netzach of Chesed

Days 22–28

Day 22 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Take Responsibility for All, Yet Protecting Oneself from Bad Influences

Week four holds the end of Sukkot — Hoshanah Rabbah, Shemini Atzeret, Simchat Torah — and the eagle sings: "And You, G-d, Lord of Hosts, Lord of Israel, awake to remember all the nations; do not be gracious to any wicked traitors, sela!" (Psalms 59:6) To remember can mean for good or for punishment, and the second half of her verse leans to the second.

That is the turn this week makes. All through Sukkot we have been bringing offerings for the nations. On Shemini Atzeret they stop, and the Jewish people are alone with G-d.

The eagle is the highest-flying bird, which gives her the widest view of everything made. Unlike other birds she carries her young on her wings rather than in her talons, because nothing can reach them up there: "You have seen what I did unto the Egyptians, and how I took them on eagles' wings and brought them to Me." (Exodus 19:4) She renews her feathers year after year, and in this week each community finishes the whole Torah and starts it again at once. And for the hoshanot and the hakafot we spend these days circling the bimah, which is what an eagle does.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yehudah HaNassi: be as careful with a small mitzvah as with a great one, because you do not know what each is worth. Some people suppose that dancing with the Torah counts for less than the prayers of Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur. It does not.

He then names three things to keep in mind, which are really four: know what is above you — a seeing eye, a listening ear, and all your deeds written in a book. Those are the four holidays we have just walked through. Rosh Hashanah is knowing; on

Yom Kippur He sees; Sukkot is the ear; and on Hoshanah Rabbah the judgment is finished and written.

The pairing is Netzach shebeChesed. The Torah ends with Moses blessing each of the twelve tribes, and Moses is netzach — victory and endurance, which is what finishing feels like. Rebbe Nachman, whose yahrzeit falls in this week, said of himself that his sefirah was netzach: "I have been victorious and I will be victorious; I have finished and I will finish." Two of his great themes are to be always happy and to always begin again, which is Simchat Torah exactly.

The eagle's lesson is to care about more than yourself. Caring for others is also one of the better ways out of sadness.

Week 4, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 23 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Justice, Speech, Moses, Beit-Horon and Leaving the Sukkah.

"The deeds of the Mighty Rock are perfect, for all His ways are justice; a faithful God, without injustice He is righteous and upright." (Deuteronomy 32:4) On Hoshanah Rabbah the year's judgment is sent out, and this is the verse for a judgment you can trust.

The haftorah answers with noise: "With praise, I call to the Lord, for from my enemies I shall be saved." (II Samuel 22:4) These are the days of calling out and dancing — and it echoes the eagle, who asked G-d to remember the nations and not to favour traitors.

The quality is verbal enunciation, saying the thing out loud. Hoshanah Rabbah is built on it: all the hoshanot of the previous days are said aloud, and the blessings of the coming year are brought down by speech. Then on Shemini Atzeret and Simchat Torah the Torah is taken up in a way that is not thought at all. We lift it with our bodies and dance. Torah cannot stay in the head; it has to come out through the mouth and into the world.

The prophet is Moses, who is this quality's hardest case. Speech did not come easily to him — in large part because his soul was so high that bringing its thoughts down into words was difficult. Which is the work of these days: getting what is pure in thought down into action, and into the dancing.

The Levitical city is Beth-Horon, a hollow house. On Shemini Atzeret we say goodbye to the sukkah and leave it empty — and carry its holiness out with us, into the year and into the world.

What this quality asks in practice is that you talk about what you learn. If Torah is only in study hours it is not yet real; it has to get into ordinary conversation, and be told to someone else. Proverbs says, a mitzvah is a candle and the Torah is light. A candle stands in one place. Light travels.

Week 4, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 24 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Being Secluded with G-d and Casting the Enemy Aside

"The Lord is a Master of war; the Lord is His Name. Pharaoh's chariots and his army He cast into the sea." The haftorah stands in the same place: "I shall sing to the Lord, the G-d of Israel. Lord, when You went forth out of Seir" — Seir being where Esau lives. Three books this week are about the enemy being dealt with.

Sotah's daf takes up *yichud*, being shut in alone with someone. That is what Shemini Atzeret is: the day G-d keeps for Himself with the Jewish people, after the guests have gone.

The generation is Keinan, whose name looks like a version of Kayin — Cain — with an extra *nun*, the letter that stands elsewhere for the fiftieth gate, the power of prayer and of teshuvah. His whole line runs parallel to Cain's, as a kosher version of it, and humanity carries on through Keinan while Cain's line is set aside. Though not entirely: Noah's wife Na'amah came from Cain's side.

The journey goes to the hard place: "They journeyed from Etham and camped in Pi hahiroth, which faces Baal zephon; and they camped in front of Migdol." Last week was the edge of the desert. This week is the mouth of the rocks, camped in front of a place of idolatry. The work is to lift the material world and bring all of it to worship the one G-d.

Keinan's lesson is that serving G-d is a *kinyan*, an acquisition — the root inside both Keinan and Cain. To acquire a thing you have to give something of yourself, usually what you worked for. The last days of Sukkot are a marathon: intense, and tiring, and what you come out with is measured by what you put in. That is why it is

called *avodah*, which means work.

Week 4, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 25 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Thinking of Others, Feeling Beloved, and the Rebbes of Chortkov and Ribnitz

"And it came to pass upon a day, when Elkanah sacrificed, that he gave to Peninnah his wife, and to all her sons and her daughters, portions." Portions for everyone — which is Sukkot, when offerings are brought for all the nations. And the verse is a set-up for the next one, where he gives Hannah a double portion. Which is what happens now: after the week of everyone, a day is kept for the Jewish people alone.

Shemini Atzeret is the hour after a great party, when the guests have gone home and only the one He loves is still there. And the word Pirkei Avot gives this week is exactly that: *beloved*.

Proverbs' fourth chapter is a chapter about not letting go. "Do not leave her, and she will preserve you; love her and she will guard you. The beginning of wisdom is to acquire wisdom, and with all your possession acquire understanding. Search for her, and she will exalt you; she will honor you when you embrace her. She will give your head a wreath of grace; she will transmit to you a crown of glory."

On the twenty-first of Tishrei, Hoshanah Rabbah, is the yahrzeit of Rabbi David Moshe Friedman, the first Chortkover Rebbe, son of the Rizhiner. Chortkov drew wealthy chassidim and served Hashem through wealth, which was the Rizhiner's own way — bringing blessing down into the physical, which is this week's business.

And on the twenty-fourth, the Ribnitzer Rebbe, Rabbi Chaim Zanvil Abramowitz, who went the other way entirely: a worker of miracles who fasted from Shabbat to Shabbat for some sixty years, and whose times for prayer seemed not to be bound by clock or place. Both of them are Rizhin. The Rizhiner himself descended from Rabbi Avraham the Angel and from the Maggid of Mezritch, and those two were known for exactly that kind of heavenly life.

Week 4, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 26 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

The Crown of the Angel Metat

"Your cheeks are comely with rows, your neck with necklaces. We will make you rows of gold with studs of silver." These two are G-d speaking to us, and Rashi reads them as the spoils of the sea, when Israel emptied Egypt out — physically, and of its sparks.

The words themselves sound like this week. *Torim*, rows, are also lines: lines of dancers, or lines of a song. *Charuzim*, studs, are also rhymes — the piyyutim of the hakafot and of Tefilat Geshem. And silver, Chassidus says, comes from *kissufim*, longing: the wanting to hold on to G-d in these days. Rashi adds a forehead plate to the rows. He adorns us and we adorn Him.

The strongest hint is in the first word. *Lehi* is a cheek, and also a jawbone — the jawbone of a donkey, *chamor*, matter, with which Samson struck down a thousand Philistines, and out of which water came. The great dancing of Sukkot is the water drawing, and out of that water came Ruach HaKodesh, as the spirit rested on Samson in that fight.

The Baal Shem Tov, on Simchat Torah: Michael boasted that the archangel Metat ties crowns for G-d out of Israel's prayers — "Today, I shall fashion an even more glorious crown for the Almighty out of these torn shoes."

Then the third verse: "While the king was still at his table, my spikenard gave forth its fragrance." Sukkot belongs to all the nations, and then on the last day He keeps a private audience for us alone — just ourselves, at His table. The commentators do not agree whether that fragrance is sweet or not, which may be the point: it is closeness, and a little inadequacy, as the reading of the Torah starts over.

Of the seventy souls the fourth is Hezron — also a descendant of Judah, the father of Caleb. *Chatzer* is a courtyard, and this is the Temple courtyard, where the dancing was: "So abundant was the light that there was no courtyard in Jerusalem that was not illumined by the light coming from the place of the water-drawing." (Mishnah, Sukkah 5:2)

Shevuot's fourth daf is about punishment for inaction, and these days are all deeds. Jeremiah's fourth chapter asks for the same turning: "If you return, O Israel, says the Lord, to Me, you shall return, and if you remove your detestable things from

My Presence, you shall not wander." Its later verses keep returning to the voice of the shofar, as the season of judgment closes.

Week 4, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 27 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Hoshanah,Shmini Atzeret, Simchat Torah - Psalms 10-12; 16:11; 32:1-3; 89:5

Hoshanah, Shmini Atzeret and Simchat Torah in psalms: the tenth, eleventh and twelfth, with a verse of the Tikkun HaKlali, the opening of Psalm 32, and a verse of Psalm 89.

Psalm 10 is the longest look this book takes at a man who believes he will not be caught. "Why, O Lord, do You stand afar, do You hide Yourself in times of distress?" The wicked man glories in what he wants; he says in his heart, "I shall not falter; for all generations no evil will befall me"; his mouth is full of oaths and deceit; he lies in wait "like a lion in his lair" for the poor. Twice he says the thing the psalm is answering: "God has forgotten, He conceals His countenance, He will never see." And the answer comes back flat: "Indeed, You do see!" It ends asking for the orphan and the downtrodden, "so that the wicked shall no longer crush the frail of the earth."

Psalm 11 is short and steady. "I have placed my trust in the Lord; thus how can you say of my soul… that it flees like a bird?" The wicked have the arrow already on the string, to shoot in the dark at the upright. And then the sentence that settles it: "The Lord is in His holy Sanctuary, the Lord's throne is in heaven, yet His eyes behold, His pupils probe mankind."

Psalm 12 is about speech gone bad. "Men speak falsehood to one another; with flattering lips, with a duplicitous heart do they speak"; those who say, "With our tongues we shall prevail." Against them: "The words of the Lord are pure words, like silver refined in the finest earthen crucible, purified seven times."

The Tikkun HaKlali's verse is the one these days are for: "Make known to me the path of life, that I may be satiated with the joy of Your presence, with the bliss of Your right hand forever." Psalm 32 opens on forgiveness — "Praiseworthy is he whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is concealed" — and on what silence cost: "When I was silent, my bones decayed with my moaning all day long." Psalm 89 holds the

throne: “Until eternity, I shall establish your seed.”

Week 4, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 28 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Eagle is Saying

The eagle opens, and this gathering is justice and praise braided with a table set for two.

“And You, G-d, Lord of Hosts, Lord of Israel” meets Haazinu’s verdict — “a faithful God, without injustice He is righteous and upright” — and then the haftorah’s shout, “With praise, I call to the Lord, for from my enemies I shall be saved,” and the sea closing over the chariots.

The eagle’s “awake to remember all the nations” is answered by “the Lord is a Master of war; the Lord is His Name,” and the Rock’s perfect deeds come in two halves around it, “for all His ways are justice.” Seir follows, and then the hard end of the eagle’s verse: “do not be gracious to any wicked traitors, sela!”

Then the song turns, and the rest of it is almost entirely tenderness. “Make known to me the path of life” / “Your cheeks are comely with rows, your neck with necklaces” / “And it came to pass upon a day, when Elkanah sacrificed” / “with the bliss of Your right hand forever” / “Praiseworthy is the man to whom the Lord ascribes no iniquity.”

The portions for Peninnah and her children are set beside the concealed sin, and the silence beside the king’s table: “whose sin is concealed” / “When I was silent” / “While the king was still at his table, my spikenard gave forth its fragrance” / “my bones decayed with my moaning all day long.”

It closes on being forgiven and adorned at once: “Praiseworthy is he whose transgression is forgiven” / “that I may be satiated with the joy of Your presence” / “We will make you rows of gold with studs of silver.”

Week 4, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK V

Hod of Chesed

Days 29–35

Day 29 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Use All Tools Available in order to Elevate the World

Week five is Rosh Chodesh Cheshvan, and the crane asks for instruments: "Give thanks to G-d with the lyre; make music for Him with the ten-stringed harp." (Psalms 33:2) Not the voice alone. With a lyre, the music made for Him is more beautiful than it was.

That is the month. Cheshvan belongs to the tribe of Menashe, Joseph's firstborn, who helped his father run the whole Egyptian empire. Tishrei was for gathering holiness; Cheshvan is for carrying it into ordinary work and spending it there, using every power and tool and technology we have.

Pirkei Avot says the same thing in Rabban Gamliel the son of Rabbi Yehudah HaNassi: "Beautiful is the study of Torah with the way of the world, for the toil of them both causes sin to be forgotten. Ultimately, all Torah study that is not accompanied with work is destined to cease and to cause sin." He goes on about serving the community for the sake of Heaven, and about governments, who "befriend a person only for their own needs… they do not stand by a person at the time of his distress."

Then Hillel, on living among people: do not separate yourself from the community; do not trust yourself until the day you die; do not judge your fellow until you have stood in his place. And do not say "when I free myself of my concerns, I will study" — because you may never be free. In a place where there are no men, strive to be a man.

Hillel also saw a skull floating on the water and said to it: because you drowned others, you were drowned; and those who drowned you will themselves be drowned.

A fitting thing at the opening of Cheshvan, which is the month of the Flood — and those waters stand for the material concerns that threaten to drown a person.

The pairing is Hod shebeChesed, which belongs to Aaron and to the service of the Kohanim. Cheshvan is the month in which the third Temple is to be inaugurated, and that is where the Kohanim will lift the material world through what they offer.

The crane's own lesson is music. It is one of the oldest ways of fighting sadness: David played the harp to lift Saul out of his torment, and the Levites sang while the Kohanim worked.

Week 5, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 30 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

The Flood, Aharon, and Perception of the Heart

"Destruction is not His; it is His children's defect you crooked and twisted generation." (Deuteronomy 32:5) Cheshvan is the month of the Mabul, the Flood in the time of Noah, and this is a verse about a generation that brought its own ruin.

The haftorah is nearer still to that water: "For the pains of death have encompassed me; streams of scoundrels would affright me." (II Samuel 22:5) *Nachalei Bli'al*, the streams of scoundrels, read more literally as rivers of G-dlessness.

The quality is perception of the heart, *Binat Ha'Lev*. Noah's great mistake was not using his heart to see that G-d wanted him to pray for the rest of mankind. Prayer is called the service of the heart — and *teivah*, the word for ark, also means a word, which is prayer. It is prayer that keeps a person above the water. The Torah also calls the makers of the Temple's vessels *Chochmei Lev*, wise of heart.

The prophet is Aharon, whom perception of the heart describes better than anything else. He is the mediator, the one who could make peace between people and between a husband and a wife. And he was the first Kohen Gadol, serving in the Mishkan, the Temple that travelled.

The Levitical city is Taanach, whose origin is unclear but looks to come from *lehi'taanot*, to fast. There is a custom among the pious to fast on the first Monday, Thursday and Monday of Cheshvan — *BaHaB*. Not fasting for its own sake: to mark the line between the holidays of Tishrei and what comes after, and to get some hold over the physical. Which is the month's whole work, conquering the world with what

Tishrei gave.

And the quality asks one more thing: let the Torah you learn reach your heart, not only your mind. As one of my Talmud teachers would ask — do you feel the question? If you do not feel the question you cannot really value the answer. And if the Torah is not in your heart you will not reach anyone else's.

Week 5, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 31 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

the Field and the Flood

"And the elite of his officers sank in the Red Sea. The depths covered them; they descended into the depths like a stone." The haftorah adds, "when You marched out of the field of Edom, the earth trembled, the heavens also dripped." Officers going under, depths closing over, heavens dripping — the Flood is in all of it, when the whole world went under its own depths.

The field matters too. Jacob was the wholesome man who sat in tents; his brother Eisav was the man of the field, out in the affairs of the world. Ephraim, who belongs to Tishrei, studied with Jacob as a child. Menashe's place is the field — ground that once belonged to Eisav alone.

Sotah's fifth daf takes up haughtiness and adultery, which are the two things that brought the Flood on. The Torah names sexual corruption and violent robbery — *chamas* — as its causes: "And the land was corrupted and the land was filled with violent robbery." Once the boundaries of personal conduct go, everything becomes permitted. And Noah himself lacked a kind of humility, praying for his own household and not for anyone else; Avraham and Moshe did not do that.

The generation is Mahalalel, who looks like a kosher version of Mehijael, of the line of Cain. Mahalalel holds *halel*, praise; Mehijael is spelled with a *chet* where Mahalalel has a *hay*. A hay is a chet with an opening in it. Chet belongs to sin; hay belongs to malchut and to teshuvah, and the opening is the door the returning person comes back through — teshuvah read as *tashuv hey*, restoring the hay.

The journey leaves the water: "They journeyed from Penei hahiroth and crossed in the midst of the sea to the desert. They walked for three days in the desert of Etham and camped in Marah." Note the change from *pi*, a mouth, to *pnei*, a face. Three days

without water, and then bitter water — Marah, which is why Cheshvan is called Mar Cheshvan, bitter, having no holidays yet. The last stage of growing up is leaving the sheltered world of water for the dry one. Moses had to push them out of the sea into the desert; they did not want to go. And at Marah, when the water could not be drunk, he threw in a tree and it became drinkable. Bitterness comes to everyone, and there are two things to do with it: be overwhelmed, or find the sweetness buried in it, which is also where healing comes from.

Mahalalel's lesson for prayer is in his name: *Hallel veHoda'ah*, praise and thanks. Prayer is serving with the whole heart — getting excited, singing, dancing if you can. Read off a page by routine, there is a good chance nothing is being done at all. You have to know before Whom you are standing, and be glad about it.

Week 5, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 32 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Loving G-d and Bringing Him into the World: Ryzhin and Bluzhev

"But unto Hannah he gave a double portion; for he loved Hannah, but the Lord had shut up her womb." Loved, and childless. It is Rachel's story again — Jacob loved her and she had no children — and one of the few dates Cheshvan does mark is Rachel's yahrzeit, on the eleventh.

The week's quality is *Ohev et HaMakom*, loves G-d, which reads literally as loving the Place. G-d is called the Place because He is not in the world; the world is in Him, and there is nowhere without Him. Which is the point just now: stepping out of the Garden of Eden that is Tishrei into the danger of Cheshvan and the world's business, He is still there. We are still inside Him.

Proverbs' fifth chapter is about love and about what can go wrong once you are out in the world: "For the lips of a strange woman drip honey, and her palate is smoother than oil. But her end is as bitter as wormwood, as sharp as a two-edged sword." And then the other way: "Drink water from your own cistern and running water from your own spring… you shall always be intoxicated with her love." Rashi reads the strange woman as foreign gods and the wife of your youth, your own cistern, as the Torah. The water is right for the month of the Flood.

The yahrzeits stay with Rizhin. On the twenty-ninth of Tishrei, Rav Menachem Mendel of Vizhnitz, the Rizhiner's son-in-law and the founder of Vizhnitz; and often this week the Rizhiner himself, on the third of Cheshvan.

A story of him and the Tzemach Tzaddik at a meal: the Rizhiner put down his fork halfway through, and explained that before he was born he had made an agreement with his soul to eat only enough to get by and not a morsel more. The Tzemach Tzaddik said that he had just understood something that had bothered him all his life — why on Friday night we welcome the angels and then so soon send them off. Because angels cannot taste food, and we do not want to eat in front of them. Then he put down his own fork, which said who he thought he was sitting with.

Also usually this week, Rabbi Yisrael Spira, the Bluzhover Rebbe, who survived the camps and lost his wife and children there. He lit Chanukah candles in Bergen-Belsen, and was asked how he could possibly say *Sheheheyanu* — who has kept us alive and brought us to this time — while thousands were dying. He said he had asked himself the same thing, and found his answer in the crowd: that people had risked their lives to come and watch the candles lit. That G-d has Jews like that is reason enough to say it.

Week 5, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 33 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

The Temple and the World, the Field and the Flood (again)

"A bundle of myrrh is my beloved to me; between my breasts he shall lie. A cluster of henna-flowers is my beloved to me, in the vineyards of Ein-Gedi." Then His answer: "Behold, you are comely, my beloved; behold, you are comely; your eyes are like doves."

The first two are ours, and they are about Him resting in our midst — which is the Temple, and the reason the world was made. Rashi ties it to being forgiven and to His dwelling in the Mishkan. And the word for henna, *kofer*, is the word for the pitch Noah was told to caulk the ark with, inside and out. The third verse is forgiveness again, but nearer the Flood: it was the dove who brought the news that there was dry land.

Cheshvan is the month of the Flood and the month the third Temple is to be built, and the month for going out into the world. All three are in these verses.

Of the seventy souls the fifth is Carmi. *Kerem* is a vineyard, as in Ein-Gedi above, and Carmi can be read Kerem-Yud, the vineyard of Hashem, which is the Temple. It is also the season for working your own fields and vineyards — and one of the first things Noah did was plant a vineyard.

Shevuot's fifth daf is technical: deriving law from a general statement followed by a particular one, forgetting after knowing where offerings are concerned, carrying from a private domain into a public one, and the signs of tzara'as. Which is a fair picture of re-entering the world: leaving the private domain, risking forgetting what you knew, and having to behave well among the minutiae of a place that is not clean.

Jeremiah's fifth chapter sends someone looking: "Stroll in the streets of Jerusalem, and see now and know, and seek in its squares, whether you will find a man, whether there is one who performs justice, who seeks faith, and I will forgive her." He wants to forgive. He is looking for one person to dwell in — someone who does justice and seeks faith, as Noah did in his generation. The rest of the chapter is the destruction coming, which is the Flood again.

Week 5, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 34 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Rosh Chodesh Cheshvan - Psalms 13-15; 32:4-6; 89:6

Rosh Chodesh Cheshvan in psalms: the thirteenth, fourteenth and fifteenth, with three verses of the Tikkun HaKlali and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 13 is marked as a prayer for the end of the long exile, for anyone in distress to say over his troubles. It is four questions in a row, all beginning the same way. "How long, O Lord, will You forget me, forever? How long will You hide Your countenance from me? How long must I seek counsel within my soul, to escape the grief in my heart all day? How long will my enemy be exalted over me?" Then the demand: "Look! Answer me, O Lord, my G-d; give light to my eyes, lest I sleep the sleep of death." And it turns, in one verse: "I have placed my trust in Your kindness, my heart will rejoice in Your deliverance."

Psalm 14 is marked as speaking of the destruction of the two Temples. “The fool says in his heart, 'There is no G-d!'” Then the looking down: “The Lord looked down from heaven upon mankind, to see if there was any wise man who searches for G-d. They have all gone astray together… there is none who does good, not even one.” It ends wanting the deliverance to come out of Zion.

Psalm 15 is the short list of what a person has to be. “Who may abide in Your tent, O Lord? Who may dwell on Your holy Mountain? He who walks blamelessly, acts justly, and speaks truth in his heart; who has no slander on his tongue, who has done his fellowman no evil… who does not change his oath even if it is to his own detriment; who does not lend his money at interest, nor accept a bribe against the innocent.” And the promise at the end: “He who does these things shall never falter.”

The Tikkun HaKlali’s verses are confession and its relief: “For day and night Your hand was heavy upon me; my marrow became dry as the droughts of summer… My sin I made known to You, my iniquity I did not cover… and You have forgiven the iniquity of my transgression forever.” Then, for this month exactly: “indeed, the flood of many waters will not reach him.”

Week 5, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 35 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Crane is Saying

The crane opens with her instruments, and this week the gathering is water and confession laid against each other.

“Give thanks to G-d with the lyre” is answered by the hand that was heavy — “For day and night Your hand was heavy upon me” — and then by the heavens extolling, and by “Behold, you are comely, my beloved.”

The drowning comes in from three sides at once. “For the pains of death have encompassed me” / “My marrow became dry as the droughts of summer, Selah” / “And the elite of his officers sank in the Red Sea.” Myrrh follows directly: “A bundle of myrrh is my beloved to me; between my breasts he shall lie” — and then the confession, “My sin I made known to You, my iniquity I did not cover.”

Hannah’s double portion sits between the streams of scoundrels and the crooked generation. “But unto Hannah he gave a double portion; for he loved Hannah, but

Hashem had shut up her womb" / "Streams of scoundrels would affright me" / "You crooked and twisted generation."

Then the depths and the promise against them: "The depths covered them" / "indeed, the flood of many waters will not reach him" / "They descended into the depths like a stone."

It ends with the music returning, and the forgiveness. "Make music for Him with the ten-stringed harp" / "the earth trembled, the heavens also dripped" / "Your faithfulness, too, in the congregation of the holy ones" / "And You have forgiven the iniquity of my transgression forever" — and the last lines are henna in the vineyards, the field of Edom, and "I said, 'I will confess my transgressions to the Lord.'"

Week 5, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK VI

Yesod of Chesed

Days 36–42

Day 36 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Impact the World, Laying a Foundation for Future Generations

Week six is the second week of Cheshvan, and the songbird sings about a house: "The songbird has also found her home, and the sparrow a nest for herself, where she may lay her young — Your altars, G-d of Hosts – my King and my Lord." (Psalms 84:4) A nest, and the altars in the same breath. It is in this month that the third Temple, His house and the place of His altars, is to be dedicated.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabban Yochanan the son of Zakkai, who took the tradition from Hillel and Shammai: "If you have learned much Torah, do not take credit for yourself — it is for this that you have been formed."

He had five disciples, which makes six of them, and he praised each for what he could carry: Rabbi Eliezer the son of Hurkenus is a cemented cistern that loses not a drop; Rabbi Yehoshua the son of Chananya — fortunate is she who gave birth to him; Rabbi Yossi the Kohen is a chassid; Rabbi Shimon the son of Nethanel fears sin; Rabbi Elazar ben Arach is an ever-increasing wellspring.

Then he sent them out with a question: which is the best trait a person can acquire? A good eye, said one. A good friend. A good neighbour. To see what is born out of your own actions. And Rabbi Elazar said: a good heart — and his teacher preferred it, because it contained all the others. Asked the opposite, Rabbi Elazar said: an evil heart. Same answer.

His own life was that going out. He got free of the siege of Jerusalem just before it fell and built a place for scholars at Yavneh, where the Oral Torah was passed on and Judaism survived. Which is Cheshvan: leaving the inward season and going into the world to hold things up.

The pairing is Yesod shebeChesed — Joseph, who fed his whole family and most of the world besides. He read Pharaoh's dream and stocked the granaries against seven years of famine, and so became the foundation under everyone else's good, in both senses.

The songbird's lesson follows from the nest. Beyond caring for others, build something that will hold for your children, and for your students, and for whoever comes after. For a person sinking under their own troubles, that can be the thing that pulls them up.

Week 6, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 37 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Being Pressed to Perform, Yehoshua and Awe

"Is this how you repay the Lord, you disgraceful, unwise people?! Is He not your Father, your Master? He has made you and established you." (Deuteronomy 32:6) That is ingratitude, after everything — the generation of the Flood, who managed to forget who made them. The haftorah stays in that water: "Bands of those that shall inherit the nether world have surrounded me; the snares of death confronted me." (II Samuel 22:6)

The quality is awe, *eimah*. After the Flood Noah felt it, having watched a world end. The Temple inspires it too.

It is worth separating awe from fear, which is next week's quality. *Yirah* is the ordinary word for fear: what you feel facing an immediate danger, or walking into an interview. *Eimah* is lower and longer — the dull, gnawing dread of something not yet visible, what a person feels marching toward a war. Studying Torah holds both. The Machzor Vitri says a student feels the direct fear of the teacher in whose presence he sits, and a more general awe at being in G-d's presence with G-d's Torah, which he must not misunderstand.

Yaakov had yirah at the place that became the Temple: "How awesome is this place! This is none other than the house of G-d, and this is the gate of heaven." Moshe had it at the bush: "Remove your shoes from your feet, for the place upon which you stand is holy soil" — and he hid his face, because he was afraid to look.

The prophet is Yehoshua, who has the same scene and reacts differently. Outside Jericho he meets a man with a drawn sword, asks "Are you for us, or for our adversaries?", and is told: "No, but I am the captain of the host of the Lord." He falls on his face, and is told to take off his shoe, for the place is holy. The Torah does not say he was afraid. He was Moshe's disciple and used to revelation — and this was the archangel Michael, not G-d Himself at the bush. The Talmud says the angel came in part because Yehoshua was neglecting Torah study at night when he was not actually fighting, which may be why the sword was out.

The Levitical city is Gath-Rimmon, the winepress of pomegranates. In Cheshvan we are pressed, to fill ourselves with as much good as a pomegranate holds seeds.

And that is the lesson: going with the flow is sometimes not enough. You have to press yourself, and know how much more there is to do.

Week 6, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 38 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Descending in order to Ascend and Sweetening "Bitter Waters"

"Your right hand, O Lord, is most powerful; Your right hand, O Lord, crushes the foe." The haftorah: "also the clouds dripped water. The mountains melted at the presence of the Lord." Clouds dripping and mountains melting — the Flood is still over this month.

Sotah's sixth daf takes up forbidden marriages, which were among the Flood's causes, and the bitter waters that would punish or clear a woman accused when her witnesses could not be brought.

The generation is Yered, who looks like a kosher Irad — the same name without the *ayin*. Ayin means an eye, and part of what undid Cain was the way he looked at his brother's accepted offering; sins of this kind begin with the eye. Ayin also means nothing, and Ecclesiastes says the difference between a person and a beast is *ayin*, nothing — read deeper, the ability to hold yourself as nothing, as part of the Infinite Light. Perhaps Yered made his ayin into such thorough nothingness that it stopped appearing in his name.

Cain's line runs Enoch, Mehujael, Irad — education, then a profane life, then descent, going downhill. Seth's line runs the other way: Mahalalel, Yered, Enoch —

praise, then lowering yourself, in order to teach the next one. The results speak for themselves. Cain's descendants found better and better ways to be depraved and better weapons to kill with, until Cain was killed by one. Yered taught his son well, and that Enoch walked with G-d and was taken so the world's corruption could not reach him; his son Metushelach lived longest of anyone and died before the Flood came.

Yered and *Irad* both come from *laredet*, to go down. Which is this month's work: coming down from the heights of Tishrei to make this world a home.

The journey arrives somewhere good: "They journeyed from Marah and arrived in Elim, and in Elim there were twelve springs of water and seventy palm trees." Twelve springs for twelve tribes, seventy palms for seventy nations, and the tribes' water is what waters the palms. Elim is the strength that comes up out of bitterness — the same letters as the Name written with a *hay*, reordered to read *eli mah*, the hidden dimension of love, which emerges from inside the dark.

Exile has mixed everything up — which tribe a Jew belongs to, which nation a man comes from. *Bilbul*, a mix-up, is the root of *Bavel*, and the Talmud we learn is the Bavli: by logic and the rules of reading, confusion is sorted and put back where it belongs. *Mabul*, the Flood, is the same root, because the Flood mixed everything too.

Yered's lesson for prayer is humility, which is in his name. The one who leads is called *Yored Lifnei HaTeivah*, he who goes down before the Ark; the place he stands was lower than the room, and the law forbids praying from a raised place. Prayer comes from underneath: out of the depths I called You.

Week 6, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 39 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Dealing with Difficult People

"And her rival vexed her sore, to make her fret, because the Lord had shut up her womb." Channah's story is Rachel's again — childless, and watching her sister bear one child after another. Rachel's yahrzeit is the eleventh of Cheshvan.

The week's quality is *Ohev et HaBri'ot*, loves people — more exactly, loves the creatures. It belongs to Aharon: "Be of the disciples of Aharon — a lover of peace, a pursuer of peace, loves the creatures and draws them close to Torah." Our sages say

creatures is the word used because Aharon loved the people who had nothing else obviously good about them except that G-d had made them. In Cheshvan, out in the world, we meet exactly those people, and the work is to love them and learn from them.

Which is Channah's situation precisely. She lived beside a rival who taunted her for being childless, and that took real love of people and a real willingness to judge her favourably. We are told Peninah's motive was actually good — she wanted to sharpen Channah's prayers.

Proverbs' sixth chapter is a chapter about dealing with other people, and about learning from creatures that are not people at all. On standing surety for a stranger: "you have been trapped by the sayings of your mouth." On getting free: "Save yourself like a deer from the hand and like a bird from the hand of the snare." On industry: "Go to the ant, you sluggard; see her ways and become wise." And a portrait you would recognise anywhere: "An unscrupulous man, a man of violence, walks with a crooked mouth; he winks with his eyes, shuffles with his feet, points with his fingers."

The seventh of Cheshvan is the yahrzeit of Rabbi Yehuda Meir Shapiro of Lublin, who made the Daf Yomi cycle an institution — a devoted chassid of the Chortoker Rebbe, chief rabbi of Galina and Piotrkov, author of Or HaMeir, and founder of Yeshivat Chachmei Lublin in 1930. He had to argue the Jewish leadership of his day into Daf Yomi, partly against his own youth. It is now the measure of Talmud study across the world.

The ninth is the yahrzeit of Rabbi Yidele Horowitz, the Dzikover Rebbe, raised by his grandfather the Vizhnitzer. A formidable scholar who could not stand being treated as a rebbe, lived frugally, and gave away every penny sent to him by his chassidim, to orphans and widows.

Week 6, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 40 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

the Temple, Shimon and Hamas

"Behold, you are comely, my beloved, yea pleasant; also our couch is leafy. The beams of our houses are cedars; our corridors are cypresses." Then a new chapter opens: "I am a rose of Sharon, a rose of the valleys."

The first two are ours, and they are about Him resting among us — the Temple again. Rashi reads *yea pleasant* as His overlooking our transgression and letting His Shechinah rest in our midst, which is the praise of the fire coming down, "and all the people saw and shouted for joy." *Our couch is leafy* he reads as leafy with sons and daughters, all gathered to Him. Both the Tabernacle and the Temple are called a bed, because they are the source of Israel's fruitfulness. *The beams of our houses are cedars* is the praise of the Tabernacle — and the cypresses of the next line are the wood the Ark was built from.

Chavatzelet, the rose, our sages read as *chav tzel*, the shade of love, which Betzalel built: the Temple itself.

Of the seventy souls the sixth is Shimon — of all Jacob's sons the one tied to violence, which is what brought the Flood. *Chamas* is the word, and Jacob says of Shimon and Levi that their weapons are weapons of chamas. The name Shimon itself comes from *shmiah*, hearing.

Shevuot's sixth daf is mostly the afflictions of the metzora, with a dispute about colour. The metzora stands for a heavy kind of guilt and for bad behaviour among people — *lashon hara*, evil speech, and listening to it.

Jeremiah's sixth chapter sets the same things side by side: "Cut the trees and cast on Jerusalem a siege mound; that is the city whose sins have been visited upon her, everywhere there is oppression in its midst. As a well lets its water flow, so has she let her evil flow; violence and spoil is heard therein before Me continually; sickness and wounds. Be corrected, O Jerusalem, lest My soul be alienated from you; lest I make you a desolation, a land uninhabited." Water, and violence heard, and a land left empty — which is the world after the Flood. And a correction that could still stop it.

Week 6, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 41 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second Week of Cheshvan - Psalms 16-18; 32:7-9; 89:7

The second week of Cheshvan in psalms: the sixteenth, seventeenth and eighteenth, with three verses of the Tikkun HaKlali and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 16 is the whole Tikkun HaKlali psalm at once, having been given three verses at a time until now. "Watch over me, O G-d, for I have put my trust in You…

The Lord is my allotted portion and my share; You guide my destiny. Portions have fallen to me in pleasant places; indeed, a beautiful inheritance is mine… I have set the Lord before me at all times; because He is at my right hand, I shall not falter… Make known to me the path of life, that I may be satiated with the joy of Your presence."

Psalm 17 submits to being searched. "You have probed my heart, examined it in the night, tested me and found nothing; no evil thought crossed my mind; as are my words so are my thoughts." Then the famous asking: "Guard me like the apple of the eye; hide me in the shadow of Your wings." The enemy is drawn sharply — "their fat has closed their hearts; their mouths speak arrogantly… his appearance is like a lion longing to devour" — and the psalm ends on waking: "in the time of resurrection, I will be sated by Your image."

Psalm 18 is the long one, and it is the haftorah of these weeks set out whole: David's song on the day he was delivered from all his enemies and from Saul. "I love You, Lord, my strength. The Lord is my rock, my fortress, and my rescuer." It gives the pangs of death and the snares, and then the answer arrives as weather: the earth quaking, smoke in His nostrils, a thick cloud under His feet, hailstones and coals, "the channels of water became visible, the foundations of the world were exposed." And then the rescue: "He sent from heaven and took me; He brought me out of surging waters… He brought me into spaciousness; He delivered me because He desires me." Its measure-for-measure verses are among the plainest in the book: "With the kindhearted You act kindly, with the upright man You act uprightly. With the pure You act purely, but with the crooked You act cunningly."

The Tikkun HaKlali's verses are shelter and instruction: "You are a refuge to me; protect me from distress; surround me with songs of deliverance forever. I will enlighten you and educate you in the path you should go." And then the warning not to need forcing: "Be not like a horse, like a mule, senseless, that must be muzzled with bit and bridle."

Week 6, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 42 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Songbird is Saying

The songbird opens, and the gathering sets her nest against the right hand and the snares.

"The songbird has also found her home" meets "Your right hand, O Lord, is most powerful," and then the altars — "Your altars, G-d of Hosts" — with the mountains melting. The nether world's bands come in next, braided with Haazinu's reproach: "Bands of the nether world have surrounded me" / "Is this how you repay Hashem" / "the snares of death confronted me" / "you disgraceful, unwise people?!" And straight after that, the answer from the Tikkun: "surround me with songs of deliverance forever."

Then the nest is finished in pieces, with the cedars built through it. "And the sparrow a nest for herself" / "the beams of our houses are cedars" / "where she may lay her young" / "my King and my Lord."

The fatherhood and the crushing hand come together — "Is He not your Father, your Master?" / "Your right hand, O Lord, crushes the foe" / "You are a refuge to me; protect me from distress" / "He has made you and established you" — and the corridors of cypress close that run.

The last stretch braids Channah's rival with the mule. "And her rival vexed her sore, to make her fret" / "that must be muzzled with bit and bridle" / "also the clouds dripped water" / "in the path you should go" / "be not like a horse, like a mule, senseless" / "because Hashem had shut up her womb."

It ends with the rose and the teaching: "Behold, you are comely, my beloved, yea pleasant" / "I will enlighten you and educate you" / "I am a rose of Sharon, a rose of the valleys" / "I will advise you with what I have seen."

Week 6, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK VII

Malchut of Chesed

Days 43–49

Day 43 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Recognize and Reveal the Divine Presence within Us and the World

Week seven is still Cheshvan, and the swallow cannot keep quiet: "So that my soul shall praise You, and shall not be silent, G-d my Lord – I shall give thanks to You forever." (Psalms 30:13)

The word for forever, *l'olam*, holds *olam*, world — and olam comes from *ehelem*, which means hidden, a mask. Which is the month exactly: by going into the world we uncover a Presence that was covered up until then.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Eliezer three things. The honour of your fellow should be as precious to you as your own, and do not be easy to anger. Repent one day before your death — and since nobody knows the day, that means repent daily. And warm yourself by the fire of the sages, but beware of being burned by its embers: "for their bite is the bite of a fox, their sting is the sting of a scorpion, their hiss is the hiss of a serpent, and all their words are like fiery coals."

The Flood began on the seventeenth of Cheshvan, which falls in this week or the next. It would not have happened if those people had repented one day before their deaths and treated their neighbours and their sages properly. And the Torah holds Noah to account as well, for not praying for the others: his neighbour's honour was not precious to him. Stealing was one of the Flood's great causes, and stealing begins with an eye looking jealously at what belongs to somebody else.

The pairing is Malchut shebeChesed, and this week is the yahrzeit of Rachel, who is malchut. She had a great deal of chesed too, and did the very thing Rabbi Eliezer asks: Jacob had worked seven years for her and had given her signs so that Laban could not switch brides on the wedding night — and when Rachel saw Leah under

the canopy she gave her sister the signs rather than let her be humiliated.

Malchut is also speech, which is the swallow who cannot be silent. The Alter Rebbe ties malchut to *kavod*, honour or glory — the word in the swallow's own verse, and the word we say after the Shema: *Baruch Shem Kvod Malchuto L'Olam Va'ed*.

The swallow's lesson: recognise and thank Him, always. And instruments were last week. This week it has to be your own voice.

Week 7, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 44 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Hearing the Cry of Rachel

"Remember the days of old; reflect upon the years of other generations. Ask your father, and he will tell you; your elders, and they will inform you." (Deuteronomy 32:7) Rashi takes it straight to the water: the generation of Enosh, whom G-d inundated with the waters of the ocean, and the generation of the Flood, whom He washed away.

The haftorah is this week's own verse: "When I am in distress, I call upon the Lord, yes I call upon my G-d: and out of His abode He hears my voice, and my cry enters His ears." (II Samuel 22:7) Because this is the week of Rachel's yahrzeit, and the most famous line in all of Tanach about her is a voice being heard: "A voice is heard in Ramah, lamentation and bitter weeping: Rachel is weeping for her children and refuses to be comforted for her children, because they are away." And the answer: "Restrain your voice from weeping, and your eyes from tears; for your work will be rewarded, says G-d; and they will return from the land of the enemy. There is hope for your future." He hears her as He hears David.

The quality is fear, *yirah* — last week's awe, now nearer and sharper. The prophet is Pinchas, in whom yirah is the whole story: what he did about the tribes' missing fear of Heaven at ba'al peor is what made him worthy to be a Kohen, then Kohen Gadol, and then Elijah the Prophet.

The Levitical city is Golan of Bashan, also a city of refuge. Golan comes from *galut*, exile — which is Rachel's verse. And galut shares its root with *legalot*, to reveal. Exertion in exile is what brings the revelations, and that is why Abraham did not object to being told his children would be exiled and come out with great

possessions. Those were not only material: *rechush*, possessions, has the same numerical value as *Torah*.

What fear asks of a student is plain enough. The Alter Rebbe explains in the Tanya that fear of G-d matters not only for the prohibitions but for the positive commandments too. It is usually fear and not love that provides the first push to get anything done.

Week 7, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 45 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

More References to Rachel

"And with Your great pride You tear down those who rise up against You; You send forth Your burning wrath; it devours them like straw." The retribution of the Flood is still running through these verses.

The haftorah holds two things that turn out to be one: "this was at Sinai, because of the presence of the Lord, the G-d of Israel. In the days of Shamgar the son of Anath." Both are feminine. The Shechinah, the Divine Presence, is always spoken of as feminine, and often as Rachel in particular — and this is her week. Anath is the name of a warrior goddess in Canaanite myth, and if it is a woman's name here, this is one of the very few places in Tanach where a man is named for his mother rather than his father.

Sotah's seventh daf carries on with the woman suspected of adultery and the bitter waters. On the way she is given a chance to reconsider, and she is reminded how her own forefathers admitted what they had done, repented, and earned their place in the World to Come. Which belongs to this week too, and to the verse about asking your father.

The generation is Chanoch, a kosher version of Cain's son of the same name. Cain's Enoch had a city named after him and sank into civilisation, further and further from nature and from Hashem. Seth's Chanoch walked with G-d. Rabbi Shalom Arush explains that he spent most of his time apart, so the world could not get at him, but came back regularly to teach — and in the end was taken alive, while he was still pure. The root of his name is *chinuch*, education, which is a parent's work.

The journey turns back to the water: "They journeyed from Elim and camped by the Red Sea." Last week was the twelve springs and the seventy palms, the tribes and the nations, both scattered and mixed together in exile. This week is standing at the shore, ready for the splitting. And on the week of Rachel Imeinu's yahrzeit the exile is felt more sharply, which is part of lifting it.

Chanoch's lesson for prayer is education. Pirkei Avot says an ignoramus cannot be pious. Beside Him we are all ignorant, and prayer is not mainly an intellectual thing — but there are still basics in how a person approaches the King, and anyone who can learn them should. Intent is what matters most, and intent is much harder when you do not understand what you are saying.

Week 7, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 46 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Elevating (and Being Elevated) by Your Place

"And as he did so year by year, when she went up to the house of the Lord, so she vexed her; therefore she wept, and would not eat." Channah weeping, and going up each year — this is Rachel's week, whose crying is heard, and Cheshvan, which belongs to the Temple.

The week's quality is *Messameach et haMakom*, which reads as making the Place happy. He is called the Place because nowhere is without Him — and there is one place where the Presence gathers more than anywhere else, which is the Temple.

Where you are matters enormously. The Rambam writes that one of the ways open to a person who wants to turn from what he has done is to move house. There is a notion that changing place changes your *mazal*, and that is part of Avraham leaving his father's country for the land. Channah does not stay put either; she goes up to weep and pray for a child, rather than sit in the place where she is being taunted.

But the quality turns it around. Once a person is learning Torah for its own sake, it is no longer the place's job to make him happy — it is his job to make the place happy. We can make a Torah atmosphere wherever we are, which the sixth Lubavitcher Rebbe pressed hard, and the Rebbe after him. Even under a barrage like Channah's, how you behave is still yours and not the room's.

Proverbs' seventh chapter is another warning about strange places: "She is bustling and rebellious; her feet do not dwell in her house. Sometimes she is in the street, sometimes in the squares, and she lurks at every corner… Let your heart not veer off into her ways; stray not in her paths. For many are the dead that she has felled."

The eleventh of Cheshvan carries two more yahrzeits besides Rachel's, both of them first in lines that are still giving light. Rabbi Menachem Nachum, the Maggid of Chernobyl, a close disciple of the Ba'al Shem Tov and of the Maggid of Mezeritch, who wrote Meor Einayim — and Chernobyl, a name now attached to disaster, is also a name attached to great holiness. And Rabbi Avraham Wienberg, the Slonimer Rebbe, disciple of Rabbi Noah of Lechovitch and Rabbi Moshe of Kobrin, who wrote Yesod Ha'Avodah, and who was respected by chassidim and their opponents alike in Lithuania, where Chassidic thought was not welcome.

Week 7, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 47 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Love and the Temple

"As a rose among the thorns, so is my beloved among the daughters." That one is His. Then ours: "As an apple tree among the trees of the forest, so is my beloved among the sons; in his shade I delighted and sat, and his fruit was sweet to my palate. He brought me to the banquet hall, and his attraction to me was symbolic of his love."

The rose among thorns is Rachel, who like her mother and her sister was a rose pulled out of the thorns of the house of Lavan and Bethuel. The Zohar opens by comparing Israel to a thirteen-petalled rose on this very verse, and reads the petals as thirteen of *rachamim*, mercy. Rachel was known for her rachamim, and for the rachamim Jacob showed her. All three verses are about love declared, and the love between G-d and Israel in them is also the love between Jacob and Rachel. Rashi reads the banquet hall as the tent of meeting.

Of the seventy souls the seventh is Jemuel, which may be read *Yamoh-el*, his sea is G-d — apt for the month of the Flood. *Yam* is also the name of the washbasin Solomon made for the first Temple, which may be another way to read it.

Shevuot's seventh daf is about eating a holy offering while impure, set beside entering the Temple while impure, and about the goat whose blood went into the Holy of Holies. The Temple cleans sin away — but the Talmud concludes that no offering is brought to pardon a sin done on purpose.

Jeremiah's seventh chapter says the same thing, louder: "Stand in the gate of the house of the Lord, and proclaim there this word… Improve your ways and your deeds, I will allow you to dwell in this place. Do not rely on false words, saying: The Temple of the Lord, the Temple of the Lord, the Temple of the Lord are they." The Temple matters and His mercy is real, and neither is a licence.

Week 7, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 48 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Cheshvan - Psalms 19-21; 32:10-11 & 41:1-2; 89:8

The third week of Cheshvan in psalms: the nineteenth, twentieth and twenty-first, with the end of Psalm 32, the opening of Psalm 41, and a verse of Psalm 89.

Psalm 19 begins with a sky that talks without talking. "The heavens recount the glory of the Almighty; the sky proclaims His handiwork. Day to day speech streams forth; night to night expresses knowledge." And then: "There is no utterance, there are no words; their voice is inaudible. Their arc extends throughout the world; their message to the end of the earth." The sun comes out of its tent "like a groom coming forth from his bridal canopy, like a strong man rejoicing to run the course."

Then it turns from the sky to the Torah, and the turn is the whole psalm: "The Torah of the Lord is perfect, restoring the soul; the testimony of the Lord is trustworthy, making wise the simpleton… more desirable than gold, than much fine gold; sweeter than honey or the drippings of honeycomb." It ends in two requests about the two kinds of wrong: "Yet who can discern inadvertent wrongs? Purge me of hidden sins. Also hold back Your servant from willful sins." And the last line is the one said after every prayer: "May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You, Lord, my Strength and my Redeemer."

Psalm 20 is a blessing said over somebody else. "May the Lord answer you on the day of distress; may the Name of the G-d of Jacob fortify you. May He send your help from the Sanctuary… May He grant you your heart's desire." And then the line about

what to lean on: “Some rely upon chariots and some upon horses, but we invoke the Name of the Lord our G-d. They bend and fall, but we rise and stand firm.”

Psalm 21 is the king answered. “You have given him his heart’s desire, and You have never withheld the utterance of his lips. You preceded him with blessings of good; You placed a crown of pure gold on his head. He asked of You life, You gave it to him — long life, forever and ever.”

The Tikkun HaKlali’s verses close Psalm 32 on the difference trust makes: “Many are the agonies of the wicked, but he who trusts in the Lord is surrounded by kindness. Rejoice in the Lord and exult, you righteous ones!” Then Psalm 41 opens on a particular kindness: “Fortunate is he who is thoughtful of the poor, for the Lord will save him on the day of evil.”

Week 7, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 49 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Swallow is Saying

The swallow opens, and this gathering runs on remembering and being heard.

“So that my soul shall praise You, and shall not be silent” is set between Haazinu’s remembering — “Remember the days of old; reflect upon the years of other generations” — and the great assembly: “The Almighty is revered in the great assembly of the holy ones.”

Then the apple tree and the rejoicing come together. “In his shade I delighted and sat, and his fruit was sweet to my palate” / “Rejoice in the Lord and exult, you righteous ones!” / “He brought me to the banquet hall” / “Sing joyously, all you upright of heart!” / “and his attraction to me was symbolic of his love” / “awe-inspiring to all who surround Him.”

The thanks give way to the year-by-year going up, and to the rose: “G-d my Lord – I shall give thanks to You forever” / “and as he did so year by year, when she went up to the house of Hashem” / “as a rose among the thorns, so is my beloved among the daughters” / “ask your father, and he will tell you; your elders, and they will inform you.”

Then the cry and the burning wrath are braided — “and out of His abode He hears my voice, and my cry enters His ears” / “and with Your great pride You tear

down those who rise up against You" / "yes I call upon my G-d" / "You send forth Your burning wrath" — with the poor man's blessing laid in among them: "Fortunate is he who is thoughtful of the poor."

The last lines put Channah's weeping beside Shamgar and the straw. "So she vexed her; therefore she wept, and would not eat" / "in the days of Shamgar the son of Anath" / "the Lord will save him on the day of evil" / "many are the agonies of the wicked" / "it devours them like straw" / "but he who trusts in the Lord is surrounded by kindness" — and it ends at the mountain: "this was at Sinai, because of the presence of the Lord."

Week 7, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK VIII

Chesed of Gevurah

Days 50–56

Day 50 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

Not to Lose Focus on our Spirituality and Relationship with G-d

Week eight is the end of Cheshvan, and the swift says one short thing: "My help is from G-d, Maker of Heaven and Earth." (Psalms 121:2)

It is the right verse for how far into the month we are. The deeper in we go the more we are immersed in things to be got done — sometimes sinking in them — and we need His help to stay afloat and not lose sight of what we were doing all this for.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yehoshua on what ruins a person: "An evil eye, the evil inclination, and the hatred of one's fellows, drive a person from the world." Sin takes you out of the world. Though the phrase can be read the other way as well: turning back after sin takes a person higher than this material world reaches.

All three were loose in the generation of the Flood. The Torah singles out theft as what was most common then — and theft is the evil eye acting, wanting what is not yours. They were so taken up with things that ethics and the spirit stopped seeming important.

The pairing is Chesed shebeGevurah, kindness inside severity. The Flood came on slowly, which gave people room to turn back even after the rain had started. And it was not all destruction: it washed the world and let it begin again. Forty days and forty nights, which is also the forty measures of water a mikvah needs to purify.

From the swift we learn that we need Him for everything, in everything. If you feel alone and past helping, do what this bird does and ask.

Week 8, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 51 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Humility is Key

"When the Most High gave nations their lot, when He separated the sons of man, He set up the boundaries of peoples according to the number of the children of Israel." (Deuteronomy 32:8) Rashi reads both halves as this month's history: giving those who angered Him their portion means He flooded them and drowned them; and separating the sons of man is the scattering of the generation that built the tower — whom He could have removed from the world altogether and did not. He set boundaries instead, and let them live.

The haftorah is the same ground shaking: "Then the earth shook and quaked, the very foundations of heaven did tremble; and they were shaken when he was angered." (II Samuel 22:8)

The quality is humility, *anavah*, and real humility means caring about someone besides yourself. Noah failed that test. Moshe, whom the Torah calls the humblest man on earth, passed it — and is a tikkun for Noah. Told that He would destroy the people and build a nation out of him, which is very nearly what Noah was told, Moshe answered: erase me from Your book. The Hebrew, *M'cheni Nah*, has the same letters as *Mei Noach*, the waters of Noah, which is what the prophets call the Flood.

The prophets this week are Elkanah and Channah, who are prayer and the Temple, which is the month. Both are humility. From Channah we learn how to pray — whispering, so that nobody hears but herself and Hashem. And Elkanah, for all his own level, was worried about his whole generation: he made the pilgrimage to Shiloh every year by a different route so that more people would come with him, at a time when nobody was bothering, and even though the priests serving there had become corrupt. Their son Samuel was the one who lifted the people.

The Levitical city is Be'eshterah, another name for Ashtarot — which appears to be named for Ashtoreth, a goddess that King Solomon is said to have worshipped. The commentators say he did not; his wives did, and his not stopping them counted against him as if he had. He built the first Temple and finished it in this month. And Ashtarot seems to be bound up with idol worship about wealth, which was Solomon's own exposure, being rich — and is ours in a smaller way, going into this month and risking drowning in things.

So: be careful not to pick up false gods out there, or false ideas, or the rationalisations that go with them. Solomon also wrote that many waters cannot extinguish the love. The many waters are the difficulty of making a living, and however deep they get, they cannot put it out.

Week 8, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 52 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Methuselah and Affirming Life

"And with the breath of Your nostrils the waters were heaped up; the running water stood erect like a wall." Water standing up — the sea and the Flood alongside each other again.

The haftorah brings in another woman, which has been this fortnight's thread: "in the days of Jael, caravans ceased, and travelers walked on crooked paths." Those crooked paths, *arachot akalkalot*, have at their root *lekalkel*, to ruin — which is what had taken hold of the human race before the Flood.

Sotah's eighth daf continues with the bitter waters, and takes care that the testing itself should not provoke illicit thoughts about other men. It also treats Divine retribution in general, which comes *middah k'neged middah*, measure for measure.

The generation is Methuselah, a kosher Methushael. He was righteous, and he lived longer than anyone in history — nine hundred and sixty-nine years — and he died immediately before the Flood came. His yahrzeit falls in this month, on the same day as Rachel's.

Both names open with *met*, dead. But Methuselah continues with *shalach*, sent, and Methushael with *sha'al*, asked or borrowed, which is also *she'ol*, the grave. One name sends death away; the other brings it closer. Methuselah's life was life-affirming and his predecessor's was not. He kept his righteousness in an environment thoroughly corrupted, in a way that was itself above nature — which is the task in exile too.

The journey is into hunger: "They journeyed from the Red Sea and camped in the desert of Zin." That is where the provisions carried out of Egypt ran out. They cried, and the manna came. The Torah says there was no water either, and water also stands for Torah. We are at the same point in the year: what Tishrei supplied is running down, and we have to ask hard for what will keep us going. In Kislev it

comes the way the manna came, from outside nature altogether. One meaning of *Zin* is moon, and a new moon is as empty as that desert.

Methuselah's lesson for prayer is to affirm being alive. Before anything else, praise and thanks for being here, in the way the Creator meant. As the Torah puts it: choose life. That is nearly the only decision there is, and it comes up every day.

Week 8, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 53 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Rejoicing with Creation

"And Elkanah her husband said unto her: 'Hannah, why weepest thou? and why eatest thou not? and why is thy heart grieved? am not I better to thee than ten sons?'" Here is somebody stepping in to try to make her happy.

The further we get from Tishrei the more bogged down the world's business makes us feel, and it can be a great deal at once. Being able to reach somebody who will lift you is worth something. And the week's quality is exactly that: *Messame'ach et HaBri'ot*, one who makes the creatures happy.

Elkanah's three questions are a short course in how. Sometimes you have to remind a person that they are a created being with the same ordinary needs as every other one — why aren't you eating? Then point at what is good: am I not better to you than ten sons? And then the thing that is hardest to hear and truest, that it looks this bad only from where we are standing, and the Creator has a plan for each of us in which everything He does is for the best.

Proverbs' eighth chapter is wisdom speaking in her own voice, and most of it is about creation. "The Lord acquired me at the beginning of His way, before His works of old. From the distant past I was enthroned, from the beginning, of those that preceded the earth. I was created when there were yet no deeps, when there were no fountains replete with water… When He established the heavens, there I was, when He drew a circle over the face of the deep… when He gave the sea its boundary, and the water shall not transgress His command." And then the lines that make the chapter belong to this week: "I was a nursling beside Him, and I was His delight every day, playing before Him at all times; playing in the habitable world of His earth, and having my delights with the children of man."

The twenty-first of Cheshvan is the yahrzeit of two great Sefardi kabbalists. The Radbaz, Rabbi David ben Zimra, Chief Rabbi of Egypt from about 1514 to 1553, who taught the Arizal and Rabbi Betzalel Ashkenazi, and was a wealthy businessman besides. And Rabbi Avraham Azulai, author of the Chessed L'Avraham, who also shaped the Arizal and is quoted often in his works — Chief Rabbi of Hebron, and the great-great-grandfather of the Chidah.

Week 8, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 54 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Lovesick

"Sustain me with flagons of wine, spread my bed with apples, for I am lovesick. His left hand was under my head, and his right hand would embrace me. I adjure you, O daughters of Jerusalem, by the gazelles or by the hinds of the field, that you neither awaken nor arouse the love while it is desirous."

Two of these are ours to Him and the third is addressed to the nations. Rashi takes the first literally as nursing: sustain me now as one does the sick, with flagons of grape wine or cakes of white flour; spread my bed around me with apples for the good smell, in the way of the sick — for I am sick for his love, and I thirst for Him here in my exile. That is this month. The deeper into the year, the more entrenched in daily business, and the sicker for what we are missing.

The second verse remembers when it was easier to see. Rashi: His left hand was under my head — in the desert; and His right hand would embrace me — He went a three days' journey to find them rest, and where the rest was He brought down manna and quails. All of which I remember now in exile, and I am sick for His love. The left hand is discipline, laid under the head to keep us in line; the right is kindness, in an embrace. Which is this week's pairing exactly, kindness inside severity.

The third verse turns outward and is less yielding: whatever the weight of the physical world just now, we are not giving up what we have with Him.

There is the Flood in these verses too. Noah comes out of the ark and back into the world and is overwhelmed by it; he plants a vineyard and falls much as Adam did. One of the major opinions in the Talmud is that the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge

was the grape.

Of the seventy souls the eighth is Jamin — *yemin*, the right hand, which is the kindness above. Which is what this part of the year leans on more and more.

Shevuot's eighth daf stays with the goat whose blood went into the Holy of Holies, but the sins have got graver: idolatry, certain sexual sins, murder — though the Talmud is speaking of them done unwittingly. The deeper into exile, the more atonement is needed.

Jeremiah's eighth chapter is the same descent: sins mounting, worse ones, and the eye for how bad they are going dim. They become ordinary, then acceptable, and at last we think we are doing His will. The chapter happens to name the birds of this season: "Even the stork in the heaven knows her seasons, and the turtledoves and the crane and the swallow await the time of their coming, but My people do not know the ordinance of the Lord." And: "they healed the breach of My people easily, saying, 'Peace, peace,' but there is no peace."

Week 8, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 55 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fourth Week of Cheshvan - Psalms 22-24; 41:3-5; 89:9

The fourth week of Cheshvan in psalms: the twenty-second, twenty-third and twenty-fourth, with three verses of Psalm 41 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 22 is headed as the prayer for the length of the exile and the fall from prestige to lowliness, for a person to say in agony, and in which to make vows. It opens with the hardest line in the book: "My G-d, my G-d, why have You forsaken me! So far from saving me, from the words of my outcry? My G-d, I call out by day, and You do not answer; at night — but there is no respite for me." Then, immediately: "Yet You, Holy One, are enthroned upon the praises of Israel."

It goes very low. "And I am a worm and not a man; scorn of men, contempt of nations." The body comes apart: "I am poured out like water, all my bones are disjointed; my heart has become like wax, melted within my innards. My strength is dried up like a potsherd, and my tongue cleaves to my palate." The enemies are animals — bulls of Bashan, a lion, dogs — and they divide his garments and cast lots for his clothing. And then it turns and does not turn back: "For He has not despised

nor abhorred the entreaty of the poor… Let the humble eat and be satisfied… All the ends of the earth will remember and return to the Lord."

Psalm 23 is given a setting: when David was in the forest of Cheret and nearly died of starvation, and G-d fed him with a taste of the World to Come. "The Lord is my shepherd, I shall lack nothing… Though I walk in the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for You are with me… You will prepare a table for me before my enemies."

Psalm 24 asks who may go up. "The earth and all therein is the Lord's… Who may ascend the mountain of the Lord, and who may stand in His holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart, who has not used My Name in vain or sworn falsely." And then the gates, twice over: "Lift up your heads, O gates, and be lifted up, eternal doors, so the glorious King may enter. Who is the glorious King? The Lord, strong and mighty; the Lord, mighty in battle."

Psalm 41's verses are about being kept through illness: "The Lord will guard him and keep him alive… The Lord will support him on the bed of illness; You will turn him over in his bed all throughout his sickness." And then the plainest prayer of a sick man: "I said, 'Lord, be gracious to me! Heal my soul, for I have sinned against You!'"

Week 8, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 56 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Swift is Saying

The swift opens, and this gathering is the boundaries of the nations braided with a sickbed.

"When the Most High gave nations their lot" comes in first, with Elkanah's portions and a reproach: "and to all her sons and her daughters, portions" / "because they came not to the aid of the Lord" / "then the earth shook and quaked." The gazelles and the hinds follow, and the separating of the sons of man, and the foundations of heaven trembling — and then the left hand: "His left hand was under my head" / "and he will be praised in the land."

The swift's own verse sits at the centre of that: "My help is from G-d, Maker of Heaven and Earth."

Then the boundaries are finished and the manna comes in. “He set up the boundaries of peoples” / “and they were shaken when he was angered” / “when Elkanah sacrificed, that he gave to Peninnah his wife” / “I have heard the complaints of the children of Israel” / “I said, 'O Lord, be gracious to me; heal my soul because I have sinned against You.'” And the promise of meat and bread is laid right across the number of the children of Israel: “in the afternoon you shall eat meat” / “the Lord will preserve him and keep him alive” / “according to the number of the children of Israel.”

The lovesickness lands between them: “and his right hand would embrace me” / “the Lord will support him on his sickbed” / “sustain me with flagons of wine, spread my bed with apples, for I am lovesick” / “and in the morning you shall be sated with bread.”

It ends with the adjuring and the knowing: “I adjure you, O daughters of Jerusalem” / “and you shall know that I am the Lord, your G-d” — and the last lines are the love that must not be woken before it wants to be, and the enemies it will not be given over to.

Week 8, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK IX

Gevurah of Gevurah

Days 57–63

Day 57 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

Fighting Darkness with Light

Week nine, and the stormy petrel announces: “Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the straight-hearted.” (Psalms 97:11)

Some years this week sits entirely in Cheshvan; other years it already takes in the first of Kislev, the month of Chanukah. Even when Rosh Chodesh Kislev falls later, this week holds a date the Maccabees kept: the twenty-third of Cheshvan, which in the time of the Talmud was much celebrated, because that was when the stones of the altar that the Greeks had made impure were carried out.

Light, and sowing, and protection for the righteous. The Maccabees were righteous fighters of the seed of Aaron, and G-d arranged it that they beat Greece, which was the greatest empire there was.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yossi: “The property of your fellow should be as precious to you as your own. Perfect yourself for the study of Torah, for it is not an inheritance to you. And all your deeds should be for the sake of Heaven.”

Inheritance is the word that ties it to Kislev. The Greeks admired the Torah as a philosophy and liked its practical parts — respecting another man’s money among them — but they wanted our link to it cut, and our own connection to G-d with it. The Midrash puts it exactly: “darkness symbolizes Greece, which darkened the eyes of Israel with its decrees, ordering Israel to, 'Write on the horn of an ox that you have no inheritance in the G-d of Israel.'” Rabbi Yossi was himself a kohen, like the Maccabees, and like them he is called a chassid — someone who goes past the letter of the law to do what G-d wants.

For Rabbi Yossi the thing that matters most is a good neighbour, and avoiding a bad one at all costs. A good neighbour, *shachen tov*, may be the Shechinah, which lives among the Jewish people and in the Temple. The bad one is the empire that worked so hard to make us like itself.

The pairing is Gevurah shebeGevurah, severity within severity.

The petrel's lesson is that a long way towards being happy is simply being a good, honest, fair person. Rebbe Nachman teaches to look for those good points and dwell on them — in others and in yourself. Even when they are small and incomplete, they are worth real joy.

Week 9, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 58 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Choosing Joy

"Because the Lord's portion is His people Jacob, the lot of His inheritance." (Deuteronomy 32:9) Inheritance again, which is the week's whole subject and the Greeks' particular target — the decree that Israel write on the horn of an ox that they have no inheritance in the G-d of Israel.

The haftorah is fire: "Smoke went up in His nostrils, and fire out of His mouth did devour; coals flamed forth from Him." (II Samuel 22:9) The miracle of Chanukah is light and fire. And coals are a good figure for the Jews of that time, because a coal can be cold on the outside and hot inside, and all that is needed is to get the heat out. That was true then and it is true now, when Jews of every kind come out of the woodwork to light together. The verse is also about His might, which is the other half of that miracle — the military one.

The quality is joy, *simchah*. The spiritual kind is one of the great subjects of Chanukah, in praise and in thanks; it is also central to the Temple and to the work of the Kohanim.

The prophet is Eli, the Kohen Gadol, whose service had to be done in joy despite what his life handed him — including his own sons' corruption. Which rhymes with Chanukah, where part of the fight was against the corrupting pull of Hellenist culture.

Because this week lies about half the time in Cheshvan, whose four Levitical cities have all been given, its city is one of the three cities of refuge still to come — likely in the territory of the half-tribe of Menasheh, across the Jordan. And since half the time this week already belongs to Kislev, whose tribe is Benjamin, it is also Jerusalem: half the Temple's area, itself a city of refuge, lies in Benjamin, though in time Jerusalem will be its own territory and no tribe's. It fits either way. Cheshvan saw the first Temple finished and will see the third dedicated; Kislev holds the finishing of the Mishkan and the rededication of the second.

What joy asks is simple and hard. It is not meant to depend on your circumstances. Being happy is first of all a decision — and for the merit of making it, He will give you plenty to be happy about.

Week 9, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 59 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Lamech and Avoiding Greek Traps

"The depths congealed in the heart of the sea. Because the enemy said, I will pursue." The verse breaks in half, and so does the week: the first part is still the Flood, the second starts something new — a pursuing enemy, which is Chanukah's subject.

The haftorah splits the same way: "The open cities ceased, in Israel they ceased, until I Deborah arose; I arose as a mother in Israel." Open cities ceasing is civilisation stopping, as in the Flood. Then Devorah stands up, as a mother. Her war against Sisera runs parallel to the Maccabees' — and a mother's deepest job is keeping her child's identity intact, which is why Chanukah comes from *chinuch*, education. These weeks have been full of women: Rachel, Anath, Yael, and now Devorah.

Sotah's ninth daf also divides: the bitter waters, and then Shimshon. Samson belongs to Teveth with the tribe of Dan, but Kislev's subject is in him anyway — he was meant to be pure, and what undid him was impurity, intermarriage among it. Teveth holds several days of Chanukah too.

The generation is Lamech, Noah's father, a kosher version of Cain's Lamech, who killed Cain and his own son besides. Cain's Lamech destroys his ancestor and his child; Seth's Lamech, the moment his son is born, says the world will be comforted through him — and through that son his whole line, and the human race, is saved.

Both Lamechs have speeches recorded. Cain's: "Adah and Zillah, hearken to my voice… for I have slain a man by wounding him and a child by bruising him." Seth's: "And he named him Noah, saying, 'This one will give us rest from our work and from the toil of our hands from the ground, which the Lord has cursed.'"

Cain's Lamech also stands for aesthetics and pleasure worshipped without check, which is what Greek culture was at the time, and for technology used the same way. Rashi says that before Noah there were no plowshares, and he made them. Cain's line built better weapons, until Cain himself was killed by one; Seth's built tools that made life easier. Beauty and science are good things held inside something larger, which is what Noah says: "May God expand Japheth, and may he dwell in the tents of Shem." Japheth — whose name comes from *yoffi*, beauty, and from whom Yavan, Greece, descends — may grow; in the tents of Shem, whose name means *name*.

The journey is a knock: "They journeyed from the desert of Zin and camped in Dophkah." From *dofek*, to knock. It is the new moon coming, and the knocking in the chest — *Kol Dodi Dofek*, the voice of my beloved knocking. Providence was ready to put everything back as it had been, if they had all been willing to return; only some were, and the majority and the notables stayed in Babylon, preferring dependence, unwilling to leave their houses and their affairs. Which is the risk of exile: getting comfortable.

Lamech's lesson for prayer is to reach Him above reason. In *melech*, king, the mem is *moach*, the mind, and the lamed is *lev*, the heart — and the mind is meant to rule the heart. Swap the two letters and melech becomes *lemech*, a fool. And yet there is also *shtus d'kedusha*, holy folly: prayer is the service of the heart and not the mind, and what we have with Him is above nature and above logic.

Week 9, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 60 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Enclothed in Humility

"So Hannah rose up after they had eaten in Shiloh, and after they had drunk — now Eli the priest sat upon his seat by the door-post of the temple of the Lord." Hannah rising, and the next figure in the story arriving: Eli, the Kohen Gadol. Kislev and Chanukah belong to the Kohen Gadol and to the priests. Rashi notes Eli had been made judge over all Israel — and in the Chanukah story the Chashmona'im were priests and kings at once.

And Eli is sitting by the door-post, the *mezuzah*, of the Temple. Which is precisely where the Chanukah lamp is put.

The week's quality is that the Torah enclothes him with humility. It is a strange pairing, because clothes — and particularly the kind one would associate with the Torah — sound like honour, not lowliness. The High Priest's garments are described as being for honour and beauty. But the honour and the beauty are not his. They belong to Hashem and to the office, and the splendour of them is exactly what makes the man wearing them feel small. The Torah works the same way: the more you learn of how great He is and how deep it goes, the smaller you get.

Rashi finds it in the spelling. "And Eli the priest was sitting on the chair" is written defectively, missing a letter, because that day he sat on a huge chair, having been appointed judge over Israel. The chair makes the office great and the man small. And he sat outside, where he could greet whoever came in, which is its own kind of humility.

Proverbs' ninth chapter splits in two. The first part is wisdom keeping house: "Wisdom has built her house; she has hewn her seven pillars. She has prepared her meat; she has mingled her wine; she has even set her table… 'Whoever is simple, let him turn in here'… 'Come, partake of my bread and drink of the wine I have mingled.'" Rashi reads the house as the world and the seven pillars as the seven days of creation. The rest of the chapter returns to corruption and temptation. And buried in it is the Jewish answer to everything Greece offered: "The beginning of wisdom is the fear of the Lord, and the knowledge of the holy ones is understanding." The Greeks were wisdom itself, and not that.

The twenty-seventh of Cheshvan is the yahrzeit of Reb Yaakov Leizer, second Rebbe of Pshevorsk, who based himself in Antwerp. He had hundreds of chassidim and never left off his plain ways: he respected the lowliest Jews, often slept on a bench in the ezras nashim so a wandering beggar could have his bed, and slept in his sukkah with tens of others who had none.

And the twenty-ninth is the yahrzeit of Rebbe Tzvi-Hirsch of Riminov, who was his predecessor's personal attendant before he was his successor — known as Rav Tzvi Hersch Meshares, the helper — and later as a worker of miracles, whose Torah was gathered in Be'erot HaMayim.

Week 9, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 61 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Beloved

"The sound of my beloved! Behold, he is coming, skipping over the mountains, jumping over the hills. My beloved resembles a gazelle or a fawn of the hinds; behold, he is standing behind our wall, looking from the windows, peering from the lattices. My beloved raised his voice and said to me, 'Arise, my beloved, my fair one, and come away.'"

All three are ours, and all three share their second word: *dodi*, my Beloved. What they describe is rescue that does not go by the rules — skipping over mountains, jumping hills — which is Kislev and the Maccabees, where He saves in ways nature does not allow. Which is also the difference between the two systems in that war. Jews want a close relationship with Him and call Him beloved; the Greeks of the time believed in the cosmos and its laws, and in no Judge at all.

And "standing behind our wall, looking from the windows, peering from the lattices" is a known reference to the blessing of the priests — Kislev and Chanukah again.

Of the seventy souls the ninth is Ohad, spelled with a *hey* where *echad*, one, has a *chet* — and monotheism was the other great dividing line. Rashi notes that the family of Ohad was one of the few wiped out entirely: when Aharon died the clouds of glory withdrew and the Canaanites came to fight, and the people set their hearts on going back to Egypt and went back eight stages of the journey. The Levites pursued them

to bring them back and killed seven of their families, losing four of their own. Which has the shape of the Chanukah story too, where part of the fighting was Jew against Jew, those who meant to stay Jews against those who did not.

Shevuot's ninth daf stays with the goat offered outside the Temple, and takes up the goats of Rosh Chodesh and the festivals. Rosh Chodesh, with Shabbat and circumcision, was one of the three the Greeks tried to forbid outright. It stands for His never-ending part in how we live: for all that we now use a fixed calendar, the ideal was looking up for the first thin appearance of the new moon — a reminder that even the part of our lives tied to nature's cycles is in His hands.

Jeremiah's ninth chapter arrives at lines everybody knows: "Let not the wise man boast of his wisdom, nor the strong man boast of his strength, nor the rich man boast of his riches. But let him that boasts exult in this, that he understands and knows me, for I am the Lord Who practices kindness, justice and righteousness on the earth." Wise, strong, rich — the Greeks were all three, and their wisdom had no G-d in it. Which is what we say in the Shemoneh Esreh: the strong into the hands of the weak, the many into the hands of the few, the impure into the hands of the pure. The chapter ends on circumcision, and on hearts that are uncircumcised.

Week 9, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 62 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Last Week of Cheshvan / Week of Rosh Chodesh Kislev - Psalms 25-27; 41:6-8; 89:10

The last week of Cheshvan, or the week of Rosh Chodesh Kislev, in psalms: the twenty-fifth, twenty-sixth and twenty-seventh, with three verses of Psalm 41 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 25 is a request to be taught. "O Lord, make Your ways known to me; teach me Your paths. Train me in Your truth and teach me, for You are the G-d of my salvation; I yearn for You all day." It asks for an old mercy and a short memory: "O Lord, remember Your mercies and Your kindnesses, for they have existed for all time. Do not recall the sins of my youth." Then the line about who gets taught: "Good and upright is the Lord, therefore He directs sinners along the way. He guides the humble with justice… The secret of the Lord is to those who fear Him." And near the end, alone: "Turn to me and be compassionate to me, for I am alone and afflicted."

Psalm 26 asks for the opposite of mercy — to be examined. “Judge me, O Lord, for in my innocence I have walked… Try me, O Lord, and test me; refine my mind and heart.” Then the company he has kept and not kept: “I did not sit with men of falsehood, and with hypocrites I will not mingle.” And what he does instead: “I wash my hands in purity, and circle Your altar, O Lord, to give voice to thanks, and to recount all Your wonders. I love the shelter of Your House, O Lord, and the place where Your glory resides.”

Psalm 27 is the one said through this season. “The Lord is my light and my salvation — whom shall I fear? The Lord is the strength of my life — whom shall I dread?” Then the single request, which is the heart of it: “One thing I have asked of the Lord, this I seek: that I may dwell in the House of the Lord all the days of my life, to behold the pleasantness of the Lord, and to visit His Sanctuary.” It asks not to be hidden from — “Do not conceal Your countenance from me” — and holds the hardest comfort in the book: “Though my father and mother have forsaken me, the Lord has taken me in.” It ends twice over: “Hope in the Lord, be strong and let your heart be valiant, and hope in the Lord.”

Psalm 41's verses are the whispering of enemies: “My foes say that evil awaits me: 'When will he die, and his name perish?' And if one comes to see me, he speaks insincerely… Together they whisper against me.” And Psalm 89 answers with the sea: “You rule the vastness of the sea; when its waves surge, You still them.”

Week 9, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 63 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Stormy Petrel is Saying

The stormy petrel opens, and this gathering is a beloved arriving while enemies whisper.

“Light is sown for the righteous” is set between the beloved raising his voice and the Lord’s own portion: “My beloved raised his voice and said to me” / “Light is sown for the righteous” / “because the Lord’s portion is His people” / “'Arise, my beloved, my fair one, and come away.'”

Then three risings together — Devorah’s, Hannah’s, and the beloved coming over the hills: “until I Deborah arose; I arose as a mother in Israel” / “so Hannah rose up

after they had eaten in Shiloh" / "the sound of my beloved! Behold, he is coming" / "skipping over the mountains, jumping over the hills."

And immediately the whispering starts. "My foes say that evil awaits me" / "the depths congealed in the heart of the sea" / "because the enemy said, I will pursue" / "when will he die, and his name perish?" The open cities cease, and the insincere visitor comes in, and the smoke goes up in His nostrils — "for his heart gathers iniquity for himself" / "together they whisper against me — all my enemies" / "and fire out of His mouth did devour."

Then the sea is stilled: "you rule the vastness of the sea" / "when its waves surge, You still them."

It ends at the windows and the doorpost. "Looking from the windows" / "now Eli the priest sat upon his seat" / "my beloved resembles a gazelle or a fawn of the hinds" / "by the door-post of the temple of Hashem" / "behold, he is standing behind our wall" — and the last lines are Jacob as the lot of His inheritance, joy for the straight-hearted, and peering from the lattices.

Week 9, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK X

Tiferet of Gevurah

Days 64–70

Day 64 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Trust in G-d's Mercy

Week ten, and the bat repeats something G-d said: "Comfort My people, comfort them, says your Lord." (Isaiah 40:1)

Now we are fully into Kislev, whose tribe is Benjamin — known for keeping Jewish values intact for the generations after him, and for how much he was prepared to give up. The bat can see in the dark, which is the useful trick in a month of long cold nights. And it is in this month, at Chanukah, that the comfort actually arrives: the Greeks' darkness is beaten and the light of the Temple is put back.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Shimon: "Be meticulous with the reading of the Shemah and with prayer. When you pray, do not make your prayers routine, but an entreaty of mercy and a supplication before the Almighty… And do not be wicked in your own eyes."

The Shema is the plainest statement of there being One, and of this people taking Him as King. Prayer is the intimacy with Him. Those two are exactly what the Greeks wanted gone. They could live with a cosmos — cold, indifferent to how anyone behaves — but not with a G-d who is a merciful Father and a King.

Rabbi Shimon's own answer, asked what path to take, was to see what is coming — literally, to see what is being born — and his worst thing was borrowing and not repaying, because one who borrows from a friend borrows from G-d. Seeing what is about to happen is one of the Talmud's definitions of real wisdom. The Greeks had wisdom. Wisdom by itself is not enough: it has to be tied to the ethics that come with One G-d. And not repaying a loan is not only dishonest, it throws back the mercy somebody showed you, which was a piece of His.

The pairing is Tiferet shebeGevurah — and tiferet is also called *rachamim*, mercy. Further from Tishrei now, we still remember how beautiful it was, and we ask for mercy to hold on to what we decided then.

The bat's lesson: pray for mercy, and hold up the people around you — the poor and the pressed-upon first.

Week 10, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 65 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Samuel and Purity

"He found them in a desert land, and in a desolate, howling wasteland. He encompassed them and bestowed understanding upon them; He protected them as the pupil of His eye." (Deuteronomy 32:10) A desolation, and understanding given inside it. That was the state of things at the time of the Chanukah miracle — and what He gave them was not only protection from being absorbed, but the very tools of logic and argument that Greek thought had, to be used on the Torah. Much of the reasoning in the Babylonian Talmud came out of that meeting. The Talmud is full of Greek words, and the name of the Greek king Ptolomy, *Talmai*, has the same numerical value as *Talmud*.

The haftorah bends the sky: "And He bent the heavens and He came down; and thick darkness was under His feet." (II Samuel 22:10) Coming down and bending what nature does — which is what the Jews saw then. And the Greek exile is compared to darkness, while this festival is the one of light.

The quality is purity, *taharah*. With last week's joy, those two are the qualities of Chanukah: after the Greeks defiled the Temple the Kohanim purified it and dedicated it again, and the miracle turns on pure oil still carrying the Kohen Gadol's seal.

The prophet is Samuel, who is purity itself. A Nazir from before he was born, raised in the Tabernacle by the Kohen Gadol, spoken to by G-d while he was still a child — and his greatness is reckoned as Moshe and Aharon together.

The Levitical city is Gibeon, where something else was bent. "Then Joshua spoke to the Lord on the day when the Lord delivered up the Amorites before the children of Israel, and he said in the sight of Israel, 'Sun, stand still upon Gibeon, and Moon in

the valley of Ayalon.' And the sun stood still, and the moon stayed, until the people had avenged themselves upon their enemies." Night was coming and the pursuit would have had to stop; the sun staying put gave them the light and the hours. The whole world saw it.

What purity asks of a student is a mind clear enough to take the thing in. A head full of a million useless or degrading images cannot absorb Torah properly, and if the animal in a person is loose it is hard to concentrate and harder to feel what is holy. Without some purifying, the line between holy and ordinary blurs until nothing seems special at all. If everything is holy then nothing is. A yes is only worth something if the same person sometimes says no.

Week 10, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 66 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Noah and Seeking Comfort, Compassion

"I will overtake, I will share the booty; my desire will be filled from them; I will draw my sword, my hand will impoverish them." That is the enemy talking, and confident — as the Greeks were at first about what looked like a small and simple Jewish revolt.

The haftorah names the cause: "When they chose new gods, then there was war in the cities; was there seen a shield or a spear." Assimilation, idolatry, and then being hunted — all three were in the Greek exile.

Sotah's tenth daf stays with Samson, and takes in Judah and Abshalom. Its subject is licentiousness, and children brought up badly who turn against their parents. Which belongs to this month, since Chanukah comes from *chinuch*, education.

The tenth generation from Adam is Noah, who lived in a society that had gone entirely rotten — much as the Jews did under the Greeks. Pirkei Avot says that He waited ten generations before bringing the Flood, out of patience.

The journey is into strength: "They journeyed from Dophkah and camped in Alush." Alush means power, and power's danger is how easily it corrupts. Last week was the knocking, which was formless. This week is having the power to do something with it, in an ordinary day, and do it well.

Noah's lesson for prayer is asking for comfort, which in many ways is what prayer is. His name comes from *lenachem*, to comfort — the bat's own verse this week,

nachamu nachamu ami. Think what comfort Noah must have needed, having watched the whole world destroyed.

Week 10, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 67 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Prayer out of Fear of G-d

"And she was in bitterness of soul — and prayed unto the Lord, and wept sore." Hannah praying out of bitterness, in the week the bat sings of comfort. The verse says she prayed *al* Hashem, upon Him, above the level of revelation that the Name itself is. In Kislev too, the connection runs very high.

The week's quality is that the Torah enclothes him with fear — following last week's humility. The two go together, and they are together in the list of forty-eight as well. What Kislev and Chanukah ask for involves both.

Hannah's weeping is the fear. She had been made to feel so small and so insignificant that it brought her to a greater fear of G-d, and that is what let her pray with such complete self-effacement that no words came out of her mouth at all. She was entirely nullified before the Master.

Proverbs' tenth chapter is the righteous set against the wicked, line after line, and much of it is about the mouth. "Treasures of wickedness will not avail, but charity will save from death… Blessings shall come upon the head of a righteous man, but violence shall cover the mouth of the wicked. The mention of a righteous man is for a blessing, but the name of the wicked shall rot… He who covers up hatred has false lips, and he who spreads slander is a fool. In a multitude of words, transgression will not be avoided, and he who holds back his lips is wise. The tongue of the righteous is choice silver… Fear of the Lord will add days, but the years of the wicked will be shortened."

The righteous few against the wicked many is Chanukah's own phrase. And it is worth noticing that this month's two Chassidic holidays, Yud Kislev and Yud-Tes Kislev, both mark a Rebbe of Chabad coming out of a prison he was put in by slander.

The week holds two yahrzeits of men who built Torah in America out of nothing hospitable. Rabbi Aharon Kotler, on the third of Kislev — born in Russia, orphaned

young, formed at Slabodka under the Alter and Rabbi Moshe Mordechai Epstein, and the founder of the Lakewood yeshiva, now one of the great centres of Torah study anywhere. And Rabbi Chaim Michoel Dov Weissmandl, on the sixth — born in Hungary, who during the war went to every authority he could reach to try to save the Jews of Slovakia and failed, lost his entire family, and got out by sawing the lock off a carriage and jumping from a moving train. In America he founded the Nitra Yeshiva and a farming community that kept the Torah's agricultural laws.

Week 10, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 68 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Connecting to Holiness

"For behold, the winter has passed; the rain is over and gone. The blossoms have appeared in the land, the time of singing has arrived, and the voice of the turtledove is heard in our land. The fig tree has put forth its green figs, and the vines with their tiny grapes have given forth their fragrance; arise, my beloved, my fair one, and come away."

Winter into spring, which is rescue. Rashi reads it against Egypt and the Passover redemption, and the redemption of this month has much of that one in it. The rain being over is the Flood finally behind us. The singing is the pure singing of the Kohanim and the Maccabees.

And the third verse, Rashi takes apart: "The fig tree has put forth its green figs" — these are the transgressors of Israel, who perished during the three days of darkness; "and the vines with their tiny grapes gave forth their fragrance" — those who were left of them repented and were accepted. Figs and grapes are two of the fruits the Land is praised for, and after the Greeks were beaten, life in it began to come back to normal.

Of the seventy souls the tenth is Jachin, which means to establish or to prepare — and the verb is in our prayer for Jerusalem: *ve'chise David meheira le'tocha tachin*, and install within it soon the throne of David. There is a separate blessing for the kingdom, and yet the throne is named inside the rebuilding, because the Temple and the throne together are what the city is: a place united by worship and by governance. Jachin was also the name of one of the two pillars of Solomon's Temple;

the other was Boaz.

Shevuot's tenth daf continues with the goat of the festivals, of Rosh Chodesh and of Yom Kippur, and asks whether the holiness of certain Temple items can leave them.

Jeremiah's tenth chapter keeps the nations' idols apart from Israel's portion: "Not like these is Jacob's portion, for He is the One Who formed everything, and Israel is the tribe of His inheritance; the Lord of Hosts is His name." And it ends with verses said in the Passover Hagaddah: "Pour out Your wrath upon the nations that do not know You… for they have devoured Jacob and consumed him and destroyed him, and have wasted his dwelling."

Week 10, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 69 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second Week of Kislev - Psalms 28-30; 41:9-11; 89:11

The second week of Kislev in psalms: the twenty-eighth, twenty-ninth and thirtieth, with three verses of Psalm 41 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 28 asks not to be met with silence. "I call to You, O Lord; my Strength, do not be deaf to me; for should You be silent to me, I will be like those who descend to the pit. Hear the sound of my pleas when I cry out to You, when I raise my hands toward Your holy Sanctuary." It asks not to be gathered up with the wrong people — "with evildoers who speak of peace with their companions, though evil is in their heart" — and then it is answered, mid-psalm: "Blessed is the Lord, for He has heard the voice of my pleas. The Lord is my strength and my shield; in Him my heart trusted and I was helped."

Psalm 29 is the one about a voice. Seven times "the voice of the Lord," and the whole psalm is weather and force: "The voice of the Lord is over the waters, the G-d of glory thunders… The voice of the Lord breaks cedars; the Lord shatters the cedars of Lebanon. He makes them leap like a calf… The voice of the Lord strikes flames of fire. The voice of the Lord makes the desert tremble… The voice of the Lord causes the does to calve, and strips the forests bare." Then it sits down: "The Lord sat as King at the Flood; the Lord will sit as King forever. The Lord will give strength to His people; the Lord will bless His people with peace."

Psalm 30 is headed as a song for the dedication of the House, which is this month's business exactly. "I exalt You, Lord, for You have uplifted me… Lord, You have brought up my soul from the grave." It holds the line people carry around with them: "For His wrath endures but for a moment… when one retires at night weeping, joy will come in the morning." And the honest admission in the middle: "In my security I thought, 'I shall never falter.' Lord, by Your favor You have made my mountain stand strong; when You concealed Your countenance I was alarmed." Its argument is almost cheeky: "What profit is there in my death, in my going down to the grave? Can dust praise You?" And its end is the turn: "You have turned my mourning into dancing; You have undone my sackcloth and girded me with joy."

Psalm 41's verses are the betrayal: "Even my ally in whom I trusted, who ate of my bread, has raised his heel over me."

Week 10, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 70 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Bat is Saying

The bat opens with the comfort, and the gathering puts it straight beside Hannah's bitterness.

"Comfort My people, comfort them, says your Lord" / "and she was in bitterness of soul" / "and prayed unto Hashem, and wept sore." Then the heavens bend, and the friend turns: "And He bent the heavens and He came down" / "even my ally in whom I trusted, who ate of my bread" / "has raised his heel over me" / "and thick darkness was under His feet."

The call to come away lands in the middle of the enemy's boasting. "Arise, my beloved, my fair one, and come away" / "I will overtake, I will share the booty" / "my desire will be filled from them" / "when they chose new gods" / "then there was war in the cities" / "I will draw my sword, my hand will impoverish them" / "was there seen a shield or a spear."

Then the answer, three lines of it: "Let his wickedness pour into him; now that he lies down, he shall rise no more" / "you crushed Rahav like a corpse" / "with Your powerful arm You scattered Your enemies."

And the last stretch is spring arriving over the top of the desert. “But you, Lord, be gracious to me” / “and the vines with their tiny grapes have given forth their fragrance” / “He found them in a desert land, and in a desolate, howling wasteland” / “the blossoms have appeared in the land, the time of singing has arrived” / “He encompassed them and bestowed understanding upon them” / “for behold, the winter has passed; the rain is over and gone.”

It ends with the turtledove, the green figs, and the pupil of His eye.

Week 10, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XI

Netzach of Gevurah

Days 71–77

Day 71 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

Fighting Evil and Heresy, Yet Knowing How to Forgive

Week eleven, and the stork carries on where the bat left off: "Speak to the heart of Jerusalem, and call to her, for her time has arrived, for her sins have been pardoned, for she has taken double from G-d's hand for all her sins." (Isaiah 40:2) The punishment is over; the city has had double for everything.

And what is the heart of Jerusalem? Most likely the Temple itself. It was on Chanukah that the Temple was taken back, cleaned of impurity and dedicated again — and Chanukah means dedication.

This week holds Yud Kislev, when the second Rebbe of Lubavitch, the Mitteler Rebbe, was let out of prison. He had been arrested on charges invented out of nothing, that he was fomenting rebellion against the government — strikingly like the charges made against his father.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Elazar: "Be diligent in the study of Torah. Know what to answer a heretic. And know before whom you toil, and who is your employer who will repay you the reward of your labors."

Knowing what to answer an *apikores* is this month exactly, since what we are marking is having held off the parts of Greek philosophy that cut against the Torah. Epicureanism, with its eye on pleasure, is probably the strain furthest from it, and the one with the most appeal just then. And the other half of his saying — know before Whom you work, and who pays — is the direct connection the Greeks could not make sense of at all.

Rabbi Matis Weinberg points out that *Tzion* and *Yavan*, Zion and Greece, differ by a single letter: the *tzadik*. That is the difference — acting justly before G-d with a

good heart, and being bound to Him and to the righteous of every generation. Which is why the Midrash has the Greeks demanding their heresy be written on the horn of an ox, the sign of Yosef HaTzadik.

The pairing is Netzach shebeGevurah. The first chapter of the Shulchan Aruch teaches that gevurah's own place is the heart, where a person can defeat his own enemy, the yetzer hara.

And the stork's lesson, which is harder than it sounds: learn to ask forgiveness properly, and learn to actually forgive. We are only here because of His forgiveness, handed out daily.

Week 11, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 72 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Ministering the Sages

"As an eagle awakens its nest, hovering over its fledglings, it spreads its wings, taking them and carrying them on its pinions." (Deuteronomy 32:11) A parent waking its young and carrying them. One of the great subjects of Chanukah is *chinuch*, bringing children up — and we can see the pains the Alter Rebbe took over his own son and successor.

There is a Chassidic saying that Yud Kislev is the birth of the chassid and Yud Tes Kislev, next week, his circumcision. The two dates belong to each other, which says a good deal about the bond between the first two Rebbes of Chabad.

Both this week's verses are wings. The haftorah: "And He rode upon a cherub and did fly; He was seen upon the wings of the wind." (II Samuel 22:11) Flying belongs to a month whose holidays are above nature, and to the kind of men they are about.

The quality is ministering to the sages, which is the other side of that bond: the Alter Rebbe was meticulous about his son's upbringing, and the son was diligent in serving his father and carrying on his work.

The prophet is Gad, who the Midrash says served King David closely, always at his side along with Nathan. He is there at the turns: telling David to return to the land of Judah, and later about the sin of the census and the building of the altar.

The Levitical city is Gebah, which brings up another father and son and one of the stranger miracles between them — the war against the Philistines in Samuel I,

with Shaul and Yonatan, and Yonatan's armour-bearer, who ministered to him.

What this quality means in practice: a large part of learning Torah is being around somebody who already has it. There are things in it that cannot be got from a book. And in the presence of a sage you not only get your questions answered — you find out how many questions you had not thought to ask.

Week 11, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 73 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Shem and Being Truthful

"You blew with Your wind, the sea covered them; they sank like lead in the powerful waters." The word for wind is *ruach*, which is also spirit and soul. Spirit, and its strength, is what separated the Jews from the Greeks. And the sea stands for hidden wisdom, as water stands for Torah.

The haftorah: "when the forty thousand went against Israel? My heart is toward the lawgivers of Israel." Forty thousand of the enemy defeated, and a heart turned toward the wise men of Israel — which is Chanukah twice over: the sheer numbers, and where the victory came from, which in that case was the Kohanim. And it suits two lawgivers saved on Yud Kislev and Yud Tes Kislev.

Sotah's eleventh daf is Egypt — the enslavement, the persecution, and the brave work of Miriam and Yocheved, and the miraculous ways Jewish children were kept alive.

The eleventh generation from Adam is Shem, Noah's son, whose name means *name* and who stands for truth. Avraham comes from him, and all the Semitic peoples. His brother Yafeth's name means beauty, and Yavan, Greece, descends from him. So the Maccabean war with Greek culture is in fact a fight between the sons of Shem and of Yafeth.

The journey runs dry: "They journeyed from Alush and camped in Rephidim, but there there was no water for the people to drink." Rephidim comes from *rafeh*, weak, and points at devotion to Torah study gone slack. Last week was learning to hold power without being corrupted by it; this week is getting past the weakness that comes of having no water. That is Kislev's fight, and the Mitteler Rebbe's.

Shem's lesson is self-examination done truthfully — going back over the day, the week, the month, and seeing what can be better. *Cheshbon HaNefesh*, a spiritual accounting, and a central part of the practice called hitbodedut.

Week 11, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 74 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Creating a Kosher Environment

"And she vowed a vow, and said: to Lord of Hosts, if You will look upon the affliction of Your bondswoman, and You will remember me, and You will not forget Your bondswoman and You will give Your bondswoman a man-child, and I shall give him to the Lord all the days of his life, and no razor shall come upon his head."

Hannah's vow over a son — and Yud Kislev is also about a son, Rabbi Dovber of Lubavitch, who walked in his father's steps. The Alter Rebbe was exacting about how he was raised, bringing him up in great sanctity, rather as Samuel was raised.

The week's quality reads literally as: the Torah makes him kosher to be a tzadik. Which is Hannah's words exactly — the need to give a child a kosher environment, one in which a holy life is actually possible. And the parents' prayers count for as much. Rebbe Nachman said of himself that he reached what he reached in the merit of his mother's prayers. Of Rabbi Chanina, Pirkei Avot says *Ashrei Yoladtoh*, praiseworthy is the one who gave birth to him.

Proverbs' eleventh chapter keeps the righteous and the wicked side by side, line after line. "Deceitful scales are an abomination of the Lord, but a perfect weight is His will. When willful wickedness comes, then comes disgrace, but with the modest is wisdom… Riches will not avail on the day of wrath, but charity will save from death… With his mouth, the flatterer destroys his neighbor; but with knowledge, righteous men are extricated. When it goes well with the righteous, the city rejoices… With the blessing of the upright, the ceiling is raised, but with the mouth of the wicked it is demolished."

The righteous few against the wicked many is Chanukah's phrase again.

This week carries the yahrzeits of two Modzitzer Rebbes. Rabbi Yisrael Taub, on the thirteenth of Kislev, who founded the dynasty and composed more than two hundred melodies, many still sung — his most famous written during the amputation

of his leg, which was done without anaesthetic. He is also the Divrei Yisrael, after his commentary on the first three books of the Torah. And his son Rabbi Shaul Yedidya Elazer Taub, on the sixteenth, who composed over a thousand melodies and died in Israel in 1947, having only lately arrived, meaning to settle there.

Week 11, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 75 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Staying True to the Covenant

"My dove, in the clefts of the rock, in the coverture of the steps, show me your appearance, let me hear your voice, for your voice is pleasant and your appearance is comely." That one is His. Then ours: "Seize for us the foxes, the little foxes, who destroy the vineyards, for our vineyards are with tiny grapes. My beloved is mine, and I am his, who grazes among the roses."

The dove in the rock is this people crying out in purity when there is nowhere to go. Rashi puts it at the Red Sea, where the crying revealed what Israel is underneath — which is rather like a hidden flask of pure oil still carrying the Kohen Gadol's seal. And the voice is called *arev*, pleasant, which spells *orev*, a raven, next week's creature.

The little foxes that ruin vineyards: the fox stands for the Temple's destruction, and Rashi recalls the Egyptians throwing infant boys into the Nile — who ended up drowned themselves. Wine, like oil, means wisdom and Torah. The Greeks came for our knowledge at a moment when the people's learning was thin: infants, and tiny grapes.

The third verse is the whole relationship in a line, and Rashi makes it mutual and exclusive: "He demanded all His needs from me… All my needs I demanded of Him, and not of other deities." Which neither the rationalist nor the pagan Greek could follow.

Of the seventy souls the eleventh is Tzochar — also the name, in the Torah, of the father of Ephron the Hittite, who sold Avraham the Ma'arat HaMachpelah to bury Sarah. And *tzohar*, with a *hey*, was the light in the Ark. Perhaps he is here for both: the difficulty of dealing with other nations holding the Land, and the light of this festival. The tzohar, like the Menorah, lit what was outside it as well as what was within.

Shevuot's eleventh daf is the holiness of the ketoret and of what is dedicated — and the ketoret has eleven ingredients.

Jeremiah's eleventh chapter has Him telling the prophet to speak to Jerusalem, and returning again and again to the fathers — one generation holding to the next, which is the week's subject. And to the *brit*, the covenant, which the Greeks set themselves against: "Cursed be the man who will not hearken to the words of this covenant, which I commanded your forefathers on the day I took them out of the land of Egypt, out of the iron furnace."

Week 11, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 76 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Kislev - Psalms 31-33; 41:12-14; 89:12

The third week of Kislev in psalms: the thirty-first, thirty-second and thirty-third, with the end of Psalm 41 and a verse of Psalm 89.

Psalm 31 is a long look at being disgraced. "In You I have taken shelter, O Lord, I shall never be shamed… For You are my rock and my fortress." Then the state he is in: "my eye wastes away from vexation — my soul and my stomach. For my life is spent in sorrow, my years in sighing." And the loneliness of it, which is worse than the enemies: "Because of my adversaries I have become a disgrace — exceedingly to my neighbors, and a dread to my friends; those who see me outside flee from me. Like a dead man, I was forgotten from the heart; I became like a lost vessel." It holds the line said at the end of each day — "I entrust my spirit into Your hand" — and then turns on one sentence: "But I trusted in You, O Lord; I said, 'You are my G-d.' My times are in Your hand." Near the close it gets wide: "How abundant is Your good that You have hidden for those who fear You." And it ends as an instruction to everybody else: "Be strong and fortify your hearts, all who put their hope in the Lord!"

Psalm 32 is the whole confession psalm, having been given three verses at a time until now. "Fortunate is he whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered… When I was silent, my limbs wore away through my wailing all day long… My sin I made known to You, my iniquity I did not cover… and You have forgiven the iniquity of my transgression forever." And then: "the flood of many waters will not reach him."

Psalm 33 is praise with instruments and a reason given for each line. "Sing joyously to the Lord, you righteous ones… Extol the Lord with a harp; sing to Him with a ten-stringed lyre. Sing to Him a new song." Then how things got here: "By the word of the Lord the heavens were made, and by the breath of His mouth all their hosts… For He spoke, and it came to be; He commanded, and it endured." And then the part that belongs to this month: "The Lord has annulled the counsel of nations; He has foiled the schemes of peoples… The king is not saved by a great army, nor a warrior rescued by great might. The horse is a false guarantee for victory; with all its great strength it offers no escape. But the eye of the Lord is directed toward those who fear Him."

Psalm 41 closes: "And I, because of my integrity, You upheld me; You set me before You forever. Blessed is the Lord, the G-d of Israel, to all eternity, Amen and Amen."

Week 11, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 77 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Stork is Saying

The stork opens, and this gathering is wings over a nest while a vow is being made.

"Speak to the heart of Jerusalem, and call to her" meets the cherub — "And He rode upon a cherub and did fly" — and then the eagle: "as an eagle awakens its nest, hovering over its fledglings." The pardon follows, with the sea closing over them: "for her time has arrived, for her sins have been pardoned" / "You blew with Your wind, the sea covered them" / "He was seen upon the wings of the wind" / "it spreads its wings, taking them and carrying them on its pinions."

Then the dove in the rock, and Hannah beginning: "My dove, in the clefts of the rock, in the coverture of the steps" / "if You will look upon the affliction of Your bondswoman" / "for she has taken double from G-d's hand for all her sins."

The foxes come in next, with the forty thousand and the lead: "Seize for us the foxes, the little foxes" / "who destroy the vineyards, for our vineyards are with tiny grapes" / "when the forty thousand went against Israel?" / "they sank like lead in the powerful waters."

Then the vow is laid out across the whole last stretch, a clause at a time, with the psalm's assurances between them. "And she vowed a vow, and said: to Lord of Hosts" / "and no razor shall come upon his head" / "and You will remember me, and You will not forget Your bondswoman" / "with this I shall know that You desire me" / "show me your appearance, let me hear your voice" / "You set me before You forever" / "my beloved is mine, and I am his" / "and You will give Your bondswoman a male child."

It ends with the giving over and the blessing: "and I shall give him to the Lord all the days of his life" / "my heart is toward the lawgivers of Israel" / "Blessed is the Lord, the G-d of Israel" / "who grazes among the roses" — and then the heavens and the earth, and to all eternity, Amen and Amen.

Week 11, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XII

Hod of Gevurah

Days 78–84

Day 78 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

Revealing Warmth to Those that Are Cold and Indifferent

Week twelve, and the raven asks: "Who prepares food for the raven, when his young ones cry out to G-d?" (Job 38:41)

This is the week of Yud Tes Kislev, called the Rosh Hashanah of Chassidism — the day the Alter Rebbe came out of prison, and the yahrzeit of the Maggid of Mezeritch. He had been accused of treason by the opponents of Chassidism, with the death penalty in prospect, and he came out of it. He took the release as a verdict in the Heavenly Court as well as the earthly one, and afterwards he taught far more openly. The effort that followed carried the warmth of Chassidism into the coldest and most indifferent part of a Jew: the intellect. The capital of intellectual Judaism was Vilna, where he had been sent.

The raven is the right creature for that. It was put out of Noah's ark for not keeping the rule of celibacy, and it is known for being cruel and careless toward its own young. And yet when Elijah fled from Ahab, G-d arranged that the raven — which does not even feed its own chicks — should bring him food. Elijah had run out of hope and was complaining about the state of the people, and the lesson was that like the raven, everyone has warmth and good in them; it only has to be brought out.

The word itself says so. *Orev*, raven, is close to *arev* — responsible for another, and sweet, and mixed together, as in *Kol Israel Arevim Zeh LaZeh*, that all of Israel is responsible for, sweet to and mixed up with one another. Which is nearly the whole basis of Chassidism and of the Torah: love your fellow as yourself.

Twelve is the twelve tribes. For all the differences and the setbacks, we are mixed together and answerable for each other. On his deathbed Jacob was worried about

exactly those differences, and the Talmud says his twelve sons answered him in unison: "Listen, O Israel" — meaning Jacob — "Hashem is our G-d, Hashem is One."

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Tarfon: "The day is short, the work is much, the workers are lazy, the reward is great, and the Master is pressing." And: "It is not incumbent upon you to finish the task, but neither are you free to absolve yourself from it." Chassidism came to light a fire under people who were low and spiritually asleep. An alarm clock: the time is short, start now.

The pairing is Hod shebeGevurah. Hod belongs to the inner dimensions of the Torah — as Lag Ba'Omer, which is hod within hod, is the yahrzeit of the man who set down the Zohar.

Week 12, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 79 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Nathan and Friendship

"So the Lord guided them alone, and there was no alien deity with Him." (Deuteronomy 32:12) One of the first principles of Chassidism is *hashgachah pratit* — that everything that happens comes straight from Him, with nothing else interfering, and that all of it is for the best. And one of the first acts in rededicating the Temple was clearing out the foreign gods the Greeks and their sympathisers had put in it.

The haftorah: "And He fixed darkness about Him as booths; gathering of waters, thick clouds of the skies." (II Samuel 22:12) Chassidus is about turning darkness into light, and darkness is the sign of the Greek exile. Chanukah also runs eight days in order to answer the eight days of Sukkot, which the verse's own word for booths calls up.

The quality is bonding of friends, which may be the main principle of the whole movement: that chassidim are one family, and that all Jews are one.

The prophet is Nathan, who shows what it means from both sides. He is the one who reproves King David with a parable, over an act that was the opposite of bonding with a friend. And it is by that same bonding that he later acts for Batsheva against Adonyah's attempt on the throne: Adonyah had gathered his own friends and allies to declare himself king, so David sends Nathan to join Benaiah ben Yehoyada and Zadok the Kohen and the rest, and declare Solomon.

The Levitical city is Anathoth, which may be the darkest of them. The Zohar says Anathoth means poverty. It was a town of Kohanim gone wrong, whose people wanted to kill the prophet Jeremiah, who came from there, and whose prospects in his prophecy are grim. Chassidus came to teach that even Anathoth can be raised. The name comes from *Anat*, a Canaanite warrior-goddess who looks related to Athena — which suits a month about fighting Greece both ways. And the name has a better side: it is the name of the parent of Shamgar, one of Israel's judges and deliverers, and of a man of the tribe of Benjamin, and of one who signed a covenant in the Book of Nehemiah.

The lesson follows last week's. One of the first things Pirkei Avot says is: make for yourself a rabbi, acquire for yourself a friend, and judge every person favourably — acquiring the friend comes straight after making the teacher. The Talmud puts it harder: either companionship or death. Studying with a partner brings clarity, and lets you see how far you have actually got.

Week 12, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 80 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Arpachshad and the Fiery Furnace

"Who is like You among the powerful, O Lord? Who is like You, exalted in the holy place?" *Mi Chamocha Ba'Elim Hashem* — the acronym that gives the Maccabees their name. And the question comes twice, which answers to the two lights the Alter Rebbe brought: the revealed, in law, and the hidden, in Chassidus. The first half of the verse is His greatness out in the open — *elim* meaning the forces of nature — and the second is the hidden kind.

The haftorah is about giving yourself up willingly, and then: "The riders of white donkeys." Which points at Mashiach, who comes on a donkey. The Alter Rebbe's Tanya belongs to this day, and R. Zusya of Anipoli is said to have foretold: with the Tanya the Jewish people will go out to greet the righteous Mashiach.

Sotah's twelfth daf is Miriam and Moshe. The Talmud says Moshe was also called Tuviah, for the great light revealed about him at his birth — which goes with a man named Shneur for the two lights he brought. And Miriam spoke to her father and so persuaded him, and through him the whole people, not to divorce their wives. The

Alter Rebbe's daughter Devorah Leah had a conversation of that kind with her father too, about giving up her own life to add years to his, so that the work could go on.

The generation is Arpachshad, Shem's son, whose name breaks into three words: *ohr*, light; *pach*, a vial; and *shad*, from Sh-dai, one of His names, read as *Shomer Daltot Yisrael*, Guardian of the doors of Israel — the Name that goes on a mezuzah. All three are this festival. Light; the small vial of pure oil that lasted eight days instead of one; and the lamp that is lit beside the mezuzah. A mezuzah's first fixing is called *Chanukath HaBayit*, the dedication of a house. The Midrash also reads Sh-dai as the One who told the world *dai*, enough — who set limits on what He made, being Himself without any. Which is this festival's message from the other direction: He can also do what nature does not allow.

The journey arrives at the mountain: "They journeyed from Rephidim and camped in the Sinai desert." Last week's weakness for want of water turns out to have been for the sake of a larger knowledge — as this week gives the Torah of Chassidus.

Arpachshad is also tied to Ur Chasdim, where Abraham was thrown into the furnace for defying Nimrod. Which brings to mind Rabbi Elimelech of Lizhensk's practice: in any idle moment, lying awake, picture a great fire burning in front of you reaching to the heavens, and for the sake of His holiness go against your nature and throw yourself in. The Holy One joins good intentions to great deeds — so you are no longer idle but keeping a commandment.

Week 12, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 81 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

The Rosh Hashanah of Chassidut

"And it came to pass, as she prayed long before the Lord, that Eli watched her mouth." She prays at length, and the Kohen Gadol guards her mouth.

Which is the story of this week. Yud Tes Kislev begins with a heavenly decree against the Alter Rebbe for revealing the secrets of Chassidut, and it came out as fifty-three days in prison on invented charges of treason against the Czar. During those days he was visited by the Baal Shem Tov and by the Maggid of Mezritch — whose yahrzeit is Yud Tes Kislev — and told that he was not only absolved of the decree but should teach and reveal more. With his masters having watched his

mouth, his teaching afterwards became far more expansive. Chassidim speak of before Petersburg and after Petersburg, Petersburg being where he was held.

The week's quality is that the Torah makes him fit to be *chassid*, pious — and Yud Tes Kislev is the Rosh Hashanah of Chassidut. Hannah in that verse is piety itself.

Proverbs' twelfth chapter keeps contrasting the righteous with the wicked. The difference between a tzadik, last week's word, and a chassid is that the chassid goes past the letter of the law to please the Creator. The chapter is full of that kind of thing: "A good man will obtain favor of the Lord… A righteous man has regard for the desire of his beast, but the mercy of the wicked is cruel… The righteous is more generous than his neighbor… In the road of charity is life, and on the way of its path there is no death."

Two yahrzeits here, both close to the Alter Rebbe. The eighteenth of Kislev is Rabbi Baruch of Mezhibuz, the Baal Shem Tov's grandson, a disciple of the Maggid and one of the leading rebbes of the Alter Rebbe's own day — and it was to him that the Alter Rebbe wrote, once freed, describing the miracles. He once challenged the Alter Rebbe, who is said to have answered: "You may be his grandson in a physical sense; I am his grandson in a spiritual sense."

And the nineteenth is the Maggid of Mezritch himself, the Baal Shem Tov's successor, whose disciples became the leaders of the movement — Rebbe Elimelech of Lizhensk and his brother Rav Zusia of Anipoli, Rebbe Menachem Mendel of Vitebsk, Rebbe Levi Yitzchak of Berditchev, Rebbe Aharon of Karlin, Rebbe Shmuel Shmelke of Nikolsburg and his brother Rebbe Pinchas Horowitz of Frankfurt. On his deathbed he turned to the Alter Rebbe: "Zalmanyu, give me your hand. You will remain alone, you are for yourself — you have your own way. You will need a lot of help from Heaven. I will yearn for you very much, and G-d willing, I will save you from all your troubles." And, by the Chabad tradition, he said: "This day is our Yom Tov."

Week 12, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 82 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Longing for G-d

"Until the sun spreads, and the shadows flee, go around; liken yourself, my beloved, to a gazelle or to a fawn of the hinds, on distant mountains." Then a new chapter: "On my bed at night, I sought him whom my soul loves; I sought him but I did not find him. I will arise now and go about the city, in the market places and in the city squares. I will seek him whom my soul loves; I sought him, but I did not find him."

All of it is ours. The sun spreading is what happened after the release: Chassidut went out across the land — to distant mountains, to a bed at night, which is exile, and into the city, the market, the squares. There was nowhere it could not get into. And taken together the verses are a long ache for Him. The Alter Rebbe's longing for Hashem was such that it gave him a breathing complaint.

Of the seventy souls the twelfth is Saul the son of the Canaanitess. Rashi explains that this is Dinah's son — she had been raped and taken by a Canaanite who meant to marry her. One of the subjects of this month is intermarriage and assimilation, and in Dinah's story Shimon and Levi act with the zeal of Maccabees to get her back. Though their violence and their deceit, unlike the Maccabees', were not right, and Jacob condemned them for it. The tribe of Levi learned in the end what to do with its zeal.

Shevuot's twelfth daf is about buying what is dedicated on condition of using the remainder, and what to do with animals left over from offerings, and then the goat sent to Azazel, which atoned for whatever the inner goat did not. Which has something of Chassidut's own innovation in it: that everything is holy and has a use, that every Jew is holy, and that even the animal soul can be made holy.

Jeremiah's twelfth chapter lays out one disaster after another and rebukes the people — and all the way through calls them "My inheritance" and "My soul's beloved." The Greeks wanted that exact belief gone, that this people had a portion in Him, and the love between them was the thing they could not grasp. "I have abandoned My House, I have forsaken My inheritance; I have delivered My soul's beloved into the hand of her enemies." And later: "after I uproot them, I will return and have pity on them, and I will restore them, each one to his inheritance and each one to his land."

Day 83 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fourth Week of Kislev - Psalms 34-36; 42:1-4; 89:13

The fourth week of Kislev in psalms: the thirty-fourth, thirty-fifth and thirty-sixth, with the opening of Psalm 42 and a verse of Psalm 89.

Psalm 34 is headed from when David feigned insanity before Avimelech and was driven away. It is mostly instruction, and generous with it. “I bless the Lord at all times; His praise is always in my mouth… I sought the Lord and He answered me; He delivered me from all my fears. Those who look to Him are radiant; their faces are never humiliated.” Then the invitation: “Taste and see that the Lord is good.” And the teaching, asked as a question: “Who is the man who desires life, who loves long life wherein to see goodness? Guard your tongue from evil, and your lips from speaking deceit. Turn away from evil and do good, seek peace and pursue it.” Its best-known line is near the end: “The Lord is close to the broken-hearted, and saves those with a crushed spirit.”

Psalm 35 is a lawsuit. “Fight my antagonists, O Lord, battle those who battle against me. Take hold of shield and armor and arise to help me… say to my soul, 'I am your deliverance.'” What stings most in it is the ingratitude: “They repay me evil for good… But I wore sackcloth when they were ill; I afflicted my soul with fasting… As if it were my friend, my brother, I went about; like a mother in mourning, I was bent over in gloom. But when I limped, they rejoiced and gathered.” And their words: “They opened their mouths wide against me, they said, 'Aha! Aha! Our eyes have seen his misfortune.'” Against which: “You saw, Lord, be not silent.”

Psalm 36 opens inside the head of a man who has stopped being afraid of anything. “Sin says to the wicked, 'There is none who need place the fear of G-d before his eyes.' For Sin makes itself appealing to him… On his bed he contemplates evil, he stands in a path that is not good; he does not despise evil.” And then, without a join, the psalm turns and becomes one of the widest things in the book: “O Lord, Your kindness is in the heavens; Your faithfulness is till the skies. Your righteousness is like the mighty mountains, Your judgments extend to the great deep; man and beast You deliver, O Lord. How precious is Your kindness, O G-d; man takes shelter

in the shadow of Your wings… For the source of life is with You; in Your Light do we see light."

Psalm 42 begins the thirst: "As a hart cries longingly for rivulets of water, so does my soul cry longingly to You, O G-d… My tears were my bread day and night when they say to me all day long, 'Where is your G-d?'"

Week 12, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 84 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Raven Is Saying

The raven opens, and this gathering is a search carried out in the dark.

"Who prepares food for the raven, when his young ones cry out to G-d?" is answered by the guiding — "the Lord guided them alone, and there was no alien deity with Him" — and then the darkness set about Him as Sukkot, with the gathering of waters and the thick clouds.

Then the great question twice, and the thirst under it: "Who is like You among the powerful, O Lord? Who is like You, exalted in the holy place?" / "My soul thirsts for G-d, for the living G-d; when will I come and appear before G-d?"

And then the searching, with Hannah's long prayer set inside it. "On my bed at night, I sought him whom my soul loves" / "I sought him but I did not find him" / "and it came to pass, as she prayed long before the Lord" / "that Eli watched her mouth" / "I will seek him whom my soul loves" / "I sought him, but I did not find him."

The gazelle on the distant mountains follows, and then the willing offering and the white donkeys, with the hart crying for water across them: "that offered themselves willingly among the people" / "the riders of white donkeys" / "as a hart cries longingly for rivulets of water" / "so does my soul cry longingly to You, O G-d."

Then the taunt, and the going out into the city: "My tears were my bread day and night" / "when they say to me all day long, 'Where is your G-d?'" / "I will arise now and go about the city" / "in the market places and in the city squares."

It ends on the compass and the mountains singing — "the north and the south — You created them; Tabor and Hermon sing of Your Name" — and then the sun spreading, the shadows fleeing, and a maskil of the sons of Korah.

Week 12, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XIII

Yesod of Gevurah

Days 85–91

Day 85 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Publicize Miracles with Pride and Humility

Week thirteen brings in Chanukah, and the starling sings about being seen: "Their seed shall be known among the nations, and their offspring among the peoples; all who see them shall acknowledge them, that they are the seed that G-d has blessed." (Isaiah 61:9)

Which is this week's own mitzvah — *pirsumei nissa*, publicising the miracle, so that everyone can see what was given to this people in the days of the Greeks.

The song's attention to seed points at the kohanim, whose line, unlike nearly everything else in Judaism, runs by the physical male seed; there are even tests for a kohen gene, to tell with near certainty whether a man descends from Aaron. The Maccabees were kohanim, and what they did made the seed of Aaron known among the nations.

And Chanukah comes from *chinuch*. The starling also says that each of us was a seed, planted and tended and blessed by parents and teachers and above all by G-d — and the same or better has to be done for our children and students. Darkness and assimilation are beaten by education in the end.

Pirkei Avot gives Akavia the son of Mahalalel, who is blunt: "Reflect upon three things and you will not come to the hands of transgression. Know from where you came, where you are going, and before whom you are destined to give a judgment and accounting. From where you came — from a putrid drop; where you are going — to a place of dust, maggots and worms; and before whom you are destined to give a judgment and accounting — before the supreme King of Kings, the Holy One, blessed be He."

That is seed again, put much less kindly — and it is pointed straight at what this week defeated. Hellenistic culture valued man, and the human body in particular, above everything. Akavia says the body comes from a putrid drop and ends being eaten by worms, and is then judged by G-d Himself. Keep your eye on G-d, not on man.

Which also shows how much mercy there is in it. Low where we came from and low where we are going, and still in a direct relationship with the King of kings, the way children are with a father. There is a spark of Him in us, and when He punishes it is for our good. Chassidism teaches that we have no idea how precious the body is to Him — precious like the seed in the starling's song.

The pairing is Yesod shebeGevurah, and it could hardly fit better: yesod is foundation, and this week a people held to its foundation, with courage, against a policy of forced assimilation.

Week 13, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 86 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

David and Avigail, and the Quality of "Sharp Discussion"

"He made them ride upon the high places of the earth, that they would eat the produce of the field. He let them suck honey from a rock, and oil from the mighty part of the crag." (Deuteronomy 32:13) High places, something impossible, and oil — the whole story is in one verse. The word for high places, *bamah*, also means altar. And the oil can be read as the *pintele yid*, the innermost part of a Jew that stays pure whatever happens and shows itself when things get hard.

The haftorah: "From the brightness before Him flamed forth coals of fire." (II Samuel 22:13) Brightness and fire, which is the Menorah — and coals again, which can be burning inside and need one more step before the fire shows.

The quality is sharp discussion with students, *pilpul*. One of the things this people got out of the Greek exile was sharpness and logic. The Greek king's name, *Talmai*, has the same numerical value as *Talmud*, and the Talmud grew greatly out of that encounter — it even carries Greek words.

The prophets are David and Avigail. David is monarchy, and the Maccabees made a dynasty; he is also the proof that a person can be entirely holy and entirely involved

in the world at once — Torah and prayer alongside running a government and fighting wars. Chanukah has both halves too: the military victory, and the victory of Jewish wisdom over Greek wisdom, which are David and Solomon respectively. And Avigail kept blood from being spilt by going to David and talking to him about her husband, as the Hasmoneans kept further blood from being spilt by making an alliance with Rome. Both of them had the sharpness this week is about. David's mind was such that the halachah always followed his opinion, and it was Avigail's argument that stopped him.

The Levitical city is 'Almon, which means hidden — from *He'elem*, and from *olam*. Revealing what is hidden is the point of Kislev. Through this miracle you can see that the whole *olam* is a kind of screen and that His power is the real thing. And on Chanukah even the most hidden Jews come out. There are limits on what may be used for Shabbat candles and no such limits for these; every Jew is lit up by it.

Week 13, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 87 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Shelah and Chanukah

"Too awesome for praises, performing wonders! You inclined Your right hand; the earth swallowed them up." Praise for wonders, which is the week's whole work. The haftorah asks for it to be told: "those that sit in judgment, and those that walk on the path, tell of it" — and says the persecution has stopped "between the places of drawing water," which stands for the study of Torah the Greeks were attacking.

Sotah's thirteenth daf is the burial of Jacob and of Joseph, and opens with the room filling with light when Moshe was born. On Jacob's burial, the Talmud notices that the argument with Eisav was not won by reasoning: Eisav was making a baseless claim and demanding proof of this and that, and Chushim son of Dan could not stand to see his grandfather's burial held up, so he went ahead and killed him. Which is almost exactly how the revolt began — Matisyahu, told to slaughter a pig on a pagan altar, refused, and then killed the Jew and the Syrian official who had demanded it.

The generation is Shelah, Arpachshad's son — and Shelah is one of the names of Mashiach. It is also the name of Judah's son, whom he did not give to Tamar.

Rabbi Yosef Jacobson draws the two together. Rabbi Isaac Luryah wrote that the judgment begun on Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur is completed some three months later, in the days of Chanukah. Three months after Judah and Tamar, Judah is told what Tamar has supposedly done and the verdict goes against her. And at that moment she sends word: "I am pregnant by the man who is the owner of these articles. Identify, I beg you, these objects. Who is the owner of this seal, cord and staff?"

Read as the Jew speaking to G-d, the timing is exact. At the moment the prosecuting angels have nearly proved the whole experiment a failure, the Jew sends word that the report is false — if he has strayed here and there it is a surface thing, and underneath he belongs to no one else. And he points at the objects: the cord, which is the wick soaked in oil each night, commemorating a sealed cruse found after the Temple was plundered; the seal on that cruse; and the staff, which he has had to pick up over and over for two thousand years, leaving house and security to find somewhere he could still live as a Jew.

Then Judah answers: "She is right; it is from me that she conceived. She did it because I did not give her to my son Shelah." And Shelah is the name of Mashiach. Read that way, it is G-d saying the fault is His: how can I expect a Jew never to sin, never to try his luck with a world that looks so appealing, when I held back the light of Mashiach so long? "It is I who is guilty of treason," not the Jew. Tamar is an innocent palm tree with one heart to her Father in heaven.

The journey is a hard place: "They journeyed from the Sinai desert and camped in Kivroth hataavah" — the graves of craving. Having received the Torah, the work is burying one's desires, through *itkafia* and *itapcha*. The Baal Shem Tov reads the graves of craving as utter self-nullification in cleaving to G-d, where cravings die and are buried with no chance of coming back. Chanukah is, unlike the other festivals, mainly a spiritual one: there is no commandment to make a meal. It is a holiday for praising Him.

Week 13, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 88 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Being Straightforward

"Now Hannah, she spoke in her heart; only her lips moved, but her voice could not be heard; therefore, Eli thought she had been drunken." This is the clearest demonstration that prayer is a spiritual act before it is anything else. No sound has to leave a person for Him to hear the cry. And this festival is the victory of the spiritual over the material.

The week's quality is that the Torah makes him fit to be *yashar*, correct — literally straight: truthful, straightforward. Yashar is tied particularly to keeping the negative commandments, which draw down revelations beyond the created order. In the story Eli wrongly takes Hannah for drunk, when she was praying out of a broken heart — and praying drunk would break a negative commandment. Her conduct is the conduct of a yashar, past reproach, and what it drew down was a child.

Proverbs' thirteenth chapter carries on setting the righteous against the wicked, and speaks directly about light: "The light of the righteous will rejoice, but the candle of the wicked will ebb away. Only with wickedness does one cause quarrels, but there is wisdom with those who take counsel."

Two yahrzeits. On the twenty-fourth of Kislev, Rabbi Chaim Chizkiya Medini, known for the Sdei Chemed, an encyclopaedic work of law in eighteen volumes. He was born in Jerusalem and lived in Turkey and Crimea before returning; he was considered for Rishon L'Zion, and moved to Hebron to give himself to his studies instead, eventually becoming its Chief Rabbi. Jews and Arabs alike held him a holy man.

And on the twenty-seventh, Rabbi Chaim Tirar of Chernowitz, known for the Be'er Mayim Chayim, his commentary on the Torah, and for Sidduroh Shel Shabat on the holiness of the Sabbath. He was one of the most important disciples of the Maggid of Mezritch, and studied under Rabbi Yechiel Michel of Zlotchov.

Week 13, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 89 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Finding G-d in Exile

“The watchmen who patrol the city found me: 'Have you seen him whom my soul loves?' I had just passed them by, when I found him whom my soul loves; I held him and would not let him go, until I brought him into my mother’s house and into the chamber of her who had conceived me. I adjure you, O daughters of Jerusalem, by the gazelles or by the hinds of the field, that you neither awaken nor arouse the love while it is desirous.”

After all the searching and not finding, and after asking the watchmen — Rashi reads them as Moshe and Aharon, and perhaps they are the leaders and prophets and priests of any generation — He is found. That is Chanukah: He shows Himself, in an impossible victory and in oil that burned eight days.

And once found, not let go until He is brought into the mother’s house, into the chamber of the one who conceived — which is the rededication of the Temple, the home of the Shechinah.

The third verse is the same one that closed week eight. Standing here instead, after the finding, the hard tone toward the nations reads as a victory shout rather than a refusal.

Of the seventy souls the thirteenth is Levi, and the fit needs no explaining: every kohen and every zealous Maccabee came from him.

Shevuot’s thirteenth daf asks whether Yom Kippur atones for everything, repentance or not, and finds three exceptions: one who denies the basis of the Torah, one who ridicules it, and one who annuls circumcision. Denying the Torah’s origin and undoing circumcision were two of the sharpest points of conflict with Hellenist culture. The daf also treats the atonement of the kohanim separately from everyone else’s.

Jeremiah’s thirteenth chapter is the girdle he is told to wear, which rots and becomes useless — and then: “just as the girdle clings to a man’s loins, so have I caused the entire house of Israel and the entire house of Judah to cling to Me.” The chapter returns to skirts uncovered and pulled over the face, and to darkness: “Give the Lord your God honor before it becomes dark, and before your feet stumble on the dark mountains.” Then: “Will a Cushite change his skin, or a leopard his spots?”

The leopard, in Jewish tradition, is particularly Greece — for its beauty, its speed, and above all its boldness. The word for its spots also means stains, *kesem*, of the kind tied to impurity. And leopards are known to mate outside their species. The chapter's last line asks when Jerusalem will ever be pure. In the days of the Maccabees, it was.

Week 13, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 90 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fifth Week of Kislev - Psalms 37-39; 42:5-7; 89:14

The fifth week of Kislev in psalms: the thirty-seventh, thirty-eighth and thirty-ninth, with three verses of Psalm 42 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 37 is a long argument against envying people who are doing well out of doing wrong. "Do not compete with the wicked; do not envy doers of injustice. For like grass they will be swiftly cut down." Its instructions are the kind you can act on: "Trust in the Lord and do good… Delight in the Lord, and He will grant you the desires of your heart. Cast your needs upon the Lord… Let go of anger, abandon rage." And it keeps returning to how short the apparent advantage is: "For soon the wicked one will not be; you will gaze at his place and he will be gone… I saw a powerful wicked man, well-rooted like a vibrant, native tree. Yet he vanished, behold he was gone; I searched for him, but he could not be found." The line in it people remember is an old man's testimony: "I have been a youth, I have also aged; yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken, nor his offspring begging bread."

Psalm 38 is illness and shame together. "There is no soundness in my flesh because of Your rage, no peace in my bones because of my sin. For my iniquities have flooded over my head; like a heavy load, they are too heavy for me. My wounds are rotted; they reek because of my foolishness." And the loneliness in it is precise: "My friends and companions stand aloof from my affliction; my intimates stand afar." His answer to the people laying traps is silence: "But I am like a deaf man, I do not hear; like a mute that does not open his mouth… Because for You, O Lord, I wait."

Psalm 39 is about holding the tongue and what holding it costs. "I said that I would guard my ways from sinning with my tongue; I would guard my mouth with a muzzle… I became mute with stillness, I was silent even from the good, though my

pain was crippling. My heart grew hot within me, a fire blazed in my utterance." Then it asks the size of a life: "O Lord, let me know my end and what is the measure of my days… Behold, like handbreadths You set my days; my lifetime is as naught before You." And: "he amasses riches and knows not who will reap them."

Psalm 42's verses are a memory of walking up: "These do I recall, and pour out my soul from within me: how I traveled in covered wagons; I would walk leisurely with them up to the House of G-d, amid the sound of rejoicing and thanksgiving, the celebrating multitude." Then the question asked twice in that psalm: "Why are you downcast, my soul, and why do you wail within me? Hope to G-d, for I will yet thank Him."

Week 13, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 91 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Starling is Singing

The starling opens, and the gathering is riding high places while a soul is downcast.

"He made them ride upon the high places of the earth" / "that they would eat the produce of the field" comes first, with the starling's seed threaded through it: "Their seed shall be known among the nations" / "and their offspring among the peoples" / "He let them suck honey from a rock" / "and oil from the mighty part of the crag" / "all who see them shall acknowledge them."

Then the telling, and the wonders: "those that sit in judgment" / "and those that walk on the path, tell of it" / "too awesome for praises" / "performing wonders!" / "instead of the noise of adversaries" / "between the places of drawing water" / "You inclined Your right hand" / "the earth swallowed them up."

And then the searching and the mistaken accusation together. "The watchmen who patrol the city found me: have you seen him whom my soul loves?" / "only her lips moved, but her voice could not be heard" / "therefore, Eli thought she had been drunk" / "now Hannah, she spoke in her heart" — and immediately the psalm's own question: "why are you downcast, my soul, and why do you wail within me? Hope to G-d."

The coals of fire come next, and the finding, and the pouring out of the soul: "from the brightness before Him flamed forth coals of fire" / "I had just passed them

by, when I found him whom my soul loves" / "these do I recall, and pour out my soul from within me."

The last stretch braids the holding-on with the walking up to the House. "Held him and would not let him go, until I brought him into my mother's house" / "and into the chamber of her who had conceived me" / "I would walk leisurely with them up to the House of G-d" / "amid the sound of rejoicing and thanksgiving, the celebrating multitude."

It ends low and then level: "My G-d! My soul is downcast upon me" / "because I remember You from the land of Jordan" / "and Hermon's peaks, from Mount Mitzar" — and the last line is the love that must not be woken before it wants to be.

Week 13, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XIV

Malchut of Gevurah

Days 92–98

Day 92 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Believe in Our Own Strength, which Comes from G-d

Week fourteen carries on Chanukah and brings in Rosh Chodesh Teveth, and the domestic goose asks for everything at once: "Give thanks to G-d and call upon His name, make His works known amongst the peoples, sing to Him, make music to Him, speak of all His wonders!" (Psalms 105:1-2) Which is last week's mitzvah again — telling the miracle — now sung.

Teveth is a hard month. It holds the fast of the tenth, when Jerusalem was besieged. Its tribe is Dan, whose mark is strength and the power to multiply. Dan had only one child and looked likely to die out, and became one of the largest tribes. Samson came from Dan, and he too is physical strength and that same power.

This week also holds Didan Netzach, "victory is ours," on the fifth of Teveth — the day of the victory of the books, when the Lubavitcher Rebbe's case over the Lubavitch library was won, and a secular court openly recognised what there is between a Rebbe and his chassidim. It sits well beside the Maccabees' victory, and beside a month that is about valuing what is written.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Chanina, deputy high priest: "Pray for the integrity of the government; for were it not for the fear of its authority, a man would swallow his neighbor alive." Taken plainly and taken as a figure, both: without something above them, the strong eat the weak, in body and in money.

It is a striking place for the deputy Kohen Gadol's teaching to fall — the week a people celebrates being freed from a foreign power by a handful of kohanim, and thanks G-d for delivering the strong into the hands of the weak.

The pairing is Malchut shebeGevurah, and it closes another seven. The Maccabees were hard and disciplined, which is gevurah, and when they had won they founded a line of kings, which is malchut. Like them, we are to act inside the material world, with discipline — which is Teveth's own quality.

The goose's lesson: notice the miracles that happen around you daily, and say them out loud. Recalling them and telling them is one of the better ways to be grateful, and gratitude is a source of blessing and of happiness.

Week 14, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 93 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Solomon and Having a Settled Mind

"The cream of cattle and the milk of sheep, with the fat of lambs and rams of Bashan and he goats, with kidneys of wheat, and it would drink the blood of grapes which was as the finest wine." (Deuteronomy 32:14) Cattle, sheep, lambs, rams, goats, fat, wheat, wine — every one of them went into the Temple's offerings, in the week the Temple was dedicated again.

The haftorah: "The Lord thundered from heaven; and the Most High gave forth His voice." (II Samuel 22:14) Thunder is light breaking through darkness, and a miracle is His voice in the open.

The quality is calmness, *yishuv* — which also means to settle, to sit, to dwell. All of which this festival is. The Temple is where He dwells on earth; the war with the Greeks was about being able to serve Him quietly in our own land. And *Chanukah* can be read *chanu k"h*, they rested on the twenty-fifth.

The prophet is King Solomon, the wisest of men — and this festival is about wisdom, Jewish chochmah set against Greek. He built and dedicated the first Temple, and his reign was the prosperity Haazinu's verse describes. He is also calmness itself: *shalom* is the root of his name, and the Tanach shows him settling disputes.

The Levitical city is Elteke, of which little is known beyond its being given to Dan. It is known for a battle in which Sancherib beat the Egyptians, after which he laid siege to Jerusalem. When all looked lost Isaiah told the king not to fear, and the next day Sancherib's army was struck by plague. That happened on Passover, with

Israel and the angels saying Hallel that night — which is what we do on this festival. It is said that G-d wanted to make Chezekiah the Mashiach and did not, because he failed to say Hallel after the miracle.

The name also resembles Tekoa, both holding the uncommon pair *tav* and *kuf*. Tekoa was known for its olive oil — the only oil chosen for the Temple — and at the rededication, pure oil had to be brought from there. It took eight days to produce, which is how long the Kohen Gadol's small flask lasted, and how many days this festival runs. Oil also stands for chochmah, the highest part of the intellect, from which inspired thought comes. The Talmud notes that in Tekoa, where olive oil was common, chochmah was common too. And as the Psalm says, the beginning of chochmah is the fear of G-d.

Week 14, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 94 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Eber and Fighting Off Physical Desires

"With Your loving kindness You led the people You redeemed; You led them with Your might to Your holy abode." Led, and led to a holy place, which is the week. The haftorah asks for it to be said out loud: "there they will tell the righteous acts of the Lord, the righteous acts of restoring open cities in Israel" — telling the miracle again, and restoring, which is what happened to the Temple.

And this is Rosh Chodesh Teveth, whose power is to multiply when things look hopeless.

Sotah's fourteenth daf is the burial of Moshe, who is buried opposite Baal Peor — as a guard against it — and Baal Peor is promiscuity, intermarriage and idolatry, which is what the Maccabees were fighting. The tractate also opens a new chapter and returns to the Sotah ritual, with the kind of offering she brings: barley, which is animal feed. What she is accused of is an animal's behaviour, so the offering is an animal's too.

The generation is Eber, who with his great-grandfather Shem had set up a yeshiva to study His laws even then. The destruction that falls in Teveth is bound up with Torah study not being given its proper weight. Eber seems to be helping Shem against the values of Yafeth and his grandson Yavan — and it was by learning in

Eber's yeshiva that Yaakov prepared himself to face the deceit and the pull of assimilation in Lavan's house.

The journey is to a place with a bad name: "They journeyed from Kivroth haTaavah and camped in Hazeroth." Hazeroth is where Miriam spoke against Moses, and some say where Korach rebelled. Last week was burying the cravings; this week turns to bad speech and to rebellion against one's leaders. Lashon hara is weighed equal to idolatry, immorality and murder — and the Talmud says it was for those three that the first Temple fell.

Week 14, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 95 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Being Faithful

"And Eli said to her: Until when will you be drunk? Throw off your wine from upon yourself." The Kohen Gadol telling her to put the wine down. Which is worth sitting with, because this whole festival began with a Kohen Gadol — Matisiyahu — killing a man who wanted to bring a pagan offering in the Temple. Chanukah means dedication, and it is the Temple dedicated again once the idolatry was cleared out. Serving while drunk is also what killed Aaron's sons at the first dedication of the Tabernacle, which was finished on the twenty-fifth of Kislev.

But notice that Eli says *your* wine. What is wine? Rabbi Meir held that the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge was the grape, and so do the Zohar and a Midrash. The Tree of Knowledge stands for secular wisdom, as the Tree of Life stands for Torah. Rabbi Riskin points out that the Menorah is shaped like a tree, and may be the two trees perfectly combined — and that the kohanim's job is to clean and purify its lights.

So this festival is the fight between a culture tied to the Torah and one tied to secular wisdom alone — but the Torah is not against secular wisdom. It has its place, so long as it dwells in the tents of Shem. Adam's sin was not tasting the Tree of Knowledge; it was tasting it before the Tree of Life. Had he given himself to the Tree of Life first, the other would have become permitted in time.

Which may be why Eli says *your* wine. His job is to keep improper influences out of the Temple, including a person too drunk to judge how much of that tree to take in. Noah had the same trouble — the Zohar says he planted a vineyard to repair

Adam's sin, and erred, and got drunk. But Eli does not rule the thing out altogether. There is a place for it, and it may still belong to Channah the tzadeket, in the right dose. That is this festival's message too.

The week's quality is that the Torah makes him *ne'eman*, faithful — from *emunah*. Emunah is what separated the Jews from the Greeks, and emunah is above reason, so a person acting out of it can look irrational to others, or even drunk, exactly as in this story. Part of having it is not being thrown by how it looks from outside.

Proverbs' fourteenth chapter runs on the same contrasts: "The wisest of women — each one built her house, but a foolish one tears it down with her hands… A faithful witness does not lie, but he who speaks lies is a false witness."

The yahrzeits are Ishbitz and Peshischa. On the fourth of Teveth, Rabbi Gershon Chanoch Henoch Leiner of Radzin, the Baal HaTecheles, grandson of the founder; and often this week the founder himself, Rav Mordecai Yosef Leiner of Ishbitz, the Mei Shiloach — a childhood friend and colleague of the Kotzker Rebbe, both of them students of Reb Simcha Bunim of Peshischa. He followed Kotzk and taught there, and in the end the two parted and Ishbitz was founded. His own students included Rav Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin.

Week 14, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 96 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Sticking with the Torah and the Temple

"Who is this coming up from the desert, like columns of smoke, perfumed with myrrh and frankincense, of all the powder of the peddler? Behold the litter of Solomon; sixty mighty men are around it, of the mighty men of Israel. They all hold the sword, skilled in warfare; each one with his sword on his thigh because of fear at night."

Coming up out of the desert under the Clouds of Glory — and this festival is eight days in order to answer Sukkot, which is that protection remembered. Rashi takes the verses to the Mishkan, the Temple that moved, and to "the war of Torah, and similarly, the priests who surround it, who camp around the Mishkan, skilled in the order of their service."

And then he says what the swords are. “Each one with his sword: his weapons. These are the Masorah and the mnemonics, by which they preserve the correct version of the Oral Law and the masorah, lest it be forgotten. Because of fear at night: lest they forget it, and troubles will befall them.” The night is Greece’s darkness. The weapons are the devices for keeping the text and the reading exact — which is both the fight against a perverted law and the respect for Torah whose absence, as this month remembers, brought the first Temple down.

Of the seventy souls the fourteenth is Gershon — the name of one of Levi’s sons and of one of Moshe’s. It is a name about being a stranger, and about holding on to who you are among foreign influences. Moshe’s Gershon was brought up by Yitro as well as by Moshe, and Yitro’s influence told in the long run. Gershon’s family also had charge of keeping up the Mishkan.

Shevuot’s fourteenth daf carries on with the kohanim’s atonement, taken separately, and opens a chapter on awareness of impurity and what happens when a person forgets its laws. Impurity against purity is this festival; and ignorance of the law is Teveth’s tenth day.

Jeremiah’s fourteenth chapter is a drought from beginning to end — and there is no reference to water in Scripture that is not the Torah. Its close comes back to this month exactly: “Do not condemn us for Your name’s sake, do not disgrace the throne of Your glory. Remember, do not break Your covenant with us.” The throne of His glory, Rashi says, is the Temple.

Week 14, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 97 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the First Week of Teveth - Psalms 40-42; 42:8-10; 89:15

The first week of Teveth in psalms: the fortieth, forty-first and forty-second, with three verses of the Tikkun HaKlali and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 40 opens with being pulled out. “I put my hope in the Lord; He turned to me and heard my cry. He raised me from the turbulent pit, from the slimy mud, and set my feet upon a rock, steadying my steps. He put a new song in my mouth.” Then it says what is actually wanted: “You desired neither sacrifice nor meal-offering, but obedient ears You opened for me… I desire to fulfill Your will, my G-d; and Your

Torah is in my innards." And it will not keep quiet about it: "I did not conceal Your righteousness within my heart… I did not hide Your kindness and truth from the vast congregation." Then the weight comes back: "my sins have overtaken me and I cannot see; they outnumber the hairs of my head." It ends plainly: "As for me, I am poor and needy… my G-d, do not delay!"

Psalm 41 is the whole psalm of the man thoughtful of the poor, having been given to us a few verses at a time. "Fortunate is he who is thoughtful of the poor, for the Lord will save him on the day of evil… The Lord will support him on the bed of illness." Then the sickroom visitors: "if one comes to see me, he speaks insincerely, for his heart gathers iniquity for himself, and when he goes out he speaks of it." And the betrayal: "Even my ally in whom I trusted, who ate of my bread, has raised his heel over me."

Psalm 42 is the thirst, whole. "As the deer cries longingly for brooks of water, so my soul cries longingly for You, O G-d! My soul thirsts for G-d, for the living G-d. When will I come and behold the countenance of G-d? My tears have been my bread day and night, when they say to me all day, 'Where is your G-d?'" It remembers walking up to the House in a crowd, and asks itself twice why it is downcast. And it holds the line that is this month's measure of depth: "Deep calls to deep at the roar of Your channels; all Your breakers and waves have swept over me." Then: "By day the Lord ordains His kindness, and at night His song is with me, a prayer to the G-d of my life."

Psalm 89's verse names what the throne stands on: "Righteousness and justice are the foundation of Your throne; kindness and truth go before Your countenance."

Week 14, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 98 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Domestic Goose is Saying

The domestic goose opens, and this gathering runs the day's kindness against the night's song.

"Give thanks to G-d and call upon His name" / "make His works known amongst the peoples" / "by day the Lord ordains His kindness" / "and at night His song is with me." Then the music, and the prayer: "sing to Him, make music to Him, speak of all

His wonders!" / "a prayer to the G-d of my life."

Then the throne, and the depths: "Righteousness and justice are the foundation of Your throne" / "kindness and truth go before Your countenance" / "deep calls to deep at the roar of Your channels" / "all Your breakers and waves have swept over me."

Solomon's litter comes next with its guard: "Behold the litter of Solomon; sixty mighty men are around it, of the mighty men of Israel" / "they all hold the sword, skilled in warfare" / "each with a sword on his thigh due to fear at night." And then the thunder: "The Lord thundered from heaven; and the Most High gave forth His voice."

The lowest line in the gathering falls here, between the thunder and the wine: "I say to G-d, my rock, 'Why have You forgotten me? Why must I walk in gloom under the oppression of the enemy?'" / "and it would drink the blood of grapes as the finest wine" / "and Eli said to her: Until when will you be drunk? Throw off your wine from upon yourself."

It ends in the desert and the spices, and then in the plenty: "of all the powder of the peddler" / "who is this coming up from the desert" / "like columns of smoke, perfumed with myrrh and frankincense" / "the cream of cattle and the milk of sheep" / "with the fat of lambs and rams of Bashan and he goats, with kidneys of wheat."

Week 14, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XV

Chesed of Tiferet

Days 99–105

Day 99 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

Giving Proper Value to Torah and to the Presence of the Shechinah

Week fifteen, and the wild goose has two songs. Seeing Israel busy with Torah: "A voice cries out: Prepare in the wilderness the way for G-d, make straight in the desert a path for our G-d." (Isaiah 40:3) And on finding its food out there: "Cursed is the man who trusts in human beings; Blessed is the man who trusts in G-d, and G-d shall be his assurance." (Jeremiah 17: 5, 7)

This is the week of the fast of the tenth of Teveth, when Jerusalem was besieged in the days of the first Temple — the first step toward its destruction and the exile of the Shechinah. It is also the yahrzeit of Rabbi Nathan of Breslov, Rebbe Nachman's chief disciple.

Few survived that destruction, and they multiplied back into a numerous people — like Dan, whose month this is. Much the same happened to Rabbi Nathan: he took up a movement that was tiny, against terrible opposition, and it not only survived but grew beyond measure.

The Midrash says Jerusalem was besieged and the Temple later destroyed because the people did not recite the blessing over Torah study. That is, because of what they did not think the Torah and the holy writings were worth. Which sits beside Didan Netzach, the victory of the books, from last week.

And there is the other half of the goose's song. They also put their trust in the wrong place — in an alliance with Egypt, against which the prophets had warned. In a prophecy made on the twelfth of Teveth, before the siege, Ezekiel calls Egypt "a reed-like support for the House of Israel — whenever they held you in their hand you would snap, piercing their every shoulder." When Egypt fell to Babylon, Israel

followed.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Chanina son of Tradyon: two who sit together and let no word of Torah pass between them are a session of scorners; two who sit and exchange words of Torah have the Divine Presence resting between them. And even one who sits alone and occupies himself with it has a reward set aside for him: "He sits alone in meditative stillness; indeed, he receives reward for it."

The pairing is Chesed shebeTiferet. When the siege began it was not yet hopeless — there was still room to turn back and stop the whole thing. Kindness inside mercy, which is tiferet's other name.

What the goose knows is that Torah study matters and that its food comes from Him and not from any person. If we do our part, He will do His.

Week 15, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 100 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

The Prophet Iddo and the Importance of Scripture

"And Jeshurun became fat and rebelled; you grew fat, thick and rotund; Israel forsook the G-d Who made them, and spurned the Mighty Rock of their salvation." (Deuteronomy 32:15) Rebellion after everything — which is what the tenth of Teveth is about, a people grown fat and not valuing what they had.

But the word for fat, *shemen*, used twice here, is also the word for oil. And oil belongs to the lights of Chanukah, which take in Rosh Chodesh Teveth and so shine through this whole month. So the verse can be read the other way: Jeshurun became full of oil and kicked away the enemy; grew full of oil, thick and rotund in holiness; spread out the knowledge of the G-d Who made them, and made song with the lyre about the Rock of their salvation. Spreading the word is this season's own mitzvah.

The haftorah suits the second reading better: "And He sent out arrows and He scattered them, lightning and He discomfited them." (II Samuel 22:15) Scattering, and light.

The quality is *Mikrah*, scripture — and the first Temple fell over the blessing not said on Torah study, over scripture not being held holy enough.

The prophet is Iddo, and the only thing Tanach says of him is that he wrote: he set down the events of Rehoboam, and the genealogy of the kings of Israel, with

Shemaiah the Prophet. He took writing and records seriously. And the Talmud says Iddo is the prophet who went against his own word and was mauled by a lion — which runs painfully close to a people that did not heed the words of the prophets and of scripture.

The Levitical city is Gibbethon, another name attached to disaster: the Talmud says Rabbi Akiva's twenty-four thousand students who died were "from Gibbethon to Antipatris." And then, in the manner of this month and of Dan — out of five more students, Rabbi Akiva rebuilt everything.

Week 15, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 101 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Peleg and Evil Speech

"People heard, they trembled; a shudder seized the inhabitants of Philistia." Years later it would be this people trembling, when Babylon came and laid its siege.

The haftorah: "Then the people of the Lord went down to the cities. Praise! Praise! Deborah." The word for cities, *shearim*, also means gates — and on the tenth of Teveth Nebuchadnezar came down on the city and closed round its gates. As for "Praise, praise Devorah," Rashi explains that it is said because the spirit of G-d had left her, since she had praised herself. Which belongs to this week too: the Temple lost its spirit because the people did not bless the Torah they studied. All Torah and all prophecy come from Him, and there is no room to praise yourself for it.

Sotah's fifteenth daf sets the Sotah's offering beside the metzora's, and notes that the metzora's purification is the more severe. The metzora's sin is *lashon hara* — which is weighed against all three of the great sins, and is another reason given for the Temple's fall. And he is sent out of the camp, and can only come back once he is clean, which is the exile that followed.

The generation is Peleg, named so because in his days the tower was built and the world's people were split and scattered into different lands. That is the same exile, and the same sentence as the metzora's, who was sent out for having split people apart with his mouth. The Babylonians made a point of taking most of the people out of the land and settling others in parts of it, and the division between Israel and the Babylonian diaspora held for centuries.

The journey is to a place named for a mouth: "They journeyed from Hazeroth and camped in Rithmah." Rithmah is also Kadesh Barnea, where the spies slandered the Land — the lesson of Miriam not having been learned — and what came of that, and of the people accepting it, was Tisha B'Av. Rashi derives the name from the slander: "What can He give you, and what can He add to you, you deceitful tongue? Sharpened arrows of a mighty man, with coals of brooms."

Slandering the Land was in the end slandering Him: they did not believe He could bring them into it. Last week was bad speech about people and rebellion against leaders; this week is bad speech about G-d and about the Land. And the Talmud teaches that whoever does not show gratitude to another person will end up not showing it to Hashem either.

Week 15, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 102 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Handling Reproof

"And Hannah answered and said: 'No, my lord, I am a woman of a sorrowful spirit; I have drunk neither wine nor strong drink, but I poured out my soul before the Lord.'"

That is the fast, in a sentence. Sorrow said out loud, nothing drunk, and the soul poured out instead.

The week's quality is that the Torah distances him from sin — which does not only mean that he does not sin. It also means that a person wrongly suspected of sinning is required to speak up. The Talmud learns that principle from this very verse.

Proverbs' fifteenth chapter is about how reproof is given and how it is taken. "A gentle reply turns away wrath, but a distressing word stirs up anger… A fool despises the discipline of his father, but he who keeps reproof will become cunning… A scorner does not like being reproved; he does not go to the wise… The ear that listens to reproof of life shall lodge among the wise. He who rejects discipline despises his life, but he who hearkens to reproof acquires sense. The fear of the Lord is the discipline of wisdom, and before honor there is humility." A fast day is largely about knowing how to take reproof and turn.

The tenth of Teveth is the yahrzeit of Rebbe Nosson of Breslev, Rebbe Nachman's main disciple, who published his works and carried the thing forward. Rebbe Nachman called him his Yehoshua, and Breslev chassidim say plainly that without Rebbe Nosson we would be lost. His life was faith and determination against very hard opposition: in trying to hold on to Rebbe Nachman he was opposed not only by other Chassidic leaders but by his parents, his in-laws, and his wife. He stayed with it, knew how to take opposition and reproof that was not deserved, and went on pouring out his soul.

The twelfth of Teveth is the yahrzeit of Rebbe Moshe of Peshevorsk, from whom that dynasty comes. This week belongs to the written Torah, and he was known for the Torah scrolls, tefillin and mezuzot that he wrote — a man of great purity, and the author of Ohr Penei Moshe.

Week 15, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 103 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Jerusalem and Motherhood

"King Solomon made himself a palanquin of the trees of Lebanon. Its pillars he made of silver, its couch of gold, its curtain of purple, its interior inlaid with love, from the daughters of Jerusalem. Go out, O daughters of Zion, and gaze upon King Solomon, upon the crown with which his mother crowned him on the day of his nuptials and on the day of the joy of his heart."

Solomon in this book is always Him, and here the Jewish people are His mother. Rashi cites a Midrash: calling them His mother is the highest thing He says about His love for them.

And that image stands against what this week remembers. Jeremiah, on the siege: "Better off were the victims of the sword than the victims of hunger… The hands of compassionate women boiled their own children; they have become their food in the destruction of the daughter of my people."

In time to come, the tenth of Teveth will be a day of joy. These verses look like that time — full of the Temple and the Tabernacle and Jerusalem, with the day of his nuptials being the giving of the Torah and the day of the joy of his heart the Tabernacle's dedication.

Of the seventy souls the fifteenth is Kehath, who is Moshe and Aharon's grandfather and also their uncle, their mother Yocheved's brother. The Rebbe explains that Kehath comes from a word meaning to gather. His charge in the Tabernacle was the highest of all the Levites': carrying the Holy Ark and its vessels. And it was Kehath's camp that Korach belonged to, which ended in enormous destruction. The destruction belongs to this week and the highest task to the time when the Temple stands again and this day is a feast.

Shevuot's fifteenth daf is the sanctifying of the Temple's vessels, and the ritual of adding on to Jerusalem or to the Azarah — which is done with singing and with loaves of bread carried. Set that against the tenth of Teveth, when Jerusalem was not added to but closed in; when instead of singing there was mourning, and instead of bread, famine.

Jeremiah's fifteenth chapter takes the same two subjects, motherhood and Jerusalem, from the dark side: "She who bore seven has been cut off, her soul grieves, her sun sets when it is still day." And: "Woe is to me, my mother, that you bore me, a man of quarrel and a man of contention to the whole land."

Week 15, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 104 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second Week of Teveth - Psalms 43-45; 42:11-12, 59:1-2; 89:16

The second week of Teveth in psalms: the forty-third, forty-fourth and forty-fifth, with the end of Psalm 42, the opening of Psalm 59, and a verse of Psalm 89.

Psalm 43 is short and asks for an escort. "Avenge me, O G-d, and champion my cause against an impious nation… For You are the G-d of my strength; why have You abandoned me?" Then the request that gives the psalm its shape: "Send Your light and Your truth, they will guide me; they will bring me to Your holy mountain and to your sanctuaries. Then I will come to the altar of G-d." And the question again, and the same answer: "Why are you downcast, my soul… Hope to G-d, for I will yet thank Him."

Psalm 44 is the hardest psalm in this stretch. It opens on what the fathers told: "You drove out nations with Your hand… For not by their sword did they inherit the land, and their own arm did not save them, but by Your right hand." Then it turns,

and the turn is brutal: “Though You abandon and disgrace us… You deliver us like sheep to be devoured, and scatter us among the nations; You sell Your nation without gain, and do not set a high price upon them.” And then, in the middle of that, the thing it refuses to give up: “all this has come upon us, yet we have not forgotten You, nor have we been false to Your covenant… Even when You crushed us in the place of serpents, and shrouded us in the shadow of death — did we forget the Name of our G-d, and extend our hands to a foreign G-d? Is it not so that G-d can examine this, for He knows the secrets of the heart.” Then: “For it is for Your sake that we are killed all the time; we are regarded as sheep for the slaughter.” And it ends shouting: “Arise! Why do You sleep, my Lord? Wake up!”

Psalm 45 is a wedding song, and it knows it: “My heart is astir with a noble theme; I say, 'My composition is for the king; my tongue is the pen of a skillful scribe.'” Then: “Gird your sword upon your thigh, O mighty one — it is your majesty and splendor.”

Psalm 42's last verses carry the reproach — “my oppressors have reproached me by saying to me all day long, 'Where is your G-d?'” — and Psalm 59 opens with Saul’s men around the house: “Save me from my enemies, my G-d; strengthen me against those who rise up against me.” Psalm 89's verse is the shofar: “Fortunate is the people that know the blasting of the shofar.”

Week 15, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 105 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Wild Goose Is Saying

The wild goose opens — seeing Israel busy with Torah — and the gathering sets the way through the wilderness against a palanquin.

“A voice cries out: Prepare in the wilderness the way for G-d” is framed by the shofar and the light: “Fortunate is the people that know the blasting of the shofar” / “O Lord, may they walk in the light of Your countenance.” Then the straight path, and the daughters of Zion called out to look: “Make straight in the desert a path for our G-d” / “Go out, O daughters of Zion, and gaze upon King Solomon.”

The people going down to the cities comes next, with the palanquin built around it: “Then the people of the Lord went down to the cities” / “King Solomon made himself a palanquin of the trees of Lebanon” / “Praise! Praise! Deborah” / “its pillars

he made of silver, its couch of gold, its curtain of purple."

Then the interior inlaid with love, the trembling, and the crown: "its interior inlaid with love, from the daughters of Jerusalem" / "People heard, they trembled" / "upon the crown with which his mother crowned him."

The goose's second song arrives here, braided with Haazinu's growing fat — the two readings of *shemen* side by side: "And upon finding its food in the wilderness, it says" / "And Jeshurun became fat and rebelled" / "Cursed is the man who trusts in human beings" / "you grew fat, thick and rotund" / "Blessed is the man who trusts in G-d" / "Israel forsook the G-d Who made them" / "and He sent out arrows and He scattered them."

The last stretch is Hannah answering, with Saul's men at the door: "And Hannah answered and said: 'No, my lord'" / "I am a woman of a sorrowful spirit" / "with murder in my bones, my oppressors have reproached me" / "I have drunk neither wine nor strong drink" / "but I poured out my soul before Hashem."

It ends: "Save me from my enemies, my G-d" / "a shudder seized the inhabitants of Philistia" / "strengthen me against those who rise up against me" / "and G-d shall be his assurance."

Week 15, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XVI

Gevurah of Tiferet

Days 106–112

Day 106 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Use Adversity as a Way to Grow, Relying on G-d for Support

Week sixteen, and the ducks — plural, which matters — say: "Trust in G-d forever and ever, for G-d, the Eternal, is the strength of worlds." (Isaiah 26:4)

The Talmud calls Teveth the coldest month of the year, "when the body takes pleasure in the body." And Perek Shirah has ducks here rather than a duck. They breed fast and keep large families; they travel in groups and depend on each other to get through the cold.

Which is this month's own story. After the first Temple fell, very few were left — the Book of Jeremiah counts four thousand six hundred exiled to Babylon altogether. And in a fairly short time that community in Babylon became numerous, influential and rich.

The song is about His strength and also about His giving us the power to bring life. *Tzur* means strength and also Creator, or Craftsman; *Yotzer*, from the same root, is used of the One who "fashioned you from the womb." And the verse mixes the Names: the feminine one of *yud* and *hey*, the masculine *Tzur*, and between them the Name that holds both.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai: three who eat at one table and speak no words of Torah have eaten of idolatrous sacrifices — "all tables are filled with vomit and filth, devoid of the Omnipresent." But three who eat at one table and do speak words of Torah have eaten at G-d's own table: "This is the table that is before G-d."

That belongs here because the Temple fell over how little Torah study was thought to be worth. And Rabbi Shimon, who knew the hidden part of the Torah

better than anyone, is teaching how to serve Him with the body — which is the deeper reading of the body taking pleasure in the body. The Lubavitcher Rebbe explains that serving Him with the body, not only with mind and soul, reaches further: to His essence. An ordinary meal becomes the table of G-d. The same is true of marriage, which can be the holiest thing a person does or the most profane, depending entirely on the two people and what they intend.

The pairing is Gevurah shebeTiferet: recovering from the loss, and using discipline to get back to the balanced beauty of the Torah.

The ducks' own lesson is to lean on Him completely, the way you would lean on a rock.

Week 16, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 107 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Michaiah and the Oral Torah

"They provoked His zeal with alien worship; they made Him angry with abominable deeds." (Deuteronomy 32:16) Idolatry, which is what brought the first Temple down — and which is tied to Dan in particular, the tribe that first brought idol worship into the Land after the conquest, in the account of Pessel Micha near the end of Judges.

The verse can also be turned around. The zeal and the anger need not be His: they can be the people's, zealous and angry *for* Him. Zeal against idolatry was the Maccabees' defining mark, and kohanim as a class are known for zeal — and sometimes for being hot-headed with it.

The haftorah reads better the second way: "And the depths of the sea appeared; the foundations of the world were laid bare, by the rebuke of the Lord and the blast of the breath of His nostrils." (II Samuel 22:16) Rashi takes it to the splitting of the sea. The depths of the sea may be the Talmud; and the foundations of the world may be the Temple, which holds the Even Shtiah, the stone creation began from.

The quality is Mishnah, the Oral Torah — in a week still shaped by the tenth of Teveth, which came of Torah study not being held holy enough.

The prophet is Michaiah son of Imlah, and the Oral Torah is exactly his problem. It has to be handed on faithfully, and interpreted honestly. Sometimes men claim to

speak for the tradition and are corrupting it. In his story four hundred prophets gave the king the answer he wanted, and one prophet saw what was actually there. Even false prophets can be moved by a spirit; the spirit can be false. He prophesied in the days of Ahab, a wicked king who nevertheless studied Torah — which is the same corruption of what study is for.

The Levitical city is Ayalon, where Joshua told the moon to stand still, and where he beat five Amorite kings. The Talmud reads the sun and moon as Moshe and Joshua and the passing on of the oral tradition: as Joshua took it from Moshe, the moon takes its light from the sun, having none of its own. Teveth is the only month with a festival at the new moon. And a moon that nearly disappears and then comes back to full is this month and this tribe exactly — as is Ayalon's own history, pushed out of Dan's hands by the Amorites, later the scene of Saul and Jonathan's victory, later held by Benjamin and Efraim, and in the end a border town that Rehoboam fortified.

Week 16, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 108 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Overcoming Setbacks

"Then the chieftains of Edom were startled; as for the powerful men of Moab, trembling seized them." Startled, and trembling — and at the siege it was this people's turn to shudder.

The haftorah repeats the matter of the spirit leaving Devorah for praising herself: "Praise! Praise! Utter a song. Arise Barak, and capture your captives, son of Abinoam." And the captives taken may also be Jerusalem's own, carried off once the city fell.

Sotah's sixteenth daf is still the Sotah's offering, now the soil put into the water she drinks, with a good deal about the metzora alongside — which keeps to this month's subjects: exile, and not enough to eat or drink.

The generation is Reu, Peleg's son, born just after the world's people had been split up and scattered. And where his father's name means separation, Reu's is related to the words for shepherd and for friend. So the name looks like the ability to gather again and do well after a scattering — after that tower, and after Babylon.

The journey is to a bursting fruit: "They journeyed from Rithmah and camped in Rimmon Perez." Rimmon Perez means a pomegranate bursting open, and a pomegranate full of seeds stands for being fruitful and for keeping mitzvot. Last week was slander and the exile that comes with it. This week is regrouping, and getting back to being productive.

Week 16, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 109 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Bringing Oneself Close to Merit

"Count not thy handmaid for a wicked woman: for out of the abundance of my complaint and my vexation have I spoken hitherto." She asks Eli to judge her favourably rather than as a wicked woman. The word she uses, *Bli'al*, is also bound up with idolatry — and the sages learn from here that a person who prays the Amidah drunk is likened to one who worships idols. And she names her vexation, which is this month's own feeling.

The week's quality is that the Torah brings a person close to merit. Her speech is the illustration.

Proverbs' sixteenth chapter is about the same thing — a man's part and His part. "The preparations of the heart are man's, but the answer of the tongue is from the Lord. All ways of man are pure in his eyes, but the Lord counts the spirits… With loving-kindness and truth will iniquity be expiated… When the Lord accepts a person's ways, He will cause even his enemies to make peace with him. Better a little with righteousness than great revenues with injustice. A man's heart plans his way, but the Lord prepares his step."

Three yahrzeits this week, all of them tied to the Seer of Lublin. The sixteenth of Teveth is Rabbi Aryeh Leibish of Vishnitza, called Rebbe Leibish Charif, the sharp one, a very close disciple of the Seer. The seventeenth is Rabbi Fischel Shapira of Strickov, who was a disciple in turn of the Maggid of Mezritch, then of Rebbe Elimelech, then of the Seer — known for such humility that he was called *Olah Temimah*, the unblemished offering.

And the eighteenth is Rabbi Tzvi Elimelech Shapira of Dinov, author of the Bnei Yissachar, which is the basis for a great many of the insights in this work. He was

Rebbe Elimelech's nephew, and a disciple of the Seer of Lublin and of Menachem Mendel of Rimanov.

Week 16, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 110 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Being Wife and Midwife

"Behold, you are fair, my beloved; behold, you are fair; your eyes are like doves, from within your kerchief; your hair is like a flock of goats that streamed down from Mount Gilead. Your teeth are like a flock of uniformly shaped ewes that came up from the washing, all of whom are perfect, and there is no bereavement among them. Your lips are like a scarlet thread, and your speech is comely; your temple is like a split pomegranate from within your kerchief."

This week's verses and next week's — the first six of the fourth chapter — are the ones that use the body most openly as a figure for what this people is. Which belongs to the month in which the body takes pleasure in the body, meaning the essence of this people meeting His essence.

Of the seventy souls the sixteenth is Merari, whose family had the least prestigious and the heaviest job in the Tabernacle: carrying the beams, the crossbars, the pillars and the bases. *Merari* comes from *mar*, bitter — the same root as Miriam. The Rebbe's father explains that of Yocheved's three children, Miriam answers to Merari. These were the foundations the rest of it stood on, which is the quiet and necessary thing Miriam did as a midwife. Teveth is cold and in some ways bitter, and it is also strength, foundation, and the power to multiply.

Shevuot's sixteenth daf asks whether the holiness of the first Temple was temporary or permanent, and takes up the case of someone who becomes impure inside it, and the laws of bowing there. The fast of the tenth belongs to that Temple in particular.

Jeremiah's sixteenth chapter turns the month's other subject dark: "You shall take no wife, and you shall have no sons or daughters in this place." And: "Behold, I will cut off from this place in your presence and in your days a voice of mirth and a voice of gladness, a voice of a bridegroom, and a voice of a bride."

Week 16, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 111 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Teveth - Psalms 46-48; 59:3-5; 89:17

The third week of Teveth in psalms: the forty-sixth, forty-seventh and forty-eighth, with three verses of Psalm 59 and one of Psalm 89. All three are headed as being about the Messianic era, when weapons are put down.

Psalm 46 is steadiness while everything else moves. "G-d is our refuge and strength, a help in distress, He is most accessible. Therefore, we will not be afraid when the earth is transformed, when mountains collapse in the heart of the seas." Then the city: "The river — its streams will bring joy to the city of G-d, the sacred dwelling of the Most High. G-d is in her midst, she will not falter." And the end of war, stated as an act: "To the end of the earth He causes wars to cease; He breaks the bow, snaps the spear, and burns the wagons in fire." Then the one-word command: "Stop waging war! And know that I am G-d." It closes on the refrain it used before: "The Lord of Hosts is with us; the G-d of Jacob is our stronghold forever."

Psalm 47 is the shofar psalm said before the blowing. "All you nations, clap hands; sound to G-d with a sound of jubilation… He chooses our heritage for us, the glory of Jacob whom He loves eternally. G-d ascends through teruah, the Lord — through the sound of the shofar." And at the end the nations are not beaten but gathered: "The most noble of the nations are gathered, the nation of the G-d of Abraham."

Psalm 48 walks around a city. "The Lord is great and exceedingly acclaimed in the city of G-d, His holy mountain. Beautiful in landscape, the joy of the whole earth is Mount Zion." Kings came against her, "they saw and were astounded; they were terror-stricken, they hastened to flee. Trembling seized them there, pangs as of a woman in the throes of labor." And then the line this week's other books keep reaching for: "As we have heard, so have we seen." It ends with an instruction: "Walk around Zion, encircle her, count her towers. Consider well her ramparts, behold her lofty citadels, that you may recount it to a later generation."

Psalm 59's verses are the ambush: "For behold they lie in ambush for my soul, mighty ones gather against me — not because of my sin nor my transgression, O Lord."

Week 16, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 112 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Ducks are Saying

The ducks open, and this gathering braids a description of beauty with an ambush.

"Trust in G-d forever and ever" arrives already surrounded by the washing and the perfect flock — "that came up from the washing" / "all of whom are perfect" — and then the rejoicing: "they rejoice in Your Name all day" / "for G-d, the Eternal, is the strength of worlds."

The teeth and the temple follow, with the righteousness between them: "Your teeth are like a flock of uniformly shaped ewes" / "and they are exalted through Your righteousness" / "your temple is like a split pomegranate from within your kerchief."

Then the zeal and the rebuke, and the protest of innocence laid right across them: "They provoked His zeal with alien worship" / "by the rebuke of the Lord and the blast of the breath of His nostrils" / "without iniquity on my part, they run and prepare" / "awaken towards me and see!" / "they made Him angry with abominable deeds" / "rescue me from evildoers, save me from men of bloodshed."

Channah's own protest comes in here, broken across the psalm's: "and my vexation have I spoken hitherto" / "not because of my sin nor my transgression, O Lord" / "count not thy handmaid for a wicked woman" / "for behold they lie in ambush for my soul" / "for out of the abundance of my complaint" / "mighty ones gather against me."

Then the chieftains of Edom are startled, with the scarlet thread beside them, and Moab's trembling, and the hair like a flock of goats, and the praise: "Praise! Praise! Utter a song."

It ends where it is fairest: "Behold, you are fair, my beloved; behold, you are fair" / "your eyes are like doves, from within your kerchief" / "Arise Barak, and capture your captives, son of Abinoam" / "and the depths of the sea appeared" / "that streamed down from Mount Gilead" / "the foundations of the world were laid bare" / "and there is no bereavement among them."

Week 16, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XVII

Tiferet of Tiferet

Days 113–119

Day 113 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Pay Attention to G-d's Guidance and to Trust in Our Redemption

Week seventeen, the last of Teveth, and the bee-eater says: "I will whistle to them and gather them, for I have redeemed them, and they shall increase as they have before increased." (Zechariah 10:8) The increase is Dan again. The whistle is a shepherd's.

This week holds the yahrzeit of the Alter Rebbe, on the twenty-fourth of Teveth. He died largely of the flight from Napoleon. He had backed Russia in that war, because he judged that Napoleon's egalitarian promises would end in assimilation — and that spiritual persecution of that kind was more dangerous than the physical oppression of the Russian government, much as the Greeks had been more dangerous than other empires.

On the flight, the Alter Rebbe rode in the third carriage and his grandson Rabbi Nachum in the first, and at every crossroads they asked him which way. At one of them Rabbi Nachum misheard. When the mistake came to light, much later, "the Alter Rebbe sighed deeply and said: 'How good is it when a grandson follows in the path of his grandfather — and the opposite is true when a grandfather has to follow the path in which his grandson leads him.' … The mistake at the crossroads caused all kinds of troublesome detours, and soon after Alter Rebbe passed away in Piena."

The whistle, then, is the ways He uses to turn a lost Jew back. He is the shepherd and we are the flock. The Zohar calls Moses *Rayah Mehemnah*, a faithful shepherd and a shepherd of faith, and the leader of each generation is that generation's Moses. The point of following such advice is not to lose your way in the dark, which is exactly what happened in that story.

Seventeen is the numerical value of *tov*, good — and it is also the number of the seventeenth of Tammuz, which began the Temple's end. The Talmud ties the two kinds of loss together: the passing of tzadikim is likened to the burning of the Temple. The Lubavitcher Rebbe answers the difficulty the same way for both: this is a descent for the sake of an ascent, and the ascent is great enough to make the exile worth it, there being no other way to reach that rung. The passing of a tzadik opens a level nothing else reaches, and that is the only reason for it. So seventeen really is good, with the extent of the good hidden for now. It is also the value of *cheit*, sin, which is the one thing holding the redemption back — because of our sins we were exiled from our land.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Chanina the son of Chachina'i: "One who stays awake at night, or travels alone on the road, and turns his heart to idleness, has forfeited his life." The night is exile. In it you cannot be alone and occupied with nothing; you have to be gathered, listening for the whistle, and studying — or you lose the road.

Rebbe Nachman reads the same words the other way round. Travelling alone is making your own path in prayer and hitbodedut; *batalah*, idleness, he hears as *bitul*, self-nullification; and "forfeits his life," *mitchayev et nafsho*, he reads as making his soul such that the whole world is obliged to exist for it. Which is the condition of a generation's tzadik.

The pairing is Tiferet shebeTiferet. And the bee-eater's Hebrew name, *Rachamah*, has *rachamim* in it — mercy, which is tiferet's other name. Its lesson is to be sure He is with you and guiding you through the bad part, and also to be listening, so that when the call comes you do not miss it.

Week 17, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 114 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Obadiah and Minimized Business Activity

"They sacrificed to demons, which have no power, deities they did not know, new things that only recently came, which your forefathers did not fear." (Deuteronomy 32:17) Idolatry again, which is Teveth and is Dan.

And again the verse can be turned: would they sacrifice to demons? No. Their power was G-d; they did not know new ones. Which is worth stopping on, because

the verse names what makes assimilation attractive. It is *new* — then as now, the Torah gets painted as out of date. And it comes "from close by." What pulls hardest in another culture is the part that most resembles our own. The Greeks and the Hellenized Jews came from close; what they championed, wisdom and humanism, was often very near Jewish ideals.

The haftorah goes with the positive reading: "He sent from on high and He took me; He drew me out of many waters." (II Samuel 22:17) And many waters, as Book 1 has it, is the struggle of making a living.

Which is the quality: *miut schorah*, minimised business activity. Money and the getting of it turn idolatrous very easily — it becomes the end, and we forget we wanted it in order to serve Him better and provide for a family. So business is to be conducted with *miut*, smallness and humility, with study and service still the main thing.

The prophet is Obadiah, who prophesied like Michaia in Ahab's days, when idolatry was everywhere. Ahab is the opposite of this quality: he took another man's field by force and had the owner killed, and for that he was sentenced from Heaven. Obadiah is the quality itself — he used his own money to keep a hundred prophets alive and hidden from Ahab and Jezebel, and that act earned him prophecy. His name says it: servant of G-d. He understood whose work he was actually doing.

His prophecy is that G-d loves Jacob and hates Esau, which is the message in a fight against assimilation. Much of what drew Jews to Roman culture and its offshoots was how like Judaism they looked. Esau is Jacob's brother, after all. And Jacob, meeting him, says: "My master knows that the children are tender, and the flocks and the cattle, which are raising their young, depend upon me, and if they overdrive them one day, all the flocks will die. Now, let my master go ahead before his servant, and I will move at my own slow pace." He did not want Esau near his family — and, reading the flocks as well as the children, he did not want his possessions exposed to Esau's appetite either.

The Levitical city is Gath-rimmon, the winepress of pomegranates: out in the world and in its dark, there is a great deal of good available, and a person can come back as full as that fruit.

Week 17, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 115 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Avraham, Serug, and the Alter Rebbe

"All the inhabitants of Canaan melted. May dread and fright fall upon them." And the haftorah could not suit Dan better: "Then ruled a remnant among the mighty of the nations; the Lord dominated the strong for me." A remnant ruling over the mighty, which is being small and then not.

Sotah's seventeenth daf is the writing of the curses on the scroll that gets dissolved in the water, and how curses can be inferred from blessings — and how even in the words for man and woman there is *fire* waiting, if the Divine Presence does not dwell between the couple. Both halves belong to this month: blessings turned to curses, and two Temples left by the Presence and then burned.

The daf also tells how Avraham was rewarded for refusing the spoils of the king of Sodom. Which runs alongside the Alter Rebbe. Napoleon was offering Jews more money and more freedom, and he saw where it led. The king of Sodom had said, take the goods and I will take the souls — and Avraham would not. And where Avraham refused even the smallest personal thing, Napoleon went looking for the smallest personal thing belonging to the Alter Rebbe, who had set fire to his own house before leaving, so that nothing was found.

The generation is Serug, Reu's son, and his name is a further gathering: from *lesareg*, to interlace, to interweave. More than rejoining a flock — being woven in. Which is the Alter Rebbe's own innovation: that chassidim are one family, bound unbreakably. The Hayom Yom for the twenty-fourth of Teveth has it exactly. Asked what the Alter Rebbe meant by the "ways of Chassidus" and by "Chassidus," the Tzemach Tzedek answered: the ways of Chassidus are that all chassidim are to be like one family, with affection, as the Torah teaches. And Chassidus is vitality — to bring life and light into everything, to shed light even on what is undesirable, "to become aware of one's own evil exactly as it is, in order to correct it."

The journey is to bricks: "They journeyed from Rimmon Perez and camped in Libnah." Libnah is from *leveinim*, bricks, which belong to the labour in Egypt — where at the end they were not even given straw. In Torah Or, quoting the Zohar, the Alter Rebbe explains that that labour has a counterpart in study: *leveinim*, bricks, points at *libun hilchesa*, the clarifying of law, and *chomer*, mortar, at *kal vachomer*, one

of the main rules of interpretation. The hard labour of exile can be exchanged for the labour of study. Last week was being fruitful; this week is studying properly — which is the thing this month remembers the lack of.

Week 17, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 116 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Going to Peace

"And Eli answered and said: Go in peace, and the God of Israel will grant your request which you have asked of Him."

The Hebrew is *Lechi L'Shalom*, which is *go to peace* rather than *go in peace* — and *Lech B'Shalom*, go in peace, is said only of those who have died. Rav Kook explains that nobody can be wished final peace in this world. This is a world of struggle, and Teveth more than most of it. The ultimate peace will come; in the meantime, expect an intense journey. The events around the Alter Rebbe's passing were exactly that.

The week's quality is that from such a person people enjoy counsel. Which is the verse: Eli's counsel is what finally lets Channah breathe, knowing the prayer will be answered. And the whole Book of Proverbs is counsel from the wise enjoyed; the seventeenth chapter is no different.

Besides the Alter Rebbe, the twenty-fourth of Teveth carries two more yahrzeits. Rabbi Shmuel Bornstein of Soccatchov, son of the Avnei Nezer, known for the Shem MiShmuel — and like the Alter Rebbe, both father and son were known for the revealed Torah and the law as much as for their Chassidic insight.

And Rabbi Moshe Mordechai Biderman, the sixth Lelover Rebbe, who was living in Israel when Jerusalem was liberated. Of all the Chassidic rebbes he spent the most time at the Kotel; he moved to Jerusalem to be near it, and his prayers there would take up most of the day.

Week 17, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 117 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Our Intimate Connection with G-d

"Your neck is like the Tower of David, built as a model; a thousand shields hanging on it, all the quivers of the mighty men. Your two breasts are like two fawns, the twins of a gazelle, who graze among the roses. Until the sun spreads and the shadows flee, I will go to the mountain of myrrh and to the hill of frankincense."

These are the verses that use the body most openly for what this people is. The two breasts belong to bearing and feeding, which is Teveth — and Rashi reads them as Moshe and Aharon, and as the two tablets, and explains how the laws on the first, between a person and G-d, answer to the laws on the second, between a person and a person.

Which is this week's own man as well. *Shneur* is *shnei or*, two lights, and he made good on the name: the light of Chassidus and the Torah's deep secrets, in the Tanya and the rest; and a light in the revealed Torah, in his Shulchan Aruch.

Of the seventy souls the seventeenth — not named outright — is Yocheved, the mother of Moshe and Aharon, who like Miriam did the quiet work of midwifing Jewish children.

Shevuot's seventeenth daf is about not taking your time leaving the Temple, and not taking the shortest way out, and entering the grounds improperly. Then it turns to how a man withdraws from a woman who becomes a niddah during intercourse. Both halves are this month's: sins about the Temple, and marriage.

Jeremiah's seventeenth chapter holds the wild goose's own verses from two weeks ago, and they are about multiplying from nothing: "Cursed is the man who trusts in man and makes flesh his arm… He shall be like a lone tree in the plain… Blessed is the man who trusts in the Lord; the Lord shall be his trust. For he shall be like a tree planted by the water, and by a rivulet spreads its roots, and will not see when heat comes, and its leaves shall be green, and in the year of drought will not be anxious, neither shall it cease from bearing fruit."

Trees, in the week before Rosh Chodesh Shevat.

Week 17, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 118 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fourth Week of Teveth - Psalms 49-51; 59:6-8; 89:18

The fourth week of Teveth in psalms: the forty-ninth, fiftieth and fifty-first, with three verses of Psalm 59 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 49 is addressed to everybody and aimed at the rich. "Hear this, all you peoples… sons of common folk and sons of nobility, rich and poor alike." Then the question it answers: "Why am I afraid in times of trouble? Because the sins I trod upon surround me." And what money cannot do: "There are those who rely on their wealth, who boast of their great riches. Yet a man cannot redeem his brother, nor pay his ransom to G-d. The redemption of their soul is too costly, and forever unattainable." It watches men who know better do it anyway: "Though he sees that wise men die, that the fool and the senseless both perish, leaving their wealth to others — nevertheless, in their inner thoughts their houses will last forever."

Psalm 50 is G-d speaking, and what He says He does not want is the surprise. "Not for the lack of your sacrifices will I rebuke you, nor for the lack of your burnt offerings… I do not take oxen from your house, nor goats from your pens; for every beast of the forest is Mine, the cattle of a thousand mountains." And then: "Were I hungry, I would not tell you, for the world and everything in it is mine. Do I eat the flesh of bulls, or drink the blood of goats? Offer confession as a sacrifice to G-d, and fulfill your vows."

Psalm 51 is David after Nathan came to him, and it is the psalm to say over one's own sins. "Be gracious to me, O G-d, in keeping with Your kindness… Cleanse me thoroughly of my wrongdoing, and purify me of my sin. For I acknowledge my transgressions, and my sin is always before me. Against You alone have I sinned." Then: "You desire truth in the innermost parts; teach me the wisdom of concealed things. Purge me with hyssop and I shall be pure; cleanse me and I shall be whiter than snow. Let me hear tidings of joy and gladness; then the bones which You have shattered will rejoice." And the request that is this week's whole business: "Create in me a pure heart, O G-d, and renew within me an upright spirit. Do not cast me out of Your presence, and do not take Your Spirit of Holiness away from me."

Psalm 59's verses are a city circled by dogs: "They return toward evening, they howl like the dog and circle the city. Behold, they spew with their mouths, swords are

in their lips, for they say, 'Who hears?'"

Week 17, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 119 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Bee-Eater is Saying

The bee-eater opens, and this gathering sets being drawn out of the water against dogs circling a city.

"I will whistle to them and gather them" / "He sent from on high and He took me" / "the twins of a gazelle, who graze among the roses" / "He drew me out of many waters" / "and they shall increase as they have before increased."

Then the splendour, and the remnant ruling: "Indeed, You are the splendor of their might" / "the Lord dominated the strong for me" / "and in Your goodwill our glory is exalted."

The demons come next, with Canaan melting: "They sacrificed to demons, which have no power" / "all the inhabitants of Canaan melted" / "may dread and fright fall upon them" / "which your forefathers did not fear" / "then ruled a remnant among the mighty of the nations" / "deities they did not know, new things that only recently came."

And then the swords in the lips, and the quivers, and the waking: "swords are in their lips, for they say, 'Who hears?'" / "all the quivers of the mighty men" / "And You, Lord, G-d of Hosts, G-d of Israel" / "until the sun spreads and the shadows flee" / "wake up to remember all the nations" / "a thousand shields hanging on it" / "behold, they spew with their mouths" / "your two breasts are like two fawns" / "they howl like the dog and circle the city."

It ends with Eli's blessing laid between the mountain of myrrh and the request granted: "and to the hill of frankincense" / "And Eli answered and said: Go in peace" / "I will go to the mountain of myrrh" / "and the God of Israel will grant your request" / "for I have redeemed them" / "they return toward evening" / "your neck is like the Tower of David, built as a model" / "do not grant favor to any of the iniquitous traitors, Selah" / "which you have asked of Him."

Week 17, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XVIII

Netzach of Tiferet

Days 120–126

Day 120 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Live in Harmony with Nature in a Manner that is Above Nature

Week eighteen is Rosh Chodesh Shevat, and the grasshopper asks a question: "I lift my eyes up to the mountains, where shall my help come from?" (Psalms 121:1)

It is answered ten weeks back. The swift, the eighth creature, sings the verse that comes next: "My help comes from the Lord, Creator of Heaven and Earth." Eighteen and eight, question and answer — and eight is the number of what is beyond nature. The grasshopper's song tends to land in the weeks of Vaera or Bo, which are the plagues, locusts among them: help arriving from Him with nature set aside entirely.

Shevat is Tu B'Shvat, the New Year of the Trees, kept on the fifteenth — though the Mishnah has a dispute about whether it should be the first. Which is itself the month's subject: we keep the trees' new year in the middle of winter, and that is faith.

The tribe is Asher, and the word is *ta'anug*, pleasure or delight; the Sixth Lubavitcher Rebbe notes that *asher* itself means delight, from *ashruni*. Jacob blesses Asher that he will bring delicacies to the king. On Tu B'Shvat we drink wine and eat many kinds of fruit — and the delights of this month are intellectual too.

Shevat belongs to the Oral Torah. It was on Rosh Chodesh that Moses began going back over everything he had taught in forty years, which is the whole Book of Deuteronomy. The Chidushei HaRim says that every new Torah insight a person has comes to him in Shevat.

And passing on the Oral Torah needs one trait above all: humility. Without it a person cannot teach purely and plainly what he received from the one before him. Humility is Moses' own mark, the humblest of men and the first to hand it on.

Which may be why in Perek Shirah the insects — the humblest creatures — are the ones singing through all four weeks of Shevat. As David said, "I am a worm and not a man."

Eighteen is *chai*, life, which is why gifts are given in multiples of it. Rosh Chodesh Shevat and Tu B'Shvat are a celebration of life in general, not only human life. And *chai* is also a thing's essence: the Ba'al Shem Tov and the Alter Rebbe were both born on Chai Elul, the eighteenth, the life and essence of Elul; Rebbe Nachman's yahrzeit is the eighteenth of Tishrei; Lag Ba'Omer is the eighteenth of Iyar. Eighteen is also the number of blessings in the Amidah, which is called simply *Tefilah* because it is prayer's essence — and prayer is the recognition that a Jew's life is not natural at all.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Nechunia the son of Hakanah: "One who accepts upon himself the yoke of Torah is exempted from the yoke of government duties and the yoke of worldly cares; but one who casts off the yoke of Torah is saddled with" both. Take up the Tree of Life, which is above the world, or be handed the world's obligations instead. Calling the Torah a yoke also says what acquiring it costs. Rabbi Mendel of Kotsk points out that plenty of sages had worldly work and even professions, and did not experience it as a yoke or a worry.

The pairing is Netzach shebeTiferet. A tree is a balance of root, trunk, branch and leaf, and only the balance keeps it up: no roots and it falls, too many branches and it falls, too few leaves and it cannot make enough to grow. In Shevat, mid-winter, it has to hold on. The same balance is wanted between the two yokes, and what it is differs from person to person and from one part of a life to another.

The grasshopper's lesson is that help comes from Him, provided we are willing to look up past our own small view. The Midrash reads the mountains as the patriarchs, and says it is largely for their deeds that we are saved — so look past the present situation, at the whole of what you are and where you came from.

Week 18, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 121 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Achia HaShiloni and "Minimized" World Activity

"You forgot the Mighty Rock Who bore you; you forgot the G-d Who delivered you." (Deuteronomy 32:18) Shevat is a month of nature, and the verse puts His relation to us as birth, which is the most natural figure there is. But Shevat is also what stands above nature, and the Oral Torah, and *ta'anug*, and *emunah* — keeping the trees' new year in the depths of winter.

And the verse can be read as a prayer instead: Rock, they are your children; forget completely our sins; G-d delivers you. The haftorah goes with that: "He delivered me from my mighty enemy; from them that hated me; for they were too powerful for me." (II Samuel 22:18) Help against odds, which is nature set aside.

The quality is *miut derech eretz*, minimised worldly activity — which is the same thing Pirkei Avot says this week from the other side. When a person's affairs are conducted small and humbly, His hand becomes much easier to see in them.

The prophet is Achiah HaShiloni, who may represent being above nature better than anyone: Maimonides records that he lived longer than any other prophet, and he taught both Eliyahu and the Ba'al Shem Tov. It was precisely because those two kept their worldly activity small that they merited having him revealed to them. And Achiah told the Ba'al Shem Tov that he had to reveal himself to the world — to be involved in it, but in the way of *miut*, smallness. The Ba'al Shem Tov himself spoke about being a genuinely good person with a simple connection to G-d: both *derech eretz*, being a mentsch, and caring for the *amei ha'aretz*, the simple folk.

The Levitical city is Mishal, which means a prayer, a request. Which is the grasshopper's question, and the eighteen blessings, and this month's faith and delight. Mishal also has the letters of *moshel*, to rule — and in prayer we accept who the Ruler is.

Week 18, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 122 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Nahor and Ta'anug

"With the arm of Your greatness may they become as still as a stone, until Your people cross over, O Lord." Still as a stone — and entering Shevat we are reminded of the four levels in nature: *domem*, the silent or mineral; *tzomeach*, the growing; *chai*, the living; *medaber*, the speaking. Each week of this month touches one of them, and this week's verse gives us the stone.

The haftorah begins something that will run through Shevat and Adar: what each tribe did in the fight against Sisera. This week is Ephraim and Benjamin, whom Rashi reads as Joshua and Shaul, and how they fought Amalek. Joshua is the Oral Torah, which is Shevat; Shaul belongs to Purim and Adar. And though Amalek is Adar's business, Amalek is the opposite of *emunah* — *Amalek* has the same numerical value as *safek*, doubt. The war against Sisera was a test of faith that not all the tribes passed, and which tribe showed faith and which showed doubt is the thread from here to Adar.

Sotah's eighteenth daf continues with the writing of the curses, and its theme is that things done twice rather than once, or divided rather than whole, or for two people rather than one, are invalid. Nature is multiplicity — and all of it still comes from Him.

The generation is Nahor, Serug's son and Avraham's grandfather. He lived in Ur Kasdim, where Avraham was born, and he had a grandson also called Nahor — continuity through children, as in nature. The name comes from *nachar*, to blow the nose, to sneeze, to snort. Which connects to the breath blown into Adam's nose, and so to nature and the world's making. And sneezing is a physical pleasure, which is this month's quality. The Talmud says that sneezing during prayer is a good sign, since as one is relieved below, so above.

The journey is to being broken: "They journeyed from Libnah and camped in Rissah." Rissah means broken — and only through that brokenness and smallness can a person actually take the Torah in. Rabbi Jacobson notes that Rissah also means a stopped-up well in Arabic: to draw water from the Torah's well, you have to feel that small. Last week was studying properly; this week is being broken enough to receive what is taught.

Week 18, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 123 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Wisdom That Brings Others Enjoyment and Pleasure in Life

"And she said: May your bondswoman find favor in your eyes; and the woman went on her way and ate, and her face was not sad anymore."

That she *ate* looks like an idle detail and is not. It is the measure of how much she had been let go of. Her faith in what Eli said let her take pleasure in food again — *ta'anug*, which is this month.

The week's quality is that people enjoy wisdom from such a person. Eli's wisdom is what lets her be comforted and eat. The word used is *Tushiah*, which is rare in Tanach and can also be rendered resourcefulness. Even having first misread her entirely, he was quick enough, once she spoke, to see his mistake and bless her with a child. And the first verse of Proverbs' eighteenth chapter uses that same rare word: "He who is separated seeks lust; in all sound wisdom, he is exposed."

Two great yahrzeits. The second of Shevat is Reb Zusha of Anipoli, one of the Maggid of Mezritch's main disciples and the brother of Rebbe Elimelech of Lizhensk. The two of them travelled Eastern Europe bringing Torah and life to the communities there, and Rabbi Noach of Kobryn once heard that Chassidus took root only in the places those brothers had passed through. The stories about him are of miracles, of humility, and of how deeply he looked at himself.

And the fourth of Shevat is the Baba Sali, grandson of Rav Yaakov Abuchatzeira — among the most prominent of Sefardi holy men, with thousands of stories of open miracles, and a man whose love for Hashem, for this people and for the Torah was past measuring. He kept close relations with Torah sages of every kind, and had a particular affinity for Chassidic teaching and its leaders.

Week 18, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 124 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Nature as a Metaphor and the Setting for Our Relationship with G-d

"You are all fair, my beloved, and there is no blemish in you. With me from Lebanon, my bride, with me from Lebanon shall you come; you shall look from the peak of Amanah, from the peak of Senir and Hermon, from the lions' dens, from mountains of leopards. You have captivated my heart, my sister, my bride; you have captivated my heart with one of your eyes, with one link of your necklaces."

The middle verse is all nature: a forest, three peaks, lions, leopards. Rashi reads it as His being with us in exile and coming back out of it with us. And the peak of Amanah has the root of *emunah* in it.

Of the seventy souls the eighteenth is Judah, who of all the brothers stands most for the Oral Torah: Jacob sent him ahead to set up a yeshiva in Egypt before the family came down. He is this month's two qualities as well. He showed great faith facing the viceroy who turned out to be Joseph — and his pleasure-seeking, with Tamar, got him into trouble he was not afraid to own and turn from.

Shevuot's eighteenth daf continues on withdrawing from a niddah, where the point is avoiding pleasure, and on separating before the set period of impurity; then on whether a person must know what made him impure before he forgot that he was. It takes in forbidden foods, forbidden relations, and acts that show a lack of faith, like working on Shabbat or Yom Kippur.

Jeremiah's eighteenth chapter is G-d as the potter, which asks for faith that all of it comes from Him. "And at one instant I may speak concerning a nation and concerning a kingdom, to build and to plant." And then: "Shall one abandon water flowing from rocks of the field that comes from the snow of Lebanon? Shall strange cold flowing water be abandoned?" In Shevat the sap begins to move while the cold is still on. Lebanon, whose trees went into the Temple, is in the Song's verses above too — and Levanon is often the Temple itself.

Week 18, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 125 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the First Week of Shevat - Psalms 52-54; 59:9-11; 89:19

The first week of Shevat in psalms: the fifty-second, fifty-third and fifty-fourth, with three verses of Psalm 59 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 52 is about Doeg, who informed on David to Saul, and about a man who takes pride in harm. “Why do you boast with evil, O mighty one? G-d’s kindness is all day long. Your tongue devises treachery; like a sharpened razor it works deceit. You love evil more than good, falsehood more than speaking righteousness.” And then the answer: “G-d will likewise shatter you forever; He will excise and pluck you from” where you stand.

Psalm 53 is headed as speaking of when Titus pierced the curtain of the Holy of Holies with his sword and thought he had killed Him. It opens with the fool: “The fool says in his heart, 'There is no G-d!'” And the looking down: “G-d looked down from heaven upon mankind, to see if there was any man of intelligence who searches for G-d. But they all regressed together.” Then the fright: “There they will be seized with fright, a fright such as never was.” And the wish at the end: “O that out of Zion would come Israel’s deliverance!”

Psalm 54 is from when the Ziphites told Saul that David was hiding with them, and it is short and direct. “O G-d, deliver me by Your Name, and vindicate me by Your might. G-d, hear my prayer, listen to the words of my mouth. For strangers have risen against me, and ruthless men have sought my soul; they are not mindful of G-d.” Then the turn: “Behold, G-d is my helper; my Lord is with those who support my soul.” And the close: “With a free-will offering I will sacrifice to You; I will offer thanks to Your Name, O Lord, for it is good. For He has saved me from every trouble.”

Psalm 59's verses are the laughing: “But You, Lord, You laugh at them; You mock all nations. Because of his might, I wait for You, for G-d is my stronghold. The G-d of my kindness will anticipate my need.”

Week 18, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 126 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

Week 18: The Grasshopper is Saying (Book 7)

The grasshopper opens with its question, and the gathering answers it from four directions at once.

"I lift my eyes up to the mountains" / "where shall my help come from?" / "For our protectors turn to the Lord" / "and our king to the Holy One of Israel."

Then the peaks and the dens, with waiting laid under them: "You shall look from the peak of Amanah" / "from the peak of Senir and Hermon" / "from the lions' dens, from mountains of leopards" / "because of his might, I wait for You, for G-d is my stronghold" / "the G-d of my kindness will anticipate my need."

The stone comes next, with the crossing and the rescue: "With the arm of Your greatness may they become as still as a stone" / "until Your people cross over, O Lord" / "He delivered me from my mighty enemy" / "from them that hated me; for they were too powerful for me" / "But You, Lord, You laugh at them; You mock all nations."

Then the forgetting, braided with the tribes: "You forgot the Mighty Rock Who bore you" / "you forgot the G-d Who delivered you" / "Out of Ephraim, whose root was against Amalek" / "after you will be Benjamin with your abaters."

The captivating follows — "You have captivated my heart, my sister, my bride" / "you have captivated my heart with one of your eyes" / "with one link of your necklaces" — and then Channah asking for favour.

It ends with the fairness, Lebanon, and the face: "You are all fair, my beloved, and there is no blemish in you" / "with me from Lebanon, my bride, with me from Lebanon shall you come" / "and the woman went on her way and ate" / "and her face was not sad anymore."

Week 18, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XIX

Hod of Tiferet

Days 127–133

Day 127 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Feel that G-d is Close Even When He Seems Far Away

The locust is saying, "O G-d, You are my Lord; I will exalt You, I will praise Your Name; for You have done wondrous things; Your counsels of old are faithfulness and truth." (Isaiah 25:1) It blesses G-d for His wonders and for the true and loyal advice He gives from afar.

The nineteenth week holds Yud Shevat, the yahrzeit of the Sixth Rebbe of Lubavitch, Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneerson, and the date on which his successor, Rebbe Menachem Mendel Schneerson, became rebbe exactly one year later. Shevat is the transmission and development of the Oral Torah; the first to pass it on was Moses, who transmitted it to Joshua. Yud Shevat is the transmission of the Torah of Chassidut from the Sixth Rebbe to the Seventh.

The song holds the word etzot and the word emunah. Etza means advice, but etz means tree, and emunah means faith — and the month is both. In the middle of winter the trees are cold and leafless, and on Tu B'Shvat the Jewish people celebrate them anyway, trusting that they will blossom and yield fruit.

The song also reaches for three names at once. Hashem is the Name for how He is above nature and time, connected to Rachamim, mercy. Elohai, my Elohim, is G-d as He is expressed in nature, connected to gevurah, strength or discipline. Atah, You, is the way of calling out that shows closeness, and it also points to His essence far above any given name. So the locust sings of connecting to G-d above nature yet still within it, and of feeling distant from Him while being close to Him at the same time.

Rav Moshe Wolfsohn reads the Akeidah along the same lines. Ness means a test, but also to raise. The main test, the tenth and final one, was not the willingness to

sacrifice his son — Abraham's first test was throwing himself into a furnace before G-d had even revealed Himself to him — but that Hashem seemed so far away: "Vaya'ar Et HaMakom Merachok," he saw the place from a distance, and Hamakom is itself one of Hashem's names. After years of closeness Abraham was stripped of his levels of greatness and had to serve like the simplest of Jews, with simple emunah, like the generation of Ikvessa d'Meshicha, the heels of Mashiach. He was rewarded, "Ekev Asher Shamatah beKoli," because you hearkened to My voice — and ekev also means heel. The verse of the week ends with the words "Merachok Emunah Amen."

Bati LeGani was the last ma'amar of the Previous Rebbe and the first of his successor, and the Rebbe went deeper into it for over forty years. It tells how the Shechinah rested and was revealed in the world at the beginning of creation, then became distanced and hidden through sins beginning with the eating of the Tree of Knowledge, then returned by degrees through the acts of tzadikim until the giving of the Torah at Mount Sinai — and it draws the parallel to the final redemption.

Nineteen is a number of increments. Shmoneh Esreh was increased from 18 to 19, and it is a ladder to G-d like the ladder in Jacob's dream, where the angels ascended and descended; with every blessing we climb a rung. Nineteen is also the gematria of Chavah, Eve, whom some commentaries call a loftier version of Adam.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Chalafta the son of Dosa of the village of Chanania, who counts the levels down: ten who sit and occupy themselves with Torah have the Divine Presence among them, and so do five, and three, and two, and even one. The combination is Hod shebeTiferet, grateful service within beauty and balance — and in the month of trees, gratitude is what makes faith easier to hold. The Kotzker Rebbe, as a child, was asked where G-d is. The expected answer was "everywhere." He said: "G-d is wherever you let Him in."

Week 19, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 128 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Jehu and "Minimized" Pleasure (Ta'anug)

The second week of Shevat. Haazinu keeps to the parent and the child: "And the Lord saw this and became angry, provoked by His sons and daughters." (Deuteronomy 32:19) Read in a positive light, the anger is not His at them — He saw the prayer and was insulted by the anger directed against His sons and daughters.

The Haftarah verse agrees: "They confronted me on the day of my calamity; but the Lord was a support to me." (II Samuel 22:19) The support comes from King David's emunah, which is one of the themes of Shevat, along with ta'anug, pleasure.

So the quality is minimized pleasure, miut ta'anug. The idea is not to be rid of pleasure but to take it with miut, smallness and humility — to enjoy the world's pleasure in the way that lifts the world and connects it back to its Creator.

The prophet is Jehu son of Hanani, who spoke out against the corruption of the kings of both Israel and Judah. In one of his few positive statements he praises Jehoshaphat, king of Judah, for exactly this quality — for having removed the idolatrous Ashera trees: "Nevertheless there are good things found in thee, in that thou hast put away the Asheroth out of the land, and hast set thy heart to seek G-d." (2 Chronicles 19:3) The trees were used for idol worship and to beautify the place where it was done; pleasing to the senses, and forbidden beside the altar. Maimonedes writes that one may not derive any pleasure or benefit from them at all.

The levitical city is Abdon, from eved, servant. It brings to mind the verse in Beshalach: "Vaya'aminu BaHashem ub'Moshe Avdo," and they believed in Hashem and in Moshe His servant. Abdon was also the name of one of the Judges, whose sons and grandsons rode on seventy donkeys. All of it is the yoke of Torah taken up willingly, and in this month, the Oral Torah.

Week 19, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 129 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Terah and Nature

The Song of the Sea reaches the arrival: "until this nation that You have acquired crosses over. You shall bring them and plant them on the mount of Your heritage." Acquiring and inheriting are the themes of Yud Shevat, the Previous Rebbe's yahrzeit and the day the Rebbe took the leadership a year later. The verses also carry two of the elements — the plant kingdom in "and plant them," the mineral in the mountain.

The Haftarah sends the high officials down into the fighting: "out of Machir came down officers, and out of Zebulun they that handle the pen of the scribe." Machir is of the tribe of Menashe. That is the message of Yud Shevat and of Bati L'Gani, studied that day, where we are told to spend all the treasures and use everything at our disposal. Chassidic texts that only a select few could reach in manuscript — by the pen of the scribe — were now printed for everyone. The Rebbe's decision to accept was itself a coming down, into the wars of Hashem.

Daf Yud Tet of Sotah is her drinking the water and waving the mincha offering, with a discussion of when a woman can be forced to drink and whether the Name has already been erased. There too different elements in nature act on each other. And it runs parallel to the Chassidim urging the Rebbe to accept: he could not be forced into it.

The generation is Terah, son of Nahor, father of Avraham. He moved from Ur Kasdim to Charan on his way to the Land of Canaan and never arrived. Terah means delay, and he was delayed; it also means to breathe, from re'ach, smell. His father's name, Nahor, means sneezing or snorting. Breathing and smelling belong to pleasure and to nature, which are Shevat.

The journey is from Rissah to Kehelathah. Kehelathah means gathering, and it is the place of Korach's rebellion — where on Yud Shevat the emphasis is the exact opposite: a gathering to accept a new leader who was wholly devoted to the one before him. The personal journey is to be broken in order to receive the Torah, and then to gather with others and commit to the leader.

Week 19, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 130 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Wisdom, Understanding and Knowledge

Channah's nineteenth verse is the answer arriving quietly: "And they arose early in the morning, and prostrated themselves before the Lord: and they returned and came to their house, to Ramah, and Elkanah knew Hannah, his wife, and the Lord remembered her."

Shevat is pleasure, Ta'anug, and faith, Emunah, and the verse carries both. It speaks of marital relations, which the Torah often calls knowledge, Da'at — and Da'at is the connecting point between the male aspect of intellect, Chochmah, wisdom, and the female one, Binah, understanding. It is what lets Chochmah impregnate Binah. And it says that Hashem remembered Channah, that her Emunah was rewarded.

The quality of Pirkei Avot is that people enjoy understanding, Binah, from those who study Torah for its own sake. Channah in the verse is Binah. The whole Book of Proverbs is about enjoying understanding from those who have it, and chapter 19 keeps to it: "He who acquires sense loves his soul; he who guards understanding will eventually find good," and "Beat a scorner, and a simple man will gain cunning; reprove a man of understanding, and he will understand knowledge." Rashi reads that second one as a reference to the plagues in Egypt — which is the locust of this week in Book 1.

Besides the Previous Rebbe, the week holds the yahrzeits of two great tzadikim of Yemeni descent, both on the 10th of Shevat: Rabbi Shalom Shabazi, the leader of his generation, known as Mori, a tremendous scholar and the greatest of Yemenite poets, and Rabbi Shalom Sharabi, the Rashash, the father of all contemporary sephardic kabbalists.

Two rabbis from Chassidic dynasties have yahrzeits this week as well. Rabbi David Biederman of Lelov, on the 7th of Shevat, was one of the main disciples of the Seer of Lublin and the founder of the Lelover dynasty; he was known for his extraordinary ability to see every Jew in a positive light, and he taught Rebbe Yitzhak of Vorka, known for the same tremendous Ahavat Yisrael.

Week 19, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 131 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Spiritual Pleasure

The Song's verses this week are all fragrance and sweetness: "How fair is your love, my sister, [my] bride; how much better is your love than wine, and the fragrance of your oils than all spices!" Then: "Your lips drip flowing honey, O bride; honey and milk are under your tongue, and the fragrance of your garments is like the fragrance of Lebanon." And then the closing: "A locked up garden is my sister, [my] bride; a locked up spring, a sealed fountain." Nature again, and Ta'anug, pleasure.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the nineteenth is Shelah. Judah's first two sons are skipped because they died childless through their sins, and those brothers stand for pleasure engaged in wrongly. Shelah was meant to marry Tamar; he was still young, and Yehudah later looked for ways to keep her from him.

Daf Yud Tet of Shvuot is mostly the one who forgot both that he was impure and that he was in the Temple, and then the two main kinds of oath, both about food. The forgetting belongs to the Oral Law, which is this month's focus. The food belongs to Ta'anug.

Jeremiah's nineteenth chapter is the same pair gone wrong — eating and pleasure, completely corrupted. "Because they forsook Me and they estranged this place and burnt incense therein to other gods, which they had not known." "And they built the high places of Baal to burn their children with fire as burnt offerings to Baal, which I did not command, neither did I speak nor did it enter My mind." And the end of it: "And I will feed them the flesh of their sons and the flesh of their daughters, and each one will eat the flesh of his friend, in the siege and the straits."

Week 19, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 132 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second Week of Shevat - Psalms 55-57; 59:12-14; 89:20

The second week of Shevat in psalms: the fifty-fifth, fifty-sixth and fifty-seventh, with three verses of Psalm 59 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 55 is from David escaping Jerusalem before the slanderers, Doeg and Achitofel, who had declared him deserving of death. He had counted Achitofel a

friend and given him the utmost honour, and Achitofel breached their covenant. The wound is that it came from inside: “For it is not the enemy who taunts me-that I could bear; nor my foe who raises himself against me, that I could hide from him. But it is you, a man of my equal, my guide and my intimate. Together we took sweet counsel; we walked with the throng to the house of G-d.” Before that is the wish to be gone: “If only I had wings like the dove! I would fly off and find rest.” And the smooth words: “Smoother than butter are the words of his mouth, but war is in his heart; his words are softer than oil, yet they are curses.” It ends where it can: “Cast your burden upon the Lord, and He will sustain you; He will never let the righteous man falter.”

Psalm 56 is from mortal danger at the palace of Achish, brother of Goliath, when the Philistines seized him in Gath, and in that danger David accepts vows upon himself. “On the day I am afraid, I trust in You.” And twice over: “in G-d I trust, I do not fear-what can [man of] flesh do to me?” Then the flask: “You have counted my wanderings; place my tears in Your flask-are they not in Your record?” And both hands of it: “When G-d deals strictly, I praise His word; when the Lord deals mercifully, I praise His word.”

Psalm 57 is from hiding in the cave from Saul. Like Jacob facing Esau, David prayed that he neither be killed nor be forced to kill. “Favor me, O G-d, favor me, for in You my soul took refuge, and in the shadow of Your wings I will take refuge until the disaster passes.” The lions: “My soul is in the midst of lions, I lie among fiery men; their teeth are spears and arrows, their tongue a sharp sword.” The pit they dug: “they dug a pit before me, [but] they themselves fell into it.” And then the waking: “My heart is steadfast, O G-d, my heart is steadfast; I will sing and chant praise. Awake, my soul! Awake, O harp and lyre! I shall awaken the dawn.”

Psalm 59's verses ask for less than destruction, so that nothing is forgotten: “Do not kill them, lest my nation forget; drive them about with Your might and impoverish them, O our Shield, my Master.” And Psalm 89's verse is the choosing: “I have granted aid to [David] the mighty one; I have exalted the one chosen from among the people.”

Week 19, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 133 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

Week 19: The Locust is Saying (Book 7)

The locust opens, and what it opens is a braid of the week's six books into one song.

The anger first, and the asking that it stop short: "At the sight of their accursed state and deterioration, [people] will recount" / "Consume them in wrath, consume them and they will be no more" / "And the Lord saw this and became angry" / "Provoked by His sons and daughters" / "Do not kill them, lest my nation forget" / "Drive them about with Your might and impoverish them."

Then the crossing and the planting: "Until this nation that You have acquired crosses over" / "You shall bring them and plant them on the mount of Your heritage" / "And they will know that G-d rules in Jacob, to the ends of the earth, Selah."

Then the morning in Ramah, and the support: "And they arose early in the morning, and prostrated themselves before the Lord" / "And they returned and came to their house, to Ramah" / "I will praise Your Name; for You have done wondrous things" / "They confronted me on the day of my calamity" / "But the Lord was a support to me."

Then the scribes and the remembering: "Out of Machir came down officers" / "And out of Zebulun they that handle the pen of the scribe" / "And Elkanah knew Hannah, his wife, and the Lord remembered her" / "Your counsels of old are faithfulness and truth."

And the end is the garden: "How fair is your love, my sister, [my] bride" / "How much better is your love than wine, and the fragrance of your oils than all spices!" / "Your lips drip flowing honey, O bride" / "Honey and milk are under your tongue" / "O G-d, You are my Lord; I will exalt You" / "And the fragrance of your garments is like the fragrance of Lebanon" / "A locked up garden is my sister, [my] bride" / "A locked up spring, a sealed fountain."

Week 19, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XX

Yesod of Tiferet

Days 134–140

Day 134 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Be Solid and Giving in Our Relationships

The spider is saying, "Praise Him with sounding cymbals! Praise Him with loud clashing cymbals!" (Psalms 150:5) It is the twentieth animal, and this is the week of Tu B'Shvat, the New Year of the Trees.

The spider mattered to King David, to whom Perek Shirah is attributed. A Midrash teaches that he once wondered why G-d had created it at all and could find no purpose for it. Later, fleeing from Saul, he entered a cave, and a spider spun an entire web across the entrance. Saul's men saw the web and reasoned that nobody could have been inside for long, so they went away without checking. The web saved his life and taught him that everything G-d creates has a glorious purpose. Perhaps that is why he kept the spider for Tu B'Shvat itself, the high point of Judaism's celebration of nature, and why its verse comes from the very last Psalm, where the praise comes to its culmination.

A web and a tree are built the same way. A tree takes a long time to grow and then bears fruit; a spider takes a long time to make its web, and its fruits are what the web catches. Both are examples of balance and resistance, both are delicate, and both stand up to very strong winds because they can absorb impact by giving a little instead of breaking.

Twenty is two complete units, so it intensifies the duality and the relationship that two already holds. It is also the age of full maturity, when a man may be enlisted for war and is expected to provide for his own sustenance, and from twenty onward we are held accountable in the Heavenly court.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Elazar of Bartota: give to Him what is His, for you and all that is yours is His, as King David said, "For everything comes from You, and from Your own hand we give to You." (I Chronicles 29:14) Fitting that David is the one quoted, in the week that is so much his. Tzedakah comes from the word for justice, and the Tanya explains that it is arguably the highest of all the mitzvoth: when we give away part of our livelihood we give away part of our own life. We fought hard for that money, and letting it go is the clearest admission that all of it was a gift to begin with — and that even after Hashem gives, it stays His, because He is the Supreme Owner of everything.

Rabbi Elazar's line belongs to Tu B'Shvat directly. The first fruits were brought as an offering to the Temple, and all fruit requires ma'aser, tithing; Tu B'Shvat is the day the obligation to tithe the fruit begins, which is why it is the Rosh Hashanah of the Trees. He grants the fruit, so at least a tenth of it goes back to Him, as at least a tenth of our income goes to tzedakah.

The same holds for passing on the Oral Torah. Whoever transmits it has to stay conscious that it comes from G-d, the Ultimate Teacher — both what came from a teacher and the new insight that looks like one's own. He grants knowledge for safekeeping and for the best use we can make of it, and there is a concept of tithing one's time to teach Torah too.

The combination is yesod shebetiferet, a foundation that has both beauty and balance, which is what a tree is. And from the spider: with total confidence and a loud, firm voice — like the smashing of cymbals — we can be a good influence on others, and help them see that nobody is alone.

Week 20, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 135 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Azariah and "Minimized" Sleep

Tu B'Shevat, and Haazinu's verse hides His face: "And He said, 'I will hide My face from them. I will see what their end will be, for they are a generation of changes [reversals]; they are not [recognizable] as My children whom I have reared.'" (Deuteronomy 32:20) Read positively, He hides His face from their sins and focuses on how they will be at their completion — a generation transformed by teshuvah, and His children after all, with faith in them.

The Haftarah says the same from the other side: "And He brought me forth into a wide place; He delivered me because He took delight in me." (II Samuel 22:20) Once we are taken out of our confines, our essence comes out, which is what He desires. Delight and desire are Ta'anug, and Ta'anug is Shevat. The Hebrew for "generation of changes" is Dor Ta'apuchot, which sounds like Tapuach, apple — and the theme underneath is emunah, which is also the ability to change for the better. To celebrate the New Year of the Trees in the middle of winter, knowing spring will come, is the whole message of the day.

So the quality is minimized sleep, miut sheinah. Sleep confines us; consciousness drops and so does the ability to serve. But sleep is also a moment of increased faith, because we trust that we will wake. That is Tu B'Shvat again: the tree's vitality is still dormant and the fruit is already there in potential. Better not to sleep — not to slacken — in serving Him; and in the hours when we are less attuned, to act with miut, smallness and humility, hoping to serve better soon.

The prophet is Azariah son of Oded, and his prophecy to King Asa is exactly this. "Hearken to me, Asa and all of Judah and Benjamin; the Lord is with you because you are with Him, and if you seek Him, He will be found by you, but if you forsake Him, He will forsake you." He describes the sleeping years — "there were many days for Israel without a true G-d and without an instructing priest, and without the Torah" — and then the waking: "And they returned to the Lord, the G-d of Israel, when they were in distress, and they sought Him, and He was found by them." And the charge: "But you be strong and let your hands not slacken, for there is reward for your work." Asa heard it, strengthened himself, removed the abominations from Judah and Benjamin and from the cities he had captured from Mount Ephraim, renewed the

altar, and gathered the people.

The levitical city is Helkath, from chelek, part — which is the tithing of produce again, the thing this day begins.

Week 20, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 136 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Avraham and Giving

The Song of the Sea names the house: "directed toward Your habitation, which You made, O Lord; the sanctuary, O Lord, [which] Your hands founded." Rashi explains "directed toward Your habitation" to mean that the Temple below stands directly opposite the Temple above. At that moment neither the Temple nor the Tabernacle had been built; they were there only in potential, a reflection of the one above. Which is Tu B'Shevat exactly — celebrated in midwinter, when the fruit is only there in potential.

The Haftorah brings Issachar: "And the princes of Issachar were with Deborah, as was Issachar with Barak; into the valley they rushed forth with their feet." Issachar was wholly given to learning Torah and passing it on, and so stands for the Oral Torah more than any other tribe, which is this month.

Daf Kaf of Sotah keeps on with the drinking and when she can refuse, and takes in teaching Torah to women, how the water tests her, what ink may be used, and how a woman's merit can hold back punishment. It also has a passage that looks down on withholding from pleasure improperly — and pleasure is the theme of the day.

The generation is Avraham, forefather of the Jewish people and father, Av, of many others, which is what his name means. At the time his name was changed, and even before that, he was still childless: his children too were there only in potential. He was known for his hospitality, feeding his guests all kinds of delicacies, and that was how he taught them about the One True G-d.

The connection is plainer still in the tamarisk. "And Avraham planted an eshel, a tamarisk tree… and there he called in the name of G-d, L-rd of the world," and then, "And Avraham lived in the land of the Philistines for an extended period" — and after those verses comes the binding of Yitzchak. Why does it matter that he planted a tree? The tamarisk is large and broad-branched, and he was living in a desert, so he

planted it to shade wayfarers from the scorching sun. The Talmud widens eshel from one tree to an orchard, so that passersby could refresh themselves with fruit, and offers a second reading in which eshel is an inn: bread and meat, drink and lodging. The Midrash says he even gave his guests a court of law to settle any dispute among them. He did not stop at bread, salt and water — not the bare minimum but the things that bring pleasure: fruit, wine, delicacies, lodging, and a court for their troubles.

The journey is from Kehelathah to Mount Shepher. Rabbi Jacobson explains that Mount Shepher means beautiful mountain, and cites Targum Yonasan, which renders it mountain with beautiful fruit. The personal journey moves on from the gathering and the commitment to the leader, to the enjoyment and the beauty of both the natural and the spiritual fruit.

Week 20, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 137 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Hanging in There Through the Winter

Channah's twentieth verse is the birth: "And it was, when the time came about (lit. after the seasons and the days), after Hannah had conceived, that she bore a son, and she called his name Samuel, because (she said); 'I asked him of the Lord.'" Conception and birth run through this month. In Shevat the fruit is there in potential, and it still takes a turn of seasons and days before the tree bears it — and in the meantime there is the harshness of winter to get through.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that people enjoy power from those who study Torah for its own sake, Lishmah: "Mine are counsel and wisdom, I am understanding, mine is power." Gevurah is might, strength, discipline, and also judgment. In the story, Eli's blessing is what gives Channah the strength to bear a child, and the name Shmuel and the reason given for it say plainly that it all came from Hashem.

Proverbs 20 carries the same. "Fear of a king is like a lion's roar; he who provokes him forfeits his life." "A king sits upon a throne of judgment; all evil is spread out before him." "Who will say, 'I have cleansed my heart; I have become purified of my sin'?" And then: "'It is bad, it is bad,' says the buyer, but when he goes away, then he boasts." Rashi reads that last one as the pains and the rewards of Gevurah together —

one who acquires Torah through poverty and the pains of hunger says woe is me for this trouble, and then goes away full of wisdom and boasts about the pain he suffered.

The week usually holds the yahrzeits of two Chassidic founders: Rabbi Mordechai of Lechovitch on the 13th of Shevat and Rav Yechiel Danziger of Alexander on the 14th. Rabbi Mordechai is one of the foremost figures in the Karlin dynasty, and Lechovitch later branched into Kobrin, Koidanov and Slonim. There are many stories about him and many recorded statements; he once gave this blessing: "Don't fool yourself, don't fool G-d, and don't fool people."

Rav Yechiel Danziger founded Alexander, which before the Holocaust was the second largest dynasty after Ger. He was a student of Rabbi Yitzchak Kalish of Vorka, and after Rabbi Yitzchak's son, Rabbi Menachem Mendel of Vorka, passed away, many of his disciples became Alexander Chassidim. Rav Yechiel's teachings are recorded in the group's primary text, Yismach Yisroel, written by his son.

Strikov continues Alexander. After Rav Yechiel's son, Rabbi Yisroel Yitzchok Danziger, passed away, the leadership was eventually transferred to Rav Elimelech Menachem Mendel Landau of Strikov, whose yahrzeit also often falls this week, on the 19th of Shevat; he only accepted it once his brother, Rabbi Tzvi Aharon, had passed away. Under him there were 150 Strikover houses of study throughout Poland; he founded Yeshivas Zechusa DeAvraham in Israel, and his Torah thoughts are published in Maggid Devarav L'Yaakov and Bayeshishim Chochmah. Also this week: Rav Yaakov Yehoshua Falk Katz, the Pnei Yehoshua, and Rabbi Aryeh Kaplan on the 14th of Shevat, Rav Yechezkel of Kuzmir, grandfather of the first Modzitzer Rebbe, on the 17th, and sometimes Rav Shmuel Weinberg of Slonim, the Divrei Shmuel, on the 19th.

Week 20, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 138 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Perez and Bursting Out of the Cold

This week the Song names the fruit outright. “Your arid fields are as a pomegranate orchard with sweet fruit, henna and spikenard.” Then the whole list: “Spikenard and saffron, calamus and cinnamon, with all frankincense trees, myrrh and aloes, with all the chief spices.” And then the water: “A garden fountain, a well of living waters and flowing streams from Lebanon.” Nature and pleasure again, but fruit and trees by name, because this is the Rosh Hashanah of the trees.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twentieth is Perez, whose name means to burst forth. His birth is told in some detail, and how he burst forth to become the firstborn — which is how the flowers and the fruit have to come out, after the trees have endured the cold.

Daf Kaf of Shvuot keeps on with the laws of oaths, most of them about eating and pleasure.

Jeremiah’s twentieth chapter is the pain he endured, and its most striking part is where he speaks of the day of his birth. “Cursed be the day in which I was begotten; the day in which my mother bore me shall not be blessed.” “That he did not put me to death from the womb, that my mother should be my grave and her womb a perpetual pregnancy. Why did I come forth out of the womb to see toil and grief, and my days end with shame?” Birth and conception again, from the other end of it.

Week 20, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 139 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Shevat - Psalms 58-60; 59:15-17; 89:21

The third week of Shevat in psalms: the fifty-eighth, fifty-ninth and sixtieth, with three verses of Psalm 59 again and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 58 is David’s anguish at Avner and the others who justified Saul’s pursuit of him. It opens by asking the judges why they are silent: “Is it true that you are mute [instead of] speaking justice? [Instead of] judging men with fairness?” Then the venom: “Their venom is like the venom of a snake; like the deaf viper that closes its ear so as not to hear the voice of charmers, [even] the most skillful caster of spells.”

Then the asking: “O G-d, smash their teeth in their mouth.” “Let them melt like water and disappear.” “Like the snail that melts as it goes along.” And the end of it: “And man will say, 'There is indeed reward for the righteous; indeed there is a G-d Who judges in the land.'”

Psalm 59 is the great miracle of the escape through a window, unnoticed by the guards at the door, with the prayers he offered then. “Rescue me from my enemies, my G-d; raise me above those who rise against me.” The dogs: “They return toward evening, they howl like the dog and circle the city.” The laughing: “But You, Lord, You laugh at them; You mock all nations.” Then the asking for less than destruction, so nothing is forgotten: “Do not kill them, lest my nation forget.” And the morning at the end: “As for me, I shall sing of Your might, and sing joyously of Your kindness toward morning, for You have been a stronghold to me, a refuge on the day of my distress.”

Psalm 60 has a story behind it. Joab, David’s general, came to Aram Naharayim for war and the people asked him: are you not from the children of Jacob? What of the pact he made with Laban? He did not know what to answer and put it to the Sanhedrin. The psalm is David’s prayer for success in that war, and it starts from the breach: “O G-d, You forsook us, You have breached us! You grew furious-restore us! You made the earth quake, You split it apart-heal its fragments, for it totters!” Then the banner: “[Now] give those who fear You a banner to raise themselves, for the sake of truth, Selah.” Then the dividing up of the land, Shechem and the Valley of Succot, Gilead and Menasseh, Ephraim and Judah, Moab and Edom and Philistia. And the close, which gives the fighting back to Him: “Grant us relief from the oppressor; futile is the salvation of man. With G-d we will do valiantly, and He will trample our oppressors.”

Psalm 89's verse is the anointing: “I have found David, My servant; I have anointed him with My holy oil.”

Week 20, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 140 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Spider is Saying

The spider opens, and the week’s six books come in around it.

The howling first, braided with the hiding: “And they will return toward evening” / “They will howl like the dog and circle the city” / “And He said, 'I will hide My face from them. I will see what their end will be’” / “They will wander about to eat” / “When they will not be sated they will groan” / “For they are a generation of reversals” / “They are not My children whom I have reared.”

Then the singing toward morning, and the princes going down: “As for me, I shall sing of Your might” / “And sing joyously of Your kindness toward morning” / “And the princes of Issachar were with Deborah” / “As was Issachar with Barak.”

Then the birth and the anointing together: “And it was, after the seasons and the days” / “After Hannah had conceived, that she bore a son” / “I have found David, My servant; I have anointed him with My holy oil” / “And she called his name Samuel” / “Because, 'I asked him of the Lord.'”

Then the house, with the refuge inside it: “Directed toward Your habitation” / “Which You made, O Lord” / “For You have been a stronghold to me” / “A refuge on the day of my distress” / “The sanctuary, O Lord, [Which] Your hands founded” / “And He brought me forth into a wide place.”

And the end is the orchard and the cymbals: “Your arid fields are as a pomegranate orchard” / “With sweet fruit, henna and spikenard” / “Praise Him with sounding cymbals!” / “Into the valley they rushed forth with their feet” / “Spikenard and saffron, calamus and cinnamon, with all frankincense trees” / “He delivered me because He took delight in me” / “Myrrh and aloes, with all the chief spices” / “A garden fountain, a well of living waters and flowing streams from Lebanon” / “Praise Him with loud clashing cymbals!”

Week 20, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXI

Malchut of Tiferet

Days 141–147

Day 141 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Keep Things in Perspective

The fly, when Israel is not busying itself with Torah, is saying: "The voice said, 'Call out'. And he said, 'What shall I call out? All flesh is grass, and all its grace is as the flower of the field.' '...The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our Lord shall endure forever.'" And then: "I will create a new expression of the lips: Peace, peace for him who is far off and for him who is near, says G-d, and I will heal him." (Isaiah 40:6,8; 57:19) The song is a kind of dialogue — one voice says call out, and the second asks what there is to say.

This is the last week of Shevat, and it holds the yahrzeit of Rebbetzin Chaya Mushka, the Rebbe's wife, on the 22nd of Shevat. Just after Tu B'Shvat, with trees and nature still in view, the fly comes to remind us that nature and life itself, beautiful and pleasurable and meaningful as they are, are fleeting. They reflect the Creator; only the Creator, and those attached to Him, last.

Flies do not disturb the tzadikim. Perhaps that is why we only know what the fly sings when the Jews are not studying Torah: when we are truly engaged in it we are all tzadikim, no fly comes near, and so there is no way to hear the song.

The fly recalls the Shunammite woman, the Ishah Shunamit. She kept the great mitzvah of hachnasat orchim, hospitality, in the tradition inherited from Abraham, and prepared a room so the prophet Elisha could always stay with her and her husband. The Talmud and the Zohar explain how she knew his greatness: she never saw a fly land on his table. His table was like the altar of the Temple, where there were never flies, despite the constant meat and blood — so the story is about the sanctification of pleasure. She was childless and always satisfied with what she had;

asked by the prophet whether she needed anything, she answered, "I dwell within my people." Her behaviour toward Elisha, the disciple of Elijah, is one of the prime biblical examples of humility, modesty, kindness and hospitality.

The same things show in the Rebbetzin's life. She had no children of her own and considered all her people, the Chassidim, to be her children. She was the Rebbe's best friend and most devout partner throughout his life, and she was known for her great kindness, hospitality and modesty, learned in the home of her father, Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn, the Sixth Lubavitcher Rebbe.

Twenty-one is the sum of the first three letters of Hashem's name. It is also the square root of 441, the gematria of Emet, truth, which is G-d's seal.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yaakov: one who walks along a road and studies, and interrupts his studying to say, "How beautiful is this tree!", "How beautiful is this ploughed field!" — the Torah considers it as if he had forfeited his life. That is the fly's song again. The eternal words of the Creator are not to be put down in order to enjoy something passing, or even to exalt His own Creation. The Maggid of Mezritch reads the teaching as being about someone who stops learning in order to reflect on how much he has learned.

This week completes the third cycle of seven, and the combination is Malchut shebeTiferet, kingship within beauty. Malchut is a female sefirah, and the truest feminine beauty is inner beauty: "Kol Kvudah Bat Melech Pnimah," all the glory of the princess is within. One of the last verses of Eshet Chayil, sung before Kiddush on Shabbat night, says the same — "charm is deceitful and beauty is vanity; a woman that is G-d-fearing, she is the one to be praised" — and those are among the last verses of Solomon's Book of Proverbs. King Solomon, who also wrote Ecclesiastes, knew what held permanent value and what was only vanity of vanities. The fly teaches the same lesson, and adds that healing always comes through Him, with no need of intermediaries.

The 22nd of Shevat is also the yahrzeit of Rabbi Menachem Mendel of Kotsk, who was known for cutting through people's flowery, egocentric behaviour and keeping entirely to the truth.

Week 21, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 142 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Jahaziel and "Minimized" Speech

The last week of Shevat. Haazinu answers provocation with provocation: "They have provoked My jealousy with a non G-d, provoked My anger with their vanities. Thus, I will provoke their jealousy with a non people, provoke their anger with a foolish nation." (Deuteronomy 32:21) Read positively, it turns around completely: they have been zealous for Me against a non-G-d and angered for Me against the vanities of the nations, so I will be zealous for them and angry for them in return.

The Haftarah verse says exactly that: "The Lord rewarded me according to my righteousness; According to the cleanness of my hands He recompensed me." (II Samuel 22:21) Zealotry, done rightly, comes out of the depths of faith, as it did in Pinchas and Eliyahu, and the promise is that we will be rewarded for our emunah. Vanities, meanwhile, are a focus on what is not essential — the same thing as "How beautiful is this tree."

So the quality is minimized conversation, miut sichah; idle talk is the standing example of vanity. Conversation distracts and runs on into consequences nobody intended, which is why the sages warn against too much of it, even with one's own wife. But purposeful conversation taken with miut, humility and smallness, is a very good quality. Prayer itself is called conversation — Isaac went to converse in the field — and Rebbe Nachman holds Hitbodedut, conversing with G-d, to be the highest of all levels. Conversation in a field suits this month well.

The prophet is Jahaziel the Levite, and his prophecy is this quality at work. "Hearken, all Judeans, inhabitants of Jerusalem, and King Jehoshaphat, so said the Lord to you: You shall not fear, neither shall you be dismayed because of this great multitude, for the war is not yours but G-d's." And then: "It is not for you to fight in this [war]; set yourselves, stand and see the salvation of the Lord with you, O Judah and Jerusalem; fear not and be not dismayed." The salvation that follows is full of humility, with singing and praise. When we do our part and then step back and let Hashem do the rest, incredible things happen. Sometimes the best thing is to be quiet, as at the splitting of the Sea of Reeds: "The Lord will fight for you, but you shall remain silent." (Exodus 14:14)

The levitical city is Rehob, which means street, from rahav, wide. The near word merchav, wide place, is in last week's Haftarah verse. Called to out of dire straits, He answers broadly, and that is the essence of emunah.

Week 21, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 143 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Isaac and Emunah

The Song of the Sea's verses are first of all a declaration of faith, Emunah, which is this month: "The Lord will reign to all eternity; When Pharaoh's horses came with his chariots and his horsemen into the sea." They hold the elements too — Pharaoh and the horsemen are man, the horses are animal, and the sea is mineral, Domem.

The Haftorah turns to doubt: "(But) among the divisions of Reuben, (there were) great resolves of heart. Why do you sit between the borders." Great resolves and no resolve — that was Reuben's own difficulty. He knew he had to save Joseph and lacked the emunah to do it outright; he knew later that Benjamin had to be brought to Egypt, and again could not carry his father.

Daf Kaf Alef of Sotah keeps on with how the merit of Torah and mitzvoth can protect from punishment, and how a woman can earn merit from Torah — fitting in the week of the Rebbetzin's yahrzeit, the 22nd of Shevat.

The generation is Yitzchak, the second forefather, whose whole life, and above all his near sacrifice, was Emunah. His name comes from Tzchok, laughter: Yitzchak means he will laugh, which is faith in what has not happened yet, and also pleasure, Ta'anug.

The journey is from Mount Shepher to Haradah. Haradah means trembling, and it is tied to the fear the people felt after the plague that followed Korach's rebellion. Trembling also belongs to happiness: "Vegilu b'Readah," rejoice in trembling, and the Talmud says that where there is gilah, rejoicing, there must be trembling. The personal journey takes the beauty and the enjoyment of the last stop and gets ready for the trembling happiness of Adar.

Week 21, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 144 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Malchut (Kingship)

Channah's twenty-first verse is the yearly pilgrimage: "And the man, Elkanah and his entire household, went up to slaughter to the Lord, the sacrifice of the days and his vow." Household, Beitoh, usually means a man's wife — so the verse is there to set up what comes next, that Channah stays behind to nurse Shmuel and will only bring him to the Tabernacle, to live there, once he is weaned.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that the Torah grants him kingship, Malchut, which is a feminine sefirah and receives its energy from the others. The verse says the Torah gives kingship; it is left to us to know how to receive it. And Elkanah goes up out of gratitude.

Proverbs 21 opens on kingship and then turns to the weight a wife carries, here for the worse. "A king's heart is like rivulets of water in the Lord's hand; wherever He wishes, He turns it." "It is better to sit on the corner of a roof than with a quarrelsome wife and the house of a friend." "It is better to dwell in a desert land than [with] a quarrelsome and vexatious wife."

Besides Rebbetzin Chaya Mushka's yahrzeit on the 22nd of Shevat, the week holds Rebbe Menachem Mendel of Kotzk on the same day and Rebbe Yehoshua Rokeach, the Second Rebbe of Belz, son of the Sar Shalom, on the 23rd. The Kotzker was known for immense Torah knowledge reached very young and for an uncompromising pursuit of truth; his sharp, penetrating sayings cut through people's ego and fantasies. Among his students were the first two leaders of Ger, the largest Chassidic group in all of Poland. The 22nd of Shevat is also the yahrzeit of one of his closest disciples, Rabbi Yehuda Leib Eiger of Lublin, grandson of Rabbi Akiva Eiger, and the 21st of Shevat that of another, R. Yechiel Meir Lifschitz of Gostynin, Der Tilim Yid.

Rebbe Yehoshua Rokeach grew the Belz dynasty his father had begun into the largest in Galicia. He fought vigorously against the Haskalah, the Jewish secularist enlightenment movement. He was a tremendous Torah scholar, known also for common sense in his leadership; he moved his followers to study with great devotion and set up programs for newly married men to stay in Yeshiva. Sometimes this week also holds Rav David HaLevi Segal, author of the Turei Zahav, and Rabbi Mordechai

Yosef Elazar Leiner, the Radziner Rebbe, both on the 26th of Shevat.

Week 21, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 145 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Celebrating "Sweet Fruit" in the Winter

The Song calls both winds and then sits down to eat. "Awake, O north wind, and come, O south wind; blow upon my garden, that the spices thereof may flow out; let my beloved come to his garden and eat his sweet fruit." Then the answer: "I have come to my garden, my sister, [my] bride; I have gathered my myrrh with my spice, I have eaten my sugar cane with my sugar, I have drunk my wine with my milk. Eat, friends; drink, yea, drink abundantly, beloved ones." The drinking abundantly may be looking ahead to Adar. And then the verse that is Shevat itself: "I sleep, but my heart is awake. Hark! My beloved is knocking: Open for me, my sister, my beloved, my dove, my perfect one, for my head is full of dew, my locks with the drops of the night." Still the middle of winter, but past Tu B'Shvat, and inside the trees the sap has begun to melt.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twenty-first is Zerach, Perez's brother, whose name means sunrise. At the birth he was the first to put out his hand and the second to be born. Sunrise is like that too: it is the first moment the morning Shmoneh Esreh can be said, and where the day begins, though most people start praying much later. Shevat is the same — the first appearance of spring and the sun, with spring itself a long way off.

Daf Kaf Alef of Shvuot keeps on with the laws of oaths, most of them about eating.

Jeremiah's twenty-first chapter is full of nature — valleys, plains, fruit, a forest. "Behold I am against you, O dweller of the valley, rock of the plain, says the Lord, those who say, 'Who will encamp upon us, and who will come into our dwellings?'" And then: "And I will visit upon you according to the fruit of your deeds, says the Lord, and I will ignite a fire in her forest, and it will consume all her surroundings."

Week 21, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 146 · Book 6 · General Remedy

G-d is our Strength - Psalms 61-63; 59:18, 77:1-3; 89:22

G-d is our strength, in three psalms: the sixty-first, sixty-second and sixty-third, with one verse of Psalm 59, the opening of Psalm 77, and one verse of Psalm 89.

Psalm 61 David composed while fleeing from Saul, and all of it asks for long life — not to pursue the pleasures of the world but to serve G-d in awe, all his days. "From the end of the earth I call to You, when my heart is faint [with trouble]: Lead me upon the rock that surpasses me!" Then the shelter: "I will dwell in Your tent forever; I will take refuge in the shelter of Your wings, Selah." And the asking itself: "Add days to the days of the king; may his years equal those of every generation. May he sit always before G-d; appoint kindness and truth to preserve him."

Psalm 62 prays for the downfall of his enemies and tells his generation not to rest their faith in riches, because piling up wealth is futility. "To G-d alone does my soul hope; my salvation is from Him. He alone is my rock and salvation, my stronghold; I shall not falter greatly." The blessing that is a curse: "with their mouths they bless, and in their hearts they curse, Selah." The weighing: "Men are but vanity; people [but] transients. Were they to be raised upon the scale, they would be lighter than vanity." The warning: "Put not your trust in exploitation, nor place futile hope in robbery. If [corrupt] wealth flourishes, pay it no heed." And the close, one thing heard as two: "G-d spoke one thing, from which I perceived two: That strength belongs to G-d; and that Yours, my Lord, is kindness."

Psalm 63 is from hiding in the Judean desert, yearning toward the place of the Holy Ark like a man thirsty for water. "My soul thirsts for You, my flesh longs for You; [like one] in a desolate and dry land, without water, so [I thirst] to see You in the Sanctuary, to behold Your might and glory. For Your kindness is better than life; my lips shall praise You." Then the nights: "Indeed, I remember You upon my bed; during the watches of the night I meditate upon You." And the holding on: "My soul cleaved to You; Your right hand supported me."

Psalm 59's verse is the strength: "[You are] my strength, to You I will sing, for G-d is my stronghold, the G-d of my kindness." Psalm 77 begins in the night that will not close: "[I raise] my voice to G-d and cry out; [I raise] my voice to G-d and He will listen to me. On the day of my distress, I sought the Lord; my wound oozes at night

and does not abate; my soul refuses to be comforted." And Psalm 89's verse answers it: "It is he whom My hand shall be prepared [to assist]; My arm, too, shall strengthen him."

Week 21, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 147 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Fly is Saying

The fly opens — when Israel is not busying itself with Torah — and the week's books answer around it.

The sea and the provoking first: "When Pharaoh's horses came with his chariots" / "And his horsemen into the sea" / "They have provoked My jealousy with a non-G-d" / "Provoked My anger with their vanities" / "All flesh is grass, and all its grace is as the flower of the field" / "(But) among the divisions of Reuben, (there were) great resolves of heart."

Then the calling out, with the sitting still and the sleeping beside it: "The voice said, 'Call out'. And he said, 'What shall I call out?'" / "Why do you sit between the borders?" / "I sleep, but my heart is awake. Hark! My beloved is knocking" / "My perfect one, for my head is full of dew" / "My locks with the drops of the night" / "My wound oozes at night and does not abate" / "My soul refuses to be comforted."

Then what withers and what does not: "The grass withers, the flower fades" / "But the word of our Lord shall endure forever" / "The Lord will reign to all eternity" / "[You are] my strength, to You I will sing" / "The Lord rewarded me according to my righteousness" / "According to the cleanness of my hands He recompensed me."

Then the healing and the arm: "I will create a new expression of the lips: Peace, peace for him Who is far off and for him who is near, says G-d, and I will heal him" / "It is he whom My hand shall be prepared [to assist]" / "My arm, too, shall strengthen him."

And the end is the garden, with the pilgrimage and the crying out braided through it: "Awake, O north wind, and come, O south wind" / "Blow upon my garden, that the spices thereof may flow out" / "And the man, Elkanah and his entire household, went up to slaughter to the Lord" / "Let my beloved come to his garden and eat his sweet fruit" / "For G-d is my stronghold, the G-d of my kindness" / "I

have come to my garden, my sister, [my] bride" / "I have gathered my myrrh with my spice" / "[I raise] my voice to G-d and cry out" / "I have drunk my wine with my milk" / "On the day of my distress, I sought the Lord" / "Eat, friends; drink, yea, drink abundantly, beloved ones" / "Open for me, my sister, my beloved, my dove."

Week 21, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXII

Chesed of Netzach

Days 148–154

Day 148 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Complement Each Other in Happiness

The Sea Monsters say: "Praise G-d from the land, the sea monsters and all the depths." (Psalms 148:7) This is the week of Rosh Chodesh Adar, whose sign is Pisces, so the water creatures are rightly the ones singing through the four weeks of this month. Adar is the month of Purim, and when it begins we increase in joy. The depths of the song are the deep and hidden miracles He did for us in it.

Adar belongs to the tribe of Naftali, and to the quality of being an emissary, a sheliach. Jacob's blessing calls Naftali an ayalah shlucha, a sent-off gazelle, and he was sent as a messenger more than once. Moses's blessing calls him seva ratzon, satisfied will — and ratzon, will, belongs to keter, the highest of the sefirot, which means crown. Naftali is the only tribe described as a feminine animal, and the crown fits, because the hero of this month is a woman sent on a mission to obtain a crown, Queen Esther. Like her, Naftali stands for self-sacrifice and humility: the tribe was known for its speed and alacrity, and its prince accepted being last to bring an offering at the inauguration of the Tabernacle. Being a sheliach takes enormous nullification before the one who sends you, and tremendous will to see the mission done.

The phrase "Ve'anochi Tola'at ve lo Ish," I am a worm and not a man, belongs here too: Velo Ish has the same numerical value as Sheliach. It comes from Psalm 22 — the same number as this week — whose opening verse holds ayelet hashachar, the gazelle of the morning. The sages teach that ayelet hashachar is the planet Venus, the last star to appear before morning, and Queen Esther, the last prophet to appear before the redemption. Adar is likewise the last month counting from Nissan, and the

prince of Naftali was the last to bring his offering, wrapping up the work of Asher and of all the tribes before him. That is a sheliach's work, and ours: to finish what those before us began.

Adar is the only month often counted twice. Seven times every nineteen years there are two, Adar I and Adar II, and Adar II belongs to the tribe of Levi. The parallels are strong. Like Naftali, the Levites, and the kohanim above all, were known for alacrity and care in the mitzvot, and they served as emissaries for the whole people in the Temple, with tremendous self-sacrifice. There is one more link between Levi and the sea animals of this month: the animals in the sea did not perish in the Flood, and the tribe of Levi was never enslaved by the Egyptians.

So Adar runs on duality. Pisces is two fish facing opposite ways. The Purim story has not one hero but two, Esther and Mordechai. And this is the month of the half-shekel, a contribution to the Temple so that sacrifices could be brought for the whole public — half and not whole, because no Jew is complete alone, and each of us completes the other.

Twenty-two is the number of letters in the Hebrew alphabet. Hashem made the Torah and the world by combining them, so each letter completes the others too; and the Torah starts with beit, which is duality and relationship. The sea monsters hold the same thing. It seems strange that they should sing about praise on land, until you see that they know their own song is not enough by itself.

The other duality of the month is hidden and revealed. The miracle of Purim came through hidden means, and though His hand is more than apparent in the events, the actual name of G-d never appears in the Megillah. Even the name Megillat Esther says it: Megillah is of nigleh, revealed, and Esther of nistar, hidden. In the song, the depths are what is hidden and the land is what is revealed. The song also recalls Jacob's blessing to his two grandchildren, Ephraim and Menashe: "You will multiply like fish in the face of the land." Rabbi Yitzchak Ginsburgh notes that the gematria of Naftali equals the gematria of Ephraim and Menashe.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Dusta'i the son of Rabbi Yannai, in the name of Rabbi Meir: whoever forgets even a single word of this learning, the Torah considers it as if he had forfeited his life, from "Just be careful, and verily guard your soul, lest you forget the things that your eyes have seen." (Deuteronomy 4:9) But the verse continues, "and lest they be removed from your heart," so nobody forfeits his life for

studies that proved too hard — only for deliberately putting them out of his heart. One of the main mitzvot of Adar is remembering what Amalek did and the command to destroy it; forgetting to destroy evil puts our own lives in danger.

The combination is chesed shebenetzach, kindness within victory. The week begins two months of victory and redemption, netzach, which carry Purim and Passover, and we mark the kindness He showed us by being more joyful than usual. The lesson from the sea monsters is that praising G-d by ourselves is not enough — we have to think of those who are distant, as they think of those on land.

Week 22, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 149 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Adar, Eliezer son of Dodavahu, and "Minimized" Laughter

Rosh Chodesh Adar, the month of Naftali and of ratzon, desire. Haazinu burns: "For a fire blazed in My wrath, and burned to the lowest depths. It consumed the land and its produce, setting aflame the foundations of mountains." (Deuteronomy 32:22) Read positively, the wrath is not against Israel but against the foolish nation that attacks it — Amalek. The Hebrew behind "lowest depths" is Sheol, which can also be read as Shaul, the first king, who failed to wipe Amalek out; the anger has burned since. In Adar we read Parashat Zachor and remember to destroy Amalek and everything it stands for. The Purim story sets Mordechai, a descendant of Shaul, against Haman, a descendant of Hagag, king of the Amalekites — and Mordechai wins, and Haman is killed along with his sons.

The Haftarah verse draws the same line twice: "For I have kept the ways of the Lord and have not wickedly departed from [the commandments of] my G-d." (II Samuel 22:22) The good half, "Shamarti Darchei," I have kept the ways, holds the letters of Mordechai. The second half, "Veloh Rashati," have not wickedly, points to Haman, who is called Haman HaRashah — and sounds like the name of Vashti, Achashverosh's wife before Esther.

The quality is minimized laughter, miut schok. Laughter can slide into frivolity and pull a person into the wrong circles. It is not bad in itself — it can open the mind, and there is even a custom, based on the Talmud, of beginning each lesson with a joke — but it has to be held with miut, smallness and humility. That holds for

the whole month, when we are Marbim B'Simcha, and for Purim itself, when it is a mitzvah to get drunk and behave with schok; what has to stay is the intention.

The prophet is Eliezer son of Dodavahu, and his words to King Yehoshaphat are about exactly this care in company. Yehoshaphat was righteous, and at one point he associated himself with King Ahab. The prophet rebuked him and he was punished: the ships he had built with Ahab were broken and could not sail. That is the last event the Tanach records before his death.

The levitical city is Kedesh, also a city of refuge. Its name is from Kadosh, holy, and it is near the word Kiddush, the blessing over wine — which fits the drinking of this month, superficially frivolous and in fact tremendously holy, in some ways holier than Yom Kippur.

Week 22, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 150 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Adar and Ratzon (Will, Desire)

Rosh Chodesh Adar. The Talmud says MisheNichnas Adar Marbim b'Simcha — when Adar enters, we increase in joy. The month belongs to Naftali, the Ayalah Shluchah, the swift gazelle sent out; when there are two Adars the second belongs to Levi, who served, and will serve again, as emissary for the whole people in the Temple.

The Song of the Sea is back in the water: "and the Lord brought the waters of the sea back upon them; and the children of Israel walked on dry land in the midst of the sea." Dry land in the midst of the sea is the same paradox as Jacob's blessing to Efraim and Menashe, that they would increase like fish over the land.

The Haftorah stays with Reuben's doubt: "to hear the bleatings of the flocks? At the divisions of Reuben, (there are) great searchings of heart." Resolve is ratzon, will, and this month is full of it. Naftali is s'vah ratzon, filled with will; Levi was known for determination and self-sacrifice; Reuben's conduct shows neither. Each tribe had a perfectly good excuse for staying out of the fight — they did not share a border with where it happened — and Devorah makes plain that more was expected of them.

The bleating is worth following. The Tanach has a later one, tied tightly to this month, and it belongs not to Reuven the firstborn but to Shaul the first king. Shaul

was commanded to destroy Amalek completely. He did not act with enough Ratzon: he left Amalek's king alive, and the best of the flock. Amalek has the same numerical value as Safek, doubt, which is the opposite of Ratzon. When Shmuel came to reprimand him, Shaul said he had fulfilled the command, and Shmuel asked what, then, was this bleating of flocks he was hearing. The hesitation is the same as Reuven's, a divided heart — and as Reuven is replaced as firstborn, Shaul is replaced as king.

Daf Kaf Beit of Sotah keeps on with the acts that can look pious and end up destroying the world. One of its main discussions is of someone who rules when he is not capable of it, and does not rule when he is. Shaul again: he ruled where he should have obeyed, letting the king and some of the flock live, and did not take his own prominence seriously enough — small in the eyes of the people — and the destruction Amalek still causes came of it.

The generation is Jacob, whose name is from Ekev, heel. A heel treats someone else as the head, which is a messenger's position, and Purim belongs to the people as heel, Ya'akov, rather than head, Yisrael, and to the times of Yikveta d'Meshicha.

The journey is from Haradah to Makheloth. Makheloth means assembly, and in modern Hebrew a choir, a gathering to sing and play. Rabbi Jacobson suggests it may be where the people gathered to see the miracle of Aharon's staff. The personal journey takes last week's trembling happiness further, into unity and into gatherings of singing and dancing.

Week 22, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 151 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Dominion versus Kingship, Royalty

Channah's twenty-second verse is the staying behind: "But Hannah did not go up, for she said to her husband: 'Until the child is weaned, then I shall bring him, and he shall appear before the Lord, and abide there forever.'" The text is careful to say that she told her husband why, which shows her concern for him and a certain subservience — even though she has her way in the end. Adar is the month of Purim, where another woman, Queen Esther, convinces her husband, Achashverosh, to save her people and destroy Haman, who was effectively running the kingdom.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that the Torah grants dominion, Memshalah. It is not kingship, Malchut, because it does not need royalty: one can rule without being king, as Joseph did as viceroy and, LeHavdil, as Haman did. Memshalah is a more masculine power, sheer power and force, where Malchut is the more sublime feminine quality, connected to speech. Both are in the verse, and both are in this month.

Proverbs 22 is about power, mostly economic. "A name is chosen above great wealth; good favor over silver and gold." "A rich man and a poor man were visited upon; the Lord is the Maker of them all." "In the wake of humility comes fear of the Lord, riches, honor, and life." And then: "A rich man will rule over the poor, and a borrower is a slave to a lender." The word for rule there is Yimshol, the same root as Memshalah.

In a year with two months of Adar the yahrzeits are usually kept in the second, unless the person died in the first Adar of a year that also had two — so the descriptions wait for next month, when weeks 22 through 25 come round again.

Week 22, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 152 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Mordechai the Shepherd

The Song undresses and washes: "I have taken off my tunic; how can I put it on? I have bathed my feet; how can I soil them?" Taking off the head garment reads as letting go of the intellect, which belongs to this month, and turning to the feet. The Rebbe's Ma'amar Ve'Atah Tetzaveh speaks of Mordechai, the Moshe of the generation, as the head, and the Jewish people as the feet.

The next verse is almost the two most crucial verses of Megillat Esther: "My beloved stretched forth his hand from the hole, and my insides stirred because of him." Against it: "And it came to pass when the king saw Queen Esther standing in the court, that she won favor in his eyes, and the king extended to Esther the golden scepter that was in his hand, and Esther approached and touched the end of the scepter."

Then the myrrh: "I arose to open for my beloved, and my hands dripped with myrrh, and my fingers with flowing myrrh, upon the handles of the lock." Myrrh is

Mor, and the Talmud says Mordechai is hinted in the Torah at the verse about pure myrrh, Mor Dror, which in Aramaic is Mara Dachia.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twenty-second is Hezron. Hezron comes from chatzer, courtyard or enclosure — and to carry in a courtyard, two neighbours have to set up an eruv chatzeirot. Eruv shares its root with Arev, sweet. When Jews come together and their duality works for the good, there is sweetness, which is this month.

Daf Kaf Beit of Shvuot keeps on with oaths about eating, but its weight falls on the laws of speech, and on whether drinking counts as eating. Drinking is one of the main themes of Adar — drinking to the point of not knowing the difference between blessed is Mordechai and cursed is Haman. The daf opens its discussion of speech with someone who curses Hashem by mistake and must bring a sacrifice.

Jeremiah's twenty-second chapter is a people left leaderless and confused, with eating and drinking through it. "Shall you reign, for you compete with the cedar? Your father-did he not eat and drink and perform justice and righteousness? Then it was well with him." "All your shepherds shall be broken by the wind, and your lovers shall go into captivity." And the end: "O land, land, land, hearken to the word of the Lord."

Week 22, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 153 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the First Week of Adar - Psalms 64-66; 77:4-6; 89:23

The first week of Adar in psalms: the sixty-fourth, sixty-fifth and sixty-sixth, with three verses of Psalm 77 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 64 the masters of homiletics read as Daniel in the lion's den — David foresaw it with divine inspiration and prayed for him, Daniel being a descendant of his. The tongues are the weapon: "who have sharpened their tongue like the sword, aimed their arrow-a bitter word-to shoot at the innocent from hidden places; suddenly they shoot at him, they are not afraid." The hiding: "They sought pretexts; [and when] they completed a diligent search, each man [kept the plot] inside, deep in the heart." And then it turns on them: "But G-d shot at them; [like] a sudden arrow were their blows. Their own tongues caused them to stumble."

Psalm 65 is praise that gives up on praising. “Silence is praise for You, O G-d [Who dwells in] Zion” — because who could recount His mighty acts? Then the rain, which is most of the psalm: “You remember the earth and water it, you enrich it abundantly [from] G-d’s stream filled with water.” “You saturate its furrows, gratifying its legions; with showers You soften it and bless its growth. You crown the year of Your goodness [with rain], and Your clouds drip abundance.” And the fields answering: “The meadows don sheep, and the valleys cloak themselves with grain; they sound blasts, indeed they sing.”

Psalm 66 is the praise we will offer when the exiles are gathered in. “Raise your voices in jubilation to G-d, all the earth!” “Go and see the works of G-d, awesome in His deeds toward mankind. He turned the sea into dry land, and they passed through the river on foot; we rejoiced in Him there.” Then the testing: “For You tested us, O G-d; You refined us as one refining silver. You brought us into prison; You placed a chain upon our loins. You mounted men over our head; we went through fire and water, and You brought us out to abundance.” And the end, which asks to be listened to: “Come listen, all you who fear G-d, and I will relate what He has done for my soul.”

Psalm 77's verses are a man awake all night: “I remember G-d and I stir; I speak and my spirit becomes faint, forever. You held fast the awakenings of my eyes; I throb and I do not speak. I think of days of yore, ancient years.” And Psalm 89's verse is the protection: “No enemy will exact from him, neither will an unjust person afflict him.”

Week 22, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 154 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Giant Sea Creatures Are Saying

The giant sea creatures open, and what they ask for is praise from the other element: “Praise G-d from the land, the giant sea creatures and all the depths.”

Then the fire and the water, one after the other: “For a fire blazed in My wrath, and burned to the lowest depths” / “It consumed the land and its produce, setting aflame the foundations of mountains” / “And the Lord brought the waters of the sea back upon them” / “For I have kept the ways of the Lord and have not wickedly

departed from my G-d" / "And the children of Israel walked on dry land in the midst of the sea."

Then the child left at home, and the forever in both: "But Hannah did not go up, for she said to her husband: Until the child is weaned, then I shall bring him" / "I remember G-d and I stir; I speak and my spirit becomes faint, forever" / "And he shall appear before the Lord, and abide there forever" / "No enemy will exact from him, neither will an unjust person afflict him."

Then the hand through the hole, with the washing and the bleating between: "My beloved stretched forth his hand from the hole, and my insides stirred because of him" / "I have taken off my tunic; how can I put it on?" / "To hear the bleatings of the flocks?" / "I have bathed my feet; how can I soil them?" / "At the divisions of Reuben, (there are) great searchings of heart."

And the end is the myrrh on the lock, and the sleeplessness beside it: "I arose to open for my beloved, and my hands dripped with myrrh" / "You held fast the awakenings of my eyes; I throb and I do not speak" / "And my fingers with flowing myrrh, upon the handles of the lock" / "I think of days of yore, ancient years."

Week 22, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXIII

Gevurah of Netzach

Days 155–161

Day 155 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Be Happy Even Without Knowing Why Things Are the Way They Are

The Leviathan is saying, "Give thanks to G-d for He is good, His kindness endures forever." (Psalms 136:1) This week holds the seventh of Adar, the birthday and the yahrzeit of Moses, Moshe Rabbeinu, who is from the tribe of Levi — and the first three letters of Leviathan spell Levi.

So the Leviathan is Moses. Fish stand for tzadikim, and as the Leviathan is the biggest of all fish, Moses is the greatest of all tzadikim. There is a hidden version of the same thing in the name of his main disciple, Yehoshua Bin Nun: Nun means fish in Aramaic, and a student is considered like a son. The gematria of Nun is fifty, and Moses reached the fiftieth level of holiness when he passed away, which is implied in the name of his burial place, Mount Nevoh — read as Nun Boh, the Nun is in it. The last letter of Leviatan is Nun; exchange the Lamed, thirty, and the Yud, ten, for a Mem, forty, and the word becomes Mavet, death, and Nun — though we say that Moshe Rabbeinu never truly died.

The song itself is well known, repeated many times in Psalm 118: "Hodu l'Hashem Ki Tov Ki l'Olam Chasdoh." Ki Tov, for He is good, is exactly what the Torah says Yocheved saw in her newborn son — she saw Ki Tov, that he was good — which is why one of Moses's names is Tuviah, from Tov. Rashi explains that at his birth his mother saw the house fill with light, and our sages say that is the light which will only be revealed at the end of creation.

Twenty-three is the gematria of ziv, light, radiance. Rabbi Yitzchak Ginsburgh explains that ziv, unlike or, is light shining far from its source. The Leviathan is mysterious and unknown, and will only be fully revealed in the messianic era; what

we understand of it now is negligible, no more than brightness coming from a long way off. We know from Psalm 104:26 and from Midrashim that G-d created it to play with, without knowing what that means, and we know it will be the food served to us in the final redemption.

Ziv is also a biblical name for Iyar. The Torah says it was in the month Ziv that Solomon began to build the Temple, and the Second Temple was begun in Iyar too. Iyar is when we count the omer, and Sefirat Ha'Omer comes from sapir, saphire: in Iyar we work to become radiant like saphire, proper vessels for Him to dwell in. Entering Adar, with Moses's birth and passing in it, we begin on our inner Temple. The Torah reading of this week usually concerns the building of the Tabernacle, and we are still collecting the half-shekel, which went to the Temple's upkeep.

Balance in the world required that the female Leviathan die, and the Leviathan sings about kindness anyway. It knows perfectly well that everything Hashem does is for the good. Moses too showed great kindness, leading the people out of Egypt to receive the Torah at Mount Sinai. And as the largest of the fish, the one closest to G-d, the Leviathan is not content to praise by itself: it commands others to do their part.

The last ma'amar the Rebbe reviewed and edited, Ve'Atah Tetzaveh, was delivered during Adar, and it is about the relationship between Moses and the rest of the people. Tetzaveh means to command, and also to tie or unite — the root of mitzvah. Tetzaveh is the one portion since Moses was introduced in which his name does not appear, said to be a hidden reference to his passing on the 7th of Adar, since the portion is read around then. The connection is so strong that when there are two Adars his yahrzeit is kept in the first, because that is when Tetzaveh is read, even though the main date for a yahrzeit is normally the second.

The Rebbe's stroke was on the 27th of Adar I. Two years later, on that same date in 5754, he suffered another, which led to his passing a few months later. Less than two months before the first one he gave an enigmatic talk about how his late father-in-law, the Previous Rebbe, had not been able to speak clearly in his last years — and said that we all had to take it on ourselves to increase Torah study and Chassidic gatherings to make up for that difficulty, and to do it with happiness. Two months later he was in the same condition.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Chanina the son of Dosa: whoever's fear of sin takes precedence over his wisdom, his wisdom endures, and whoever's wisdom takes precedence over his fear of sin, it does not. Moses showed fear of Hashem from their first meeting at the burning bush. Rabbi Chanina also says that one who is pleasing to his fellow men is pleasing to G-d, and one who is not, is not — which fits Moses too. The Talmud teaches that every day a heavenly voice says, "the entire world is sustained in merit of Chanina my son, yet for Chanina my son, one measure of carobs is enough from Friday to Friday."

The combination is gevurah shebenetzach, discipline and strength within determination and victory. Moses represents netzach, and his death is connected to gevurah. The lesson from the Leviathan is that everything G-d does is for the good, so He can be trusted entirely.

Week 23, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 156 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Hosea and Slowness to Anger (Erech Apayim)

The week of the seventh of Adar, Moshe's birth and his passing. Haazinu keeps on with the loss: "I will link evils upon them. I will use up My arrows on them." (Deuteronomy 32:23) Read positively, it is the gathering up of evil that was over them and the complete destruction of the arrows — Amalek among them — that had been used against the people. Rashi's commentary hints at this: it is the arrows that are diminished, not the Jews.

The Haftorah stays positive: "For all His ordinances were before me; and [as for] His statutes, I did not depart from it." (II Samuel 22:23) The word for before me is Lenegdi, which can also be read Lenegdai, toward those against me — so the commandments are a protection against the attackers.

The quality is slowness to anger, erech apayim, and it belongs to this week, because it was through Moshe's pleading for the people that G-d revealed this quality of His, one of the thirteen attributes of mercy. In that plea Moshe said that if G-d would not forgive them, "erase me from Your book" — and because of it his name does not appear in Tetzaveh, read in the week of his yahrzeit. And it was a relative lack of this attribute, at his own level, which we cannot fathom, that led him to

castigate the people and strike the rock instead of speaking to it, and so kept him from entering the Land of Israel.

The prophet is Hosea, whose prophecies turn on G-d's unending mercy and slowness to anger, and His love for the people despite their sins.

The levitical city is Hamoth-Dor, the springs of Dor. Hamoth shares a root with Hamath, anger. Springs are heat contained: the springs of Tiberias are said to come from an opening in the gates of Gehinnom made at the time of the Flood — an opening that came out of anger and was then contained and put to good use. And Dar is from the word for home, a domesticated anger.

Week 23, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 157 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Being an Emissary

Zayin Adar, Moshe Rabbeinu's birthday and yahrzeit. Just as Zayin Adar usually falls on Tetzaveh, where his name is left out, his name is left out of the verses after the Song of the Sea as well: "Miriam, the prophetess, Aaron's sister, took a timbrel in her hand, and all the women came out after her with timbrels and with dances. And Miriam called out to them, Sing to the Lord, for very exalted is He; a horse and its rider He cast into the sea." It is her turn to lead now, and she is called Aaron's sister, not Moshe's — a sheliach again, a shluchah in this case.

The Haftorah rebukes two more: "Gilead abides beyond the Jordan; and Dan, why does he gather into the ships?" There is a division inside Menashe here — Machir went to the war and Gilead stayed. Dan's choice looks worse still, because it is the reverse of the Sea of Reeds: there the people went into the sea and turned it into land and so beat their enemy, and here Dan leaves the land to take refuge in the sea. That is the opposite of a sheliach, who gives himself up for something larger.

Daf Kaf Gimmel of Sotah takes up when a Mincha offering is disqualified, and then mostly the differences between men and women in the laws of priesthood and sacrifices. The parallel is that there are things a woman can do in a man's place, as Miriam did, and others she cannot, or does differently.

The generation is Yehudah, leader of his brothers, the lion, the king of the tribes. His name comes from Hoda'ah, acknowledgement: his brothers acknowledge him

and act according to his will, on his behalf, like shluchim. And Yehudah was himself an emissary for Jacob, sent to Egypt ahead of the others to found a Yeshiva, a dwelling place for Torah in exile.

The journey is from Makheloth to Tahath. Tahath means bottom, a low point, as Moshe's passing was. It also holds the chance of rising. Rabbi Simon Jacobson puts it this way: Tachath is also the depths we fall to when we leave Mak'heloth, forsaking unity; and we can turn Tachath into a place of peace, when each of us dwells beneath — tachath — our vine and fig tree. It belongs with the idea that Hashem made the world because He desired a Dira Ba'Tachtonim, a dwelling place in the lower realms. The personal journey is unity and joy in a place where the focus is on those around Moses rather than on Moses himself, and from there, making that dwelling place below out of a situation of spiritual lowliness — which is the story of Purim, and the sacrifices Esther made.

Week 23, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 158 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Coming to a Good Decision

Channah's twenty-third verse is her husband letting her decide: "And Elkanah her husband said to her: 'Do what seems good to you. Stay until you have weaned him, only, may the Lord fulfill His word.' And the woman stayed and nursed her son, until she weaned him."

Which word? Rashi gives two answers. By the simple reading: you asked of Him seed of righteous men, and Eli announced to you through divine inspiration that the God of Israel will grant your request — may the Lord fulfill His word. The Midrash Agadah gives another. Rabbi Nehemiah said in the name of Rabbi Samuel, the son of Rabbi Isaac, that every day a divine voice would resound through the world saying that a righteous man was destined to arise and his name would be Samuel; so every woman who bore a son named him Samuel, and as soon as they saw his deeds they said, this is not Samuel. When our Samuel was born and people saw his deeds, they said it seems that this one is the expected righteous man. That is what Elkanah was praying for. There is a clear parallel with Moshe Rabbeinu, the expected redeemer.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that the Torah grants jurisprudence, Chikur Din — investigating a matter in order to reach the right decision. In the verse, Elkanah hands the decision to Channah: do what seems good to you. It sits well with this week's combination, Gevurah shebeNetzach.

Proverbs 23 is jurisprudence, and keeps last week's rulership going. "If you sit down to dine with a ruler, you should understand well who is in front of you." "Bring your heart to discipline and your ears to words of knowledge." "Hear you, my son, and grow wise, and walk in the way of your heart."

As last week, in a year with two months of Adar the yahrzeits are usually kept in the second, so the descriptions wait for next month, when weeks 22 through 25 come round again.

Week 23, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 159 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

When Hashem and our Leaders Are Hidden

The Song opens the door and finds nobody: "I opened for my beloved, but my beloved had hidden and was gone; my soul went out when he spoke; I sought him, but found him not; I called him, but he did not answer me." Then the beating: "The watchmen who patrol the city found me; they smote me and wounded me; the watchmen of the walls took my jewelry off me." And then the asking: "I adjure you, O daughters of Jerusalem, if you find my beloved, what will you tell him? That I am lovesick."

Looking and not finding, calling and getting no answer, being smitten and wounded — all of it may be the loss of Moshe. The hiddenness is also Hester Panim, when His face is hidden, which is the Purim story. Rashi, on that third verse, refers directly to Mordechai's generation in the days of Haman, and how the people kept the Torah through all the suffering. That is the message of Adar. Our sages teach that Mordechai in his generation was like Moshe in his.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twenty-third is Hamul, whose name looks to come from Chemlah, pity, mercy. Hamul would be one who is dealt with mercifully — as Moshe was at his birth.

Daf Kaf Gimmel of Shvuot keeps on with whether drinking belongs to eating, and much of it is about wine and intoxicating drink. It also takes up combining many oaths into one, and then an oath not to eat forbidden food. One of the great points of contention in the Purim story was eating at Achashverosh's meal.

Jeremiah's twenty-third chapter is a people left without a proper shepherd, and then Mashiach, who will be like Moshe: "Behold, days are coming, says the Lord, when I will set up of David a righteous shoot, and he shall reign a king and prosper, and he shall perform judgment and righteousness in the land." The future redemption will be like the one from Egypt and larger: they shall no longer say, "As the Lord lives, Who brought up the children of Israel from the land of Egypt," but, "As the Lord lives, Who brought up and Who brought the seed of the house of Israel from the northland and from all the lands where I have driven them." And the prophet himself, drunk without wine: "Because of the prophets my heart is broken within me, my bones shake, I was like a drunken man and like a man whom wine has overcome, because of the Lord and because of His holy words."

Week 23, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 160 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second Week of Adar - Psalms 67-69; 77:7-9; 89:24

The second week of Adar in psalms: the sixty-seventh, sixty-eighth and sixty-ninth, with three verses of Psalm 77 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 67 is known as an especially revered prayer. It speaks of the ingathering of the exiles and the wars of Gog and Magog, a time when the Lord will be One. "May G-d be gracious to us and bless us; may He make His countenance shine upon us forever, that Your way be known on earth, Your salvation among all nations." It is short and all of it is the nations joining in: "The nations will rejoice and sing for joy, for You will judge the peoples justly and guide the nations on earth forever."

Psalm 68 David composed about a future event — Sennacherib surrounding Jerusalem on Passover in the reign of Hezekiah — and about the good of the Messianic era. "Let G-d rise, let His enemies be scattered." Then the One who takes in whoever has nobody: "A father of orphans and judge of widows is G-d, in the abode of His holiness. G-d settles the solitary into a home, and frees those bound in

shackles." Then Sinai: "the earth trembled, even the heavens dripped before the presence of G-d; this mountain of Sinai [trembled] before the presence of G-d, the G-d of Israel." The dove: "[you will be like] wings of a dove covered with silver, her pinions with brilliant gold." The chosen mountain: "Why do you prance, O mountains of peaks? This is the mountain G-d has desired as His dwelling." And the procession, with the tribes in it: "The singers began, then the musicians, in the midst of the maidens playing timbrels." "There Benjamin, the youngest, rules them; the princes of Judah stone them, [as do] the princes of Zebulun, and the princes of Naphtali."

Psalm 69 is a man going under. "Deliver me, O G-d, for the waters have reached until my soul! I have sunk in muddy depths without foothold; I have come into deep waters, and the current sweeps me away." The hatred without cause: "More numerous than the hairs on my head are those who hate me without reason." The loneliness of it: "I have become a stranger to my brothers, an alien to my mother's sons, for the envy of Your House has consumed me." The mockery: "Those who sit by the gate speak of me, and [of me] are the songs of drunkards." Then the asking: "Rescue me from the mire, so that I not sink." "Do not hide Your face from Your servant, for I am in distress-hurry to answer me." The comfort that never came: "I longed for comfort, but there was none; for consolers, but I did not find. They put gall into my food, and for my thirst they gave me vinegar to drink." And then the turn at the end: "I will praise the Name of G-d with song, I will extol Him with thanksgiving!" "For the Lord listens to the needy, and He does not despise His prisoners."

Psalm 77's verses are the night questions: "During the night I recall my music, I meditate with my heart, and my spirit searches: Is it for eternity that my Lord forsakes [me], nevermore to be appeased? Has His kindness ceased forever? Has He sealed the decree for all generations?" And Psalm 89's verse is the answer in force: "And I will crush his adversaries before him, and will strike down those who hate him." Crushing recalls the first lines of Tetzaveh, which speak of crushed, Catit, oil, and the striking down looks like Amalek. The Tikkun HaKlali verses belong to the loss of Moshe.

Week 23, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 161 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Leviathan is Saying

The Leviathan opens on a door opened to nobody, and the week's books come in around it.

The hiding first, with the questions underneath: "I opened for my beloved" / "But my beloved had hidden and was gone" / "Is it for eternity that my Lord forsakes me?" / "Nevermore to be appeased?" / "Give thanks to the Lord, for He is good" / "For His kindness is eternal."

Then the sea, and the music recalled at night: "Sing to the Lord, for exalted is He" / "Horse and rider He cast into the sea" / "During the night I recall my music, I meditate with my heart and my spirit searches" / "My soul went out when he spoke, I sought him, but found him not" / "Has His kindness ceased forever?" / "Has He sealed the decree for all generations?"

Then the keeping of the ordinances, and the watchmen: "For all His ordinances were before me" / "And as for His statutes I did not depart from them" / "The watchmen who patrol the city found me" / "They smote me and wounded me" / "I will link evils upon them, I will use up my arrows on them" / "The watchmen of the walls took my jewelry off me" / "And I will crush his adversaries before him" / "And will strike down those who hate him" / "Only may the Lord fulfill His word."

Then the two who would not come, and the lovesickness: "Gilead abides beyond the Jordan" / "And Dan, why does he gather into ships?" / "I adjure you, O daughters of Jerusalem, if you find my beloved, what will you tell him?" / "I called him, but he did not answer me."

And the end is the household and the timbrel: "And Elkanah, her husband said to her, Do what seems good to you" / "Stay until you have weaned him" / "For I am lovesick" / "Miriam, the prophetess, Aaron's sister, took a timbrel in her hand" / "And the woman stayed and nursed her son until she weaned him."

Week 23, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXIV

Tiferet of Netzach

Days 162–168

Day 162 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Live Above Our Worldly Concerns

The fish are saying: "The voice of G-d is upon the waters, the G-d of glory thunders; G-d is upon many waters." (Psalms 29:3) This is the week of Purim, when we remember that Hashem is with us through everything, even if sometimes hidden. Purim is the salvation of the Persian exile, when Haman, with the King's support at first, sought to exterminate the whole people, and through Mordechai and Esther the decree was annulled and Haman, his sons and the enemies of the Jews were the ones killed.

The Zohar says that Yom Kippur, Yom haKippurim, is a day that is KePurim, like Purim — so Purim is higher. If on Yom Kippur we stand at the level of angels, then on Purim we must stand higher than angels, at the level of tzadikim; and fish, as last week, stand for tzadikim.

On Purim we drink many waters in order to come closer, trying to reach ad deloyadah, not knowing the difference between blessed be Mordechai and cursed be Haman. It is in many ways the experience of the four rabbis who entered the Pardes, where Rabbi Akiva said, "When you reach the stones of pure marble, do not say: 'Water, water.'" On Purim we see that there are no divisions on high, that all is One, and that there is no difference between what we take for good and what we take for evil. At those levels the desire to cleave to Him pulls like great waves, out of this world; the voice thunders as at Mount Sinai, and we want to nullify ourselves entirely — ratzo. To survive it we have to do as Rabbi Akiva did and enter in peace and return in peace, understanding that His desire is that we come back and make a dwelling place for Him here — shov.

The song says the voice, and He Himself, are above the waters. But the fish are not above the waters; they are inside them. Even they need emissaries in order to perceive Him fully. Shlichut runs all through the Purim story: Esther is Mordechai's emissary and he is hers, and their messages went through shluchim. So on Purim we give each other mishloach manot, from the word sheliach, preferably through a third person.

Many waters is in the Song of Songs too, where King Solomon writes that many waters cannot extinguish the love. The many waters are the difficulties and turbulences of making a living, which however great cannot put out a Jew's love for G-d.

The Hebrew for fish is dag. Rabbi Yitzchak Ginsburgh explains that fish are the rectification of worry, da'agah, especially about a livelihood. In the time of Nehemiah certain Jews desecrated the Sabbath by selling fish in the market of Jerusalem, not trusting Him for their living: the dag became da'ag, excessive concern. Fish are always aware of their dependence on water, which is more tangible than air — and so always aware of the Source of their existence.

Twenty-four is the twenty-four presents of the kohanim, of the tribe of Levi, and the priesthood was later divided into twenty-four watches. Caf and dalet spell kad, a jar: the famous kad of Chanukah, which held pure oil with the seal of the Kohen Gadol and lasted eight days instead of one. Even the impurity and turbulence of the Hellenistic period did not put out the people's love, and they came out of the struggle with the Greeks purer than before, with redoubled faith. Purim's link to the kohanim is strong too. Esther has to fast and enter the King's chamber to ask for her people's life, much as the Kohen Gadol on Yom Kippur. The Mishnah calls the Kohen Gadol a sheliach Hashem, and he also served as an emissary of the people; Esther was both at once. The kohen is also called malach Hashem, a messenger, literally an angel.

Purim carries two kinds of pairing. Mordechai, of the tribe of Benjamin, of King Shaul, and Haman, a descendant of Amalek, are polar opposites. Esther and Mordechai complete each other for the good, where Haman and Achashverosh completed each other for evil.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Dosa the son of Hurkinas: morning sleep, noontime wine, children's talk and sitting at the meeting places of the ignorant drive a person from the world. Every one of them is encouraged on Purim. There are two ways to reach ad deloyada, sleeping or drinking during the day. The Purim story turns on the words of

children studying Torah, which is where the redemption came from. And on Purim we press our unity and make no distinction between rich and poor, in money or in Torah: mishloach manot, gifts to the poor, everyone at one feast. All of it takes us out of this world of illusion — olam, world, from he'elem, hidden — and into higher levels of reality.

The combination is tiferet shebenetzach, beauty and balance within persistence and determination, which is Esther and Mordechai exactly. The lesson from the fish is that material concerns must not eat into our trust in Him.

Week 24, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 163 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Amos and a "Good Heart"

The week of Purim. Haazinu's verse is as grim as they come: "They will sprout hair from famine, attacked by demons, excised by Meriri. I will incite the teeth of livestock upon them, with the venom of creatures that slither in the dust." (Deuteronomy 32:24) The simple positive reading turns it on Amalek. But the second half can be read positively of the Jewish people themselves. "Shen Behemoth Eshalach Bam Im Chamat Zochalei Afar" can be the mitzvoth of Purim: sleep, sheinah; eating a meal and providing one for the needy, behemoth, animals; messenger gifts, mishloach manot, eshalach bam; and drinking the venom of those who lie in the dust, chamat zochalei afar, the drunkards. Wine as venom is in Chabakuk: "Woe to him who gives his friend to drink, who adds Your venom and also makes him drunk in order to gaze upon their nakedness."

The Haftarah asks to be tamim, pure, here translated single-hearted: "And I was single-hearted toward Him, and I kept myself from my iniquity." (II Samuel 22:24) The whole difference between the Jewish people and Amalek comes down to this. Our sages explain that Amalek's essence is instilling doubt in Israel's faith — Amalek has the numerical value of Safek, doubt — and the way to win is to be tamim with G-d, to act with simplicity. That is also the test inside the mitzvah of drinking: when the mind is not fully in control and the truth of a personality comes out, is a person still devoted, and still clear of lewd and improper behaviour.

So the quality is a good heart, lev tov. Purim is all about the heart; the intellect is nullified with wine and the true emotions come out. Wine goes with the heart directly — wine gladdens the heart of the human being — and most explicitly at the start of the Megillah itself: "On the seventh day, when the heart of the king was good with wine, kitov lev bayayin." (Esther, 1:10)

The prophet is Amos, whose prophecy defines what a good heart is: "Seek good and not evil in order that you live, and so the Lord G-d of Hosts shall be with you, as you said. Hate evil and love good, and establish justice in the gate; perhaps the Lord G-d of Hosts will be gracious to the remnant of Joseph."

The levitical city is Kartan, apparently short for Kiriataim, two cities. Adar runs on duality, and the heart has its own: a good inclination and a bad one. On Purim both are meant to serve G-d, with the intellect out of the centre of the work.

Week 24, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 164 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Peretz and the Power of Joy

Just after the Song of the Sea, there is no water. "Moses led Israel away from the Red Sea, and they went out into the desert of Shur; they walked for three days in the desert but did not find water. They came to Marah, but they could not drink water from Marah because it was bitter; therefore, it was named Marah." Our sages teach that water in the Torah always means Torah. Purim is the same situation — and the fast of Esther is three days without food or drink — with Hashem hidden and the people's lives embittered and threatened by Haman. Their answer was to reaffirm their belief and receive the Torah again.

The Haftorah turns to Asher, who also stayed out: "Asher dwelt at the shore of the seas, and by his breaches he abides." The word for his breaches is mifratzav, the root of Peretz, this week's generation. Rashi explains that Asher was worried about the parts of its land open to attack. Like the tribes before him, Asher's answer to the fight was to protect himself — and the whole idea of Adar is being willing to give yourself up for someone else.

Daf Kaf Dalet of Sotah is cases of women who do not drink, often for extenuating circumstances. Esther is the perfect example. The Midrash says she was married to

Mordechai before Achashverosh, and even the plain reading is a problem because Achashverosh was not Jewish; it is hard to imagine greater extenuating circumstances than the days of the Purim miracle. She was in a certain way forced into the marriage, and her actions saved the entire people.

Peretz is one of the twin sons of Yehudah and Tamar. He burst out of the womb first and so took the firstborn's right, which had looked like going to his brother Zerach. Tamar's whole story has the theme Esther's has, and Yael's later in the Song of Devorah: that under extenuating circumstances acts which would otherwise deserve severe punishment are counted righteous. Peretz is from Lifrotz, to breach a fence or boundary, which can go either way — hence two sayings in our tradition: "Poretz Geder Yishchenu Nachash," one who breaks boundaries is bitten by a snake, and "Simchah Poretzet Geder," happiness breaks boundaries. Mashiach is also known as HaPoretz. That is the happiness of Purim and of the redemption, which turns darkness into light.

The journey is from Tahath to Tarah. Tarah is spelled like Terach, Avraham's father, and Terach comes from smell — and the Purim story has much to do with smell, which is very spiritual, and was the one element not used at Achashverosh's party. Rabbi Jacobson explains that Terach also means wild goat and old fool, which is the behaviour of Purim, brought onto the path of holiness. The personal journey moves from making a dwelling place below out of spiritual lowliness, to lifting our surroundings through holy foolish behaviour.

Week 24, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 165 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

"When Wine Comes in Secrets Come Out"

Channah's twenty-fourth verse brings the child: "And she brought him with her when she had weaned him, with three bulls, and one ephah of meal, and an earthenware jug of wine, and she brought him to the house of the Lord, to Shiloh, and the child was young." The first word of what she brings is Parim, bulls, spelled the same as Purim. And there is a jug of wine in it.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that the Torah's secrets are revealed to him. The Talmud famously says "Nichnas Yayin Yotzeh Sod," when wine enters, secrets come

out, which usually means something bad. On Purim it is good: when one drinks, the secrets of Torah are revealed.

Proverbs 24 is mostly about fighting evil, and it reads like the pair of phrases a person is meant to stop telling apart. “Do not envy men of evil; do not desire to be with them; for their heart thinks of plunder, and their lips speak of wrongdoing.” “Wicked man, do not lurk by the dwelling of a righteous man; do not plunder his resting place. For a righteous man can fall seven times and rise, but the wicked shall stumble upon evil.” “When your enemy falls, do not rejoice, and when he stumbles, let your heart not exult.” And: “He who says to a wicked man, 'You are righteous'-peoples will curse him; nations will be wroth with him.”

Its ending is another practice that is bad all year and good on this one day — sleeping in the daytime. “And I, myself, saw; I applied my heart; I saw and learned a lesson. Little sleep, little slumber, little clasping of the hands to lie down. Then your poverty will come strolling and your wants like an armed man.” Which is Pirkei Avot for this week almost word for word: morning sleep, noontime wine, children’s talk and sitting at the meeting places of the ignorant, drive a person from the world.

As before, in a year with two months of Adar the yahrzeits are usually kept in the second, so the descriptions wait for next month, when weeks 22 through 25 come round again.

Week 24, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 166 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

the Intoxicating Power of Food and Drink

The Song is asked what is so special about him, and answers. “What is your beloved more than another beloved, O fairest of women? What is your beloved more than another beloved, that you have so adjured us?” Then: “My beloved is white and ruddy, surrounded by myriads. His head is as the finest gold; his locks are curled, [they are as] black as a raven.” The fairest of women is likely Queen Esther, chosen above all the women of the Persian Empire, and white and ruddy looks like the wine of Purim.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twenty-fourth is Issachar, conceived on the night Rachel exchanged for the dudayim of Leah. The intoxicating nature of the dudayim runs parallel to the intensity of Purim, which also arrives

through physical intoxication.

Daf Kaf Dalet of Shvuot keeps on with forbidden foods, and how one act of eating can break more than one law. One of the great points of contention in the Purim story was that the Jews ate at Achashverosh's festive meal.

Jeremiah's twenty-fourth chapter has duda'ey te'enim, translated pots of figs, literally dudayim of figs. "The Lord showed me two pots of figs, prepared before the Temple of the Lord after Nebuchadrezzar, king of Babylon, had exiled Jeconiah son of Jehoiakim king of Judah and the princes of Judah and the craftsmen and the sentries of the gates from Jerusalem and brought them to Babylon. One pot [contained] very good figs like the first ripe figs, and the other pot [contained] very bad figs that could not be eaten because they were so bad." Some could be eaten, some not at all — the very good and the very bad, which is Adar. The vision is about those who went willingly into exile in Babylon and those who stubbornly stayed in the Land of Israel. And its end sounds like Haazinu's verse for this week: "And I will send forth the sword, the famine, and the pestilence against them until they are consumed from upon the land that I gave them and their forefathers."

Week 24, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 167 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Adar - Psalms 70-72; 77:10-12; 89:25

The third week of Adar in psalms: the seventieth, seventy-first and seventy-second, with three verses of Psalm 77 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 70 is short and urgent, a prayer that his enemies be shamed for shaming him and reveling in his troubles, and that the righteous then rejoice. "O G-d, [come] to rescue me; O Lord, hurry to my aid." "Let those who say, 'Aha! Aha!' be turned back in return for their shaming [me]." And the last line, which does not stop asking: "But I am poor and needy; hurry to me, O G-d! You are my help and deliverer; O G-d, do not delay!"

Psalm 71 is an old man's prayer, with his enemies declaring him deserving of death. It starts from the beginning of his life: "For You are my hope, O my Lord, G-d, my security since my youth. I have relied on You from the womb; You drew me from my mother's innards; my praise is of You always." Then the fear of the end: "Do not

cast me aside in old age; do not forsake me when my strength fails; for my enemies say of me, and those who watch my soul conspire together, saying, 'G-d has forsaken him. Give chase and catch him, for there is no rescuer.'" He asks for time to finish the telling: "Even into old age and hoariness, O G-d, do not abandon me, until I tell of Your might to the generations, and of Your strength to all who are to come." And the reviving: "You, Who has shown me many and grievous troubles, You will revive me again; You will lift me again from the depths of the earth."

Psalm 72 David composed for Solomon, praying that he be granted the wisdom to provide justice for the poor. "O G-d, impart Your justice to the king, and Your righteousness to the son of the king. May he judge Your people with righteousness, Your poor with justice." The rain: "May [his words] descend like rain upon cut grass, like raindrops that water the earth." The reach: "And may he rule from sea to sea, and from the river until the ends of the earth." And what the kingship is for: "for he rescues the needy one who cries out, the poor one who has no one to help him. He pities the impoverished and needy, and saves the souls of the destitute. He redeems their soul from deception and violence, and their blood is precious in his eyes." It ends the second book of psalms: "Blessed is His glorious Name forever, and may the whole earth be filled with His glory, Amen and Amen. The prayers of David, son of Jesse, are concluded."

Psalm 77's verses keep asking through the night and then turn: "Has G-d forgotten mercy? Has He in anger restrained His compassion forever? I said, 'It is to terrify me that the right hand of the Most High changes.' I remember the deeds of Yah, when I remember Your wonders of long ago." And Psalm 89's verse answers: "Indeed, My faithfulness and My kindness shall be with him, and through My Name his glory shall be exalted."

Week 24, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 168 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Fish Are Saying

The fish open on the voice above the water, and the week comes in around them.

The sea and the leaving of it first, with the terror in the middle: "The voice of G-d is upon the waters" / "Asher dwelt at the shore of the seas" / "Moses led Israel away

from the Red Sea" / "And they went out into the desert of Shur" / "I said, 'It is to terrify me that the right hand of the Most High changes'" / "Has G-d forgotten mercy? Has He in anger restrained His compassion forever?" / "Indeed, My faithfulness and My kindness shall be with him" / "And I was single-hearted toward Him and I kept myself from my iniquity."

Then the bitter water, with the famine braided through it: "They came to Marah, but they could not drink water from Marah" / "Because it was bitter" / "Therefore, it was named Marah" / "They will sprout hair from famine" / "Attacked by demons, excised by Meriri" / "They walked for three days in the desert but did not find water" / "I will incite the teeth of livestock upon them" / "The G-d of glory thunders; G-d is upon many waters."

Then the glory and the remembering: "And through my name his glory shall be exalted" / "I remember the deeds of Yah" / "When I remember your wonders of long ago."

Then what was carried to Shiloh, and the venom beside it: "With three bulls, and one ephah of meal, and an earthenware jug of wine" / "With the venom of creatures that slither in the dust" / "My beloved is white and ruddy, surrounded by myriads" / "His head is as the finest gold" / "His locks are curled, black as a raven."

And the end is the child and the question: "And she brought him to the house of the Lord, to Shiloh" / "And the child was young" / "What is your beloved more than another beloved, O fairest of women?" / "What is your beloved more than another beloved, that you have so adjured us?" / "And she brought him with her when she had weaned him" / "And by his breaches he abides."

Week 24, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXV

Netzach of Netzach

Days 169–175

Day 169 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Have Self-Sacrifice in order to Fulfill Our Mission in Life

The frog is saying, "Blessed is the Name of the honor of His Kingdom for all eternity." (Talmud, Pesachim 56a) Its song is said every day, at least twice a day, because it is part of the Shemah — Baruch Shem Kevod Malchuto L'Olam Va'ed — in which we accept His kingship and His commandments with great self-sacrifice.

This week is the yahrzeit of Rebbe Elimelech of Lizhensk, who exemplified exactly that. One of his main meditative techniques was to imagine throwing himself into a great pillar of fire to sanctify G-d's name, so that everything else he did that day would be done at the same level.

The frog appears in the introduction to Perek Shirah in a story of self-sacrifice. The second plague was frogs, and they jumped into the ovens of the Egyptians, giving up their lives without hesitation. That later inspired Chananya, Misha'el and Azariah, who refused to bow to an idol knowing they would be thrown into a burning furnace, and came out of it unscathed. The plague answered what the taskmasters had done: they worked the people so hard in the open sun that there was no time to eat or drink and they were left dehydrated. Frogs are water creatures whose bodies absorb moisture, and the Midrash teaches that during the plague a vast number of frogs sought out and absorbed all the moisture in Egypt, so the Egyptians felt dehydrated too. Water is a metaphor for Torah, and a sheliach's work is to find the Torah and the holy sparks of the Diaspora and absorb and elevate them, searching even in the driest places. We are all emissaries.

Perek Shirah explains that the frog, as an amphibian, does what no other animal does: it voluntarily serves as food for a land animal that feeds only on water animals.

With water as Torah, the frog gives up its life to bring Torah to the animals on dry land. It tells King David that because of this, Hashem will make it whole, will complement it — each Jew completing the other, like the half-shekel of this month. And in Perek Shirah itself the frog joins land and sea again: it comes after the fish and before the sheep and goat, the link between the water animals of Adar and the land animals of Nissan.

The week of the frog always falls after Purim and close to the reading of Parah, which is about purifying a person from the greatest source of impurity, contact with the dead. The kohen who performs that purification sacrifices himself by becoming impure in the process, temporarily. Queen Esther does the same, making herself impure by marrying Achashverosh in order to save the whole people. Purim and Parah have very similar roots.

That double role — superficially negative, in fact extremely positive — is in Baruch Shem Kevod itself. The Talmud in Pessachim suggests the verse is somehow embarrassing to say out loud, which is why we say it quietly, and some authorities hold it to be a lower form of declaring His unity. But many famous commentaries teach the opposite: that it is far higher, said by the angels themselves, and we say it quietly only because it is too lofty for this world. The one day we say it openly is Yom Kippur, when we are all at the level of angels — and angels are emissaries.

There is a famous Midrash that the plague began as a single giant frog, and that when the Egyptians struck it, it multiplied into many smaller frogs, who split again, like the giant frog's emissaries. Rebbe Elimelech is known as a Rebbe of Rebbes, because the most prominent Polish Rebbes were his disciples or their disciples, all of them like emissaries continuing his legacy: the Chozeh of Lublin, who would thank G-d an hour a day for bringing down the soul of his Rebbe, the Ohev Yisrael, the Rimanover, the Maggid of Kozhnitz, and others. Rebbe Tzvi Elimelech of Dinov, the Bnei Issachar, was his nephew.

The frog also tells King David, "Every song I say contains three thousand parables." A parable brings an idea down so that others can reach it, so the frog has three thousand emissaries attached to its song. At his passing the Lubavitcher Rebbe had roughly three thousand emissaries, and there are roughly three thousand Chabad centres today. The number appears after the golden calf as well: Moses stood in the gate and said, "Whoever is for the Lord, [let him come] to me!", and all the sons of

Levi gathered to him, and that day some three thousand men fell. The Levites acted with extreme self-sacrifice and did not consider brother or friend — right at the time, and perhaps still in need of a tikkun. The Chabad shluchim treat everyone as a brother and friend, and they too fall from a pure and holy way of living in order to reach people who need guidance. Three thousand halachot were also forgotten during the mourning for Moses, and perhaps the three thousand shluchim who study the Rebbe's words are a tikkun for that.

Roughly three thousand appears in Samson's story too. The house was full, all the lords of the Philistines were there, and on the roof about three thousand men and women watched his sport; and Samson said, "Let my soul die with the Philistines," and bent with his might, and the house fell, and the dead he killed at his death were more than he had killed in his lifetime. Like the kohen of the red heifer and like Esther, he was willing to sacrifice himself, spiritually and physically, to bring redemption. There is even a hint of Purim in it: the Hebrew for on the roof is "Al haGag," which in Aramaic would be "Agag" — and Haman descended from Agag, king of the Amalekites. At the end of the Purim story, besides Haman and his sons, 75,000 Amalekites are killed, which is twenty-five times three thousand.

Twenty-five belongs to Chanukah, which fell on the twenty-fifth of Kislev, and the word Chanukah itself means Chanu, they rested, and Kah, twenty-five. The twenty-fifth letter in the Torah is or, light. The Chashmonaim held the double role of kohanim and kings. And Rebbe Elimelech, whose name means G-d is my King, had a strong complementary bond with his saintly brother, the Tzadik Reb Zusya of Anipoli.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Elazar of Modi'in: one who profanes the kodashim, degrades the Festivals, humiliates his friend in public, abrogates the covenant of our father Abraham, or interprets the Torah contrary to its true intent, has no share in the World to Come, even with Torah knowledge and good deeds. Just after Purim we begin preparing for Passover — the Shulchan Aruch says to begin thirty days before — and the days of giving Maot Chitim, money so the poor can celebrate it properly. The five faults line up with those preparations. Profaning the holy is the Passover sacrifice, whose meat was sacred and had to be treated properly. Degrading the festivals is Passover itself, in its physical preparations, destroying the chametz, and its spiritual ones, clearing out egotism and inflated self-importance. Humiliating a

neighbour publicly is why the charity goes out in advance, so that nobody has to beg in order to celebrate. The covenant of Abraham is circumcision: it was on Passover that the angels visited him and Sarah and he gave them matzot; all the men were circumcised just before the first Passover in Egypt, and Joshua had all the men circumcised again before entering Israel after the years in the desert, during which none were; and in the days of the Temple the uncircumcised could not eat the Passover sacrifice. Interpreting the Torah against its true meaning is the rulings people reach while cleaning: it is easy to ask whether Torah law does not simply require nullifying the chametz verbally, when the point is to hold to the letter and the spirit both, each at his own level.

The same list fits the time of Chanukah. The Greeks defiled the sacred objects of the Temple and opposed the sacred dates, Shabbat and Rosh Chodesh. The Hellenistic Jews had no shame and fought naked in gymnasiums, and many reversed their circumcision. Hellenistic Jews, Saducees and other cults sought to corrupt the true interpretations, and the Greeks tried to misrepresent the Torah's sacred nature and forced it to be translated into Greek.

The combination is netzach shebenetzach, victory within victory. This week is the midpoint, joining the victory of Adar to the victory of Nissan, and twenty-five is exactly midway through the Counting of the Omer. The lesson from the frog is to serve with great self-sacrifice, remembering how brief our stay here is.

Week 25, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 170 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Micah the Morashite and "Faith in the Sages"

The last week of Adar. Haazinu spares nobody: "From outside, the sword will bereave, and terror from within; young men and maidens, suckling babes with venerable elders." (Deuteronomy 32:25) That was Haman's decree exactly. Read positively, the verse turns the decree on its head and describes the destruction of Amalek, whom the people are commanded to wipe out entirely, women and elderly and babies included. Killing Agag, king of the Amalekites, Samuel says: "As thy sword hath made women childless, so shall thy mother be childless among women."

The Haftorah stays positive, and uses the word Leneged again, as in week 23: “And the Lord has recompensed me according to my righteousness; according to my cleanness before His eyes.” (II Samuel 22:25) Leneged Einav, before His eyes, can also mean for the one against His eyes — because Amalek is not only against the Jewish people but against G-d Himself, a thorn in His eyes. Amalek is closely tied to keri, a source of impurity, so cleanness here may also mean fulfilling the command to destroy Amalek without question, correcting King Saul’s mistake.

The quality is faith in the sages, emunat chachamim, and it is central to Purim, when the people trusted the actions of Mordechai and Esther. At first glance Mordechai could even be blamed for starting the persecution by not bowing to Haman. They did not blame him; they stood behind him and followed his directives. Haman saw them as an Am Mordechai, a nation of Mordechais.

The prophet is Micah the Morashite, and much of his prophecy is aimed at the heads of the people, its sages. “Hearken now, you heads of Jacob and officers of the house of Israel! Is it not incumbent upon you to know the judgment? Those who hate good and love evil-who rob their skin from upon them and their flesh from upon their bones.” Then the prophets who mislead, “who bite with their teeth and herald peace, but concerning whomever does not give into their mouth, they prepare war.” Then the darkness: “it shall be night for you because of the vision, and it shall be dark for you because of the divination, and the sun shall set on the prophets.” And then himself: “But I am truly full of strength from the spirit of the Lord and justice and might, to tell Jacob his transgression and Israel his sin.” The charge is bought justice: “Its heads judge for bribes, and its priests teach for a price; and its prophets divine for money, and they rely on the Lord, saying, 'Is not the Lord in our midst? No evil shall befall us.'” And the sentence: “Zion shall be plowed as a field; Jerusalem shall become heaps, and the Temple Mount like the high places of a forest.” The hiddenness of Hashem runs through all of it, which is this month.

The link to emunat chachamim is plainer still in Jeremiah, where the elders of the land stand up and argue from Micah’s case: Micah the Morashtite was prophesying in the days of Hezekiah the king of Judah and said that Zion shall be plowed for a field — did Hezekiah and all Judah put him to death? Did he not fear the Lord? And he entreated the Lord, and the Lord renounced the evil He had spoken. “But we are doing great harm to ourselves.”

The levitical city is Jerusalem, because the Temple was also a city of refuge. For now half of it rests in Judah and half in Benjamin; in the future Jerusalem will have its own territory, separate from every tribe. This is the last week of the year for contributing the half-shekel toward the upkeep of the Temple there. And in the Megillah, when Achashverosh offers Esther up to half his kingdom, the sages learn that he meant up to Jerusalem.

Week 25, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 171 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Hezron and Sweetening Bitter Judgments

The bitter water gets sweetened: "The people complained against Moses, saying, What shall we drink? So he cried out to the Lord, and the Lord instructed him concerning a piece of wood, which he cast into the water, and the water became sweet. There He gave them a statute and an ordinance, and there He tested them." Rebbe Elimelech of Lizhensk, whose yahrzeit is this week, teaches that this is the main service of the tzadik: to sweeten and cancel the bitter decrees against the Jewish people.

The Haftarah finishes its round of the tribes with the two who went: "Zebulun is a people that jeopardized their lives to die, as did Naphtali, upon the high places of the field." These two hold the whole spirit a sheliach needs; they are literally willing to give up their lives for the cause. Naphtali is the month of Adar, and Zebulun, in its partnership with Issachar, carries the month's other theme, duality.

Daf Kaf Heh of Sotah takes up what to do where a woman starts behaving immodestly in general, and whether a husband can cancel a warning — he can. Which is the same thing again: the tzadik's avodah, using self-sacrifice to cancel decrees against the people even when they are not behaving as they should.

The generation is Hezron, son of Perez, father of Caleb. Hezron comes from chatzer, courtyard or enclosure, a term discussed in halachah, especially in Eruvim, where two neighbours share one courtyard and have to set up an eruv chatzeirot in order to carry in it. Then both own the area together and it is no longer a separate domain for either. Eruv shares a root with Arev, sweet: when Jews come together and the duality works for the good, there is sweetness. Chatzer is also the courtyard of

the Temple.

The journey is from Tarah to Mithkah, and Mithkah comes from matok, which also means sweet. The personal journey moves on from lifting our surroundings through holy foolish behaviour, to sweetening whatever bitterness we meet, our own or our people's.

Week 25, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 172 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

"An Ever-Increasing Wellspring"

Channah's twenty-fifth verse is one line: "And when the bullock was slain, the child was brought to Eli." The last week of Adar is tied to bringing contributions to the Temple — by now the courts had the right to take the yearly half-shekel by force from anyone who had not brought it.

The Talmud teaches that this verse shows Shmuel's hidden greatness. Eli said, call a priest and let him come and kill the animal. Seeing them look for a priest, Samuel asked why: the shechitah may be performed by a layman. They brought him to Eli, who asked how he knew. He answered: Is it written, "The priest shall kill"? It is written, "The priests shall present the blood" — the office of the priest begins with receiving the blood, which shows that the slaughtering may be done by a layman. Eli said to him: you have spoken very well, but all the same you are guilty of giving a decision in the presence of your teacher.

Adar reveals what is secret. That is why the text we read on Purim is Megillat Esther, revealing, Legalot, what is hidden, Nistar — and here what is revealed is the hidden greatness of a little boy. Last week's quality was that the Torah's secrets are revealed to him; this week's is that he becomes as an ever-increasing wellspring. A wellspring is the same idea: it brings water, which is Torah, from the depths of the earth up to the surface. Ma'ayan is often associated with the hidden parts of Torah, like the teachings of the Baal Shem Tov. And Shmuel in that story is a living example of one.

Proverbs 25 opens on exactly this. "These too are Solomon's proverbs, which the men of Hezekiah, king of Judah, maintained. The honor of God is to conceal a matter, whereas the honor of kings is to search out a matter. The heaven for height,

the earth for depth, and the honor of kings are unsearchable. Remove dross from silver, and a vessel emerges for the refiner."

The week holds the yahrzeits of Rebbe Elimelech of Lizhensk on the 21st of Adar and Rabbi Yitzchak Meir Alter, the Chiddushei HaRim, on the 23rd. Rebbe Elimelech was one of the main disciples of the Maggid of Mezritch and the Rebbe of Rebbes of the Jews of Poland and Galitzia, brother of Reb Zushia of Anipoli; many of his disciples became rebbes themselves, among them the Chozeh of Lublin, the Ohev Yisrael, Reb Menachem Mendel of Rimanov and the Maggid of Kozhnitz. He wrote the Noam Elimelech, one of the foundational texts of Polish Chassidism. Rabbi Yitzchak Meir Alter founded Ger, which became the largest of all Chassidic groups, in great part through his inspiring and caring leadership, and his Chiddushei HaRim is a Chassidic classic. Also this week: Rav Chanoch Henach of Alexander, who served as rebbe of Ger for some time after the Chidushei HaRim passed away, and Rabbi Nachum Mordechai of Chortkov, son of Rabbi Yisrael Friedman, both on the 18th of Adar, and Rabbi Meir Yechiel of Ostrovtze on the 19th.

Week 25, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 173 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Learning Torah and Listening to the Leader of the Generation

The Song goes on describing him, and all of it is spice and precious material. "His eyes are like doves beside rivulets of water, bathing in milk, fitly set." "His jaws are like a bed of spice, growths of aromatic plants; his lips are [like] roses, dripping with flowing myrrh." "His hands are [like] wheels of gold, set with chrysolite; his abdomen is [as] a block of ivory, overlaid with sapphires." The myrrh the Talmud reads as Mordechai. Rashi explains that these verses are mainly about the study halls, and how there the mysteries of the Torah are clarified and uncovered. Our sages explain that it was the work of Mordechai and the Jews of that time to strengthen the public study of Torah which brought the redemption — and the month is Megillat Esther, uncovering, Legalot, the hidden, Nistar.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twenty-fifth is Tola, later the name of one of the Judges, from the tribe of Issachar. Tola's sons are listed in Chronicles, and Rashi has a fascinating comment there: in the Pentateuch it is

written “and Job,” because Job was his name originally; but since they settled themselves to learn Torah, as it says of the sons of Issachar that they possessed understanding of the times, he merited to be called Jashub. Which belongs with Mordechai, the leader and judge in the time of Purim, and with that public study.

Daf Kaf Heh of Shvuot keeps on with the laws of oaths, and whether they can apply to the past as well as the future. Week 25 is the midway point of the Counting of the Omer of the weeks of the whole year.

Jeremiah’s twenty-fifth chapter is about listening to the leader of the generation — here the king — and to the prophets and the words of Hashem, and much of it is drinking. “From the thirteenth year of Josiah son of Amon, king of Judah, until this day, these twenty-three years the word of the Lord has come to me, and I spoke to you, arising early and speaking, but you did not hearken. And the Lord sent to you all His servants, the prophets, sending them early, but you did not hearken and you did not incline your ear[s] to listen.” Then the cup: “Take this cup of the wine of fury from My hand, and you shall give it to all the nations to whom I send you, to drink. And they shall drink and reel to and fro and be like madmen because of the sword that I am sending among them.” And it will not be refused: “Drink, become drunk, and vomit, fall and you shall not rise.” “And it shall be, if they refuse to take the cup from your hand to drink, that you shall say to them: So said the Lord of Hosts: You shall surely drink.”

Week 25, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 174 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fourth Week of Adar - Psalms 73-75; 77:13-15; 89:26

The fourth week of Adar in psalms: the seventy-third, seventy-fourth and seventy-fifth, with three verses of Psalm 77 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 73 asks why the righteous suffer while the wicked prosper, and prays for an end to the long exile; read it, and you will find repose for your soul. It admits how close it came: “But as for me, my feet nearly strayed; in an instant my steps would have been swept aside. For I envied the revelers when I saw the tranquility of the wicked.” Their ease: “They have no part in the toil of men, nor are they afflicted like other mortals; therefore they wear pride as a necklace.” Their mouths: “They set their

mouths against Heaven, while their tongues walk upon the earth." And the bitter thought: "Surely in vain have I purified my heart, and washed my hands in cleanliness; for I was afflicted all day, and my rebuke came each morning." He would not say it aloud: "Were I to say, 'I shall tell it like it is,' behold I would turn the generation of Your children to rebels." It only resolved in one place: "until I came to the sanctuaries of G-d, and perceived their end." Then the whole thing turns: "I was a boor and did not understand, like an animal was I with You. Yet I was always with You; You held my right hand." And the end of it: "Whom do I have in heaven [besides You]? And when I am with You I desire nothing on earth. My flesh and my heart yearn; G-d is the rock of my heart and my portion forever."

Psalm 74 mourns the synagogues and study halls that were burned — the Philistines destroyed the Tabernacle of Shiloh, Nebuchadnezzar the first Temple — and asks how long the exile can run. "Why, O G-d, have You abandoned us forever, does Your wrath fume against the sheep of Your pasture?" The burning: "They set Your Sanctuary on fire; they desecrated the Abode of Your Name to the ground. Their rulers thought together in their hearts; they burned all the meeting places of G-d in the land." And the worst of it, that nobody can say when it ends: "We have not seen our signs; there is no longer a prophet, and there is none among us who knows how long." Then it argues from His own power: "In Your might, You divided the sea; You shattered the heads of the sea-monsters on the waters. You crushed the heads of the Leviathan." "Yours is the day, the night is also Yours; You established the moon and the sun. You set all the boundaries of the earth; summer and winter-You created them." And the asking: "Do not give the soul of Your turtledove to the wild beast; do not forget the life of Your poor forever."

Psalm 75 says how great Israel is: on their holidays they do not take to frivolity but to song and praise and the study of the holiday's laws, and when they said at the giving of the Torah, "We will do and we will hear!", they let the world go on existing. It also warns those who indulge in worldly pleasures and credit their prosperity to themselves. "When I choose the appointed time, I will judge with fairness. When the earth and all its inhabitants were melting, I established its pillars forever." Then the warning: "Do not raise your pride heavenward, nor speak with an arrogant neck. For not from the east or the west, nor from the desert does greatness come. For G-d is Judge; He humbles one, and elevates the other." And a cup again: "For there is a cup

[of punishment] in the hand of the Lord, with strong wine of full mixture; He pours from this, and all the wicked of the earth will drink, draining even its dregs."

Psalm 77's verses turn at last from asking to telling: "I meditate on all Your works, and speak of Your deeds. O G-d, Your way is in sanctity; what god is as great as G-d? You are the G-d Who works wonders; You make Your might known among the nations." And Psalm 89's verse sets the hand on the water: "I will set his hand upon the sea, his right hand upon the rivers."

Week 25, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 175 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Frog Is Saying

The frog opens, and the two tribes who risked their lives open with it.

The jeopardy and the blessing first: "Zebulun is a people that jeopardized their lives to die" / "As did Naphtali, upon the high places of the field" / "Blessed is the Name of the honor of His Kingdom for all eternity."

Then the thirst, and the hand set on the water: "The people complained against Moses, saying, What shall we drink?" / "I will set his hand upon the sea, his right hand upon the rivers" / "His eyes are like doves beside rivulets of water, bathing in milk, fitly set."

Then the statute and the piece of wood: "There He gave them a statute and an ordinance, and there He tested them" / "So he cried out to the Lord, and the Lord instructed him" / "Concerning a piece of wood, which he cast into the water, and the water became sweet" / "I meditate on all Your works, and speak of Your deeds."

Then the spices and the gold, with the wonders between them: "His jaws are like a bed of spice, growths of aromatic plants" / "His lips are [like] roses, dripping with flowing myrrh" / "You are the G-d Who works wonders; You make Your might known among the nations" / "His hands are [like] wheels of gold, set with chrysolite" / "His abdomen is [as] a block of ivory, overlaid with sapphires."

And the end is the recompense and the sword, with the child carried in: "And the Lord has recompensed me according to my righteousness" / "According to my cleanness before His eyes" / "O G-d, Your way is in sanctity; what god is as great as G-d?" / "From outside, the sword will bereave, and terror from within" / "And when

the bullock was slain, the child was brought to Eli" / "Young men and maidens, suckling babes with venerable elders."

Week 25, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXVI

Hod of Netzach

Days 176–182

Day 176 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Be Humble and Let G-d Guide Us

The sheep and goat are saying: "Who is like You among the might ones, G-d, who is like You, mighty in holiness, awesome in praise, worker of wonders." (Exodus 15:11) The small pure domestic animal is the sheep — Nissan's sign is Aries — and the goat as well. Rosh Chodesh Nissan is the inauguration of the Mishkan, where sacrifices of pure kosher animals like these were brought, and Nissan is the month of redemption and miracles.

Shepherd and flock is one of the great metaphors for G-d and the Jewish people. He is far above our understanding, as a shepherd is entirely beyond the understanding of his flock; and like sheep we have complete humility and faith that our Shepherd leads us the right way, even with foxes and lions along it.

The goat stands for the Jewish people in Chad Gadya, sung on Passover night. The name means One Goat, and it sounds close to Haggadah, the text read at the Seder. Chad Gadya is like Perek Shirah in being full of animals and natural elements, but there the animals are the exiles and the nations that conquered the Land of Israel: the cat that eats the goat is the Assyrians, the dog that eats the cat is Babylon, the stick is Persia, the fire is Macedonia, the water is Rome, the ox is the Saracens, the slaughterer is the crusaders, and the Angel of Death is the Turks. At the end G-d saves us from all of them and brings us back to our Land.

The two zuzim the goat was bought for are said to be the two tablets of the Ten Commandments given at Mount Sinai, and also look like the two Temples that were destroyed and their people exiled. Zuz means to move, to change places; the Third Temple will not move. Each animal that sings during Nissan carries an exile and a

redemption from it. Sheep were gods to the Egyptians, our first exile, and the goat, Seir, points to Esau, our last. We were redeemed from Egypt in this month, and in this month we will be redeemed again.

The Torah says plainly that Nissan is the head of all months, Rosh Chodashim, so it belongs to Judah, the leader of his brothers, from whom King David comes. Every legitimate king, Mashiach included, descends from David and so from Judah. Yehudah comes from hoda'ah, acknowledgement, the root of Modeh, as in the Modeh Ani we say on waking, acknowledging Him as King and thanking Him for returning the soul. The tribe is marked by self-sacrifice, acknowledgement and thankfulness.

Because the Egyptians idolized sheep, it is fitting that the sheep is the one to proclaim His absolute greatness. The sheep is the animal of the Passover sacrifice, which showed the Egyptians that G-d is far greater than any other god. On Shabat HaGadol, just before Passover, we mark the miracle that the Egyptians did not turn on the Jewish people when they tied sheep to their bedposts and told them they were about to sacrifice their gods. And since Nissan is the month of Passover, it is right that the song comes from the Song of the Sea, sung after the splitting of the Sea of Reeds.

Twenty-six is the gematria of Hashem. It is also twice thirteen, which is the gematria of echad, one, and of ahavah, love.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yishmael: be yielding to a leader, affable to the black-haired, and receive every man with joy. Among the kohanim Rabbi Yishmael was the head, the Kohen Gadol, and besides his closeness to Hashem he had, as Aaron had before him, a great love for every member of the people whatever their status. And the verse fits Nissan, the head of the months.

The combination is hod shebenetzach. With humility and gratitude, self-sacrifice and acknowledgement, we reach the miraculous victory of this month. The sheep and the goat teach that all our work on ourselves rests on the belief that only Hashem can truly redeem us.

Week 26, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 177 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Amotz and Destroying our Arrogance

Rosh Chodesh Nissan, the month of Judah, the leader of the brothers, from whom King David and all his royal descendants come. Haazinu's verse is the last that speaks directly of destruction, and this time it is total: "I said that I would make an end of them, eradicate their remembrance from mankind." (Deuteronomy 32:26) Which confirms that the grim verses before it were about Amalek, since it is Amalek that will be utterly destroyed, not the Jewish people. Adar carries that destruction most, but Nissan has it too: Passover is marked by burning all the chametz. Spiritually chametz is the ego, and Amalek's impurity is bound up with an inflated ego. As Rabbi Shalom Arush explains, the kelipah of Amalek is haughtiness and a lack of gratitude. Haman had so much and said all of it was meaningless because one man, Mordechai, would not bow to him.

The Haftorah stays kind: "With a kind one, You show Yourself kind. With an upright mighty man, You show Yourself upright." (II Samuel 22:26) Rid of ego and personal wants, acting with temimut, purity, and keeping our attention on what He wants, we are answered in the same vein. The verse also carries hoda'ah, acknowledgement, which is the root of Judah's name — Judah courageously recognised Tamar's righteousness. Hoda'ah is also thanks: when we are grateful, He gives us more to be grateful for. And we should be grateful for everything, even what looks bad to us, because everything He does is for the good.

So the quality is acceptance of suffering, kabalat hayissurim, which is the ultimate sign of gratefulness and humility.

The prophet is Amotz, father of Isaiah. The Talmud teaches that Amotz was the brother of Amatziah, son of King Joash. He watched his brother fall. Amatziah began his reign well, obeying the prophet and winning militarily; then, having taken spoils from Edom, he began to worship their idols. G-d sent Amotz to question him, and Amatziah dismissed the prophet with tremendous arrogance — an arrogance the King of Israel, Joash, also pointed out before defeating him in battle. His downfall came of keeping the spoils of Edom and not cleansing them of idolatry, which is the burning of chametz exactly. Amotz did not press him: "So the prophet desisted, but he said, 'I know that G-d has made a plan to destroy you, for you have done this

thing, and you have not heeded my counsel.'" He accepted that the suffering coming was G-d's will, and came of his brother's arrogance.

The levitical city is Hebron, also called Kiryat Arbah, and also a city of refuge. Kiryat Arbah means City of Four — the four couples buried there, Adam and Eve, Abraham and Sarah, Isaac and Rebeccah, Jacob and Leah, and also the four giants who lived there. Four is a theme of Passover too: four glasses of wine, four kinds of sons in the Hagaddah.

The four giants look like the four main exiles. Sheshai is Babylonia: the Jastrow dictionary calls Sheshai a surname for Babylonia, and it spells Bavel in the transposition known as Atbash; the Midrash says he was named for being made of marble, Shaish, which suits Nebuchadnezzar and the statues made in his honour. Achiman is Persia, his name a contraction of Achashverosh and Haman. Talmai is Greece, whose leader in that exile was Talmai, Ptolomy in English. The fourth is named only as the father of the other three, which is Edom, the father of the exiles, the longest and harshest by far.

Giants stand for arrogance, and the forefathers buried in Hebron for humility. Abraham said to G-d, "I am but dust and ashes" — and when we nullify the chametz we declare it like the dust of the earth.

The four giants also line up with the four couples. Sheshai and Bavel recall the Tower of Babel, whose generation and whose leader Nimrod Avraham confronted directly; Avraham is also known for destroying his father's statues. Achiman and Persia, and the Purim story, are marked by extreme self-sacrifice, which is Isaac and the Akeidah; and the Torah notes how Isaac and Rebecca prayed together for a child, and how much of what followed was settled by Rebecca's actions, like the blessing of Jacob over Eisau. Talmai and Greece were an affront to the Torah, its Divine origin and its way of life, and Torah is above all Jacob's: Jacob, Ish Tam, a wholesome and straightforward man, stands against the godless sophistication of the Greeks. The father of the giants is Rome, and it involves all of humanity — Pax Romana reached the whole world, and in many ways we are still under it. Edom is Eisav, who was red, like Mars and his military prowess. Adam and Eve are all of humanity, and Adam is also an acronym of three: Adam himself, David, and Mashiach. David was red too, a kosher version of Eisav and of the potential Eisav missed so badly. Mashiach son of David will redeem the whole world, fix the curse of the snake, and bring it back to

the fullness it had in the Garden of Eden.

Week 26, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 178 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Connecting to the "Head"

Rosh Chodesh Nissan is the head of the month that is the head of all the months. Nissan is king of the months as Judah, its tribe, was leader of all the tribes.

Beshalach gives the condition and the healing: "If you hearken to the voice of the Lord, your G-d, and you do what is proper in His eyes, and you listen closely to His commandments and observe all His statutes, all the sicknesses that I have visited upon Egypt I will not visit upon you, for I, the Lord, heal you." And then the camp: "They came to Elim, and there were twelve water fountains and seventy palms, and they encamped there by the water." The twelve fountains are the tribes and the seventy palms the seventy elders, and perhaps also the seventy general souls that went down to Egypt and the seventy nations. A true leader, the head of the people, has to be connected to all of them. The portion is faith in Hashem and the exodus — do our part, and He does His — and He is named as our Healer.

The Haftorah turns to kings: "The kings came and fought; then fought the kings of Canaan."

Daf Kaf Vav of Sotah returns to women who do not drink but dwells more on those who must, and its cases are not only unusual but often at an unusually low spiritual level: possible social outcasts, the Mamzer, converts. And in the middle of all that, a ray of hope. The verse "She will be vindicated, and bear seed" teaches that if she used to give birth in pain she will give birth easily; if she used to bear daughters she will bear sons; if she used to bear short babies she will bear tall ones; if she bore babies with a dark complexion she will bear babies with a light complexion. Which is the story of Judah and Mashiach. Out of Lot's daughter and her father comes Moab, a Mamzer; out of Judah and Tamar, who faced the death penalty and was vindicated; and later out of the persistent efforts of a convert, Ruth, who was vindicated too — comes King David, and Mashiach.

The generation is Ram, son of Hezron, father of Aminadav, who fathered Nachshon and Elisheva, Aharon's wife. Ram is also Calev's brother, and Calev is

Miriam's husband, so he stands close to Moshe and the exodus. His name says it too: Ram means mighty, exalted, and the Jews left Egypt with a Yad Ramah, an exalted arm — and His arm runs all through Beshalach. As a side note, Ram in English is this week's Perek Shirah animal, and Nissan's sign is Aries.

The journey is from Mithkah to Chashmonah. Mithkah comes from matok, sweet. Chashmonah goes with the Chashmonaim and Chanukah: this week is the inauguration of the Mishkan as Chanukah is the inauguration of the Temple, and some note that Chashmonah is the 25th place journeyed to, as Chanukah is the 25th of Kislev and the name itself is Chanu-Kah, they rested on the 25th. Rabbi Simon Jacobson explains that Chashmonah means ambassador, and may also point to leadership; the Chashmonaim became kings. In the first days of Nissan the Nasi of each tribe brought sacrifices for the inauguration. The personal journey moves on from sweetening bitterness to rededicating ourselves, leading, staying connected to our leaders, and starting again in this second half of the year.

Week 26, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 179 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

The Big Picture

Channah's twenty-sixth verse is a request whose content is not stated: "And she said, 'Please, my lord! As surely as your soul lives, my lord, I am the woman who was standing here with you, to pray to the Lord.'" Rashi fills it in: take care of him, that he become your disciple — and according to the Midrash of our sages, do not punish him with death. Last week Shmuel had shown great insight and in doing so had given a ruling in front of his master, which is punishable by death, and the more grievous because Eli was the Judge and head of the whole people. So she asks Eli both to take the boy on and to forgive him.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that he becomes an unceasing river. Shmuel's insight into one area of law belongs to the ever-increasing wellspring of last week, the ability to find new rulings by concentrating on chosen parts of the text. An unceasing river is the other thing: comprehensive knowledge of the whole Torah. That is what Channah is asking Eli to teach him.

Proverbs 26 is mostly about the actions of fools, and also the lazy, the quarrelsome, the deceptive and the wicked. What runs through it is that an act which might be righteous in itself becomes ridiculous in the wrong context — honouring fools, or fearing some danger purely as an excuse not to get out of bed. A person needs the big picture in order to act rightly.

The week holds the yahrzeits of Rav Yitzchak Abuchatzera, the Baba Chaki, on the 25th of Adar, and Rabbi Shlomo Hakohen Rabinowicz, the Tiferes Shlomo, founding Rebbe of Radomsk, on the 29th. The Baba Chaki was the Baba Sali's brother, and like him was known for great holiness and saintly conduct; like him he moved from Morocco to Israel, and he became chief rabbi of Ramla-Lod. Rabbi Shlomo Hakohen Rabinowicz was called the Tiferes Shelomo after the Chassidic masterpiece he wrote, and founded Radomsk in 1843. When Rabbi Moshe Biderman of Lelov made aliyah in 1850 he told his followers to become Chassidim of the Tiferes Shelomo, and the court grew to thousands upon thousands. Besides his scholarship and his speaking, the Radomsker Rebbe was known for a beautiful voice and for composing new nigunim. Also this week: Rabbi Menachem Mendel of Visiva, son of Rabbi Yisroel Hager of Vizhnitz, on the 25th of Adar, and Rabbi Elimelech of Grodzensk, author of Divrei Elimelech and Imrei Elimelech and father of the Piazeczna Rebbe, on the 1st of Nissan. Rosh Chodesh Nissan is also the birthday of Rebbe Nachman of Breslov.

Week 26, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 180 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

The Importance of Speech

The Song finishes the description and then loses him again. "His legs are [as] pillars of marble, founded upon sockets of fine gold, his appearance is like the Lebanon, chosen as the cedars." "His palate is sweet, and he is altogether desirable; this is my beloved, and this is my friend, O daughters of Jerusalem." And then the daughters ask: "Where has your beloved gone, O fairest of women? Where has your beloved turned, that we may seek him with you?"

All of it is the mouth, which is the chief symbol of Passover. Rabbi Levi Yitzchak of Berditchev says that Pesach is Peh Sach, a mouth converses, because it is a special

mitzvah at the Seder to recount and turn over the miracles of our liberation as much as possible. The Megaleh Amukos says Pharaoh is Peh Rah, an evil mouth. Rashi reads the verses the same way: his appearance is like the Lebanon means that one who reflects and ponders over His words finds blossoms and sprouts in them, like a forest in bloom — so are the words of Torah, and whoever meditates over them constantly finds new explanations in them. And his palate is sweet means his words are pleasant.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twenty-sixth is Puvvah, whose name also looks to come from Peh, mouth, and so from Pessach. It is near the name Puah, spelled with an Ayin rather than an Aleph, which belongs to Miriam at the very start of the Exodus story: Puah comes from a root that implies a particular gift of speech, and Rashi comments that she could soothe a crying baby to sleep with her special way of talking. Puvvah is also the name of Tola's father, the Judge from the tribe of Issachar.

The daf of Shvuot this week keeps on with oaths, and above all whether an oath has to be spoken. Peh Sach again.

Jeremiah's twenty-sixth chapter presses the same point from the other end — not the mouth but the ear. "And the priests and the prophets said to the princes and to all the people, saying, 'This man is liable to death, for he prophesied concerning this city, as you have heard with your ears.'" "And Jeremiah said to all the princes and to all the people saying, 'The Lord sent me to prophesy concerning this house and concerning this city all the words that you have heard.'" And the warning: "But you should know that if you put me to death, that you are bringing innocent blood upon yourselves and upon this city and upon its inhabitants, for indeed God sent me concerning you, to speak into your ears all these words."

Week 26, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 181 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Rosh Chodesh Nissan - Psalms 76-78; 77:16-18; 89:27

The week of Rosh Chodesh Nissan in psalms: the seventy-sixth, seventy-seventh and seventy-eighth, with three verses of Psalm 77 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 76 holds the prophecy of the vast army of Sennacherib seized by a deep slumber that left the soldiers' hands powerless to raise their weapons, so that they all

fell in battle. “G-d is known in Judah, His Name is great in Israel.” The sleep: “The stout-hearted were without sense, they slept their sleep, and all the warriors were unable to find their strength. At Your rebuke, O G-d of Jacob, chariot and horse were stunned.” Then the stillness: “From heaven You let the verdict be heard; the earth feared and was still, when G-d rose to pass judgment, to save all the humble of the earth forever.”

Psalm 77 is here whole, and it is the psalm whose verses have been arriving three at a time for weeks. It begins in the night that will not end — “my wound oozes at night and does not abate; my soul refuses to be consoled” — and asks everything it can: “Is it for eternity that my Lord forsakes [me], nevermore to be appeased? Has His kindness ceased forever? Has G-d forgotten mercy?” Then it turns on remembering: “I remember the deeds of Yah, when I remember Your wonders of long ago.” And then the sea answers it: “You redeemed Your people with a mighty arm, the children of Jacob and Joseph, Selah. The waters saw You, O G-d, the waters saw You and trembled; even the deep shuddered.” “Your way was through the sea, Your path through the mighty waters; and Your footsteps were not known.” And the last line is the whole answer in one image: “You led Your people like a flock, by the hand of Moses and Aaron.”

Psalm 78 recounts every miracle from the exodus to David becoming king, and it is built as a thing to hand on: “Listen, my people, to my teaching; incline your ear to the words of my mouth. I will open my mouth with a parable, I will utter riddles of long ago; that which we have heard and know [to be true], and that our fathers have told us. We will not withhold from their children, telling the final generation the praises of the Lord.” The point of telling is that the next generation not be like the last: “And they shall not be like their fathers, a wayward and rebellious generation, a generation that did not set its heart straight.” Then the sea and the rock: “He split the sea and brought them across; He erected the waters like a wall.” “He split rocks in the wilderness, and gave them to drink as if from the abundant depths.” Then the asking for meat: “They spoke against G-d; they said, 'Can G-d set a table in the wilderness? True, He hit the rock and waters flowed, streams gushed forth; but can He also give bread?'” And the answer that was already there: “He had rained upon them manna to eat, and given them grain of heaven. Man ate the bread of angels.” Then the long account of forgetting and being forgiven: “Yet He is compassionate,

pardons iniquity, and does not destroy; time and again He turns away His anger." "He remembered that they were but flesh, a spirit that leaves and does not return." Then the plagues told backwards into memory — the rivers turned to blood, the frogs, the grasshopper and the locust, the hail, the firstborn — and the shepherding out: "He drove His nation like sheep, and guided them like a flock in the desert." Then Shilo abandoned, and the waking: "And the Lord awoke like one who had been asleep, like a warrior shouting [to sober himself] from wine." And the end is the choosing: "He chose the tribe of Judah, Mount Zion which He loves." "And He chose David His servant, and took him from the sheep corrals. From following the nursing ewes, He brought Him to shepherd His nation Jacob, Israel His inheritance. And he tended them with the integrity of his heart, and led them with the skill of his hands."

The Tikkun HaKlali verses are the sea again — "the waters perceived You, they trembled, even the deeps quaked" — and Psalm 89's verse is the name he will call Him by: "He will call to Me, 'You are my Father, my G-d, and the Rock of my salvation.'"

Week 26, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 182 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Lamb Is Saying

The lamb opens on who is like Him, and the week's books come in around it.

The holiness and the redeeming arm first, with the kings: "Who is like You among the might ones, G-d" / "Who is like You, mighty in holiness" / "You redeemed Your people with Your arm" / "The sons of Jacob and Joseph forever" / "The kings came and fought" / "Then fought the kings of Canaan."

Then the end of Amalek and the healing: "I said that I would make an end of them" / "Eradicate their remembrance from mankind" / "All the sicknesses that I have visited upon Egypt I will not visit upon you, for I, the Lord, heal you" / "With a kind one, You show Yourself kind" / "With the upright, mighty, You show Yourself upright."

Then the hearkening, and the cedars: "And he said, if you hearken to the voice of the Lord, Your G-d" / "And you do what is proper in His eyes" / "His appearance is like the Lebanon" / "Chosen as the cedars" / "O daughters of Jerusalem."

Then the waters trembling, and the marble pillars: “They trembled, even the deeps quaked” / “They poured forth thick waters” / “His legs are [as] pillars of marble” / “Founded upon sockets of fine gold” / “The skies let out a voice” / “Even your arrows went abroad.”

Then the fountains and the palms, with the woman who stood there praying: “Water fountains and seventy palms” / “And they encamped there by the water” / “The waters perceived You, O G-d” / “The waters perceived You” / “And she said, 'Please, my lord! As surely as your soul lives, my lord’” / “And you listen closely to His commandments” / “And observe all His statutes” / “They came to Elim, and there were twelve.”

And the end is the asking and the answering: “Where has your beloved gone, O fairest of women” / “Where has your beloved turned” / “I am the woman who was standing here with you, to pray to the Lord” / “His palate is sweet, and he is altogether desirable” / “This is my beloved, and this is my friend” / “He will call to Me, You are my Father, My G-d, and the Rock of my salvation” / “Awesome in praise, worker of wonders” / “That we may seek him with you.”

Week 26, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXVII

Yesod of Netzach

Days 183–189

Day 183 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Purify Ourselves in order to Change

The cow is saying, "Rejoice to the Lord over our strength, trumpet to the Lord of Jacob!" (Psalms 81:2) The large pure domestic animal is the cow, and the week stands closer still to Passover.

The Jewish people are called both Israel and Jacob, and Jacob is the name used when we are in the more fragile, humble state. Feeling weak, we have to lean harder on Hashem as the source of our strength. This is also the week of the Rebbe Rashab's yahrzeit, on the 2nd of Nissan — and his leadership fell in a tumultuous time, with the people in a particularly fragile state, facing the harsh anti-religious oppression of the Bolsheviks in Russia.

The cow carries the spiritual exile and impurity of Egypt, in the golden calf. It also carries the purification of the Parah Adumah, the Red Heifer, which had to be entirely red, pure and whole, tamim. Its ashes purified the highest form of impurity, contact with the dead, and every Jew who found himself impure had to go through that in order to bring the Passover offering this month — which is why we read Parashat Parah in the weeks before the holiday. The Rebbe Rashab is a tremendous example of purity himself: he established the Tomchei Tmimim yeshiva system, whose students were known as tmimim, the pure and wholesome ones, and his last ma'amar was about the final destruction of Amalek and the husks of impurity, the kelipah.

Twenty-seven is kaf and zayin, which spell zach, pure. Preparing for Passover, we have to purify ourselves in body and in spirit, returning to G-d and waiting eagerly for His redemption.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Akiva, who first says how to keep that purity: jesting and frivolity accustom a person to promiscuity, and tradition is a safety fence to Torah, tithing a safety fence to wealth, vows a safety fence for abstinence, and a safety fence for wisdom is silence. Then the loves. Beloved is man, for he was created in the image of G-d, and it is a sign of still greater love that he was told so. Beloved are Israel, for they are called children of G-d, and it is a greater love that they were told so. Beloved are Israel, for they were given a precious article, and greater still that they were told so. All is foreseen, and freedom of choice is granted. And then the open shop: everything is placed in pledge, and a net is spread over all the living; the store is open, the storekeeper extends credit, the account-book lies open, the hand writes, and all who wish to borrow may come and borrow; the collection-officers make their rounds every day and exact payment from a man, with his knowledge and without it; their case is well founded, the judgment is a judgment of truth, and ultimately all is prepared for the feast. In Nissan too, everything is prepared for the feast.

Rabbi Akiva elsewhere says how praiseworthy the Jewish people are, whose purification comes directly from our Father in Heaven. And nobody suits this month better: he is one of the greatest examples of complete humility and self-sacrifice. He began to study Torah at the age of 40, sitting silently and humbly beside small children — and became one of the greatest Torah scholars of all time. His name shares a root with Jacob; both come from eikev, heel, where Israel holds the same letters as Li Rosh, mine is the head. The head is the highest part of the body and the heel the lowest.

The combination is yesod shebenetzach, foundation within determination and victory, which is perhaps the most prominent feature of Jewish education through the long exile. The lesson from the cow is that in the work of our tikkun — the very reason we came into the world — G-d is the source of our strength. The cow sings about Jacob, who worked all his life against the obstacles set in front of him, and only after much perseverance became Israel. Each of us changes and advances too, even without noticing, and He is beside us through it.

Week 27, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 184 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Eliyahu and Knowing One's Place

The second week of Nissan. Haazinu names what delays the end: "Were it not that the enemy's wrath was heaped up, lest their adversaries distort; lest they claim, 'Our hand was triumphant! The Lord did none of this!'" (Deuteronomy 32:27) Read as the destruction of Amalek, the reason it has taken so long is haughtiness — an inflated ego that distorts reality. Something of that was seen after the Six-Day War, when the miraculous victory led to uncalled-for exuberance and distortion, and from there to the debacle of the Yom Kippur War.

The Haftorah says it from the other side: "With a pure one, You show Yourself pure; But with a perverse one, You deal crookedly." (II Samuel 22:27) In the days before Passover we try our utmost to purify ourselves, above all of ego.

So the quality is he who knows his place, Hamakir Et Mekomoh, which may be the best description of humility there is. Being humble is not thinking oneself meaningless; it is knowing one's place — one's responsibility and task in life. And Makom, place, is one of the names of G-d, so Hamakir et Mekomoh can also mean he who knows his G-d. That is the message of Passover. Pharaoh, the ultimate overgrown ego, refused at first to release the people because he said he did not know G-d. Moshe, the most humble of men, knew Him better than any other mortal.

The prophet is Eliyahu, who was humble and still did not hesitate to speak against the King of Israel and to rebuke all of Israel for hesitating to serve G-d alone. He knew his place: asked, "Why are you here, Eliyahu?", he answered, "I have acted with great zeal for Hashem, G-d of Legions." He is also one of the best examples of one who knows his G-d — every Shabbat we read his description and exaltation of G-d's attributes, Patach Eliyahu — and he has a major part in the Passover Seder.

The levitical city is Libnah, also a city of refuge, from Lavan, white. It may point to the purification before Pessach, and to Libun, one of the koshering processes, in which metal is heated until it is white hot. Lavan is also one of the main enemies of the Jewish people: the Seder's recounting begins "Arami Oved Avi," an Aramean tried to destroy my father, which is Lavan, who tried to destroy Jacob.

Week 27, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 185 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Amminadab, Emunah & Self-Sacrifice

This week holds the yahrzeit of Rabbi Shalom DovBer of Lubavitch, the Rebbe Rashab, and the Torah portion goes fully into Parashat HaMan — the training of a people to have faith and not complain. "They journeyed from Elim, and the entire community of the children of Israel came to the desert of Sin, which is between Elim and Sinai, on the fifteenth day of the second month after their departure from the land of Egypt. The entire community of the children of Israel complained against Moses and against Aaron in the desert." The phrase "the entire community" comes twice, and against the complaining it says that the lack of emunah in that generation was widespread and would take serious work. The commentaries note that it was at this place that their food supplies ran out, and that was the source of the complaint.

The Haftorah's verse is the exact opposite of worrying about supplies: "in Taanach by the waters of Megiddo; they took no gain of money." The Canaanite kings took no money to come and attack. If our enemies will disregard their finances like that, how much more should we, who know where our sustenance comes from.

Daf Kaf Zayin of Sotah takes up a woman of ill repute, some cases of women who do not drink, and the punishment of the male adulterer, and ends with laws taught when Rabbi Elazar ben Azariah became the Nassi, and with how the Song of the Sea was sung between Moshe and the Children of Israel. Both of those belong to Judah and to this month: the Nassi had to be of the tribe of Judah, as an extension of the Davidic dynasty, and Rabbi Elazar's appointment is one of the crucial focus points of the Passover Hagadah. In these days we also read the Nassi for each day, connecting to the head of each tribe. And the Song of the Sea is the Exodus itself.

The generation is Aminadav, son of Ram, father of Nachshon and of Elisheva, Aharon's wife; Miriam was married to his uncle, Calev. There is a well-known Midrash that it was Nachshon's action which split the Sea of Reeds. Aminadav may be the main link between the line of Judah and the family of Moses, and so between the redemption from Egypt and the Messianic one. His name means offering of my people, and Nedavah is a voluntary offering, as the gift of inauguration was. The Rebbe Rashab was a Nasi too, one who offered himself with great Mesirat Nefesh on behalf of his people.

The journey is from Chashmonah to Moseroth, the place of Aaron's passing. Aaron was the Nassi of the tribe of Levi, and we read of his lighting of the Menorah as part of the inauguration; he is the fifth Shepherd, as the Rebbe Rashab was the Fifth Rebbe of Lubavitch. Rabbi Jacobson explains that Moseroth comes from musar, advice and chastisement about conduct — and cleaning for Passover is also a cleaning of ego, which takes the ability to accept criticism. Moseroth is near Mesirat Nefesh, self-sacrifice, and near Masoret, tradition, and much of Passover is the keeping of family custom. The personal journey moves on from rededication and leadership to self-sacrifice and emunah, clearing out the ego before the holiday.

Week 27, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 186 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

He Becomes Modest

Channah's verse this week is the whole of her answer: "For this child did I pray, and the Lord granted me my request, which I asked of Him." The Talmud teaches that Eli the Kohen Gadol was willing to punish Shmuel and to pray that G-d give Channah a child even better than him. She would not have it: this was her child, the one she had prayed for — and by the next verse he is no longer hers but Hashem's.

That is Nissan and the redemption from Egypt exactly. The Jews of that time were far from perfect, and they were the children of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, whom He had promised to bring out; deeper than that, they were His children, and He redeemed them whatever their condition. Later, after the golden calf, He offers Moshe to destroy the people and build a nation out of him, and Moshe answers that if He did such a thing, "erase me from Your Book."

The Pirkei Avot quality is that he becomes modest. One side of modesty is not asking Hashem for personal greatness. Channah did not want a greater child than Shmuel; she was happy with her portion. Proverbs 27 opens on the same thing: "Do not boast for tomorrow, for you do not know what the day will bear. May a stranger praise you and not your mouth, an alien and not your lips."

Besides the Rebbe Rashab on the 2nd of Nissan, the week holds Rabbi Yochanan Twersky, the first Rebbe of Rachmastivka, on the 4th, and Rabbi Avraham Yehoshua Heschel, the Ohev Yisrael, Rebbe of Apt, on the 5th. The Rebbe Rashab was known

for the love and care he gave his only son, Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak, the Rebbe Rayatz, above all in his education; he said that it is an absolute duty for every person to spend half an hour every day thinking about the education of his children, and to do everything in his power, and beyond his power, to inspire them to follow the path along which they are being guided.

Rabbi Yochanan Twersky was known for great humility. His father, Rav Mordechai Twersky, the Maggid of Chernobyl, said his son had the soul of Rabbi Yochanan Ben Zakkai; he was the last of eight brothers, each of whom became a rebbe. One story tells it best. When the Maggid of Chernobyl was niftar, his sons gathered to divide his spiritual inheritance — one took his kind heart, another his sharp mind, and so on. Reb Yochanan wanted his father's gornisht, his nothingness, his deep humility. But his brother, Harav Moshe of Koristchov, took the gornisht, so Reb Yochanan was left with gor gornisht, absolutely nothing, and he was pleased.

Rabbi Avraham Yehoshua Heschel was one of the close disciples of Rebbe Elimelech of Lizhensk, and was called the Ohev Yisrael, Lover of Israel, for his great love of his fellow Jew. A very similar inheritance story is told of his teacher: before he died, Rebbe Elimelech bequeathed the sight of his eyes to the Chozeh of Lublin, the spirit of his heart to the Kozhnitzer Maggid, the soul of his mind to Rebbe Menachem Mendel of Riminov, and the power of speech to Rebbe Avraham Yehoshua Heshel of Apt. Also this week: Rabbi Yaakov Yosef, son of Rabbi David Twersky, the Skverer Rebbe, on the 2nd of Nissan; Rabbi Tzvi Elimelech Shapira of Bluzhov, son of Rabbi David of Dinov, the Tzvi LaTzadik, and Rabbi Moshe son of Shlomo Rokeach, the Kiev-Zlotchover Rebbe, both on the 5th; and Rabbi Mordechai of Neshchiz, disciple of R. Yechiel Michel of Zlotchov, on the 8th.

Week 27, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 187 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Faith in the Shepherd

The Song puts him in the garden, grazing. “My beloved has gone down to his garden, to the spice beds, to graze in the gardens and to gather roses.” Then the line that holds both sides: “I am my beloved’s, and my beloved is mine, who grazes among the roses.” And then the praise: “You are fair, my beloved, as Tirzah, comely as Jerusalem, awesome as the bannered legions.” Hashem as Shepherd, which is what these weeks of Nissan are about — a faithful flock and its Shepherd — and the month is Aries, the ram.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twenty-seventh is Iob, whose name recalls Job without the aleph. Job is tied closely to the events before the redemption: the Midrash teaches that he was one of Pharaoh’s three top advisors when the decision was made to throw the Jewish boys into the Nile. And Job is a standing symbol of the need for faith and humility.

Daf Caf Zayim of Shvuot takes up oaths about a mitzvah, and two oaths made over the same loaf of bread — which is the house being prepared for Passover.

Jeremiah’s twenty-seventh chapter has behemot, domesticated animals, and chayot, wild ones, and several Passover phrases: an outstretched arm, and G-d’s servant — a term usually kept for Moses — given here to Nebuchadnezzar. “I made the earth, the man and the beast that are upon the face of the earth, with My great strength and with My outstretched arm, and I gave it to him that pleased Me. And now, I have given these lands into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar the king of Babylon, My servant, and even the beasts of the field I have given to him to serve him.” The chapter also carries the yoke of Babylonian oppression and the rest of what that exile did. In Nissan we live through the exiles again, and the redemption from each of them.

Week 27, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 188 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second week of Nissan - Psalms 79-81; 77:19-21; 89:28

The second week of Nissan in psalms: the seventy-ninth, eightieth and eighty-first, with three verses of Psalm 77 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 79 is Asaph thanking G-d for sparing the people and turning His wrath on the wood and stones of the Temple, and weeping bitterly all the same: the place where the High Priest alone could enter, and only on Yom Kippur, is now so desolate that foxes stroll through it. "O G-d, nations have entered Your inheritance, they defiled Your Holy Sanctuary; they turned Jerusalem into heaps of rubble." The unburied: "They spilled their blood like water around Jerusalem, and there is no one to bury [them]." The asking: "Do not recall our former sins; let Your mercies come swiftly towards us, for we have fallen very low." And the prisoners: "Let the groan of the prisoner come before You; liberate those condemned to death, as befits the greatness of Your strength." It ends with what the flock can still do: "And we, Your people, the flock of Your pasture, will thank You forever."

Psalm 80 asks Him to come near as He did long ago. "Listen, O Shepherd of Israel, Who leads Joseph like sheep. Appear, You Who is enthroned upon the cherubim." Its refrain comes three times: "Return us, O G-d; cause Your countenance to shine, that we may be saved." Then the vine, which is the whole middle of it: "You brought a vine out of Egypt; You drove out nations and planted it. You cleared space before it; it took root and filled the land. Mountains were covered by its shade, and its branches became mighty cedars." And then the breach: "Why did You breach its fences, so that every passerby plucked its fruit? The boars of the forest ravage it, and the creepers of the field feed upon it." And the asking to look: "O G-d of Hosts, please return! Look down from heaven and see, and be mindful of this vine."

Psalm 81 was chanted in the Holy Temple on Rosh Hashanah, a day of many miracles for Israel, and it opens with this week's song: "Sing joyously to G-d, our strength; sound the shofar to the G-d of Jacob. Raise your voice in song, sound the drum, the pleasant harp, and the lyre. Blow the shofar on the New Month, on the designated day of our Holy Day." Then Egypt: "He ordained it as a precept for Joseph when he went forth over the land of Egypt; I heard a language which I did not know. I have taken his shoulder from the burden; his hands were removed from the pot."

Then the answer out of hiding: “In distress you called and I delivered you; [you called] in secret, and I answered you with thunderous wonders; I tested you at the waters of Merivah, Selah.” Then the opening of the mouth: “I am the Lord your G-d who brought you up from the land of Egypt; open wide your mouth, [state all your desires,] and I shall grant them.” And then the grief of it: “But My people did not heed My voice; Israel did not want [to listen to] Me.” “If only My people would listen to Me, if Israel would only walk in My ways, then I would quickly subdue their enemies.” And the last line, which is what was on offer: “I would feed him with the finest of wheat, and sate you with honey from the rock.”

Psalm 77's verses are the thunder and the path through the sea, ending “You led Your people like a flock, by the hand of Moses and Aaron.” And Psalm 89's verse is the rank: “I will also make him [My] firstborn, supreme over the kings of the earth.”

Week 27, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 189 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Cow Is Saying

The cow opens, and the week braids the garden into the desert.

The grazing and the journey first: “My beloved has gone down to his garden, to the spice beds” / “To graze in the gardens and to gather roses” / “And the entire community of the children of Israel” / “Came to the desert of Scin, which is between Elim and Sinai” / “You led Your people like a flock” / “By the hand of Moses and Aaron.”

Then the date, and the complaining: “On the fifteenth day of the second month” / “After their departure from the land of Egypt” / “The entire community of the children of Israel” / “Complained against Moses and against Aaron in the desert” / “The sound of Your thunder was in the rolling wind” / “Lightning lit up the world; the earth trembled and quaked.”

Then measure for measure, and the enemy’s boast: “With a pure one, You show Yourself pure” / “But with a perverse one, You deal crookedly” / “Were it not that the enemy’s wrath was heaped up” / “Lest their adversaries distort” / “Your way was through the sea” / “Your path through the mighty waters” / “And Your footsteps were not known.”

Then the kings who took nothing: “In Taanach by the waters of Megiddo” / “They journeyed from Elim” / “They took no gain of money” / “Lest they claim, 'Our hand was triumphant! The Lord did none of this!'”

And the end is the trumpet and the child prayed for: “Rejoice to the Lord of our strength” / “Trumpet to the Lord of Jacob!” / “I will also make him [My] firstborn” / “Supreme over the kings of the earth” / “For this child did I pray” / “I am my beloved’s” / “And my beloved is mine” / “Who grazes among the roses” / “You are fair, my beloved, as Tirzah” / “Comely as Jerusalem, awesome as the bannered legions” / “And the Lord granted me my request” / “Which I asked of Him.”

Week 27, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXVIII

Malchut of Netzach

Days 190–196

Day 190 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Recognize our Limits in order to Free Ourselves from Them

The pig and rabbit are saying: "G-d is good to the good, and to the straight-hearted." (Psalms 128:2) The small impure domestic animal is read by some as the pig and by others as the rabbit. This week carries the first night of Passover, the yahrzeit of the Third Lubavitcher Rebbe, Menachem Mendel, the Tzemach Tzedek, and the birthday of the Seventh Rebbe, who carries the Third's name, his ancestor by direct patrilineal descent.

The sages consider the pig a hypocrite: it displays the external mark of a kosher animal, split hooves, while its intestines make it non-kosher. The rabbit and its kind — the hare, the hyrax — are the exact reverse: no split hooves, and the intestines of a kosher animal. Inside they are upright of heart, and their outward actions are plainly not. Besides the pig and the camel, the hyrax and the hare are the only animals the Torah names explicitly as not kosher. The Midrash in Vaikra Rabbah explains that the hyrax is the Persian exile and the hare the Greek one; the pig is the Roman exile, which belongs to Esau and his descendants, and that is the exile we are in now. Their song is about the final redemption, when even the pig will be upright of heart and all of them will be kosher.

The Tzemach Tzedek and the Rebbe carry the message of Passover, which is redemption; Tzemach Tzedek is one of the names of Mashiach, as Menachem is. As the animals show, redemption has an inner side and an outer one. Inwardly, both of them brought important new concepts into Chassidic thought and were at last able to publish and spread the works of the Rebbes before them. Outwardly, both were extremely successful in action: the Tzemach Tzedek set up agricultural settlements

that saved many Jews from dire poverty and rescued thousands upon thousands of children forced to enlist in the Russian army, and the Rebbe established Jewish centres all over the world and helped save thousands of Jews trapped behind the iron curtain of the Soviet Union.

Twenty-eight is twice fourteen, yad, the strong and outstretched arm that took us out of Egypt — here doubled, two outstretched arms. On Passover we celebrate that He saved us then while believing fully that He will save us again, more miraculously than in Egypt. Twenty-eight is also kaf and chet, which spell koach, strength — and koach also means potential, what has not yet been revealed. The pig looks as though it has the possibility of being kosher, and it is not, at least not yet. It stands for Esau, who had enormous potential; that potential made Isaac believe he would prove worthy of the firstborn's blessings. Like the pig, Esau would play the tzadik before his father, so much so that the Midrash relates he would ask Isaac how to tithe salt and straw — neither of which needs tithing, so that the question made him look ready to go beyond the letter of the law. The Rebbe explains that salt is an example of potential: on its own it is only salt, and with other food it brings out flavour and even keeps it from spoiling.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Eliezer the son of Azariah, and the rabbinical discussion in the Haggadah begins with his remarks. If there is no Torah, there is no common decency, and if there is no common decency, there is no Torah. If there is no wisdom, there is no fear of G-d, and without fear of G-d there is no wisdom. Without applied knowledge there is no analytical knowledge, and the reverse. If there is no flour, there is no Torah, and if there is no Torah, there is no flour. Then the trees: one whose wisdom is greater than his deeds is a tree with many branches and few roots, which a storm uproots and turns on its face — "He shall be as a lone tree in a wasteland" — and one whose deeds are greater than his wisdom is a tree with many roots and few branches, which all the storms in the world cannot budge: "He shall be as a tree planted upon water, who spreads his roots by the river; who fears not when comes heat, whose leaf is ever lush."

That is the inner and outer kosher again. Knowledge needs action and action needs knowledge, and Rabbi Elazar makes clear that action comes first — which the Rebbe stressed too: HaMa'aseh Hu HaIkar. The flour may also be the matzah, and the custom of providing flour to the poor, Maot Chitim, wheat money, so they can

celebrate properly. And preparing for the holiday means ridding ourselves of chametz, the leavened bread outside and the inflated ego within.

This week completes another cycle of seven, and the combination is malchut shebenetzach. At the Seder we live victory, humility and redemption openly, in this physical world. From the pig and the rabbit we learn to want a life of complete integrity, and a complete redemption.

Week 28, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 191 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Elisha and Being Happy with One's Lot

The week of the first day of Passover. Haazinu: "For they are a nation devoid of counsel, and they have no understanding." (Deuteronomy 32:28) Read another way entirely: once this people — Amalek — is no more, there is counsel, and when they are nothing, there is understanding. Amalek is arrogance, and destroying it, burning the chametz of our inflated ego, is where wisdom comes from; Chochmah stands for Koach Mah, the strength of being "what," nothing. And read a third way: when the Jewish people make themselves like nothing, there is counsel and understanding.

The Haftarah agrees: "And the humble people You do deliver; But Your eyes are upon the haughty [in order] to humble them." (II Samuel 22:28)

So the quality is another of humility's basics: he who is happy with his lot, HaSameach Be'Chelkoh.

The prophet is Elisha, Eliyahu's disciple and successor, who showed it in accepting that place — and who later received a very special portion indeed, twice the spirit of Eliyahu. One of the greatest examples of being happy with one's lot is in his own story. Asking the Shunamite woman whether she needed anything, so that he could repay the great hospitality she and her husband gave him, he got this answer: "I dwell among my people." She asked for nothing, and she had no children at the time.

The levitical city is Eshtemoa, whose name seems to mean making oneself heard — which is the Seder, and the importance of speaking abundantly about the miracle.

Week 28, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 192 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Nachshon and Help from Above

This week holds the first day of Passover, and the portion holds the people at their most desperate, forgetting every miracle they had just seen: "The children of Israel said to them, If only we had died by the hand of the Lord in the land of Egypt, when we sat by pots of meat, when we ate bread to our fill! For you have brought us out into this desert, to starve this entire congregation to death." And then the Mannah: "Behold! I am going to rain down for you bread from heaven, and the people shall go out and gather what is needed for the day, so that I can test them, whether or not they will follow My teaching." On Seder night one of the primary mitzvot is to eat matzah, the bread of faith and of healing, which runs parallel to the Mannah.

The Haftorah fights from the same direction: "From heaven they fought; the stars from their courses fought against Sisera." The Mannah came from heaven, and so did the whole salvation in Egypt. On Passover the initiative came from above to below — Ita'aruta d'Leilah, arousal from Above, and then Ita'aruta d'Letatah, arousal from below. The plagues and the splitting of the sea did not follow from any first effort of ours.

Daf Kaf Cheit of Sotah goes on to how the water also checks and punishes the male adulterer, who stays forbidden to her as her husband does, and how she becomes forbidden to eat Terumah. The punishment of the adulterer is open heavenly intervention: he was nowhere near the drinking, and it reached him exactly as it reached her. And the terumah runs parallel to the mannah, the matzah and above all the Passover offering — holy food, given to the kohanim by Divine decree, which could only be eaten in a state of purity.

The generation is Nachshon, the first Nassi of the tribe of Judah, who brought the first offering for the inauguration of the Mishkan, read on each of the first days of Nissan. He is best known for the splitting of the sea: diving in before it split is the very essence of faith. His name holds Nachash, snake, which has the same gematria as Mashiach, who will uproot the evil of the primordial snake, the yetzer harah — a clearer link still between the redemption from Egypt and the one to come.

The journey is from Moseroth to Benei Jaakan. Rabbi Jacobson writes that Benay Yaakan literally means the sons of Yaakan, grandson of Seir, and is also translated as

wells of distress, a place that is narrow, confined and tight. On Passover we live through the distress and narrowness of the Egyptian exile as well as the redemption from it. The personal journey moves from purifying our conduct before the holiday to feeling both the narrowness and the freedom of the first exile and the last. This week faces Seir, literally goat, another name of Eisav, who is our last exile, and evil in general, and that primordial snake.

Week 28, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 193 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Being Patient and "Long" of Spirit

Channah's twenty-eighth verse hands him over: "And I also have lent him to the Lord; all the days which he will be alive, he is borrowed by the Lord." And he prostrated himself there to the Lord — Samuel, though some say Elkanah. On Passover we give ourselves over too, nullifying the ego entirely, and in the time of the Temple we went there and prostrated ourselves. The Passover story is leaving one domain, slavery in Egypt, and entering another, service of G-d: He took Goy MiKerev Goy, a nation from the innards of another nation.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that the Torah makes him patient — Erech Ruach, more literally long-spirited. It looks toward Mashiach, as we read in the Haftorah of the last day of Pessach: "And the spirit of G-d shall rest upon him.... And he will be permeated with the spirit of the fear of the L-rd." Menachem and Tzemach Tzedek are both names of Mashiach.

The Midrash Shmuel says Channah's own words were divinely inspired with Ruach HaKodesh without her knowing it: "For as long as he lives he is lent [sha'ul] to the Lord" — because as long as Samuel lived, so did Saul. That G-d let Shaul live on despite his grave sins is itself an example of His patience.

Proverbs 28 holds the same patience in a single verse: "Because of the sin of a land, its princes are many, but because of an understanding, knowledgeable man, so will [its retribution] be delayed" — Ya'arich, from Erech.

Besides the Tzemach Tzedek, the week holds at least three other great yahrzeits, major figures in both the Sefardi and Ashkenazi worlds, and like him authorities in the revealed and the hidden Torah both; all three lived in Tzfat. The 11th of Nissan is

the yahrzeit of Rabbi Yeshayahu HaLevi Horowitz, the Shnei Luchot HaBrit, the Shlah. He was chief rabbi of Cracow, Frankfort and then Prague, later moved to Israel and became chief rabbi of Jerusalem, lived his last years in Tzfat, and is buried near Maimonedes' grave in Tiberias. His major work is a foundational kabbalistic text, a basis for many Chassidic works including the Tanya. The 13th of Nissan is the yahrzeit of Rabbi Yosef Karo and of Rabbi Moshe Alsheich. Rabbi Yosef Karo wrote the Shulchan Aruch, the basic text of Jewish law, still in use today; he was chief rabbi of Tzfat, and also wrote the Beit Yosef and the Maggid Meisharim, which records his conversations with an angel. Rabbi Moshe Alsheich was his student and a member of the Beit Din of Tzfat, and his interpretations and discourses on the Torah are widely used to this day. Also this week: R' Chaim Meir ben R' Yisroel Hager of Vizhnitz, the Imrei Chaim, on the 9th of Nissan, and Rabbi Asher Yeshaya of Ropshitz, son-in-law and successor of Rabbi Naftali of Ropshitz, on the 14th.

Week 28, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 194 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Shimron and the "Night of Vigil" (Leil Shimurim)

This week the Song speaks from His side. "Turn away your eyes from me, for they have made me haughty; your hair is like a flock of goats that streamed down from Gilead." "Your teeth are like a flock of ewes that came up from the washing, all of which are perfect and there is no bereavement among them." "Your temple is like a split pomegranate from beneath your kerchief." Domesticated animals again, the goat and the ewe, and a warning off haughtiness, which is the essential work of Passover: out with the chametz, in with the matzah.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twenty-eighth is Shimron, whose name has Shomer in it, to keep, to guard. Matzah has to be Shmurah, guarded: "You shall guard the matzot." They are guarded so they cannot become chametz, or they may not be eaten. The main mitzvah of eating matzah falls on the first night, and that night is called Leil Shimurim, a night when we feel Him watching over us so strongly that it is even common custom to leave the doors unlocked.

Daf Kaf Chet of Shvuot keeps on with oaths made over a loaf of bread, and what happens if the bread is eaten — bread again, in the week when it is not eaten.

Jeremiah's twenty-eighth chapter has the yoke of the Babylonian exile, the kind a domesticated animal carries, and then the clearest case of a man so full of spiritual chametz that he believes his own false prophecies, against Jeremiah, who keeps his humility throughout. "And Hananiah the prophet took the bar off the neck of Jeremiah the prophet and broke it." "Go and say to Hananiah, saying: So said the Lord: Bars of wood have you broken, and you shall make in their stead bars of iron." "And Jeremiah the prophet said to Hananiah the prophet: The Lord did not send you, and you assured this people with a lie. Therefore, so said the Lord: Behold I send you off the face of the earth; this year you shall die, for you have spoken perversion against the Lord." And then: "And Hananiah the prophet died in that year, in the seventh month." Nissan is the seventh month counting from Rosh Hashanah.

Week 28, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 195 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Nissan - Psalms 82-84; 90:1-4; 89:29

The third week of Nissan in psalms: the eighty-second, eighty-third and eighty-fourth, with the opening of Psalm 90 and one verse of Psalm 89.

Psalm 82 admonishes judges who feign ignorance of the law, dealing unjustly with the pauper and the orphan while coddling the rich and pocketing their bribes. "G-d stands in the council of judges; among the judges He renders judgment: How long will you judge wickedly, ever showing partiality toward the evildoers? Render justice to the needy and the orphan; deal righteously with the poor and the destitute." What their blindness costs: "But they do not know, nor do they understand; they go about in darkness, [therefore] all the foundations of the earth tremble." And what they are: "I said that you are angels, supernal beings, all of you; but you will die as mortals, you will fall like any prince."

Psalm 83 is a prayer about the wars against Israel in the days of Jehoshaphat, when the nations plotted against them. "O G-d, do not be silent; do not be quiet and do not be still, O G-d." The plot in their own words: "Come, let us sever them from nationhood, and the name of Israel will be remembered no more." Then the roll of them, conspiring with one heart: the tents of Edom and the Ishmaelites, Moab and the Hagrites, Geval and Ammon, and Amalek, Philistia with the inhabitants of Tyre,

and Assyria joined with them. Then the precedents: “Do to them as to Midian; as to Sisera and Yavin at the brook of Kishon.” And the asking: “My G-d, make them like whirling chaff, like straw before the wind.” It ends not in destruction but in recognition: “Fill their faces with shame, and they will seek Your Name, O Lord.” “And they will know that You, Whose Name is the Lord, are alone, Most High over all the earth.”

Psalm 84 mourns the destruction of the Temple from the depths of the heart and speaks of all the blessings that come with its restoration; fortunate is the one who trusts it will be rebuilt and does not despair in this long exile. “How beloved are Your dwellings, O Lord of Hosts! My soul yearns, indeed it pines, for the courtyards of the Lord.” The bird in the ruin: “Even the bird has found a home, and the swallow a nest for herself, where she lays her young on the [ruins of] Your altars.” The road there: “Fortunate is the man whose strength is in You; the paths [to the Temple] are in his heart. For those who pass through the Valley of Thorns, He places wellsprings; their guide will be cloaked in blessings. They go from strength to strength; they will appear before G-d in Zion.” And the weighing: “For better one day in Your courtyards than a thousand [elsewhere]. I would rather stand at the threshold of the house of my G-d, than dwell [in comfort] in the tents of wickedness.”

Psalm 90 begins here, and it is Moses’s own: “A prayer of Moses, the man of G-d. O Lord, You have been our dwelling place throughout all generations. Before the mountains were born, and You brought forth the earth and the inhabited world, and from everlasting to everlasting, You are G-d. You bring man to the crushing point, and You say, 'Return, O sons of men.' For a thousand years are in Your eyes like yesterday, which passed, and a watch in the night.” And Psalm 89's verse holds: “I will forever keep My kindness for him, and My covenant will remain true to him.”

Week 28, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 196 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Pig Is Saying

The pig opens, and the week sets the haughty next to the humble.

The eyes and the counsel first: “Turn away your eyes from me, for they have made me haughty” / “For they are a nation devoid of counsel and they have no

understanding" / "G-d is good to those that are good, as well as to the straight-hearted" / "And the humble people You do deliver; but Your eyes are upon the haughty to humble them."

Then the pots of meat, and the crushing point: "The children of Israel said to them, If only we had died by the hand of the Lord in the land of Egypt" / "When we sat by pots of meat, when we ate bread to our fill!" / "For you have brought us out into this desert, to starve this entire congregation to death" / "You bring man to the crushing point and You say, 'Return, O sons of men.'"

Then the flocks, and the dwelling place: "Your hair is like a flock of goats that streamed down from Gilead" / "Your teeth are like a flock of ewes that came up from the washing" / "All of which are perfect and there is no bereavement among them" / "A prayer of Moses, the man of G-d. O Lord, You have been our dwelling place throughout all generations."

Then the child lent, and what was there before the mountains: "And I also have lent him to the Lord; all the days which he will be alive, he is borrowed by the Lord" / "Before the mountains were born, and You brought forth the earth and the inhabited world" / "And from everlasting to everlasting, You are G-d."

And the end is the bread from heaven and the stars: "Behold! I am going to rain down for you bread from heaven" / "From heaven they fought; the stars" / "From their courses fought against Sisera" / "I will forever keep My kindness for him, and My covenant will remain true to him" / "Your temple is like a split pomegranate from beneath your kerchief" / "For a thousand years are in Your eyes like yesterday, which passed, and a watch in the night" / "And the people shall go out and gather what is needed for the day" / "So that I can test them, whether or not they will follow My teaching" / "And he prostrated himself there to the Lord."

Week 28, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXIX

Chesed of Hod

Days 197–203

Day 197 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

After the Initial Inspiration, To Get to Work

The beast of burden is saying, "When you eat the fruit of your labors, happy are you and good is your lot." (Psalms 128:2) The large impure domestic animal, which Rabbi Slifkin translates simply as the beast of burden, and the week is Passover.

On Passover we feel the influx of blessing and redemption come in. And from the second day onward we begin counting the omer and working on ourselves, so that by Shavuot we will have earned the Torah, at least in part by the work of our own hands.

The animal looks to be Yishmael and his descendants. This son of Abraham was known for his great capacity for prayer and for trusting in G-d's blessings and salvation, and he did receive great blessings — though part of them showed how much of his way of living still needed improving: the angel tells Hagar that his hand would be on everyone. Later in life he repents, returns to G-d, and has a good relationship with Isaac, and in messianic times the two will live together in peace. Our sages read the verse as a double blessing: praiseworthy in this world, and good for you in the world to come. There is a Chassidic custom, instituted by the Ba'al Shem Tov, of making a meal on the eighth day of Passover called Moshiach Seudah, in honour of Mashiach and the world to come.

Twenty-nine goes with the cycle of the moon, 29.5 days, on which the Jewish month is based; Muslims, who consider themselves descendants of Yishmael, follow a purely lunar calendar. It is also the number of days in a woman's cycle.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Eliezer the son of Chisma: the laws of kinin, bird offerings, and the laws of menstrual periods — these are the meat of Halachah, while

the calculations of solar seasons and gematria are the condiments of wisdom. On Passover we eat no chametz, which spiritually is setting aside everything that inflates us and takes from our essence; and on Passover He connects to us personally, as our Redeemer rather than as Creator of the Universe. The teaching says something like that: He does not want us lost in grandiose and esoteric subjects like astronomy and gematria, but also in the details of serving Him in how we behave from day to day. Both sets of laws are exactly about daily conduct, and both are fundamental — to the relationship between G-d and the Jewish people, and between husband and wife, which is itself a metaphor for the first, as Solomon's Song of Songs has it. Bird offerings belong to our coming closer: korban is from karov, close, and in the absence of sacrifices, prayer and study stand in their place. And the laws of the cycle are what make wives permissible to their husbands.

The combination is chesed shebehod: this week we work on ourselves in order to receive and appreciate the blessings of the holiday properly. What the beast of burden teaches is that He helps us and travels with us, and still we should not want our spiritual growth spoon-fed. Everything comes from Him, and we have to do the work.

Week 29, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 198 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Jonah, Gechazi, and Placing a Fence Around One's Words

Passover, days two through eight. Haazinu asks for reflection: "If [only] they were wise and would understand this; they would reflect upon their fate." (Deuteronomy 32:29) The word for fate is Acharitam, literally their end. Much of Pessach is reflecting not only on the redemption from Egypt but on using it to think about the final one — Acharit k'Reshit, as we say in our prayers. In the Diaspora the eighth day is kept, and in Hebrew it is not called Shmini, Eighth, but Acharon shel Pessach, the Last Day of Passover. On it the Ba'al Shem Tov instituted the Moshiach Seudah, a meal in honour of the messianic redemption, and the Rebbe Rashab instituted that four cups of wine be drunk at it, as at the Seder.

The Haftorah is light in the dark: "For You are my lamp, O' Lord; And the Lord does light my darkness." (II Samuel 22:29) We are still in the darkness of exile, and

connecting to Him and to the final redemption brings light into it — as in the first redemption, when Egypt was plagued with darkness and the Jewish people still had light.

The quality is he who makes a fence around his words. During Pessach, and above all at the seder, we have to be very careful with words. Pessach stands for Peh Sach, the mouth talks.

The prophet is Jonah ben Amittai, of Jonah and the Whale, who was a disciple of Eliyahu and Elisha. He is this quality itself: he would not speak to the Assyrians, so as not to help those he foresaw would harm the Jewish people, and even on a storm-tossed ship about to sink because of his refusal he still would not speak. He belongs to the final redemption too — the Vilna Gaon explains that he is a prototype for Mashiach ben Yosef — and to the first, since the King of Nineveh is said to be Pharaoh himself.

Another student of Elisha who could well have been the twenty-ninth prophet is Gechazi, but the Tanach and the Oral tradition record enough mistakes of his that he likely missed it. Because he does not make a fence around his words, Gechazi becomes a Metzorah. Looked at closely, though, he held a spark of Mashiach ben David, and his intentions were most likely good; it was the actions that were wrong for the time and place. Our sages teach that he and his sons were the Metzora'im by the gates of Aram who ended up saving the Jews of their day — and Mashiach himself is described in the Talmud as a Metzorah by the gates of Rome.

The levitical city for the week of Passover is Juttah, spelled like Yatteh, to turn, incline, or stretch out one's hand. It is the word in this passage: "Now the Egyptians are men and not G-d, and their horses are flesh and not spirit, and the Lord shall turn His hand, and the helper shall stumble and the helped one shall fall, and together all of them shall perish." Rashi: the Holy One, blessed be He, supports everything with His hand, and when He turns it they fall, like one who holds something and tips his hand so that it drops. Jonathan renders it: shall raise the blow of His might. Which suits the week that holds the 7th day of Passover, when the Egyptian horses and their riders were thrown into the sea, and when He took us out with a strong hand and an outstretched arm — Yad Chazakah v'haZroah Netuyah, the same root as Yuttah.

Week 29, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 199 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Salmah and Leaving Our Own "Egypts"

Beshalach keeps on with the Mannah and ends in knowing: "And it shall be on the sixth day that when they prepare what they will bring, it will be double of what they gather every day. [Thereupon,] Moses and Aaron said to all the children of Israel, [In the] evening, you shall know that the Lord brought you out of the land of Egypt." The mannah is a great reinforcement of emunah, which is the heart of Passover. The Talmud also draws an important principle of law from that verse — preparing for a holiday. "When they prepare what they will bring" is understood to mean having in mind beforehand what one will use, physically and spiritually, during the holiday; and that a holiday cannot prepare for an ordinary day or even for the Sabbath, and the Sabbath cannot prepare for an ordinary day or a holiday.

The Haftorah sweeps them away: "The brook Kishon swept them away, that ancient brook, the brook Kishon." That is the splitting of the Sea of Reeds, kept this week, where the Egyptians were swept away; Rashi states that the Kishon had been a guarantor for the Sea of Reeds.

Daf Kaf Tet of Sotah goes further into her being forbidden to eat Terumah, and into other purity laws of Terumah and of sacrifices generally. Passover was a time when the laws of purity were particularly strict, because the Passover sacrifice had to be brought and eaten in purity — and we are strict about what we eat on it still, many keeping to nothing but food from their own kitchen.

The generation is Salmah, son of Nachshon and father of Boaz. Salmah means a garment, and he is also called Salmon, a small garment, since "on" is a suffix of smallness — which makes Nachshon a small snake. Psalm 104 says "Oteh Ohr Ka'Salmah," He enwraps Himself with light as a garment, which is part of the preparatory prayers before donning the Talit. The Alter Rebbe explains in Tanya that the Torah is the intermediary which bridges the infinite and the finite, the light and the garment. Salmah stands between in just that way: between Nachshon and the generation of the exodus, and Boaz, who marries Ruth and sets up the birth of King David. Salmah also comes from Sulam, ladder, and the Midrash builds on it: because until him they formed a ladder of princes, and from him onwards a ladder of kings. Passover is an intermediary stage too, the Holiday of Spring, a first step toward

freedom and the start of the summer months.

The journey is from Benei Jaakan to Hor hagidgad, a hole or crevice of Gidgad. On the Arizal's writings, Rabbi Jacobson explains that Hor HaGidgad has to do with the intellect, the head and its crevices. It also looks related to the Mannah, which was called zerah gad, a seed of gad. The Talmud translates gad several ways, one of them that it would be magid, that it would tell, resolving doubts; another that it comes from Haggadah, the stories of the Talmud, which draw the heart of the listener as the Mannah did. And to receive the Mannah we have to make a vessel for it, a crevice inside ourselves. The personal journey moves from the narrowness and the freedom of the exiles to opening our hearts — to the gift of the mannah, and the gift of emunah.

Week 29, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 200 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Forgiving of (Personal) Insults

Channah's song begins: "My heart has rejoiced through the Lord; My horn has been raised by the Lord. My mouth is opened wide against my enemies, For I have rejoiced in Your salvation." Passover is also a great rejoicing, thanking Him for salvation in the face of our enemies.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that the Torah makes him forgiving of insults — which looks hard to square with that verse. Channah makes a point of her victory over her enemies, and Rashi comments that she meant none other than her husband's other wife, Peninah, who had insulted her constantly for having no children. We also learn that Peninah paid a heavy price for those insults, and eventually lost all her children. So how do the two go together?

One answer is that she never names Peninah, which shows she was not bitter and had forgiven her rival. That is a difficult answer, since she still calls her an enemy even after Shmuel is born. A deeper one is inside Pirkei Avot itself. The Hebrew for insult here is Elbonoh, and the word appears again in the next section, which is the only thing linking the two: "Said Rabbi Joshua the son of Levi: Every day, an echo resounds from Mount Horeb proclaiming and saying: 'Woe is to the creatures for their insult to the Torah.'" A sage is obliged to protect the honour of the Torah and

of those who study it; he may forgive insults to himself, and he cannot forgive insults to the Torah and to Hashem. Rabbi Levi states that Peninah's intentions were pure, that she only wanted Channah to pray more fiercely. Even so, to insult a woman as righteous as Channah, wife of one of the leaders of the generation, constantly, went past personal animosity. It was an affront to the Torah itself.

The same shape is in our redemption. The punishments the Egyptians received were not simply a quid pro quo for what they did to the Jews: Pharaoh's not knowing and not acknowledging Hashem was an affront to the Torah, though the Torah had not yet been given. And the Jews are told to avenge Midian not out of vengefulness but because what the Midianites did, using their own daughters to entice the Jews, was an affront to Torah.

Proverbs this week holds both halves. On calming things: "Scornful men inflame a city, but the wise turn away wrath." "When a wise man contends with a foolish man, whether he is angry or he laughs, he will have no contentment." "A fool lets out all his wind, but afterwards a wise man will quiet it." And on what falls on those who insult the Torah: "When the wicked attain greatness, transgression increases, and the righteous will see their downfall." "Without vision the people become unrestrained, but he who keeps the Torah is fortunate."

The week holds the yahrzeits of two well-known early founders of the Chassidic movement, both known for a profound love of their fellow Jews: Rabbi Aharon the Great of Karlin on the 19th of Nissan and Rabbi Yitzchak Kalish of Vorka on the 22nd. Rabbi Aharon was a close disciple of the Maggid of Mezritch, and Karlin was so large and prominent a group in Lithuania that at one point Chassidim in general were called Karliners; he is remembered for the ecstatic and unrestrained fervor of his prayer, for his solicitude for the needy, and for the moral teachings of his Azharos, Warnings. Rabbi Yitzchak Kalish founded the Vorki dynasty in Poland; travelling with his teacher, R. David of Lelov, he became a disciple of R. Yaakov Yitzchak, the Seer of Lublin, and of R. Simchah Bunem of Pshischah, and some of his teachings and stories about him appear in Ohel Yitzchak and Hutzak Chein. His son R. Yaakov David founded Amshinov, and his son R. Menachem Mendel continued Vorki. Also this week: Rabbi Yitzchak Twerski, first Rebbe of Skver, and Rabbi Meir Abuchatzeira, the Baba Meir, son of the Baba Sali, both on the 17th of Nissan, and Rabbi Yosef Dov Soloveitchik, the Rav, on the 18th.

Day 201 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Feeling Chosen (Our Special Bond with G-d)

The Song counts the others and then sets her apart. “There are sixty queens and eighty concubines, and innumerable maidens. My dove, my perfect one, is but one; she is one to her mother, she is the pure one of she who bore her; daughters saw her and praised her, queens and concubines, and they lauded her.” And then: “Who is this who looks forth like the dawn, fair as the moon, clear as the sun, awesome as the bannered legions?” It was on Passover that the Jews were truly born as a nation, and on the Seventh Day, when the Sea of Reeds split, that the distinction became clearest and the other nations most afraid.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the twenty-ninth is Zebulun, whose name comes from Yizbeleni in Leah’s prophecy, which means he will make his chief dwelling with me. Which is the Song’s words again. Passover is also the first step toward the Mishkan: the whole purpose of leaving Egypt is to serve Hashem and to have His dwelling among the people.

The daf of Shvuot this week takes up the sacrifices brought for breaking a two-part oath, about not eating figs and grapes, and the laws of vain oaths, and imposing an oath on someone else, with oaths over a loaf of bread again. A vain oath is one that contradicts what people know to be true, something impossible, like camels flying or a serpent the size of an olive press; or one that contradicts a previous oath, as in “I swear that I will eat this loaf, I swear that I will not eat it.” The Splitting of the Sea contradicted everything everyone knew to be true, and the nature of the Sea, and apparently even the oath that the waters of Noah would never again pass over the earth. Moshe imposes an action on the Sea of Reeds all the same, to fulfil Hashem’s oath to Abraham and the people’s oath to Joseph about burying his bones in Israel. The Midrash Tehillim teaches that the sea only split when it saw Joseph’s casket.

Jeremiah’s twenty-ninth chapter is redemption from exile in the form of an oath, which was indeed fulfilled, and a special bond — seeking Him and finding Him. “For at the completion of seventy years of Babylon I will remember you, and I will fulfill

My good word toward you, to restore you to this place. For I know the thoughts that I think about you, says the Lord, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope. And you shall call Me and go and pray to Me, and I will hearken to you. And you will seek Me and find [Me] for you will seek Me with all your heart." And the other side, for those who do not go to Babylon: "I will make them as the loathsome figs, which cannot be eaten because they are so bad."

Week 29, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 202 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fourth Week of Nissan - Psalms 85-87; 90:5-7; 89:30

The fourth week of Nissan in psalms: the eighty-fifth, eighty-sixth and eighty-seventh, with three verses of Psalm 90 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 85 laments the long and bitter exile and asks why this one runs longer than the ones before, imploring Him to fulfil His promise quickly; every individual should say it when in distress. It begins with what He has already done: "O Lord, You favored Your land; You returned the captives of Jacob. You forgave the iniquity of Your people, and covered all their sin forever." Then the asking: "Return us, O G-d of our salvation, and annul Your anger toward us. Will You forever be angry with us?" Then the listening: "I hear what the Almighty Lord will say; for He speaks peace to His nation and to His pious ones, and they will not return to folly." And then the four of them meeting: "Kindness and truth have met; righteousness and peace have kissed. Truth will sprout from the earth, and righteousness will peer from heaven."

Psalm 86 is David's troubles and his enemies Doeg and Achitophel, with much praise through it; this one too is for any individual in distress. "Lord, turn Your ear, answer me, for I am poor and needy." "For You, my Lord, are good and forgiving, and exceedingly kind to all who call upon You." Then the nations: "All the nations that You have made will come and bow down before You, my Lord, and give honor to Your Name, for You are great and perform wonders, You alone, O G-d." Then the asking for one heart: "Lord, teach me Your way that I may walk in Your truth; unify my heart to fear Your Name." And the saving already done: "For Your kindness to me has been great; You have saved my soul from the depth of the grave."

Psalm 87 was composed to be sung in the Holy Temple, and praises the glory of Jerusalem, a city that produces many great scholars, eminent personalities and people of good deeds, and speaks of the good of the Messianic era. “The Lord loves the gates of Zion more than all the dwelling places of Jacob. Glorious things are spoken of you, eternal city of G-d.” Then the register, which is the whole point of it: “I will remind Rahav Egypt and Babylon concerning My beloved; Philistia and Tyre as well as Ethiopia, 'This one was born there.' And to Zion will be said, 'This person and that was born there’; and He, the Most High, will establish it.” And the last line: “Singers as well as dancers [will sing your praise and say], 'All my inner thoughts are of you.'”

Psalm 90's verses are how fast it goes: “You carry them away as a flood; they are like a sleep; in the morning, like grass it passes away. In the morning, it blossoms and passes away; in the evening, it is cut off and withers.” And Psalm 89's verse answers with what does not: “And I shall make his seed endure forever, and his throne as the days of the heavens.”

Week 29, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 203 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Beast of Burden is Saying

The beast of burden opens, and the week puts the fruit of our own labour beside the grass that withers.

The mouth opened wide, and the evening: “My mouth is opened wide against my enemies” / “For I have rejoiced in Your salvation” / “[In the] evening, you shall know that the Lord brought you out of the land of Egypt” / “That when they prepare what they will bring” / “It will be double of what they gather every day” / “When you eat the fruit of your labors” / “Happy are you and good is your lot.”

Then the praising daughters, and the throne: “Daughters saw her and praised her” / “Queens and concubines, and they lauded her” / “And I shall make his seed endure forever” / “And his throne as the days of the heavens” / “And Hannah prayed and said.”

Then the one who looks forth like the dawn, and the lamp: “Who is this who looks forth like the dawn” / “Fair as the moon, clear as the sun” / “Awesome as the bannered legions?” / “For You are my lamp, Oh Lord” / “And the Lord does light my

darkness."

Then the grass, with the counting of queens through it: "In the morning, like grass it passes away" / "In the morning, it blossoms and passes away" / "Moses and Aaron said to all the children of Israel" / "There are sixty queens and eighty concubines, and innumerable maidens" / "If [only] they were wise and would understand this" / "They would reflect upon their fate" / "For we perish from Your wrath" / "And from Your anger we are dismayed."

And the end is the brook and the one dove: "And it shall be on the sixth day" / "In the evening, it is cut off and withers" / "You carry them away as a flood" / "They are like a sleep" / "The brook Kishon swept them away" / "That ancient brook, the brook Kishon" / "My dove, my perfect one, is but one, she is one to her mother" / "She is the pure one of she who bore her" / "My heart has rejoiced through the Lord" / "My horn has been raised by the Lord."

Week 29, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXX

Gevurah of Hod

Days 204–210

Day 204 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Know that the World Needs More Love and Respect

The camel is saying, "G-d shall roar from upon high and cause His voice to sound forth from His holy place, His shout echoes profoundly over His dwelling place." (Jeremiah 25:30) This is the last week of Nissan and the week of Yom HaShoah, Holocaust Remembrance Day.

The verse is Hashem lamenting the destruction of the Temple. Since it fell, the Jewish people have had to survive a very long time without their basic source of spiritual sustenance, as a camel survives long stretches without water. Nissan is the month of redemption, from Egypt and in the future both — and even on Passover there is an egg on the Seder plate as a sign of mourning, because the final redemption has not come. This week also holds the yahrzeit of Yehoshua Bin Nun, on the 26th of the month.

By the same Midrash cited in week twenty-eight, the camel is the Babylonian exile, when the First Temple was destroyed. Like the beast of burden, it also looks to point to Yishmael. Finishing Nissan, we live through all the exiles and all the redemptions, hoping soon for the one that takes us out of this exile.

Thirty intensifies the balance of three, and it is the numerical value of Yehudah, whose tribe this month belongs to. Pirkei Avot teaches that thirty is the age of koach, strength and potential, when a person is at the height of physical and intellectual capacity; it was at thirty that the kohanim began serving in the Temple. That strength belongs to Judah and to King David, who, unlike Esau, acknowledged their mistakes and repented of them, and so could use all their capacity for good.

Pirkei Avot gives Ben Zoma. Who is wise? One who learns from every man. Who is strong? One who overpowers his inclinations. Who is rich? One who is satisfied with his lot. Who is honorable? One who honors his fellows. All of it bears on the tragedy of the Counting of the Omer: the 24,000 disciples of Rabbi Akiva died because of how hard they found it to respect, accept and learn from each other's readings of their master's teachings. The destruction of the Temple and the exile we are still in, the Holocaust inside it, came of sinat chinam, baseless hatred; we will be redeemed from this last exile through ahavat chinam, baseless love for each person.

The teaching also fits Yehoshua Bin Nun. He was Moses's closest disciple and successor and could still meet anyone: on the verse describing Joshua as "a man in whom there is spirit," Sifrei explains that he was able to meet the spirit of every man. And the second question fits him too. The Rebbe once said of his yahrzeit that on this day assistance from heaven is granted to become a conqueror, like Yehoshua Bin Nun, the most prominent of the conquerors. This week we prepare for the conquests of Iyar.

The combination is gevurah shebehod. The Counting of the Omer, especially once Passover and Nissan are over, is a stretch of service that can be hard, and takes strength and discipline to overcome the evil inclination. And the camel reminds us what we are here for: to make a dwelling place for G-d in this world, beginning with a sacred space for Him inside ourselves.

Week 30, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 205 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Isaiah and Giving All the Credit to G-d

The last week of Nissan, with Yom HaShoah and the yahrzeit of Yehoshua in it. Haazinu counts the odds: "How can one [person] pursue a thousand, and two put ten thousand to flight, unless their [Mighty] Rock has sold them out, and the Lord has given them over?" (Deuteronomy 32:30) Far-fetched as it sounds, that happened in the Holocaust. It also ran the other way in Yehoshua's conquest of the Land of Israel, when the Jews pursued nations far larger than they were — as in the War of Independence and the Six-Day War.

The Haftorah is the same arithmetic read positively: “For by You I run upon a troop; By my G-d I scale a wall.” (II Samuel 22:30) King David runs at a whole troop alone and scales a wall, and the verse says who it is by.

So the quality is humility again: he claims no credit for his achievements, Einoh Machazik Tovah L’atzmo. The credit goes to G-d, as that verse says.

The prophet is Isaiah — Nissan begins with Amotz and ends with his son. His behaviour is this quality. Having one of the most vivid and intimate visions of G-d and the Divine Chariot, he does not think of himself and how great he must be to have merited it. The opposite: “Woe is me, for I am lost, because a man of unclean lips am I, and in the midst of people of unclean lips do I dwell; for the King, the L-rd of Hosts, have mine eyes seen.” His prophecy holds many admonitions and many consolations, and the optimism always rests on G-d granting the success, once we return to Him. Joshua was very humble too, and took no credit; he always saw himself as Moshe’s follower and disciple.

The levitical city is Beth-shemesh, the house of the sun. It was Yehoshua who told the sun to stand still: “Sun, stand still upon Gibeon, and Moon in the valley of Ajalon.” “And the sun stood still, and the moon stayed, until the people had avenged themselves upon their enemies.” A city of the sun for his yahrzeit is striking, since our sages compare Moshe to the sun and Yehoshua to the moon — and perhaps that is the point, that he saw himself not as a separate thing but as being of the house of Moshe, the student who never left the tent. Beth-shemesh figures elsewhere in the Tanach too: it is the birthplace of Shimshon, whose name is also from Shemesh, and who stands more than any other leader for a supernatural strength that comes from G-d.

Week 30, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 206 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Destruction and Conquest

Beshalach: "And [in the] morning, you shall see the glory of the Lord when He hears your complaints against the Lord but [of] what [significance] are we, that you make [the people] complain against us? And Moses said, When the Lord gives you in the evening meat to eat and bread in the morning [with which] to become sated, when the Lord hears your complaints, which you are making [the people] complain against Him, but [of] what [significance] are we? Not against us are your complaints, but against the Lord." He hears the complaints, and Moshe counts himself and Aharon as nothing — Nachnu Mah. Yehoshua shared that. What the Jewish people went through in the Holocaust cannot be described; and He hears our complaints.

The Haftorah treads: "tread down, O my soul, (their) strength. Then were pounded the heels of the horses." It could be read as Jewish suffering, the soul and the strength of a people trodden down into such horror. As Rashi explains, the simple meaning is that we trod with our feet on the strength of our enemies, as Joshua put his feet on the neck of the Canaanite kings. The horse is a symbol of strength, and next week's animal; and horses pounding recalls the horse and its rider thrown into the sea.

Daf Lamed of Sotah goes further into purity laws of terumah and sacrifices, and ends on how the Song of the Sea was sung — in detail, and how even babies and unborn fetuses sang it too. Part of what makes the Holocaust so terrible is that it reached infants, babies and the unborn. And so the month of Nissan ends back at the splitting of the sea.

The generation is Boaz, son of Salmah, husband of Ruth, and the leader of the people in his day. Boaz holds the word oz, strength — Yehoshua's strength, perhaps, and the rescue that came to Ruth after all the death she had seen.

The journey is from Hor hagidgad to Jotbathah, which means calm, peace and tranquility. The personal journey moves from opening our hearts to the mannah and to emunah, to the peace that comes with complete faith — and perhaps to the relative tranquility of returning to our homeland, marked next week on Yom Ha'Atzmaut.

Week 30, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 207 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Yehoshuah and Being Uplifted by the Torah

Channah's second verse: "There is none as holy as the Lord, For there is none besides You; And there is no rock like our God." Rashi cites the Talmud: there is no artisan, Tzayar, like our G-d, who makes a form within a form. In pregnancy He shapes and gives life to each of us. Yehoshua was formed by Hashem through Moshe in the same way, and is called the son of Nun, which is a reference to Moshe himself — a person's teacher is like the one who bore him. The Talmud goes on: read not "There is none bilteka" but "There is none lebalotheka," none to consume You. The nature of flesh and blood is to be outlived by its works, and the Holy One, blessed be He, outlives His works. Which reads differently in the week of Yom HaShoah, when so many were so brutally consumed.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that the Torah uplifts him. Few have been as uplifted as Channah at the birth of her child, and the verse shows it. It is true of Yehoshua too: he was not inherently cleverer than everyone else, and he worked on himself until he was chosen as Moshe's successor for his dedication to the Torah. And it is the Torah that lifted so many communities after the loss of the Holocaust.

Proverbs this week opens in exactly that posture of humility before what is transmitted: "For I am more boorish than any man, neither do I have man's understanding. Neither have I learned wisdom, nor do I know the knowledge of the holy ones. Who ascended to heaven and descended? Who gathered wind in his fists? Who wrapped the waters in a garment? Who established all the ends of the earth? What is his name and what is the name of his son, if you know? Every word of God is refined; He is a shield for all who take refuge in Him. Do not add to His words, lest He prove to you, and you be found a liar."

Then it turns to a generation gone wrong. "Distance falsehood and the lying word from me; give me neither poverty nor wealth; provide me my allotted bread." "A generation that curses its father and does not bless its mother. A generation that is pure in its eyes, but is not cleansed of its filth. A generation-how lofty are its eyes! And its eyelids are raised. A generation whose teeth are [like] swords, and its molars are [like] knives, to devour the poor of the land and the needy of men." And the things that are never full: "The grave, the confined womb, and the earth, which is not

sated with water, and fire, which does not say, 'Enough!'"

The week holds the yahrzeits of the founders of two important dynasties. Rabbi Chaim Halberstam of Sanz, on the 25th of Nissan, was the first Rebbe of Sanz-Klausenberg, famous for extraordinary dedication to the mitzvah of tzedaka and as a renowned Torah scholar; his voluminous and wide-ranging writings were published as the Divrei Chaim, and his eldest son founded the Sanzer synagogue in Tsfat. Bobov and Klausenberg descend from him. Rabbi Moshe Pallier of Kobrin, on the 29th of Nissan, was a close follower of R. Mordechai of Lechovitch and then of his son R. Noach, and in 1833 became the first Rebbe of Kobrin, with thousands of chassidim, many of whom later moved to Eretz Yisroel; his teachings are collected in Imros Taharos. Also this week: Rabbi Nachman of Tulchin, student of Rabbi Nosson of Breslov, and Rabbi Moshe Teitelbaum, the Satmar Rebbe, both on the 26th of Nissan, Rabbi Aharon HaKohen Rosenfeld, the Pinsk-Karliner Rebbe, on the 28th, and Rabbi Mordechai Shalom Yosef Friedman, the Sadigerer Rebbe, on the 29th.

Week 30, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 208 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Sered, Nets and Chains

The Song goes down to the nut garden: "I went down to the nut garden to see the green plants of the valley, to see whether the vine had blossomed, the pomegranates were in bloom. I did not know; my soul made me chariots for a princely people." And then the calling back: "Return, return, O Shulammite; return, return, and let us gaze upon you." "What will you see for the Shulammite, as in the dance of the two camps?"

Rashi reads the garden largely as Torah scholarship and the keeping of the commandments, and mentions teachers of the Mishnah by name — the Oral Torah passed from Moshe to Yehoshua, and from Yehoshua to the elders and the generations after. He brings a second reading of the nut too: just as a nut that falls into the mud does not have its interior sullied, so are the Israelites exiled among the nations and smitten with many blows, and their deeds are not sullied. Which fits this week.

The next verse he reads as exile, the Roman one we are still in, where the Holocaust happened. On "I did not know," Rashi has the congregation of Israel

lamenting: I did not know to beware of sin, that I should keep my honour and my greatness, and I erred in the matter of groundless hatred and controversy, which intensified in the reign of the Hasmonean kings, Hyrcanus and Aristobulus, until one of them brought the kingdom of Rome and received the kingship from their hand and became their vassal — and since then, my soul made me to be chariots, that the nobility of other nations ride upon me. The Second Temple fell to baseless hatred, and not learning the lesson of it is what has kept us in exile.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirtieth is Sered. A Sarad is a netmaker or a maker of chains. Yehoshua would catch and hold every word of Moshe as a netmaker catches fish — and Yehoshua Bin Nun literally means Joshua the son of a fish, which is Moshe himself. Chains suit the week too, for the captivity endured in the Holocaust.

Daf Lamed of Shvuot begins a new chapter on the oath taken by a witness in court: whom it applies to, the rules against favouring one party over another, and distancing oneself from falsehood. Much of it fits Yehoshua. There is also an emphasis on the people as a whole, with verses on Am — "B'Tzedek Tishpot Amisecha." Yom HaShoah marks a time full of falsehood, and a time when all Jews were persecuted together, whatever their religiosity or nationality.

Jeremiah's thirtieth chapter is destruction and calamity again, and Rashi notes that it is not only the Temple and the Babylonian exile but also Gog and Magog. It speaks of pain like birth pangs, as in the pangs before the Messianic era, Chevlei Mashiach, which many believe the Holocaust to be. "A sound of quaking we have heard, fear, and there is no peace." "Ask now and see whether a male gives birth. Why have I seen every man [with] his hands on his loins like a woman in confinement, and every face has turned to pallor?" "Ho! For that day is great, with none like it, and it is a time of distress for Jacob, through which he shall be saved." And unlike the chapters before it, this one has a silver lining, that this people will not be finished: "For I am with you, says the Lord, to save you, for I will make an end of all the nations where I dispersed you, but of you I will not make an end, but I will chasten you in measure, and I will not completely destroy you." The wound stays open all the same: "No one deems your wound to be healed, you have no healing medicines. All your lovers have forgotten you, they do not seek you."

Week 30, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 209 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fifth Week of Nissan - Psalms 88-90; 90:8-10; 89:31

The fifth week of Nissan in psalms: the eighty-eighth, eighty-ninth and ninetieth, with three verses of Psalm 90 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 88 weeps bitterly over the maladies and the suffering Israel endures in exile, and describes them in detail. It is the darkest of them. “For my soul is sated with affliction, and my life has reached the grave. I was reckoned with those who go down to the pit, I was like a man without strength.” The abandonment: “You have put me into the lowest pit, into the darkest places, into the depths. Your wrath has weighed heavily upon me, and all the waves [of Your fury] have constantly afflicted me. You have estranged my friends from me, You have made me abhorrent to them; I am imprisoned and unable to leave.” Then the argument that there is no praise from the grave: “Do You perform wonders for the deceased? Do the dead stand to offer You praise? Selah. Is Your kindness recounted in the grave, your faithfulness in the place of perdition?” And still the praying: “But, I, to You, O Lord, I cry; each morning my prayer comes before You.” It ends where it began: “You have estranged from me beloved and friend; I have been rejected by my intimates.”

Psalm 89 is here whole — the psalm whose verses have come one a week all year. It is the kingship of the House of David, and the lament over its long fall. “I will sing of the Lord’s kindness forever; to all generations I will make known Your faithfulness with my mouth. For I have said, 'The world is built with kindness.'” Then the covenant itself: “I have made a covenant with My chosen one; I have sworn to David, My servant: 'I will establish Your descendants forever; I will build your throne for all generations.'” Then the sea and the foundations: “You rule the vastness of the sea; when its waves surge, You still them.” “Righteousness and justice are the foundation of Your throne; kindness and truth go before Your countenance.” Then, one after another, every verse that has been arriving singly for weeks: the aid granted to David, the anointing with holy oil, the arm that strengthens him, the adversaries crushed, the hand set upon the sea, the calling out “You are my Father,” the firstborn supreme over the kings of the earth. And then the condition and the promise that outlasts it: “If his children forsake My Torah and do not walk in My ordinances… then I will punish their transgression with the rod and their misdeeds with plagues. Yet I shall

not take away My kindness from him, nor betray My faithfulness. I will not abrogate My covenant, nor change that which has issued from My lips." Then the turn, and it is severe: "Yet You have forsaken and abhorred; You became enraged at Your anointed. You annulled the covenant with Your servant; You have profaned his crown [by casting it] to the ground. You shattered all his fences; You turned all his strongholds into ruin." And the asking: "How long, O Lord, will You conceal Yourself-forever?" "Where are Your former deeds of kindness, my Lord, which You swore to David in Your faithfulness?" And then the last line, which is how the third book of psalms ends: "Blessed is the Lord forever, Amen and Amen."

Psalm 90 is Moses's prayer, which David found in this form by a tradition attributing it to him, and brought into the Tehillim; the Midrash attributes the next eleven to Moses as well. It is the brevity of a human life, and it moves a person to repent and to drop his pride. "My Lord, You have been a shelter for us in every generation. Before the mountains came into being, before You created the earth and the world-for ever and ever You are Almighty G-d." The measure: "Indeed, a thousand years are in Your eyes like yesterday that has passed, like a watch of the night." The grass: "In the morning it thrives and sprouts anew; in the evening it withers and dries." The count: "The days of our lives number seventy years, and if in great vigor, eighty years; most of them are but travail and futility, passing quickly and flying away." And then the one request that follows from all of it: "Teach us, then, to reckon our days, that we may acquire a wise heart." Then: "Satiate us in the morning with Your kindness, then we shall sing and rejoice throughout our days. Give us joy corresponding to the days You afflicted us, the years we have seen adversity." And the last line, twice over: "May the pleasantness of the Lord our G-d be upon us; establish for us the work of our hands; establish the work of our hands."

Week 30, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 210 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Camel is Saying

The camel opens, and the week sets the treading down beside the nut garden.

The treading and the garden first: "Tread down, O my soul strength" / "Then were pounded the heels of the horses" / "I went down to the nut garden" / "To see the

green plants of the valley" / "To see whether the vine had blossomed" / "The pomegranates were in bloom."

Then the condition and the hidden sins: "If his children forsake My Torah" / "And do not walk in My ordinances" / "You have set our wrongdoings before You" / "Our hidden sins before the light of Your countenance" / "For all our days have vanished in Your wrath" / "We cause our years to pass like a fleeting sound."

Then what significance are we, with the thousand and the ten thousand: "But [of] what [significance] are we, that you make complain against us?" / "When the Lord hears your complaints, which you are making complain against Him" / "How can one pursue a thousand, and two put ten thousand to flight" / "Unless their Rock has sold them out, and the Lord has given them over?" / "There is none as holy as the Lord, for there is none besides You" / "And there is no rock like our God."

Then the meat and the bread, with the count of our years: "But [of] what [significance] are we?" / "And Moses said, Not against us are your complaints, but against the Lord" / "When the Lord gives you in the evening meat to eat" / "And bread in the morning to become sated" / "The days of our lives number seventy years, and if in great vigor, eighty years" / "Most of them are but travail and futility" / "Passing quickly and flying away."

And the end is the glory and the roar, and the calling back: "And [in the] morning, you shall see the glory of the Lord" / "When He hears your complaints against the Lord" / "G-d shall roar from upon high and cause His voice to sound" / "From His holy place, His shout echoes profoundly over His dwelling place" / "Return, return, O Shulammite" / "Return, return, and let us gaze upon you" / "What will you see for the Shulammite, as in the dance of the two camps?" / "I did not know; my soul made me chariots for a princely people" / "For by You I run upon a troop" / "By my G-d I scale a wall."

Week 30, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXXI

Tiferet of Hod

Days 211–217

Day 211 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Be Proud of Our Humble Connection with G-d

The horse is saying, "Behold, as the eyes of the servants to the hand of their master, as the eyes of the maidservant to the hand of her mistress, so are our eyes to G-d our Lord until He will favor us." (Psalms 123:2) This is the week of Rosh Chodesh Iyar, of the day of remembrance for the fallen soldiers of Israel and the victims of terror, and of the fifth of Iyar, the miraculous victory of the War of Independence.

From beginning to end of this month we are counting the omer. Iyar is also a month of healing, and its letters alef, yud and reish are an acronym of "Ani Hashem Rofecha," I am G-d your Healer. The month belongs to the tribe of Issachar, whom the Torah calls a strong-boned donkey — close to a horse — taking on the yoke of Torah study. Issachar and Zevulun had their partnership, Zevulun in commerce and supporting Issachar's full dedication to Torah; that dedication is Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai, whose yahrzeit falls this month, and of whom it is said Toratoh Emunatoh, that his Torah study was his profession.

The horse belongs to the fifth of Iyar directly, because in ancient times the horse is military might. The Song of the Sea has G-d throwing horse and rider into the sea — which is the song of the ox, later this month. And for all that power, the horse sings of looking constantly to Hashem for mercy. In the War of Independence the people fought mightily and heroically, like horses, and the victory was only possible because it was miraculous, a product of His great mercy. A horse follows its rider loyally; like the horse, the Jewish people waited a very long time and suffered greatly until He showed favour and made it possible to live in our Holy Land again.

The song is also how a person who is ill or injured prays for healing, which belongs to the day of remembrance and to the fifth of Iyar both. The miracle of the War of Independence came shortly after the Holocaust, when the people as a whole was like a sick person in urgent need.

Thirty-one has the same numerals as thirteen, the thirteen attributes of mercy. It is also the number of kings the Tanach lists as defeated at the end of Joshua's conquest of the Land. And it is lamed and alef, which spell E-l, one of the names of G-d — a name of infinite power and also of infinite mercy. The word el appears many times in the horse's song.

Pirkei Avot gives Ben Azzai: run to pursue a minor mitzvah, and flee from a transgression, for a mitzvah brings another mitzvah and a transgression brings another transgression; the reward of a mitzvah is a mitzvah, and the reward of a transgression is a transgression. As one mitzvah draws the next, healing of body and spirit also comes slowly, a step at a time, like the Counting of the Omer. He also says: do not scorn any man, and do not discount any thing, for there is no man who has not his hour, and no thing that has not its place. Which is Yom Ha'Atzma'ut as much as the horse is — the Jewish people and the Land of Israel finally had their hour.

The combination is tiferet shebehod. With patience and balance, step by step, we serve Him and climb. The horse's example is to understand that for all our strength we are nothing more, and nothing less, than servants of G-d — to be proud of that humble connection, and to know that the journey may be slow and the arrival is certain.

Week 31, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 212 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Yoel and the Rock of Israel

Rosh Chodesh Iyar, and Yom Ha'Atzma'ut. Iyar belongs to Issachar, known for complete dedication to the study of Torah. Haazinu: "For their rock is not like our [Mighty] Rock. Nevertheless, our enemies sit in judgment." (Deuteronomy 32:31) The best description of that Tzur is probably King David's in this week's Haftorah verse: "[He is] the G-d Whose way is perfect; The word of the Lord is tried; He is a shield unto all them that trust (take refuge) in him." (II Samuel 22:31) Both verses describe His protection through Israel's difficult struggle for independence, against overwhelming odds, while the rest of the world simply sat in judgment — a hypocritical judgment that continues to this day.

The quality is beloved, Ahuv. Rabbi Meir uses the same word of those who study Torah for its own sake, Lishmah, as Issachar did. The victory kept on Yom Ha'Atzma'ut is itself a sign of how beloved we are, and that feeling came shortly after the Holocaust, when so many felt abandoned.

The prophet is Yoel, whose prophecy runs the same way: destruction and then the modern miracles. He describes the plague of locusts that devastated the Land of Israel, and after the Jews repent they are promised much grain, wine and oil.

The levitical city is Kishion, from kasheh, difficult, tough — which is Issachar, the strong-boned donkey, and which is how the Jews fought and won the War of Independence.

Week 31, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 213 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Obed and Working Hard

Rosh Chodesh Iyar, Yom HaZikaron and Yom Ha'Atzmaut. Iyar is healing — Ani Hashem Rofecha — and the month of Issachar.

Beshalach: "And Moses said to Aaron, Say to the entire community of the children of Israel, Draw near before the Lord, for He has heard your complaints. And it came to pass when Aaron spoke to the entire community of the children of Israel, that they turned toward the desert, and behold! the glory of the Lord appeared in the cloud."

Which is the horse's song: our eyes are a servant's eyes on his Master until He shows mercy. He saw everything we went through, heard the complaints, and brought us back to our Land.

The Haftorah has the horse in it too: "by reason of the prancings, the prancings of their mighty ones. 'Curse you Meroz,' said the messenger of the Lord, 'curse you bitterly (you) inhabitants thereof.'" Meroz and its people failed to help in the war.

Daf Lamed Alef of Sotah takes up serving G-d out of love and out of fear, and how many witnesses are needed to testify to her seclusion. Love and fear is the horse again. The War of Independence certainly had aspects of serving out of fear that had not been there before; it had an Ein Brera about it, no other way out, which belongs to the destruction of the Holocaust. The daf also names Iyov, Job, who suffered so much and served out of love, and whose fortunes were turned back in the end, his family, health and wealth restored.

The generation is Obed, son of Boaz and father of Yishai. Obed means worker, and is near eved, servant — the horse's song again. He could also point to the Jewish army and the pioneering, hardworking generation of Israel's independence.

The journey is from Jotbathah to Abronah, which is a river crossing, a ford. Arguably the most important crossing in history is the Jordan, to conquer the Land of Israel; another is the Jabok, when Yaakov faced Eisav. The very word Hebrew comes from crossing — Abraham was known as ha'Ivri. So a crossing is also establishing, or re-establishing, our identity in our own eyes and in other people's. The personal journey moves from the peace that comes with complete faith and with living in our homeland to re-establishing that identity in connection with the land, in the pioneers' phrase: livnot v'lehibanot, to build and to be built.

Week 31, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 214 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Accepting Greatness with Humility

Channah's third verse warns off pride: "Do not increasingly speak haughtily; Let not arrogance come out of your mouth, For the Lord is a God of thoughts, And to Him are deeds counted." Which is the horse again, looking to Hashem like a servant for all its strength. Israel's victory in the War of Independence came of His great mercy and is no reason for haughtiness.

The Pirkei Avot quality is that the Torah raises him above all creations. Even while it says that one who studies for its own sake is raised above everything, the word used is creations, Ma'assim, rather than things or people — which keeps the proportion right, since even the highest being is a minute creation beside the Creator. This is the very last of the qualities, the culmination of all the others.

Proverbs 31 begins with a king raised above everyone and chastised all the same by the one who gave him life: "The words of Lemuel the king; a prophecy that his mother chastised him; What, my son, and what, the son of my womb, and what, the son of my vows?" It is the last chapter of the book, and it closes with Eshet Chayil, an ode to the Torah itself.

The week holds many yahrzeits, among them two prominent students of the Maggid of Mezritch. Rabbi Menachem Mendel of Vitebsk, on the 1st of Iyar, was an elder disciple of the Magid and one of the earliest Chasidic rebbes; he led the first modern aliyah to Israel, in 1777, where he and three hundred Chasidim and others settled in Tsefat, and after a few years they moved to Tiberias, where he is buried in the students of the Baal Shem Tov section of the Old Cemetery. His works include Pri HaAretz and Likutei Amarim. Rabbi Shmuel Shmelke HaLevi Horowitz of Nikolsburg, on the 2nd of Iyar, was a major disciple of the Maggid along with his younger brother Rabbi Pinchas, who became the Rabbi of Frankfort; many of the leading rebbes in Poland and Galitzia were originally his disciples, and among his books are Divrei Shmuel and Nazir HaShem. Also this week: Rabbi Chaim Vital, principal student of the Arizal, on the 30th of Nissan; Rabbi Yaakov Beirav, Chief Rabbi of Tzfat, and Rabbi Avraham of Slonim-Baranovich, the Beis Avrohom, on the 1st of Iyar; Rabbi Shmuel Eliyahu, son of Rabbi Shaul Yedidya Elazer Taub, the Modzhitzer Rebbe, on the 4th; Rabbi Chaim Meir Yechiel Shapira of Mogelnitz on

the 5th; and Rabbi Yaakov Chaim Perlow, the Stoliner Rebbe, and Rabbi Yosef Meir Weiss on the 6th.

Week 31, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 215 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Strong and Praiseworthy

This week the Song's verses are all praise paid by the other nations, and a wish to cleave to the Jews. "How fair are your feet in sandals, O daughter of nobles! The curves of your thighs are like jewels, the handiwork of a craftsman." "Your navel is [like] a round basin, where no mixed wine is lacking; your belly is [like] a stack of wheat, fenced in with roses." "Your two breasts are like two fawns, the twins of a gazelle." That reads as rare and out of place, and it is exactly what happened after Yom Ha'Atzma'ut: for the first time in a long while, the Jews were widely admired, from 1948 onward. Rashi notes that where the Jewish people praise G-d from the top down, beginning at the head, the nations' praises of the Jewish people run from the bottom up, beginning at the feet — and the first praise after the War of Independence was for deeds and military might, which belong to the feet. The twins of a gazelle may be Iyar too: Yissachar and Zebulun, whose partnership was like twins.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirty-first is Elon, which means oak tree — majestic, large, strong, enduring. Elon Moreh is another name for Shechem, the first place Avraham visited, and Yaakov, and Yehoshua on entering the Land; and in modern times the first settlement established in Judea and Samaria after the Six Day War was Elon Moreh. Shechem is the gateway to the Land of Israel.

Daf Lamed Alef of Shvuot keeps on with the oath of a witness in court and with staying clear of falsehood, and takes up who is excluded from liability for a court oath, and mistakes made by accident or on purpose, Shogeg uMezid. The return to the Land is often discussed in Jewish law through the three oaths made during exile, one of them not to return by force. There is much debate over whether returning violated it, and if so whether, in the circumstances, anyone could be liable for it. Almost all opinions hold that it was not a violation.

Jeremiah's thirty-first chapter says it openly — a return, to build and be built. "Yet again will I rebuild you, then you shall be built, O virgin of Israel; yet again shall you be adorned with your tabrets, and you shall go out with the dances of those who make merry. Yet again shall you plant vineyards on the mountains of Samaria." The call: "Rise! Let us go up to Zion, to the Lord, our God." The gathering, and who is in it: "Behold I bring them from the north country and gather them from the uttermost ends of the earth, the blind and the lame amongst them, the woman with child and she who travails with child all together; a great company shall they return there. With weeping will they come, and with supplications will I lead them, along brooks of water will I make them go, on a straight road upon which they will not stumble." The shepherd: "He Who scattered Israel will gather them together and watch them as a shepherd his flock." The turning: "I will turn their mourning into joy and will comfort them and make them rejoice from their sorrow." And then Rachel, and the answer to her: "A voice is heard on high, lamentation, bitter weeping, Rachel weeping for her children, she refuses to be comforted for her children for they are not. So says the Lord: Refrain your voice from weeping and your eyes from tears, for there is reward for your work, says the Lord, and they shall come back from the land of the enemy. And there is hope for your future, says the Lord, and the children shall return to their own border."

Week 31, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 216 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the First Week of Iyar - Psalms 91-93; 90:11-13; 89:32

The first week of Iyar in psalms: the ninety-first, ninety-second and ninety-third, with three verses of Psalm 90 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 91 moves people to seek shelter under the wings of the Divine Presence. It also speaks of the four seasons of the year and their respective ministering powers, telling those who safeguard their souls to avoid them. "You who dwells in the shelter of the Most High, who abides in the shadow of the Omnipotent: I say of the Lord who is my refuge and my stronghold, my G-d in whom I trust, that He will save you from the ensnaring trap, from the destructive pestilence. He will cover you with His pinions and you will find refuge under His wings; His truth is a shield and an armor."

Then the four times of danger: “You will not fear the terror of the night, nor the arrow that flies by day; the pestilence that prowls in the darkness, nor the destruction that ravages at noon.” Then the arithmetic of it: “A thousand may fall at your [left] side, and ten thousand at your right, but it shall not reach you.” Then the angels: “For He will instruct His angels in your behalf, to guard you in all your ways. They will carry you in their hands, lest you injure your foot upon a rock. You will tread upon the lion and the viper.” And the promise at the end: “When he calls on Me, I will answer him; I am with him in distress. I will deliver him and honor him. I will satiate him with long life, and show him My deliverance.”

Psalm 92 the Levites sang every Shabbat in the Holy Temple; it speaks of the World to Come and comforts those crushed by suffering. “It is good to praise the Lord, and to sing to Your Name, O Most High; to proclaim Your kindness in the morning, and Your faithfulness in the nights.” The thing a fool cannot see: “When the wicked thrive like grass, and all evildoers flourish-it is in order that they may be destroyed forever.” And the tree that answers the grass: “The righteous will flourish like a palm tree, grow tall like a cedar in Lebanon. Planted in the House of the Lord, they shall blossom in the courtyards of our G-d. They shall be fruitful even in old age; they shall be full of sap and freshness- to declare that the Lord is just; He is my Strength, and there is no injustice in Him.”

Psalm 93 is the Messianic era, when He will don grandeur and leave no room for a man to boast before Him as Nebuchadnezzar, Pharaoh and Sennacherib did. “The Lord is King; He has garbed Himself with grandeur; the Lord has robed Himself, He has girded Himself with strength; He has also established the world firmly that it shall not falter. Your throne stands firm from of old; You have existed forever.” Then the rivers: “The rivers have raised, O Lord, the rivers have raised their voice; the rivers raise their raging waves. More than the sound of many waters, than the mighty breakers of the sea, is the Lord mighty on High.”

Psalm 90's verses ask for the measure of a day: “Who can know the intensity of Your anger? Your wrath is commensurate with one’s fear of You. Teach us, then, to reckon our days, that we may acquire a wise heart. Relent, O Lord; how long [will Your anger last]? Have compassion upon Your servants.” And Psalm 89's verse continues last week’s condition: “if they profane My statutes and do not observe My commandments.”

Day 217 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Horse is Saying

The horse opens, and the week sets the prancing of the mighty against the eyes of a servant.

The statutes and the prancings first: “If they profane My statutes and do not observe My commandments” / “By reason of the prancings” / “The prancings of their mighty ones” / “Do not increasingly speak haughtily” / “Let not arrogance come out of your mouth” / “[He is] the G-d Whose way is perfect” / “The word of the Lord is tried.”

Then the shield, with the asking how long: “Your wrath is commensurate with one’s fear of You” / “He is a shield unto all them that trust in Him” / “Relent, O Lord; how long? Have compassion upon Your servants” / “Who can know the intensity of Your anger?”

Then the servant’s eyes, and the reckoning of days: “Behold, as the eyes of the servants to the hand of their master” / “So are our eyes to G-d our Lord until He will favor us” / “And Moses said to Aaron, Say to the entire community of the children of Israel” / “Teach us, then, to reckon our days” / “That we may acquire a wise heart.”

Then the glory in the cloud, and the praises from the feet up: “And it came to pass when Aaron spoke to the entire community of the children of Israel” / “That they turned toward the desert, and behold! The glory of the Lord appeared in the cloud” / “How fair are your feet in sandals, O daughter of nobles!” / “As the eyes of the maidservant to the hand of her mistress” / “The curves of your thighs are like jewels, the handiwork of a craftsman” / “Your navel is a round basin, where no mixed wine is lacking” / “Your belly is [like] a stack of wheat, fenced in with roses” / “Your two breasts are like two fawns, the twins of a gazelle.”

And the end is the curse on Meroz and the two rocks: “'Curse you Meroz,' said the messenger of the Lord” / “'Curse you bitterly inhabitants thereof'” / “For the Lord is a G-d of thoughts, and to Him are deeds counted” / “For their rock is not like our Rock” / “Nevertheless, our enemies sit in judgment” / “Draw near before the Lord, for He has heard your complaints.”

Week 31, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXXII

Netzach of Hod

Days 218–224

Day 218 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Recognize Deep in Our Heart How Small We Are, How Great G-d Is

The mule is saying, "All the kings of earth shall acknowledge You, G-d, for they have heard the sayings of Your mouth." (Psalms 138:4) The second week of Iyar, still joined to the miracles of Israel's independence — it was then that the right of the Jewish people to the Land of Israel was clearly recognised by the leaders of the world and the United Nations. A verse of the Psalms says, "Do not be like the horse or like the mule, without understanding." It took the nations a long time to understand that right, and for that brief moment in history the world did recognise it.

There is a contrast between this week's animal and next week's. The mule belongs to the gentile prophet Bilaam, whose mule spoke to him; the donkey belongs to Abraham, and to Moshe and Mashiach. The two lives run in parallel. Pirkei Avot teaches that Abraham and Bilaam are polar opposites: Abraham humble and the greatest source of blessing, Bilaam arrogant and the greatest source of curse. Rashi compares Abraham rising early to saddle his donkey, to go and sacrifice Isaac, with Bilaam rising early to saddle his mule, to meet Balak, bring sacrifices and try to curse the Jewish people. Abraham and his descendants were promised the Land; Balak and Bilaam did everything in their power to take it from them. In the end Bilaam was forced not only to recognise the glory of Israel but to praise it and bless it tremendously, and both he and Balak were later defeated by the conquering Israelites.

Iyar belongs to Issachar, whom the Torah calls a strong-boned donkey, and a mule is a donkey bred with a horse. The mule also carries this month's theme of deficiency and the need for healing: it cannot procreate.

Thirty-two is the thirty-two paths of wisdom, chochmah, named in Kabbalah. There are three opinions about Bilaam's connection to Laban: that Bilaam was Laban himself, or his son, or his grandson. Laban's name, Lamed Beit Nun, holds the thirty-two paths of wisdom, lamed beit, and the fifty gates of understanding, nun. Had Laban nullified himself before Yaakov, the tzadik of the generation, the evil in him would have been nullified and all those levels revealed in him.

Thirty-two is also lamed and beit, which spell lev, heart. Sometimes we understand something with the intellect and still cannot get the heart to understand it. For all the heart's stubbornness, in the end we will all acknowledge Hashem, as the mule's song says plainly. One way to hurry it is the saying of our sages the Lubavitcher Rebbe often quoted: words that come from the heart enter the heart. Lev is not only the physical organ; the heart of a thing is its essence. The Torah, which is the essence of Hashem, ends with lamed and begins with beit, which spells lev. The Land of Israel is the heart of our people, and Jerusalem is the heart of our heart. And in the episode of the spies, the only one besides Joshua who stood firmly for our ability to conquer the Land was called Kalev — the name itself shows his connection to our heart.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Levitas of Yavneh, who turns to the other side of the heart, the yetzer harah: be very, very humble, for the hope of mortal man is worms. The word he uses for man is enosh, the lowest of all the names for a human being: if we keep to our physical side, our only hope is to be food for worms. Attend to the soul instead, the divine part of us, and we will know how to use our hearts, and will be able to love our neighbour as ourselves. That is also the lesson of chapter 32, the lev of the Tanya. And it is close to the phrase Abraham is most famous for: "I am like dust and ashes" — dust, because man comes from dust and returns to it, and ashes, because Abraham and Sarah were sterile and could have no children, like the mule. And G-d is capable of anything: children for Abraham and Sarah, speech for a mule, the kings of the nations recognising His words, and Bilaam blessing Israel.

The combination is netzach shebehod. It takes great persistence to reach our own hearts. The mule is persistence and stubbornness itself. This week is also the yahrzeit of Eli the High Priest, on the 10th of Iyar: besides being Kohen Gadol he was leader of the generation, so he held both of these sefirot together — as Samuel, his disciple, also represents both, since the Book of Psalms equates him to Moses and to Aaron.

Eli's death, falling backwards and breaking his neck on hearing the fate of the Mishkan, is close to next week's animal: the Torah commands that an owner who does not intend to redeem a firstborn donkey with a sacrifice must break the donkey's neck, and in Kabbalah the neck is the part of the body most associated with the Holy Temple and the Mishkan. The other animal with a commandment about breaking a neck is a female calf, in the case of an unexplained murder — and the mule is close to the donkey and female like the calf.

The lesson from the mule is that even kings, the rich and the powerful, must understand that they are completely subject to Hashem, who controls everyone without distinction. If anything a king is more subject than anyone, as Proverbs says: "A king's heart is like rivulets of water in the Lord's hand; wherever He wishes, He turns it."

Week 32, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 219 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Nahum and Light that Comes from Darkness

The second week of Iyar. Haazinu: "For their vine is of the vine of Sodom, and of the field of Gemorrah; their grapes are grapes of rosh, and they have bitter clusters." (Deuteronomy 32:32) Read of the Jewish people, their actions paralleled Sodom and Gemorrah and deserved great punishment. It can as easily be read of their enemies, following the verse just before it. And it can be read as the victory they won, which came out of enduring the suffering and the fermentation of Sodom, and the fields — the concentration camps — of Gemorrah: the strength came out of the bitterness. Rashi notes that the second half of the verse, and the next one, concern the suffering the Jews endured.

The Haftorah keeps to the positive: "For who is G-d, save the Lord? And who is a rock, save our G-d?" (II Samuel 22:32) He alone is G-d, and He alone is the Tzur. This week is bound to the one before it, Yom Ha'Atzma'ut, and to the one before that, Yom HaShoah.

The quality is loving G-d, ohev et HaMakom — and why that name for Him here? Perhaps because this week belongs to the Land of Israel, and it is in that place that we experience Him as fully as possible, as Yaakov did at Beit-El.

The prophet is Nahum, whose message is also that after great suffering He has redeemed the people and the Land, and so we show Him appreciation and love: “Behold on the mountains the feet of a herald announcing peace. O Judah, keep your feasts, pay your vows-for the wicked one shall no longer continue to pass through you; he has been completely cut off.” And then: “Watch the way! Strengthen your loins! Fortify your power mightily. For the Lord has restored the pride of Jacob as the pride of Israel.”

The levitical city is Dobrath, which means gathering a flock together — a perfect name for the week that marks the flock of the People of Israel gathered back to its Land. More fitting still, Dobrath is the name of a well-known kibbutz established in 1946, against much struggle and Arab opposition.

Week 32, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 220 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Battling for the Land, Laying the Foundations

Like last week, this one is tied to Yom Ha’Atzmaut and the Land. Beshalach: “The Lord spoke to Moses, saying, I have heard the complaints of the children of Israel. Speak to them, saying, In the afternoon you shall eat meat, and in the morning you shall be sated with bread, and you shall know that I am the Lord, your G-d.” He heard the complaints, and answered them mercifully and miraculously.

The Haftorah names again those who did not come: “because they came not to the aid of the Lord, to the aid of the Lord against the mighty.” Why would He need aid in battle? Rashi states that those who aid Israel are as if they aid the Divine Presence. In 1948 the nations of the world did not come to Israel’s aid. The Jewish people faced tremendous odds and came through by Divine mercy.

Daf Lamed Beit of Sotah takes up invalid witnesses, and the statements that must be said in Hebrew to be valid, and the blessings and curses said at Mount Grizim and Mount Eival when the people entered the Land. Entering the Land is this week; and the Hebrew may point to the renewal of the everyday use of the language.

The generation is Yishai, son of Obed and father of King David, and he was great in many ways. He is one of the eight princes of man in Micha according to Sukkah. He went out at the head of a multitude of followers and returned with a multitude,

and he taught Torah to a multitude. He inspired David to fight Goliath. Four people died solely because of the serpent's advice to Eve, having never sinned, and Ishai was one of them. The Sages said that Ishai lived more than 400 years. He is identified as Beis haLachmi, usually rendered as from Beis Lechem, Bethlehem. Radak quotes a Midrashic reading of that term: after David killed Goliath, King Saul asked who David was, which is puzzling since he already knew — so some read the question as whether he was the scion of a powerful line, and David answered that he was a son of Yishai Beis haLachmi, meaning a man of war, from Milchamah.

This is week 32, whose gematria is lev, heart. Yishai, spelled yud, shin, yud, has the gematria of 320, ten times Lev. His name reads as Yesh Yud, there is Yud, perhaps the 32 paths of Chochmah, which are also Lev. Yishai laid the foundations for his son David to be king, as the pioneering generation that made the return possible laid the foundations for a redemption still to come. And like Israel's pioneers, he was a man of war.

The journey is from Abronah to Etzion geber, which means the crow of the rooster, and may also mean the wisdom of the rooster. The personal journey moves from re-establishing our identity with the land to the spiritual awakening of Lag Ba'omer, when we open ourselves to the inner wisdom of the Kabbalah.

Week 32, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 221 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Ups and Downs

Channah's fourth verse turns everything over: "The bows of the mighty are broken; And those who stumbled, are girded with strength." Which is an accurate description of what happened in 1948.

From here Pirkei Avot stops describing those who study Torah for its own sake and takes up verses on the greatness of the Torah itself, which gives life to its observers in this world and in the World To Come: "For they are life to he who finds them, and a healing to all his flesh." The first verse is life and the healing of flesh. At independence the Jewish people were broken, and somehow gathered strength and found life and healing. The same can be said of Channah.

And the readings move from Proverbs to Ecclesiastes. Its first chapter is the world going round in circles, with its ups and downs: the wicked may be on top for a time, and they fall in the end, and life and endurance go to those who stay humble. “The words of Koheleth son of David, king in Jerusalem.” Rashi reads the opening that way — the sun rises, all the rivers run into the sea — and says he calls the wicked the sun, the moon and the sea, which have no reward; so it was taught in Sifrei, that the section deals with the wicked and compares them to the rising of the sun, which ultimately sets. Then: “A generation goes and a generation comes, but the earth endures forever.” Rashi: however much a wicked man toils and labours to oppress and to rob, he does not outlive his works, for the generation goes and another comes and takes it all from his sons. And who are the ones who endure? The humble and low, who bring themselves down to the earth, as it says, “But the humble shall inherit the earth.” And the Midrash Tanhuma states that all the righteous of Israel are called earth, as it is said, “for you shall be a desirable land.” Then: “It goes to the south and goes around to the north; the will goes around and around, and the will returns to its circuits.” Rashi again: however much the sun of the wicked rises, it will set; however much power they gain, they return to the place of filth they came from.

The week holds many yahrzeits, among them the founders of two prominent Chassidic lines. Rabbi Yitzchak Isaac Yehuda Yechiel Safrin ben Alexander Sender of Komarno, on the 10th of Iyar, was one of the most prolific and respected expounders of the Kabbalah teachings of the Baal Shem Tov. He insisted that every Jew should study the Zohar and the Writings of the Arizal, and emphasised the importance of Kabbalistic meditation. A close disciple of Rebbe Tzvi Hersh from Zhiditchov — Komarno is considered a branch of Zhiditchov — he was a hidden ascetic for many years, and only later, as Rebbe of thousands of chasidim, became known for his genius, piety and ability to work wonders. He wrote volumes on Jewish mysticism and on Mishnah and law; his commentaries include Heichal HaBrachah on the Torah, Otzar HaChaim on the commandments, and Zohar Chai on the Zohar.

Rabbi Naftali of Ropshitz, on the 11th of Iyar, was born on the same day the Besht passed away, and became rebbe to many thousands. Deciding to join the chassidic movement, he chose Rabbi Elimelech of Lizensk as his mentor, and then became a dedicated chasid of the three patriarchs: the Chozeh of Lublin, the Maggid of Koznitz, and Rabbi Menachem Mendel of Rymanov. During the Napoleonic wars the

Tzaddikim were divided over Napoleon. Rabbi Menachem Mendel of Rymanov strongly supported him and held that the wars were Gog and Magog, a prelude to the Messiah; his disciple Rabbi Naftali, and Rabbi Shneur Zalman, the Baal HaTanya, were strongly opposed, sensing that a victory would bring changes that would threaten the community's way of life. After those three passed away he settled in Ropshitz, which became the focal point for thousands of chassidim. Ropshitz chassidut is known for its captivating niggunim, melodies of ecstasy and of yearning for nearness to G-d. He is a crucial figure in the development of Galician Chassidut, and many minhagei Ropshitz are followed in Galicia. He was known for profound wisdom, a sharp sense of humour and musical gifts, and was a master of kabbalistic interpretation; his demeanour, sermons and witticisms hid a depth that only his closest students could reach, foremost among them Rabbi Chaim of Tzanz. Some of his teachings are in Zera Kodesh, Ayalah Sheluchah and Imrei Shefer, and many stories about him are in Ohel Naftoli.

Also this week: Rabbi Yerachmiel Rabinowitz of Peshischa, son of the Yid HaKadosh, and Rabbi Moshe Mordechai Twersky of Lublin-Trisk, both on the 8th of Iyar; Rabbi David Twerski of Tolna, son of Rabbi Mordechai of Chernobyl, on the 10th; and Rabbi Masoud Abuchatzeira, son of the Abir Yaakov and father of the Baba Sali, on the 12th.

Week 32, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 222 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Securing Our Connection to the Land in the Face of the Enemy

The Song's verses are the nations' praises again, and they are full of places in the region, where so many came to attack us: "Your neck is like an ivory tower; your eyes are [like] pools in Heshbon, by the gate of Bath-Rabbim; your face is as the tower of Lebanon, facing towards Damascus." "Your head upon you is like Carmel, and the braided locks of your head are like purple; the king is bound in the tresses." "How fair and how pleasant you are, a love with delights!" Heshbon is in Jordan; and there is Lebanon, and Damascus.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirty-second is Jahleel, whose name means to wait for, to yearn for G-d. Yachel also carries forgiveness, and

nullification, and desecration. This week is about the nations finally acknowledging Israel after so many years, and its animal is the mule, which belongs to Bilaam — who was trying to nullify the oath G-d made to Abraham, and was in many ways the anti-Abraham. And it is the heart, since 32 is Lev. We yearn for Hashem with all our hearts and to return to our land, and in that, He nullifies those who fight our connection to the Land of Israel.

Daf Lamed Beit of Shevuoth keeps on with who is excluded from liability for a court oath — which is last week's three oaths again.

Jeremiah's thirty-second chapter says the return openly, and the prophet himself is told to redeem his family's portion of the Land by buying it. "Behold, Hanamel, the son of Shallum your uncle, is coming to you, saying: Buy for yourself my field that is in Anathoth, for the right of redemption is yours to buy it." Then the deed, witnessed and put away to last: "Take these scrolls, this deed of purchase and the signed one and this open scroll, and put them into an earthen vessel so that they remain many years. For so says the Lord of Hosts, the God of Israel; Houses and fields and vineyards shall be purchased again in this land." Then the gathering: "Behold I will gather them from all the lands where I have driven them with My anger and with My wrath and with great fury, and I will restore them to this place and I will cause them to dwell safely. And they shall be My people, and I will be their God." Then the covenant: "And I will form for them an everlasting covenant, that I will not turn away from them to do them good, and My fear I will place in their heart, not to turn away from Me. And I will rejoice over them to do good to them, and I will plant them in this land truly with all My heart and with all My soul." And the measure of it: "As I have brought upon this people all this great evil, so will I bring upon them all the good that I speak concerning them." And the fields bought in a land now called desolate: "Men shall buy fields for money and inscribe deeds and sign [them] and appoint witnesses in the land of Benjamin and in the environs of Jerusalem."

Week 32, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 223 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second Week of Iyar - Psalms 94-96; 90:14-16; 89:33

The second week of Iyar in psalms: the ninety-fourth, ninety-fifth and ninety-sixth, with three verses of Psalm 90 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 94 is a prayer any individual can use for the redemption, and an important moral teaching with it. “The Lord is a G-d of retribution; O G-d of retribution, reveal Yourself! Judge of the earth, arise; render to the arrogant their recompense. How long shall the wicked, O Lord, how long shall the wicked exult?” What they do, and what they say about it: “They kill the widow and the stranger, and murder the orphans. And they say, 'The Lord does not see, the G-d of Jacob does not perceive.'” Then the answer, which is made of questions: “Shall He who implants the ear not hear? Shall He who forms the eye not see? Shall He who chastises nations not punish?” Then the fortunate man: “Fortunate is the man whom You chastise, O Lord, and instruct him in Your Torah, bestowing upon him tranquillity in times of adversity, until the pit is dug for the wicked. For the Lord will not abandon His people, nor forsake His heritage.” And the holding up: “When I thought that my foot was slipping, Your kindness, O Lord, supported me. When my [worrisome] thoughts multiply within me, Your consolation delights my soul.”

Psalm 95 speaks of the time when a man will say to his fellow, come, let us sing and offer praise to G-d for the miracles He has done for us. “Come, let us sing to the Lord; let us raise our voices in jubilation to the Rock of our deliverance.” Whose everything is: “in His hands are the depths of the earth, and the heights of the mountains are His. Indeed, the sea is His, for He made it; His hands formed the dry land.” Then the flock, and the condition: “For He is our G-d, and we are the people that He tends, the flock under His [guiding] hand-even this very day, if you would but hearken to His voice!” And the warning from the wilderness: “Do not harden your heart as at Merivah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness, where your fathers tested Me; they tried Me, though they had seen My deeds. For forty years I quarreled with that generation.”

Psalm 96 is the same time coming: come, let us sing to G-d. “Sing to the Lord a new song; sing to the Lord, all the earth. Sing to the Lord, bless His Name; proclaim His deliverance from day to day. Recount His glory among the nations, His wonders

among all the peoples." Then the call to the families of nations to bring an offering and come to His courtyards. And then the whole world joining in, which is how it ends: "The heavens will rejoice, the earth will exult; the sea and its fullness will roar. The fields and everything therein will jubilate; then all the trees of the forest will sing. Before the Lord [they shall rejoice], for He has come, for He has come to judge the earth; He will judge the world with justice, and the nations with His truth."

Psalm 90's verses ask for joy to match the affliction: "Satiate us in the morning with Your kindness, then we shall sing and rejoice throughout our days. Give us joy corresponding to the days You afflicted us, the years we have seen adversity. Let Your work be revealed to Your servants, and Your splendor be upon their children." And Psalm 89's verse completes the condition of the last two weeks: "then I will punish their transgression with the rod and their misdeeds with plagues."

Week 32, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 224 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Mule Is Saying

The mule opens, and the week sets broken bows against the kings who acknowledge Him.

The breaking and the acknowledging first: "The bows of the mighty are broken" / "And those who stumbled, are girded with strength" / "All the kings of earth shall acknowledge You, G-d" / "For they have heard the sayings of Your mouth."

Then the towers and the pools, with the asking for joy: "Your neck is like an ivory tower" / "Your eyes are [like] pools in Heshbon, by the gate of Bath-Rabbim" / "Your face is as the tower of Lebanon, facing towards Damascus" / "Your head upon you is like Carmel" / "Give us joy corresponding to the days You afflicted us" / "The years we have seen adversity."

Then the vine of Sodom, and those who did not come: "For their vine is of the vine of Sodom" / "And of the field of Gemorrah" / "Because they came not to the aid of the Lord" / "To the aid of the Lord against the mighty" / "For who is G-d, save the Lord?" / "And who is a rock, save our G-d?"

Then the braided locks, and the splendour upon the children: "And the braided locks of your head are like purple" / "The king is bound in the tresses" / "Let Your

work be revealed to Your servants” / “And Your splendor be upon their children.”

And the end is the meat and the bread, with the bitter clusters between: “The Lord spoke to Moses, saying, I have heard the complaints of the children of Israel” / “Their grapes are grapes of rosh, and they have bitter clusters” / “Speak to them, saying, 'In the afternoon you shall eat meat'” / “'And in the morning you shall be sated with bread'” / “Satiate us in the morning with Your kindness” / “Then we shall sing and rejoice throughout our days” / “And you shall know that I am the Lord, your G-d” / “How fair and how pleasant you are, A love of delights!”

Week 32, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXXIII

Hod of Hod

Days 225–231

Day 225 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Recognize the Spiritual Treasures Hidden within Each One of Us

Week thirty-three is the week of Pesach Sheini and Lag Ba'Omer. Lag Ba'Omer is a day of great celebration, because it was then that the students of Rabbi Akiva stopped perishing. It is also the yahrzeit of Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai — Yesod ha'Olam, the foundation of the world — and the custom is to light a bonfire in his honor, representing the great light he brought to the world through his teachings of Kabbalah.

In Perek Shirah the creature of this week is the donkey, which proclaims: "Yours, O Lord, are the greatness, and the might, and the glory, and the victory, and the majesty, for all that is in the heavens and on the earth is Yours; Yours is the kingdom and You are He Who is exalted over everything as the Leader." (I Chronicles 29:11) King David recited this verse when he was at the height of his glory, reiterating that everything is from Hashem: glory and kingship, the Heavens and the earth.

In the Counting of the Omer this is the week of hod, acknowledgement — Hod shebeHod — so it is quite appropriate that the song of the donkey should so gracefully acknowledge that everything comes from G-d. The song contains all seven emotional sefirot: gedulah is a reference to chesed; then come gevurah, tiferet, netzach and hod; hakol is a reference to yesod; and mamlachah, a reference to malchut.

From Pirkei Avot, Rabbi Yochanan the son of Berokah: whoever desecrates the Divine Name covertly is punished in public, and regarding the desecration of the Name the malicious and the merely negligent are one and the same.

Pesach Sheini is the yahrzeit of Rabbi Meir.

Week 33, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 226 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Chabakuk and Torah that Comes from Suffering

The thirty-third week is the week of Pesach Sheini and Lag Ba'Omer, and in Haazinu the verse speaks again of the bitter punishment faced by the Jewish people, comparing it to wine: "Their wine is the bitterness of serpents, and the bitterness of the ruthless cobras." (Deuteronomy 32:33) Read in a positive light, their deep Torah wisdom came from the bitter serpents, and their ability to be a head — to have a deep mind — from dealing with ruthless cobras.

Wine is also a known metaphor for the essence and the hidden part of the Torah, associated primarily with the works of Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai. The joy of Lag Ba'Omer comes in contrast to the suffering and the mourning of the Omer period, with the passing of twenty-four thousand of Rabbi Akiva's students. Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai himself acquired this wine through much suffering, and in the end he said that the suffering he endured was very much worth it.

The haftorah verse: "G-d is He who has fortified me with strength; and He looseth perfectly my path." (II Samuel 22:33) The word for strength is chayil, a known reference to the Torah, the source of King David's power. The verse also carries a word written differently from how it is spoken — darchoh, His way, rather than darchi, my way — so that it reads: G-d makes clear to me His perfect way. The word for perfect is tamim, itself a reference to the Torah, as David says, Torat Hashem Tmimah Meshivat Nafesh.

The quality of this week is Ohev et HaBriot, loving the creations, the third term Rabbi Meir uses of those who study Torah lishmah. The prophet is Chabakuk; the Levitical city, Jarmuth.

Week 33, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 227 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Blessed Above All Others

Week thirty-three is the week of Pesach Sheini and Lag Ba'Omer, and the Torah portion section for this week first introduces the Mannah: "It came to pass in the evening that the quails went up and covered the camp, and in the morning there was a layer of dew around the camp. The layer of dew went up, and behold, on the surface of the desert, a fine, bare substance as fine as frost on the ground."

The Mannah is fine as frost and compared to the dew, in contrast with the physicality of the quail. That contrast is also one between the revealed Torah, nigleh, and the Kabbalah, nistar. In nigleh there is back and forth and room for digestion — setting aside certain opinions and coming to conclusions. When it comes to Kabbalah there is no need for separating the good from the bad. There is also an opinion that the Mannah began falling on Lag Ba'Omer, and that this is the reason for its celebration.

The haftorah: "Blessed above women shall Jael, the wife of Heber the Kenite, be; above women in the tent shall she be blessed." The women in the tent are a reference to the blessings given to the matriarchs (Talmud, Sanhedrin 105). Similarly, Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai is said to be praiseworthy above all of his colleagues.

Daf Lamed Gimmel of Sotah continues the discussion of statements that must be said in Hebrew to be valid and those that may be said in any language, and the blessings and curses said at Mount Grizim and Mount Eival. It goes into the language of angels and heavenly voices, and contains a story of what Shimon HaTzadik heard in the Kodesh HaKodashim.

The generation is David. The journey: they journeyed from Ezion geber and camped in the desert of Zin, which is Kadesh.

Week 33, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 228 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Health

Channah's fifth verse keeps last week's reversals going and turns them to the body: "They that were full have hired out themselves for bread; and they that were hungry have ceased; while the barren hath borne seven, she that had many children hath languished." Physical wealth and health, and above all the ability to have children.

Pirkei Avot, on the greatness of the Torah, stays physical too, and seems to point the same way: "It shall be health to your navel, and marrow to your bones."

Ecclesiastes 2 is the pleasures of the body and physical wealth, told by the one man who could afford all of them. "I said to myself, 'Come now, I will mix [wine] with joy and experience pleasure'; and behold, this too was vanity. Of laughter, I said, '[It is] mingled'; and concerning joy, 'What does this accomplish?'" Then the building: "I made myself great works; I built myself houses, and I planted myself vineyards. I made myself gardens and orchards, and I planted in them all sorts of fruit trees. I made myself pools of water, to water from them a forest sprouting with trees." Then the having: slaves and household and cattle and flocks, silver and gold and the treasures of kings and provinces, every kind of musical instrument, wagons and coaches — "So I became great, and I increased more than all who were before me in Jerusalem; also my wisdom remained with me. And [of] all that my eyes desired I did not deprive them; I did not deprive my heart of any joy." And then the accounting: "Then I turned [to look] at all my deeds that my hands had wrought and upon the toil that I had toiled to do, and behold everything is vanity and frustration, and there is no profit under the sun."

The week holds many yahrzeits, among them two prominent rebbes of the Chernobyl line. Rabbi Mordechai, Mottel, of Chernobyl, on the 20th of Iyar, succeeded his father Rabbi Nachum, and was the son-in-law of Rabbi Aharon the Great of Karlin and afterwards of Rabbi David Seirkes, an important disciple of the Baal Shem Tov. All eight of his sons became major Chasidic leaders. One of them, Yaakov Yisrael Twerski of Cherkassy, the first Hornsteipel Rebbe, married Devora Leah, one of the six daughters of Rabbi DovBer of Lubavitch, son of Rabbi Shneur Zalman of Liadi — a match the two grandfather-Rebbes arranged, to make the most of the prediction that the Moshiach would be born of the elder disciple of the

Maggid of Mezritch or the youngest. His grandson, named after him, Rabbi Mordechai, Mottele, Twersky of Rachmistrivka, on the 17th of Iyar, moved to Jerusalem from Europe in 1908; he was known for a sharp mind, and many businessmen sought his advice, and he was himself a skilled craftsman who did complex engravings in silver and copper. His father, Rabbi Yochanan Twerski, son of the famous Rebbe Mottele of Chernobyl, was the first Rebbe of Rachmistrivka.

Also this week: R' Chaim Meir Yechiel Shapira, the Saraph of Moglenitz, and Rabbi Shmuel of Karov-Vinagrov on the 15th of Iyar; Rabbi Moshe Chaim Ephraim of Sudylkov, the Degel Machaneh Ephraim, on the 17th; Rabbi Moshe Isserles, the Ramah, on the 18th; Rabbi Menachem Mendel of Riminov and Rabbi Shmuel Abuchatzeira, forefather of the Abuchatzeira dynasty, on the 19th; and Rabbi Yechi ben R' Avrohom Abuchatzeira on the 20th.

Week 33, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 229 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

The Tzadik

Lag Ba'Omer, and the counting enters a new stretch in which most people stop all signs of mourning. The Song changes speakers with it. Rashi: until this point the nations praise Him; from here on are the words of the Shechinah, to reveal Israel, who are among the nations. And Lag Ba'Omer is a day of tremendous revelation, the day of the Tzadik Yesod Olam, Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai.

The verses are the palm. "This, your stature, is like a palm tree, and your breasts are like clusters [of dates]. I said: Let me climb up the palm tree, let me seize its boughs, and let your breasts be now like clusters of the vine and the fragrance of your countenance like [that of] apples." The Tamar is the metaphor for the upright Tzadik Yesod Olam, and the vav, which is Yesod, stands upright too; in Perek Shirah the Tamar's own verse is "Tzadik KaTamar Yifrach, K'Erez BaLevanon Yizgueh." The vine is the hidden Torah, and the fragrance of apples is the fragrance of Gan Eden, which is known to be like an apple orchard. The third verse belongs here as well: "And your palate is like the best wine, that glides down smoothly to my beloved, making the lips of the sleeping speak." That is revelation — the inner secrets that gave the Jewish people life in times when they were spiritually asleep, and made their

lips speak.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirty-third is Dinah, the last directly descended from Leah; from here the count turns to Rachel's descendants, beginning with Joseph's family. The first listed, after Rachel, Joseph and Binyamin, who are left for the end, is Joseph's wife, Asenath daughter of Poti-phera Chief of On, whom the Midrash teaches is Dinah's own daughter.

The lesson of the Counting of the Omer and of Lag Ba'Omer is love and respect for one another, and Dinah is the great example of it. Leah foresaw that Dinah was to have been a boy, and prayed that she be turned into a girl so that Rachel could still merit two sons, founders of tribes. Asenath — daughter of Dinah, who came from Leah, and mother of Efraim and Menasheh by Joseph, who came from Rachel — holds that same union; and Efraim and Menashe are the link between the two sides of the people, Rachel and Leah, Yehudah and Yosef, which is why Jacob says those two will be to him like Reuven and Shimon. Dinah endured a great deal and was redeemed in the end, marrying Shimon and seeing her daughter marry Joseph. Dinah means judgement, strictness, and the Hey at the end of her name adds mercy. Asenath's name is harsh too: "And Dinah gave birth to a daughter and named her Asenat, saying, 'To my woe did I bear her for Shechem the son of Chamor who had taken me by force to his house.'" And her name carries an added Heh as well, since she is not called Bat Potiphar but Bat Potipherah.

Daf Lamed Gimmel of Shvuot keeps on with who is excluded from liability for a court oath, especially where there are two pairs of witnesses, with a long discussion of liability for fines, of claiming on behalf of someone else, and of oaths applying only to monetary claims. Lag Ba'Omer is the day we celebrate how the merit of Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai and his son, Rabbi Elazar, spared the whole world from judgement: in Rabbi Shimon's days there was never a rainbow in the sky, because the rainbow is the reminder of the oath never to destroy the world again, and in his time no such sign was needed. Fittingly, one of the main principles of this daf comes from an opinion of Rabbi Elazar son of Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai, and the next daf opens with words of Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai himself.

Jeremiah's thirty-third chapter is joy after desolation, and purification from sin, with the House of David and the Kohanim in it, and even the idea of counting. Iyar is a month of healing and Lag Ba'Omer a day of festivity, weddings among them.

“Behold, I will bring it healing and cure, and I will cure them, and I will reveal to them a greeting of peace and truth.” “And I will purify them of all their iniquity that they sinned against Me.” Then the sound returning to the empty streets: “There shall again be heard in this place, concerning which you say, 'It is desolate without man and without beast,' in the cities of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem that are desolate… the sound of mirth and the sound of joy, the voice of a bridegroom and the voice of a bride, the sound of those saying, 'Thank the Lord of Hosts, for the Lord is good, for His loving-kindness endures forever.'” Then the shepherds, and the counting: “flocks shall again pass under the hands of one who counts them.” And the plant: “In those days and in that time I will cause to grow for David a plant of righteousness, and he shall execute justice and righteousness in the land.” And the two lines that will not be cut off, the throne and the priesthood.

Week 33, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 230 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Iyar - Psalms 97-99; 90:17, 105:1-2; 89:34

The third week of Iyar in psalms: the ninety-seventh, ninety-eighth and ninety-ninth, with the last verse of Psalm 90, the opening of Psalm 105, and one verse of Psalm 89.

Psalm 97 is the revealing of His kingship. “When the Lord will reveal His kingship, the earth will exult; the multitudes of islands will rejoice. Clouds and dense darkness will surround Him; justice and mercy will be the foundation of His throne.” Then the melting: “The mountains will melt like wax before the Lord, before the Master of all the earth.” Then the idols: “All who worship graven images, who take pride in idols, will be ashamed.” And the end, which is sown rather than given: “You who love the Lord, hate evil; He watches over the souls of His pious ones, He saves them from the hand of the wicked. Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the upright in heart.”

Psalm 98 is how Israel will praise Him for the Redemption. “Sing to the Lord a new song, for He has performed wonders; His right hand and holy arm have wrought deliverance for Him.” Then the seeing of it: “He has made known His salvation; He has revealed His justice before the eyes of the nations. He has remembered His kindness and faithfulness to the House of Israel; all, from the farthest corners of the

earth, witnessed the deliverance by our G-d." Then the instruments — harp, trumpets, the sound of the shofar — and then the world joining: "The sea and its fullness will roar in joy, the earth and its inhabitants. The rivers will clap their hands, the mountains will sing together."

Psalm 99 refers to the wars of Gog and Magog, which come before the Redemption. "When the Lord will reveal His kingship, the nations will tremble; the earth will quake before Him Who is enthroned upon the cherubim." Then the three who were answered: "Moses and Aaron among His priests, and Samuel among those who invoke His Name, would call upon the Lord and He would answer them. He would speak to them from a pillar of cloud; they observed His testimonies and the decrees which He gave them." And both halves of the answer: "Lord our G-d, You have answered them; You were a forgiving G-d for their sake, yet bringing retribution for their own misdeeds."

Psalm 90 ends here, on our own hands: "And may the pleasantness of the Lord our G-d be upon us, and the work of our hands establish for us, and the work of our hands establish it." Psalm 105 begins: "Give thanks to the Lord, call out in His name; make His deeds known among the peoples. Sing to Him, play music to Him, speak of all His wonders." And Psalm 89's verse holds, as it has through the condition of the last three weeks: "But I shall not cancel My kindness from him, and I shall not betray My faith."

Week 33, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 231 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Donkey is Saying

The donkey opens with everything being His, and the week's books come in around it.

The greatness and the palm first: "Yours, G-d, is the greatness, and the might" / "And the splendor, and the victory, and the glory" / "This, your stature, is like a palm tree" / "And your breasts are like clusters [of dates]" / "Sing to Him, play music to Him, speak of all His wonders" / "For everything in the Heavens and earth [is Yours]" / "Yours, G-d, is the kingship, and the exaltation over all."

Then the blessing on Jael, with the bitter wine: “Blessed above women shall Jael” / “The wife of Heber the Kenite, be” / “Their wine is the bitterness of serpents” / “And the bitterness of the ruthless cobras” / “While the barren hath borne seven” / “She that had many children hath languished.”

Then the clusters and the apples, and the strength: “And let your breasts be now like clusters of the vine” / “And the fragrance of your countenance like apples” / “Above women in the tent shall she be blessed” / “G-d is He who has fortified me with strength” / “And He loosened perfectly my path” / “And may the pleasantness of the Lord our G-d be upon us.”

Then the quails and the dew, with the kindness not cancelled: “It came to pass in the evening that the quails went up and covered the camp” / “But I shall not cancel My kindness from him” / “And I shall not betray My faith” / “And in the morning there was a layer of dew around the camp” / “The layer of dew went up” / “I said: Let me climb up the palm tree” / “Let me seize its boughs” / “And behold, on the surface of the desert, a fine bare [substance] as fine as frost on the ground.”

And the end is the hungry who have ceased, and the work of our hands: “They that were full have hired out themselves for bread” / “And they that were hungry have ceased” / “Give thanks to the Lord, call out in His name” / “Make His deeds known among the peoples” / “And the work of our hands establish for us” / “And the work of our hands establish it.”

Week 33, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXXIV

Yesod of Hod

Days 232–238

Day 232 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Work in a Focused Manner and without Ego

The ox is saying, "Then Moses and the Children of Israel sang this song to G-d, and they said, I shall sing to G-d, for He has triumphed; He has thrown the horse and its rider into the sea." (Exodus 15:1) The month of Iyar is linked to Taurus, and the ox is the last of the farm animals to sing, with a verse from the opening of the Song of the Sea.

The sheep and the goat, the first farm animals, also sang a verse from the Song of the Sea, on Rosh Chodesh Nissan. The cow, which came next, sang a verse that calls the people Jacob, the more fragile and humble side — Yaakov is from Ekev, heel. The ox uses the name Israel, the stronger side. Across this journey of liberation, from the start of Nissan until now, we make the whole transformation from Jacob to Israel. The Hebrew for ox is Shor, which is near Shir, song, and Yashar, upright — and Israel itself reads as Yashar-El, the upright one of G-d, and, with the letters turned around, Shir-El, the song of G-d, and even Li-Rosh, to me is the head. The ox's song is in the future tense, which points to the World to Come.

There is the same journey inside Iyar. The first animal of the month was the horse, and now at its end the ox sings about the horse and its rider being thrown into the sea. Both are strength. But the horse's power is a somewhat unrestrained military might, where the ox is marked by humbly accepting its yoke; the ox's meat is kosher and the horse's is not. That firm acceptance of the yoke of Heaven is what is most precious in His eyes. The ox belongs to the conquest of the Land too, which is this month: "Moab became terrified of the people, for they were numerous, and Moab became disgusted because of the children of Israel. Moab said to the elders of Midian,

'Now this assembly will eat up everything around us, as the ox eats up the greens of the field.'" And Joseph is called an ox, and Joshua descended directly from Joseph.

Thirty-four is twice 17, the gematria of tov, good — the 17 years Jacob lived with Joseph in Israel and the 17 more he lived with Joseph in Egypt, the best years of his life. It is also the gematria of Vayechi, the portion that tells of Jacob's passing. So 34 is that journey from Yaakov to Yisrael, and the healing Jacob found on being reunited with his son. And it is the gematria of ga'al, redeemed.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yishmael the son of Rabbi Yossi: one who learns Torah in order to teach is given the opportunity to learn and teach; one who learns in order to do is given the opportunity to learn, teach, observe and do. That bears on the death of Rabbi Akiva's students during the omer. They died because they did not respect one another enough: those who thought they knew more believed the respect should come to them rather than from them. The thing that matters in learning is learning in order to teach and to do, not in order to feed one's own ego — which leads a person to think his knowledge makes him better than others, and defeats the whole purpose of having learned.

The combination is yesod shebehod. Joseph, who is yesod, is called an ox by Jacob in the blessing on his deathbed, in the portion of Vayechi. The lesson from the ox is to work on ourselves in a concentrated and humble way, remembering His omnipotence — and to keep in mind that He saved us from our enemies before, and does it again in every generation, so there is nothing to fear.

Week 34, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 233 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Zephaniah and Loving Tzedakot

The last week of Iyar. Haazinu asks a question: "Is it not stored up with Me, sealed up in My treasuries?" (Deuteronomy 32:34) By Rashi's plain reading, the sins of the Jewish people have not been forgotten; He has stored and preserved them. And there is room for another reading, because why would sins be sealed in His treasuries, which implies something He treasures rather than something He despises? Perhaps what is stored is not their sins but their suffering for His sake, which He does treasure. And that suffering gives access to His treasuries, as it did for Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai, and to the return to the Holy Land.

The Haftorah: "He makes my feet like hinds; And sets me upon my high places." (II Samuel 22:34) He set King David in Jerusalem, Ir David, which stands on a mountain, Mount Zion. As in the verse before it, the kri differs from the ksiv: it is read as making David's feet swift like hinds, presumably for battle, and the ksiv speaks instead of G-d's feet. The Torah says the Earth is the place of His feet, and His representatives on Earth are the Jewish people; Moshe once calls them feet. The word for hinds, Ayalot, is spelled like Ayalut, strength — as in Psalm 22, with Ayaluti, my strength — so the first half can read that He gives the people the power to overcome the enemy and conquer the Land, which fits the second half, David established in Jerusalem. It also recalls Moshe's final blessing, "Ve Atah Al Bamoeimoh Tidroch," and you shall trample upon their high places, which Rashi reads as Yehoshua, commanded in the conquest to place his own feet on the neck of the Cana'anite enemies — and the neck is also the Temple. And there is an almost identical verse at the end of Chabakuk's prayer, last week's prophet, where G-d comes gloriously to save the people and their anointed leader: "G-d the Lord is my strength. He made my feet [as swift] as the hind's, and he guides me on my high places. To the conductor [to play] with my melodies!"

Perhaps because Lag Ba'omer has passed, the quality is no longer one of the marks of someone who studies Torah for its own sake, though love continues in it: loves the ways of righteousness, ohev et hatzedakot. Righteousness stands in the plural and the feminine, which suggests it should also be read as loving the many givings of tzedakah. Charity is called tzedakah because it is not first of all an act of generosity

but an act of righteousness and justice. It is a quality found in every Jew, not only the observant ones — plainly so in the efforts to support the Jews of the Holy Land, and in the Zionist endeavour as a whole.

The prophet is Zephaniah, whose prophecy is full of it. “Seek the Lord, all you humble of the earth who executed His judgment; Seek righteousness, seek humility! Perhaps you will be concealed on the day of the Lord’s wrath.” “The Lord is just in her midst; He commits no injustice. Every morning He brings His judgment to light. It does not fail. But the one who commits injustice knows no shame.” “The remnant of Israel shall neither commit injustice nor speak lies; neither shall deceitful speech be found in their mouth, for they shall graze and lie down, with no one to cause them to shudder.” He also names what tzedakah stands against, the lust for money and the trust placed in it: “Neither their silver nor their gold will be able to save them on the day of the Lord’s wrath.”

The levitical city is 'Ein Gannim, the fountain of gardens. Ein also means eye, and it is the letter Ayin, whose value is seventy; one who gives tzedakah generously is said to have an Ayin Tovah. The Tanya draws the connection between Tzedakah and gardens — the Upper and the Lower Garden of Eden — and the letter Ayin. Charity is greater than all the commandments, because performing them produces garments for the soul: garments that let the soul withstand the intense Divine revelation it will meet in Gan Eden instead of being nullified by it, drawn from the light of the Ein Sof, so that having an infinite source they can bear an infinite revelation. And this is the meaning of “He who sows tzedakot brings forth yeshuot,” salvations — the drawing down of the light of the shin-ayin nehorin, the three hundred and seventy lights spoken of in the holy Zohar: shin, three hundred, for the three intellectual faculties of ChaBaD at the level called hundreds, and ayin, seventy, for the seven emotive attributes, each holding ten. That illumination, the helmet of salvation, is drawn onto the head, the beginning, of the Ten Sefirot.

Like Dobrath, 'Ein Gannim has its own connection to the Zionist endeavour: it was the name of Israel’s first Moshav Poalim, a worker’s settlement, a model a little different from the kibbutz, and among its residents were prominent members of the Zionist movement, David Ben-Gurion among them.

Week 34, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 234 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Feeling "Shalem" (Whole)

Beshalach describes what the Mannah actually was: "When the children of Israel saw [it], they said to one another, It is manna, because they did not know what it was, and Moses said to them, It is the bread that the Lord has given you to eat. This is the thing that the Lord has commanded, Gather of it each one according to his eating capacity, an omer for each person, according to the number of persons, each one for those in his tent you shall take." There was a social side to it, which had people talking to each other — and some commentaries say it had them not recognising one another, because after such spiritual food they stood at a higher level. And there was the miracle in it: each was to take one omer a person, and whatever anyone took came out according to his eating capacity. Him filling the people's needs with bread belongs to the healing of Iyar. "Omer lagulgolet" also looks toward Lag Ba'Omer, the main day of this month, since it holds the word omer, and lagulgolet in Hebrew has two Lamed Gimmels in a row — lag, lag.

The Haftorah sates thirst and hunger: "Water he requested, (but) milk she gave him: in a lordly bowl she brought him cream." Out of the context of Yael killing Sissera, which is a worthy event in itself, the verse hints at the motherly kindness of women, who offer milk and cream when only water was asked for. The mannah is the same: instead of simply giving bread from the earth, He gave heavenly bread, with its own powers and blessings.

Daf Lamed Dalet of Sotah keeps on with crossing the Jordan, the spies, and Hebron. Week 34 is the completion of a cycle, with the Jews now ready to enter the Land — and with the disaster of the spies to keep in mind.

The generation is Solomon, Shlomoh, whose name comes from Shalom, peace, and is also near Shalem, whole, complete. We finish Iyar with the sense of being whole again, healed. And Shlomoh lived to see his father's work completed and the Temple finished — and on that day he wrote the Song of Songs.

The journey is from Kadesh to Mount Hor, at the edge of the land of Edom. Hor HaHar is a double mountain, a small apple atop a big apple, and it is the place where Aharon HaKohen passed away. Rabbi Simon Jacobson explains that the double mountain is Aharon's love — love within love. That love and harmony is what is

needed to receive the Torah on another mountain, Mount Sinai, where the Jews camp in week 35. The personal journey moves from living with people's faults to the love and peace of Aharon, Rosh Chodesh Sivan, and the giving of the Torah.

Week 34, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 235 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

The Tree of Life

Channah's sixth verse holds both ends: "The Lord kills and makes alive; He brings down to the grave and raises up." Which is the whole difference between those He heals and those He does not.

Pirkei Avot, on the greatness of the Torah, is also about life this week: "She is a tree of life for those who hold fast to her, and happy are those who support her."

Ecclesiastes 3 opens on the same contrast. "Everything has an appointed season, and there is a time for every matter under the heaven. A time to give birth and a time to die; a time to plant and a time to uproot that which is planted. A time to kill and a time to heal; a time to break and a time to build." The third of those is striking: it sets killing against healing — because healing is ultimately the sparing of life itself.

The week holds two prominent yahrzeits from the line of Kosov, two brothers who passed away on the same date, the 25th of Iyar: Rabbi Chaim Hager of Kosov and Rabbi David of Zubeltov, sons of Rabbi Menachem Mendel Hager of Kosov. Rabbi Chaim succeeded his father as Rav and Rebbe in Kossov in 1827 and wrote the Toras Chayim; a prominent synagogue in Tsfat is named after him, and his son Menachem Mendel became the first Rebbe in Vishnitz. Rabbi David of Zubeltov was the son-in-law of Rabbi Moshe Leib of Sassov and became a rebbe in his own right at the young age of 29, held in great respect for his wisdom even by the other rebbes of his generation. Also this week: Rabbi Mordechai Shraga of Husyatin and Rabbi Shlomo-Eliezer Alfandri on the 22nd of Iyar, Rabbi Benyamin Mendelson on the 24th, and Rabbi Yitzchak-Isaac of Homil, Rabbi Shmuel Eliyahu of Zvolin — son of Rabbi Yecheskel of Kuzmir and father of the first Modzhitzer Rebbe — and Rabbi Shlomo of Zivhil on the 26th.

Week 34, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 236 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Healing and Rabbi Shimon's "Wine"

The last week of Iyar, the end of the journey from Yaacov to Yisrael that began in Nissan, with Shavuot ahead. The Song's verse is wine: "And your palate is like the best wine, that glides down smoothly to my beloved, making the lips of the sleeping speak." Wine is the inner secrets of the Torah, and those secrets are what gave the Jewish people life in hard times when they were spiritually asleep, bringing them back and making their lips speak. Which is Lag Ba'Omer and the Kabbalah revealed by Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai, and the healing of Iyar. The verses that follow belong here too: "I am my beloved's, and his desire is upon me. Come, my beloved, let us go out to the field, let us lodge in the villages. Let us arise early to the vineyards; let us see whether the vine has blossomed, the tiny grapes have developed, the pomegranates have lost their flowers; there I will give you my love." Closeness, with His desire upon us; and the tiny grapes developed and ready to give and receive His love at Mt. Sinai.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirty-fourth is Gad, son of Zilpah, and with him Menasheh, son of Joseph. Gad was known as a fierce warrior, and his name means good luck. Menashe's name has the verb to forget at its root, for Joseph forgetting the hardships of his past; and Menashe also means to sustain, since he was Joseph's main assistant in sustaining Egypt and running the affairs of the empire. Both of them are the healing of Iyar, and the journey from hardship to strength and relative independence.

Daf Lamed Dalet of Shvuoth keeps on with oaths applying only to monetary claims, and takes up witnesses who did not see or know the facts, and deriving the laws of an oath over a pikadon from the laws of court oaths. The theme again is the move from a poor and weak position to one of strength and order. Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai is by far the most quoted rabbi on this daf, from beginning to end.

Jeremiah's thirty-fourth chapter is going from slave to free, in the seven-year cycle, and then the promise broken. "The word that came to Jeremiah from the Lord after King Zedekiah had made a covenant with all the people who were in Jerusalem, to proclaim freedom to them; That every man should let his manservant and every man his maidservant, a Jew and a Jewess go free, that none should hold his Jewish

brother as a slave." They did it: "then they obeyed and let them go." And then they undid it: "But afterwards they turned and brought back the manservants and the maidservants whom they had let free, and forcibly made them into manservants and maidservants." He reminds them where the law came from — "I made a covenant with your fathers on the day that I brought them forth out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slaves" — and what they have just done: "And now this day you turned and did what was right in My sight by proclaiming liberty every man to his neighbor, and you made a covenant before Me in the House upon which My Name is called. But then you turned and profaned My Name." And the sentence is made out of their own word: "You have not hearkened to Me to proclaim freedom, every one to his brother and every one to his neighbor; behold I proclaim freedom to you, says the Lord, to the sword, to the pestilence, and to the famine."

Week 34, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 237 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fourth Week of Iyar - Psalms 100-102; 105:3-5; 89:35

The fourth week of Iyar in psalms: the hundredth, hundred and first and hundred and second, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 100 is for the hearts of those who suffer in this world: let them serve G-d with joy all the same, because all of it is for their good, as in the verse, "He whom G-d loves does He chastise." It also refers to the thanksgiving sacrifice, the only one to be offered in the Messianic era. It is five verses long. "Serve the Lord with joy; come before Him with exultation. Know that the Lord is G-d; He has made us and we are His, His people and the sheep of His pasture. Enter His gates with gratitude, His courtyards with praise; give thanks to Him, bless His Name. For the Lord is good; His kindness is everlasting, and His faithfulness is for all generations."

Psalm 101 is David keeping himself apart from others, and his conduct inside his own house. "I will pay heed to the path of integrity-O when will it come to me? I shall walk with the innocence of my heart [even] within my house. I shall not place an evil thing before my eyes; I despise the doing of wayward deeds, it does not cling to me." Then whom he will not have near him: "He who slanders his fellow in secret, him will I cut down; one with haughty eyes and a lustful heart, him I cannot suffer."

And whom he will: “My eyes are upon the faithful of the land, that they may dwell with me; he who walks in the path of integrity, he shall minister to me. He that practices deceit shall not dwell within my house.”

Psalm 102 is the prayer of the exiled, and the right prayer for anyone in distress: “A prayer of the poor man when he is faint [with affliction], and pours out his tale of woe before the Lord.” The body of it: “For my days have vanished with the smoke; my bones are dried up as a hearth. Smitten like grass and withered is my heart, for I have forgotten to eat my bread.” The loneliness: “I am like the bird of the wilderness; like the owl of the wasteland have I become. In haste I fled; I was like a bird, alone on a roof.” The food: “For I have eaten ashes like bread, and mixed my drink with tears.” And then it turns, and the turn is the whole psalm: “But You, Lord, will be enthroned forever, and Your remembrance is for all generations. You will arise and have mercy on Zion, for it is time to be gracious to her; the appointed time has come. For Your servants cherish her stones, and love her dust.” What the nations will see: “Then the nations will fear the Name of the Lord, and all the kings of the earth Your glory, when [they see that] the Lord has built Zion, He has appeared in His glory.” Who it is written for: “Let this be written for the last generation, so that the newborn nation will praise the Lord.” Why He looked: “to hear the cry of the bound, to untie those who are doomed to die.” Then the asking not to be taken mid-life: “My G-d, do not remove me in the midst of my days! You Whose years endure through all generations.” And the comparison that answers it: “In the beginning You laid the foundations of the earth, and the heavens are the work of Your hands. They will perish, but You will endure; all of them will wear out like a garment; You will exchange them like a robe, and they will vanish. But You remain the same; Your years will not end. The children of Your servants will abide; their seed shall be established before You.”

Psalm 105's verses are the seeking: “Glory in His holy Name; may the heart of those who seek the Lord rejoice. Search for the Lord and His might; seek His countenance always. Remember the wonders that He has wrought, His miracles, and the judgments of His mouth.” And Psalm 89's verse holds again: “I will not abrogate My covenant, nor change that which has issued from My lips.”

Week 34, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 238 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Ox is Saying

The ox opens on remembering the wonders, and the week comes in around it.

The remembering and the manna first: “Remember the wonders that He has wrought” / “His miracles, and the judgments of His mouth” / “When the children of Israel saw, they said to one another, 'It is manna'” / “Because they did not know what it was” / “And your palate is like the best wine” / “That glides down smoothly to my beloved.”

Then the seeking, and the sleeping lips: “May the heart of those who seek the Lord rejoice” / “Search for the Lord and His might” / “Seek His countenance always” / “Making the lips of the sleeping speak” / “Glory in His holy Name.”

Then the bread and the covenant: “And Moses said to them, It is the bread that the Lord has given you to eat” / “This is the thing that the Lord has commanded” / “I will not abrogate My covenant” / “Nor change that which has issued from My lips” / “Is it not stored up with Me, sealed up in My treasuries?”

Then the song itself, and the feet set high: “Then Moses and the Children of Israel sang this song to G-d” / “And they said, 'I shall sing to G-d, for He has triumphed” / “He has thrown the horse and its rider into the sea'” / “He makes my feet like hinds” / “And sets me upon my high places.”

And the end is the gathering by capacity, and the milk in the lordly bowl: “Gather of it each one according to his eating capacity” / “An omer for each person, according to the number of persons” / “Each one for those in his tent you shall take” / “Water he requested, (but) milk she gave him” / “In a lordly bowl she brought him cream” / “The Lord kills and makes alive” / “He brings down to the grave and raises up.”

Week 34, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXXV

Malchut of Hod

Days 239–245

Day 239 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Thank G-d in Unison

The wild animals say: "Blessed is the One Who is good and bestows good." (Talmud, Brachot 48b) This week holds Yom Yerushalayim and Rosh Chodesh Sivan.

Their song is the blessing Jewish law gives when something substantially good happens. It is called HaTov veHaMetiv, and it stands above the more familiar She'ychianu, because it is said when the good reaches not only the person but others as well. That all the wild animals, with their strong and ferocious instincts, can sing in unison a song that shows concern for others belongs directly to Rosh Chodesh Sivan. Sivan carries the giving of the Torah, which was made possible by the unity of the Jewish people then: the Torah tells that on Rosh Chodesh Sivan they all camped at Mount Sinai "as one man with one heart."

Sivan belongs to Zevulun, known for merchant skill and for the ability to survive in the outside wild jungle that is the commercial world. That prowess also kept his brother's tribe, Issachar, whose life was insular and wholly given to Torah; Zevulun supported Issachar fully. The Torah explicitly compares the Jewish women in Egypt to wild animals, and Rashi explains further that the whole people is called wild animals, since Benjamin is a wolf, Judah a lion, Dan a lion cub. For all our strong personalities and different ways of thinking — two Jews, three ideas, as the saying goes — we manage to get along. That closeness, among ourselves and with Him, is also in the month's sign: Gemini, twins.

On Yom Yerushalayim we mark Israel's miraculous victory in the Six-Day War, when Jerusalem was reunited — a day when something substantially good happened to all of the Jewish people, which is the blessing exactly. Today we say HaTov

veHaMetiv only when something very good happens, and when something very bad happens, or what looks bad to us, we say Baruch Dayan Emet, Blessed be the True Judge. The Talmud teaches that in Messianic times we will say HaTov veHaMetiv in all circumstances, because we will understand that what we once took for bad was ultimately for the good. Yom Yerushalayim is that too. The term appears in the Psalms as a reference to the destruction of the Temple and of Jerusalem, perhaps the worst event in our history; since 1967 it names the day Jerusalem was liberated. The meaning of that destruction is still hard to understand, and we know at least that the second use of the name could not exist without the first.

The song also holds a double tov — HaTov veHaMetiv. The gematria of tov is 17, and twice that is 34, which was last week; this week builds on it. Thirty-five is the gematria of yehudi, which names every Jew even though its root is only the tribe of Judah — the whole people able to unite behind one tribe. Its first appearance in the Tanach is in Megillat Esther, of Mordechai, who was of Benjamin; and the Megillah calls the whole people Am Mordechai. Thirty-five is also lamed and heh, the only two letters in the word Hallel, the song of praise said on Rosh Chodesh Sivan, and said by many on Yom Yerushalayim.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Tzadok: do not separate yourself from the community; do not act as a counselor-at-law when serving as a judge; do not make the Torah a crown to magnify yourself with, or a spade with which to dig. So would Hillel say, one who makes personal use of the crown of Torah shall perish — and one who benefits himself from the words of Torah removes his life from the world. That is the unity of Rosh Chodesh Sivan. And Rabbi Tzadok fasted for forty years to prevent the destruction of the Temple; Rabbi Yochanan ben Zakkai said of him that had there been one more tzadik like him, Jerusalem would not have been destroyed. His words falling in the week of Yom Yerushalayim is fitting indeed.

This week completes another cycle of seven, and the combination is malchut shebehod. Malchut is taking abstract ideas and applying them in the real world; this week we bring our service and our pursuit of peace to fruition. The lesson from the wild animals is that everything He does is for the good, and what looks bad for us will prove in the end to have been for our good.

Week 35, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 240 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Uriah and Loving the "Just"

Yom Yerushalayim and Rosh Chodesh Sivan. Sivan, the month of Shavuot, belongs to Zevulun, who could combine the study of Torah with making a living, and kept not only himself but Issachar, who was immersed in learning.

Haazinu speaks of vengeance and reckoning: "Vengeance is poised with Me, and it will pay at the time their foot stumbles. For the appointed day of their reckoning is near, and what is destined for them hastens." (Deuteronomy 32:35) And a positive message is there too: the vengeance read as against the enemy, and the payment as for the good deeds of the Jews and for their suffering. On Rosh Chodesh Sivan we feel the day of payment for the work of the omer, Shavuot, coming fast. On receiving the Torah the people collapsed, feeling the soul leave the body and return. The revelation of the final day of judgment will be one in which we are overawed by His kindness toward His people — and a glimmer of that kindness was seen in the Six-Day War and the conquest of Jerusalem, which was a victory we stumbled into.

The Haftorah: "He trains my hand for war, so that mine arms do bend a brass bow." (II Samuel 22:35) Another reference to His kindness on Yom Yerushalayim.

The quality is loves justice, Ohev Et HaMeisharim — and as last week, Meisharim is not the usual word for justice. Meishar means levelled or plowed, a levelled plain or field, and it comes from yashar, straight, so it means a straight and righteous path. A tzadik is called that for fulfilling the positive commandments, and a yashar for fulfilling the negative ones. Working at being both is part of preparing to receive the Torah. On Rosh Chodesh Sivan the whole people could be like one man with one heart because of the harmony those two produce — above all the negative ones, in not harming one another. And yashar is the root of Yisrael and of Yeshurun. The omer is a personal transformation from Ha'Akov l'Mishor, from Yaakov to Yisrael.

The prophet is Uriah, whose prophecy is tied to this quality and to Jerusalem: it was Uriah who said in the name of G-d that Zion would be plowed like a field, and Meishar is a levelled, plowed field. As Rabbi Akiva explained, his prophecy is linked to the good outcomes for Jerusalem as well: just as Uriah's prophecy had been fulfilled, so would the positive prophecy of Zechariah be fulfilled. Chassidic thought explains that sometimes a descent is needed for a greater ascent, Yeridah L'Tzorech

Aliyah. Given the corruption and crookedness of the time, Jerusalem had to be plowed and made straight and upright again — and out of that plowed field would come the foundation of the Jerusalem of today, and of the Jerusalem of Messianic times, with the Temple rebuilt. His own story is tragic: because of his negative prophecies he runs to Egypt, is brought back, and is killed by the king of Judah. His message is not in a book of his own but inside the Book of Jeremiah, and his prophecy is described chiefly as being "like all the words of Jeremiah" — and Jeremiah is next week's prophet. His murder was a Yeridah L'Tzorech Aliyah too.

The levitical city is Yokneam, whose name looks like a contraction of Yikneh Am, He will acquire a nation — which can also be read as a nation shall acquire. On Shavuot Hashem acquired us as a nation, and on Shavuot we acquired the Torah. The verse stands in the future tense all the same, because that acquiring was to be felt again: in the days of Purim, when the Jews took the Torah on themselves at a higher level, and with the coming of Mashiach. Yokneam today is an important high-tech centre and an extensive archeological site.

Week 35, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 241 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

To Be United and Not Divided

Yom Yerushalayim and Rosh Chodesh Sivan. Beshalach: "And the children of Israel did so: they gathered, both the one who gathered much and the one who gathered little. And they measured [it] with an omer, and whoever gathered much did not have more, and whoever gathered little did not have less; each one according to his eating capacity, they gathered." That is how harmony is reached — each one doing his share. The unity is Sivan, and it is Yom Yerushalayim. One link to the Six Day War may be how much was done in how little time: in six days Israel's territory more than tripled, which belongs with whoever gathered little not having less, because with miracles the time and effort are not necessarily in proportion to the outcome.

The Haftorah is Yael's hand: "She put forth her hand to the pin, and her right hand to strike the weary." She struck Sissera at the right moment, and one of the great miracles of the Six Day War was striking bravely and effectively at the right time.

Daf Lamed Heh of Sotah keeps on with the spies, Calev in particular, and takes up transporting the Aron and the rocks used for writing the Torah and as signs for later generations. Calev suits Yom Yerushalayim, since he showed the spirit it takes to conquer the land, as was done in 1967. Part of the discussion of the Aron is bringing it to Jerusalem. And setting up those rocks to write the Torah on reads like the encampment at Har Sinai.

The generation is Rehoboam, son of Solomon, king when the kingdom split in two. His name is from Rehav, wide and expansive, and Am, nation. His counterpart is Jeroboam, crowned king of the Kingdom of Israel, whose name also holds Am and can be read as one who will increase, or will fight for, the nation. The division between the two kingdoms increased nothing. So it is fitting that Rehoboam is the link for week 35, when the nation was united on Rosh Chodesh Sivan, and when Jerusalem and Judea and Samaria were reunited under Jewish sovereignty. Both kings' ways were sinful. In Rehoboam's time idol worship and adultery spread in the Kingdom of Judah; Jeroboam caused still more idol worship in the Kingdom of Israel, and Pirkei Avot cites him as the standing example of one who sinned and made others sin, future kings included — he even set up golden calves to be worshipped in a temple set against the one in Jerusalem. Getting ready to accept the Torah has to include banishing the idols and the adulterous behaviour of our own time.

The journey is from Mount Hor to Zalmonah, from Zalmon, darkness. Rabbi Jacobson connects it to the verse in Psalms about becoming whitened from the dark shadows of exile. That is close to the song of the deer next week: "And I shall sing of Your strength, I shall rejoice of Your kindness in the morning, for You were a refuge to me, and a hiding place on the day of my oppression." On Shavuot we think of all the darkness we had to come through to reach this light. The personal journey moves from the love and peace of Aharon to the light about to arrive after the dark.

Week 35, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 242 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

True Wealth and Honor

Channah's seventh verse: "The Lord impoverishes and makes rich. He humbles; He also exalts." He gives wealth and standing, and He takes them away.

Pirkei Avot, on the greatness of the Torah, turns to the true wealth and the true standing, which come from the Torah, and uses ornament for it: “For they shall be a garland of grace for your head, and necklaces about your neck.”

Ecclesiastes 4 sets physical wealth against the wealth that comes of wisdom, and shows that even a king without wisdom is humbled in his own kingdom: “Better a poor and wise child than an old and foolish king, who no longer knows to receive admonition. For out of the prison he has come to reign, for even in his kingdom, he becomes humble.”

The week holds three prominent yahrzeits: Rav Meir’l of Premishlan on the 29th of Iyar, Rabbi Yisroel of Vizhnitz and Rabbi Chaim-Elazar Spira, the Munkaczer Rebbe, both on the 2nd of Sivan.

Reb Meir’l and Reb Yisroel of Ruzhin were very good friends, for all that they served Hashem in very different ways: the Rizhiner lived in grand luxury and Reb Meir with the bare minimum. One day Reb Meir’l was riding in a simple wagon drawn by a lone horse and met R’ Yisroel of Rizhin in a wagon drawn by four powerful horses. He asked why he needed them. The Rizhiner answered that if he got stuck in the mud, those horses could pull him out easily. Reb Meir replied: since I have one weak horse, I am careful not to get stuck in the mud in the first place. He was also on very good terms with Gedolim of the non-chassidic world, such as Reb Shlomo Kluger and Reb Yosef Shaul Natanson, and many Divrei Torah and exchanges between them are recorded. He lived in abject but patient poverty and exerted himself tirelessly for the needy and the suffering; his divine inspiration and his ready wit have become legendary. He wrote no works, and some of his teachings were collected and published by his Chassidim after his death.

Rabbi Yisroel of Vizhnitz, in Bukovina, had many thousands of followers over the 43 years he served as Rebbe, and after WWI he headed a major yeshiva in Hungary. For his warmth and friendliness to every Jew he was known as the Ahavas Yisrael. Rabbi Chaim-Elazar Spira, the Munkaczer Rebbe, wrote and published over twenty books on law, Torah, chasidism, religious philosophy and custom; the work that made him world famous is the Minchas Elazar, in six volumes.

Week 35, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 243 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Feeling Hashem's Desire

The Song's verse is one line, and it is about being wanted: "I am my beloved's, and his desire is upon me." That desire was certainly felt in the days just before the giving of the Torah, and again when we were able to re-conquer Jerusalem. The verses that follow belong here too: "The pots [of figs] have given forth [their] fragrance, and on our doorways are all manner of sweet fruits, both new and old, which I have hidden away for you, my beloved." "O, that you were like my brother, who sucked my mother's breasts! I would find you outside, I would kiss you, and they would not despise me." "I would lead you, I would bring you to the house of my mother, who instructed me; I would give you to drink some spiced wine, of the juice of my pomegranate." Rosh Chodesh Sivan is the sign of twins — like my brother — and the house of my mother looks like Jerusalem.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirty-fifth is Ziphion, son of Gad, and with him Ephraim, son of Joseph. Ziphion looks related to Letzapot, to see into the distance, like the name of a mountain in Jerusalem, Har HaTzofim, which saw some of the greatest battles for the city in 1948 and 1967. Ephraim comes from being fruitful and multiplying, and Israel's size certainly multiplied after the Six Day War; Ephraim was also the ancestor of Joshua, who conquered the Land the first time. Ephraim and Menashe, last week, were partners much as Issachar, of Iyar, and Zevulun, of Sivan: of the two brothers Ephraim is the one associated with spiritual pursuits and the acquiring of Torah, and Menashe with running the affairs of the kingdom.

Daf Lamed Heh of Shvuot takes up exemptions, when oaths are not made, the wording of an oath, the holy names of G-d, and whether an oath must include His name. Those names belong to the revelation and the giving of the Torah on Shavuot — and the Torah itself is one of His names.

Jeremiah's thirty-fifth chapter holds the story of the Rechabites, sons of Jonadab the son of Rechab, children of Yitro. "And I placed before the sons of the house of the Rechabites goblets full of wine, and cups, and I said to them, 'Drink wine.' And they said, 'We will not drink wine, for Jonadab the son of Rechab, our father, commanded us saying, "You shall not drink wine, you or your children forever. And

you shall not build a house, neither shall you sow nor shall you plant a vineyard, nor shall you have [any], but you shall dwell in tents all your days.“'” And they kept it: “And we have dwelt in tents, and we have hearkened and done according to all that Jonadab our father has commanded us.” Yitro’s story, a convert’s story, belongs to the giving of the Torah — it is in Parashat Yitthro that we read of it. And the Rechabites show the unity of children all obeying their father’s wish together; they were converts themselves, as the whole Jewish people were like converts on Shavuot.

Week 35, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 244 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Rosh Chodesh Sivan - Psalms 103 -105; 105:6-8; 89:36

The week of Rosh Chodesh Sivan in psalms: the hundred and third, hundred and fourth and hundred and fifth, with three verses of Psalm 105 again and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 103 is David’s prayer when he was ill, and the right prayer for the sick, above all said by the sick person himself while his soul is still in his body, so that he can bless G-d from his depths, body and soul. “Bless the Lord, O my soul; and all my being, His holy Name. My soul, bless the Lord; forget not all His favors: Who forgives all your sins, Who heals all your illnesses; Who redeems your life from the grave, Who crowns you with kindness and mercy; Who satisfies your mouth with goodness; like the eagle, your youth is renewed.” Then the measures of His patience: “He has not dealt with us according to our transgressions, nor requited us according to our sins. For as high as heaven is above the earth, so has His kindness been mighty over those who fear Him. As far as the east is from the west, so has He distanced our transgressions from us. As a father has compassion on his children, so has the Lord had compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our nature; He is mindful that we are but dust.” Then our side of the comparison: “As for man, his days are like grass; like a flower of the field, so he sprouts. When a wind passes over him, he is gone; his place recognizes him no more.” And then everything is called to bless Him — the angels, the hosts, all His works — and the last line returns where it started: “My soul, bless the Lord!”

Psalm 104 tells the beauty of creation, what was made on each of the six days, and the awesomeness of the One who sustains all of it, from the horns of the wild ox to the eggs of the louse. “You enwrap [Yourself] with light as with a garment; You spread the heavens as a curtain.” The waters put in their place: “You set a boundary which they may not cross, so that they should not return to engulf the earth.” The drinking: “He sends forth springs into streams; they flow between the mountains. They give drink to all the beasts of the field; the wild animals quench their thirst.” What grows: “He makes grass grow for the cattle, and vegetation requiring the labor of man to bring forth food from the earth; and wine that gladdens man’s heart, oil that makes the face shine, and bread that sustains man’s heart.” Who lives where: “The high mountains are for the wild goats; the rocks are a refuge for the rabbits.” The clock of it: “He made the moon to calculate the festivals; the sun knows its time of setting. You bring on darkness and it is night, when all the beasts of the forest creep forth. The young lions roar for prey, and seek their food from G-d. When the sun rises, they return and lie down in their dens. Then man goes out to his work, to his labor until evening.” The accounting: “How manifold are Your works, O Lord! You have made them all with wisdom; the earth is full of Your possessions.” The sea, with the Leviathan created to frolic in it. And the dependence of all of it on one hand: “They all look expectantly to You to give them their food at the proper time. When You give it to them, they gather it; when You open Your hand, they are satiated with goodness. When You conceal Your countenance, they are terrified; when You take back their spirit, they perish and return to their dust. When You will send forth Your spirit they will be created anew, and You will renew the face of the earth.”

Psalm 105 David composed when he brought the Holy Ark up to the City of David, and sang before the Ark. It recounts the miracles done for the Jews in Egypt, beginning with Joseph sent ahead of them, imprisoned and then freed, until he could imprison the princes of Egypt without consulting Pharaoh. The covenant first: “He remembers His covenant forever, the word which He has commanded to a thousand generations; the covenant which He made with Abraham, and His oath to Isaac. He established it for Jacob as a statute, for Israel as an everlasting covenant, stating, 'To you I shall give the land of Canaan’-the portion of your inheritance, when they were but few, very few, and strangers in it.” The protection on the road: “He permitted no

one to wrong them, and admonished kings for their sake: 'Do not touch my anointed ones, and do not harm my prophets.'" Then Joseph: "He sent a man before them; Joseph was sold as a slave. They afflicted his foot with chains, his soul was put into iron; until the time that His words came, the decree of the Lord purified him." Then the plagues told one after another — darkness, blood, frogs, beasts and lice, hail and flaming fire, grasshoppers and locusts without number, and every firstborn. Then the leaving: "And He took them out with silver and gold, and none among His tribes stumbled. Egypt rejoiced at their leaving, for the fear [of Israel] had fallen upon them." Then the desert: the cloud for shelter and the fire for the night, the quail and the bread of heaven, the rock opened so that waters streamed through dry places like a river — "for He remembered His holy word to Abraham His servant." And the point of all of it: "He gave them the lands of nations, they inherited the toil of peoples, so that they might keep His statutes and observe His laws. Praise the Lord!"

The Tikkun HaKlali verses are the seed of Abraham and the covenant remembered to the thousandth generation. And Psalm 89's verse is the oath: "One thing have I sworn by My holiness, that I will not fail David."

Week 35, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 245 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Wild Animals Say

The wild animals open, and the week sets the oath beside the hand trained for war.

The swearing and the hands first: "One thing have I sworn by My holiness" / "That I will not fail David" / "He trains my hand for war" / "So that mine arms do bend a brass bow" / "She put forth her hand to the pin" / "And her right hand to strike the weary."

Then the reckoning, and the raising and lowering: "For the appointed day of their reckoning is near" / "And what is destined for them hastens" / "The Lord impoverishes and makes rich. He humbles; He also exalts" / "Vengeance is poised with Me" / "And it will pay at the time their foot stumbles."

Then the gathering that came out even: "And the children of Israel did so" / "They gathered, both the one who gathered much" / "And the one who gathered little" / "And they measured [it] with an omer" / "And whoever gathered much did not have

more, and whoever gathered little did not have less" / "I am my beloved's, and his desire is upon me" / "Each one according to his eating capacity, they gathered."

And the end is the blessing itself, with the covenant under it: "Blessed is the One Who is good and bestows good" / "The seed of Abraham His servant, the children of Jacob, His chosen ones" / "He is the Lord our G-d; throughout all the earth are His judgments" / "He remembered His covenant forever, the word He had commanded to the thousandth generation."

Week 35, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXXVI

Chesed of Yesod

Days 246–252

Day 246 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Have Emunah

The gazelle is saying, "And I shall sing of Your strength, I shall rejoice of Your kindness in the morning, for You were a refuge to me, and a hiding place on the day of my oppression." (Psalms 59:17) This week holds Shavuot, and the whole week is also known as Shivah Yemei Miluim, in which the Shavuot sacrifices could still be brought to the Temple.

The Hebrew for gazelle is Tzvi, which has the same gematria as emunah, complete faith. Its three letters — tzadi, beit, yud — are an acronym for "tzadik b'emunatoh yichieh," a tzadik lives through his faith, a verse of the prophet Habakkuk; and the Talmud explains that this verse is a summary of the whole Torah given to Moses at Mount Sinai on Shavuot. The song holds faith in both directions, in the morning and in trouble, which is night. Psalm 92 opens the same way: "It is good to give thanks to the Lord, and to sing to Your name, O Most High; To declare in the morning Your kindness and Your faith at night." After the troubles of the Counting of the Omer, which belongs to the night, on Shavuot the revelation comes clear as day.

The horns of a gazelle are like a double crown, and the Jewish people received a double crown on Shavuot, as a reward for their faith. The Midrash teaches that other nations refused the Torah, and the Jews did not even ask first what was in it: they said "Na'aseh veNishmah," we will do and we will listen, accepting the commandments before knowing what they were. So each Jew was given two crowns, one for Na'aseh and one for Nishmah — crowns that were later removed after the sin of the golden calf.

Thirty-six is the thirty-six hidden tzadikim who sustain the world. It is also the total number of Chanukah candles lit over the eight days. Both belong to the light revealed on Shavuot, when, through the work of the omer, we all stand closer to the level of tzadikim — and those thirty-six are literally the foundation of the world.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yossi: whoever honors the Torah is himself honored by the people, and whoever degrades the Torah is himself degraded by the people. That belongs to the giving of the Torah and to what happened soon after. When we accepted it we were shown great honour; when we dishonoured it with the golden calf, the honour was taken away.

The combination is chesed shebeyesod, kindness within foundation. On Shavuot the people had to stand firm — not coming too close to the mountain, not letting their souls expire altogether from the revelation — in order to receive the great good that is the Torah. The lesson from the gazelle is to have faith at night, in the hard times, knowing that the night will pass and we will thank Him in the open light of day.

Week 36, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 247 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Accepting the Truth

The week of Shavuot. Haazinu: "When the Lord will judge His people, and will reconsider His servants, when He sees that the power is increasing, and none is controlled or strengthened." (Deuteronomy 32:36) Shavuot is not usually thought of as a day of judgment, and in many ways it has much of one, like Rosh Hashanah. How a person's studies will go through the year is largely settled on Shavuot. As we try not to sleep much on Rosh Hashanah, on Shavuot we stay up all night learning. And for all that it is a day of celebration, what happened immediately after the giving of the Torah — the sin of the golden calf — needed His great mercy, and Moshe begging on our behalf.

The Haftorah points at Shavuot plainly: "And You have given me the shield of Your salvation; And You have increased Your humility for me." (II Samuel 22:36) At Mount Sinai He lowered Himself, which is increased humility, so that He could be revealed to the people.

The quality is loves reproof, Ohev Et Hatochachot. Every year before Shavuot we read the Tochachah in the portion of Bechukotai. This week is tied to the events just after the giving of the Torah, which hold much reproof. And only by being open to reproof can a person learn and grow; it is one of the main teachings of the Book of Proverbs: "Reprove not a scorner lest he hate you; reprove a wise man and he will love you. Give a wise man, and he will become yet wiser; teach a righteous man, and he will increase in learning. The beginning of wisdom is the fear of the Lord, and the knowledge of the holy ones is understanding."

The prophet is Jeremiah, whose prophecy is more associated with reproof than any other: he spoke so strongly about the destruction of the Temple, the devastation of Jerusalem and the Babylonian exile, and he lived to see them. He also recorded the Book of Lamentations, which sets out G-d's reproof as vividly as it has ever been set out. He stood at a level few prophets reached, which also suits the week of Shavuot. And his message belongs to the day: "Let not the wise man glory in his wisdom, neither let the mighty man glory in his might; let not the rich man glory in his riches. But let him that glorieth, glory in this, that he understandeth and knoweth Me, that I am the L-rd Who exercises mercy, justice, and righteousness on the earth; for in these things I delight, saith the L-rd."

The levitical city is Kartah, which means city in Aramaic. Perhaps the point is that receiving the Torah means knowing the simple truth, even when the truth is painful. The Jewish people come from Shem, whose name means name, which points to the same plain truth he stood for. The ruins of Kartah, outside Haifa, are an important and beautiful archeological site today.

There is also an opinion that Kartah is Tavor, a city of the tribe of Issachar — and Mount Tabor was shared by Issachar and Zevulun, so the two brothers share the levitical city of the week of Shavuot, which is the brotherly love the giving of the Torah needed; and the sign of Sivan is gemini, twins. Mount Tabor also thought itself worthy of being the mountain where the Torah would be given, and was later the scene of miracles in the days of Devorah. Rashi, on "I, to the Lord I shall sing," notes that the word is repeated, and gives an Aggadic reading: the Holy One did not withhold the reward of Mount Tabor and Mount Carmel, who came to the giving of the Torah expecting it to be given upon them and turned away in shame. He said to them, I will pay you double fold. At Sinai it was said, "I am the Lord your G-d"; at

Tabor it will be said, "I... I...". At Sinai it was said, "I am the Lord your G-d"; at Carmel it will be said twice, "The Lord He is G-d, the Lord He is G-d," in the days of Elijah.

Week 36, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 248 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Not Leaving the Learning for the Morning

Beshalach: "And Moses said to them, Let no one leave over [any] of it until morning. But [some] men did not obey Moses and left over [some] of it until morning, and it bred worms and became putrid, and Moses became angry with them." Which is Shavuot itself, where at the first giving of the Torah the people overslept and Moshe reprimanded them for it — and that is the basis of the custom of spending the whole night studying, not leaving it until morning.

The Haftorah is Yael again: "she struck Sisera, pierced his head, and wounded and penetrated his temple." Taken out of the context of her act, as in week 34, the words could describe the experience of Mount Sinai, where the Torah pierced and penetrated our minds in a way that left a mark in every Jewish soul.

Daf Lamed Vav of Sotah keeps on with how the people entered the Land, how the tribes stood at Mount Grizim and Mount Eival, and how the names of the tribes were inscribed on the Ephod — a symbol of unity, which is Shavuot and Sivan. There is discussion of there being 50 letters in the Ephod, and 50 belongs to Shavuot too. The daf also spends a good deal of time on Yosef and the tests he came through. Shavuot is about miracles, and about all of Israel standing at a mountain and entering a covenant; and Yosef is the consummate example of one who followed the Torah, the very definition of a Tzadik.

The generation is Abijam, son of Rehoboam, also known as Abijah, which means my father is Hashem. As we received the Torah through unity, he sought to reunite the kingdoms of Judah and Israel — and for all his military victory he could not reach it. He followed his father's wicked ways, and the people were steeped in idolatry. Jeroboam, the sinful king of Israel who built an alternate temple with golden calves, also had a son named Abiyah; that child fell critically ill, died, and was eulogized by all of Israel — and even a eulogy for the son of an evil king shows the unity of this

week.

The journey is from Zalmonah to Punon, the place where the people complained and were bitten by snakes, and were healed through Moshe's copper snake. Punon comes from the word for directed, or faced, and also means death in Greek. At the giving of the Torah the people died and were revived at once: facing Hashem and hearing Him speak, their souls left their bodies. Punon also has two letter Nuns, which may point to the fiftieth day of the omer, which is Shavuot. The personal journey is to take in the light of Shavuot against the darkness of the omer, and to be revived by the Torah as well.

Week 36, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 249 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

The Crown(s) of Torah

Channah's eighth verse lifts people off the ground: "He lifts the poor from the dust; From the dunghill, He raises the pauper, To seat them with princes, And a seat of honor He causes them to inherit, For the pillars of the earth are the Lord's, And He placed the world upon them." He is the one who decides who deserves honour and nobility.

Pirkei Avot, on the greatness of the Torah, speaks of honour again and makes it an ornament: "She shall give to your head a garland of grace, a crown of glory she shall grant you." It was on Shavuot that the people were crowned with a double crown, one for Na'aseh, we will do, and one for Nishmah, we will listen.

Ecclesiastes 5, like chapter 4, sets wealth against poverty, and names cases where a king is the one who is subservient: "If you see oppression of the poor and deprivation of justice and righteousness in the province, wonder not about the matter, for the Highest over the high waits, and there are higher ones over them. And the loftiness of the earth is in everything; even the king is subservient to the field."

The week holds the yahrzeit of the Baal Shem Tov on the 6th of Sivan, and of Rabbi Avraham Mordechai Alter, the third Gerrer Rebbe, on the same date. Rabbi Yisrael ben Eliezer, the Baal Shem Tov, master of the good Name, a unique and seminal figure in Jewish history, revealed the Chassidic movement and his own identity as an exceptionally holy person on his 36th birthday, the 18th of Elul 1734.

He wrote no books, though many claim to hold his teachings; one available in English is the annotated translation of Tzava'at Harivash. Rabbi Avraham Mordechai Alter, son of the Sfas Emmes, was the third Rebbe of Gur, spiritual leader of over 250,000 Chassidim in pre-WW II Poland. In 1940 he managed to escape with three of his sons to Israel, though the vast majority of his followers did not survive; he began to rebuild the Gerrer community in Jerusalem and died there during the siege of the city on Shavuos, 1948. He was known as the Imrei Emmes, after the title of his major book.

Also this week: Rabbi Yitzchak Issac son of Rabbi Yisachar Beirish of Ziditchov on the 9th of Sivan, Rabbi Moshe of Rozvadov on the 10th, Rabbi Yehuda son of Rabbi Alter Yechezkel Horowitz of Dzhikov on the 11th, and Rabbi Avraham son of Rabbi Noach Weinberg of Slonim on the 12th.

Week 36, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 250 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Chag (Festival)

The Song's verse goes out of doors: "Come, my beloved, let us go out to the field, let us lodge in the villages." The field and the villages look toward Eisav, who was a man of the field, and Rashi comments that Kefarim, villages, should be read Kofrim, disbelievers — because at the giving of the Torah He offered it to the other nations, Yishmael and Eisav among them, and they refused. Shavuot belongs to the field in its own right as well: it is Chag HaKatzir, the Harvest Festival, and Chag HaBikkurim, the Festival of the First Fruits.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirty-sixth is Haggi, and with him Bela, son of Benjamin. Haggi comes from Chag, festival: Chagi means my festival, or Chag-Yud, the festival of G-d. Chag covers all the festivals and especially those with a pilgrimage to Jerusalem — Shavuot, Pessach and Sukkot. Bela means swallowed up, for how Joseph disappeared from Benjamin when he was still a child; Benjamin naming his sons after Joseph is evidence of the brotherly love that existed and still exists among the Jewish people, which is a key part of our meriting to receive the Torah.

Daf Lamed Vav of Shvuot keeps on with the wording of an oath and the holy names of G-d, and opens a new chapter on the oath of a pikadon, a gift or deposit. The names belong to the revelation and the giving of the Torah — and the Torah was the gift itself, given at Sinai.

Jeremiah's thirty-sixth chapter is the writing of a scroll, which is in fact the Book of Lamentations, spoken by Jeremiah and written down by Baruch ben Neriah. "And Jeremiah called Baruch the son of Neriah, and Baruch wrote from Jeremiah's mouth all the words of the Lord that He had spoken to him, on a roll of a book." He could not go himself: "I am imprisoned; I cannot enter the House of the Lord. And you shall come and read in the roll that you have written from my mouth, the words of the Lord, in the ears of the people." Then the king destroyed it: "And it came to pass, when Jehudi read three or four verses, he rent it with a scribe's razor, and cast [it] onto the fire which was on the brazier until the entire roll was consumed." And nobody flinched: "And the king and all his servants who heard all these words were neither frightened nor did they rend their garments." Then it was written again, longer: "And Jeremiah took another roll and gave it to Baruch the son of Neriah the scribe, and he wrote on it from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the book that Jehoiakim the king of Judah burnt with fire, and there were yet added to them many words like those." There is a strong parallel there with the giving of the Torah.

Week 36, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 251 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second Week of Sivan - Psalms 106-108; 105:9-11; 89:37

The second week of Sivan in psalms: the hundred and sixth, hundred and seventh and hundred and eighth, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 106 carries on from the last one, praising Him for the miracles it did not mention, because who can recount the mighty acts of G-d? Were we to try, we could not name them all. "Praise the Lord for He is good, for His kindness is everlasting. Who can recount the mighty acts of the Lord, or proclaim all His praises? Fortunate are those who preserve justice, who perform deeds of righteousness all the time." Then the confession, and it is long: "We have sinned as did our fathers, we have acted perversely and wickedly. Our fathers in Egypt did not contemplate Your wonders,

they did not remember Your abundant kindnesses, and they rebelled by the sea, at the Sea of Reeds. Yet He delivered them for the sake of His Name, to make His strength known." Then the forgetting: "Then they believed in His words, they sang His praise. They quickly forgot His deeds, they did not wait for His counsel." Then the calf: "They made a calf in Horeb, and bowed down to a molten image. They exchanged their Glory for the likeness of a grass-eating ox." And the one man standing in the way: "He said that He would destroy them-had not Moses His chosen one stood in the breach before Him, to turn away His wrath from destroying." Then the land despised, Baal Peor, Phineas rising and the plague stayed, the waters of Merivah, and the nations not destroyed but mingled with. And then, after all of it, the turn: "But He saw their distress, when He heard their prayer; and He remembered for them His covenant and He relented, in keeping with His abounding kindness, and He caused them to be treated mercifully by all their captors." And the ending, which is the end of the fourth book of psalms: "Deliver us, Lord our G-d; gather us from among the nations, that we may give thanks to Your Holy Name and glory in Your praise. Blessed is the Lord, the G-d of Israel, forever and ever. And let all the people say, 'Amen! Praise the Lord!'"

Psalm 107 is for those saved out of four particular dangers — imprisonment, sickness, desert travel and sea travel — who must give thanks, because their sins brought the trouble and only His kindness brought them out, so it is right that they praise Him and tell everyone of their salvation. The desert: "They lost their way in the wilderness, in the wasteland; they found no inhabited city. Both hungry and thirsty, their soul languished within them." The prison: "Those who sit in darkness and the shadow of death, bound in misery and chains of iron... He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death, and sundered their bonds, for He broke the brass gates and smashed the iron bars." The sickness: "Their soul loathes all food, and they reach the gates of death... He sent forth His command and healed them; He delivered them from their graves." And the sea, which is the longest of them: "Those who go down to the sea in ships, who perform tasks in mighty waters; they saw the works of the Lord and His wonders in the deep. He spoke and caused the stormy wind to rise, and it lifted up the waves. They rise to the sky, plunge to the depths; their soul melts in distress. They reel and stagger like a drunkard, all their skill is to no avail." And then: "He transformed the storm into stillness, and the waves were

quieted. They rejoiced when they were silenced, and He led them to their destination." Four times over comes the same line: "Let them give thanks to the Lord for His kindness, and [proclaim] His wonders to the children of man." Then the turning of places into their opposites — rivers into desert and desert into lake, fruitful land into salt-marsh and parched land into springs — and the last line, which asks for a reader: "Let him who is wise bear these in mind, and then the benevolent acts of the Lord will be understood."

Psalm 108 is a steadfast heart and a man waking the dawn: "My heart is steadfast, O G-d; I will sing and chant praises even with my soul. Awake, O lyre and harp; I shall awaken the dawn. I will thank You among the nations, Lord; I will sing praises to You among the peoples." Then the dividing up of the land again, Gilead and Manasseh, Ephraim and Judah, Moab and Edom and Philistia. And the close, which gives the fighting back where it belongs: "Give us help against the adversary; futile is the help of man. Through G-d we will do valiantly, and He will trample our oppressors."

Psalm 105's verses are the covenant and the land promised. And Psalm 89's verse is the throne: "His seed will endure forever and his throne will be [resplendent] as the sun before Me."

Week 36, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 252 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Gazelle Is Saying

The gazelle opens, and the week goes out to the field with it.

The field and the refuge first: "Come, my beloved, let us go out to the field, let us lodge in the villages" / "And I shall sing of Your strength" / "I shall rejoice of Your kindness in the morning" / "For You were a refuge to me, and a hiding place on the day of my oppression" / "And You have given me the shield of Your salvation" / "And You have increased Your humility for me."

Then the lifting out of the dust, with the judging between: "He lifts the poor from the dust" / "From the dunghill, He raises the pauper" / "When the Lord will judge His people" / "And will reconsider His servants" / "To seat them with princes" / "And a seat of honor He causes them to inherit" / "When He sees that the power is

increasing" / "And none is controlled or strengthened."

Then what must not be left until morning, and the pillars of the earth: "And Moses said to them, Let no one leave over [any] of it until morning" / "For the pillars of the earth are the Lord's, And He placed the world upon them" / "But [some] men did not obey Moses" / "And left over [some] of it until morning" / "And it bred worms and became putrid" / "And Moses became angry with them."

And the end is the piercing and the covenant: "She struck Sisera, pierced his head" / "And wounded and penetrated his temple" / "The covenant which He made with Abraham" / "And His oath to Isaac" / "He established it for Jacob as a statute, for Israel as an everlasting covenant" / "Stating, 'To you I shall give the land of Canaan'" / "His seed will endure forever and his throne will be as the sun before Me" / "The portion of your inheritance."

Week 36, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXXVII

Gevurah of Yesod

Days 253–259

Day 253 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Maintain our Humility and Not Forget the Greatness We Experienced

The elephant is saying, "How great are your works, G-d; Your thoughts are tremendously deep." (Psalms 92:6) The word for great is gadlu, from gadol, big — and the elephant is the largest of the land animals. The verse is from Psalm 92 again, as last week's was.

On Shavuot we were all deeply impressed by the greatness of Hashem and His Torah, and after a day of such revelation we all stand higher. The elephant presses that greatness on us, and that it matters not to let ourselves forget it; elephants are famous for their memory. Physical greatness belongs to the week after Shavuot in another way too, since that is when we read Nasso, the largest portion in all the Five Books of Moses.

Thirty-seven is the gematria of the root of gadol. It is also the numerical difference between the name of Moses, 345, and Korach, 308. The deep thoughts of the verse may be Korach's rebellion against Moses and Aaron. Korach wanted the leadership for himself and persuaded a substantial number of his tribesmen and neighbours to rebel; in the confrontation he and his congregation were miraculously sucked into a deep pit, which Pirkei Avot says was thought of and created in the very first week of Creation. The Rebbe explains that they were brought into the pit still alive so that they could repent and return to G-d, as Korach's sons did. It happened on Rosh Chodesh Sivan, the beginning of this month, and the portion of Korach, which tells it, is often read in the last days of Sivan.

It is fitting that Moses goes with the elephant, the largest land animal, because he also goes with the eagle, the largest bird, and the Leviathan, the largest sea animal.

He was and always will be the greatest of all prophets.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yishmael: one who refrains from serving as a judge avoids hatred, thievery and false oaths, and one who frivolously hands down rulings is a fool, wicked and arrogant. He also says: do not judge on your own, for there is none qualified to judge alone, only the One; and do not say, "You must accept my view," for that is the majority's right, not yours. That belongs to the unity of Sivan, and to the humility the commandments need. We have to do everything in our power not to make ourselves great at the Torah's expense, remembering that only G-d is truly great. And it points straight at Moses and Korach. Korach was enormously rich, with a deep-set enlarged view of himself, and his claim rested on something like the last part of this teaching — that Moses and Aaron should follow the majority rather than keep the key positions for themselves. Moses explained that the rebellion was ultimately against G-d Himself, who had chosen the two of them. And G-d does, and will, judge alone.

The combination is gevurah shebeyesod. This week we work with strength and discipline to keep a solid foundation in study and in the mitzvot, and the elephant is that foundation: who can move an elephant against its will? The lesson from it is that even the largest animal recognises the infinite greatness and depth of Hashem.

Week 37, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 254 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Strength and Stability that Come From Humility

The third week of Sivan. Haazinu asks the question: "Then He will say, 'Where is their deity, the rock in which they trusted,'" (Deuteronomy 32:37) and read positively it is asked not of the Jewish people but of the other nations — which fits the verse of week thirty-one, that our Rock is not like theirs.

The Haftorah is the footing: "You have enlarged my step[s] beneath me; And my ankles have not slipped." (II Samuel 22:37) That support is a stable rock. It also runs parallel to the elephant's verse about the works of G-d being great — Gadol, big, like the elephant, and Gimmel Dalet Lamed have the numerical value of 37.

The quality is keeping far from honor. Pirkei Avot teaches that seeking honor takes a person out of this world. Honor, or anything that feeds the ego, is an

enormous obstacle in serving G-d; haughtiness is the opposite of holiness. For all the honor given the Jewish people at Mount Sinai, the experience was so awe-inspiring that it led to greater humility. It is the same thing the Pirkei Avot of Book 1 says, about not handing down judgments needlessly — and seeking honor is what brought Korach down.

The prophet is Ezekiel, who is bound closely to keeping far from honor. G-d commands him to do things so far against what we would call kevod habriot, the honour and dignity of a person, that it is hard to imagine anyone capable of them: Ezekiel is commanded to eat excrement. And it is Ezekiel who has the most exalted visions of G-d — the Haftorah of the first day of Shavuot is his vision of the Heavenly Chariot, the opening lines of his book. He was a kohen too, like Uriah and Jeremiah, the prophets of the two weeks before.

The levitical city is Dimnah, which literally means dunghill: staying away from honor again.

Week 37, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 255 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Remembering the Shavuot Experience

Beshalach: "They gathered it morning by morning, each one according to his eating capacity, and [when] the sun grew hot, it melted. It came to pass on the sixth day that they gathered a double portion of bread, two omers for [each] one, and all the princes of the community came and reported [it] to Moses." Each took what he could hold. The sixth day is not only the sixth of the week but Shavuot, which fell on the sixth of Sivan; the double portion may be the two crowns of Torah; and all the princes of the community coming together is the unity of this month.

The Haftorah is Sissera going down: "At her feet he sank, fell, lay; at her feet he sank (and) fell." It is remarkable how often the words repeat — karah three times in the whole verse, and nafal three times, and in the part given to this week a whole phrase comes twice with "lay" set between. Taken out of the context of his death and set in Shavuot, it is perhaps the people's own experience at Mount Sinai: there we bowed and fell and lay at the feet of the Shechinah, our souls left our bodies, and we had to be revived.

Daf Lamed Zayin of Sotah takes up the splitting of the Red Sea, including the initiative and self-sacrifice of the tribe of Benjamin and of Nachshon ben Aminadav; then Har Grizim and Har Eival again, with where the Levi'im and the Kohanim stood; and then the number of covenants made with the Jewish people, the one at Har Sinai among them, and the blessings and curses. The parallels with Shavuot are many: the initiative and self-sacrifice of saying Na'aseh veNishmah, and the covenant at the mountain.

The generation is Asa, son of Abijam, an extremely righteous king who returned the kingdom to the ways of Hashem and rid it of idol worship — he even removed his own mother from her position for worshipping Ashera trees. He overlaps briefly with Jeroboam, and with all the kings of Israel who fought over Jeroboam's succession: Nadav, Baasa, Elah, Zimri, Tivni, who was never an undisputed king, and Omri. All of them ruled for very short times, Tivni never ruling at all, except Omri, who ruled for 12 years. Asa reigned for forty-one years, and except for one brief lapse of faith in dealing with Baasa he was righteous and faithful and led Judah on a good path — fitting for the week after Shavuot.

The journey is from Punon to Oboth. Rabbi Jacobson explains that Oboth means enemies, and also necromancy, as in the practice of Ovoth and Yidonim. After the giving of the Torah we begin to be tested by our enemies, who work to bring us down from the height we reached, and it matters to stay firm. Oboth is also spelled like Avoth, the patriarchs — and it was by visiting Hebron, the Cave of the Patriarchs, that Caleb was able to stay faithful to his mission and bring back a true report. The personal journey moves from being revived by the Torah to staying connected to our roots and true to our mission.

Week 37, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 256 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Years of Life and Length of Days

Channah's ninth verse: "The feet of His pious ones He will guard, And the wicked shall be cut off in darkness, For not by strength will man prevail."

Pirkei Avot, on the greatness of the Torah, also weighs life against death: "With me, your days shall be increased, and years of life shall be added to you." Days and

years look like a repetition, and they are not — a person can live many years and have little quality in his days.

Ecclesiastes 6 is length of days, and the darkness inside even a long life. “Should a man beget one hundred [children] and live many years, and he will have much throughout the days of his years, but his soul will not be sated from all the good, neither did he have burial. I said that the stillborn is better than he. For he comes in vanity and goes in darkness, and in darkness his name is covered.” And then: “For who knows what is good for man in his lifetime, the number of the days of his life of vanity, that he do them like a shadow, for who will tell man what will be after him under the sun?”

The week holds the yahrzeits of Rav Aharon of Karlin, the Beis Aharon, on the 17th of Sivan, and Rabbi Yissachar Dov of Radoshitz, the Sabba Kadisha, on the 18th.

Rebbe Aharon of Karlin was the son of Rebbe Asher of Stolin and grandson of Rebbe Aharon HaGadol of Karlin, and is known as the Second Rebbe Aharon. He was chosen as Karliner Rebbe at only 26, and led the Karlin Chassidim with prodigious scholarship and unparalleled piety and humility; tens of thousands thronged around him seeking the blessings of a man said to be endowed with ruach hakodesh, and some even claimed he had the soul of King David. His leadership fell in the dark days of the reign of Czar Nikolai I, and he knew how to cheer his Chassidim and help them carry their burdens. Some powerful residents of Karlin objected to how much song and dance filled his court, and in 1864 he was run out of town; he resettled in Stolin, and since then the dynasty has been known as Karlin-Stolin. By family tradition he was born on Rosh Chodesh Sivan, 1802, and he led the Karliner Chassidim for nearly fifty years. A gifted organiser, he worked at the bonds between himself and his followers, visiting them often in their towns and welcoming them warmly in his court. He had a striking natural simplicity and sense of humour, and regularly made jokes in the Russian vernacular even while teaching at his table; he mixed freely with people of all kinds, and his confident presence was admired even in non-Chassidic circles.

Rabbi Yissachar Dov, the Sabba Kadisha, the holy grandfather, of Radoshitz, was a disciple of the Seer of Lublin and of the Holy Yid of Peshischa. Famed as a miracle maker, he lived in poverty as a simple tutor. Also this week: Rabbi Chaim of Volozhin on the 14th of Sivan and Rabbi Dovid Twersky, Second Rebbe of Skver, on

the 19th.

Week 37, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 257 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

First Fruits

The Song goes out early: “Let us arise early to the vineyards; let us see whether the vine has blossomed, the tiny grapes have developed, the pomegranates have lost their flowers; there I will give you my love.” This one belongs to Chag HaBikkurim, the festival of the first fruits, gathered from the field and brought as an offering. Rashi explains that the pomegranates losing their flowers means they had become ripe, and he connects each of the fruits named with the knowledge and study of Torah, the study of Mishnah in particular.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirty-seventh is Shuni, whose name looks related to LeShanot, to go over, to study. And with him Becher, son of Benjamin, whose name is near Bechor, firstborn, and Bikkurim, first fruits.

Daf Lamed Zayin of Shvuot keeps on with the oath of a pikadon, a gift or deposit — and the Torah is the gift itself, given at Sinai.

Jeremiah’s thirty-seventh chapter has the king of Judah finally listening to the prophet, and the first signs of all his prophecies coming true, and of his vindication against the false prophets. “Deceive not yourselves, saying, 'The Chaldeans shall surely withdraw from us,' for they shall not withdraw.” Then the king, in private: “And King Zedekiah sent and took him, and the king asked him secretly in his house, and he said, 'Is there a word from the Lord?' And Jeremiah said, 'There is.' And he said, 'You shall be given into the hand[s] of the king of Babylon.'” And then Jeremiah’s own question: “What have I sinned against you and against your servants and against this people, that you have put me into the prison? And where are your prophets who prophesied to you, saying, 'The king of Babylon shall not come upon you or upon this land’?”

Week 37, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 258 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Sivan - Psalms 109-111; 105:12-14; 89:38

The third week of Sivan in psalms: the hundred and ninth, hundred and tenth and hundred and eleventh, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 109 David composed while fleeing from Saul, facing many enemies who acted friendly in his presence and spoke only evil of him — so he curses them bitterly. "O G-d of my praise, be not silent. For the mouth of the wicked and the mouth of the deceitful have opened against me; they spoke to me with a false tongue." The exchange that hurts: "In return for my love they hate me; still, I am [a man of] prayer. They placed harm upon me in return for my favor, and hatred in return for my love." Then the long curse, which runs from his days to his children to his name. Then the reason: "Because he did not remember to do kindness, and he pursued the poor and destitute man and the broken-hearted, to kill [him]." And the curse as clothing: "He donned the curse like his garment, and it came like water into his innards, like oil into his bones." Then his own state: "For I am poor and destitute, and my heart has died within me. Like the fleeting shadow I am banished, I am tossed about like the locust. My knees totter from fasting." And the asking: "Let them know that this is Your hand, that You, Lord, have done it. Let them curse, but You will bless." And the last line, which says where He stands: "when He stands at the right of the destitute one to deliver him from the condemners of his soul."

Psalm 110 records the answer of Eliezer, servant of Abraham, to those who asked how Abraham managed to defeat the four kings; he tells of Abraham killing the mighty kings and their armies. Read it and you will find that the whole psalm is about Abraham, who merited prominence for recognising G-d in his youth. "The Lord said to my master, 'Sit at My right, until I make your enemies a stool for your feet.' The staff of your strength the Lord will send from Zion, to rule amid your enemies." The youth kept: "because of your splendid sanctity from when you emerged from the womb, you still possess the dew of your youth." And the oath: "The Lord has sworn and will not regret: 'You shall be a priest forever, just as Melchizedek!'"

Psalm 111 is written in alphabetical sequence, two letters to a verse, except the last two, which have three each. It is short and prominent, and it is about the works of G-d and their greatness. "Great are the works of the Lord, [yet] available to all who

desire them. Majesty and splendor are His work, and His righteousness endures forever. He established a memorial for His wonders, for the Lord is gracious and compassionate." The works that hold: "The works of His hands are true and just; all His mandates are faithful. They are steadfast for ever and ever, for they are made with truth and uprightness." And the last line: "The beginning of wisdom is fear of the Lord; sound wisdom for all who practice it-his praise endures forever."

Psalm 105's verses are the few strangers on the road: "When they were few in number, hardly dwelling in it. And they walked from nation to nation, from one kingdom to another people. He let no man oppress them, and He reproved kings on their account." And Psalm 89's verse is the witness in the sky: "Like the moon, which is established forever, and it is a witness in the sky, eternally true."

Week 37, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 259 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Elephant Is Saying

The elephant opens, and the week sets a widened step beside thoughts too deep to follow.

The step and the depth first: "You have enlarged my step[s] beneath me" / "And my ankles have not slipped" / "How great are your works, G-d" / "Your thoughts are tremendously deep" / "Let us arise early to the vineyards" / "Let us see whether the vine has blossomed."

Then the gathering, and what strength cannot do: "They gathered it morning by morning" / "For not by strength will man prevail" / "And they walked from nation to nation" / "From one kingdom to another people" / "A double portion of bread, two omers for one" / "And all the princes of the community came and reported to Moses" / "Each one according to his eating capacity" / "And [when] the sun grew hot, it melted."

Then the question about their rock, and the falling at her feet: "Then He will say, 'Where is their deity'" / "'The rock in which they trusted?'" / "At her feet he sank, fell, lay" / "At her feet he sank (and) fell" / "The feet of His pious ones He will guard" / "And the wicked shall be cut off in darkness."

And the end is the ripe fruit and the moon: “The tiny grapes have developed” / “The pomegranates have lost their flowers” / “Like the moon, which is established forever” / “And it is a witness in the sky, eternally true” / “When they were few in number, hardly dwelling in it” / “It came to pass on the sixth day that they gathered” / “He let no man oppress them, and He reproved kings on their account” / “There I will give you my love.”

Week 37, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXXVIII

Tiferet of Yesod

Days 260–266

Day 260 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Be Strong and Courageous in order to Defend the Common Good

The Lion is saying, "G-d shall go out as a mighty man, He shall arouse zeal, He shall cry, even roar, He shall prevail over His enemies." (Isaiah 42:13) The verse belongs to Sivan, where the whole people trembled at the voice giving the Ten Commandments at Mount Sinai. It belongs to Zevulun too, who went out to sea to trade — and our sages draw an interesting line between going out to war and going out to make a living, which can be its own kind of war.

The week of the lion is the last of Sivan and the last of spring. The two summer months that follow, Tammuz and Av, are intense, and closely tied to the destruction of the Temple — and also to its rebuilding and the coming of Mashiach.

Here Hashem Himself is the lion. The Temple is often called a lion too, Ariel, which means lion of G-d. And the lion is the symbol of the tribe of Judah, from whom come King David and Mashiach. A Midrash runs all three together: the lion, Nebuchadnezzar the Babylonian emperor, came during the lion, the month of Av, and destroyed Ariel, the Temple, so that the Lion, G-d, will appear during the lion, the month of Av, and rebuild Ariel. The verse itself compares Him to a man at war, a roaring lion who will defeat His enemies and redeem His people. In the last week of Sivan we get ready, spiritually and physically and in our minds, for what is coming. Tammuz and Av can hold much pain, and they hold the spirit of redemption; it depends how they are approached. To come through, we have to reach the spark of the lion of Judah, of David, of Mashiach, that each of us carries. Prepared well, with everything learned from Passover to Lag Ba'Omer to Shavuot, we will be strong as lions, and with G-d beside us there is nothing at all to fear.

Thirty-eight is the gematria of Bul, the biblical name of Cheshvan. The Torah says that "in the month Bul, which is the eighth month, the house [of G-d] was finished throughout all the parts thereof, and according to all the fashion of it, and he built it in seven years." In week twenty-three we had the gematria of Ziv, the biblical name of Iyar, the month Solomon's Temple was begun. Having lived the redemption of Adar and Nissan, worked on ourselves in Iyar, and received the Torah in Sivan, our inner Temple should feel finished now — and it is our work to protect it, and to bring about the rebuilding of the Temple in Jerusalem.

Thirty-eight is chet and lamed, which spell chol, sand, recalling the blessing Abraham received that his offspring would be as many as the sand of the sea. Chol also means profane, which belongs to the destruction, the exile, and the profanation of His name in the months after Sivan. And the same letters spell lach, wet or fresh: we leave Sivan, and spring, fresh and full of water — a metaphor for Torah — and ready for the summer heat.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yonatan: whoever fulfills the Torah in poverty will ultimately fulfill it in wealth, and whoever neglects the Torah in wealth will ultimately neglect it in poverty. This week holds the same thing. If we break the Torah so soon after its revelation in Sivan, it will be harder still to keep it in the poverty that Tammuz and Av may bring. Keep it through those months of poverty, and they turn into months of tremendous enrichment, with the coming of Moshiach — and our commitment through the spiritual poverty of exile will be repaid with the ability to keep the Torah in the spiritual wealth of the Messianic era. The teaching also belongs to Zevulun, whose wealth provided for Issachar, and who, for all his professional activity, stayed faithful to the Torah and devoted to studying it.

The combination is tiferet shebeyesod. This week we feel the beauty and the balance of the Torah inside us and strengthen our foundations for the hard months. The lesson from the lion is that we have to be brave and willing to go out beyond our own sheltered worlds in order to help the people around us.

Week 38, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 261 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Daniel and Not Acting Arrogantly with One's Knowledge

The last week of Sivan. Haazinu continues last week's questions: "who ate the fat of their sacrifices and drank the wine of their libations? Let them arise and help you! Let them be your shelter!" (Deuteronomy 32:38) Read positively, the questions are still being put to Israel's enemies. The Haftorah supports that directly: "I have pursued my enemies and have destroyed them; Never turning back until they were consumed." (II Samuel 22:38) They found no refuge at all.

The quality is that he does not act arrogantly with his knowledge. Haughtiness is the opposite of holiness and of Torah, so being arrogant on the strength of what one knows is the plainest case of behaving wrongly — the knowledge does not belong to the individual but to G-d. It can also be read as not acting arrogantly with His knowledge, because the knowledge is all His. That is a central message of Sivan.

The prophet is Daniel — and this is the week of the lion, and Daniel is known above all for being thrown into the den of hungry lions and miraculously saved. His reading of Nebuchadnezzar's dream is this quality at work, because the interpretation of dreams comes from G-d. "And to these youths, the four of them, G-d gave knowledge and understanding in every script and wisdom, and Daniel understood all visions and dreams." Asked for the dream, he first asked for time, told Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah, and prayed; and when the secret was revealed to him in a vision of the night, he blessed the G-d of heaven: "May the Name of G-d be blessed from everlasting even to everlasting, to Whom are wisdom and might. And He changes the times and the seasons, He removes kings and sets up kings; He grants wisdom to the wise and knowledge to those who know understanding. He reveals the profound and secret things; He knows what is in the dark, and light dwells with Him." And standing before the king he said it plainly: "The secret that the king asks, no wise men, astrologers, necromancers, or demonologists can tell the king. But there is a G-d in heaven Who reveals secrets." And: "And I-not with wisdom that I possess more than all living, did He reveal this secret to me." Which is what his predecessor Joseph said to Pharaoh: "Not I; G-d will give an answer [that will bring] peace to Pharaoh."

Rashi notes that the sages discuss whether Daniel should count as a prophet, so some put Shemaiah here instead. The prophet Shemaiah, who prophesied in the days of Rehavam, would be well out of chronological order; another Shemaiah, a kohen, the father of Uriah, is somewhat closer and still out of order. Perhaps the name is a further hint at the quality of the week, since Shemaiah comes from Lishmoah, to hear, with the Name of Hashem in it — heard G-d, or G-d heard. It points at the humility a prophet needs: to remember that his job is to be a conduit, to hear the word of G-d when G-d hears His people. Which is Sivan as well.

The levitical city is Nahalal, whose name holds hallel, to praise. Praising G-d for everything He has done for us is the ultimate form of humility.

Week 38, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 262 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Preparing for the Summer Months

Beshalach: "So he said to them, That is what the Lord spoke, Tomorrow is a rest day, a holy Sabbath to the Lord. Bake whatever you wish to bake, and cook whatever you wish to cook, and all the rest leave over to keep until morning. So they left it over until morning, as Moses had commanded, and it did not become putrid, and not a worm was in it." The sixth day is special again, and this is preparing for the Sabbath — which is the preparing for the hard summer months, and it has to be done in Sivan.

The Haftorah finishes Sissera and turns to a window: "where he sank, there he fell down dead. Through the window looked forth, the mother of Sisera [peered] through the window." Out of the context of his death, the verse looks like Sinai again. And a mother peering through a window brings to mind the verse of the Song of Songs where G-d peers through the window to see our suffering, ready to return His Shechinah to its place — which points at the coming months too.

Daf Lamed Cheit of Sotah is all the blessing of the Kohanim, and how the blessing given outside the Temple differed from the one given inside. That blessing, which by halachah must be given out of love, as the brachah before it says, is the ultimate example of brotherly love and peace among the Jewish people.

The generation is Jehoshaphat, son of Asa, another extremely righteous king; his counterparts in Israel were Omri, Ahab, and Ahaziah. His name means G-d is Judge — and in Book 2 this week's prophet is Daniel, whose name also means G-d is my Judge. His one mistake was growing too friendly with the evil rulers of the northern kingdom and at times seeking alliances with them, which is the other side of this month's brotherly love: one has to know when to keep a distance. Overall he was extremely righteous and led the people through 25 years of real peace and prosperity. Set his name against Ahab's, which makes no reference to G-d and suggests possible incest, meaning brother-father. Ahab seems to correct that in naming his own son Ahaziah, one who holds on to G-d, with Hashem's name in it; Ahaziah is also the name of one of the kings of Judah. He followed his father's evil ways all the same, was involved in idolatry, and died after only two years.

The journey is from Oboth to the ruins of Abarim, on the Moabite boundary. Abarim comes from Aveirah, transgression. Because of our sins in the summer months of Tammuz and Av, our Temple lies in ruins — and Rashi himself draws the parallel to Jerusalem in one of his few comments on the journeys, reading the ruins of Abarim as an expression of waste and ruin, as in "into a heap in the field," and "they have turned Jerusalem into heaps." Moab was a nation known for its immorality, and like Ahab's, its name suggests incest, and was given for that reason: Moab means from the father, because the nation began when Lot had relations with his own daughter. It is our work to fight such immorality, and so to raise the sparks hidden in that nation's kelipah. And after Ahab's death it was Moab that revolted against Israel. The personal journey moves from staying true to our mission to repenting of, and fighting, the sins that brought the Temple down.

Week 38, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 263 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Strength and Long Life

Channah's tenth verse closes her song: "Those who strive with the Lord will be broken; Upon him will He thunder in Heaven; The Lord will judge the ends of the earth. And He will grant strength to His King, And raise the horn of His anointed one." Judgment, and then strength given to the king.

Pirkei Avot, on the greatness of the Torah, raises those who come near it: “Long days in her right hand; in her left, wealth and honor.”

Ecclesiastes 7 is the standing and the length of days that wisdom brings: “Be not overly wicked, and be not a fool; why should you die before your time? It is good that you should take hold of this, and also from this you shall not withdraw your hand, for he who fears God will discharge himself of them all. Wisdom affords strength to the wise more than ten rulers who were in the city.”

The week holds the yahrzeits of Rebbe Yisrael Dan of Modzitz on the 20th of Sivan, Rebbe Shlomo Shapira of Munkatch on the 21st, and Rabbi Mordechai-Tzemach Eliyahu on the 25th.

Reb Israel Dan was born in 1928 in Warsaw, the capital of Poland, and made Aliya to Eretz Yisrael with his parents in 1936, as a child of 7. He married Rachel, daughter of HaRav Shmuel Aharon Shadrovitzki from Byalistok, a great talmud chacham among the heads of Agudas Yisrael in Poland. He was chosen to replace the Imrei Aish on his passing, and his deep knowledge of the Torah became evident to many when he became the Admor on his father’s death; at his Tishim people heard many beautiful Divre Torah, pleasant to the ear. For some years he led the Chasidim in Tel-Aviv, where his father had lived, and on Lag Ba’omer 1995 he moved to a new building the Chasidim had built in Bnei Brak. Like his fathers he composed Nigunnim, many of which are already sung regularly in Jewish homes. He was very active in the public interest and a member of the Moetzet G’Dolei Hatorah, where his opinions were looked up to.

Rabbi Shlomo Shapira, author of the Shem Shlomoh, was the first Rebbe of Chassidut Munkach, son of Rabbi Elazar Shapira and grandson of Rabbi Zvi Elimelech Shapira of Dynow, the Bnei Yissachar; he was also the rabbi of the town of Munkatch. His biography is set down in a work by David Kahane called Beit Shlomoh.

Rabbi Mordechai-Tzemach Eliyahu, the former Chief Sephardic Rabbi of Israel, was born in Iraq. A noted sage in every area of Torah study and a significant kabbalist, he was considered one of the leading authorities on Jewish law in Israel. His son, Rabbi Shmuel Eliyahu, is Chief Rabbi of Tsfat.

Week 38, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 264 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Unity and Captivity

The Song's verse keeps to the first fruits, with fruit new and old: "The pots [of figs] have given forth [their] fragrance, and on our doorways are all manner of sweet fruits, both new and old, which I have hidden away for you, my beloved." Rashi comments that before, there were two kinds of fruit, good and bad, and now both of them have given forth their fragrance; they all seek Your countenance. Sivan is the height of both Jewish unity and the revelation that follows it.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirty-eighth is Ezbon, whose name looks related to Etzbah, finger. A finger is not an independent thing: it is part of a hand and has to be joined to it. And with him Ashbel, son of Benjamin, whose name means taken captive — another of the names Benjamin gave as a sign of unity with his brother, mourning that Joseph had been sold as a slave.

Daf Lamed Cheit of Shvuot keeps on with the oath of a pikadon and opens a new chapter on Shevuas HaDayanim, the oath of judges, on partial admission, and on how an oath is administered. Most of the daf is the collective oath — and this week and this month are about collectivity.

Jeremiah's thirty-eighth chapter has the king receptive again, and promising not to punish him for his words. "And King Zedekiah sent and took Jeremiah the prophet to him, to the third entrance, that was in the house of the Lord, and the king said to Jeremiah, 'I ask you a word; do not conceal a word from me.'" Jeremiah's answer: "If I tell you, will you not put me to death? And if I advise you, you will not listen to me." So the king swore secretly: "As the Lord lives who made for us this soul, I will neither put you to death nor will I deliver you into the hand[s] of these men who seek your life." Then the choice, laid out plainly: "If you go out to the officers of the king of Babylon, your soul shall live, and this city shall not be burnt with fire, and you and your household shall live. But if you do not go out… this city shall be delivered into the hand[s] of the Chaldeans, and they shall burn it with fire." The king was afraid of the Jews who had defected. And then the picture of what refusing would bring, down to the women and the children: "Behold, all the women who remained in the house of the king of Judah shall be taken out to the officers of the king of Babylon, and they shall say, 'Your cohorts have enticed you and prevailed

over you. Your feet have sunk into the mire; they have turned back.'" The last verse of the chapter says what happened: "And Jeremiah stayed in the prison yard until the day that Jerusalem was taken, and he was [there] when Jerusalem was taken."

Week 38, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 265 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Last Week of Sivan - Psalms 112-114; 105:15-17; 89:39

The last week of Sivan in psalms: the hundred and twelfth, hundred and thirteenth and hundred and fourteenth, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 112 also follows the alphabet, two letters to a verse except the last two, which have three each. It is about the good traits a man should choose, and about how to give charity — whose reward is never having to rely on others. "Fortunate is the man who fears the Lord, and desires His commandments intensely." The light in the dark: "Even in darkness light shines for the upright, for [He is] Compassionate, Merciful, and Just." The measure of the man: "Good is the man who is compassionate and lends, [but] provides for his own needs with discretion." The steadiness: "He will not be afraid of a bad tiding; his heart is steadfast, secure in the Lord." And the giving: "He has distributed [his wealth], giving to the needy. His righteousness will endure forever; his might will be uplifted in honor."

Psalm 113 recounts some of the wonders of the exodus. "From the rising of the sun to its setting, the Name of the Lord is praised. The Lord is high above all nations; His glory transcends the heavens. Who is like the Lord our G-d, Who dwells on high [yet] looks down so low upon heaven and earth!" And what He does when He looks: "He raises the poor from the dust, lifts the destitute from the dunghill, to seat them with nobles, with the nobles of His people. He transforms the barren woman into a household, into a joyful mother of children."

Psalm 114 explains why the tribe of Judah merited kingship. "When Israel went out of Egypt, the House of Jacob from a people of a foreign tongue, Judah became His holy [nation], Israel, His domain." Then the world running: "The sea saw and fled, the Jordan turned backward. The mountains skipped like rams, the hills like young sheep." Then the question put to all of them — what is the matter with you, sea, that you flee; Jordan, that you turn backward; mountains, that you skip — and

the answer: “[We do so] before the Master, the Creator of the earth, before the G-d of Jacob, Who turns the rock into a pool of water, the flintstone into a water fountain.”

Psalm 105's verses are the protection and the famine and the man sent ahead: “Do not touch My anointed ones, and do not harm My prophets.” “He called a famine upon the land; He broke every staff of bread. He sent a man before them; Joseph was sold as a slave.” And Psalm 89's verse turns hard: “But You abandoned and You rejected; You became wroth with Your anointed.”

Week 38, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 266 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Lion is saying

The lion opens, and the week sets a roar against a mother at a window.

The roaring and the pursuing first: “He shall arouse zeal, He shall cry” / “Even roar, He shall prevail over His enemies” / “I have pursued my enemies and have destroyed them” / “Those who strive with the Lord will be broken” / “Upon him will He thunder in Heaven.”

Then what was left until morning, and the famine: “So they left it over until morning” / “As Moses had commanded” / “He called a famine upon the land” / “He broke every staff of bread” / “Who ate the fat of their sacrifices” / “And drank the wine of their libations?” / “Through the window looked forth, the mother of Sisera [peered] through the window.”

Then the gods called on to help, and the dead man: “Let them arise and help you! Let them be your shelter!” / “And all the rest leave over to keep until morning” / “Where he sank, there he fell down dead” / “The Lord will judge the ends of the earth” / “And He will grant strength to His King” / “And raise the horn of His anointed one.”

Then the anointed twice over, and Joseph sold: “'Do not touch My anointed ones, And do not harm My prophets'” / “But You abandoned and You rejected; You became wroth with Your anointed” / “He sent a man before them; Joseph was sold as a slave.”

And the end is the Sabbath and the fragrance: “So he said to them, That is what the Lord spoke” / “Tomorrow is a rest day, A holy Sabbath to the Lord” / “The pots

[of figs] have given forth [their] fragrance" / "And on our doorways are all manner of sweet fruits" / "Bake whatever you wish to bake" / "And cook whatever you wish to cook" / "G-d shall go out as a mighty man" / "Never turning back until they were consumed" / "And it did not become putrid, and not a worm was in it" / "Both new and old, Which I have hidden away for you, my beloved."

Week 38, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XXXIX

Netzach of Yesod

Days 267–273

Day 267 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To See the World in a Positive Light in Order to Elevate It

This week holds Rosh Chodesh Tammuz and Gimmel Tammuz, the date of the Lubavitcher Rebbe's passing and also the beginning of the liberation of the Sixth Lubavitcher Rebbe.

Tammuz belongs to Reuven, Jacob's firstborn. His name comes from reiyiah, sight, and the month is the tikkun of our sense of sight. Reuven belongs to teshuvah in general: the Midrash says of him that he was the first to repent out of love, without being chastised first. The month is also the tikkun for the sin of the spies. Moses sent them, and they travelled through the Land of Israel for the whole month of Tammuz, and apart from Joshua and Caleb they saw it in a negative light. Tammuz carries the tragedies of the 17th day of the month — among them the destruction of the first tablets of the Ten Commandments, and the breaching of the walls of Jerusalem — and it also carries the final redemption, when, after we repent and are redeemed, the 17th of Tammuz will no longer be a day of fasting and mourning but a day of celebration. That turnaround is Reuven's own. Jacob took away his firstborn rights after a severe mistake involving one of his father's concubines, and Reuven spent his whole life doing teshuvah for it — and the Torah recognises that repentance, still calling him Jacob's firstborn long after.

The Bear is saying, "Let the wilderness and its cities lift up their voice, the village that Kedar inhabits; let the inhabitants of the rock sing, let them shout from the peaks of the mountains. Let them give glory to G-d and tell of His praise in the islands." (Isaiah 42:11-12) The song is about looking at the world with good eyes. The Bear sees that the deserts, the cities, the villages, the mountains and the islands all

hold the great potential of praising G-d. That is how the world should be seen — everyone has it, and we only need to open our eyes. One of the Rebbe's main accomplishments, which began with the Previous Rebbe, was always to see in each follower and in every Jew that enormous potential for good; it is how he formed so many leaders and reached so many people, spreading the light of Judaism and Chassidism to the far corners of the world — cities and spiritual deserts, mountains and isolated islands.

Eliyahu HaNavi, who will announce the coming of Mashiach, also goes with the Bear. As in week 12, the Tanach tells that before Elijah ascended, Elisha asked for a double portion of his strength. Soon after, when Elisha purified the waters of a city, he was insulted by some young men who had made their money carrying clean water from elsewhere, and whose trade his miracle had made useless. They began taunting him, calling him bald, to set him against Elijah, who had a head full of hair. Elisha cursed them, and two bears — an apparent reference to that double portion — came out of the wilderness and killed them. And just as the bear's song names Arabia, Kedar, the Talmud has various stories of Elijah disguising himself as an Arab when he appeared before tzadikim, to test them or to help them.

Thirty-nine is the number of kinds of work forbidden on Shabbat, which parallel the thirty-nine kinds of work done in building the Mishkan, a miniature Temple where the Divine Presence rested. The Mishkan is a microcosm of the world: as G-d rested on the seventh day of creation, the Jewish people rested on the same day while building it. And the bear's song is about distant, uninhabited places that hold the potential to praise Hashem, and so to make Him a home in this world. The Midrash Tanchumah teaches that His main object in creating the world was to make a home for Himself in the lowly realms — and that home is the Mishkan. The letters lamed and tet, which make thirty-nine, spell tel, mountain; the laws of Shabbat are known as mountains on a wire, because a vast number of prohibitions are drawn from a few explicit verses.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Meir: engage minimally in business and occupy yourself with Torah; be humble before every man; if you neglect the Torah there will be many more causes for neglect before you, and if you toil much in Torah there is much reward to give you. The Talmud says that whoever saw Rabbi Meir studying saw him take mountains and grind them into each other. He was known for miracles, many of

them involving Eliyahu HaNavi. He is teshuvah too, and seeing the potential in people and in far places: he was himself a descendant of Roman converts, and when a certain group of people mistreated and insulted him, he followed his wife Beruria's advice and, instead of praying for their destruction, prayed that they do teshuvah — which in the end they did. His words belong to Tammuz and to Reuven: humbly turning any lack of dedication to the Torah, which brought our people such obstacles and tragedies, into full dedication and toil, and so into enormous reward.

The combination is netzach shebeyesod. We have to be persistent in keeping our foundation in Torah and mitzvot. Joseph, who is yesod, endured the constant attempts of Potiphar's wife to seduce him and resisted her in the end — and Rashi compares her to a bear. There will always be bears trying to pull us off our purpose; we have to stand as firm as one ourselves. And from the bear we learn that wherever we are, we should try to speak of the Torah and raise the place we are in as far as we can.

Week 39, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 268 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Baruch and Not Being Happy in Handing Down Decrees

Rosh Chodesh Tammuz and Gimmel Tammuz. Tammuz is marked by the fast of the 17th, when the walls of Jerusalem were breached, and the month belongs to Reuven, Jacob's firstborn.

Haazinu: "See now that it is I! I am the One, and there is no G-d like Me! I cause death and grant life. I strike, but I heal, and no one can rescue from My Hand!" (Deuteronomy 32:39) That verse is Tammuz exactly — before the times of Mashiach a month of death and suffering, and after them a month of life and healing.

The Haftorah picks up the last words of it: "And I have consumed them, and I have crushed them that they cannot rise; Yes, they are fallen under my feet." (II Samuel 22:39) In this month we have been crushed and consumed in the past, and in the future the enemies of the Jews will fall under their feet.

The quality is that he does not take pleasure in handing down halachic decisions, Einoh Sameach B'hora'ah — not using the Torah for one's own honor. More literally, the person is not happy in making rulings. Tammuz has been a month in which the

Jewish people were not happy, having been handed difficult decrees in it. And it is in our power to reverse those decrees, through Teshuvah.

The prophet is Baruch, Jeremiah's scribe, who was given the task of reading those dire prophecies to the people — a task he certainly took no pleasure in, and he handed the decrees down all the same, according to his master's will. All four prophets of the month of Tammuz are related to Baruch: after him comes his father, then his brother, then his grandfather.

The levitical city is Betzer, also a city of refuge. Betzer means fortification, which suits the week, since it was in Tammuz that the fortifications of Jerusalem were breached. All the cities of this week are connected to Moab, and to Jeremiah's prophecy against that nation. Moab is the kelipah of broad powers, physical and intellectual, and the fear of losing them — which is Reuven's own.

Week 39, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 269 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Challenges to Faith in the Times of Exile

Beshalach: "And Moses said, Eat it today, for today is a Sabbath to the Lord; today you will not find it in the field. Six days you shall gather it, but on the seventh day [which is the] Sabbath on it there will be none." The mannah did not fall on the Sabbath, and it made the people nervous. Rashi sets the scene: in the morning, when they were used to going out to gather, they came to ask whether they should go out or not, and he said, what you have in your possession, eat. In the evening they came again and asked, and he said, today is the Sabbath. He saw they were worried that the manna had perhaps stopped and would not come down again, so he said, today you will not find it — meaning today you will not find it, and tomorrow you will.

Tammuz is a difficult month. In it the spies looked at the Land with negative eyes. In it, because of Moshe's brief delay in coming down the mountain, the grave sin of the golden calf happened, and then the breaking of the Luchot HaBrit. It is a month in which our Emunah is tested. And in Messianic times it will be a month of celebration. The mannah, the source of physical and spiritual substance, is not readily to be had at this time of year — in Moshe's words, today you will not find it, but tomorrow you will.

The Haftorah asks after a son who has not come home: “why is his chariot late in coming? Why tarry the strides of his chariots?” That is a challenge to faith too. And out of the context of Sissera’s death, the chariot can mean something else: the visions of the Divine Presence, Ezekiel’s and Isaiah’s, and all the esoteric literature on them, are known as Ma’aseh Merkavah, the Workings of the Chariot. From Tammuz on, we think about how late the Shechinah is in returning to its holy place.

Daf Lamed Tet of Sotah gives the laws of proper behaviour in a synagogue, during the reading of the Torah and the blessing of the Kohanim. It mentions the verses the congregation says during the priestly blessing, which are about Zion, and the verses of the blessing said on the afternoon of a fast day, which plead to be saved from exile. A synagogue is known as a mikdash me’at, a miniature Temple — and this is the time of year we turn to Zion, to the destruction, and to the rebuilding.

The generation is Jehoram, son of Jehoshaphat, whose reign was a complete disaster. His counterparts in Israel were Ahaziah and another king named Jehoram, son of Ahab, who was also wicked. Jehoram of Judah married Athaliah, daughter of Ahab and Jezebel, two of the most wicked and idolatrous people in all of Jewish history; she was idolatrous to an extreme and led her husband the same way, and soon idols and their priests were brought to Jerusalem. She then convinced him to kill his own six brothers. The kingdom was so steeped in crime and idolatry that all the nations that had been tributaries of Judah rebelled, ransacking every house including the royal palace; his wives and all but one of his children were captured and killed, and he himself died of an incurable disease. His name means G-d is exalted, and as this difficult month opens his reign shows how low we sometimes fall, and how much repentance matters.

The journey is from the ruins to Dibon gad. Dibon looks related to daveh, pining or moaning, and gad means good fortune, like the tribe of Gad, which belongs to Elul and to teshuvah. The secret is connecting Tammuz and Av to Elul, turning the word Dal, poor, into Dalet, door, which is the gates of teshuvah. The personal journey moves from fighting the sins that destroyed the Temple to pining for the good tidings that such repentance brings.

Week 39, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 270 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Years of Fullness and Peace

Channah's story ends quietly: "And Elkanah went to Ramah, to his house, and the child was serving the Lord before Eli the priest." It is a peaceful end to her life's dream of having children — and the end is really a beginning, a life full of meaning, with Shmuel now spending his days in the service of the leader of the generation.

Pirkei Avot, on the greatness of the Torah, adds peace to the length of days: "For long days, years of life, and peace, they shall add to you."

Ecclesiastes 8 says the days of the wicked will not be long: "But it will not be well with the wicked, and he will not prolong [his] days, like a shadow, because he does not fear God." And the days he does have hold no peace: "When I applied my heart to know wisdom and to see the conduct that is done upon the earth, for neither by day nor by night does he see sleep with his eyes."

Besides the Lubavitcher Rebbe's yahrzeit, the week holds Rabbi Shlomo of Bobov on the 1st of Tammuz, and Rabbi Nachman Horodenker and Rabbi Avraham of Trisk on the 2nd.

Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, the Lubavitcher Rebbe, became the seventh Rebbe of Chabad after his father-in-law, Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn, passed away in Brooklyn on the 10th of Shvat 1950. He is widely acknowledged as the greatest Jewish leader of the second half of the 20th century. A dominant scholar in both the revealed and the hidden Torah, fluent in many languages and scientific subjects, he is best known for an extraordinary love and concern for every Jew on the planet; his emissaries around the globe number in the thousands, and hundreds of volumes of his teachings have been printed, with dozens of English renditions.

Rabbi Shlomo of Bobov was the first rebbe of the Bobover dynasty, which he took up shortly after the death of his renowned grandfather, the Divrei Chaim of Sanz. He was noted for strengthening the Judaism of the younger generation and for founding numerous yeshivas, and his chasidim numbered in the thousands. Rabbi Avraham of Trisk was one of the eight sons of Rabbi Mordechai of Chernobyl, all of whom became chasidic rebbes in their own right; besides being well known for the success of his blessings, his approachability and friendliness to all comers drew thousands to the court he conducted for some fifty years at Trisk, and his book, Magen Avraham

on the Torah and the festivals, is popular among Chasidim and among yeshiva students for the guidelines it offers.

Rabbi Nachman Horodenker, Rebbe Nachman's grandfather, was associated with the pious scholars of Brody. Around 1740 he travelled with his son Reb Shimshon to Eretz Yisrael and left two years later. When Rabbi Elazar Rokeach, rabbi in Amsterdam and later Tzfat, heard that Rabbi Nachman was in Eretz Yisrael, he said that if they were both there together they would be able to bring the Mashiach, and he rushed to join him — but Rabbi Nachman had already left. And when Rabbi Nachman, back in Europe, heard that Rabbi Elazar was in Israel, he travelled back to Tsfat to join him, and Rabbi Elazar had died. When his wife passed away he returned to Europe and became one of the closest followers of the Baal Shem Tov; around that time he remarried, and Rabbi Simcha, Rebbe Nachman's father, was born. The Baal Shem Tov said that Rabbi Nachman Horodenker had prayed not to be able to hear anything unnecessary to his service of G-d, and that his request was granted. He was known for remarking on every occurrence that it was for the best, and he is quoted several times in the works of Rabbi Yaakov Yosef of Polonnoye and in Degel Machaneh Ephraim. The Baal Shem Tov held him back from returning to the Land of Israel, and in 1764, after visiting the Baal Shem Tov's grave, he said the Baal Shem Tov had appeared to him and granted permission. Rabbi Pinchas of Koretz said that as long as Rabbi Nachman was in what was then Poland, the Cossaks could not enter the country — and it was while he was on his way to Eretz Yisrael that the massacre in Uman took place. He is buried in the old cemetery in Tiveria.

Week 39, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 271 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Feeling the Harshness of Exile

The Song begins its last chapter wishing for a brother: "O, that you were like my brother, who sucked my mother's breasts! I would find you outside, I would kiss you, and they would not despise me." Fitting, now that Sivan and its twins are over and Tammuz has come, a month tied to exile, when we were despised outside our land. Rashi's comment points to Joseph: that you were like my brother, meaning that you would come to console me as Joseph did his brothers, who had done evil to him, and of whom it is said, "and he consoled them." And Rosh Chodesh Tammuz is Joseph's yahrzeit.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the thirty-ninth is Eri, whose name looks related to being awake — as in "I am asleep, but my heart is awake," on which our Sages comment: although I am sleeping in exile, my heart is awake for the Holy One, blessed be He. And with him Gera, son of Benjamin, whose name means a foreigner, which is Joseph becoming a stranger in a strange country, as the Jewish people did in this season. Er is also the name of Judah's son who was killed by G-d for his sins — and the harsh punishments of these months serve as a wake-up call.

Daf Lamed Tet of Shvuot describes the harsh punishments for false oaths. Even the family of the one who swears falsely is punished, and the punishment is immediate: water and fire do not wear away the wood and rocks of his house, but false oaths do; and regarding false oaths Hash-m does not cleanse without punishment even if he repents. The daf connects this to the oaths taken at Sinai.

Jeremiah's thirty-ninth chapter begins the description of the atrocities. It says it was in the tenth month that Nebuchadnezzar's army besieged Jerusalem, and in the fourth month that it breached the walls. Here the months are counted from Nissan, so the fourth is Tammuz; and though Tammuz is also called the tenth month, counting from Rosh Hashanah, here the tenth is Teveth. Tammuz belongs to Reuven and to sight — and after the walls are breached the king of Judah is blinded. "And the king of Babylon slaughtered Zedekiah's sons in Riblah before his eye, and the king of Babylon slaughtered all the nobles of Judah." Rashi: all the nobles of Judah are the Sanhedrin, because they had annulled the oath. "And he blinded Zedekiah's eyes, and he bound him with copper chains to bring him to Babylon. And the king's palace

and the houses of the people the Chaldeans burnt with fire, and they demolished the walls of Jerusalem."

Week 39, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 272 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Rosh Chodesh Tammuz - Psalms 115-117; 105:18-20; 89:40

The week of Rosh Chodesh Tammuz in psalms: the hundred and fifteenth, hundred and sixteenth and hundred and seventeenth, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 115 asks Him to end this long exile for the sake of His Name, that it not be desecrated. "Not for our sake, Lord, not for our sake, but for the sake of Your Name bestow glory, because of Your kindness and Your truth. Why should the nations say, 'Where, now, is their G-d?'" Then the idols, made of silver and gold by human hands, taken apart sense by sense: "They have a mouth, but cannot speak; they have eyes, but cannot see; they have ears, but cannot hear; they have a nose, but cannot smell; their hands cannot touch; their feet cannot walk; they can make no sound in their throat." And then the warning: "Those who make them will become like them-all who put their trust in them." Then the three who are told to trust instead — Israel, the House of Aaron, those who fear the Lord — and the blessing on the small with the great. And the end: "The dead cannot praise the Lord, nor any who descend into the silence [of the grave]. But we will bless the Lord from now to eternity."

Psalm 116 is David's love for G-d in the light of all the miracles done for him, and his not knowing how to repay any of it. "The pangs of death encompassed me and the misery of the grave came upon me; I encounter trouble and sorrow. I invoke the Name of the Lord, 'Lord, I implore you, deliver my soul!'" Then the saving: "The Lord watches over the simpletons; I was brought low, and He saved me. Return, my soul, to your tranquility, for the Lord has bestowed goodness upon you. For You have delivered my soul from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling." The faith held in the worst of it: "I had faith even when I declared, 'I am greatly afflicted'; [even when] I said in my haste, 'All men are deceitful.'" Then the question the psalm is built on: "How can I repay the Lord for all His beneficences to me? I will raise the cup of deliverance and proclaim the Name of the Lord." And the line that reads differently

in this month: “Grievous in the eyes of the Lord is the death of His pious ones.”

Psalm 117 is two verses, and it points at the Messianic era, when the Children of Israel will have their former glory and all will praise G-d, in fulfilment of the verse that all will then call in the Name of G-d: “Praise the Lord, all you nations; extol Him, all you peoples. For His kindness was mighty over us, and the truth of the Lord is everlasting.”

Psalm 105's verses are a man in irons and then released: “They afflicted his foot with fetters; his soul was placed in irons. Until His word came, the saying of the Lord purified him. A king sent and released him, a ruler of peoples [sent] and loosed his bonds.” And Psalm 89's verse is the crown thrown down: “You abrogated the covenant of Your servant; You profaned his crown to the ground.”

Week 39, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 273 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Bear Is Saying

The bear opens by calling on every place there is, and the week comes in around it.

The wilderness and the wish for a brother first: “Let the wilderness and its cities lift up their voice” / “The village that Kedar inhabits” / “O, that you were like my brother” / “Who sucked my mother’s breasts!” / “And Moses said, 'Eat it today, For today is a Sabbath to the Lord; Today you will not find it in the field.'”

Then the rocks and the islands, and the going home: “Let the inhabitants of the rock sing” / “Let them shout from the peaks of the mountains” / “Let them give glory to G-d and tell of His praise in the islands” / “And Elkanah went to Ramah, to his house” / “I would find you outside, I would kiss you, and they would not despise me.”

Then I am the One, with the six days and the child serving: “See now that it is I! I am the One, And there is no G-d like Me!” / “Six days you shall gather it, But on the seventh day, the Sabbath, on it there will be none” / “And the child was serving the Lord before Eli the priest” / “They afflicted his foot with fetters; His soul was placed in irons” / “You abrogated the covenant of Your servant.”

And the end is the late chariot, the striking and the healing: “Why is his chariot late in coming?” / “Why tarry the strides of his chariots?” / “I cause death and grant life. I strike, but I heal” / “And no one can rescue from My Hand!” / “And I have

consumed them, And I have crushed them that they cannot rise" / "Yes, they are fallen under my feet" / "You profaned his crown to the ground" / "Until His word came, the saying of the Lord purified him" / "A king sent and released him, A ruler of peoples [sent] and loosed his bonds."

Week 39, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XL

Hod of Yesod

Days 274–280

Day 274 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Fight for Truth

The wolf is saying, “For every matter of iniquity, for the ox, the donkey, the lamb, the garment, for every lost item which he says, 'This is it,' the matter of both of them shall come before the judge; he who the judge finds guilty shall pay double to the other.” (Exodus 22:8)

The song belongs to Reuven. As last week, he lost the double portion that was his as firstborn, because of a mistake in moving the bed of one of Jacob’s concubines. And on another occasion, when Jacob refused to let his children take Benjamin to Egypt, Reuven said that if he did not bring Benjamin back himself he would be willing to give up his two sons — which would be a double loss.

The wolf is also the symbol of Benjamin, who is close to this song too: arriving in Egypt, Benjamin is accused of theft by the viceroy, Joseph. And of all Jacob’s children Benjamin is the one most bound to the Land of Israel, because he alone was born there.

The song runs parallel to the conquest of the Land as well. Rashi’s first comment in the Torah explains why the Torah begins with the creation of the world rather than with the first mitzvah, blessing the new moon, given at our departure from Egypt: so that when the nations of the world accuse us of being thieves, claiming we are stealing the land, we can answer that the world and everything in it belongs to G-d, and it is He who decides which land to give to whom.

Forty intensifies the firmness of four. It is also deeply tied to taking in His eternal truth, the Torah: forty days and nights that Moses spent on Mount Sinai to receive it, forty years the Jews wandered in the desert, forty days and nights of the Flood, forty

seah of water for a kosher mikvah. In Pirkei Avot the age of forty is understanding — it takes forty years to truly understand one's master's teaching. A pregnancy is forty weeks, the time in which an angel teaches the fetus the whole Torah. And the spies spent forty days scouting the Land, from Rosh Chodesh Tammuz to Tisha B'Av, this week among them.

The wolf sings the verdict on a thief, and it is known that the Flood only began once people began to steal — and the Flood also served as a mikvah to purify the world.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Eliezer the son of Yaakov: he who fulfills one mitzvah acquires for himself one angel-advocate, and he who commits one transgression acquires against himself one angel-accuser; repentance and good deeds are a shield against retribution. Theft is exactly the transgression that brings an accuser. And the teaching belongs to Tammuz and the tikkun of sight: it matters to look favourably on other people and on what they own, because jealousy is often what leads to theft — and to look at people favourably in order to be a good advocate ourselves. Teshuvah runs through it, which is Reuven.

The combination is hod shebeyesod, glory and gratefulness within foundation and firmness. This week we should be thankful, dedicated and grounded in our moral ways. The lesson from the wolf is that we cannot give in to corruption: we have to stand firm so that justice and truth win out over falsehood.

Week 40, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 275 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Neriah and "Bearing the Burden with One's Friend"

The second week of Tammuz. Haazinu is an oath: "For I raise up My hand to heaven, and say, 'As I live forever.'" (Deuteronomy 32:40) The wolf's song this week also refers to an oath. An oath adds weight and power, and determination and foundation — yesod.

The Haftorah girds for battle again: "For You have girded me with strength for the battle; You have subdued under me those that rose up against me." (II Samuel 22:40) King David's verses have been about being fortified and victorious ever since the week of Lag Ba'omer. Perhaps the repetition is there to say that in conquest it is

often not enough to win once: one has to have yesod, to meet the same situation again and again and come through it without budging.

The quality is bearing the burden with one's friend, noseh b'ol im chaveroh. Not bearing the friend's burden — both are to share the burden together. That yoke might even be the yoke of Torah, which has to be taken up again day after day, an ongoing battle across a whole life. In Tammuz the burden is heavy; through love of our fellow we help each other and repair the root of what brought this on in the first place, which is baseless hatred. The qualities of this week and of every week until Rosh Chodesh Av are about how to act toward one's friend.

The prophet is Neriah, of whom little is known beyond his being the father of Baruch, last week's prophet. He was related to and a contemporary of the other prophets of this month — Baruch, Machseyah, Serayah, and Huldah — who all carried the burden of telling the news of the coming destruction. Neryah means the candle of G-d, and that is what we all are at our essence, one soul.

The levitical city is Jahaz, where Israel destroyed Sihon, king of the Amorites, told in the portion of Chukat, which is always read at this time of year. Yachatz is also mentioned in the Tanach in connection with Moab: it was conquered under Moshe and apparently retaken by Moab later. Which is the idea again that conquering something once is not enough; there has to be ongoing vigilance, a foundation, to keep it. Reuven had that struggle himself — given the firstborn's right and unable to hold it, and after his sin always in a state of Teshuvah. Yachatz also means will apportion, divide, break, like the Yachatz step of the Seder: the matzah is broken to show its brokenness and its standing as the poor man's bread. And Tammuz is tied to poverty — the letter Dalet of Tammuz and the Lamed of Av spell Dal, poor, and connecting them to Elul, with its Tav, spells Delet, door, the gates of repentance.

Week 40, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 276 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Returning to Ourselves

Beshalach: “It came about that on the seventh day, [some] of the people went out to gather [manna], but they did not find [any]. The Lord said to Moses, How long will you refuse to observe My commandments and My teachings?” The stubbornness is the point. As the Rebbe would often repeat, the reason for our suffering is “Mipnei Chata’eynu Galinu Me’Artzeinu,” because of our sins we were exiled from our Land — and the moment we stop and turn around, we are redeemed.

The Haftorah: “The wisest of her princesses answer her, she too returns answers to herself.” The wisest of princesses is the Neshamah, the soul, called a princess because she is the daughter of the King. Despairing over the exile, the soul wakes and brings us to return, to teshuvah. In Tammuz we have to see that it is time to come back to ourselves — our true selves, our Neshamah.

Daf Mem of Sotah keeps on with laws of Birkat Kohanim, the public’s prayer of thanks, and the Kohen Gadol reading the Torah on Yom Kippur, and includes a story about R. Avahu and R. Aba and their humility. The Temple again, and the ways of restoring it: humility and thanks.

The generation is Ahaziah, son of Jehoram, who reigned a very short time and continued his father’s evil ways under his mother’s terrible influence. His counterpart in Israel was Jehoram, with whom he sought a close alliance at her urging. Both were killed by Jehu, anointed king by the Prophet Elisha — and the death of the two of them shows that without repentance there is no hope of salvation. He was apparently named after his maternal uncle, the son of Ahab; his name means one who holds to G-d, and he held fast to idolatry instead.

The journey is from Dibon gad to Almon diblathaimah, which means hidden sweetness. Almon comes from He’elem, concealment, and Diblathaimah from sweetness, specifically deveilah, pressed cake figs. So the name holds a dichotomy, like Tammuz itself: it may be a place of death and mourning, and through teshuvah the month’s concealed sweetness is revealed. The personal journey moves from the good tidings of repentance to the concealed sweetness that repentance uncovers.

Week 40, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 277 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Getting to the Root of the Matter, the Torah

A new verse opens a new part of the story: "Now the sons of Eli were base men; they knew not the LORD." The main way of knowing G-d is through the Torah, and their behaviour shows a real deficit there; their lack of connection to it and respect for it was their downfall.

Pirkei Avot turns to G-d's acquisitions — He acquired five in His world, and the first is the Torah: "G-d acquired me as the beginning of His way, before His works of yore." His way begins with the Torah.

Ecclesiastes 9 holds the same thing, that everything depends on wisdom and righteousness: "For all this I laid to my heart and to clarify all this, that the righteous and the wise and their works are in God's hand; even love, even hate, man does not know; everything is before them."

The week holds the yahrzeits of three relatively recent figures: Rabbi Menachem-Mendel Futerfas on the 4th of Tammuz, 1995; Rabbi Simcha Bunim Alter, the Lev Simcha, fifth Rebbe of Ger, on the 7th, 1992; and Rabbi Yekutiel Yehuda Halberstam, the Klausenberger Rebbe, on the 9th, 1994.

Reb Mendel Futerfas was a near legendary Lubavitcher chasid, even to those who knew him personally. In 1947 he was arrested for running networks of underground yeshivas and Jewish schools, and for helping thousands of Soviet Jews reach Poland after WWII, and sentenced to 8 years in Soviet prisons and labor camps, which he came through without compromising any religious observance despite cruel pressure to do so. After another six years in Siberian exile he was allowed to emigrate to England, thanks to an appeal for family repatriation made by prime minister Harold Wilson at his summit meeting in Moscow with Chairman Nikita Khrushchev. In 1973 he settled in Kfar Chabad for the rest of his life.

Rav Simcha Bunim Alter, also known as the Lev Simcha after the works he wrote, was the fifth Rebbe of Ger, from 1977 until 1992. The Alter mishpacha managed to escape Poland during the Holocaust to Eretz Yisroel. Before becoming Rebbe he was said to have been extremely successful as a businessman, though it is not known in what line. Ger grew greatly in Eretz Yisroel under him; he carried on the family tradition of vigorous leadership of the Agudas Yisroel party in the Knesset, and he

instituted the daily learning of a page of Talmud Yerushalami.

Rabbi Yekutiel Yehuda Halberstam, the Klausenberger Rebbe, also became the post-war Rebbe of the Sanz Chassidim. One of the foremost Chasidic leaders of his generation, he is best known for reviving the study of Talmud through Mifal Shas, and for building a hospital, Laniado in Netanya, which works to the highest standards of Jewish law and medical practice. Also this week: Rabbi Pinchas HaLevi Horowitz, brother of Rabbi Shmuel Shmelke of Nicholsburg and teacher of the Chattam Sofer, and Rabbi Boruch Frankel-Tumim, father-in-law of R' Chaim of Sanz, both on the 7th of Tammuz.

Week 40, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 278 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Upholding our Morality in Exile

The Song's verse names the Temple as a house: "I would lead you, I would bring you to the house of my mother, who instructed me; I would give you to drink some spiced wine, of the juice of my pomegranate." Tammuz is bound to exile and to the destruction of that house. Forty is the gematria of the letter Mem, and next week, 41, is Alef Mem, which spells Em, mother. The verse also names the pomegranate, and this season belongs to the pomegranate in Perek Shirah.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the fortieth is Arodi, whose name seems related to Lered, to descend, which is also exile. And with him Naaman, son of Benjamin, whose name means pleasant, for how Joseph's deeds were seemly and pleasant. Like Joseph, we have to hold to the ways of righteousness even in exile.

Daf Mem of Shvuot describes admission in paying someone back. It belongs with the wolf of this week, who names "the ox, the donkey, the lamb, the garment, for every lost item" — and the daf too takes up all sorts of disputed items, ox and sheep and vessels and land. The focus again is keeping our moral standards in exile.

Jeremiah's fortieth chapter introduces Gedaliah, a righteous leader, through whose righteousness life regains some normalcy despite the great destruction. "And Gedaliah the son of Ahikam the son of Shaphan swore to them and to their men, saying, 'Fear not to serve the Chaldeans. Dwell in the land and serve the king of Babylon, and it will go well with you. And I, behold I dwell in Mizpah to stand

before the Chaldeans who will come to us, and you gather wine and dried figs and oil and put [them] into your vessels and dwell in your cities, which you have taken.'" And they came back: "And all the Jews returned from all the places they had been driven, and they came to the land of Judah to Gedaliah to Mizpah, and they gathered very much wine and dried figs." He was so righteous that he would not believe another leader meant to assassinate him: "Do not do this thing for you speak falsely about Ishmael."

Week 40, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 279 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second Week of Tammuz - Psalms 118-120; 105:21-23; 89:41

The second week of Tammuz in psalms: the hundred and eighteenth, hundred and nineteenth and hundred and twentieth, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 118 is David's immense trust, and praise for what He has already fulfilled. It begins with four voices saying the same thing — Israel, the House of Aaron, those who fear the Lord, each declaring that His kindness is everlasting. Then the distress: "From out of distress I called to G-d; with abounding relief, G-d answered me. The Lord is with me, I do not fear-what can man do to me?" The comparison: "It is better to rely on the Lord than to trust in man. It is better to rely on the Lord than to trust in nobles." The surrounding, three times over: "They surrounded me like bees, yet they shall be extinguished like fiery thorns." Then the living: "I shall not die, but I shall live and recount the deeds of G-d. G-d has indeed chastised me, but He did not give me up to death." Then the gates: "Open for me the gates of righteousness; I will enter them and praise G-d. This is the gate of the Lord, the righteous will enter it." And the lines everyone knows: "The stone which the builders scorned has become the chief cornerstone. From the Lord has this come about; it is wondrous in our eyes. This is the day which the Lord has made; let us be glad and rejoice on it. We implore You, Lord, deliver us. We implore You, Lord, grant us success."

Psalm 119 is the long one, composed in alphabetical sequence with eight verses to each letter, and every verse holds one of the words for an aspect of Torah — way, Torah, testimony, precept, commandment, statement, word, judgment,

righteousness, statute. Replete with morals and prayers, it should be said daily, as a powerful preparation for the service of G-d. Its first line sets the whole: “Fortunate are those whose way is artless, who walk with the Torah of the Lord.” Then, over and over, the asking to be taught and to be kept: “Unveil my eyes, that I may behold wonders from Your Torah.” “I am a sojourner on earth; do not hide Your commandments from me.” “Your statutes have been my songs in the house of my wanderings.” “At midnight, I rise to thank You for Your righteous judgments.” The affliction turned to account: “It is for my good that I was afflicted, so that I might learn Your statutes.” The worth of it: “The Torah of Your mouth is better for me than thousands in gold and silver.” What it is for a man walking: “Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.” “How sweet are Your words to my palate, [sweeter] than honey to my mouth!” “O how I love Your Torah! All day it is my discussion.” What it holds off: “Had Your Torah not been my delight, I would have perished in my affliction.” The peace in it: “There is abundant peace for those who love Your Torah, and there is no stumbling for them.” And the last verse, which does not end in confidence but in asking to be found: “I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek out Your servant, for I have not forgotten Your commandments.”

Psalm 120 rebukes slanderers, and shows how the deadly effect of slander reaches further than weapons. “I have called out to the Lord in my distress, and He answered me. O Lord, rescue my soul from the lips of falsehood, from a deceitful tongue. What can He give you, and what [further restraint] can He add to you, O deceitful tongue? [You resemble] the sharp arrows of a mighty one, and the coals of broom-wood.” And the end, which is a whole position in two lines: “Too long has my soul dwelt among those who hate peace. I am for peace, but when I speak, they are for war.”

Psalm 105's verses are the rise to power and the coming down to Egypt: “He made him the master of his household and the ruler over all his possessions. To bind up his princes with his soul, and he made his elders wise. Israel came to Egypt, and Jacob sojourned in the land of Ham.” And Psalm 89's verse is the breach: “You breached all his fences; You made his fortifications a ruin.”

Week 40, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 280 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Wolf Is Saying

The wolf opens on the breached fences, and the week comes in around it.

The ruin and the disputed goods first: “You breached all his fences” / “You made his fortifications a ruin” / “For every matter of iniquity” / “For the ox, the donkey, the lamb, the garment” / “For every lost item which he says, 'This is it'” / “Some spiced wine, of the juice of my pomegranate.”

Then the going before the judge, and the seventh day: “The matter of both of them shall come before the judge” / “To bind up his princes with his soul” / “It came about that on the seventh day” / “The people went out to gather, but they did not find” / “And he made his elders wise” / “He who the judge finds guilty shall pay double to the other.”

Then the sons of Eli, and the master of the household: “Now the sons of Eli were base men” / “They knew not the Lord” / “He made him the master of his household” / “And the ruler over all his possessions” / “The Lord said to Moses, How long will you refuse” / “To observe My commandments and My teachings?”

And the end is the princess answering herself, the oath, and the house of my mother: “The wisest of her princesses answer her” / “She too returns answers to herself” / “For I raise up My hand to heaven” / “And say, 'As I live forever'” / “Israel came to Egypt and Jacob sojourned in the land of Ham” / “For You have girded me with strength for the battle” / “You have subdued under me those that rose up against me” / “I would lead you, I would bring you to the house of my mother” / “Who instructed me; I would give you to drink.”

Week 40, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XLI

Yesod of Yesod

Days 281–287

Day 281 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

Not to Become Corrupt

The fox is saying, "Woe to him that builds his house without justice and his chambers without lawfulness; that uses his friend's service without wages, and does not give him for his hire." (Jeremiah 22:13) This week, beginning with the fast of the 17th of Tammuz, opens the three weeks of mourning for the destruction of the Temple, the House of G-d — a destruction that came of the injustice and lawlessness of the Jews of that time.

The week also holds the Chassidic holiday of the 12th and 13th of Tammuz, which marks the Sixth Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn's birthday and the day he was freed from prison in Communist Russia. Among Chabad Chassidim it is called Chag HaGeulah, the Festival of Redemption.

The fox is a symbol of the destruction, as the Talmud in Makkot tells. A group of rabbis gathered soon after the Temple fell and saw a fox walk into the place on the Temple Mount where the holiest part had stood. The others wept; Rabbi Akiva saw it in a positive light — which is the month of Tammuz — so much so that he laughed. He explained that the Torah makes the prophecy of Jerusalem's destruction depend on the prophecy of its redemption: now that the first has been fulfilled, the second will be fulfilled too. And explaining his laughter, he was able to truly comfort them.

At Yud Beit-Yud Gimmel Tammuz the Sixth Rebbe took on the whole Soviet empire and won. Despite open defiance, refusal to obey orders, and insisting on not giving up an inch of his religiosity, he was eventually released and his death sentence commuted. Years later the Soviet Union itself, full of injustice and G-dlessness, collapsed along with the Berlin Wall — and the Seventh Rebbe, Menachem Mendel

Schneerson, had predicted that fall many years earlier, when few thought it even possible.

Forty-one spells em, mother. That suits the start of the three weeks, whose second half falls in Av, which means father. In this historically hard stretch it matters to remember that the difficulties He gives us are ultimately for our good, as a father and a mother sometimes have to be strict with a child. In Judaism the mother is the akeret habayit, the anchor of the house, responsible for its values and its atmosphere — and the upkeep and the moral atmosphere of the Temple, G-d's house, was mainly the responsibility of the kohanim. Much of their extremely holy service paralleled housework: the daily sacrifices, the lighting of the Menorah, the upkeep of the building were close to cooking, cleaning and lighting candles for Shabat. By the time of the Second Temple the priestly class had become enormously corrupt — even the position of High Priest was open for sale to the highest bidder — and the Temple could not stand, in great part because of that.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yochanan HaSandlar: every gathering that is for the sake of Heaven will endure, and one that is not for the sake of Heaven will not. Which is the same thing: not becoming corrupt or divided out of selfish motives. The firmness of a community comes from rock-solid commitment to our principles and the desire to do His will, and the best example is the Sixth Rebbe himself, whose work kept Judaism alive through intense Communist oppression. Where we do not follow His word, the whole community suffers and our structures do not stand, as at the destruction of the Temple.

The combination is yesod shebeyesod: absolute firmness in our Jewish values. The lesson from the fox is not to let ourselves be dragged down by dishonesty and the thought of immediate gain. Walking in the path of Torah, we will be more solid and more secure.

Week 41, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 282 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Judgement followed by Teshuvah

The week of the 12th and 13th of Tammuz, and of the 17th. Haazinu sharpens: "When I sharpen the blade of My sword, and My hand grasps judgment, I will bring vengeance upon My adversaries and repay those who hate Me." (Deuteronomy 32:41) The Haftorah holds the same: "And of my enemies You have given me the back of their necks; them that hate me, that I may cut them off." (II Samuel 22:41) Judgment and Divine wrath are central to the 17th of Tammuz.

The quality is judging him favorably, Machrioh Lechaf Zechut, which belongs to the repair of sight. The phrase literally means tips him to the side of merit. Rebbe Nachman teaches that focusing on someone else's good points actually tips the person to that side. Maimonedes puts the principle more broadly, in the context of Teshuvah, which this month needs: throughout the entire year a person should look at himself as equally balanced between merit and sin, and the world as equally balanced; if he performs one sin he tips his own balance and the world's to the side of guilt and brings destruction upon himself, and if he performs one mitzvah he tips his own and the world's to the side of merit and brings deliverance and salvation to himself and others. As last week, the action is not only about the friend: the person puts himself in the balance, and by acting justly tips his friend's balance too.

The prophet is Seraiah, Baruch's brother, who went into exile with Zedekiah the King of Judah. Like Baruch, Jeremiah gave him dire prophecies to read to the king — only this time the harsh words were against Babylon itself. So the king and the people were being judged favourably, since the prophecy assured that their suffering would one day end and be avenged.

The levitical city is Kedemoth. The desert of Kedemoth was where Moshe sent messengers to Sihon, king of Heshbon, with words of peace; after Sihon refused, it was at Kedemoth that he was miraculously defeated. His refusal came out of deep Sinat Chinam, gratuitous hatred, which is what destroyed the Temple these days commemorate. Kedemoth is from Kedem, days of yore, often used of the Garden of Eden and the pristine state humanity once had — and in this month we begin our Teshuvah and try to reach back to it.

Week 41, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 283 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Standing One's Ground

Beshalach: "See that the Lord has given you the Sabbath. Therefore, on the sixth day, He gives you bread for two days. Let each man remain in his place; let no man leave his place on the seventh day. So the people rested on the seventh day." The weight falls on staying still, not leaving one's place. In a way it is the reverse of the 17th of Tammuz, when the Jews, running out of food, had no choice but to stay where they were — and then, when the walls were breached, were forced to surrender and were led into exile, unable to stay in place even on the Sabbath. And the message of Yud Beit/Yud Gimmel Tammuz has its own parallel: for all the oppression he suffered in prison, the Sixth Rebbe stood his ground and remained in his spiritual place.

The Haftorah has the enemy counting his winnings: "'Are they not finding (and) dividing the spoils? A damsel, two damsels to every man.'" Which is what happened when the walls were breached. The word used for women, Rechem, is related to womb and to mercy, and brings to mind the verse of Lamentations: "The hands of compassionate women boiled their own children." And 41 is the gematria of em, mother.

Daf Mem Alef of Sotah gives laws of the Torah reading on Yom Kippur and how the King reads the Torah in the Temple — the Temple again — and then the trait of flattery. Flattery causes corruption and leads to destruction: from the day that flattery became rampant, judgments became distorted, deeds became spoiled, and no one can say "My deeds are better than yours." The destruction itself is tied to flattery: we learn from Yirmeyahu, who supported Chananyah's false prophecy, and Chananyah's grandson later seized Yirmeyahu and handed him to the Babylonian officials. The Rebbe Rayatz on the 12th of Tammuz is the opposite of flattery — he spoke his mind about the evil of the Soviet empire, endured torture, and did not move.

The generation is Athaliah, who took the kingdom after her son Ahaziah's death; her counterpart in Israel was Yehu. Her reign was absolute terror, and her hatred after her own son's death drove her to try to destroy the whole House of David. She managed to kill every descendant of King David but one, Jehoash, who miraculously survived. Her story shows how cruel and ruthless a mother, who is naturally merciful,

can be, and how distorted and corrupt Israel had become — and a mother's mercy appears in it too, in the saving of Jehoash. The corruption parallels the 17th of Tammuz, and the hope in Jehoash parallels how the Rebbe Rayatz was saved out of the embers and the Chabad dynasty was able to go on. And Athaliah did enormous damage to the Temple, damage which Jehoash would repair.

The journey is from Almon diblathaimah to the mountains of Abarim, in front of Nebo. As in week 38, Abarim comes from aveirah, transgression — and now instead of the ruins of Abarim it is the mountain of Abarim, which is the height teshuvah reaches. The Temple itself is also called a mountain. Nebo is nun boh, the fiftieth gate Moshe reaches at his passing; that gate is beyond nature, and belongs to teshuvah, where G-d lifts us out of our sins in a way nature does not allow. The personal journey moves from the sweetness repentance uncovers to the supernatural heights it can reach.

Week 41, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 284 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Not Corrupting G-d's World

The verse is the priests' due: "And this was the due of the priests from the people: (whenever) any man would slaughter a sacrifice, the servant of the priest would come when (one) cooked the flesh, with a three-pronged fork in his hand." The sons of Eli had set up a rule by which anyone bringing a sacrifice had to give them an extra portion, more than Torah law allots. It was a Hillul Hashem, a desecration of His name, and it lowered the Mishkan in the eyes of the people. The seventeenth of Tammuz is largely about the corruption of the Jewish people of that time, the Temple's priests in particular, which brought it down.

This week's acquisition in Pirkei Avot is the heavens and the earth: "So says G-d: The heavens are My throne and the earth is My footstool; what house, then, can you build for Me, and where is My place of rest?" And: "How many are your works, O G-d, You have made them all with wisdom; the earth is filled with Your acquisitions." The verses name the Temple and the limits of it as His house — and against the account above, the point is sharp: since everything is His, and the Temple is His house, how dare the sons of Eli take more for themselves of what plainly

belongs to the Master and Owner of all heaven and earth.

Ecclesiastes 10 has a passage on the same centrality, and on not abusing what is in it. "Woe to you, O land whose king is a lad, and your princes eat in the morning. Fortunate are you, O land, whose king is the son of nobles, and your princes eat at the proper time, in might and not in drinking. Through laziness the rafter sinks, and with idleness of the hands the house leaks." And the last verse, which is watched: "Even in your thought, you shall not curse a king, nor in your bedrooms shall you curse a wealthy man, for the bird of the heaven shall carry the voice, and the winged creature will tell the matter." Rashi: the bird of the heaven is the soul, placed within you, which will ultimately fly up to the heaven.

The week holds the yahrzeits of Rebbe Tzvi-Hirsh Eichenstein, first rebbe of Zhidachov, on the 11th of Tammuz, and Rabbi Chaim Ibn Atar, the Ohr HaChaim, on the 15th. Rebbe Tzvi-Hirsh, founder of the Zhidachov dynasty, was a prominent disciple of the Seer of Lublin, and championed the position that the practice of Chasidism had to rest firmly on the study of the Kabbala of the holy Ari of Safed. He wrote and published numerous commentaries on Kabbala, including Ateret Tzvi on the Zohar, and several on the weekly readings; the Malbim was a student of his, and he was succeeded by three nephew-disciples, among them Yitzhak-Isaac of Zhidachov and Yitzhak-Isaac-Yehuda-Yechiel of Komarno. Rabbi Chaim Ibn Atar is best known as the author of one of the most important and popular commentaries on the Torah, the Ohr HaChaim; he established a major yeshiva in Israel after moving there from Morocco. Chassidic tradition holds that the main reason the Baal Shem Tov twice tried so hard, and failed, to reach the Holy Land was that he said if he could join the Ohr HaChaim there, together they could bring Moshiach. His burial site outside the Old City of Jerusalem, on the Mount of Olives, is considered a propitious place to pray. Also this week: Rabbi Elazar of Reishe on the 15th of Tammuz, Rabbi Avrohom Yehoshua Heschel of Kopischnitz on the 16th, and Rabbi Shmuel Yaacov Weinberg on the 17th.

Week 41, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 285 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

G-d's Right and Left "Hands"

The Song's verse is one line and it is held in both arms: "His left hand would be under my head, and his right hand would embrace me." It is often quoted in the Tanya and in Chassidic and Kabbalistic sources. At the same time that His left hand, which is gevurah, discipline, is under our heads, His right hand, Chesed, kindness, is around us. He held us through our exiles, and He held the Sixth Rebbe through what he faced.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the forty-first is Areli, whose name holds the same letters as Ariel, the Lion of G-d, one of the names of the Temple. And with him Ehi, son of Benjamin, whose name means my brother, Achi, for Joseph being Benjamin's brother. Brotherly love is what will rebuild the Temple.

Daf Mem Alef of Shvuot keeps on with the repayment of loans and whether it has to be done in front of witnesses, and then the difference between an oath that is d'rabbanan and one that is d'oraisa, and how a d'rabbanan oath can be reversed though payment is taken by other means. Which belongs to the 17th of Tammuz, when payment is taken for our spiritual debts.

Jeremiah's forty-first chapter is the murder of Gedaliah — for which we still fast, as for the 17th of Tammuz — and the divisions inside the Jewish people that kept the suffering going. "And Ishmael the son of Nethaniah and the ten men who were with him arose and smote Gedaliah the son of Ahikam the son of Shaphan, with the sword, and he slew him, whom the king of Babylon had appointed in the land, and all the Jews who were with him." Then the pilgrims: "men came from Shechem, from Shiloh, and from Samaria, eighty men, with shaven beards and rent garments and having cut themselves, with a meal-offering and frankincense in their hand[s], to bring to the house of the Lord." And Ishmael came out to meet them weeping, and said, "Come to Gedaliah the son of Ahikam" — and killed them in the city. Ten of them were spared for saying they had stores in the field, wheat and barley and oil and honey. And the pit he filled with the bodies was the one King Asa had made because of Baasa, king of Israel.

Week 41, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 286 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Tammuz - Psalms 121-123; 105:24-26; 89:42

The third week of Tammuz in psalms: the hundred and twenty-first, hundred and twenty-second and hundred and twenty-third, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89. All three are songs of ascents, and all three are short.

Psalm 121 alludes to the Lower Paradise, from which one ascends to the Higher, and speaks of how He watches over us. “I lift my eyes to the mountains-from where will my help come? My help will come from the Lord, Maker of heaven and earth. He will not let your foot falter; your guardian does not slumber. Indeed, the Guardian of Israel neither slumbers nor sleeps.” And the last line covers everything: “The Lord will guard your going and your coming from now and for all time.”

Psalm 122 sings the praises of Jerusalem and the miracles that happened there. “I rejoiced when they said to me, 'Let us go to the House of the Lord.' Our feet were standing within your gates, O Jerusalem; Jerusalem that is built like a city in which [all Israel] is united together.” What stood there: “For there stood the seats of justice, the thrones of the house of David.” And the asking, which is the line this week needs: “Pray for the peace of Jerusalem; may those who love you have peace. May there be peace within your walls, serenity within your mansions. For the sake of my brethren and friends, I ask that there be peace within you.”

Psalm 123 laments how long the exile has already run. “To You have I lifted my eyes, You Who are enthroned in heaven. Indeed, as the eyes of servants are turned to the hand of their masters, as the eyes of a maid to the hand of her mistress, so are our eyes turned to the Lord our G-d, until He will be gracious to us.” And then: “Be gracious to us, Lord, be gracious to us, for we have been surfeited with humiliation. Our soul has been overfilled with the derision of the complacent, with the scorn of the arrogant.”

Psalm 105's verses are the growing of the people and the turn against them: “And He made His people very fruitful, and He made it stronger than its adversaries. He turned their heart to hate His people, to plot against His servants. He sent Moses His servant, [and] Aaron whom He chose.” And Psalm 89's verse is the plundering: “All wayfarers have plundered him; he was a disgrace to his neighbors.”

Week 41, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 287 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Fox Is Saying

The fox opens on the sharpened sword, and the week sets a house built without justice beside it.

The sword and the house first: “When I sharpen the blade of My sword” / “And My hand grasps judgment” / “Woe to him that builds his house without justice” / “And his chambers without lawfulness” / “When (one) cooked the flesh, With a three-pronged fork in his hand.”

Then the spoils divided, and the bread for two days: “Are they not finding (and) dividing the spoils” / “A damsel, two damsels to every man” / “He gives you bread for two days” / “Let each man remain in his place” / “The servant of the priest would come” / “[And] Aaron whom He chose” / “And this was the due of the priests from the people” / “(Whenever) any man would slaughter a sacrifice.”

Then the unpaid wages, and the vengeance: “That uses his friend’s service without wages” / “And does not give him for his hire” / “I will bring vengeance upon My adversaries” / “And repay those who hate Me” / “Them that hate me, that I may cut them off” / “And of my enemies You have given me the back of their necks.”

Then the plundering, and the hearts turned: “All wayfarers have plundered him” / “He was a disgrace to his neighbors” / “He turned their heart to hate His people” / “To plot against His servants.”

And the end is the Sabbath and the two hands: “See that the Lord has given you the Sabbath” / “Therefore, on the sixth day” / “He sent Moses His servant” / “His left hand would be under my head, And his right hand would embrace me” / “Let no man leave his place on the seventh day” / “So the people rested on the seventh day” / “And He made His people very fruitful” / “And He made it stronger than its adversaries.”

Week 41, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XLII

Malchut of Yesod

Days 288–294

Day 288 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Be Loyal and Pursue Justice

The hound is saying, "Let the righteous rejoice in G-d; praise is befitting to the straight." (Psalms 33:1) We are in the middle of the three weeks of mourning.

The hound stands for uprightness, and it often hunts last week's animal, the fox, who stands for corruption and injustice. It is also the standing example of loyalty. In this period, for all our outward mourning, we also come to see that after so many centuries of exile and so many tragedies the Jewish people, like the hound, has kept its loyalty and faith in G-d — and that G-d has kept His faith in us. That loyalty on both sides is worth recognising and praising.

The Talmud ties the verse to the Temple as well. The word for befitting, na'avah, can be read naveh, habitation, pointing to how the enemies of the Jewish people had no power over the parts of the Temple that King David and Moses had built. And it matters to remember that the world has no power over the holy habitation inside each one of us.

Released from prison, the Previous Rebbe was sent into exile by the Soviet regime. At the Leningrad train station Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn parted with these words, quoting his father: this all the nations of the world must know, that only our bodies were sent into exile and subjugated to alien rule; our souls were not given over into captivity and foreign rule. In any matter affecting the Jewish religion, the Torah, and its mitzvot and customs, we are not subject to the dictates of any power.

Forty-two is the number of journeys in the desert. Through them He tested His people several times and we kept our loyalty and proved worthy of His love; the

people also tested Him several times, and He did not give up hope in them. Forty-two is mem and beit, which spell bam, in them. The Ba'al Shem Tov teaches that the words "vedibarta bam" in the Shemah point to the forty-two personal journeys each person makes in a life, parallel to the forty-two in the desert.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Eliezer the son of Shamua: the dignity of your student should be as precious to you as your own, the dignity of your colleague as your awe of your master, and your awe of your master as your awe of Heaven. Which is Tammuz again, and the ability to look deeper and see the value and the potential in each person, student or colleague or teacher. And the hound is itself a perfect example: its devotion to its master is like what is due to G-d.

Completing the cycle of yesod, the combination is malchut shebeyesod. This week we hold a solid foundation in our Judaism and use it to influence the world around us. The lesson from the hound is that as it sings of being upright and pursues the fox, we have to pursue justice at all costs: "Tzedek Tzedek Tirdof," justice, justice you shall pursue.

Week 42, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 289 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Mehsiah and Being Placed in the Path of Truth

The last week of Tammuz. Haazinu: "I will intoxicate My arrows with blood, and My sword will consume flesh, from the blood of the slain and the captives, from the first breach of the enemy." (Deuteronomy 32:42) The Haftorah holds the same theme: "They looked about, but there was no one to save them; [Even] to the Lord, but He answered them not." (II Samuel 22:42) And in the future this month's fortunes will be reversed for the good.

The quality is placing him in the path of truth, Ma'amidoh Al Ha'Emet. The verb does not mean place but raise — the same verb as in the opening of Pirkei Avot, where the Men of the Great Assembly advise raising up many students. Raise, because students have to be able to stand on their own two feet, and truth is by definition the foundation a person needs to stand on. The letters of emet say it too: each one has a stable base and can stand on its own, while the three letters of sheker, falsehood, cannot — they are unstable and they fall. Which is the fox of last week,

woe to him that builds his house without justice; and this week the hound, praise is befitting to the upright.

The prophet is Mehsiah, grandfather of Baruch and Seriah. His name appears in two chapters of the Book of Jeremiah, and in both the punishment named is ultimately what is needed to set the Jewish people on a path of truth and goodness.

The levitical city is Mepha'ath, also one of the cities named in the prophecy against Moab. The word means to shine. This month is about working on our sense of sight, and as we refine ourselves and look at things the right way, we can see beauty shine out, in others and in ourselves.

Week 42, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 290 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Remembering to Repent in the Face of Destruction

Beshalach describes the manna and then has it kept: "The house of Israel named it manna, and it was like coriander seed, [it was] white, and it tasted like a wafer with honey. Moses said, This is the thing that the Lord commanded: Let one omerful of it be preserved for your generations, in order that they see the bread that I fed you in the desert when I took you out of the land of Egypt." It came in different forms — a seed, a dough, a finished bread — according to a person's spiritual standing, so that for anyone not fully righteous the manna was itself a call to repent. And Rashi explains that the omerful was kept specifically for the times of Jeremiah and the destruction of the Temple.

The Haftorah divides the spoils: "a spoil of dyed garments to Sisera, a spoil of dyed garments of embroidery." When the walls were breached and the Temple destroyed, the enemy took its spoils — and dyed garments recall the clothes the Kohen Gadol wore in the Temple.

Daf Mem Beit of Sotah finishes with flattery and opens a new chapter on the Mashuach Milchamah, the Kohen anointed for war. Mashuach shares a root with Mashiach. The daf tells how that Kohen says to the people that this war is not against their brethren, and that if they are taken captive the enemy will show no mercy — as it was at the destruction. And these three weeks belong to Mashiach too, since the birth of Mashiach takes place on Tisha B'Av.

The generation is Jehoash, who replaced Athaliah once she was removed and killed, and who was still a boy. He was tutored and counselled by the righteous Kohen Yehoiadah; his counterparts in Israel were Yehu and Jehoahaz. While Yehoiadah lived he served G-d faithfully, and after Yehoiadah died he turned to idols. Yehoiadah's son, the prophet Zachariah, condemned him, and Jehoash had him killed in the Temple — stoned to death on Yom Kippur itself. That blood was not forgiven. He was severely punished, with the Syrians overrunning and sacking most of the country; and when the Temple fell the matter came up again. Our Sages say that when Nebuzaradan entered the Temple he found the blood of Zechariah seething, and asked the Jews what it meant; they tried to conceal the scandal, and he threatened to comb their flesh with iron combs, so they told him: there was a prophet among us who chastised us, and we killed him, and for many years now his blood has not rested. Nebuzaradan said, I will appease him. He killed the members of the Great and Small Sanhedrins, then youths and maidens, then school-children, 940,000 people in all. Still the blood boiled, until he cried, "Zechariah, Zechariah! I have slain the best of them; do you want all of them destroyed?" And at last the blood sank into the ground. So Jehoash holds both sides of Jewish behaviour toward the Temple: in his early years exemplary piousness, and repairs to the building; in his later years, bad influences and such disrespect that his acts were a significant factor in its destruction. His name apparently means fire of G-d — and fire can be used either way.

The journey is from the mountains of Abarim to the plains of Moab by the Jordan at Jericho, camping along the Jordan from Beth jeshimoth to Abel shittim. Arvot Moav has a double meaning, as Rabbi Jacobson explains: Arvot comes from erev, night, and from arev, mixture or confusion, and marks the most difficult part of the forty-two-part journey — and the 42nd week of the year is often a difficult one, part of the three weeks. And arev also means sweet, and teshuvah can turn these harsh days sweet. He reads Jordan-Jericho, Yarden Yerichoh, as a reference to Mashiach, whose birth is near, on the ninth of Av. Crossing the Jordan is finally leaving the wandering and entering the Land — and so leaving the more spiritual existence of the desert and engaging fully with the physical world. That is also the sense of Beth Yeshimoth, from yeshimon, wasteland, and of Abel Shitim, which he translates as desolate plains, based on the Ramban. Abel Shitim also means mourning for follies,

like the mourning of this season: the folly of impurity, since the Talmud in Sotah says a person does not sin unless a spirit of folly enters him. And the Rebbe Rayatz explains that there is also a positive spirit of folly, Shtus d'Kedushah, a folly of holiness, whose work will bring a mourning of the yetzer harah, which will then be gone from the world for good. All of it depends on Arvoth Moav, turning the darkness of Av into light. The personal journey moves from the heights teshuvah reaches to engaging the physical world, conquering the Land, and lifting it through holy folly and through the spark of Mashiach each of us holds.

Week 42, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 291 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

The Importance of Giving (not Taking By Force)

The verse goes further into what the sons of Eli took: "And he would thrust into the fire-pot, or into the pot, or into the cauldron, or into the pan, everything which the fork would pick up, the priest would take therewith; so would they do to all Israel who came there in Shiloh." A disproportionate part of every person's sacrifice, taken — which runs against the Torah, that is above all about love and about giving. The main reason the Second Temple was destroyed was Sinat Chinam, gratuitous hatred, caused by acts like these.

Pirkei Avot's acquisition this week is Abraham: "And he blessed him, and said: Blessed be Abram to G-d Most High, acquirer of heavens and earth." Abraham's whole essence was giving and love — and that verse comes immediately before he gives a tenth of everything he has to Malchitzedek, a priest. He gave to the priest of his own will, where the sons of Eli took by force, and took more than was theirs.

Ecclesiastes 11 opens on the same thing: "Send forth your bread upon the surface of the water, for after many days you will find it. Give a portion to seven and even to eight, for you do not know what evil will be on the earth." Rashi reads it: do goodness and kindness to a person about whom your heart tells you that you will never see him again, like one who casts his food upon the surface of the water — and days will yet come, and you will receive your recompense. Note what is said about Jethro: "Call him that he should eat bread," and he thought Moses was an Egyptian whom he would never see again; and in the end he became his son-in-law and brought him

under the wings of the Shechinah, and his sons and grandsons merited to sit in the Chamber of Hewn Stone. And: if you have shared your food and drink with seven who need kindness, share further with eight who come after them, and do not say, "Enough" — because days may yet come when you need them all, and then you will be saved from the evil by this charity; and if not now, when?

The week holds the yahrzeits of three important figures in Chassidism and Kabbalah: Rabbi Avraham Mattisyahu Fridman of Shtefanesht on the 21st of Tammuz, Rabbi Shlomo of Karlin on the 22nd, and Rabbi Moshe Kordevero on the 23rd. Rabbi Avraham Mattisyahu, in Romania, was the grandson of the holy Rabbi Yisroel of Rhzhin, and succeeded his father, Rabbi Menachem Nochum, as the second Rebbe of the dynasty in 1869. Famed for miraculous powers and with thousands of followers, he was also considered one of the true hidden tzadikim of his generation; in 1969 his remains — which witnesses alive today testify were still as whole and fresh as the day he died — were moved from Romania to Nachlas Yitzchok in Tel Aviv, where his grave is still a holy site of prayer for thousands. R. Shlomo of Karlin was a student of the Maggid and of Reb Aharon the Great of Karlin, whom he succeeded in 1772; most of the Chassidic leaders of the next generation in the Lithuanian region were his disciples. He died Kiddush HaShem, stabbed by a Cossack in the middle of the Amida prayer. Rabbi Moshe Kordevero, known by the acronym of his name, Ramak, was considered the head of the Tsfat Kabbalists until his death shortly after Rabbi Yitzchak Luria arrived; he wrote many major works of Kabbalah, among them Pardes Rimonim, Orchard of Pomegranates, in which he systematised all the kabbalistic knowledge revealed until then.

Week 42, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 292 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Faithfulness in Exile

The Song's verse tells the others to leave it alone: "I adjure you, O daughters of Jerusalem; why should you awaken, and why should you arouse the love until it is desirous?" The Jewish people adjuring the nations not to interfere in its relationship with G-d. Which is the hound: the people keeping their loyalty through the difficulties of exile, and G-d keeping His faithfulness to us. Rashi puts it that way too: now the congregation of Israel addresses the nations — even though I complain and lament, my Beloved holds on to my hand, and He is my support in my exile; therefore, I adjure you.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the forty-second is Asher, which means happy. And with him Rosh, son of Benjamin, whose name means head, for Joseph being Benjamin's superior. When Mashiach comes and the Temple is rebuilt, this week will be a happy one, in which we feel like a head and not a tail. Asher and Rosh hold the same letters, Reish and Shin, in reverse — and with the slightest change those letters spell Rash, poor, which these weeks tend to be.

Daf Mem Beit of Shevuoth keeps on with the repayment of loans, and takes up one who is established as a liar, questionable documents, and other breaches of trust. Which belongs to the 17th of Tammuz, when payment is exacted for our spiritual debts.

Jeremiah's forty-second chapter is faithfulness, and His help in exile. "And they said to Jeremiah, 'May the Lord be a true and faithful witness against us if we do not do according to the entire matter that the Lord your God shall send you to us. Whether good or bad, we will hearken to the voice of the Lord our God.'" And the answer: "If you dwell in this land, I will build you up and I will not pluck you up, for I have repented of the evil that I have done to you. Fear not the king of Babylon whom you fear; fear it not, says the Lord, for I am with you to redeem you and to save you from his hand."

Week 42, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 293 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Last Week of Tammuz - Psalms 124-126; 105:27-29; 89:43

The last week of Tammuz in psalms: the hundred and twenty-fourth, hundred and twenty-fifth and hundred and twenty-sixth, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89. Three more songs of ascents, all short.

Psalm 124 is what would have happened otherwise. “Were it not for the Lord Who was with us-let Israel declare- were it not for the Lord Who was with us when men rose up against us, then they would have swallowed us alive in their burning rage against us. Then the waters would have inundated us, the torrent would have swept over our soul.” And then the escape: “Our soul is like a bird which has escaped from the fowler’s snare; the snare broke and we escaped. Our help is in the Name of the Lord, the Maker of heaven and earth.”

Psalm 125 is what holds. “Those who trust in the Lord are as Mount Zion which never falters, but abides forever. Mountains surround Jerusalem, and the Lord surrounds His people from this time and forever.” And why that matters: “For the rod of wickedness will never come to rest upon the lot of the righteous; therefore the righteous need not stretch their hand to iniquity.” It ends in three words: “Peace be upon Israel.”

Psalm 126 speaks of the future, comparing our service in exile to a man who sows arid land and then cries and begs for rain so the seed is not wasted, and who gives thanks when he merits to reap. “When the Lord will return the exiles of Zion, we will have been like dreamers. Then our mouth will be filled with laughter, and our tongue with songs of joy; then will they say among the nations, 'The Lord has done great things for these.'” And the last two verses, which are the whole of it: “Those who sow in tears will reap with songs of joy. He goes along weeping, carrying the bag of seed; he will surely return with songs of joy, carrying his sheaves.”

Psalm 105's verses are the signs and the first plagues: “They placed upon them the words of His signs and His miracles in the land of Ham. He sent darkness and it darkened, and they did not disobey His word. He turned their water into blood, and it killed their fish.” And Psalm 89's verse is the enemy raised up: “You raised the right hand of his adversaries; You caused all his enemies to rejoice.”

Week 42, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 294 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Hound Is Saying

The hound opens, and the week sets rejoicing against the plunder of a Temple.

The rejoicing and the adjuring first: “Let the righteous rejoice in G-d” / “I adjure you, O daughters of Jerusalem” / “Why should you awaken, and why should you arouse the love until it is desirous?” / “And he would thrust into the fire-pot” / “Or into the pot, or into the cauldron, or into the pan” / “They looked about, but there was no one to save them” / “[Even] to the Lord, but He answered them not.”

Then what the fork picked up, and the arrows: “Everything which the fork would pick up” / “The priest would take therewith” / “I will intoxicate My arrows with blood” / “And My sword will consume flesh” / “He turned their water into blood” / “And it killed their fish.”

Then the dyed garments, and what was done to all Israel: “A spoil of dyed garments to Sisera” / “A spoil of dyed garments of embroidery” / “So would they do to all Israel” / “Who came there in Shiloh” / “From the blood of the slain and the captives” / “From the first breach of the enemy” / “You raised the right hand of his adversaries” / “You caused all his enemies to rejoice” / “He sent darkness and it darkened, And they did not disobey His word.”

And the end is the omerful kept, and the taste of it: “In order that they see the bread that I fed you” / “In the desert when I took you out of the land of Egypt” / “They placed upon them the words of His signs” / “Let one omerful of it be preserved for your generations” / “And His miracles in the land of Ham” / “Moses said, 'This is the thing that the Lord commanded'” / “The House of Israel named it manna” / “Praise is befitting to the straight” / “And it was like coriander seed” / “White, and it tasted like a wafer with honey.”

Week 42, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XLIII

Chesed of Malchut

Days 295–301

Day 295 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Pursue the Enemy and to Pursue Peace

The Cat is saying, "If you rise up like a vulture, and place your nest among the stars, from there I shall bring you down, says G-d." (Obadiah 1:4) And when it catches the mouse, the cat says, "I have pursued my enemies and overtaken them, and I did not return until they were destroyed." (Psalms 18:38) This is the week of Rosh Chodesh Av, and we begin the Nine Days leading to Tisha b'Av, a mourning more intense, and with greater hardships, than the rest of the Three Weeks.

A cat is a miniature lion. In this month we all have the potential to be lions; Mashiach will be born in Av and will reign on earth like a lion. Rosh Chodesh Av is the yahrzeit of Aaron, one of the few yahrzeit dates named explicitly in the Torah, and Aaron was known for his incessant pursuit of peace. The month's sign is Leo, and the Midrash Yalkut Shimoni quoted in week 38 shows how plainly Av belongs to the lion.

The month belongs to the tribe of Shimon, known for severe judgment, and it is the tikkun of the sense of hearing: Shimon comes from Shmiah, hearing, and the month repairs the sin of listening to the report of the spies. It was in Av that the spies came back and described the Land, and instead of holding to Kalev and Joshua's good report the people took up the bad report of the other ten and wept bitterly. Our sages teach that because they cried for no reason, He gave them a reason to cry for generations: that night was Tisha B'Av, the day both Temples were destroyed.

The cat and the mouse can be read at least two ways. Through history the Jews have played the mouse, prey to our enemies inside the nations we were exiled among; for roughly the past two thousand years we have been in the exile of Esau and Edom.

In messianic times the roles reverse, and we will be the ones pursuing, specifically Amalek, a descendant of Esau, who stands for the height of immorality and G-dlessness. The cat's song comes from the prophet Obadiah, a convert from the nation of Edom, whose whole prophecy is directed against it — and Edom is Rome and its descendants, which destroyed the Second Temple. The prophet says that one day Edom will be punished for what it did.

Forty-three is gimmel and mem, which look toward the war of Gog uMagog, whose root letters they are. By tradition that will be the last war before the coming of Mashiach, and is believed to involve the descendants of Esau and Yishmael. Mem and gimmel also spell gam, also — a word that stands out in the Psalm most tied to Aaron, whose yahrzeit is this week: "Hineh Mah Tov uMah Naim Shevet Achim Gam Yachad," behold how good and how pleasant it is for brothers also to dwell together, as the good oil on the head runs down upon the beard, the beard of Aaron. Rav Ovadia Yosef asks why gam is there at all, since it seems superfluous, and explains that when brothers sit together family problems usually come to the surface — and that also is for the good: we should sit together despite them, and do our best to solve them. Like the cat, Aaron also pursued enemies, and only in order to make peace between them and bring them nearer the Torah. As Hillel says in Pirkei Avot, be of the disciples of Aaron, loving peace and pursuing peace, loving your fellow creatures and bringing them closer to Torah. That is how the negative forces of this month are turned. The Temple was destroyed through Sinat Chinam, baseless hatred, and will be rebuilt through Ahavat Chinam, baseless love.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yehudah: be careful with your studies, for an error of learning is tantamount to a willful transgression. It is well known that the First Temple fell because Torah study was not given its weight. And Rabbi Yehudah is a perfect example of peace being possible between Jacob and Esau, the Jewish people and the Romans. He once met a Roman stranger who had just survived a shipwreck as its only survivor, and without knowing who he was gave him his own clothes. The man turned out to be a powerful Roman legislator, and because of that kindness he annulled all the harsh decrees that were about to be imposed on the Jewish people.

The week also holds Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai: there are three crowns — the crown of Torah, the crown of priesthood and the crown of sovereignty — but the crown of a good name surmounts them all. All three belong to the figures of this

month: Aharon HaKohen the priesthood, Mashiach the kingship, and Rabbi Shimon himself the Torah. It is fascinating that his words sit beside Rabbi Yehudah's, since unlike him Rabbi Shimon did not get on with the Romans. When Rabbi Yehudah once praised them for building bridges, Rabbi Shimon said he should not, because everything they do is for their own benefit; the emperor heard of it, and Rabbi Yehudah was given a high position while Rabbi Shimon had to flee, and famously spent the next 12 years in a cave with his son, Rabbi Elazar. There is a tradition that he descends from the tribe of Shimon, this month's tribe, and his own life is a transition and a tikkun of Shimon's strict justice. In the cave he and his son were concerned with pure spirituality; coming out, he could not understand how people spent so much time on material concerns, to the point that everything they looked at was consumed by fire, and he was sent back for another year. The second time he came out he understood the value of being involved with the material world. His sayings in Pirkei Avot seem to follow that: the earlier ones insist on Torah above material things, and these later ones include qualities other than Torah. They also seem to complete his saying in week 16, where he mentions three without saying three of what; here he says there are three crowns. Both sayings begin with the word shloshah, three, and the number most associated with him is thirty-three, since Lag Ba'Omer is the 33rd day of the omer. So the earlier saying can be read: a person with all three crowns on his table — Torah, priesthood, kingship — should be praised and seen as a true example, which is the crown of a Good Name. And there is a well-known story in which Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai gave an interpretation of "Hineh Mah Tov" and ended a drought — again, having understood the need for material concerns too.

The combination is chesed shebemalchut, kindness within kingship. Like Rabbi Yehudah, we try to do good deeds that land directly in this material world. And the lesson from the cat is that as it chases the mouse, we should be like Aaron and pursue the people around us in a friendly way, to bring them closer to unity, love, peace and truth.

Week 43, Book 1 — the whole entry

Rosh Chodesh Av. Av belongs to Shimon, and Rosh Chodesh itself is the yahrzeit of Aharon the Kohen. It is the month of Tisha B'Av, which marks the destruction of both Temples and is also the day the Messiah is born.

Haazinu keeps to retribution and turns to praise: "Sing out praise, O you nations, for His people! For He will avenge the blood of His servants, inflict revenge upon His adversaries, and appease His land [and] His people." (Deuteronomy 32:43) The Haftorah stays with it, and with the physical Land: "Then I ground them as the dust of the earth, as the mud of the streets I did tread upon them, I did stamp them down." (II Samuel 22:43)

The quality is placing him in the path of peace, ma'amidoh al hashalom. Aharon is peace itself; Hillel says we should all be students of Aharon, who loves peace and pursues peace. As last week, the verb ma'amidoh belongs to raising students — hinted at in the lighting of the menorah at the start of Beha'alotchah, where Aharon is told to raise the lights until they stand on their own.

The prophet is Haggai, whose prophecy is the destruction of the Temple and its rebuilding, and whose words are peace. "Who among you is left, who saw this house in its former glory? And as you see it now, is it not as nothing in your eyes? And now, be strong, Zerubbabel, says the Lord; and be strong, Joshua the son of Jehozadak the High Priest; and be strong, all the people of the land." And the promise: "And I will shake up all the nations, and they shall come [with] the precious things of all the nations. And I will fill this House with glory, said the Lord of Hosts. The silver is Mine, and the gold is Mine, says the Lord of Hosts. The glory of this last House shall be greater than the first one, said the Lord of Hosts. And in this place I will grant peace, says the Lord of Hosts."

The levitical city is Jattir, from Yeter, the remains, what is left after destruction — a fitting name for Av. Yeter can also mean an addition, close to Yoter, more: with the coming of Mashiach, Av will be a month of added importance and celebration.

Week 43, Book 2 — the whole entry

Rosh Chodesh Av, and the more intense part of the Three Weeks. Rosh Chodesh Av is Aharon's yahrzeit, one of the few named in the Torah — and this is the first Torah section to mention Aharon since the week of Moshe's yahrzeit, in Adar: "And Moses said to Aaron, Take one jug and put there an omerful of manna, and deposit it before the Lord to be preserved for your generations. As the Lord had commanded Moses, Aaron deposited it before the testimony to be preserved." The keeping of the omer again, which belongs to the times of Jeremiah and the destruction.

The Haftorah divides spoils and then turns: "dyed garments of embroidery for the neck of the spoiler.' So may perish all Your enemies, O Lord; but they that love Him (should be) as the sun when he goes forth in his might." Devorah prays that this be the fate of His enemies — which is Av, to be turned from a month of Jewish suffering into one of Jewish triumph. And those who love Him are to be as the sun in its might: Av is the hottest month, and the sun is usually associated with the gentile nations rather than the Jewish people, who go with the moon. She is hinting at the transformation of Jacob into Israel, who also stands for the sun.

Daf Mem Gimmel of Sotah has Pinchas as the Mashuach Milchamah in the war against Midian, and then those exempt from fighting a milchemet reshut, a non-mandatory war, mostly the case of a man who planted a vineyard and had not redeemed its fruit. Pinchas could not suit this week better: a Kohen, Aharon's grandson, and tied to Mashiach, born on Tisha B'Av, both by being the anointed for war in the last battle the Torah describes and by being the same person as Eliyahu HaNavi, who will accompany Mashiach. The daf also discusses how he descends from Joseph — and the Torah makes clear that it is the strength of Joseph that can defeat Esau. Pinchas looks like the ultimate archetype of Mashiach ben Yosef.

The generation is Amaziah, son of Yehoash, who began his kingship very righteous, and whose righteousness earned him a tremendous victory over none other than Edom, which he treated particularly severely. His counterparts in Israel were Jehoahaz, Jehoash and Jeroboam ben Jehoash. The victory led to haughtiness and then to idolatry, and he was castigated by his own brother Amoz, the father of the prophet Isaiah. His haughtiness led to a disastrous war against the King of Israel,

Jehoash, and because of that loss Jerusalem itself was looted and Amaziah taken captive. The destruction of Jerusalem is the main theme of the week, and the other is sinat chinam.

The forty-third week goes with conquering the Chittites, whose name comes from Chet, sin. They belong to the negative side of Chesed, which shows itself mostly in improper relations — as in the story of David and Batsheva, who was married to Uriah HaChiti, Uriah the Chittite. Esau himself married two Chittites, Judith the daughter of Beeri the Hittite and Basemath the daughter of Elon the Hittite, and made life bitter for Isaac and Rebeccah.

Week 43, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 298 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Israel, an Acquisition of G-d

The verse shows the sons of Eli pressing further: "Also, before they would make the fat smoke, and the servant of the priest would come, and would say to the man who slaughtered, 'Give meat to roast for the priest, and he will not take from you cooked meat, but raw.'" They sent a servant of the priests to force the portion out of a man before the offering was even ready, which showed disdain both for the person bringing the sacrifice and for those who served in the Tabernacle.

Pirkei Avot's acquisition this week is the people of Israel: "Till Your nation, O G-d, shall pass, till this nation You have acquired shall pass." And: "To the holy who are upon earth, the noble ones, in whom is all My delight." The verses are about the Jews being acquired as His servants after being freed from Egyptian servitude, and about their holy and noble character. The sons of Eli denigrated both: they used the priests' servants for their own motives and belittled the holiness of what the people brought.

Chapter 12 ends Ecclesiastes, and the book closes on the relationship itself: "The end of the matter, everything having been heard, fear God and keep His commandments, for this is the entire man. For every deed God will bring to judgment-for every hidden thing, whether good or bad." Rashi: what you can, do, and let your heart be to Heaven; and keep His commandments, for this is the entire man — because for this matter the entire man was created.

The week holds the yahrzeits of Rabbi Shlomo Ganzfried on the 26th of Tammuz, Rabbi Moshe Teitelbaum, the Yismach Moshe, on the 28th, and Rabbi Shlomo Halberstam of Bobov on Rosh Chodesh Av.

Rabbi Moshe Teitelbaum, known as the Yismach Moshe after the title of his book of Torah commentary, was famed both as a scholar and a wonderworker. A disciple of the Seer of Lublin, he was instrumental in spreading Chasidut in Hungary, and his descendants founded the dynasties of Satmar and Sighet.

Rabbi Shlomo Ganzfried was born in Ungvar, Hungary, in 1804. His father, Rabbi Yossef Ganzfried, died in his childhood, and the orphan was brought up by one of the great men of the generation, Rabbi Tzvi Hirsch Heller, better known as Rabbi Hirsch Charif, the Rav of Ungvar, who saw in the boy the potential of becoming one of the great authorities of Israel. Through all the years beside his teacher his soul thirsted to get to the bottom of Halachah until a clear answer was reached, and that is what drove his Halachic books. Above all of them he earned merit with the Kitzur Shulchan Aruch. From 1864, when it was first printed in Ungvar, it has been reprinted dozens of times in hundreds of thousands of copies, which has never been the case with any other book of its kind; it has become one of the most popular works of all time, worthy of every Jew. It fits Rabbi Yossef Caro's own hope that young students consult the Shulchan Aruch constantly, studying it by heart and keeping that study of youth well in their mouths in order to know the Halachah in each case, and so as not to distance themselves from it in old age. Study groups have formed in hundreds of cities and towns to learn it and spread its teachings. One of the great masters of Lithuanian Jewry said of him that he was a man aided by Providence: none of the great men of Israel have ever seen in their own lifetime, as he did, their work crowned with Halachic commentaries and new Dinim by other Rabbis. The Kitzur was printed 14 times in his lifetime, and at each reprint he added numerous new Dinim; during his lifetime Rav Ishaya Hacohen encircled the work with a commentary called Misgeret HaShulchan, the Border of the Table, printed with his permission alongside it. Though his own Shulchan had grown vast in scope, he kept the title Kitzur, abridged. When a close friend asked why he clung to that name, he answered with a smile: in the book of Psalms it is written, "You prepare a table before me" — it is not written, "You will lengthen a table before me."

Rabbi Shlomo Halberstam of Bobov survived the Holocaust along with only 300 chasidim, succeeding his father, who was among those martyred. Settling in Manhattan and then in different parts of Brooklyn, he served as the third rebbe of Bobov for over 50 years and rebuilt it to even more thousands than his father had before the war. Besides being wise and pious he was noted for his steadfastness in not taking sides in disputes — and he passed away on the same Hebrew date as Aharon the High Priest, the first Jew known for loving peace and pursuing peace.

Week 43, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 299 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Holding On Through the Birthpangs of Mashiach

The Song asks who this is, coming up out of the desert: "Who is this coming up from the desert, embracing her beloved?" "Under the apple tree I aroused you; there your mother was in travail with you; there she that bore you was in travail." The Jewish people holding tightly to Hashem under an apple tree — this twenty-two-day period belongs to the apple, the Tapuach, whose song is from Shir HaShirim — and then the travail, the birthpangs. Which is this week exactly: the closeness Aharon stands for, and the difficulty of these days, which are the birthpangs of Mashiach.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the forty-third is Imnah, whose name looks related to Yemin, right, the right hand: His great might, with which He redeemed us at the Exodus. In these days through history we have felt that might against us, and in the future it is in Av that Mashiach will be born and we will see a greater redemption and a greater might. Imnah also looks to come from Limnot, to count. And with him Muppim, son of Benjamin, whose name refers to Joseph's exceeding beauty. It was Aharon's work to count the Jewish people with Moshe — attending to their good points, their strength and their beauty.

Daf Mem Gimmel of Shvuot takes up when a shomer, a guardian, is exempt from paying, how claims must be quantified, and what happens when a security is lost. Which reads onto Aharon as a guardian of the Jewish people who quantified them in the desert, and onto the loss of the security G-d entrusted to us, the Temple, which happened at this time of year.

Jeremiah's forty-third chapter gathers everyone who had stayed in the land, and sets the people against their guardian, the prophet. They did not listen to him; they listened to Johanan the son of Kareah, who gathered them and took them to Egypt. "And Johanan the son of Kareah and all the officers of the armies and all the people did not hearken to the voice of the Lord to dwell in the land of Judah." They took everyone — "the men and the women and the children and the king's daughters and all the people whom Nebuzaradan the chief executioner had left with Gedaliah the son of Ahikam the son of Shaphan, and Jeremiah the prophet and Baruch the son of Neriah" — "And they came to the land of Egypt, for they did not hearken to the voice of the Lord."

Week 43, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 300 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Rosh Chodesh Av - Psalms 127-129; 105:30-32; 89:44

The week of Rosh Chodesh Av in psalms: the hundred and twenty-seventh, hundred and twenty-eighth and hundred and twenty-ninth, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89. Three more songs of ascents.

Psalm 127 is King David instructing his generation, and his son Solomon above all, that everything a person does should be for the sake of Heaven; and it criticises those who toil day and night after a livelihood. "If the Lord does not build a house, then its builders labor upon it in vain. If the Lord will not guard a city, the vigilance of its watchman is in vain. It is in vain for you, you who rise early, who sit up late, and who eat the bread of tension, for in fact He gives His loved ones sleep." Then the inheritance: "Behold, the heritage of the Lord is children; the fruit of the womb is a reward. As arrows in the hand of a mighty man, so are the children of youth."

Psalm 128 praises the man who lives off his own labour, avoiding theft and deception and even refusing gifts, and describes how the G-d-fearing live. "Fortunate is every man who fears the Lord, who walks in His ways. When you eat of the labor of your hands, you will be happy, and you will have goodness. Your wife will be like a fruitful vine in the inner chambers of your house; your children will be like olive saplings around your table." And the blessing at the end: "May the Lord bless you out of Zion, and may you see the goodness of Jerusalem all the days of your life. And may

you see children [born] to your children; peace upon Israel."

Psalm 129 laments Israel's troubles. "Much have they persecuted me from my youth on. Let Israel declare it now- 'Much have they persecuted me from my youth on, [but] they have not prevailed against me.'" The image is agricultural and brutal: "The plowmen plowed upon my back; they wished to make their furrow long. But the Lord is just; He cut the cords of the lawless." And the haters of Zion get the grass of a rooftop, which withers before anyone pulls it, which no reaper ever fills his hand with and no passer-by ever blesses.

Psalm 105's verses are more of the plagues: "Their land swarmed with frogs in the rooms of their monarchs. He commanded and a mixture of noxious beasts came, lice throughout all their boundary. He made their rains into hail, flaming fire in their land." And Psalm 89's verse turns the sword back: "You even turned back the sharp edge of his sword, and You did not raise him up in battle."

Week 43, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 301 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Cat Is Saying

The cat opens on the pursuit, and the week comes in around it.

The pursuing and the avenging first: "I have pursued my enemies and overtaken them" / "And I did not return until they were destroyed" / "Sing out praise, O you nations, for His people!" / "For He will avenge the blood of His servants" / "Inflict revenge upon His adversaries, And appease His land [and] His people" / "Their land swarmed with frogs In the rooms of their monarchs."

Then the meat demanded raw, and the nest among the stars: "And [they] would say to the man who slaughtered, 'Give meat to roast for the priest'" / "'And he will not take from you cooked meat, but raw'" / "Dyed garments of embroidery for the neck of the spoiler" / "If you rise up like a vulture, and place your nest among the stars" / "From there I shall bring you down, says G-d."

Then the grinding into dust, and the sword turned back: "Then I ground them as the dust of the earth" / "As the mud of the streets I did tread upon them, I did stamp them down" / "You even turned back the sharp edge of his sword" / "And You did not raise him up in battle" / "So may perish all Your enemies, O Lord" / "But they

that love Him [are] as the sun when it goes forth in its might" / "He commanded and a mixture of noxious beasts came, Lice throughout all their boundary."

And the end is the jug of manna and the apple tree: "Also, before they would make the fat smoke, And the servant of the priest would come" / "And Moses said to Aaron, take one jug and put there an omerful of manna" / "And deposit it before the Lord to be preserved for your generations" / "He made their rains into hail, flaming fire in their land" / "Who is this coming up from the desert, embracing her beloved?" / "As the Lord had commanded Moses, Aaron deposited it before the testimony to be preserved" / "Under the apple tree I aroused you; there your mother was in travail with you" / "There she that bore you was in travail."

Week 43, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XLIV

Gevurah of Malchut

Days 302–308

Day 302 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Recognize Our Mistakes and Change

The Mouse says, "I shall exalt you, G-d, for You have impoverished [uplifted] me, and You have not let my enemies rejoice over me." (Psalms 30:2) And once it is caught: "You are just for all that comes upon me, for You have acted truthfully, and I have been wicked." (Nehemiah 9:33) This is the week of Tisha B'Av.

The song belongs to Shimon and to the day. Shimon, the man and the tribe, made serious mistakes: he was instrumental in the sale of Joseph, and the tribe, its prince included, openly rebelled against Moses. And through repentance Shimon will be fully redeemed. As the mouse is caught through its own iniquities, our Temple was destroyed on Tisha B'Av through our sins, and the first step toward redemption is recognising that fault — it is said that in any generation in which the Temple is not rebuilt, it is as if that generation destroyed it.

The word the mouse uses, dilitani, for having been impoverished or uplifted, is near Dal, poor, and Delet, door. The Bnei Yissachar teaches, from the writings of the Arizal, that Tammuz is the letter dalet and Av the letter lamed, which spell Dal — and Elul, the month of Teshuvah, is the letter Tav, which makes Delet. The secret of being lifted in the poor months is to join them to the doors of Elul. That is in the words of Selichot: "kdalim uchrashim dafaknu dlatecha," like the poor and destitute we knock on Your door.

The letters of forty-four, mem and dalet, spell dam, blood, and mad, from limdod, to measure. Av has been a month in which much blood was spilled; once the Jewish people learn the lesson, measure their actions and improve, it will be a month of light and joy. The same letters spell dom, to be silent — a word often used in praise of how

our greatest sages met tragedy. Of Aaron, learning that his two eldest sons had died, the Torah says "yehidom Aharon," Aaron was silent and did not complain. Our Chassidic masters explain that King David's way went further still: after great suffering he says, "l'man yezamerchah velo yidom," I will sing to You and not be silent. There is much to learn from both approaches about how to keep this day. And dom has a brighter side: pursuing the enemies of the Jewish people, Joshua calls to the sun and commands it, "Dom!" — telling it to stop its song to G-d, which makes the sun stand still, and gives the people time to finish before the Sabbath begins.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Nehora'i: exile yourself to a place of Torah; do not say that it will come after you, that your colleagues will help you retain it; rely not on your own understanding. Tisha B'Av is about exile in general, and about one exile in particular, to a place of Torah: Yavneh. By establishing Yavneh and bringing our sages there, Rabbi Yochanan Ben Zakkai made sure Judaism continued long after the Roman Empire had stopped existing. And since the suffering of this week is so hard to understand, it is fitting to be told not to lean on our own limited understanding but to stay joined to the rest of our people.

The combination is gevurah shebemalchut. This week we work on the strength to reach goals in this material world against obstacles. As in the week of Yom Kippur, gevurah shebechesed, we fast — and not feeling like angels this time; more like the mouse. On Yom Kippur, one of the happiest days of the year, the fast is for spiritual reasons; on Tisha B'Av we fast in mourning. The day belongs to gevurah because of how many tragedies fell on it, the decree of forty years in the wilderness and the destruction of both Temples among them — and to malchut, because it is exactly out of that tragedy that Mashiach is born.

The lesson from the mouse is that He can raise us up at any moment, and that to come out of sadness we should increase our prayers and direct them to Him alone. Any fall, personal or national, is an opening for teshuvah. And judging oneself is only good if it leads to better behaviour rather than to sadness: there is a fine line between being temporarily broken-hearted over one's sins, which is a good regret, and sadness, which should be avoided at all costs. Broken-heartedness should lead to greater joy.

Week 44, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 303 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Zechariah and Settling One's Heart

The week of Tisha B'Av. Haazinu ends: "And Moses came and spoke all the words of this song into the ears of the people he and Hoshea the son of Nun." (Deuteronomy 32:44) Av is the tikkun of hearing, and into the ears of the people is how the song arrives. Perhaps Yehoshua stands beside Moshe here because of all of them he was the one best able to absorb Moshe's teaching. This week holds the birth of Mashiach, on the 9th of Av, and the Midrash teaches that Moshe is the first redeemer and the final redeemer; Yehoshua is likewise a prototype for Mashiach Ben Yoseph.

The Haftorah is plainly about that coming: "And You have allowed me to escape from the contenders amongst my people; You shall keep me as head of nations; a people whom I have not known serve me." (II Samuel 22:44) Mashiach will be not only king of Israel but will stand for the Kingdom of G-d on earth.

The quality is he deliberates in his study, Mityashev Liboh Betalmudoh. A great part of the destruction on the 9th of Av came of the hot-headedness of the zealots of that time, where the Torah scholars sought calm and compromise. More literally the phrase is that he settles his heart with his study. The Midrash says that Mashiach is a metzorah, one who suffers a form of spiritual skin disease, and that he cures one wound at a time. The Alter Rebbe explains that the cure for the metzorah is Torah — which is why the verse says "this shall be the Torah of the metzorah on the day of his purification," where the plainer wording would have been "this is the purification of the metzorah." The metzorah is a man whose heart is unsettled, and it is the Torah that settles it. The line can also be read about a friend's heart, continuing the qualities of the past weeks. And Mashiach will be known for his Torah and for his power of speech: the word Mashiach is spelled like Mesiach, one who speaks.

The prophet is Zechariah. We read in the kinot of Tisha B'Av about an earlier Zechariah, killed at the time of the First Temple's destruction, whose blood had to be avenged — and that is settling of another kind. Our Sages say that when Nebuzaradan entered the Temple he found the blood of Zechariah seething, and asked what it meant; the Jews tried to conceal it, and under threat told him there was a prophet among them who chastised them and whom they killed, and that for many years his blood had not rested. He said, I will appease him, and killed the members of

the Great and Small Sanhedrins, then youths and maidens, then school-children, 940,000 people in all; and still the blood boiled, until he cried, "Zechariah, Zechariah! I have slain the best of them; do you want all of them destroyed?" — and at last it sank into the ground.

This Zechariah's own prophecy makes some of the most direct references to Mashiach: "Be exceedingly happy, O daughter of Zion; Shout, O daughter of Jerusalem. Behold! Your king shall come to you. He is just and victorious; humble, and riding a donkey and a foal, the offspring of [one of] she-donkeys." And in the story of Rabbi Akiva laughing while the other rabbis mourn, it is Zechariah's prophecy that consoles them: old men and women shall yet sit in the streets of Jerusalem.

The levitical city is Holon, from chol, which means sand and also profane. As at the destruction, when something is emptied of its holiness it is chol, a vacuum, dead like the sand of the sea. And in the Torah almost nothing stands for life, and for children, as the sand does; we are promised to be as many as they are one day. One day our tears of sadness will be tears of joy, and the earth will be filled with the knowledge of G-d as the water covers the sea, and the sand. The numerical value of chol is forty-four. Holon is also a city in modern Israel, the country's second largest industrial area.

Week 44, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 304 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

War and Conquest

Tisha B'Av, the only twenty-four-hour fast besides Yom Kippur, marks the destruction of both Temples and many other tragedies. It was on Tisha B'Av that the spies came back with a negative report, and after the people reacted as they did it was decreed that they would spend 40 years in the desert.

Beshalach ends with exactly that span: "And the children of Israel ate the manna for forty years until they came to an inhabited land. They ate the manna until they came to the border of the land of Canaan. The omer is one tenth of an ephah." Once the forty-two journeys are done and we reach that border, in Av, the manna stops and sustenance has to come from working the Land. And that conquest belongs to

the coming of Mashiach, which belongs to this week.

The Haftorah rests the land forty years: "And the land rested forty years. And the children of Israel did that which displeased the Lord, and the Lord delivered them into the hand of Midian (for) seven years." Those forty years stand against the forty in the desert. And as the last battle of the desert years was against Midian, Israel now faced oppression from Midian after forty years of relative calm. Like Tisha B'Av, they were given into their enemies' hands because they displeased Him — which reads back onto last week's daf, where Pinchas is the anointed for war against Midian.

Daf Mem Dalet of Sotah gives the laws of the impurity of a dead body, then more of those exempt from a milchemet reshut — the engaged, and the afraid — and then opens a chapter on the Eglah Arufah, the beheading of a calf for an unsolved murder outside a Jewish city. The first and the last belong to a date marked by death. And Tisha B'Av belongs to those who fear war, like the fear that took hold when the people heard the spies.

The generation is Uzziah, also called Azariah, son of Amaziah, one of the most successful kings of Judah. His counterparts in Israel were Jeroboam ben Jehoash, Zechariah, Shallum, Menachem ben Gadi, Pekahiah ben Menahem and Pekah ben Remaliah. The start of his reign, while he was young, saw great devastation, with attackers plundering Judah from every border; once he came of age and held his throne firmly he developed the country extensively, militarily and economically. For all his piety he made one grave mistake that became the defining event of his kingdom: over repeated warnings he tried to play the part of a kohen and offer incense in the Temple, and was immediately struck with tzara'at. He stayed a metzorah for the rest of his life, living in isolation near a cemetery — and there is a well-known story in the Talmud that Mashiach, born on Tisha B'Av, is a Metzorah by the gates of Rome. Uzziah means G-d is my strength, and Azariah G-d is my help. The word for strength, Oz, is near Az, bold: there is a boldness on the side of holiness, as in being bold like a leopard, and a boldness on the side of impurity, as in the saying that those who are bold go to gehinnom. Uzziah showed both, and both belong to this day. And the Haftorah of Shabat Hazon, read this week, opens by saying it was prophesied by Isaiah, Uzziah's uncle, during his reign.

The forty-fourth week goes with conquering the Girgashites, whose name comes from Girgash, a kind of red clay. That recalls the making of man from the earth:

Adam comes from Adamah, earth, and is near Adom, red, like Edom. The Girgashites belong to the negative side of Gevurah, which shows itself in violence and murder, which is Eisav's own characteristic. King David, who is also described as red, is the tikkun of it: he used his gevurah for the good, against Goliath and in all his other battles for G-d and Israel.

Week 44, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 305 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Building G-d's House

The verse ends with a threat: "And (if) the man said to him, 'Let them make the fat smoke now, and (then) take for yourself, as your soul desires,' And he would say, 'No, but now you shall give. And if not, I shall take by force.'" Taking the portion by force, before the offering was ready — a great disdain for the laws of sacrifice and for the person bringing one, which recalls the baseless hatred and the corrupt priests of the time of the destruction.

Pirkei Avot's acquisition this week is the Holy Temple: "The base for Your dwelling that you, G-d, have achieved; the Sanctuary, O L-rd, that Your hands have established." And: "And He brought them to His holy domain, this mount His right hand has acquired." His dwelling, which He established and acquired with His own hands — where the sons of Eli spoke as though the Tabernacle and the sacrifices were theirs, putting their own will before His.

Psalm 127 was said by King Solomon, and it is about building the Temple and how its success depends entirely on His will: "If the Lord will not build a house, its builders have toiled at it in vain." Failing to keep His will leads to the destruction that came on Tisha B'Av.

The week holds the yahrzeits of two of the greatest masters of Kabbalah and Chassidut: Rabbi Yitzchak Luria, the Arizal, on the 5th of Av, and Rabbi Yaakov Yitzchok Horowitz, the Chozeh of Lublin, on the 9th. Rabbi Yitzchak Luria, known as the holy Ari, revolutionised the study of Kabbalah and its place in mainstream Judaism in the two years he spent in Zefat before his death at 38; much of Chasidic thought rests on his teachings as recorded by his main disciple, Rabbi Chaim Vital. Rabbi Yaakov Yitzchok Horowitz, the Chozeh of Lublin, succeeded R. Elimelech of

Lizensk and led the spread of chassidus in Poland. Many great Rebbes of the next generation came out of his followers: the Yid HaKodesh, Simcha Bunim of Peshischa, Meir of Apta, David of Lelov, the Yismach Moshe, the Sabba Kadisha of Radoshitz, the Bnai Yisasscher, Rabbi Naftali Zvi of Ropshitz, the Maor Vashemesh and Sar Shalom of Belz. Many of his insights were published after his death, in Divrei Emmes, Zichron Zos and Zos Zichron.

Also this week: Rabbi Shimshon Ostropolier, Rabbi Chaim Yechezkel Taub of Ozorov, and Rabbi Yitzchak Twersky, the first Skverer Rebbe in America, on the 3rd of Av; and Rabbi Ephraim Taub of Kuzmir and Rabbi Benzion Halberstam, the second Bobover Rebbe, on the 4th.

Week 44, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 306 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

"Love is as Strong as Death"

Tisha B'Av, which marks the destruction of both Temples and the enormous destruction that came with them, remembered every year with fasting and intense mourning, and on which we remember every tragedy of Jewish history, the Holocaust among them.

The Song's verse is hauntingly close to it: "Place me like a seal on your heart, liked a seal on your arm, for love is as strong as death, zeal is as strong as the grave; its coals are coals of fire of a great flame!" Death and the grave; a seal on your arm, like the numbers etched on the arms of Jews in the concentration camps; a great fire, like the one that burned the Temples. And love is stronger than death. We survived, and the great flame of our people burns still.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the forty-fourth is Ishvah, whose root is the same as Leshavot, and which looks related to this week's quality, Mityashev Liboh Betalmudoh, to settle one's heart in study. Much of the destruction on the 9th of Av came of the hot-headedness of the zealots, where the Torah scholars of that time sought calm and compromise. And with him Huppim, son of Benjamin, whose name is near Chuppah, a wedding canopy, for Benjamin never seeing Joseph's wedding. The Chuppah is the great symbol of peace and normalcy, in the prophecy of Jeremiah that is part of the Shevah Brachot said under it: "There shall again be

heard in this place, concerning which you say, 'It is desolate without man and without beast,' in the cities of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem that are desolate... the sound of mirth and the sound of joy, the voice of a bridegroom and the voice of a bride, the sound of those saying, 'Thank the Lord of Hosts, for the Lord is good, for His loving-kindness endures forever.'" Those words hold both the tragedy of Tisha B'Av and the redemption. And the Chuppah belongs to love, and to Tu B'Av next week, which is a day of marriage and love — the high that comes directly after these lows.

Daf Mem Dalet of Shvuot keeps on with a mashkon, a security, that was lost, like the Temple, and opens a new chapter on oaths taken in order to receive payment. Much of it is about someone entering another person's house without permission: a case where he takes vessels from the owner, and a case where the owner wounds him. Which reads onto Tisha B'Av, when our house, the House of G-d, was entered without permission and its vessels taken, and when those who entered were punished and will be punished again. And there is a discussion of partial admission — admitting to taking one vessel rather than two, or to wounding once rather than twice — which reads onto two Temples destroyed, both on the same day.

Jeremiah's forty-fourth chapter is the destruction brought on Jerusalem and the cities of Judah, and not listening to the prophets, which is the sense this month repairs. "You saw all the evil that I brought upon Jerusalem and upon all the cities of Judah, and behold, they are waste, and there are no inhabitants in them, because of their evil, which they did to provoke Me, to go to burn incense to worship other gods, which they did not know." And the sending that went unheard: "And I sent to you all My servants the prophets, sending them betimes, saying: Now do not do this abominable thing which I hate. But they did not hearken, nor did they incline their ear[s] to repent of their evil." And the question: "Why do you do this great evil to your souls, to cut off from you man and woman, child and suckling from the midst of Judah, not to leave over a remnant for yourselves?"

Week 44, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 307 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Tisha B'Av - Psalms 130-132; 105:33-35; 89:45

The week of Tisha B'Av in psalms: the hundred and thirtieth, hundred and thirty-first and hundred and thirty-second, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 130 prays for an end to this long exile, and it begins as low as a psalm can begin: "Out of the depths I call to You, O Lord. My Lord, hearken to my voice; let Your ears be attentive to the sound of my pleas." Then the thing that makes any of it possible: "G-d, if You were to preserve iniquities, my Lord, who could survive? But forgiveness is with You, that You may be held in awe." Then the waiting: "I hope in the Lord; my soul hopes, and I long for His word. My soul yearns for the Lord more than those awaiting the morning wait for the morning." And the last line: "And He will redeem Israel from all its iniquities."

Psalm 131 is David saying that in all his life he was never haughty and never chased greatness or the pleasures of the world. "O Lord, my heart was not proud, nor were my eyes haughty; I did not seek matters that were too great and too wondrous for me. Surely I put my soul at peace and soothed it like a weaned child with his mother; my soul was like a weaned child. Let Israel hope in the Lord from this time forth and forever." Three verses, and that is all of it.

Psalm 132 David composed while he and the elders of Israel wore sackcloth, mourning the plague that had come on the land and their distance from the Holy Temple, and it asks Him to remember the hardship David bore for the Temple's sake. "O Lord, remember unto David all his suffering, how he swore to the Lord, and vowed to the Mighty Power of Jacob: 'I will not enter into the tent of my house; I will not go up into the bed that is spread for me; I will not give sleep to my eyes, nor slumber to my eyelids; until I will have found a place for the Lord, a resting place for the Mighty Power of Jacob.'" Then the finding: "Lo, we heard of it in Ephrath; we found it in the field of the forest." Then the going up: "Ascend, O Lord, to Your resting place, You and the Ark of Your might." Then the oath that answers his: "For the Lord has sworn to David a truth from which He will never retreat: 'From the fruit of your womb will I set for you upon the throne.'" And the choosing, which is the line this week needs: "For the Lord has chosen Zion; He has desired it for His habitation.

This is My resting place to the end of time. Here will I dwell, for I have desired it." And the lamp at the end: "There I will cause David's power to flourish; there I have prepared a lamp for My anointed."

Psalm 105's verses are the hail and the locusts: "And it struck their vines and their fig trees, and it broke the trees of their boundary. He spoke and locusts came, and nibbling locusts without number. And they consumed all grass in their land, and they consumed the produce of their soil." And Psalm 89's verse is the throne on the ground: "You have brought an end to his shining, and his throne You have cast down to earth."

Week 44, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 308 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Mouse Is Saying

The mouse opens with the admission, and the week comes in around it.

The displeasing and the admitting first: "And the children of Israel did that which displeased the Lord" / "And the Lord delivered them into the hand of Midian seven years" / "You are just for all that comes upon me" / "For You have acted truthfully, and I have been wicked."

Then the portion demanded, and the locusts: "And (if) the man said to him, 'Let them make the fat smoke now and (then) take for yourself, as your soul desires'" / "He spoke and locusts came, and nibbling locusts without number" / "The omer is one tenth of an ephah" / "And he would say, 'No, but now you shall give'" / "'And if not, I shall take by force'" / "And they consumed all grass in their land" / "And they consumed the produce of their soil" / "Its coals are coals of fire of a great flame!"

Then the escape, and the two spans of forty years: "And You have allowed me to escape from the contenders among my people" / "And the land rested forty years" / "And the children of Israel ate the manna for forty years" / "Until they came to an inhabited land" / "They ate the manna until they came to the border of the land of Canaan."

Then the throne cast down, and the broken trees: "You have brought an end to his shining" / "And his throne You have cast down to earth" / "And it struck their vines and their fig trees" / "And it broke the trees of their boundary."

And the end is the song spoken into their ears, and the seal: “And Moses came and spoke all the words of this song” / “Into the ears of the people he and Hoshea the son of Nun” / “You shall keep me as head of nations” / “A people whom I have not known serve me” / “Place me like a seal on your heart, liked a seal on your arm” / “For love is as strong as death, zeal is as strong as the grave” / “I shall exalt you, G-d, for You have uplifted me and You have not let my enemies rejoice over me.”

Week 44, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XLV

Tiferet of Malchut

Days 309–315

Day 309 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Raise Ourselves Up Through Love and Humility

The Creeping Creatures are saying: "Let Israel rejoice in He Who made him; let the children of Zion be joyful in their King." (Psalms 149:2) In another version: "May the glory of G-d endure forever; may G-d rejoice in His works." (Psalms 104:31) This is the week of Tu B'Av.

Tu B'Av is the most romantic day of the Jewish calendar. It was at this time that the Tribes of Israel were allowed to intermarry among themselves again. To mark it, young Jewish women would dress in white, form a circle, and present themselves to the single men of the community who were looking for a bride; the Talmud teaches that each one would speak of the different qualities she thought might make a good impression on a potential groom. Which belongs to this month's repair of hearing, and its constant attention to a person's good points.

The weight of the song is joy, and according to the Talmud Tu B'Av, with Yom Kippur, was the happiest day of the year. The song names the joy of Zion in particular, and Tu B'Av comes right after Tisha B'Av, when Jerusalem was destroyed — and in many ways its joy can only come through the sadness of that day.

The creeping creatures are so numerous that how fast they multiply is used as the example for the Jewish people: the word the Torah uses for how we multiplied in Egypt is yishretzu, from sheretz, creeping creature.

Forty-five is the gematria of Adam, the first person created and the first to be given a soul mate. Mem and heh also spell mah, what, which belongs to humility, as in Moses's well-known "Nachnu Mah," we are what, we are nothing.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yannai: we have no comprehension of the tranquility of the wicked, nor of the suffering of the righteous. Tranquility, as in Tu B'Av; suffering, as in Tisha B'Av. As last week, the message is that we will never fully understand His ways; all we can do is hold complete faith that everything He does is for the good.

The combination is tiferet shebemalchut. On Tu B'Av the balance and beauty of this physical world is at its height, as at a Jewish wedding. In kabbalistic texts Tiferet is Jacob and malchut is his wife Rachel. Tiferet also means compassion, and this week is bound to mercy and consolation, as the haftorah readings of the seven weeks after Tisha B'Av are. The lesson from the creeping creatures is that for all their humble condition — and perhaps exactly because of it — they are truly happy, they praise His name, and they are extraordinarily fruitful.

Week 45, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 310 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Malachi and the Quality of "Asking and Responding"

The week of Tu B'Av. Haazinu closes: "And Moses finished speaking all these words to all Israel." (Deuteronomy 32:45) The word Kol, all, appears twice, and is the root of a third word, Vayichal, completed. That completion can be read of Moshe himself, of the words of the song, or of the Jewish people, and it hints at how the three complete one another: Moshe, the Torah, and the people. It also recalls the creeping creatures, who are humble and nullify themselves before G-d — and that humility is what allows peace and wholeness, Shalom and Shlemut. Wholeness is the theme of Tu B'Av, which belongs to marriage and to all of Israel being one, since it was on this date that the tribes were allowed to intermarry. And it was on Tu B'Av that the decree of Tisha B'Av — that the whole generation would die in the desert for the sin of the spies — and many later decrees were completed.

The Haftorah is about hearing properly, which is this month's tikkun, and about the power of teshuvah and of the words of the leader of a generation: "Strangers lie to me; as soon as their ears hear, they obey me." (II Samuel 22:45) They began as lying strangers, and the moment he spoke to them they obeyed and changed their ways.

The quality is asks and responds, shoel umeshiv — which is listening properly again, and which recalls the conversations the Talmud describes between the single women and men on Tu B'Av. In study there is a famous proverb that there is no greater joy than the resolution of doubt, ein simchah k'hatarat hasefeikot. Tu B'Av, with Yom Kippur, is the happiest day of the year — and after Tisha B'Av we are left with many questions: how could G-d do such things to His own people? We answer each other's questions as well as we can, as Rabbi Nehorai said last week, that colleagues help you learn and you should not rely on your own understanding. And where our colleagues' words are not enough, there is Rabbi Yannai again: we have no comprehension of the tranquility of the wicked, nor of the suffering of the righteous. The answer is emunah. Everything that happens to a person is for his own good — a notion Rebbe Nachman calls an aspect of the World to Come. And one of the best responses to seeing death and destruction is to redouble the work of rebuilding and of making life: one might say that the best response to the Holocaust has been the tremendous physical and spiritual growth now taking place, above all in the Land of Israel.

The prophet is Malachi, whose prophecy comes right after the destruction of the Temple. He speaks of how G-d loves Jacob and hates Esau — and Esau cheered the destruction of the First Temple and would be the nation that destroyed the Second. He prophesies that Esau may say it will rebuild, and G-d will demolish; not so with Jacob. His book is also full of back and forth, which is this week's quality. "A son honors a father, and a slave his master. Now if I am a father, where is My honor? And if I am a master, where is My fear? says the Lord of Hosts to you, the priests, who despise My name. But you said, 'How have we despised Your Name?' You offer on My altar defiled food, yet you say, 'How have we defiled You?'" "You have wearied the Lord with your words, and you say, 'How have we wearied [Him]?'" "'Return to Me, and I will return to you,' said the Lord of Hosts, but you said, 'With what have we to return?' Will a man rob G-d? Yet you rob Me, and you say, 'With what have we robbed You?'" And the Messianic end of it: "Lo, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and awesome day of the Lord, that he may turn the heart of the fathers back through the children, and the heart of the children back through their fathers." Our sages say that Malachi is in fact Ezra the Scribe — and it was Ezra who led the return to the Land, the rebuilding of the Temple, and the

canonisation of the Tanach: the Five Books of Moses, the Prophets and the Writings. An incredible response to the tragedy of Tisha B'Av.

The levitical city is Debir, which means the Temple itself, and is also used of the inner courtyard and the Holy of Holies.

Week 45, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 311 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Unity and Upright Behavior in the Face of Amalek

After the Song of the Sea and Parashat HaMan, Beshalach enters its third and last account: the fight against Amalek. "The entire community of the children of Israel journeyed from the desert of Sin to their travels by the mandate of the Lord. They encamped in Rephidim, and there was no water for the people to drink. So the people quarreled with Moses, and they said, Give us water that we may drink Moses said to them, Why do you quarrel with me? Why do you test the Lord?" Rephidim means weakness, weakness in Torah study above all, and the lack of water is a lack of Torah too. That brought the quarrel with Moshe, which was a quarrel with G-d, and that brought Amalek's attack. Amalek is known for cruelty and arrogance, and for having no faith and no fear of G-d. This is the season for fighting those qualities, above all in ourselves, as we do teshuvah and begin to get ready for the coming year.

The verses after the Song of Devorah begin the story of Gideon, which opens with the oppression the Jews suffered at the hands of Midian and of Amalek — a crisis that also came of not serving Hashem properly. "And the hand of Midian prevailed against Israel. Because of Midian the children of Israel made for themselves the dens which are in the mountains and the caves, and the strongholds."

Week 45 is Tu B'Av, which with Yom Kippur is the happiest and most romantic day of the year, known for unity and love, since on it the tribes were allowed to intermarry. And the verses of Beshalach begin by saying that the entire community journeyed — together, which is the unity of this season.

Daf Mem Heh of Sotah continues the Eglah Arufah: the measurements to be made, how to handle the corpse, and how to behead the calf. It was done because of a failure to accompany a stranger properly out of a city — and for that lack of unity the city's sages must now come together, in a sign of renewed unity, and perform the

ritual for atonement.

The generation is Jotham, son of Uzziah, an example of morality and humble by nature. His conduct was much shaped by what had happened to his father, as the happiness and unity of Tu B'Av is coloured by the horrific events of Tisha B'Av. His counterparts in Israel were Pekah ben Remaliah and Hosheah ben Elah. His name seems to mean Hashem is Tam, whole, complete — which belongs to Tu B'Av, when we mark the wholeness of the Jewish people. The Zohar mentions that Tu B'Av is a particularly festive holiday because it falls when the moon, which stands for the Jewish people, is full.

The forty-fifth week goes with conquering the Amorites, whose name comes from amar, the root of the verb to speak — and speech is what chiefly distinguishes man from the rest of creation. Le'emor usually means a softer speech, where Ledaber tends to be harsher. The Emorites belong to the negative side of Tiferet and Rachamim, which shows itself as pride, and as being merciful to those who deserve harshness. The gemara explains that King Saul showed exactly that improper mercy toward Amalek and its king, and because of it ended up cruel toward those who deserved mercy, at Nov, the city of Kohanim. In that episode he also did not have enough pride in his position as King to see that the word of G-d was carried out fully, and then showed too much pride when the Prophet Samuel pointed out his mistake and he would not immediately take the blame. This week we have to learn the right balance of kindness and severity, and when to use a small dose of pride and when to act with absolute humility. As Pirkei Avot has it, in one pocket we hold "I am dust and ashes," and in the other, "the world was created for me."

Week 45, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 312 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Appreciating True Beauty

The verse names the sin plainly: "And the sin of the lads was great before the Lord, for the men despised the offering of the Lord." The word is Niatzu, which the Tanach often uses for not appreciating the beauty of the Mitzvot. And Tu B'Av is the happiest day of the year, and the most romantic, which the Talmud describes as a day fit for appreciating the beauty of others, a future spouse above all. Real beauty is not only physical. The Mishnah says that on this day the daughters of Jerusalem came out and danced in the vineyards, calling, "Young man, lift up your eyes and see what you choose for yourself. Do not set your eyes on beauty but set your eyes on [good] family" — as it says, "Grace is deceitful, and beauty is vain; but a woman that fears the lord, she shall be praised."

Chapter 6 of Pirkei Avot lists eight qualities becoming to the righteous and to the world, and the first is beauty, No'i. Outer beauty that reflects the inner beauty of the righteous is becoming to both; an outer beauty with no fear of G-d behind it is deceitful and vain.

Chapter 1 of the Song of Songs is much about beauty, and it would do the writing a tremendous injustice to think King Solomon meant mainly the physical kind. "Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth, for your love is better than wine." "Draw me, we will run after you; the king brought me to his chambers." "I am black but comely, O daughters of Jerusalem! Like the tents of Kedar, like the curtains of Solomon." "Behold, you are comely, my beloved; behold, you are comely; your eyes are like doves." Rashi explains the comely: the congregation of Israel says to the nations, I am black in my deeds and comely in the deeds of my ancestors, and even some of my own deeds are comely; if I am guilty of the iniquity of the Calf, I can counter it with the merit of accepting the Torah. On the later verses he has G-d telling Israel she is fair with the deeds of her forefathers and fair with her own, because there are righteous among her who clung to Him like a dove, which, once it knows its mate, does not leave it for another. And Israel answers that the beauty is not hers but His, for overlooking her transgression and causing His Presence to rest among them.

The week holds the yahrzeits of two prominent Sephardic philanthropists, statesmen and advisors to European kings, both of whom joined outward wealth and beauty to inward G-dly pursuits and integrity: Don Isaac Abravanel on the 10th of Av and Sir Moses Montefiori on the 13th.

Don Isaac Abravanel was one of the greatest Jewish statesmen, with a large part in European history, and at the same time a strictly religious Jew, a great scholar, Bible commentator and philosopher — the last of the long line of great Jewish leaders of the Spanish Golden Age. He was born into a wealthy and learned family in Portugal; his father Judah was state treasurer and a favorite of Alfonso V, and Isaac received a thorough Jewish education, took a keen interest in languages and philosophy, and later succeeded his father in the king's service. He never forgot his humbler brethren: when Alfonso captured Arzilla in Morocco and there were two hundred and fifty Jews among the prisoners, he appointed twelve representatives to gather funds to redeem them and was himself the greatest donor, and then supported them from his own means for about two years, until they learned the language and could earn a living. When Alfonso died and Don Joao II took the throne, Joao began getting rid of the nobility and his father's ministers; Abravanel learned in time that several high officers had been beheaded and that he was slated for the same, and fled to Toledo in Spain, where his family had once lived. He arrived with his wife and two children almost penniless, since the king had confiscated his wealth. He took a position with a Jewish banking firm and was glad of the time for his studies, continuing the Bible commentaries that affairs of state had interrupted — Joshua, Judges and Samuel — and when he began on Kings, the king of Spain summoned him to take over the treasury. Ferdinand and Isabella knew they could find no greater financial genius, and in the very year Torquemada became head of the Inquisition, Abravanel officially became their treasurer, two years before the expulsion. When the decree came that all Jews must leave Spain or give up their faith, he tried hard to avert it, begging the king and queen to reconsider and offering a huge sum to the treasury; they turned a deaf ear and declined the money. On the 9th of Av 5252 he and his family were on the march with the rest of their people, giving up his exalted position to join them in exile. The refugees reached Naples, and when Ferdinand learned of it he asked the king of Naples, also called Ferdinand, not to let them stay; the young king ignored him, invited Abravanel to the royal house and made him his adviser,

and he served him and his son Alfonso II, who came to the throne in 1494. Naples was taken by King Charles of France the next year and Alfonso II fled to Sicily; Abravanel went with him into exile and served him with a fatherly devotion until he died. Then he left for Corfu, and having lost all his wealth to the French conquerors he suffered poverty and hardship. He moved to Monopoli, in the Kingdom of Naples, and eight years later settled in Venice, where the rulers soon invited him to the council of state and he became one of the leading statesmen of the Republic. He died there at the age of 71, deeply mourned by the Jewish and non-Jewish citizens of Venice; the leading rulers attended his funeral, and he was laid to rest in Padua.

Sir Moses Montefiore was a devoted worker for the public welfare, a mediator and intercessor for his brethren, a statesman and a diplomat. Kings and princes everywhere received him cordially, and he always defended the Jewish position with pride and vigor. He was born on the 13th of Cheshvan, 1784, in Livorno; his grandfather Moses Chaim Montefiore was a Sephardic Jew of that city who later settled in London and had 17 sons, one of whom, Joseph Elijah, was his father — and Moses was born in Livorno while his parents were there on business. He was raised in England in an atmosphere of Torah and Mitzvoth and remained a staunch, devout Jew his whole life. In London he built a large business with his brother Abraham; they dealt with the Rothschilds in finance and in large industrial and commercial establishments, formed an insurance company and a gas company that brought gas-lighting to many important cities of Europe, and had a hand in building railroads. He accumulated great wealth and became famous; in 1837 he was appointed Sheriff of London, the second Jew to hold that position, and in the same year Queen Victoria, newly on the throne, gave him a knighthood, and in 1846 raised him to Baron. Unlike certain others who turn from their religion once they have wealth and honor, he remained religious throughout. From an early age he took an interest in the lot of his fellow Jews, and later used his influence to obtain equal rights for the Jews of England. He was Gabbai of the Sephardic Congregations of London and six times elected Rosh HaKahal, and for many years headed the Jewish Board of Deputies, the organisation of the United Congregations. When he gave up that position at the age of 90, the United Congregations gave him a farewell gift of 12,000 pounds sterling — and he donated the entire sum to build houses for the poor in Jerusalem. He loved the Holy Land and supported its institutions most generously, visiting Eretz Yisroel

seven times, the last in 1875 at the age of 91, which, given how hard a journey was in those days, says what it says about a man of that age. He distributed vast sums there, built synagogues, supported Yeshivos and founded institutions, and in 1866 built the well-known tomb over Mother Rachel's grave. The Jews of Eretz Yisroel regarded him as a G-d sent messenger.

When the terrible blood-libel broke out in Damascus in 1840 he went there personally to defend the falsely accused. That libel, which had cost so many Jewish lives in the Middle Ages and was now renewed, threatened not only the accused but the whole community and Jews everywhere; with the help of other prominent Jewish and non-Jewish leaders he persuaded the Sultan to issue a firman declaring the libel false and forbidding its renewal. In 1846 the Russian government officially invited him to visit Russia about the Jewish situation there. The Czarist government, helped by some leaders of the Haskalah, was trying to Russify the broad masses of Russian Jewry, and hoped that the support of so important a Jewish figure would win its fight against the religious leaders who refused to cooperate; the Lubavitcher Rebbe of the time, the Tzemach Tzedek, was especially opposed to everything that would lead to assimilation and worked body and soul against it. Montefiore accepted the invitation, not to be a tool of the assimilationists but to see the Jewish position in Russia for himself, where the majority of world Jewry lived, and to see what could be done about the persecutions and pogroms. Arriving in Petersburg, he was met by Count Kissilev, the Minister of the Interior, and Uvarov, the Minister of Education, with a long list of accusations against Russian Jewry and its religious leaders. He did not rely on their testimony, or on the Maskilim, but travelled through the towns and villages where the Jews lived, and on returning to London compiled two memoranda from what he had gathered, one to each minister. He wrote politely and firmly, so as not to incite them: that the Jewish problem in Russia had nothing to do with Jewish education, which happened to be on a high level; he denied the accusations, and in turn accused the government of dealing falsely with the Jews, describing their terrible economic position under its decrees, expulsions, pogroms and sanctions, and demanded equal rights, stressing that it would be a blessing for the country too. Thanks to the great self-sacrifice of the Russian Jews, strengthened by his efforts, the government finally gave up many of its plans to force conversion and assimilation, and their economic position improved on his recommendations. In 1872 he visited

Russia again and was received by Czar Alexander the Second; he was pleased to see a new class of Jewish businessmen and professionals since his first visit, and did not notice the assimilation that had taken hold of those upper classes. He was also received in audience by the Pope in Rome, when he went to intercede for an Italian Jewish boy forcibly converted as a small child while lying ill in bed: a gentile maid sprinkled him with water, the church declared him a Christian, and he was taken from his parents and brought up as one. The case of the child Murtara caused a great storm of indignation, and no intercession brought him back. And in Rumania, on a visit to help his brothers there, he found himself in grave danger when a wild mob wanted to attack him, and narrowly escaped with his life. Nothing deterred him where it was a question of helping his poor, persecuted brothers. He died on the 13th of Av 1885, at the ripe old age of over 100. The Montefiore Museum holds a great collection of gold and silver artistry he received as gifts from kings and rulers, and documents of great historical importance; his yahrzeit is kept every year by the institutions still maintained from the funds he left.

Also this week: Rav Hillel Paritcher on the 13th of Av, and Rabbi Yaakov Leiner, the second Ishbitzer Rebbe, author of Beis Yaakov and Sefer HaZemanim, and Rabbi Meir Noson Halberstam, son of the Divrei Chaim and father of the first Bobover Rebbe, both on the 15th.

Week 45, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 313 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Our Enduring Love for G-d, Regardless of the Circumstances

The Song's verse is a love that cannot be put out: "Many waters cannot quench the love, nor can rivers flood it; should a man give all the property of his house for love, they would despise him." For all the suffering we come back to Him; the destruction cannot quench our desire for Hashem, and as Rashi notes, we are willing to give away everything for that love.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the forty-fifth is Ishvi, which also comes from Leshavot, the settling of the heart. The difference between Ishvah last week and Ishvi this week is only a Heh and a Yud — two letters that make G-d's name, and that also mark the difference between Ish, male, and Ishah, female. Those

names look related to Ish and Ishah, though they carry no Aleph. And with him Ard, the last of Benjamin's sons, whose name is related to a rose, which has its own romantic weight.

Daf Mem Heh of Shvuoth keeps on with oaths taken in order to be paid, and with the oath of a worker, which only takes effect where it is known that he was hired in the first place. The Jewish people are Hashem's workers; we have never abandoned that standing and never will, whatever we have to endure.

Jeremiah's forty-fifth chapter is about Baruch son of Neriah, and G-d rebukes him for being upset at not receiving prophecy. In the middle of such destruction he should not be thinking of himself, but should be grateful to have been saved from it. "You said, 'Woe is to me now, for the Lord has added grief to my pain. I have become weary with my sighing, but I have found no rest.'" Rashi: the Shechinah has not rested upon me to prophesy. And the answer: "Behold what I have built I will tear down, and what I planted I will uproot, and it is all the land. And you seek great things for yourself? Do not seek, for behold I am bringing evil upon all flesh, says the Lord, and I will give you your soul as prey in all the places where you will go." Baruch stood at a very high level, so a great deal more was expected of him. The lesson holds anyway: whatever the circumstances, we have to keep faith that everything we have endured is ultimately for the very best.

Week 45, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 314 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Tu B'Av - Psalms 133-135; 105:36-38; 89:46

The week of Tu B'Av in psalms: the hundred and thirty-third, hundred and thirty-fourth and hundred and thirty-fifth, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 133 is three verses and it is the verse of this season: "Behold, how good and how pleasant it is when brothers dwell together. Like the precious oil [placed] upon the head, flowing [in abundance] down the beard, the beard of Aaron which rests upon his garments. Like the dew of Hermon which comes down upon the mountains of Zion, for there the Lord has commanded blessing, life unto eternity."

Psalm 134 urges the scholarly and the pious to get up from their beds at night and go to the House of G-d. It is three verses too: “Behold: Bless the Lord, all you servants of the Lord who stand in the House of the Lord in the nights. Lift up your hands in holiness and bless the Lord. May the Lord, Who makes heaven and earth, bless you from Zion.”

Psalm 135 is longer and all praise. “For G-d has chosen Jacob for Himself, Israel as His beloved treasure.” What He does with the weather: “He causes mists to rise from the ends of the earth; He makes lightning for the rain; He brings forth the wind from His vaults.” What He did in Egypt, and then to the kings — Sichon king of the Amorites, Og king of Bashan, and all the kingdoms of Canaan — and then the land given as a heritage to His people Israel. Then the idols again, taken apart sense by sense: “They have a mouth, but cannot speak; they have eyes, but cannot see; they have ears, but cannot hear; nor is there breath in their mouth. Like them will their makers become-all who trust in them.” And the four houses called to bless: Israel, Aaron, Levi, and those who fear the Lord. “Blessed is the Lord from Zion, who dwells in Jerusalem.”

Psalm 105's verses are the last plague and the leaving: “And He smote every firstborn in their land, the first of all their strength. And He took them out with silver and gold, and there was no pauper among their tribes. Egypt rejoiced with their departure for their fear had fallen upon them.” And Psalm 89's verse is the youth cut short: “You have shortened the days of his youth; You have enwrapped him with shame forever.”

Week 45, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 315 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Creeping Creatures Are Saying

The creeping creatures open on rejoicing, and the week sets it against a quarrel over water.

The rejoicing and the unquenchable love first: “Let Israel rejoice in He Who made him” / “May G-d rejoice in His works” / “Many waters cannot quench the love” / “Nor can rivers flood it” / “Let the children of Zion be joyful in their King.”

Then the whole community moving, and the finishing of the song: “The entire community of the children of Israel journeyed” / “And Moses finished speaking all these words to all Israel” / “As soon as their ears hear, they obey me” / “And He smote every firstborn in their land” / “The first of all their strength” / “May the glory of G-d endure forever.”

Then Rephidim, with Amalek and the sin of the lads: “From the Desert of S’in to their travels” / “By the mandate of the Lord” / “They encamped in Rephidim” / “And Amalek, and those of the east” / “And they came up upon it” / “And the sin of the lads was great before the Lord” / “You have shortened the days of his youth” / “You have enwrapped him with shame forever.”

Then the thirst and the testing: “And there was no water for the people to drink” / “Strangers lie to me” / “'Why do you test the Lord?'” / “Should a man give all the property of his house for love” / “They would despise him” / “For the men despised the offering of the Lord” / “And they said, Give us water that we may drink” / “Moses said to them, 'Why do you quarrel with me?'”

And the end is Midian and the going out with silver and gold: “Because of Midian the children of Israel made for themselves” / “And it was, when Israel had sown, that Midian came up” / “So the people quarreled with Moses” / “And the hand of Midian prevailed against Israel” / “Egypt rejoiced with their departure” / “For their fear had fallen upon them” / “The dens which are in the mountains” / “And the caves and the strongholds” / “And He took them out with silver and gold” / “And there was no pauper among their tribes.”

Week 45, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XLVI

Netzach of Malchut

Days 316–322

Day 316 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Know Our Place in Order to Be Truly Happy

The Prolific Creeping Creatures are saying: "Your wife shall be like a fruitful vine in the recesses of your house; your children like olive shoots around your table." (Psalms 128:3) This is the last week of Av, and it holds the yahrzeit of the Rebbe's father, Rabbi Levi Yitzchak Schneerson, on the 20th of Av.

In the week after Tu B'Av, Perek Shirah is still on marriage and reproduction. Keeping the theme going says that love, marriage and building a home are not a single action or decision: the feeling that first brought a couple together has to be worked at and improved across a whole life, day by day, week by week, month by month, year by year.

The gematria of forty-six is Levi. Levi and Shimon were both men with an overwhelming capacity for violence and radical action, especially together: the two were responsible for killing the inhabitants of Shchem, and were the main actors in the kidnapping and sale of Joseph. The tribe of Levi turned those extreme qualities into good ones, using their zealousness on G-d's behalf, and became a tribe made up entirely of priests. In the end Shimon too will use all that strength and potential only for the good.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Matya the son of Charash: be first to greet every man, and be a tail to lions rather than a head to foxes. It is striking that this lesson falls in the last week of Av, whose sign is Leo, and a week from Rosh Chodesh, which means the head of the month. In the past Shimon and his tribe led actions that were fox-like; and the Tanach also recounts that in the end the tribe agreed to be the tail of a lion, the tribe of Judah. After Joshua's passing, when it was time to conquer the

rest of the Land, Judah was chosen to go first, and Judah turned to Shimon and asked it to follow: "Come up with me into my lot, and we will fight against the Canaanites, and I will also go with you into your lot." The Bnei Yissachar explains that the statement runs deeper, and connects the redemption of Passover, in Nissan, which is Judah, with the future redemption of Mashiach, born on Tisha B'Av, which is Shimon. On Passover we keep an egg on the Seder plate to remember the destruction that happened in Av; and in the final redemption, for all its unprecedented miracles, we will still remember the redemption from Egypt that happened in Nissan.

Likewise, under enormous Soviet pressure Rabbi Levi Yitzchak held firm to his values and refused to associate himself with the fox-like Communist leadership. His extreme care over the kashrut of the matzah he mass-produced for Passover shows that resolve, and his refusal to give in to Communist demands got him exiled to Siberia, where he passed away in this week of the year. It is known that the lion brings its tail to its head, and the fox brings its head to its tail — and today the Rebbe's father is still held in tremendous esteem as a leader, rabbi and scholar, while Soviet Communism is a completely outdated and bankrupt idea.

The combination is netzach shebemalchut. We have to be persistent in connecting ourselves to the King of kings and revealing Him in this material world. And the lesson from the prolific creeping creatures is that the humility this month of judgment gave us has to be put to use: to grow and multiply, like the vine and the olive tree.

Week 46, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 317 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Mordechai and the Quality of "Listens and Adds"

The last week of Av, and the yahrzeit of the Rebbe's father, Rabbi Levi Yitzchak Schneerson. Haazinu: "And he said to them, 'Set your hearts to all of the words which I bear witness for you this day, so that you may command your children to observe to do all the words of this Torah.'" (Deuteronomy 32:46) Hearing again — and Rashi notes that setting the heart also refers to the eyes and the ears, which belong to Tammuz and Av. Rav Levi Yitzchak was the perfect example of a man who set the words of the Torah to heart and trained his child, the Rebbe, with the utmost perfection; which is this week's creeping creatures and their children.

The other side of those creatures, total nullification and humility, is in the Haftorah verse: "The strangers will wilt, and become lame from their bondage." (II Samuel 22:46) The enemies wilting before King David.

The quality is listens and adds, shomeah umosif — the main tikkun of Av, the ability to listen properly and positively.

The prophet is Mordechai Bilshan, and Mordechai and the redemption of Purim are listening and adding themselves. Mordechai listened to a conversation of men who meant to assassinate King Achashverosh and reported it to Queen Esther, and the conspiracy fell apart. His words were added to the chronicles of the king, and later, when the future of the Jewish people hung in the balance, Achashverosh checked the chronicles and saw that Mordechai had saved him and had not been rewarded for it. That was the crucial turning point of the Megillah. And Esther's part in repeating Mordechai's words — and in attributing them to him by name — is later named as a quality that brings redemption. Mordechai is the last known prophet of the 48 the Talmud lists; Esther is the last female prophet, and comes in week 52.

The Levitical City is 'Ain, which means spring. A famous Ayin in Israel today is Ein Gedi, near the Dead Sea, among many other springs in the Land. A spring is the sign of something much deeper, coming up from far below the ground, and it takes close attention to notice — Ayin also means eye, a window into the soul. And 'Ayin is near the word Ayin spelled with an Alef, which means nothingness, and stands for nullification. Like the Prolific Creatures, our salvation comes from humility, from our sense of Ayin, as in the verse "Essah Eynai el heHarim, M'Ayin Yavoh Ezri" —

which can be read: I turn my eyes to the mountains, and my salvation comes from my sense of Ayin.

Week 46, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 318 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Handling Crisis with Humility and not Anger

Beshalach keeps on with the thirst, and now Moshe himself is in crisis: "The people thirsted there for water, and the people complained against Moses, and they said, Why have you brought us up from Egypt to make me and my children and my livestock die of thirst? Moses cried out to the Lord, saying, What shall I do for this people? Just a little longer and they will stone me!" He is criticised for believing the people could come to stone him.

The verses of the Tanach have their own crisis of sustenance: "And they encamped against them, and they destroyed the produce of the earth, until you come to Gaza. They would leave no sustenance in Israel, neither sheep, nor ox, nor donkey. For they and their cattle came up, and their tents, and they came as numerous as locusts; both they and their camels without number, and they came into the land to destroy it." Midian and Amalek again. Both passages belong to the suffering of Av, which is meant to bring us to humility and repentance.

Daf Mem Vav of Sotah keeps on with the Eglah Arufah, the qualifications of the calf itself, and the importance of escorting people out of a city. It turns on Elisha, who, had he been escorted out, would not have set bears on 42 youngsters. That city had a serious water problem and he had just remedied its water, and the miracle made the boys' water-carrying work useless; so they insulted him, and that brought the response. Like Moshe, Elisha is criticised for not controlling his anger.

The generation is Ahaz, son of Jotham, a truly terrible king — weak and extremely idolatrous, and he did tremendous damage; through his weakness and subservience to other kings the treasures of the Temple were looted. His rule was contemporary with Hoshea ben Elah and Pekah in Israel. Ahaz means to grasp, to hold — and instead of holding tight to Hashem and relying on His mercy, he tried to hold on to everyone and everything else.

The forty-sixth week goes with conquering the Cana'anites, who belong to the negative side of the fourth sefirah, Netzach, victory. Their name comes from Cana'an, whose root is Canah, from the verb to subdue. Cana'an is also the fourth son of Cham, cursed by Noah for Cham's disgraceful behaviour, which made it impossible for Noah to have a fourth son of his own; Cham's motive in essentially castrating his father was that he did not want to share the world with any other progeny of Noah. He wanted to rule as much as he could, with no competition — which is the negative side of Netzach: angry, recalcitrant, fixed on winning, unwilling to see another person's view. The Cana'anites were given the chance to surrender and none of them took it. All seven nations in the Land are called Cana'anites, so this group being named for Cana'an seems to say that it somehow holds the qualities of all seven — and Netzach too is said to hold the qualities of all the other Sefirot.

Week 46, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 319 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Serving G-d with Strength

The verse is the boy at his work: "And Samuel was serving before the Lord, being a lad girded with a linen robe." Girding is a word of strength, and the linen ephod is a sign of his holiness and his growth.

The Pirkei Avot quality becoming to the righteous and to the world is exactly that: strength. Again, not any strength, but the kind that stays firm in serving G-d, in order to serve Him as well as possible.

Chapter 2 of the Song of Songs opens on strength of a particular kind — staying strong under attack, and going on serving with beauty and holiness. "I am a rose of Sharon, a rose of the valleys." Rashi: this is prettier than the rose of the mountains because it is always moist, since the sun has no strength there. "As a rose among the thorns, so is my beloved among the daughters." Rashi: as a rose among the thorns, which pierce it and it stays constant in its beauty and its redness, so is my beloved among the daughters — they entice her to stray after strange gods as they do, and she remains firm in her faith.

The week holds the yahrzeits of Rabbi Levi Yitzhak Schneerson, father of the Lubavitcher Rebbe, on the 20th of Av, and Rabbi Aharon of Belz, the fourth Rebbe

of Belz, on the 21st. Rabbi Levi Yitzchak was considered by the Rebbe Reshab to be one of his three greatest chassidim. An outstanding scholar and a leading Kabbalist of his generation, he was Chief Rabbi of the major Ukrainian city Yekaterinoslav, today called Dniepropetrovsk, until his arrest and exile. His extensive writings from exile, crammed into the margins of his books, were rescued, smuggled out, brought to his son, and are being published in a multi-volume set called Toldot Levi Yitzchak. Rabbi Aharon of Belz, the fourth rebbe of that dynasty, was considered one of the purest holy men of his generation; in 1944 he miraculously escaped the Nazis and moved to Israel, where after a brief time in Jerusalem he set up his court in Tel Aviv. The current Belzer Rebbe, who has built a huge centre in Jerusalem, is his nephew. Also this week: Rabbi Yaakov Culi, author of the Meam Loez, on the 19th of Av, and Rabbi Meir Hagadol of Premishlan on the 22nd.

Week 46, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 320 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Enduring Through Vulnerable Times

The Song's verse is a sister not yet grown: "We have a little sister who has no breasts; what shall we do for our sister on the day she is spoken for?" Rashi explains that her time for redemption has not yet come — a vulnerable position, which leaves us open to attack. Which is the Jewish experience in Av, and the difficulties the Rebbe's father endured. In the end our situation will improve and we will be redeemed.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the forty-sixth is Briah, whose name means cut down, cropped. And with him Dan, whose name comes from Din, judgement. We are near the end of the period of stern judgement, in which we have been cut down and humbled.

Daf Mem Vav of Shvuot keeps on with the oaths of a worker, and again with someone entering another's house without permission, and someone injured — still the tragic events of Av. And the daf ends by opening a discussion of who is disqualified from taking oaths, such as those who have sworn falsely before, which looks like the beginning of Teshuvah and of our need to change, the central theme of Elul.

Jeremiah's forty-sixth chapter is the downfall of Egypt, which will be cut down and paid back for its sins, so that the Jewish people, so long open to attack, will not have to live in fear. The focus turns to the other nations and their faults. Rebbe Nachman teaches that each gentile nation is associated with a particular impurity, and as we come to Elul and begin correcting our ways we take one source of impurity at a time. "They will cut down her forest, says the Lord, for they are innumerable, for they are more numerous than locusts and they are uncountable. The daughter of Egypt has been put to shame; she has been delivered into the hand[s] of the people of the north." And then the promise, which is the end of the chapter: "You fear not, O Jacob My servant, and be not dismayed, O Israel! for behold, I will redeem you from afar and your children from the land of their captivity, and Jacob shall return and be quiet and at ease, and there shall be none who disturb his rest. You fear not, My servant Jacob, says the Lord, for I am with you, for I will make a full end of all the nations where I have driven you, but of you I will not make a full end, but I will chastise you justly, and I will not completely destroy you."

Week 46, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 321 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Last Week of Av - Psalms 136-138; 105:39-41; 89:47

The last week of Av in psalms: the hundred and thirty-sixth, hundred and thirty-seventh and hundred and thirty-eighth, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

The first of them has twenty-six verses, for the twenty-six generations between the creation of the world and the giving of the Torah, and every one of them ends the same way: for His kindness is forever. It runs from the making of the heavens and the spreading of the earth above the waters, through the great lights, the sun to rule by day and the moon and stars by night; then Egypt struck through its firstborn and Israel brought out with a strong hand and an outstretched arm; then the Sea of Reeds split into sections and Israel brought across and Pharaoh cast in; then the desert, and the great kings struck down, Sichon of the Amorites and Og of Bashan, and their land given as a heritage to Israel His servant. And then the two verses that make the whole of it personal: "Who remembered us in our humiliation, for His kindness is

forever. And redeemed us from our oppressors, for His kindness is forever." And the last: "Who gives food to all flesh, for His kindness is forever. Praise the G-d of heaven, for His kindness is forever."

Psalm 137 is the time of the destruction, when Nebuchadnezzar would ask the Levites to sing in captivity as they had in the Temple, and they would answer, how can we sing the song of G-d upon alien soil — and they were then comforted by Divine inspiration. "By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat and wept as we remembered Zion. There, upon the willows, we hung our harps. For there our captors demanded of us songs, and those who scorned us-rejoicing, [saying,] 'Sing to us of the songs of Zion.' How can we sing the song of the Lord on alien soil?" Then the oath on himself: "If I forget you, Jerusalem, let my right hand forget [its dexterity]. Let my tongue cleave to my palate if I will not remember you, if I will not bring to mind Jerusalem during my greatest joy!" And the asking at the end: "Remember, O Lord, against the Edomites the day of [the destruction of] Jerusalem, when they said, 'Raze it, raze it to its very foundation!'"

Psalm 138 is David's praise for the kindness shown him and for the promise of kingship kept. "I will thank You with all my heart, in the presence of princes I shall praise You. I will bow toward Your Holy Sanctuary, and praise Your Name for Your kindness and for Your truth; for You have exalted Your word above all Your Names. On the day that I called out You answered me, You emboldened me, [You put] strength in my soul." Then the eye that notices: "For though the Lord is exalted, He sees the lowly; the High One castigates from afar." And the asking: "If I walk in the midst of distress, keep me alive." And the last line: "Lord, complete [Your kindness] on my behalf. Lord, Your kindness is forever, do not forsake the work of Your hands."

Psalm 105's verses are the shelter and the water: "He spread out a cloud for shelter, and fire to illuminate the night. They asked, and He brought quails, and the bread of heaven sated them. He opened a rock and water flowed; in the deserts ran rivers." And Psalm 89's verse asks the question of these weeks: "How long, O Lord? Will You hide forever? Will Your anger burn like fire?"

Week 46, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 322 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Prolific Creeping Creatures Are Saying

The prolific creeping creatures open, and the week sets a household against a thirst.

The little sister and the fruitful vine first: “We have a little sister who has no breasts” / “What shall we do for our sister on the day she is spoken for?” / “Your wife shall be like a fruitful vine in the recesses of your house” / “Your children like olive shoots around your table” / “So that you may command your children” / “To observe to do all the words of this Torah” / “And Samuel was serving before the Lord” / “Being a lad girded with a linen robe.”

Then the thirst, and the camels without number: “The people thirsted there for water” / “And the people complained against Moses” / “Both they and their camels without number” / “And they came into the land to destroy it” / “And they said, 'Why have you brought us up from Egypt To make me and my children and my livestock die of thirst?'” / “The strangers will wilt, And become lame from their bondage.”

Then the produce destroyed, and the cry of a leader: “And they encamped against them, And they destroyed the produce of the earth” / “Until you come to Gaza” / “Moses cried out to the Lord” / “Saying, 'What shall I do for this people?'” / “Just a little longer and they will stone me!” / “They would leave no sustenance in Israel” / “Neither sheep, nor ox, nor donkey.”

And the end is the cloud and the rock: “He spread out a cloud for shelter” / “And fire to illuminate the night” / “For they and their cattle came up, and their tents” / “And they came as numerous as locusts” / “They asked, and He brought quails, and the bread of heaven sated them” / “He opened a rock and water flowed; in the deserts ran rivers” / “And he said to them, set your hearts to all of the words” / “Which I bear witness for you this day.”

Week 46, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XLVII

Hod of Malchut

Days 323–329

Day 323 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

Time for Teshuvah (Return to G-d)!

The snake is saying, "G-d supports all the fallen, and straightens all the bent." (Psalms 145:14) This week is Rosh Chodesh Elul, and Elul's whole character is teshuvah.

The Alter Rebbe explains that the King spends most of the year inside his palace, where it is harder to reach him, and that in Elul the King goes out to the field to speak to His people and to listen to them, greeting everyone with a smiling countenance. In Elul we can have far more direct contact with Him by increasing our study, our prayer, our repentance and our good deeds — and through teshuvah and asking forgiveness we can prepare properly for Rosh Hashanah.

Elul belongs to the tribe of Gad, a powerful and courageous tribe whose name means luck — and the point of the name is that the Jewish people stand entirely above luck and chance: everything depends on our teshuvah. So it is fitting that the animal of this week is the snake, which from the story of Creation onward has always been associated with sin and the evil inclination, and whose verse is the spirit of teshuvah exactly.

Forty-seven is the gematria of Yoel. The Book of Joel has many parallels to Elul: like several of the prophets it speaks deeply about the need for repentance, and Joel specifically about teshuvah before the great day of judgment. It also describes the people's closeness to G-d and mentions the sound of the shofar many times — and through almost the whole of Elul we blow the shofar every day after prayer, preparing for the Day of Judgment.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yaakov: this world is comparable to the antechamber before the World to Come, so prepare yourself in the antechamber in order to enter the banquet hall. He also says that a single moment of repentance and good deeds in this world is greater than all of the World to Come, and that a single moment of bliss in the World to Come is greater than all of the present world. Which suits Rosh Chodesh Elul, when teshuvah begins: as this world is the ante-room of the next, Elul is the preparation for Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur.

The combination is hod shebemalchut. It is time to bring our service of Hashem to fruition in a real and tangible way. And the lesson from the snake is that even if we fall to the lowest levels there are, we can still repent and be forgiven and lifted up.

Week 47, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 324 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Mashiach ben Yosef and Learning in Order to Teach

Rosh Chodesh Elul, the month of teshuvah, which belongs to the tribe of Gad — a strong tribe, and a standing argument that a Jew's fate is not fixed in advance but depends on his return to G-d. Haazinu says it: "For it is not an empty thing for you, for it is your life, and through this thing, you will lengthen your days upon the land to which you are crossing over the Jordan, to possess it." (Deuteronomy 32:47)

The Haftorah keeps the focus on life: "The Lord lives, and blessed be my Rock; And exalted be the G-d, [who is] my rock of salvation." (II Samuel 22:47) It begins with the Lord lives, and says that clinging to the Rock is what saves. Life matters in Elul, which prepares for the Day of Judgment. For chassidim Elul also holds Chai Elul, the Life of Elul, the birthdays of the Baal Shem Tov and the Alter Rebbe — and the Alter Rebbe said that in Elul we feel the King is in the field; which is to say, we feel how alive He is.

The quality is learns in order to teach, lomed al menat lelamed. Only being ready to teach makes what we learned alive. Kabbalah teaches that this is the difference between the Dead Sea, which receives water and gives none, and the Sea of Galilee, which is full of life because it receives and also gives to the Jordan. In Chassidism Torah is compared to water for just this reason, because it runs from a high place to a low one. And it is usually only when you are ready to teach that you find out whether

you learned anything at all: even before students ask questions and sharpen you, taking information in while hoping to pass it on is far more active. Which suits Rosh Chodesh Elul, because Teshuvah is first of all self-evaluation and active learning. In Elul the King is in the field, out of His castle among His subjects, and it is time for us to go out to the field and talk to Him — and in order to know what to say, and to put our confession into words, we need this quality of learning in order to teach, even where the only one who needs teaching is ourselves.

In his list of the 48 prophets Rashi says he does not know the 47th or the 48th. That is also where he says that if one does not count Daniel a prophet, one should include Shemayah — which looks inconsistent, since in the same breath he says two are missing from his list and then adds an extra one in case prophet number 38 should not count. There is more to this than meets the eye, and this book humbly suggests that prophets 47 and 48 are Mashiach Ben Yosef and Mashiach Ben David: prophets unknown to Rashi in the sense that they had not yet come into the world. Rabbeinu Chananel states that the two missing are Oded and Chanani, both of whom are mentioned alongside children who are specifically called prophets, and the Vilna Gaon supports that view. What is interesting is that those two names belong to the two Mashiachs. Chananiah is one of the names the Talmud gives for Mashiach ben David. Oded comes from Od, to increase, like Yosef, whose name is also from adding: naming him, Rachel said, "Yoseph Hashem ben acher," may Hashem add for me another son — and the Yalkut Shimoni explains that ben acher also means ben acharono shel olam, one who will come at the end of time, the meshu'ach milchamah, the anointed one of war, a descendant of Yosef. There is also the well-known verse "Od Yosef Chai," Yosef is still alive; and Yosef asks his brothers, "HaOd Avi Chai?", is my father still alive?

Mashiach ben Yosef belongs to this week's animal too. The word for snake, nachash, has the same numerical value as Mashiach, and Mashiach comes to remove the impurities the snake introduced. Yosef was thrown into an empty pit without water, which Rashi explains to mean it had no water and did have snakes and scorpions. He withstood the seduction of Potiphar's wife, and sexual sin is the prime example of the snake's hot venom, against the cold venom of the scorpion, which comes next week; he kept his foundation, and is called Yosef HaTzadik. Later, still pretending not to know his brothers, he says, "Haloh Yedatem Ki Nachesh

Yenachesh Ish Asher Kamoni," usually translated as, did you not know that a man like me performs divination — and which can also be read: did you not know that a man like me, Mashiach, will be able to fight the power of the snake? And in the Torah it is Yosef who has the power to fight Esau, who in Kabbalah is the embodiment of the supernal snake. Mashiach ben Yosef will withstand the hot venom of those who stand in the way of G-d being revealed in this low world. The quality of Mashiach is also a teacher's, and this week's: his teachings will be so lofty that he will even teach the Patriarchs, and he will also reach the simplest of Jews. The greatest example of a life that held the ideals of Mashiach ben Yosef is the Frierdiker Rebbe, the Rebbe Yosef Yitzchak, and the Rebbe wrote extensively on how his life paralleled Yosef's. He faced down the evil powers of Esau, in Communism and to some extent Nazism, and prevailed; the values he championed are alive today and Chabad Chassidism is alive and well, where Communism and Nazism are essentially dead. The Rebbe Rayatz also pressed this very quality: learning in order to teach, and teaching every Jew — if you know the Alef-Beis, teach it to your fellow Jew.

The levitical city for this week is unknown too. It is one of the additional cities to be added on the other side of the Jordan once Mashiach comes and the borders of Israel are widened — and the tribe of Gad, which is Elul, has its own territory on that side of the river.

Week 47, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 325 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Hezekiah and Teshuvah

Rosh Chodesh Elul, the month of teshuvah. Beshalach gets water out of stone: "And the Lord said to Moses, Pass before the people and take with you [some] of the elders of Israel, and take into your hand your staff, with which you struck the Nile, and go. Behold, I shall stand there before you on the rock in Horeb, and you shall strike the rock, and water will come out of it, and the people will drink Moses did so before the eyes of the elders of Israel." Drawing water from a rock is teshuvah: even if our sins have made us dry as a rock, with the right striking the water, which is Torah, still comes out.

The verses of the Tanach say the same: “And Israel was very impoverished because of Midian, and the children of Israel cried to the Lord. Now it was when the children of Israel cried to the Lord concerning Midian.” Impoverished by Midian, they cried out in teshuvah.

Daf Mem Zayin of Sotah keeps on with Elisha’s actions, including toward Gechazi, and with what Yehoshua ben Prachai did to his wayward student. Both men were said to have been overly strict, and so made teshuvah hard for the other. The daf also takes up the beheading of the calf where there are witnesses against the murderer, and whether the calf atones for him; and it ends by describing the decline in righteousness and in Torah — all of it teshuvah.

The generation is King Hezekiah, the ultimate example of it: the Jewish people reached tremendous heights through his own personal teshuvah. He famously said that he had a tradition from his ancestor King David that even with a knife at one’s throat one does not despair, and should go on doing teshuvah and praying for mercy. His teshuvah saved him from a heavenly death sentence for not wanting children — he knew his progeny would be wicked — and saved the whole kingdom from Sancheriv, the evil Assyrian general who had conquered the northern Kingdom. Before the north fell, Hezekiah’s counterpart was Hoshea ben Elah, who, for all his misdeeds, showed an element of teshuvah in letting the people of the north pray in the Temple in Jerusalem. Hezekiah’s name means G-d is my strength.

The forty-seventh week goes with conquering the Perizites, whose name looks to come from Prazi, an unwalled city. Which is teshuvah: going past our borders, past our natural limits, being open to change. Our sages teach that nothing can stand in the way of teshuvah. The Perizites belong to the negative side of Hod, which is service and acknowledgement, and whose negative side is being too passive and too self-effacing — and also frivolity and idolatry, being too tolerant of people and ideas that damage us and others. King David met that with his son Absalom: his self-effacing efforts to appease him and bring him back to court were misread, and in the end Absalom mounted a rebellion against his own father.

Week 47, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 326 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

The Purpose of Wealth

The verse is a mother's yearly gift: "And a small robe his mother would make for him, and she would bring it up to him from appointed time to appointed time, when she ascended with her husband, to slaughter the sacrifice of the (festive) days." Shmuel's beautiful robe, arriving every year, stands for serving Hashem from a position of wealth, and for his continued growth despite the potentially bad influence of Eli's sons.

The Pirkei Avot quality becoming to the righteous and to the world is wealth, Osher. The righteous use their wealth and their materials to serve G-d.

Chapter 3 of the Song of Songs ends on serving out of wealth, which defined King Solomon's reign: "King Solomon made himself a palanquin of the trees of Lebanon. Its pillars he made of silver, its couch of gold, its curtain of purple, its interior inlaid with love, from the daughters of Jerusalem. Go out, O daughters of Zion, and gaze upon King Solomon, upon the crown with which his mother crowned him on the day of his nuptials and on the day of the joy of his heart." The crown his mother made him recalls the robe Chanah made for Shmuel. Rashi explains that both the crown and the palanquin point to the Tent of Meeting, and reads the materials: its couch of gold, His couch and His dwelling were on the Ark cover, which is gold; its curtain of purple, this is the dividing curtain, which hangs and rides on poles from pillar to pillar; its interior inlaid, arranged with a floor of love — the Ark with an Ark cover, cherubim, and Tablets.

The week holds the yahrzeits of two prominent Chassidic rebbes who established their courts in America after the war: Rabbi Yoel Teitelbaum, the Satmar Rebbe, on the 26th of Av, and Rabbi Eliezer Zusia Portugal, the Skulener Rebbe, on the 29th. Rabbi Yoel Teitelbaum miraculously escaped Bergen-Belsen in 1944 and went to the Holy Land, and in 1947 moved to the USA, where he established himself as the Satmar Rebbe in the Williamsburg section of Brooklyn, doing extensive work building Torah education networks. Famed as the leader of Hungarian Jewry and of the largest Chassidic group in the world, and as the spiritual leader of the opposition to a secular-based Jewish government in Israel, he was also one of the greatest Torah scholars of his generation. Rebbe Eliezer Zusia Portugal, the Skulener Rebbe,

immigrated to the USA in 1960 after imprisonment in Rumania and international efforts to secure his release. He wrote Noam Eliezer and Kedushas Eliezer and was a prominent follower of the Shtefaneshter Rebbe, and he is best known for superhuman efforts to rescue Jewish orphans and refugees in Eastern Europe before, during and after WWII, and for going on supporting them, and for his Chessed L'Avraham network of schools for children, which continues today. Those who merited to be in his presence were astonished by the length of his prayers and by the beauty and intensity of the tunes he composed, many of which are internationally famous now. The week also holds two prominent figures of Ger: Rabbi Avraham Mordechai Alter, son of the Chidushei HaRim and father of the Sfas Emes, on the 27th of Av, and Rabbi Menachem Mendel Alter, son of the Sfas Emes, on the 29th.

Week 47, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 327 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Serach and the Month of Virgo

Rosh Chodesh Elul, the month of Teshuvah, whose sign is Virgo. The Song's verse speaks of the Jewish people as a young girl: "If she be a wall, we will build upon her a silver turret, and if she be a door, we will enclose her with cedar boards." Rashi makes the connection to Elul plainer, and makes it about keeping, or regaining, chastity. If she be a wall: if she is strong in her faith and her fear, to be against them like a copper wall, so that they do not enter her midst — meaning she will not intermarry with them, and they will not come into her, and she will not be seduced by them. We will build upon her a silver turret: we will be to her as a fortified city, and for a crown and for beauty, and we will build for her the Holy City and the chosen Temple. And if she be a door: which turns on its hinges, and when one knocks on it, it opens — she too, if she opens for them so that they enter her. We will enclose her with cedar boards: we will put into her door wooden boards which rot and which the worm gnaws and eats.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the forty-seventh is Serach — fittingly a woman, one of very few in this counting. Stories about her abound, among them that she was one of the few who knew the secrets of the redemption and so could identify Moshe as the redeemer. She is best known for the Midrash that she

was the one who told Jacob the news that Joseph was alive, and told it in such a way that he could take it in without dying of shock; for that she was granted eternal life. Her name looks related to Sarah's, with a Chet instead of a Heh — and Chet is near Cheit, sin, and also near the ability to repent and repair the past. The numerical value of Chet is eight, which belongs to what is above nature: teshuvah, and the Messianic age. And with her Chushim, whose name means senses, which is striking, since it is said that he was deaf — and it was because of his deafness that he was able to kill Esau. In Elul we work on correcting the sins we committed with each of our senses.

Daf Mem Zayin of Shvuot keeps on with those disqualified from taking oaths, and mentions orphans who cannot take one, and people who are clearly lying. And there is a discussion of an oath returning to its place, returning to Mt. Sinai — mainly about Heavenly punishment for those who take advantage and steal, and it also reads as Teshuvah.

Jeremiah's forty-seventh chapter is people crying out, and the downfall of the Philistines; as last week, each gentile nation is associated with a particular impurity. "So said the Lord: Behold water is coming up from the north, and it shall become a flooding stream and will inundate a land and the fullness thereof, a city and those who dwell therein, and the people shall cry out, and all the inhabitants of the land shall wail." Then the noise of it: "From the sound of the stamping of the hoofs of his mighty ones, from the noise of his chariots, the stirring of his wheels; fathers did not turn to sons out of [the] feebleness of [their] hands." And then the sword addressed directly: "Ho! Sword of the Lord, how long will you not be silent? Go into your sheath, rest and be silent." And the answer: "How shall you be silent when the Lord commanded it?"

Week 47, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 328 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Rosh Chodesh Elul - Psalms 139-141; 105:42-44; 89:48

The week of Rosh Chodesh Elul in psalms: the hundred and thirty-ninth, hundred and fortieth and hundred and forty-first, with three verses of Psalm 105 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 139 is about being known. “O Lord, You have probed me, and You know. You know my sitting down and my standing up; You perceive my thought from afar. You encircle my going about and my lying down; You are familiar with all my paths. For there was not yet a word on my tongue-and behold, Lord, You knew it all.” Then the nowhere to go: “Where can I go [to escape] Your spirit? And where can I flee from Your presence? If I ascend to the heavens, You are there; if I make my bed in the grave, behold, You are there. Were I to take up wings as the dawn and dwell in the furthest part of the sea, there, too, Your hand would guide me.” And the dark that is not dark: “Were I to say, 'Surely the darkness will shadow me,' then the night would be as light around me.” Then the making of a person: “For You created my mind; You covered me in my mother’s womb. I will thank You, for I was formed in an awesome and wondrous way.” “Your eyes beheld my raw form; all [happenings] are inscribed in Your book, even those to be formed in future days-to Him they are the same.” And then the last two verses, which are the whole month in one request: “Search me, Lord, and know my heart; test me and know my thoughts. See if there is a vexing way in me, then lead me in the way of the world.”

Psalm 140 asks to be got away from violent men. “Rescue me from the evil man, protect me from the man of violence, who devise evil schemes in their heart; every day they gather for wars. They sharpen their tongues like a serpent; the spider’s venom is forever under their lips.” The traps: “Arrogant ones have hidden a snare for me, and ropes; they spread a net by my path, they set traps for me continually.” And what he knows: “I know that the Lord will execute judgment for the poor, justice for the needy.”

Psalm 141 is a prayer offered in place of an offering, and it asks for a guard on the mouth. “Let my prayer be set forth as incense before You, the raising of my hands as an afternoon offering. O Lord, place a guard for my mouth, keep watch over the door of my lips. Do not incline my heart to a bad thing-to perform deeds in wickedness, with men, doers of evil; let me not partake of their delicacies.” And then the line that belongs to Elul: “Let the righteous one strike me with kindness and let him rebuke me; like the finest oil, let my head not refuse it.”

Psalm 105's verses are the promise kept and the going out: “For He remembered His holy word with Abraham His servant. And He took out His people with joy, His chosen ones with joyful singing. And He gave them lands of nations, and they

inherited the toil of kingdoms." And Psalm 89's verse asks what a life is for: "I am mindful what my old age is; for what futility have You created all the sons of man?"

Week 47, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 329 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Snake is Saying

The snake opens, and the week sets the question of a life against the straightening of the bent.

The old age and the wall first: "I am mindful what my old age is" / "For what futility have You created all the sons of man?" / "If she be a wall, we will build upon her a silver turret" / "And if she be a door, we will enclose her with cedar boards" / "For it is not an empty thing for you, for it is your life" / "And through this thing, you will lengthen your days" / "For He remembered His holy word with Abraham His servant."

Then the small robe, and the crying out: "And a small robe his mother would make for him" / "And the children of Israel cried to the Lord" / "Now it was when the children of Israel cried to the Lord concerning Midian" / "When she ascended with her husband, to slaughter the sacrifice of the (festive) days" / "And she would bring it up to him from appointed time to appointed time" / "G-d supports all the fallen, and straightens all the bent."

Then the staff, and the crossing: "And take into your hand your staff" / "With which you struck the Nile, and go" / "Upon the land to which you are crossing over the Jordan, to possess it" / "And He took out His people with joy, His chosen ones with joyful singing."

And the end is the rock struck, and the Rock blessed: "And the Lord said to Moses, Pass before the people" / "And take with you [some] of the elders of Israel" / "Moses did so before the eyes of the elders of Israel" / "And Israel was very impoverished because of Midian" / "And He gave them lands of nations" / "And they inherited the toil of kingdoms" / "Behold, I shall stand there before you on the rock in Horeb" / "And you shall strike the rock, and water will come out of it, and the people will drink" / "The Lord lives, and blessed be my Rock" / "And exalted be the G-d, [who is] my rock of salvation."

Week 47, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XLVIII

Yesod of Malchut

Days 330–336

Day 330 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Fight Coldness with Warmth

The Scorpion is saying, "G-d is good to all, and His mercy is upon all of His handiwork." (Psalms 145:9) This week holds the second day of Rosh Chodesh Elul. The scorpion carries a heavy load of transgression, and so thanks G-d for His mercy toward it.

Spiritually its venom is worse than the snake's. The snake's venom is hot, which is passion and desire for forbidden things; the scorpion's is cold, which is indifference. It is far easier to turn a passion for the forbidden toward something good than to redirect indifference. And indifference can be treated too, through the study of Torah. We see it in the purification of the metzorah, one afflicted with a form of spiritual leprosy through slander or other such behaviour. The Torah ends that section with "zot Torat hametzorah," this is the Torah of the metzorah, and the Alter Rebbe asks why the word Torah is used where it should simply have said this is the purification of the metzorah. Because the Torah is his purification.

Forty-eight is the number of qualities Pirkei Avot lists for acquiring the Torah. It is also the number of male prophets, and the number of Levitical cities the Torah names explicitly. All three have at least this in common: each of them stands for the Torah itself. The letters mem and chet spell mo'ach, brain. The intellect is the main conduit for taking the Torah in, and it is also usually associated with coolness — and inverting the two letters spells cham, hot. Perhaps that is another hint at how to fight coldness: at times one has to let go of the intellect, even briefly, to turn indifference into a heated desire for Torah and mitzvot.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Shimon the son of Elazar: do not appease your friend at the height of his anger; do not comfort him while his dead still lies before him; do not ask him about his vow the moment he makes it; and do not endeavor to see him at the time of his degradation. That is the inverse of the scorpion's song, because it describes a person overheated by emotion, when any attempt to step in, even to help, would most likely do harm. In those situations it is better to use the intellect coldly and keep a distance for now — so the cold qualities of the scorpion can be put to good use.

His words also describe part of the teshuvah of Elul. At first, in the heat of Rosh Chodesh Elul, we might think we can repent of everything and transform ourselves in a single moment. That is certainly possible, and usually the teshuvah that works is the one carried over a longer stretch — which is why we do it gradually across the whole month, to stay firm in the resolve all the way to Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur.

The combination is yesod shebemalchut. This week we strengthen our foundation in order to do teshuvah, and so establish His kingship in this world further. And the lesson from the scorpion is that we have both the ability and the responsibility to reach people who are far from the Torah, and to show them the warmth and the beauty of Judaism.

Week 48, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 331 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Mashiach Ben David and Learning in Order to Practice

The second week of Elul, which also holds the second day of Rosh Chodesh. Haazinu: "And the Lord spoke to Moses on that very day, saying," (Deuteronomy 32:48) Elul is about understanding that we live in the present, and that the changes are to be made now, for a better judgment on Rosh Hashanah. The Haftorah verse is in the present too, unlike most of the rest of it, which is past or future: "The G-d who takes vengeance for me; And brings down peoples under me." (II Samuel 22:48)

The quality carries last week's further: learns in order to practice, lomed al menat la'asot. Our Teshuvah in Elul has to end in a change in actual deed.

As last week, Rashi calls this week's prophet unknown. Rabbeinu Chananel and the Vilna Gaon say it is Chanani, of whom we know nothing except that he was the father of another prophet. And as last week, it is highly improbable that Rashi knew only 46 of the 48, especially since he suggests adding Shemayah in case Daniel should not count — so there is a distinct possibility that these two unknown prophets are called that because they had not yet come in Rashi's time: Mashiach Ben Yosef and Mashiach Ben David. One of the names given for Mashiach Ben David is Chanina. Another sage of that name, Chanina Ben Dosa, is the Talmud's standing example of a Tzadik Yesod Olam, the righteous one who is the foundation of the whole world: the whole world is nourished because of Chanina, and for Chanina one measure of carob is enough from Sabbath eve to the next. Chanina comes from chen, which carries both mercy and grace. Rebbe Nachman teaches that Mashiach's main weapon is prayer, and we learn how to pray from Chanah, whose name also comes from chen. And for all of Mashiach's focus on prayer and on teaching Torah, the Messianic times come when the reality we live in changes physically — which is the essence of malchut, and of King David himself, who was involved in physically turning the world for the better. As the Rebbe always said: HaMa'aseh Hu Ha'Ikar, the main thing is the deed. Which is this week's quality.

This week's animal is the scorpion, the evil inclination of coldness and indifference — and likely Amalek too, who strikes at the tail of the camp, meaning those least connected to the Torah, with its tail: "Remember what Amalek did to you on the way as you went out of Egypt. Who met you on the way and attacked the weak ones, who were straggling after you, and you were faint and weary and did not fear G-d." Rabbi Avraham Kahn explains that the Hebrew word for meeting here can also be translated as cooling: the nations were afraid of the Jewish people, and the cynicism of Amalek cooled them down. Rashi compares the cynic to someone jumping into a hot bath: he got burned, and he cooled it for others, proving it was survivable — and Amalek jumped in for no reason except to cool the Jewish people down. Where Mashiach ben Yosef's task is fighting the hot impurity of the snake, Mashiach ben David's looks more like fighting the coldness of the scorpion, though the two are clearly related. Rabbi Ginsburgh explains the scorpion: our sages teach that it is the deadliest of the poisonous creatures whose archetype is the primordial snake of Eden; the Hebrew for scorpion derives from the word for heel, as in "And

you shall bite him at the heel," so the scorpion is the consummate bite of the snake at the heel of man. The poison of the snake is hot and the scorpion's is cold, and Mashiach is the one and only soul who can overcome, kill and ultimately revive the primordial snake in order to convert it to good — his soul and his continuous state of consciousness being the ultimate rectification of heat, burning only in his love for G-d and Israel, and of cold, absolutely cold to the false vanities of this world. Which is the secret of the gematria that Mashiach equals snake. Every quality can be used for good or bad: love and fear, passion and indifference all have their place.

It is worth setting these two weeks against an earlier passage of Pirkei Avot. Rabbi Eliezer would say: the honor of your fellow should be as precious to you as your own, and do not be easy to anger; repent one day before your death; warm yourself by the fire of the sages, and beware lest you be burned by its embers, for their bite is the bite of a fox, their sting is the sting of a scorpion, their hiss is the hiss of a serpent, and all their words are like fiery coals. Repent one day before your death — and since nobody knows when that is, repentance belongs to every day, and to Elul above all. Then he turns to connecting with the sages, and to being careful in those dealings. As the Talmud says, if one merits it the Torah is an elixir of life, and if one does not merit it the Torah becomes a potion of death — said of one who studies without proper fear of G-d, who is cold and indifferent, like the scorpion, like Amalek.

Both weeks 47 and 48 hold a day of Rosh Chodesh, the head of the month, which almost never happens twice in a row in the year — and that matches the two heads of the Jewish people, Mashiach Ben Yosef and Mashiach Ben David. The duality runs through the calendar and through the people and their two prototypical leaders, Judah and Joseph. Judah is Nissan; Tishrei belongs to Ephraim, Joseph's son, and Cheshvan to his other son, Menashe. The tension between Judah and Joseph is plain in how the Torah sets their parallel stories side by side, and in their direct confrontation in Vayigash. Even their names are close, since Joseph is sometimes called Yehosef, carrying the first three letters of Hashem's name, as Judah does. The tension runs on through our history: King David and King Shaul, the two kingdoms of Judah and Israel, and in the end two Mashiachs, ben David and ben Yosef, also called Mashiach ben Ephraim. Rabbi Moshe Wolfsohn explains that the same division shows in the differences between Chassidic and Lithuanian Jewry, and

similar ones seem to run between Ashkenazim and Sephardim, and between baalei teshuvah and tzadikim gemurim — Joseph being the prototype of the tzadik gamur and Judah of the baal teshuvah. Ezekiel's vision of the Holy Chariot has a lion on the right, Judah's symbol, and an ox on the left, Joseph's; and the same prophet, in the haftorah of Vayigash, is told to take one stick for Judah and one for Ephraim and join them together, for the day when Yosef and Yehudah will be completely one. The calendar holds another duality and synthesis: its days follow both the sun and the moon. The West's calendar is purely solar and the Islamic one purely lunar, and the Jewish calendar has both — each month follows the moon, and the year often holds two months of Adar so that Passover always falls in spring. Here too Joseph is associated mainly with the year as a whole, countering Esau, and Judah with the lunar months, countering Yishmael.

The greatest life example of Mashiach Ben David is the Rebbe, Menachem Mendel Schneerson. He changed the face of world Jewry, rescuing so many from the cold forces of assimilation and the dispersal that followed the Holocaust. He also fought hard against giving in to the forces of Yishmael in Israel; those who wanted to give in were often driven by indifference to the importance of the Land, and to how giving up land was really a matter of Pikuach Nefesh. The effects of his campaign are still felt today in Israel and all over the world, in many ways more strongly than ever. And he exemplified this week's quality: HaMa'aseh Hu Ha'Ikar.

The levitical city for this week is unknown too, another of the cities to be added on the other side of the Jordan once Mashiach comes and the borders are widened — and the tribe of Gad, which is Elul, has its territory there.

Week 48, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 332 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Manasseh and Asking Hashem to Forget

Beshalach names the place for what happened there: “He named the place Massah [testing] and Meribah [quarreling] because of the quarrel of the children of Israel and because of their testing the Lord, saying, Is the Lord in our midst or not? Amalek came and fought with Israel in Rephidim.” Because they quarreled and tested Him, doubting whether He was among them, Amalek came — and the scorpion of this week is the coldness of Amalek. In the end it brought them to cry out to G-d and to fight that G-dlessness.

The Tanach verses have Him answering a cry: “that the Lord sent a prophet to the children of Israel, and he said to them, 'Thus says the Lord, G-d of Israel; I brought you up from Egypt, and I brought you out of the house of bondage. And I saved you from the hand of Egypt, and from the hand of all your oppressors; and I drove them out from before you, and I have given you their land.'” Because the people in the days of Gideon cried for mercy, He answered with mercy and reassurance.

Daf Mem Chet of Sotah describes the reforms made by Yochanan Kohen Gadol, and then a prohibition against singing after the destruction of the Temple, the loss of Ruach HaKodesh, and the various spiritual declines since the Temple fell and the Sanhedrin was abolished. The theme again is the incredible need for teshuvah.

The generation is King Menasseh, son of Hezekiah, who was extremely evil and fell deep into idolatry, and worse, led the people of Judah into it too. And after he was taken captive and tortured he did sincere teshuvah, and on returning to the throne he acknowledged Hashem and tried to bring the people back. Menashe means to forget — and in Elul we ask Hashem to forget our conduct through the year.

The forty-eighth week goes with conquering the Chivites, whose name looks to come from the Aramaic for snake, Chiviah. They belong to the negative side of Yesod: being self-centred and too concerned with one’s own pleasures. Perfecting Yesod generally means control of the sexual impulse, as Yosef HaTzadik had it.

Week 48, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 333 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

To Honor the Righteous

The verse is a blessing given and a trip taken to get it: “And Eli would bless Elkanah and his wife, and he would say, 'May the Lord grant you seed from this woman,' because of the request which he had requested of the Lord, and they would go to his place.” That last clause looks unnecessary, and it is there to show how far Elkanah and Chanah would go in order to honour Eli, the Kohen Gadol and judge of the generation — and perhaps it was because of that honour that he could give such a powerful blessing. Rashi notes that the inverted order of Eli’s words is also there to stress Chanah’s righteousness: because of the request which he had requested, for himself a son; and Eli would say to him, may the Lord grant seed — may it be the Divine Will that all the children you will have will be from this righteous woman. The sentence is inverted on purpose.

The Pirkei Avot quality becoming to the righteous and to the world is honor. Honouring the righteous can be a direct link to His blessings; to honour the righteous is ultimately to honour Him.

Chapter 4 of the Song of Songs is entirely Hashem honouring the Jewish people. Every verse praises their attributes and their righteousness: “You are all fair, my beloved, and there is no blemish in you.”

The week holds the yahrzeits of two prominent leaders in modern Israel: Rabbi Abraham Yitzchak HaKohen Kook, the first Ashkenazi Chief Rabbi of Israel, on the 3rd of Elul, and Rabbi David Zvi Shlomo Biederman, the fourth Lelover Rebbe and leader of the Chassidic community in Jerusalem, on the 5th.

Rav Kook was born in Grieva, a suburb of Dvinsk, Latvia, to Rabbi Shlomo Zalman Hakohen Kook and Perel Zlata Felman. His father’s intellectual roots were in the famed Volozhin Yeshiva, founded by the eminent disciple of the Vilna Gaon, Rabbi Hayyim of Volozhin; his maternal grandfather Raphael was a hasid of Rabbi Menahem Mendel Schneersohn of Lubavitch, author of the Responsa Tsemah Tsedek. From an early age he took in both influences, which later germinated in his thought as a unique fusion of the mitnagdic and hasidic traditions. He studied in his youth with the rabbi of neighbouring Dvinsk, Rabbi Reuven Halevi, and later in Lutchin and Smorgon; the young genius was engaged to the daughter of one of the

great rabbis of the generation, Rabbi Elijah David Rabinowitz-Te'omim of Ponevezh, and in the year before his marriage studied in Volozhin, where he grew close to the dean, Rabbi Naphtali Zevi Judah Berlin. After serving as rabbi in the small town of Zoimel and then in Boisk, Latvia, in 1904 he accepted the invitation of the port city of Jaffa to be its rabbi. In Erets Israel, himself an interesting mixture of the old and the new, he had a profound influence on both the Old and the New Yishuv. His brilliance in every part of Torah drew the finest minds among Jerusalem's young pietists — Zevi Pesah Frank, Jacob Moses Harlap, Israel Porath and others who would lead the next generation. And he had a unique gift for reaching the modern elements of society who were alienated from tradition, cementing relations with the halutsim in the outlying settlements, with many friends in the new settlement of Rehovot; his deep philosophical thought and the poetry he gave it could not fail to impress the avant-garde writers of the day, and Samuel Joseph Agnon, Joseph Brenner and others ate at his shalosh se'udot. He served Jaffa for a decade. In 1914 he travelled to Europe for the conference of Agudat Israel, a newly formed Orthodox movement, to press on the delegates the importance of Orthodox participation in settling Erets Israel; the conference was cancelled when the First World War broke out and he found himself stranded, unable to sail home. He spent the war years first as a private citizen in St. Gallen, Switzerland, in the home of an admirer, Mr. Abraham Kimhi, and then in London as rabbi of the prestigious East End synagogue Mahzikei Hadat, founded by East European immigrants. At the war's end he returned, became Ashkenazic Rabbi of Jerusalem and eventually Chief Rabbi, and in that final phase emerged as a world leader of Jewry. In 1924 he spent most of a year in the United States as part of a three-man rabbinic delegation raising funds for the destitute yeshivot of Eastern Europe, and around that time he founded his own yeshivah in Jerusalem, known ever since as Merkaz Harav. The institutions he established — the chief rabbinate and Yeshivat Merkaz Harav — continue to this day, and his teaching was preserved both orally by his disciples and in the abundant writings he penned, some of which have yet to be printed. He returned his soul to his Maker on 3 Elul, the exact day on which he had entered Jerusalem sixteen years earlier.

Rabbi David Zvi Shlomo Biederman was one of the most respected rabbinical figures in old Jerusalem through the First World War, and the leader of its Chassidic

community. He was the official head of Kollel Warsaw, and in 1883 succeeded his father as Lelover Rebbe.

Also this week: Rabbi Chanoch Henoch Dov of Alesk on the 1st of Elul, Rabbi Eliezer Hager, the Damesek Eliezer of Vizhnitz, on the 2nd, Rabbi Moshe Aharon Pinto on the 5th, Rabbi Yomtov Lippman Heller, the Tosfot Yomtov, and Rabbi Zalman Leib Teitelbaum, the Sigheter Rav, author of Yetiv Lev, on the 6th, and Chacham Eliyahu Chaim, son of Chacham Moshe and father of Chacham Yosef Chaim, the Ben Ish Chai, on the 7th.

Week 48, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 334 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Heber and To Be Connected

The second week of Elul, whose sign is virgo. The Song's verse answers last week's question: "I am a wall, and my breasts are like towers, then I was in his eyes as one who finds peace." She promises to stand firm against anyone who tries to seduce her, and by that she finds peace with her Husband.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the forty-eighth is Heber, whose name means friend, connection — perhaps the strong bond we have with Him in this month, which stands for "Ani LeDodi veDodi Li," I am for my Beloved and my Beloved is for me. Heber is also the name of the husband of another tremendously important biblical woman, Yael. And with him Naftali. Of all Jacob's children only Naftali is associated with a female animal, because the prophetess Deborah came from that tribe; Jacob describes him as an Ayalah Shluchah, a swift gazelle — close to the name Yael, which means mountain goat. Naftali also comes from the word for sweetness, which belongs to the Divine closeness of this month.

Daf Mem Cheit of Shvuot takes up contradicting testimonies about the new moon and about whether money was given, and the swearing of orphans, compared with a woman swearing in order to receive the rest of a ketubah already partly paid; and then overturning a final ruling, and swearing about uncertain claims. Teshuvah and renewal again — a new moon, and rulings overturned — and the female theme that belongs to Elul.

Jeremiah's forty-eighth chapter is the downfall of Moab. As last week, each gentile nation is associated with its own impurity.

Week 48, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 335 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Second Week of Elul - Psalms 142-144; 105:45, 137:1-3; 89:49

The second week of Elul in psalms: the hundred and forty-second, hundred and forty-third and hundred and forty-fourth, with the last verse of Psalm 105, the opening of Psalm 137, and one verse of Psalm 89.

Psalm 142 is David in the cave. "With my voice I will cry out to the Lord; with my voice I will call to the Lord in supplication. I will pour out my plea before Him; I will declare my distress in His presence." The loneliness of it: "Look to my right and see, there is none that will know me; every escape is lost to me. No man cares for my soul." And the asking: "Release my soul from confinement, so that it may acknowledge Your Name."

Psalm 143 asks not to be judged. "O Lord, hear my prayer, lend Your ear to my supplications. With Your faithfulness answer me, and with Your righteousness. Do not enter into judgment with Your servant, for no living being would be vindicated before You." Then the remembering: "I remembered the days of old; I meditated on all Your deeds; I spoke of Your handiwork. I spread out my hands to You; like a languishing land my soul yearns after You, Selah." Then the morning: "Let me hear Your kindness in the morning, for have I trusted in You. Let me know the way in which I should walk, for to You I have lifted my soul." And the verse that is the month in one line: "Teach me to do Your will, for You are my G-d. Let Your good spirit lead me in an even path."

Psalm 144 begins with hands trained for battle and then asks what a man is. "Blessed be the Lord, my Rock, Who trains my hands for battle and my fingers for war." "O Lord, what is man that You have recognized him; the son of a mortal, that You are mindful of him? Man is like a breath; his days are like a passing shadow." Then the asking for Him to come down: "O Lord, incline Your heavens and descend; touch the mountains and they will become vapor." And then the picture of a people at peace, which is how it ends: "For our sons are like plants, brought up to manliness

in their youth; our daughters are like cornerstones, fashioned after the fashion of a palace. Our storehouses are full, overflowing with all manner of food; our sheep increase by the thousands." "Happy is the nation for whom this is so. Happy is that nation whose G-d is the Lord."

Psalm 105 ends here, on what all of it was for: "In order that they keep His statutes and observe His laws. Hallelujah." And Psalm 137 begins, by the rivers of Babylon, where they sat and wept when they remembered Zion, and hung their harps on the willows, and were asked by their captors for a song of Zion. And Psalm 89's verse asks the question nobody answers: "Who is a man who will live and not see death, who will rescue his soul from the grasp of the grave forever?"

Week 48, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 336 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Scorpion Is Saying

The scorpion opens on the question of death, and the week comes in around it.

The question and the naming of the place first: "Who is a man who will live and not see death?" / "Who will rescue his soul from the grasp of the grave forever?" / "He named the place Massah [testing] and Meribah [quarreling]" / "Because of the quarrel of the children of Israel" / "For there our captors asked us for words of song" / "And our tormentors [asked of us] mirth" / "'Sing for us of the song of Zion.'"

Then Amalek, and the question in the middle of it: "Amalek came and fought with Israel in Rephidim" / "And because of their testing the Lord, saying" / "Is the Lord in our midst or not?" / "Because of the request which he had requested of the Lord" / "And they would go to his place" / "By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat" / "We also wept when we remembered Zion."

Then the reign from sea to sea, and the mercy on everything: "And may he reign from sea to sea" / "And from the river to the ends of the land" / "G-d is good to all, and His mercy is upon all of His handiwork" / "And the Lord spoke to Moses on that very day, saying."

Then the prophet sent, and the bringing out: "That the Lord sent a prophet to the children of Israel" / "And he said to them, 'Thus says the Lord, G-d of Israel'" / "The G-d who takes vengeance for me" / "And brings down peoples under me" / "I brought

you up from Egypt” / “And I brought you out of the house of bondage” / “And I saved you from the hand of Egypt” / “And from the hand of all your oppressors” / “And I drove them out from before you” / “And I have given you their land.”

And the end is the rain on cut grass, and the blessing: “May the righteous flourish in his days” / “And much peace until there is no moon” / “May it descend as rain upon cut vegetation” / “As raindrops that drip upon the earth” / “On willows in its midst we hung our harps” / “And Eli would bless Elkanah and his wife, and he would say” / “'May the Lord grant you seed from this woman'” / “In order that they keep His statutes and observe His laws. Hallelujah.”

Week 48, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK XLIX

Malchut of Malchut

Days 337–343

Day 337 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Bring More Light in Order to Extinguish Darkness Altogether

The Snail is saying, "Like the snail that melts away, a stillborn of a mole that does not see the sun." (Psalms 58:9) We are near the middle of Elul.

The snail is in a worse position than the snake or the scorpion: it is literally fading and melting away. The verse belongs to Elul, when through teshuvah we melt away our own darkness and sadness and connect straight to His light. It comes from a Psalm in which King David speaks of being able to reduce the evil inclination to nothing, as he managed to do himself. Which suits this week, because it is at forty-nine that the Counting of the Omer is complete: with the end of week forty-nine we finish this year's work on the emotional sefirot, and after climbing step by step, week after week, we have hopefully cut the evil inclination down considerably.

Pirkei Avot gives Shmuel the Small: when your enemy falls, do not rejoice; when he stumbles, let your heart not be gladdened, lest G-d see, and it be displeasing in His eyes, and He turn His wrath from him. That bears on how to behave at the fall of our greatest enemy, the evil inclination. Shmuel HaKatan was named the Small for his great humility, and we should always seek to be humble, in these days of Elul above all.

The combination completes the cycle: Malchut shebeMalchut, wholly majestic conduct still joined to this material world. Malchut is also called the poor sefirah, because it has nothing of its own and only reflects what the others send down — which makes it very humble, like Shmuel HaKatan. The lesson from the snail is that we have to bring the light of the Torah to everyone who is in spiritual darkness. And

forty-nine is the days of the Omer and the years to the Jubilee: the culmination of the count, completion, seven times seven.

Week 49, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 338 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Miriam and Increasing the Wisdom of His/Her Teacher

Haazinu sends Moshe up the mountain: "Go up this Mount Avarim [to] Mount Nebo, which is in the land of Moab, that is facing Jericho, and see the Land of Canaan, which I am giving to the children of Israel as a possession." (Deuteronomy 32:49) This is the last step before his passing, and before the fiftieth gate of binah — Nebo stands for Nun Boh, fifty is in it. He goes up Mount Avarim, perhaps from aveirah, sin, in the land of Moav, a place of great immorality whose very name recalls the incest at its conception; and Moshe, the humblest of men, is buried there as a way of repairing and lifting that place. Which is Shmuel HaKatan, whose name points to humility, and who says we are not to rejoice when our enemy falls. All of it belongs to Elul and to the teshuvah that repairs the whole year's actions, ready to take possession of the next one.

The Haftorah: "And that brings me forth from my enemies; And above those that rise against me, You have lifted me; from the violent man You deliver me." (II Samuel 22:49) Perhaps also the deliverance from sins and from accusing angels that happens this month.

The quality is increases the wisdom of his teacher, machkim et rabboh, from chochmah. Which belongs to this week's sefirah, Malchut: the poor sefirah, which has nothing of its own and only reflects what the others send: and in reflecting them it increases them, bringing them down into a deeper and fuller understanding, grounded in reality.

We see it in Miriam, this week's prophetess — and the remaining prophets of Elul are female, and the sign of the month is Virgo. After the splitting of the Sea of Reeds and the drowning of the Egyptians, the people, led by Moses, sing the Song of the Sea; and at the end of it Miriam adds to Moshe's wisdom by gathering the women and having them sing and dance with timbrels, in a song that answers his. She increased her father's wisdom too, persuading him to remarry her mother — which

led to the birth of Moshe. And the Arizal explains that the well which travelled with the people in the desert in Miriam's merit had the power to increase their wisdom and their grasp of the Oral Tradition: the Hebrew for well, be'er, has the same letters as the word for interpretation. There is a famous story of the Arizal taking his disciple, Rav Chaim Vital, and giving him that water to drink so that he could understand the deep concepts of his teachings.

Miriam also meets the Snail. After she speaks critically, and wrongly, of Moshe and is punished with tzara'as, Moshe asks that she be healed with these words: "Let her not be like the dead, which comes out of his mother's womb with half its flesh consumed!" We are meant to remember that act of hers always; it is one of the Six Remembrances of the Torah. In the month of teshuvah there is nothing more fitting than working on our speech and keeping clear of lashon harah — and speech is the quintessential characteristic of Malchut. If Miriam, his sister, who raised and supported him so lovingly and spoke of him with only the best intentions, could be punished so severely for what she said, how much more should we avoid any negative speech at all. She repents and is cured in the end; and as the sign of this month says, we all have the ability to repent and get a clean slate as the Days of Awe come near.

The levitical city is Rammoth Gilad, also a city of refuge. Rammoth means heights, and Gilad is the territory across the Jordan which, with Jazer, the tribes of Gad and Reuven chose to inherit: they had a great deal of flock and cattle and chose that land for its spaciousness. Gilad is also the land of Elijah the Prophet, and Rammoth Gilad specifically is where King Achab was wounded and died, fulfilling Eliyahu's prophecy. And Gilad looks related to Gal'Ed, the place where Yaakov had to face Lavan before coming to Israel, and where the two made a treaty — which belongs to all of this: facing one's enemy, the yetzer harah that Lavan personifies, and preparing to enter Israel, or a new year. The name Lavan also holds Lev, the 32 paths of chochmah, and nun, the 50 gates of binah. And before he met Yaakov, Hashem appeared to Lavan in a dream and told him not to say anything to Yaakov, good or bad — which is lashon harah again.

Week 49, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 339 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Amon and Raising the Lowest of Sparks

Beshalach sets up the battle: “So Moses said to Joshua, Pick men for us, and go out and fight against Amalek. Tomorrow I will stand on top of the hill with the staff of G-d in my hand. Joshua did as Moses had told him, to fight against Amalek; and Moses, Aaron, and Hur ascended to the top of the hill.” Amalek is the worst kind of kelipah. The fight was led physically by Joshua and spiritually by Moshe’s prayer, with Aharon and Hur helping, and each of the four stands for a different part of the people: Moshe is Netzach, Aharon Hod, Joshua Yesod, and Hur, Miriam’s husband from the tribe of Judah, Malchut. All of them had to work together to beat Amalek.

The Tanach verses bring in the leader of the next fight: “And I said to you, 'I am the Lord your G-d, you shall not fear the gods of the Amorites in whose land you dwell.' But you have not obeyed me.” “And the angel of the Lord came, and sat under the oak which was in Ophra, that belonged to Joash the Abiezrite; and his son Gideon was beating out wheat in the winepress, to be enabled to flee from Midian.” There are strong parallels between Moshe and Gideon, in their humility and in questioning their own appointment. Gideon has aspects of Malchut, being the only judge whose son was also appointed a leader, like a king; he is from the tribe of Menashe son of Joseph, which belongs to Yesod. And Rashi explains that the prophet who came to speak to the nation was Pinchas, a kohen, who belongs to Hod.

Daf Mem Tet of Sotah describes the power of prayer, and then the spiritual declines since the destruction, at length — how certain aspects of holiness were lost when certain rabbis died. And it describes the troubles of the generation of Mashiach, troubles which will bring us to cry out to G-d and be saved. Which is what Elul is for.

The generation is King Amon, son of Menasheh, considered the most evil of all the kings of Judah. Unlike his father he did not do teshuvah: he not only worshipped all his idols but burned the Torah and committed incest with his own mother. His rule lasted only two years, because he was murdered in a conspiracy — and the sinfulness of his reign is the precursor to the saintliness of his son Josiah’s, which comes next week. So this too is the teshuvah of Elul.

The forty-ninth week goes with conquering the Jebusites, whose name comes from Jebus, the city King David conquered and made Israel's capital and the future home of the Beit HaMikdash, Jerusalem. Jebus looks related to bushah, shame; and Yerushalayim combines fear, Yirah, and peace, Shalom. The Jebusites belong to the negative side of Malchut, which is kingship and is tied to the power of speech — so its negative side is evil speech, Lashon Harah, which is the opposite of all those qualities: one who speaks it is shameless and does not properly fear Heaven, and it causes quarrelling and ostracism, the opposite of peace. King David saw the power of it with King Saul, whose hatred for David grew out of other people praising David in front of him, which is known as Avak Lashon Harah. Doeg's Lashon Harah caused the annihilation of the entire priestly city of Nov, and Saul's own soldiers failed against the Philistines because of their slander of David. The best example of avoiding it is David's ancestor Tamar, who would not accuse Judah even though she would be thrown into a fire and burned alive — and from Tamar our sages learn that it is better to throw oneself into fire than to shame someone in public. The conquest of the seventh nation and of Jerusalem is the final, crowning step of the conquest of the land, as forty-nine is the last day of the counting of the omer.

Week 49, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 340 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

G-d's Wisdom

The verse is the rest of Channah's life in one line: "For the Lord remembered Hannah, and she conceived and bore three sons and two daughters. And the lad Samuel grew up with the Lord." Conception generally belongs to Chochmah, wisdom, and the development of the fetus to Binah; Chochmah goes with male characteristics and Binah with female ones. Chochmah is potential that has to be developed — as Shmuel was sharp and wise very young and still had to grow.

The Pirkei Avot quality becoming to the righteous and to the world is wisdom. Wisdom is only truly good when it is developed with the Lord, as the righteous develop it, and as Shmuel did. As Proverbs says, the beginning of wisdom is fear of G-d.

Chapter 5 of the Song of Songs, its last section above all, is about His wisdom, and Rashi shows that every metaphor in it describes the beauty of the Torah. My beloved is white: to whiten my iniquities; clear and white, for when He appeared at Sinai He appeared as an old man, teaching instructions. And ruddy: to exact retribution upon His enemies. His head is as the finest gold: the beginning of His words shone like finest gold, as Scripture says, the commencement of Your words enlightens — the commencement of "I am the Lord your God" showed them first that He has the right of sovereignty over them, and then He issued His decrees. His locks are curled: upon every point of the letters of the Sepher Torah were heaps upon heaps of halachoth. Black as a raven: because it was written before Him in black fire on white fire. His eyes are like doves beside rivulets of water: like doves whose eyes look toward their dovecotes, so are His eyes on the synagogues and study halls, for there are the sources of Torah, which is compared to water. Bathing in milk: when they look into the judgment they clarify the law in its true light, to justify the just and to condemn the guilty. Another reading: Torah scholars, whom He makes into eyes to illuminate the world, as the eyes illuminate for a man; and like doves that wander from dovecote to dovecote to seek their food, so do they go from the study hall of one sage to another, to seek the explanations of the Torah — and they cleanse themselves with the milk of Torah and whiten its mysteries, and resolve the matters appropriately. His jaws: the commandments of Mount Sinai, for He showed them a friendly and smiling countenance. His lips are like roses: the statements He spoke in the Tent of Meeting, which are for appeasement and atonement and a pleasant fragrance — the law of the sin offering, the guilt offering, the meal offering, the burnt offering and the peace offering. His hands: the Tablets, which He gave with His right hand, the work of His hands. Wheels of gold: the commandments, of which it is said that they are to be desired more than gold; Rabbi Joshua the son of Nehemiah said they were made miraculously, of sapphire and yet able to be rolled; or because they roll much good into the world. Set with chrysolite: He included the 613 commandments in the Decalogue. His abdomen is a block of ivory: this is Leviticus, set in the middle of the Five Books as the intestines are set in the middle of the body, smooth as a block of ivory and set with many details drawn from similar wordings, general principles and inferences from minor to major. Founded upon sockets of fine gold: Rabbi Eleazar Hakkappar said this pillar has a capitol above and a base below, and Rabbi Samuel

the son of Gadda said the sections of the Torah have a capitol above and a base below and are juxtaposed before and after them — as the sections of the Sabbatical and Jubilee years stand next to "And if you transact a sale," to teach how severe even the dust of the Sabbatical Year is; and as "May the Lord appoint a man over the congregation" stands next to "Command My sacrifice, My bread": before you command Me about My children, command them about Me. His appearance is like the Lebanon: one who reflects and ponders over His words finds blossoms and sprouts in them, like a forest in bloom, and whoever meditates over the words of Torah constantly finds new explanations in them. Chosen as the cedars, which are chosen for building and for strength and height. His palate is sweet: His words are pleasant — "And you shall not make a wound in your flesh for one who has died... I am the Lord," faithful to pay reward; is there a palate sweeter than that, do not wound yourselves and you will receive reward? And: "when a wicked man repents of his wickedness and performs justice and righteousness, he shall live because of them" — iniquities are accounted to him as merits. Is there a palate sweeter than that?

The week holds the yahrzeits of three prominent Jewish thinkers: Rabbi Tzadok HaKohen Rabinowitz of Lublin on the 9th of Elul, Rabbi Simcha Bunim of Peshischa on the 12th, and Rabbi Yosef Chaim of Bagdad, the Ben Ish Chai, on the 13th.

Rav Tzadok HaKohen, one of the great lights of Chasidic thought and arguably its most prolific author, was not born a Chasid. He was born to Rav Yaakov, the Av Bais Din of Kreisberg in Lithuania; his grandfather Rav Zalman Mireles was Rov of the three prestigious communities of Altuna-Hamburg-Wansbeck in Germany and son-in-law of the Chacham Tzvi. He was a child prodigy: he said of himself that at one year old he would make a bracha on his mother's milk, at two he davened from a siddur, by three and a half he was learning Gemara with Tosfos, and before his Bar Mitzva he was already writing Shailos U'Tshuvos — he delivered four drashos at his Bar Mitzva, printed in the Sefer Meishiv Tzedek. He was a rising star in the Litvishe world. The turning point came when his first marriage ended prematurely and his wife would not accept a divorce; wandering among the Gedolim to secure a Heter Mei'a so that he could remarry, he met the Shoel U'Maishiv, Rav Tzvi Hirsh Chayos, Rav Shlomo Kluger and others, and also great Chasidic Rebbes — Rav Shalom of Belz, the Divrei Chaim, the Chidushei HaRim, Rav Meir Premishaln. And when he met Rav Mordechai Yosef Leiner, the Izhbetzer Rebbe, he found a soulmate, and the

Litvishe Rav Tzadok became his ardent Chasid. In the end his first wife accepted the Get and no Heter Mei'a was needed; he remarried and moved to Lublin. Under Rav Mordechai Yosef he learned together with another Litvak turned Chasid, Rav Leibele Eiger, grandson of Rebbi Akiva Eiger and son of Rav Shlomo Eiger. After Rav Mordechai Yosef's petira in 1854 he refused to take his Rebbe's mantle and pushed Rav Leibele Eiger to lead instead, and in the 33 years until Rav Leibele's petira he learned in solitude and composed his many seforim. In 1887 he again refused to lead and pushed for Rav Avrohom Eiger, and this time the Chasidim would not give in, and he became the Rebbe of Lublin. He very much wanted to emigrate to Eretz Yisroel and his Chasidim would not hear of it. He was Niftar on 9 Elul. He left no sons, and left the world his vast writings, which have had a profound impact on Jewish thinking since: Pri Tzadik, Divrei Sofrim, Otzar HaMelech, Yisroel Kedoshim, Tzidkas HaTzadik, Taanas Hashovim, Kuntras Divrei Chalomos, and many others.

Rabbi Simcha Bunim of Peshischa spent many years as a business man and a pharmacist. A beloved disciple of the Seer and of the Holy Yid, whom he succeeded, he is known as a rebbe of rebbes; his major disciples included the Kotsker and the first Rebbes of Ger and Alexander.

Rabbi Yosef Chaim of Bagdad, the Ben Ish Hai, is one of the most important Sephardic sages of the last two centuries. At 25 he succeeded to his father's rabbinical position and held it for 50 years. In 1869 he visited the Holy Land and was offered the position of Rishon LeZion, Sephardic Chief Rabbi, and did not accept it. A great scholar and Kabbalist, highly regarded as a pure and holy man, his rulings are followed to this day by many Sephardim worldwide, and he published many important books on law, Midrash, Kabbalah and ethics.

The week also holds yahrzeits from the Rizhin and Sadiger dynasty: Rabbi Moshe Yehudah Leib of Pashkan on the 10th of Elul, and Rabbi Shalom Yosef Friedman of Sadigora and Rabbi Avraham Yaakov Friedman of Sadigora on the 11th. And Rabbi Moshe Elyakim Briah Hopstein, the Be'er Moshe, second Rebbe of Kozhnitz, Rabbi Yaakov Yisroel Twerski of Cherkas and Rabbi Avraham Yissachar Behr HaKohen Rabinowitz of Radomsk on the 13th.

Week 49, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 341 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

The King is in the Field

The Song's verse is a vineyard let out: "Solomon had a vineyard in Baal-Hamon; he gave the vineyard to the keepers; each one brought for the fruit thereof one thousand pieces of silver." The Jewish people are the vineyard, and a populous nation placed in the hands of the nations of exile, the keepers. It can also be read by the Alter Rebbe's teaching that in Elul the King is in the field and greets each person with a smile: in Shir HaShirim the name Solomon is Hashem Himself, and He comes to the field, the vineyard, and to each keeper, each Jewish person. And each one shows an enormous desire to connect to Him in this month — a thousand pieces of silver, and silver, kesef, stands in Kabbalah for desire, kissufim.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the forty-ninth is Malkiel, which means my King is G-d. Besides the King in the field, this week is Malchut shebeMalchut. And with him Jahze'el, which means G-d will apportion, or divide, or break — which is Malchut too, both being given the position and being humble and broken.

Daf Mem Tet of Shvuot is practically a chapter in itself: the four kinds of watchmen, Shomrim — one who watches for free, one who borrows, one who receives a fee, and one who rents — each with different rights and obligations. It is striking how close that is to the keepers of the Song. As the year ends we also have to show that we took good care of what was entrusted to us: our soul. And if we did not, it is time to make it right.

Jeremiah's forty-ninth chapter is the downfall of Ammon, and of Edom, Aram and Elam. As before, each gentile nation is associated with its own impurity.

Week 49, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 342 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Third Week of Elul - Psalms 145-147; 137:4-6; 89:50

The third week of Elul in psalms: the hundred and forty-fifth, hundred and forty-sixth and hundred and forty-seventh, with three verses of Psalm 137 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 145 is a psalm of praise by David, and all of it is praise. "I will exalt You, my G-d the King, and bless Your Name forever. Every day I will bless You, and extol Your Name forever. The Lord is great and exceedingly exalted; there is no limit to His greatness." The handing on: "One generation to another will laud Your works, and tell of Your mighty acts." Then the attributes: "The Lord is gracious and compassionate, slow to anger and of great kindness. The Lord is good to all, and His mercies extend over all His works" — which is the scorpion's verse of last week. Then this week's: "The Lord supports all who fall, and straightens all who are bent." And the line everyone knows: "The eyes of all look expectantly to You, and You give them their food at the proper time. You open Your hand and satisfy the desire of every living thing." And the nearness: "The Lord is close to all who call upon Him, to all who call upon Him in truth."

Psalm 146 says where not to put your trust. "Do not place your trust in nobles, nor in mortal man who has not the ability to bring deliverance. When his spirit departs, he returns to his earth; on that very day, his plans come to naught. Fortunate is he whose help is the G-d of Jacob, whose hope rests upon the Lord his G-d." And what He does instead: "He renders justice to the oppressed; He gives food to the hungry; the Lord releases those who are bound. The Lord opens the eyes of the blind; the Lord straightens those who are bowed; the Lord loves the righteous. The Lord watches over the strangers; He gives strength to orphan and widow."

Psalm 147 is Jerusalem and the weather and the stars. "The Lord is the rebuilder of Jerusalem; He will gather the banished of Israel. He heals the broken-hearted, and bandages their wounds. He counts the number of the stars; He gives a name to each of them. Great is our Master and abounding in might; His understanding is beyond reckoning. The Lord strengthens the humble; He casts the wicked to the ground." What He does not want: "He does not desire [those who place their trust in] the strength of the horse, nor does He want those who rely upon the thighs of man. He desires those who fear Him, those who long for His kindness." Then the winter: "He dispenses snow like fleece; He scatters frost like ashes. He hurls His ice like morsels; who can withstand His cold? He sends forth His word and melts them; He causes His wind to blow, and the waters flow." And then the thing given to one people only: "He tells His words to Jacob, His statutes and ordinances to Israel. He has not done so for other nations, and they do not know [His] ordinances."

Psalm 137's verses are the oath of a man who will not forget: “How shall we sing the song of the Lord on foreign soil? If I forget you, O Jerusalem, may my right hand forget [its skill]. May my tongue cling to my palate, if I do not remember you, if I do not bring up Jerusalem at the beginning of my joy.” And Psalm 89's verse asks after what was promised: “Where are Your former acts of kindness, O Lord, which You swore to David in your trust?”

Week 49, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 343 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Snail is Saying

The snail opens, and the week sets a man sent up a mountain to look beside a man melting away.

The going up and the picking of men first: “Go up this Mount Avarim [to] Mount Nebo” / “Which is in the land of Moab, that is facing Jericho” / “So Moses said to Joshua, Pick men for us” / “With the staff of G-d in my hand” / “And the angel of the Lord came” / “You have lifted me; from the violent man You deliver me.”

Then the keepers and the remembering: “He gave the vineyard to the keepers” / “For the Lord remembered Hannah, and she conceived” / “Joshua did as Moses had told him, to fight against Amalek” / “A stillborn of a mole that does not see the sun” / “You shall not fear the gods of the Amorites in whose land you dwell.”

Then the Land seen from a distance, and the snail: “And see the Land of Canaan, which I am giving” / “And go out and fight against Amalek” / “Like the snail that melts away” / “To the children of Israel as a possession” / “And above those that rise against me” / “Tomorrow I will stand on top of the hill” / “And I said to you, 'I am the Lord your G-d'” / “And that brings me forth from my enemies” / “But you have not obeyed me.”

Then Jerusalem not forgotten, and the kindness asked after: “If I forget you, O Jerusalem, may my right hand forget [its skill]” / “Where are Your former acts of kindness, O Lord” / “To be enabled to flee from Midian” / “And bore three sons and two daughters” / “How shall we sing the song of the Lord on foreign soil?” / “Each one brought for the fruit thereof one thousand pieces of silver.”

And the end is the oak at Ophra and the boy growing up: “That belonged to Joash the Abiezrite” / “Which You swore to David in your trust” / “And Moses, Aaron, and Hur ascended to the top of the hill” / “And sat under the oak which was in Ophra” / “And the lad Samuel grew up with the Lord” / “Solomon had a vineyard in Baal-Hamon” / “If I do not bring up Jerusalem at the beginning of my joy.”

Week 49, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK L

the Mochin

Days 344–350

Day 344 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Know That There Are No Limits to Our Growth and Closeness to G-d

The Ant is saying, "Go to the ant, you sluggard; consider her ways and be wise." (Proverbs 6:6) Weeks 50 to 52 stand for Shavuot, when we are given a higher level of the intellectual sefirot than the one given at Passover; they also go with the Passover weeks of the coming year, the intellectual sefirot granted before the Counting of the Omer. Those sefirot are chochmah, binah and da'at, and this first week belongs to chochmah.

The week holds Chai Elul, the birthday of the Ba'al Shem Tov and of the Alter Rebbe. The Ba'al Shem Tov founded the Chassidic movement and revealed deep secrets of the Torah that let every Jew serve Hashem at a higher level. The Alter Rebbe, who considered himself the spiritual grandson of the Ba'al Shem Tov, founded Chabad Chassidism — and Chabad is an acronym of those three sefirot. Its main aim is to bring light and Chassidic warmth into the intellect, which is the coldest part of a person. As in week twelve, Chassidism lights a fire inside a person, a wake-up call to serve more properly and be more diligent, like the ant.

Fifty is Shavuot and the Jubilee. Like eight, it stands for something extraordinary, beyond nature and beyond comprehension — and the ant is an animal that does not seem to obey logic, since its strength is past understanding: it can carry loads dozens of times its own weight. The ant sings of how we can acquire chochmah by following its example. As far as we are connected to Hashem, we too can do things that look impossible, because His power is entirely beyond nature. And when we connect to the immense teshuvah that came of the teachings of the Ba'al Shem Tov and the Alter Rebbe, and to the great miracles of their lives, the energy of Chai Elul itself

exceeds our comprehension.

Pirkei Avot gives Elisha the son of Avuyah: one who learns Torah in his childhood, to what is that comparable? To ink inscribed on fresh paper. One who learns Torah in his old age? To ink inscribed on erased paper. That first contact with the Torah, for a child and for an older person, belongs to chochmah — the first contact with wisdom, the feeling when an idea first lights up in the mind.

The Talmud calls Elisha the son of Avuyah Acher, the Other, because the rabbis of his time excommunicated him. His conduct was so disrespectful and so evil in G-d's eyes that a heavenly voice declared that everyone should do teshuvah except him. It is no coincidence that Acher falls exactly in the week of Chai Elul: the Chassidic way is always to look for the good side of a person or a situation, and to bring closer even those furthest away and help them repent. The Rebbe, from an interpretation of the Arizal, explains that G-d would have accepted even Acher's repentance.

And the teaching itself, which looks negative, can be taken very positively. The word for old, zaken, also means wise, and stands for "zeh shekanah chochmah," one who has acquired wisdom. The word for erased, machuk, is spelled like mechok, from a chok — a law of the Torah beyond human comprehension. With those two, the second half reads: a sage who studies the Torah is like ink written on paper taken in as a law beyond human comprehension. A true sage accepts all of the Torah, even the parts the mind can follow, as though all of it were a chok. And that was exactly Acher's first mistake, which led him astray: he was somewhat arrogant and thought he could understand everything with his intellect, and when he met a situation past his logic he became a heretic. The Ba'al Shem Tov always extolled the beauty of the faith of simple Jews who had little understanding, and who accepted the Torah as though all of it were a chok. The Alter Rebbe teaches that chok is also near chakuk, carved or etched: when a person begins to study, he connects to the Torah, and the two are still separate things, like ink and paper; once he matures and studies as a sage, the person and the Torah become one — the Torah is carved into his heart, and there is no erasing it. The Talmud in Shvuot has the same thing: when a person begins to study it is called the Torah of Hashem, and after he has studied, that Torah is called Toratoh, his Torah.

Acher's lesson belongs to the ant too. For all the ant's fine qualities it is also capable of something less fine: feeling arrogant and superior. We hear it in the song itself, which calls others lazy while praising its own ways. In many ways arrogance is held worse than sin: of an arrogant man G-d says that He and I cannot live together. That is serious, and Chassidism came to repair it too. One of the most extraordinary of all Chabad chassidim, Reb Hillel Paritcher, said that before he became a chassid he considered himself a tzadik — and once he began to study the Tanya he thought, halevai, I hope I can become a beinoni, an intermediate Jew. The Alter Rebbe himself pressed the importance of humility in a ma'amar he said soon after his release from prison on the 19th of Kislev, called Katonti, I became small, where he explains that any accomplishment we reach is due to the grace shown us, and that recognising that help should make us more grateful, smaller and humbler. Every time we come closer to Him we should feel smaller beside Him — the right response to blessing, which Jacob showed after fleeing from Laban.

At the end of the first chapter of the Tanya the Alter Rebbe explains that kelipah is tied to the four natural elements: fire, water, air and earth. Fire is anger and arrogance, which is the ant. Water is the desire for physical pleasure, the snake. Air is indifference and sarcasm, the scorpion. Earth is sadness and laziness, the snail. In the first four weeks of Elul we do teshuvah for our sins in each of those elements and each of those animals.

In the tractate of Chullin, Rabbi Akiva says: how manifold are Thy works, O Lord — Thou hast creatures that live in the sea and creatures that live upon the dry land, and if those of the sea were to come up onto the dry land they would straightway die, and if those of the land were to go down into the sea they would straightway die; Thou hast creatures that live in fire and creatures that live in the air, and if those of the fire were to come up into the air they would straightway die, and if those of the air were to go down into the fire they would straightway die. How manifold are Thy works, O Lord. That belongs to the four elements, and he seems to be teaching how to handle each kind of kelipah: take it out of its natural habitat.

The great gift of the ant is that there are no limits to how close we can come to Hashem, and that like the ant we can be an example to people who want to reach higher in their Judaism.

Week 50, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 345 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Devorah and Properly Understanding What One Learns

Week fifty, the week of Chai Elul, which marks the birth of the Baal Shem Tov and the Alter Rebbe, and the yahrzeit of the Maharal of Prague. Haazinu tells Moshe where he will die: "And die on the mountain upon which you are climbing and be gathered to your people, just as your brother Aaron died on Mount Hor and was gathered to his people." (Deuteronomy 32:50) We are told that tzadikim never die, and that even in Heaven they go on climbing from level to level. We are also told that when Moshe saw his brother pass away he wanted a death like his, and that Hashem granted it. Even at his death, brotherly love. And there is a repetition and a continuation here, something like the one between the life of the Baal Shem Tov and the life of the Alter Rebbe — whose teachings, and the Tanya itself, rest on the works of the Maharal of Prague. Which suits Chai Elul, because when a tzadik dies he is actually more alive than before, and affects the world far more.

The Haftarah: "Therefore I will give thanks to You, O' Lord, among the nations, and to your name I will sing praises." (II Samuel 22:50) Giving thanks and praising Him is what life is finally about, and Chassidism is about realising Hashkachah Pratis, that everything comes from Hashem and everything is for the good. Fitting for Chai Elul, because it was on this date that the Baal Shem Tov revealed himself to the world, among the nations.

The quality is one who properly understands what he learns. Which is Chai Elul too: the Alter Rebbe carried on the tradition he received from his teacher the Magid, who had it from the Baal Shem Tov, and he pondered what he had learned and organised it in the Tanya — as his knowledge of the revealed Torah was organised in his Shulchan Aruch. The Baal Shem Tov said of him that he would bring two lights, Shnei Or, into the world, in the hidden parts of the Torah and in the revealed.

The prophetess is Devorah. There is a parallel between ants and bees: both soldierly, both part of something larger, and both with a queen. Like the Ant, Devorah also suffered from the sin of pride, which cost her her prophecy for a moment. Overall she was extremely modest and humble, and that is what made her worthy of prophecy; of her it is said, "The wisdom of a woman built her home" — and the word is Chochmah, this week's sefirah. She is this week's quality as well,

since as a judge she had to ponder and properly understand what she heard; and we see it in her own song, where she thinks over Israel's situation, the different tribes' reactions to the war, Yael's heroism, the people asking her to sing, and the fate of Sisera and his mother. The song even has a back and forth between her and the people, who say "Arise Devorah… arise and sing a song," and she answers.

The levitical city is Mahanaim, a very special place. It is where Jacob met angels of G-d, who received him into the Land of Israel after Lavan had gone back to his own place, and from where he sent messengers to Esav. It is also where King David fled from his son Absalom, and where he and his army were given provisions by Barzillai the Gileadite, and where the tide of that rebellion turned in David's favour — and among the provisions was honey, which belongs with the bee, Devorah. On Chai Elul we enter the final twelve days of repentance before Rosh Hashanah, and we are given the spiritual provisions it needs; each of the twelve days stands for repentance for a different month, and Chai Elul itself corresponds to Tishrei.

Week 50, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 346 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Josiah and Emunah

Beshalach keeps on with Amalek, and the hands: "It came to pass that when Moses would raise his hand, Israel would prevail, and when he would lay down his hand, Amalek would prevail. Now Moses hands were heavy; so they took a stone and placed it under him, and he sat on it. Aaron and Hur supported his hands, one from this [side], and one from that [side]; so he was with his hands in faith until sunset." The key ingredient is Emunah. Amalek stands for the lack of it, and has the same numerical value as safek, doubt; and our sages teach that it was not Moshe's hands that won the war but the people turning their faces toward Heaven, in an act of faith.

The Tanach section is Gideon's doubt: "And the angel of the Lord appeared and said to him, 'The Lord is with you, mighty man of valor.' And Gideon said to him, 'Please my lord, if the Lord be with us, why then has all this befallen us? And where are all His wonders which our forefathers told us, saying, "Did not the Lord bring us up from Egypt?" But now the Lord has forsaken us, and He has delivered us into the hand of Midian.'" That is the same doubt Amalek works to instil: how can the people

of G-d, with G-d on their side, fall to another nation? The answer is that it is for our sins, and that it is only this way, living the exile and the exodus again in part, that we come to teshuvah, which is Elul, and Chai Elul above all.

Having finished Sotah, which answers to the Counting of the Omer, we move to the tractate most closely tied to it, Nazir, which stands for the three weeks of Shavuot and for Passover of the coming year — and the Nazir belongs deeply to the teshuvah of Elul. Sotah follows Nazir in the order of the Mishnah, and the opening pages of both tractates take up why. In the Torah the two sections stand side by side, and there Sotah comes first; the reason given for the juxtaposition is that one who sees a Sotah in her disgrace should vow to abstain from wine and become a Nazir. In the Talmud the order is reversed because the legal discussion moves from vows, which are near Nazir, and only then to related topics. The same is true here: Passover comes before the omer, which is the vow we take to be free and to receive the Torah; and on Shavuot, once one has seen the Sotah in her disgrace — once he has broken his animal behaviours and the Ruach Shtus of Kelipah during the omer — he is ready to rise further, to become a Nazir from wine, to crown himself, from Nezer, with the wine of Torah given on Shavuot. On Shavuot we received two crowns, one for Na'aseh and one for Nishmah. The Torah says of the nazir, "for the crown of his G-d is on his head," which Ibn Ezra explains to mean he has a crown of royalty on his head; and the Torah calls him holy. Three kinds of people are crowned with a nezer in the Tanach: the King, the Kohen Gadol and the Nazir. The Kohen Gadol is named that way first, then the Nazir, then the King — and both the King and the Kohen Gadol have strict rules about how often they cut their hair.

The very first mention of a Nazir is of Joseph, called the Nazir of his brothers. The Reisha Rav, HaGaon Rav Aaron Levine, explains how his life parallels a Nazir's, dividing it into three phases: the conspiracy of his brothers, which nearly killed him; his slavery in Potiphar's house, where he had to fend off Potiphar's wife's advances, which came of his physical beauty and his long hair; and the events leading to his appointment as viceroy and the meeting with his brothers, when he had wine for the first time in 22 years. He sets those against the three main prohibitions of the Nazir: not being in contact with the dead, letting the hair grow, and not drinking wine. For these three weeks, Nazir is divided into sections of 22 dapim, roughly matching a division of the tractate into three. This week's dapim, covering chapters 1 to 3,

describe the kinds of vows and expressions that make a person a Nazir, the cases where the vow has to begin again, and how Naziriteship only applies in the Land of Israel — which parallels the first years of Joseph's life there.

The generation is King Josiah, son of Amon, considered the most righteous of all the kings of Judah since David. He repudiated his father's ways entirely, repaired the Temple, and lifted the spiritual standing of the people in an unparalleled way — fitting for the week of Chai Elul. His greatness shone from the time he took the reins at the tender age of 8, which also parallels the childhoods of the Baal Shem Tov and the Alter Rebbe. And for all his strengthening of the people, spiritually and militarily, he was defeated in the end: in what looked like a preventable death, he refused Pharaoh free passage on his way to war with another power, overestimating how far the people had repented, and was killed in battle, and the people were burdened again by an Egyptian ruler, Pharaoh Necho.

In this fiftieth week we move from working on the emotional characteristics to the intellectual ones, which widens our territory, and goes with conquering the Kenites. They belong to Chochmah: their name looks related to kinyan, acquisition, and of all the sefirot kinyan belongs to Chochmah — and the Hebrew for elder or sage is Zaken, which stands for Zeh She Kanah Chochmah, he who acquired wisdom. The Alter Rebbe, whose birthday is this week, is called Rabbeinu HaZaken. The Kenites are the descendants of Yitro and historically had good relations with the Jewish people, and Yitro himself holds both sides of Chochmah: before converting he engaged in every kind of idol worship and knew Chochmat HaGoyim, the wisdom of the nations, deeply — and his wisdom made his recognition of G-d all the more powerful. Yael is married to Chever the Keinite, and among her descendants would be the source of most of our Chochmah today, Rabbi Akiva: the Midrash states that Yael became pregnant from Sisera, and that Rabbi Akiva would come from that line. Which is Yitro's pattern again, from a Chochmah set against the service of Hashem to the ultimate service of Hashem — and Rabbi Akiva's own life draws it too, unlearned until the age of 40, and then the greatest sage of all time.

Week 50, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 347 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Wisdom that Comes with Experience

The verse is an old man hearing about his sons: "Now, Eli had become very old, and he heard all that his sons were doing to all Israel, and that they would lie with the women who congregated at the entrance of the tent of meeting." Zaken Meod, very old — and his sons lacked that quality entirely, using their unwise youthfulness on the women who came with sacrifices. The Talmud explains that they did not actually have relations with them, but delayed in bringing their offerings, which made certain women stay overnight near the Tabernacle and kept them from their husbands.

The Pirkei Avot quality becoming to the righteous and to the world is that same word: Ziknah, sageness, old age. And this is the week of Chai Elul, the birthday of the Ba'al Shem Tov and of the Alter Rebbe, called Rabbeinu HaZaken — and our sages teach that Zaken stands for Zeh SheKanah Chochmah, he who has acquired wisdom.

Chapter 6 of the Song of Songs describes a relationship rather different from the earlier chapters. It holds the verse that is the acronym of Elul, Ani LeDodi veDodi Li: "I am my beloved's, and my beloved is mine, who grazes among the roses." Rashi: who pastures his flocks in a calm and goodly pasture. The relationship is more subdued, and wiser. Rashi notes throughout that what is described is the Jewish people in the times of the Second Temple — a love that comes with the wisdom acquired after a brief betrayal and a sense of abandonment, rebuilt slowly until it reaches its height again: "Who is this who looks forth like the dawn, fair as the moon, clear as the sun, awesome as the bannered legions?" Rashi: like the dawn, which lights up little by little; so were the Israelites in the Second Temple — in the beginning Zerubbabel was the governor of Judah and not a king, and they were subject to Persia and to Greece, and afterwards the house of the Hasmoneans defeated them and they became kings.

The week holds the yahrzeits of two great Torah sages who also lived to an advanced age: Rabbi Avraham Sternhartz on the 20th of Elul and Rabbi Yonasan Eibeshitz on the 21st.

Reb Avraham Sternhartz was Reb Noson's great-grandson and a grandson of the Tcheriner Rav. Orphaned young, he was raised by his illustrious grandfather, whose influence on him was unmistakable. Even as a child he showed great diligence in

study, a trait his grandfather was known for: after the morning prayers he would seclude himself in the attic and study Rebbe Nachman's Likutey Moharan, not stopping until he knew the day's lesson by heart. He completed the entire Talmud at sixteen and married; he was a scribe in Tcherin, and at nineteen was accepted as Rav in Kremenchug; at twenty-two he was appointed prayer leader for the Rosh HaShannah kibutz, a post he also held after coming to the Holy Land, for seventy years in all. He arrived in Jerusalem's Old City in 1936, where he was received as the outstanding Breslover elder of his generation, and in 1940 he established the kibutz in Meron for Rosh HaShannah. Exiled from the Old City during the War of Independence in 1948, he was resettled in Katamon with many other Breslover Chassidim. Among his disciples were a number of the major Breslover leaders of recent decades: Reb Moshe and Reb Nachman Burstein, Reb Michel Dorfman, Reb Shmuel Horowitz, Reb Gedaliah Aharon Koenig, Reb Zvi Aryeh Lippel, Reb Zvi Aryeh Rosenfeld, Reb Shmuel Shapiro and Reb Yaakov Meir Shechter. It was said of him that he was a living Likutey Moharan: just looking at him, one could see that his every action rested on some statement of Rebbe Nachman's. Giving a lesson, he would read from the text, divert into complementary material for an hour or two, and then pick up at the exact word where he had left off — all of it from memory, without ever looking at the page, and he did it until he passed away at ninety-three and a half.

Rabbi Yonasan Eibeshitz was chief rabbi of many cities, Posen, Prague and Altuna among them. He died in Metz at over one hundred years old, and wrote many important books on law, scripture and thought. Also this week: Rabbi Yaakov Koppel Chassid on the 15th of Elul, Rabbi Yehudah Loew, the Maharal, and Chacham Abdallah Somech on the 18th, and Rabbi Ze'ev Nachum Bornstein on the 19th.

Week 50, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 348 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

The King's Field

The Song keeps to the vineyard and settles accounts: "My vineyard, which is mine, is before me; you, O Solomon, shall have the thousand, and those who watch its fruit, two hundred." He will reclaim His field, and the nations will repay us for everything they took.

The verse also seems to point at the two men whose birthday falls this week. Last week's vineyard belonged to Ba'al Hamon, which is close to the Ba'al Shem Tov's name; and Hamon, which means many, also points to Avraham, whom our sages read as Av Hamon Goyim, father of many nations — and the Ba'al Shem Tov's role as founder of Chassidut is known to parallel Avraham's in many ways. The Alter Rebbe's name was Schneur Zalman: Zalman is the Yiddish form of Solomon, Shlomoh, and Schneur means Shnei Ohr, two lights, for his revelations in Nistar, the hidden Torah, and Nigleh, the revealed one. He received the field, the teachings of the Baal Shem Tov, and watched its fruit, developing them into the system called Chassidut Chabad. He transmitted all of those teachings — the full thousand silver coins, which stand for the desire for G-d — and added another two hundred, like his name, in the hidden and the revealed both.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the fiftieth named here is Rachel. Of all the Matriarchs she is the only one whose name is mentioned an extra time, specifically as the wife of Jacob — the emphasis on women and on closeness to G-d that belongs to Elul and to Virgo. Rachel means a female sheep, which is devotion to the Shepherd. And with her Guni, son of Naftali, whose name looks related to Gani, my garden, from Shir HaShirim — perhaps the special closeness of the month when the King is in the field.

The dapim of Makkot this week include all of chapter 1, which is mostly about invalidating witnesses — as the teshuvah, tefilah and tzedakah of Elul invalidate the heavenly accusations against us. And the last of them are part of chapter 2, the laws of someone who has to go to a city of refuge for an accidental killing; the whole idea of such a city is teshuvah. That discussion also holds Yeridah leTzorech Aliyah, a descent for the sake of an ascent, which is fundamental to teshuvah and to Chassidut generally.

Jeremiah's fiftieth chapter is the downfall of the greatest empire of the time, Babylon, and a consolation for the Jewish people, who are called sheep, with the fields of the Land in it, and with forgiveness, which is Elul. "My people were lost sheep, their shepherds caused them to stray, [to the] mountains [they] led them astray; from mountain to hill they went, they forgot their resting place. All who found them devoured them, and their adversaries said, 'We are not to blame because they sinned against the Lord.'" Then the two empires: "A scattered sheep is Israel which lions have driven away. First the king of Assyria devoured him, and this last one broke his bones, Nebuchadrezzar the king of Babylon. Therefore, so said the Lord of Hosts, the God of Israel; Behold I visit retribution upon the king of Babylon and upon his land, as I visited upon the king of Assyria." And the return: "And I will return Israel to his dwelling and he shall pasture in the Carmel and the Bashan, and in Mount Ephraim and Gilead shall his soul be sated. In those days and at that time, says the Lord, the iniquity of Israel shall be sought, but it shall not be there, and the sins of Judah, but they shall not be found, for I will forgive those I leave over."

Week 50, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 349 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fourth Week of Elul - Psalms 148-150; 137:7-9; 89:51

The fourth week of Elul in psalms: the hundred and forty-eighth, hundred and forty-ninth and hundred and fiftieth — the last three — with three verses of Psalm 137 and one of Psalm 89.

Psalm 148 calls on everything there is, from the top down. "Praise the Lord from the heavens; praise Him in the celestial heights. Praise Him, all His angels; praise Him, all His hosts. Praise Him, sun and moon; praise Him, all the shining stars." Then from the earth up: "Praise the Lord from the earth, sea-monsters and all [that dwell in] the depths; fire and hail, snow and vapor, stormy wind carrying out His command; the mountains and all hills, fruit-bearing trees and all cedars; the beasts and all cattle, creeping things and winged fowl; kings of the earth and all nations, rulers and all judges of the land; young men as well as maidens, elders with young lads." Which is very nearly the whole roster of singers this year has gone through, in one psalm.

Psalm 149 is a new song. “Sing to the Lord a new song, [recount] His praise in the assembly of the pious. Israel will rejoice in its Maker; the children of Zion will delight in their King. They will praise His Name with dancing; they will sing to Him with the drum and harp. For the Lord desires His people; He will adorn the humble with salvation.” And then the praise that is also a weapon: “The exaltation of G-d is in their throat, and a double-edged sword in their hand.”

Psalm 150 is the last of them, and it is nothing but praise, instrument by instrument: “Praise G-d in His holiness; praise Him in the firmament of His strength. Praise Him for His mighty acts; praise Him according to His abundant greatness. Praise Him with the call of the shofar; praise Him with harp and lyre. Praise Him with timbrel and dance; praise Him with stringed instruments and flute. Praise Him with resounding cymbals; praise Him with clanging cymbals.” And the last line of the whole book: “Let every soul praise the Lord. Praise the Lord!”

Psalm 137's verses finish that psalm, on Edom and Babylon and the day of Jerusalem. And Psalm 89's verse asks Him to remember: “Remember, O Lord, the disgrace of Your servants, which I bear in my bosom, [the disgrace] of all great nations.”

Week 50, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 350 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Ant is Saying

The ant opens by telling the sluggard to come and look, and the week comes in around it.

The looking and the mighty man first: “Go to the ant, you sluggard” / “Consider her ways and be wise” / “And the angel of the Lord appeared and said to him, 'The Lord is with you, mighty man of valor'” / “Now, Eli had become very old” / “Now Moses hands were heavy” / “And Gideon said to him, 'Please my lord, if the Lord be with us'” / “And to your name I will sing praises.”

Then the sons and the sinking hand: “And he heard all that his sons were doing to all Israel” / “And when he would lay down his hand, Amalek would prevail” / “Remember, O Lord, the disgrace of Your servants” / “So they took a stone and placed it under him, and he sat on it” / “And was gathered to his people.”

Then the questions, and the hand of Midian: “Why then has all this befallen us?” / “Remember, O Lord, for the sons of Edom” / “And He has delivered us into the hand of Midian” / “O Daughter of Babylon, who is destined to be plundered” / “But now the Lord has forsaken us” / “One from this [side], and one from that [side]” / “'Did not the Lord bring us up from Egypt?'” / “And where are all His wonders which our forefathers told us, saying.”

Then the dying on the mountain, and the thousand: “Which I bear in my bosom, [the disgrace] of all great nations” / “And die on the mountain upon which you are climbing” / “You, O Solomon, shall have the thousand” / “And those who watch its fruit, two hundred” / “The day of Jerusalem, those who say, Raze it, raze it, down to its foundation!”

And the end is the hands held up until sunset: “Just as your brother Aaron died on Mount Hor” / “Aaron and Hur supported his hands” / “My vineyard, which is mine, is before me” / “Therefore I will give thanks to You, O’ Lord, among the nations” / “It came to pass that when Moses would raise his hand” / “And be gathered to your people” / “At the entrance of the tent of meeting” / “Israel would prevail” / “And that they would lie with the women who congregated” / “So he was with his hands in faith until sunset.”

Week 50, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK LI

the Mochin

Days 351–357

Day 351 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Understand That We Are All One Soul

The Weasel is saying, "Let every soul praise G-d, Halleluyah!" (Psalms 150:6) Which is the power of repentance in Elul, and the messianic age, when every being, even the lowest, will praise Him openly. Week 51 also holds the 25th of Elul, the day the world was created — man was created on Rosh Hashanah — so it belongs with every living thing praising the Creator.

Chuldah is also the name of one of the seven prophetesses of the Tanach, the last to prophesy before the Babylonian exile began; her words concerned the fall of the Davidic dynasty in the kingdom of Judah, which had become extremely corrupt, and her prophecy is powerful and incriminating. The weasel stands for corruption and decay, in nature and in civilisation: Chuldah comes from Chaled, which means decadent. The Talmud states that the weasel is the only land animal with no counterpart in the sea — and the first time the world became corrupt, He brought the Flood. A creature that cannot live in water and has no sea counterpart recalls that time.

And the weasel describes the way out of decay beautifully. Where before, in its decadence, the whole world was destroyed as a single thing, the weasel urges all of us to praise G-d together as a single thing. The word it uses for living being is neshamah, which means breath and also soul — and it stands in the singular even though it covers everyone, because the weasel understands that we are all ultimately one soul, a part of G-d. Breath is life, and the most basic connection we have with Him: through breathing we are joined to Him constantly, in a way past our understanding. In Elul we recognise that constant connection. The King is in the

field, ready to hear us, and Elul is a good time to go out to a field or any other quiet place to breathe, to meditate, and to talk to Him.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Yossi the son of Yehudah of Kfar HaBavli: one who learns Torah from youngsters, to whom is he comparable? To one who eats unripe grapes and drinks wine from the press. One who learns Torah from the old? To one who eats ripened grapes and drinks aged wine. And Rabbi Meir adds: look not at the vessel but at what it contains — there are new vessels filled with old wine, and old vessels that do not even hold new wine. Rabbi Yossi compares the Torah to wine, which works on us beyond the intellect; and with age a person gathers knowledge and experience beyond his earlier capacity. The comparison belongs to binah, the second intellectual sefirah: after the light-bulb moment when an idea is conceived, the idea has to be developed and properly understood, like wine fermenting. He teaches that it is not ideal to learn from those who have not had time to work their Torah through, and Rabbi Meir explains that this is not necessarily about a teacher's physical age.

As last week, there is a way to read it entirely positively. The word for young, ketanim, literally means small, and can mean humble, as in Shmuel HaKatan, who gave the lesson of week forty-nine. The word for grapes, anavim, is almost the same sound as anav, humble. The word for unripe is kehot, which is also the name of Moses and Aaron's grandfather, Kehot. And the phrase for out of the winepress is migitoh, which, with a little poetic licence, can be read m'yegiatoh, from one's own efforts. Wine is a metaphor for the most hidden secrets of the Torah, and a humble person teaches those secrets in a way that has the student deduce them through his own work — which is worth far more than getting all of one's knowledge on a silver platter. So the verse can read: one who learns Torah from humble ones is like studying under Kehot, which is to say Moses and Aaron, and reaching the deep secrets of the Torah through his own efforts. Which belongs to Elul and Rosh Hashanah, when we humbly work at correcting our conduct and connecting to Him.

This week is Shavuot and binah. The gift from the weasel is that any person, at any level, can connect straight to Hashem, simply and naturally, with no need of intermediaries — as simply as breathing. And that we are all one.

Week 51, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 352 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Chuldah and Relating a Statement in the Name of the One Who Said It

The week of selichot. Haazinu gives the reason Moshe is sent to die on Mount Nebo: "Because you betrayed Me in the midst of the children of Israel at the waters of Merivath Kadesh, [in] the desert of Zin, [and] because you did not sanctify Me in the midst of the children of Israel." (Deuteronomy 32:51) His death was a form of atonement for a past misdeed, however minute — and his punishment is a reminder of how careful we have to be in loyalty to G-d and in sanctifying His name. This is the week to ask forgiveness for our failures in both.

The Haftarah verse is far more positive: "He gives great salvation to His king, and He performs kindness to His anointed; to David and to his seed, forevermore." (II Samuel 22:51) Repent properly and come to Him rightly, and He shows kindness. Elul is the King in the field, and Ani Ledodi Vedodi Li, a love that goes both ways: show Him kindness and serve Him rightly as our king, and He shows us kindness and brings salvation to the king He appointed for us.

The quality is one who relates a statement in the name of the one who said it. In the week of selichot we are careful not to take credit for our own actions, or for the chance to do teshuvah: we pray in the merit of our patriarchs, and say over and over the 13 attributes of mercy, which are words G-d spoke Himself and gave to us through Moses.

The prophet is Chuldah — and, remarkably, Chuldah is also the animal of week 51. Her story is full of this quality, on both sides: the men who come to her in the name of Josiah the King, and Chuldah herself. In Kings and in Chronicles the account repeats several times that men — two of them named Shaphan and Achbor — asked her in the name of the king, and she answers by speaking in the name of G-d. Perhaps "beshem omroh," saying something in the name of the one who said it, means more than citing a source: it means being true to the meaning of the original message. Chuldah may exemplify that better than any other prophet, because King Josiah specifically sought her out instead of Jeremiah, thinking that as a woman she might be more merciful and bring back a gentler answer — and she spoke as strongly as Jeremiah would have. The sages even discuss why she prophesied publicly at all when Jeremiah was the main prophet of the time, and explain that the two were

relatives.

The levitical city is Cheshbon, which literally means accounting. This is the season for a Chesbon HaNefesh, a spiritual accounting and self-examination before Rosh Hashanah.

Week 51, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 353 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Using Understanding (Binah) to Strengthen our Faith in the Merciful King

Beshalach ends the battle and writes it down: "Joshua weakened Amalek and his people with the edge of the sword. The Lord said to Moses, Inscribe this [as] a memorial in the book, and recite it into Joshua's ears, that I will surely obliterate the remembrance of Amalek from beneath the heavens." The inscription and the reciting are meant to encourage anyone in doubt that He will certainly destroy Amalek and punish them for their impudence — and Amalek has the numerical value of safek, doubt. This is the season for strengthening faith and preparing to crown Him as King.

The Tanach section is Gideon's doubt and his sense of weakness: "And the Lord turned toward him and said, 'Go, with this your strength, and save Israel from the hand of Midian. Have I not sent you?' And he said to Him, 'Please O Lord, with what shall I save Israel? Behold, my thousand is the poorest in Menasseh, and I am the youngest in my father's household.'" As in the Torah section, He gives Gideon strength and encouragement, and does it by appealing to his logic and understanding. There is also a parallel between Gideon, who is of Menasheh, and Joshua, who is of Efraim — both descendants of Joseph.

This week's dapim of Nazir, covering chapters 4 to 6, describe cases where others join in someone's vow, nullifying a wife's vow, and other laws about women and vows, or the power to annul another's vow. Then vows made in error — including vows made without knowing the Temple had been destroyed — and other mistakes a Nazirite might make in breaking the conditions of his vow. Which parallels the second phase of Joseph's life, when he grew his hair and made himself attractive to Potiphar's wife, and the further crisis of being falsely accused and imprisoned. And nullifying vows is one of the most important preparations for Rosh Hashanah.

The generation is Jehoiakim, also called Eliakim. Before him his brother Jehoahaz reigned briefly for three months, displeased Pharaoh Necho, and was replaced by Jehoiakim, who was renamed. Eliakim was lax in his piety and did not help the people return; Judah fell into greater and greater corruption. He angrily refused to listen to the prophets and sought to kill both Jeremiah and Baruch. He was finally forced to submit to Babylonia, which had defeated Egypt, and pay heavy taxes, and after three years he rebelled; the rebellion was crushed and he died in captivity. His failure to listen to the prophets was his greatest folly. Both Jehoiakim and Eliakim mean G-d will establish, and the only difference is which name of G-d is used: El, unlike Hashem, refers to the thirteen attributes of mercy and belongs particularly to Elul, which begins with the letters of El. Through the month those attributes are said over and over in Selichot — all month in Sefardi communities, and in the week before Rosh Hashanah in Ashkenazi ones.

The fifty-first week goes with conquering the Kenizites, the root of whose name is Zaken spelled backwards. Zaken, elder or sage, stands for Zeh She Kanah Chochmah, he who acquired wisdom; and the Kenizim stand for the mirror of Chochmah, which is Binah, understanding. Two famous righteous leaders carry the name: Caleb the Kenizite and his brother Othniel ben Kenaz, both known for territorial conquests. Caleb, with Joshua, was the only spy who came back from the Land with a positive report, and Othniel ben Kenaz conquered Kiriat Sefer and so merited to marry Caleb's daughter, Achsah. Both embody Binah, which is a form of intellectual conquest: Caleb used his understanding to handle the other spies with great cunning and so avoided an even greater disaster, and his name holds Lev, heart, which is close to Binah. Othniel ben Kenaz was the first Judge of the Jewish people, and the one who restored the laws Joshua had forgotten during the mourning for Moshe, using deductive reasoning, which is Binah's own work.

Week 51, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 354 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Wholeness and Long Life

The last week of Elul, ending days before Rosh Hashanah. The verse is a father confronting his sons: “And he said to them: 'Why do you do the likes of these things, for I hear evil reports about you, from all these people.'” A call to repentance, much like the call made to us before the new year. And it names what is often held the worst of all sins, Lashon HaRah, which is said to kill three people: the one who speaks it, the one who listens, and the one it is spoken about. King David writes: “Who is the man who desires life, who loves days to see goodness? Guard your tongue from evil and your lips from speaking deceitfully. Shun evil and do good, seek peace and pursue it.” Which is finally the advice Eli is giving his sons so that they may have life, as we seek to be inscribed in the Book of Life for the coming year.

The Pirkei Avot quality becoming to the righteous and to the world is exactly that long life: Seivah, old age, ripe old age. Seivah also carries wholeness, completion. Chapter 5 of Pirkei Avot says that one who reaches the age of 70 reaches Seivah, and our sages note that 70 is considered a full life span; King David himself passed away at 70, and is described as having reached Seivah Tovah, a good old age. Which suits the week in which we are about to complete the cycle of the year. The Lubavitcher Rebbe quotes the Arizal to explain that reaching Seivah does not mean the mission is accomplished, and that we have to keep rising: the Arizal follows a different text of that Mishnah — at 60 one attains seivah — and does not read old age as a negative quality, reading “Rise before a person who has reached old age” to mean that reaching old age summons the inner resources that let a person rise and accomplish his purpose. And the word Seivah, for all that it means completion, holds the letters of Shav, to return, to do teshuvah. Even the fully righteous must always be looking for ways to grow.

Chapter 7 of the Song of Songs opens by calling the Jewish people Shulamit, whose root is Shalom — peace, and also wholeness and completion, like the name Shlomoh. It is a completeness reached in our service of Him, and the chapter goes on describing the perfection of each limb and part of the people’s body; it holds the close, intimate relationship of this month and the completion of the year. And strikingly, despite the name, the verse about Shulamit is about returning: “Return,

return, O Shulammite; return, return, and let us gaze upon you." "What will you see for the Shulammite, as in the dance of the two camps?" For all the sense of wholeness, we have to go on striving for more.

The week holds the yahrzeits of two of our greatest sages, who embodied long life and completeness: Rabbi Yisrael Meir HaKohen Kagan, the Chafetz Chaim, on the 24th of Elul, and Rabbi Shalom Rokeach, the Sar Shalom, first Belzer Rebbe, on the 27th.

Rabbi Israel Meir HaCohen Kagan is commonly known as the Chafetz Chaim, after his famous work on guarding one's tongue. Born in Zhetel, Poland, in 1838, he was taught by his parents until the age of 10 and then moved to Vilna to study further. Refusing the pulpit rabbinate, he settled in Radin and lived off a small grocery store his wife managed while he did the bookkeeping, watching every penny to make sure nobody was cheated. He spent his days learning and spreading his knowledge among ordinary people, and as his reputation grew, students came from all over Europe, so that by 1869 his house was known as the Radin Yeshiva. He was also very active in Jewish causes, travelling extensively even in his 90s to encourage the observance of Mitzvos; one of the founders of Agudas Yisrael, he was deeply involved in Jewish affairs and helped many yeshivos survive the financial troubles between the wars. Exemplifying the verses in Psalms about guarding the tongue, he passed away in 1933 at the ripe age of 95. His greatest legacy is the 21 sefarim he published. His first, the Sefer Chafetz Chaim, is the first attempt to organise and clarify the laws of evil talk and gossip; he later wrote Shmirat HaLashon, which pressed the same point through the words of our Sages. The Mishnah Brurah, his commentary on the daily laws of a Jew, is in many Jewish homes and is accepted universally for deciding Halacha. Firmly believing that he lived right before the time of Moshiach and the rebuilding of the Temple, he wrote a work stressing the study of the laws of sacrifices and the Temple, and he published seforim to strengthen kashrus, family purity and Torah study.

Rabbi Shalom of Belz could trace his ancestry to the great gaon Rabbi Eliezer of Amsterdam, author of Ma'aseh Rokeach. Orphaned young, he was brought up by his uncle, Rabbi Yissachar Ber, the Rabbi of Skol, under whom he studied Talmud and Halachah with great intensity, and the fire of his Chasidut was nurtured by the Chozeh of Lublin, Rabbi Yehoshua Heshel of Apta, the Maggid of Koznitz and

Rabbi Uri of Strelisk. After his marriage he gave 1000 days and nights to uninterrupted study of the revealed and the kabalistic Torah, and emerged a recognised scholar of eminent stature; students and accomplished scholars came to him in ever larger numbers, foremost among them the renowned Rabbi Shlomo Kluger of Brody. In Belz he blazed a new trail: fusing excellence in Torah scholarship with the burning mystical zeal of Chasidism. Since the movement began, the mitnagdim had accused chasidim of spending too much time in joyous celebration with their rebbes at the expense of Torah study, which is the bedrock of Judaism — and by stressing the overriding importance of in-depth study, the Belzer Rebbe removed that stigma of superficiality. He committed none of his discourses to writing; they were recorded from the memories of his followers, who collected and published them. He built a magnificent yeshivah and study hall in Belz that became the spiritual centre for tens of thousands of Belzer chasidim in Galicia, and was succeeded by his son, Rabbi Yehoshua. In the 1940s the Nazi persecutions all but wiped out the splendour that was Belz; after the Holocaust the scattered remnants, under the surviving scion of the dynasty, the young Rabbi Yisachar Dov, miraculously restored it. Today the new Belzer yeshivah building graces the Jerusalem skyline, and Belzer centres of learning are in every major city in America, Israel and Europe.

Also this week: Rabbi Uri of Sterlisk, the Saraph, and Rabbi Menachem Mendel Danziger, the Alexanderer Rebbe, on the 23rd of Elul, Rabbi Yechiel Michil of Zlotchov, the Maggid of Zlotchov, on the 25th, and Rabbi Shmuel Abba Zikelinsky of Zichlin on the 26th.

Week 51, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 355 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Speaking to the King

The last week of Elul. The Song's verse is one line, and it is Him asking to be spoken to: "You, who sit in the gardens the friends hearken to your voice; let me hear [it]." The King is in the field, waiting for us to speak. Rashi explains that the gardens are the gardens of strangers in exile, and the friends are the angels who hear the voice of the Jewish people in the synagogues — which belongs to Rosh Hashanah in particular. The voice He hears may also be the voice of the Shofar, our desperate cry to reconnect.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the fifty-first added here is Joseph, who is named separately along with his mother Rachel and his brother Benjamin. Joseph is the Tzadik Yesod Olam, the foundation of the world, from whom the physical and spiritual sustenance of the rest of the world comes — which belongs to Rosh Hashanah, the day the sustenance of the whole year is settled. Tishrei also belongs to the tribe of Efraim. And with him Yetzer, son of Naftali, whose name points to the teshuvah we do for the sins committed through our Yetzer Harah. Yetzer also comes from Yotzer, creator — and on Rosh Hashanah we crown Him as King, the Creator of the Universe.

This week's dapim of Makkot hold all of chapter 2, which is entirely about cities of refuge, and part of chapter 3, on the laws of lashes and when they are given. Elul belongs to both: we seek refuge, and we seek repentance and early atonement, so as to be ready for the Day of Judgement.

Jeremiah's fifty-first chapter keeps on with the judgment and the downfall of Babylon. As Babylon was a destroyer, so it will be destroyed — which reads onto the vengeance that cities of refuge exist for, except that Babylon will have nowhere to hide. "You are for Me a shatterer, yea weapons of war, and with you I would shatter nations, and with you I would destroy kingdoms." And then, with you I would shatter a horse and his rider, a chariot and its rider, man and woman, elder and youth, young man and virgin, a shepherd and his flock, a farmer and his team, governors and officers. "And I will recompense Babylon and all the inhabitants of the Chaldeans for all their evil that they committed in Zion before your eyes, says the Lord. Behold I am against you, O destroying mountain, says the Lord, who destroys

all the earth." And the measure of it: "As Babylon [caused] the slain of Israel to fall, so in Babylon shall fall the slain of all the land." And the instruction to those who get out: "Fugitives from the sword, go, do not stand still! Remember the Lord from the distant past, and let Jerusalem enter your mind."

Week 51, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 356 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Fourth Week of Elul - Perek Shirah 1-3; 150:1-3; 89:52

This week Book 6 turns the year over: instead of psalms it is the opening of Perek Shirah, chapters one to three, with the opening of Psalm 150 and the last verse of Psalm 89.

Chapter One is the world itself. The Heavens say, "The Heavens tell of God's glory, and the firmament tells of His handiwork." The Earth says, "Hashem's is the earth and all its entirety, the inhabited land and those who dwell therein," and, "We have heard songs from the edge of the earth, glory to the righteous." The Garden of Eden says, "Arouse, O North, and come, O South! Blow upon my garden, let its fragrance flow forth." Gehennom says, "For He has satiated a longing soul and has filled the hungry soul with good." The Desert says, "The desert and the wasteland shall rejoice, and the arid region shall rejoice and blossom like a rose." The Fields say, "Hashem founded the land with wisdom; He established the heavens with understanding." The Waters say, "The sound of His voice places the multitude of waters in the heavens." The Seas say, "More than the voices of many waters, mightier than the breakers of the sea, Hashem is mighty on high." The Rivers say, "Let the rivers clap their hands, together the mountains shall sing for joy!" And the Wellsprings say, "And as singers that are flutists, are all my wellsprings within you."

Chapter Two is the sky and the weather. The Day says, "The day to day utters speech and night to night expresses knowledge." The Night says, "To tell of Your compassion in the morning, and of Your faithfulness by nights." The Sun, the Moon — "He made the moon for the festivals; the sun knows its destination" — and the Stars: "You alone are Hashem; You made the heavens, and the heaven of heavens and all their legions." The Rain Clouds say, "He made darkness His secret place." The Clouds of Glory say, "Even when it's clear, He troubles the rain cloud to form." The

Wind says, “I will say to the north, relinquish; and to the south, do not withhold; bring My sons from afar, and My daughters from the ends of the earth.” The Lightning says, “He makes lightning for the rain; He brings forth the wind from His treasuries.” The Dew says, “I shall be as dew to Israel, he shall blossom like a rose.” And the Rains say, “You shall spray a rain of generosity, O Lord, to strengthen Your heritage when it falters.”

Chapter Three is what grows. The Trees of the Field say, “Then shall the trees of the forest sing out at the presence of Hashem, for He comes to judge the earth.” The Grapevine: “When the wine is found in the cluster, and one says, 'Do not destroy it, for it contains a blessing,' so I shall do for the sake of My servants.” The Fig: “He who guards the fig shall eat of her fruits.” The Pomegranate, the Palm — “The righteous flower like the palm tree; they grow tall like a cedar in Lebanon” — and the Apple: “Like the apple among the trees of the forest, so is my beloved among the young men.” The Sheaves of Wheat say, “from the depths have called out to You, Hashem.” The Sheaves of Barley say, “A prayer of the pauper when he swoons, and pours his supplications before Hashem.” The Other Sheaves say, “The meadows don sheep; the valleys wrap themselves in fodder, they shout for joy, they even sing!” The Vegetables of the Field say, “The furrows are watered in abundance, the soil is settled, You soften it with showers, You bless its growth.” And the Grasses say, “May the glory of Hashem endure forever; may Hashem rejoice in His works.”

Psalm 150 begins again: “Praise G-d in His holy place, praise Him in the firmament of His might. Praise Him with His mighty deeds, praise Him as befits His superb greatness. Praise Him with a shofar blast, praise Him with psaltery and lyre.” And Psalm 89 ends here, after a year of one verse a week, on the disgrace rather than the consolation: “Which Your enemies disgraced, O Lord, which they disgraced the ends of Your anointed.”

Week 51, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 357 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Wiesel is Saying

The weasel opens on a father’s question, and the week comes in around it.

The question and the betrayal first: “And he said to them: Why do you do the likes of these things” / “Because you betrayed Me in the midst of the children of Israel” / “Which Your enemies disgraced, O Lord” / “That I will surely obliterate the remembrance of Amalek from beneath the heavens” / “For I hear evil reports about you, from all these people” / “At the waters of Merivath Kadesh, the desert of Zin” / “Which they disgraced the ends of Your anointed” / “Because you did not sanctify Me in the midst of the children of Israel.”

Then the turning toward Gideon, and the memorial written down: “And the Lord turned toward him and said” / “The Lord said to Moses, Inscribe this [as] a memorial in the book” / “He gives great salvation to His king” / “And He performs kindness to His anointed” / “Let every soul praise G-d, Halleluyah!” / “Hallelujah! Praise G-d in His holy place” / “Praise Him in the firmament of His might” / “To David and to his seed, forevermore.”

Then the weakening of Amalek, and the sending: “Joshua weakened Amalek and his people with the edge of the sword” / “'Go, with this your strength, and save Israel from the hand of Midian'” / “And recite it into Joshua’s ears” / “'Have I not sent you?'” / “You, who sit in the gardens the friends hearken to your voice” / “Let me hear [it].”

And the end is the youngest son asking with what, and the last praise: “And he said to Him, 'Please O Lord, with what shall I save Israel?'” / “Praise Him with His mighty deeds” / “Praise Him as befits His superb greatness” / “'Behold, my thousand is the poorest in Menasseh'” / “'And I am the youngest in my father’s household'” / “Praise Him with a shofar blast” / “Praise Him with psaltery and lyre.”

Week 51, Book 7 — the whole entry

WEEK LII

the Mochin

Days 358–364

Day 358 · Book 1 · Song of Nature

To Crown G-d as Our King

The Dogs are saying: "Come, let us worship and bow down; let us kneel before G-d our Maker." (Psalms 95:6) This week coincides with Rosh Hashanah of the following year, the day man was created. Which raises the question of why Rosh Hashanah is kept on this date and not on the 25th of Elul.

The Midrash relates that when Adam was created even his heel, the lowest and least sensitive part of him, outshone the sun, so holy was he; he was so full of light that all the animals came and bowed to him, believing he was their creator. And Adam told them, "Come let us bow down together and worship the One Who created us all." That was his purpose — to bring the whole world to the service of Hashem. The words of the dogs are Adam's exact words on that day, and they are the whole purpose of Rosh Hashanah: crowning our Creator as our King. A remarkable conclusion for this awe-inspiring text — and the song of the dogs echoes the rooster's, as the yearly cycle starts over.

Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur are the two times in the year when Jews kneel and bow completely during prayer. Lowering the head to the ground, we submit our intellect to the Divine King, who is infinitely greater than us and beyond us. The dog has the same characteristic, since the Hebrew for dog, kelev, reads kuloh lev, all heart: its heart entirely rules its intellect. In daily life it is a basic principle of Chabad Chassidism that the intellect must rule the heart — and standing before our Father, King and Judge, we know our intellect is nothing beside Him.

In Kabbalah the dog also stands for kelipah. The image of Satan, the Angel of Death, is a dog with many eyes; the dog is all heart, and it is through the emotions

that the evil inclination attacks. The conclusion of Perek Shirah holds an angel's explanation to Rabbi Yeshaya, a student of Rabbi Chanina Ben Dosa, of why the dog is in it at all: the angel explains that the dogs behaved very well and kept silent during the departure from Egypt, and that the dog's feces are used in tanning the leather for tefillin and other holy writings. As with the redemption from Egypt, in the final redemption even the deepest impurities will be nullified and lifted into the keeping of Torah and mitzvot.

Fifty-two is the gematria of kelev, dog, and of Behemah, animal, which is also a form of kelipah. It is the number of one of the names of G-d, B"N, which is tied to the kabbalistic work of raising the divine sparks caught in the kelippot — and when that raising is finished, He sends Mashiach. And fifty-two is the gematria of Eliyahu, the prophet who will announce his arrival. So week 52 is the total transformation of the dog, from impurity to holiness, which is the coming of Mashiach announced by Eliyahu HaNavi. The Talmud states that when dogs cry, the Angel of Death has come to town, and when they laugh, Elijah the Prophet has come. And we can already see how much dogs themselves have changed: they are no longer usually associated with impurity but are man's loyal companions, and show enormous healing behaviour.

The letters nun and beit together spell ben, son. There is a verse in the Prophets that before the great final day He will send Elijah, who will bring back the hearts of parents through their children. Rosh Hashanah is a day of judgment, when we relate to Him as our King — and also a day when we relate to Him as His children. Children run through its Torah readings: Sarah barren for 90 years until she bore Isaac, and the same story of Chanah, both of which happened on Rosh Hashanah; Hagar, whose story is about saving the life of her son Yishmael; and on the second day the sacrifice of Isaac, with a Haftorah about Rachel weeping for her children, and about Ephraim, called His dear and beloved son. And perhaps the story most associated with the blowing of the shofar is of a lost prince who after many years has even forgotten his mother tongue, and who, seeing his father the King, calls out in a deep and loud cry.

Fifty-two is also the gematria of bakol, in everything. The Torah says that by the end of Abraham's life he had been blessed with bakol — and there are many readings of what that means, especially since Isaac was blessed with mikol, from everything, and Jacob with kol, everything. One of the main ones is that Abraham was blessed

with a daughter. Which also suits this last week, as we complete everything in the year and begin again. And when the letters of bakol are spelled out, their numerical value equals the gematria of shofar — another line between week 52 and week 1.

Pirkei Avot gives Rabbi Elazar HaKapar: envy, lust and honor drive a man from the world. We have to be in control of our emotions, and envy and lust and the pursuit of honor are finally irrational, given that He runs the world and everything He does and commands is for our good. There is a more positive reading too: aim those desires at Him — in holy envy, which is the envy of scholars, in the desire to be close to Him, in wanting to honour Him — and the relationship becomes so strong that it takes us out of the concealment and the illusion that this world is. Olam, world, comes from ehelem, concealment.

And he says: those who are born will die, and the dead will live; the living will be judged, to learn, to teach and to comprehend that He is G-d, He is the former, He is the creator, He is the comprehender, He is the judge, He is the witness, He is the plaintiff, and He will judge. Blessed is He, for before Him there is no wrong, no forgetting, no favoritism and no taking of bribes; know that everything is according to the reckoning. Let not your heart convince you that the grave is your escape: for against your will you are formed, against your will you are born, against your will you live, against your will you die, and against your will you are destined to give a judgment and accounting before the king, king of all kings, the Holy One, blessed be He. That is a perfect description of what Rosh Hashanah is, and with those words the yearly cycle, and the cycle of a life, begins again. It belongs to da'at, the applying of knowledge to the reality of daily living — and notice how the word runs through it: to know, to make known and to have knowledge are leidah, lehodiah, le'ivadah, all from the root of da'at.

This week belongs to Shavuot and to da'at, also called keter, crown. In the week of Rosh Hashanah we crown Him as our King, and we have to understand that we are nothing beside Him: He alone decides, judges and creates. There is nothing besides Him. And the lesson from the dogs is that it is our duty to reach the people who are suffering and far from Judaism, and to lift them, so that they too can praise their Creator.

Week 52, Book 1 — the whole entry

Day 359 · Book 2 · Song of Moses

Esther and Bringing Redemption to the World

The last week of the year, and the week of Rosh Hashanah. Haazinu ends: "For from afar, you will see the land, but you will not come there, to the land I am giving the children of Israel." (Deuteronomy 32:52) On Rosh Hashanah we see the whole potential of a new year from a distance, before entering it — and we should look at it with Moshe's eyes, and lift it. Once we do enter, we leave the old year behind entirely and start again, with a new lease on life.

The Haftarah of Haazinu has only 51 verses, which would leave this week short one; and the verse that follows in the Book of Samuel reads as a summary and conclusion both of it and of King David's life, as this week is the summary and conclusion of the whole year: "And these are the last words of David; the saying of David the son of Jesse, and the saying of the man raised on high, the anointed of the G-d of Jacob, And the sweet singer of Israel." (II Samuel 23:1)

The quality this week is last week's and more: whoever relates a statement in the name of the one who said it brings redemption to the world, as it says, "And Esther told the king in the name of Mordechai." And on Rosh Hashanah the fate of the world is decided.

The prophetess is Esther, which is fitting, since Pirkei Avot names her in that very description. She is the last of the prophets, and she is also a queen, and her relationship to the king reflects ours with the King of the Universe: our sages teach that in the Megillah, wherever the word king stands alone, it is a reference to G-d.

The levitical city is Jazer, land good for pasture. It was in Jazer, and in Gilad, that the tribes of Reuben and Gad chose to settle on the other side of the Jordan. Like Moshe himself they do not settle in the Land of Israel proper; they choose instead to lift the land outside it, and so widen the borders. It is about Jazer that the Torah records the discussion between those tribes and Moshe, at the very end of the Book of Numbers, at the end of the forty years — a discussion about judging others favourably, and about setting a good example so that it is easier for others to judge you that way. That is not always easy, and perhaps that is why the land is called Jazer, which can be read as Yud Ezer: Yud for Hashem, and Ezer, help — G-d will help. The Midrash states that the spies of Jazer had such faith in Hashem and in Moshe's

prayers that they not only spied the city out successfully but went ahead and conquered it.

Week 52, Book 2 — the whole entry

Day 360 · Book 3 · Song of the Sea

Crowning G-d as Our King

Beshalach ends with an altar and a name: "Then Moses built an altar, and he named it The Lord is my miracle. And he said, For there is a hand on the throne of the Eternal, [that there shall be] a war for the Lord against Amalek from generation to generation." Amalek is an impediment to His throne, an obstacle to His Kingship, to be fought in every generation. Rosh Hashanah is crowning Him as King, which makes that fight all the more significant: Amalek is doubt, and Rosh Hashanah is the ultimate certainty of our faith.

The Tanach section keeps on with Gideon, whose lack of complete emunah shows in his asking for a sign: "And the Lord said to him, 'Because I shall be with you, and you shall strike Midian as one man.' And he said to Him, 'If I have now found favor in your eyes, then show me a sign that it is You that speaks with me.'" In the end He grants the sign and the faith is restored. There is a parallel between the altar Moshe built and the sign Gideon asked for: both are signs and testaments, one meant for the future, testifying to a past miraculous battle, the other confirming a recent assurance about a miraculous battle still to come. Which are the two sides of Rosh Hashanah — the year that passed, and the year coming.

This week's dapim of Nazir, covering chapters 7 to 9, compare the Nazir and the Kohen Gadol and give the rules for an impure person entering the Temple; then cases of doubt about whether someone became unclean; then the Nazirite vows of women and slaves; the laws of the Metzorah; and whether Shmuel HaNavi was a Nazir. Which parallels the third part of Joseph's life, where he reaches power and stature and becomes responsible for the affairs of Egypt, whose whole population essentially becomes his slaves. The Kohen Gadol and Shmuel HaNavi belong to Rosh Hashanah too, since it was on Rosh Hashanah that Hashem answered Chanah's prayer for a child, and the answer came through Eli the Kohen Gadol.

The generation is Mattaniah, also called Zedekiah, the last king of Judah. As with Jehoiakim, his rule followed a brief three-month reign by his nephew Jehoahaz, also called Jeconiah. Jerusalem was then besieged by Babylonia, which took the city and exiled the nobles and most of the population, leaving only the very poorest; Jeconiah was exiled too, and Nebuchadnezzar appointed his uncle Mattaniah as a tributary and renamed him Zedekiah. He showed no signs of repentance either, and he too rebelled. He threw Jeremiah in prison, and later Jeremiah was thrown into a mudpit and nearly died before the king saved him; and he refused Jeremiah's call to surrender. The rebellion was crushed again, and this time Jerusalem was devastated and the Temple destroyed. He tried to flee and was captured; his children were murdered in front of him and his eyes were put out. On Rosh Hashanah, likewise, one cannot run away from one's fate: one has to be ready to face the King and be judged. That may be the significance of the last king of Judah's change of name — Mattaniah means G-d's gift, and Zedekiah means G-d's justice. Rosh Hashanah is first of all being judged for the deeds of the past year, even though it is also about Chesed, and about Him giving us life and sustenance for the year ahead.

The fifty-second week goes with conquering the Kadmonites, whose name is tied to kadmon, original, primordial. Kabbalah uses that word of the beginning of Creation and of the primordial forces of existence: Adam Kadmon is a supernal revelation connected to Keter, crown, which is this week's sefirah, also called Da'at. Adam Kadmon also points to Adam, the first man, created on Rosh Hashanah. And the Nachash Kadmoni, the primordial snake, is the essence of the Yetzer Harah, which will be destroyed in the end with the coming of Mashiach — and only then will we be able to crown Him fully as our King.

Week 52, Book 3 — the whole entry

Day 361 · Book 4 · Song of Hannah

Parent and Child

The reading closes Eli's reprimand, and because the custom is not to end on a less than positive note, it takes in two more verses: "No, my sons, for the rumor which I hear the Lord's people spreading, is not good. If man will sin to man, the judge will judge him. If, however, he will sin against God, who will intercede in the judgment in his behalf?" But they would not hearken to their father's voice, for the Lord desired to kill them. "And the lad, Samuel, was growing up, and bettering himself both with the Lord and with people."

Those verses hold much of Rosh Hashanah. First the relationship of father and son — 52 is the numerical value of ben, son. Then judgment, by men and above all by G-d, which is what the day is: it is on Rosh Hashanah that He decides who will live and who will die, and the verse says of Eli's sons that He desired to kill them. And the last verse has Shmuel, already a Tzadik, going on growing, with Hashem and with people both. On Rosh Hashanah we look to connect with the community, and with the Tzadik at its head, in order to be judged in the merit of the whole congregation. And as last week, teshuvah is growth, and one must always be looking for ways to grow, in the Days of Awe above all.

The Pirkei Avot quality becoming to the righteous and to the world is children. Pirkei Avot brings proof-texts for the qualities it lists, most of them about old age and children: "Old age is a crown of beauty, to be found in the ways of righteousness." "The beauty of youths is their strength, and the glory of sages is their age." "The crown of sages are their grandchildren, and the beauty of children their fathers." "And the moon shall be abashed and the sun shamed, for the L-rd of hosts has reigned in Zion, and before his elders is glory." And Rabbi Shimon the son of Menasia says that these seven qualities the sages named for the righteous were all realized in Rabbi Judah HaNassi and his sons. He was head of the whole Jewish people and the compiler of the Mishnah, the entire Oral Torah, so it is fitting that he hold all of those traits — as Rosh Hashanah, the head of the year, holds the whole year.

Chapter 8 of the Song of Songs is full of family: brother and sister, and above all mother and child. "O, that you were like my brother, who sucked my mother's

breasts!" "I would lead you, I would bring you to the house of my mother, who instructed me." "His left hand would be under my head, and his right hand would embrace me." "Under the apple tree I aroused you; there your mother was in travail with you; there she that bore you was in travail." Rashi comments on that last: we have said that the Holy One, blessed be He, called her His mother — there she became Your mother. And on the earlier verse about the crown his mother crowned him with, Rashi brings this: Rabbi Simeon bar Yohai asked Rabbi Eleazar the son of Rabbi Jose whether he had heard from his father what that crown meant, and he answered with a parable of a king who had an only daughter of whom he was very fond. He could not stop loving her until he called her my daughter, as it says, "Hearken, daughter, and see." He could not stop loving her until he called her my sister, as it says, "Open for me, my sister, my beloved." He could not stop loving her until he called her my mother, as it says, "Hearken to Me, My people, and My nation" — where the word can be read and to my mother. And Rabbi Simeon bar Yohai stood up and kissed him on his head. So in calling the Jewish people His mother, He points to the highest relationship there is — and the verse that explains it is about the Jewish people crowning Him, which is exactly our work on Rosh Hashanah. It was also on Rosh Hashanah that two of the most important mothers in the Tanach were answered and told they would have children: our matriarch Sarah, with Isaac, and the prophetess Chanah, with Shmuel. Both accounts are part of the readings of the day.

The week holds the yahrzeits of two very special mothers in Israel: Rebbetzin Devorah Leah Schneerson, mother of Rabbi Menachem Mendel, the Third Lubavitcher Rebbe, the Tzemach Tzedek, on the 3rd of Tishrei, and Rebbetzin Chanah Schneerson, mother of the Lubavitcher Rebbe, on the 6th.

Devorah Leah was the second daughter of Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi, the Alter Rebbe. One day, in the middle of his anxiety, he called for her, and in the privacy of his study told her about the very difficult times ahead and the strong heavenly opposition to revealing the innermost parts of Chassidism; he described, in the gravest tones, a vision of the faces of the Maggid and the Baal Shem Tov, extremely dark and clouded. She understood that her father's life was in danger. On her own initiative she gathered three of his senior chassidim and asked them to promise to do everything she asked and to swear not to reveal her requests to anyone,

and only when they agreed did she go on. She reminded them that they were her father's chassidim, and that they must be ready to do whatever was needed for his work and the Baal Shem Tov's to flourish. Breaking down in tears, she begged them: "I ask you to swear a solemn oath, one that cannot be annulled, that you will follow my request even if a human life is at stake." One of them grew apprehensive at such a commitment, and the other two calmed him, saying she must have thought the matter through and would not act recklessly. Then she told them of the urgency and the threat over her father's life, and said: "You three chassidim will now constitute a beit din, a court of Jewish law. I have decided to give my own life in lieu of my father's. I will die and he will live."

On the eve of Rosh Hashanah that year, after the afternoon prayers, she went into the small synagogue where her family and some elder chassidim were deep in prayer, walked to the holy ark and said aloud: "You are all witnesses before these Torah scrolls, that I, Devorah Leah, daughter of Sterna, accept upon myself, with a clear mind, to exchange lives with my father, Schneur Zalman, son of Rivkah. I, through my death, will be the atonement." That night, the first night of Rosh Hashanah, the Alter Rebbe left his room to find her, and as she came to him he began to bless her with the customary leshanah tovah, a good year. She cut the blessing short with, "Father, leshanah tovah tikatev veteichatem" — you should be inscribed and sealed for a good new year. And when he was about to finish his blessing to her, she pleaded, "Father, say no more!" At the end of Rosh Hashanah he called for her and her husband, Rabbi Sholom Shachna, who broke down in tears and asked what they were to do: their young son, Menachem Mendel, was so special and so young and tender, having just had his third birthday. Her last request of her father was that he personally take on the raising and the education of her only son. The Alter Rebbe promised her: "Your son, Menachem, will be a nechamah to me, a nechamah to you and a nechamah to all of the Jewish people." The next day, the third of Tishrei, her prayer came true, and her soul left her body.

Rebbetzin Chana Schneerson was born in 1880 in Nikolaeiv, Russia. Her father was the distinguished and pious scholar Rabbi Shlomo Halevy Yanovsky, Rabbi of Nikolaeiv, known throughout the Jewish world for five scholarly books he wrote; her mother was the righteous Rebbetzin Rachael, daughter of Rabbi Yitzchak Pushnitz, the Rabbi of Dobrinka. As a girl she was educated by her father and by her

great-grandfather, Rabbi Avraham David Lout. In 1900 she married the renowned scholar and brilliant kabbalist Rabbi Levi Yitzchak Schneerson, great-grandson of the Tzemach Tzedek. He was appointed Rav of Yekatrinoslav and was for all practical purposes the spiritual leader of the entire Jewish population of the Ukraine, and she stood at his side, adding to his holy work. The congregation there was mostly non-religious professionals; the Rebbetzin, intelligent and pleasant, was knowledgeable in Torah and also spoke Russian, had a good rapport with them, and contributed significantly to his success. She was elegant, always well-dressed and friendly. She gave birth to three sons, the eldest of them Rabbi Menachem Mendel, the Lubavitcher Rebbe. In 1939 Rabbi Levi Yitzchak was arrested for his energetic work to preserve religious observance, and when he was exiled a year later she joined him, paying no heed to the difficulty or the danger. She was widowed in 1944, when he passed away prematurely at 66 from the cruelties of that exile. Three years later she managed to emigrate from the Soviet Union, and at great danger to herself she smuggled out his writings of Kabbalah — writings later printed and published by her son, and available to all of us. Later that year she reached Paris and was reunited with her eldest son, whom she had not seen in 20 years. The two travelled to New York, where she lived the last 17 years of her life warmed by the light of her son, who in 1951 became the seventh Lubavitcher Rebbe. Her gentle, unassuming manner, with a thread of majestic grace in every word and movement, deeply impressed everyone who met her.

Also this week: Rabbi Amnon of Mainz on the 1st of Tishrei, Rabbi Yisrael of Stolin, the Yenuka, and Rabbi Yitzchak-Meir of Kapichnitz on the 2nd, the Chayei Adam on the 4th, and the Shpoler Zeide on the 6th.

Week 52, Book 4 — the whole entry

Day 362 · Book 5 · Song of Songs

Transforming the World and Becoming Whole

The Song ends on a request to go: "Flee, my beloved, and liken yourself to a gazelle or to a fawn of the hinds on the spice mountains." A crowning of G-d, in a sense, since the gazelle's antlers are like a crown. On Rosh Hashanah we reach new heights too, which are those spice mountains: we flee the limits of this world and connect to Him on a much higher plane. Rashi explains that the Jewish people are asking Him to take us out of exile and hasten the redemption, so that we may serve Him on Mount Moriah, where Avraham bound Isaac — and Mount Moriah and that binding are themes of the day.

Of the seventy souls that descended to Egypt, the fifty-second added here is Benjamin, who was also named separately. Benjamin comes from Ben Yamin, and 52 is the value of Ben; Yamin is the right hand, the strong hand, and on Rosh Hashanah we feel His strength. And by working on ourselves through a whole year we go through a transformation like his, whose name went from Ben Oni, child of my suffering, to Ben Yemini, son of my right hand. Exile has its difficulties and it has its rewards. And with him Shilem, son of Naftali, whose name comes from Shalem, complete — we arrive here at the completion of the journey. Shilem also literally means paid: through exile we also atoned.

This week's dapim of Makkot hold the rest of chapter 3, on the sins for which a person is lashed; and at the very end the chapter takes up decrees that were annulled, and exile in general, and the final redemption. Atonement and the wish for the exile to end belong to Rosh Hashanah.

Jeremiah's fifty-second chapter is the last, and for the week in which we crown Him King it begins with the life of the last king of the Kingdom of Judah, Zedekiah, and the great suffering he went through; then it returns to the dire accounting of what happened to Jerusalem and the Temple and the remaining exiles. And like the end of Makkoth, after all the tragedy it ends well: "And it was in the thirty-seventh year of the exile of Jehoiachin king of Judah, in the twelfth month, on the twenty-fifth day of the month, that Evil-merodach, king of Babylon, in the year of his coronation, lifted up the head of Jehoiachin, king of Judah and released him from prison. And he spoke with him kindly and placed his throne above the throne of the

kings who were with him in Babylon. And he changed his prison garb, and he ate meals before him regularly all the days of his life." And the twenty-fifth day of the twelfth month, counting from Tishrei, is the 25th of Elul, the first day of Creation, in the week of Rosh Hashanah.

Week 52, Book 5 — the whole entry

Day 363 · Book 6 · General Remedy

Reviewing the Week of Rosh Hashanah - Perek Shirah 4-6; 150:4-6; 89:53

The last of Book 6, and it is the rest of Perek Shirah — chapters four to six, every creature of the year in one place — with the end of Psalm 150 and the last verse of Psalm 89.

Chapter Four begins with the Rooster, who says, "When the Holy One, blessed be He, comes to the righteous in the Garden of Eden, all the trees of the Garden of Eden exude their fragrance, and they rejoice and praise, and then He arouses and praises," and then calls seven times: raise up your heads, O gates, so that the King of Glory may enter; and again; and "Stand, O righteous ones, and engross yourselves in Torah so that your reward will be double in the World-to-Come"; and "I have hoped for Your salvation, Hashem"; and "How long will you recline, O lazy one? When will you rise from your sleep?"; and "Do not love sleep, lest you become poor"; and "It's time to act for Hashem, for they have violated Your Torah." Then the Hen: "He gives bread to all flesh, for His lovingkindness endures forever." Then the Pigeon, who moans and asks that its sustenance be as bitter as an olive in His hands rather than sweet as honey in the hands of flesh and blood. Then the Eagle, the Crane, the Bird who has found its home, the Swallow, the Swift — "My help is from Hashem, Maker of Heaven and Earth" — the Petrel, the Bat, who says, "Be comforted, My people, be comforted," and the Stork, who speaks to the heart of Jerusalem. Then the Crow, the Starling, the Domestic Goose, and the Wild Goose, which, seeing Israel engrossed in Torah, says, "A voice cries, Make way for Hashem," and on finding its food says, "Cursed is the man who trusts in a human; blessed is the man who trusts in Hashem." Then the Ducks, the Bee-Eater, the Grasshopper — "I lift my eyes to the mountains, from where shall my help come?" — the Locust, the Spider, and the Fly, who speaks when Israel is not engrossed in Torah. Then the Giant Sea Creatures, the Whale, the

Fish and the Frog.

Chapter Five is the animals: the Sheep and Goats, "Who is like You among the might ones"; the Cattle; the Swine; the Beast of Burden, "If you eat the fruit of your labors, how happy and fortunate you are"; the Camel, who roars His agony about His Temple; the Horse, whose eyes are a servant's eyes on his master's hand; the Mule; the Donkey, "To You, Hashem, is the greatness and the might"; the Ox, who sings the Song of the Sea; the Wild Animals, "Blessed is the Good One Who does good"; the Deer; the Elephant, "How great are your works, Hashem"; the Lion; the Bear; the Wolf; the Fox; the Greyhound; and then the Cat and the Mouse, who answer each other — the Cat, "If you rise up like a vulture, and place your nest among the stars, from there I shall bring you down," and the Mouse, "I shall exalt you G-d, for You have impoverished me"; and when the Cat catches it, the Cat says, "I shall pursue my enemies and overtake them," and the Mouse says, "And You are just for all that comes upon me, for You have acted in truth and I have been wicked."

Chapter Six is the smallest of them, and the shortest chapter: the Insects, "May Israel rejoice in his Creator"; the Reptiles, "Your wife shall be like a fruitful vine"; the Snake, "Hashem supports the fallen and straightens the bent over"; the Scorpion, "Hashem is good to all, and His mercy is upon all His handiwork"; the Snail, "Like a snail that melts away"; the Ant, "Go to the ant, sluggard; see its ways and become wise"; the Rat, "Let every soul praise Hashem, Halleluja!"; and the Dog, last of all: "Come, let us prostrate ourselves and bow, let us kneel before Hashem our Maker."

Psalm 150 finishes: "Praise Him with timbres and dance, praise Him with stringed instruments and flute. Praise Him with resounding cymbals, praise Him with resonant cymbals. Let every soul praise G-d. Hallelujah!" And Psalm 89, which has given one verse a week for a whole year and ended last week on a disgrace, has one line left, and it is this: "Blessed is the Lord forever. Amen and Amen."

Week 52, Book 6 — the whole entry

Day 364 · Book 7 · Gathering of Songs

The Dogs Are Saying

The dogs open the last day of the year with the invitation Adam gave the animals, and the week comes in around it.

The bowing and the blessing first: “Come, let us worship and bow down” / “Let us kneel before G-d our Maker” / “Let every soul praise G-d. Hallelujah!” / “Blessed is the Lord forever. Amen and Amen” / “Praise Him with timbres and dance.”

Then the setting of hearts, and the promise to be with him: “And he said to them, 'Set your hearts to all of the words’” / “'Which I bear witness for you this day’” / “And the Lord said to him, 'Because I shall be with you’” / “Praise Him with stringed instruments and flute” / “'So that you may command your children’” / “'To observe to do all the words of this Torah’” / “'And you shall strike Midian as one man’” / “Praise Him with resounding cymbals.”

Then the war from generation to generation: “The strangers will wilt, and become lame from their bondage” / “A war for the Lord against Amalek from generation to generation” / “For the Lord desired to kill them” / “Flee, my beloved, and liken yourself to a gazelle” / “Or to a fawn of the hinds on the spice mountains.”

Then the father’s warning and the asking for a sign: “No, my sons, for the rumor which I hear the Lord’s people spreading, is not good” / “And he said, For there is a hand on the throne of the Eternal” / “But they would not hearken to their father’s voice” / “And he said to Him, 'If I have now found favor in your eyes’” / “If man will sin to man, the judge will judge him” / “Then show me a sign that it is You that speaks with me” / “If, however, he will sin against God” / “Who will intercede in the judgment in his behalf?”

And the last lines of the year are an altar, a boy still growing, and a name: “Then Moses built an altar, and he named it” / “Praise Him with resonant cymbals” / “And the lad, Samuel, was growing up” / “And bettering himself both with the Lord and with people” / “The Lord is my miracle.”

Week 52, Book 7 — the whole entry